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2 Chronicles 1:1–6

2 Chronicles

2 Chronicles 1:1–6

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 1:1–6 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 1:1–6 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 1:1–6 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

Solomon, the son of King David, became the new king of Israel after David died. This story happens soon after David died.

Solomon made himself strong as king and took full control of the kingdom of Israel. King Solomon made himself strong by defeating his enemies to become the only ruler of Israel. King Solomon's older brother, Adonijah, had tried to become king, but Solomon told Solomon's military leader, Benaiah, to kill Adonijah. Solomon also told Benaiah to kill Joab and Shimei. Joab had been King David's military leader and had supported Adonijah when Adonijah rebelled. Shimei was from the tribe of King Saul and had cursed King David when David ran away from Absalom, because Shimei hated David and blamed David for the death of King Saul's sons. Solomon had also banished Abiathar the priest from the priesthood. These men had all been enemies of King David and were dangerous to Solomon now as king. Solomon also began to build a wall around Jerusalem and likely made sure the army stayed loyal to Solomon.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about a person who became the leader of your community or country after that person struggled with other people who also wanted to become the leader. Describe all the things that the new leader did after he became the leader to make sure that he remained the leader and became strong. Pause this audio here.

Solomon became strong because Yahweh, Solomon's God, was with Solomon. Yahweh was the true king of Israel and had chosen Solomon to rule. Yahweh blessed Solomon, protected Solomon, and helped Solomon take full control of the kingdom. Yahweh made Solomon a great and powerful king. Yahweh also gave Solomon wealth and honor during Solomon's rule.

After Solomon took control of the kingdom of Israel, Solomon spoke to the people of Israel. King Solomon called all the people of Israel and their leaders together. It was normal for a king to gather the people for important events. The storyteller lists the leaders to show that all of Israel supported Solomon. Solomon spoke to the army commanders, the judges, and the leaders of Israel who were heads of clans, or groups of families and tribes. The army commanders who led the military of Israel were in charge of groups of 100 and 1,000 soldiers.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Discuss how you organize your warriors and the different levels of people who lead the warriors. Tell of a time when these leaders of the warriors had a disagreement with the great chief of your people. Pause this audio here.

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The judges were also leaders in Israel because they were responsible for making sure people followed the rules. The judges did this by listening to the people's problems and deciding what was right according to the law of Israel. The heads of families were wise and important men from each clan or large family group.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Discuss what your community's leadership structure looks like. For example, you may say that fathers lead their homes, clan leaders lead the clans, and the chiefs lead the community. Tell about a time when all these leaders, as well as the people, were gathered together. Pause this audio here.

We do not know what Solomon said in the gathering, but we know what happened next. Solomon and all the people went to the high place at Gibeon. High places were special places where people could worship, with altars for sacrifices. Before the Israelites built the temple, people used high places to worship Yahweh. People went to the high place at Gibeon because the Tent of Meeting that Moses had made was there. Yahweh had told Moses that Yahweh would meet the people there and that the people should bring their sacrifices to the tent.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of the Tent of Meeting. Talk about the place where the people of your community believe they can meet with God, the spirits, or the ancestors. Tell about a time that the leaders of your community went to that place, what they did, and why they did it. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller tells us that the ark of God was not in the Tent of Meeting at Gibeon. The ark was not there because King David had moved the ark from Kiriath Jearim to Jerusalem and placed it in a new tent. Normally, the ark stayed in the Tent of Meeting, but the Philistines had taken the ark of God during a battle. Later, the Philistines returned the ark, and then the people of Beth Shemesh took it and gave it to the people in Kiriath Jearim, where it stayed for 20 years. Then David brought the ark to Jerusalem. Even though the ark of God was not at Gibeon, the bronze altar was still there. This is the same altar that Yahweh had instructed Moses to make for burning sacrifices. Bezalel, the grandson of Hur, is the one who made this altar with the wisdom that Yahweh had given Bezalel.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of the ark of God and the bronze altar. Pause this audio here.

Solomon and the people worshiped Yahweh at the bronze altar. Solomon offered 1,000 burnt offerings. The priests likely killed the animals, cut them up, and burned them completely, except for the skin, which they kept. These offerings showed that the people wanted to dedicate themselves fully to Yahweh. It is likely that the people dedicated their new king, Solomon, to Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Describe the kind of offerings that the people of your community offer God, the spirits, or ancestors to please them. Tell of a time when a leader has offered a large number of sacrifices. Why did the leader do this?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 1:1–6 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four scenes.

In the first scene: King Solomon took firm control of the kingdom of Israel because Yahweh was with Solomon. Yahweh made Solomon very great.

In the second scene: King Solomon spoke to all the people of Israel and to their military leaders, judges, and the heads of the families of Israel.

In the third scene: King Solomon and all the people who had gathered went to the high place at Gibeon because the Tent of Meeting that Moses had made was there. The bronze altar that Bezalel, the son of Uri, had made was also there.

In the fourth scene: King Solomon and the people of Israel worshipped Yahweh there. And King Solomon offered 1,000 burnt offerings.

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The characters in this passage are:

- Yahweh
- King Solomon
- King David
- All the people of Israel
- The military commanders of thousands
- The military commanders of hundreds
- The judges of Israel
- The leading men of Israel who are heads of the families, or clans
- Moses
- Bezalel, the son of Uri and grandson of Hur
- And the priest who offered Solomon's sacrifices—the storyteller does not mention the priests, but they were likely there

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

King David had died, and David's son Solomon had become the new king of Israel. It is not clear how long after King David died this story takes place, but it is not too long. In the first scene, King Solomon strengthened himself over his kingdom, or took firm control of Israel. A king is normally the most powerful man in the kingdom. The king rules with the help of other powerful people, who can be dangerous to the king's rule if they are not loyal to the king. King Solomon strengthened himself over his kingdom by making sure that there was no one to challenge Solomon's rule. Solomon also strengthened himself over Israel by doing things that would make the Kingdom of Israel safe from its enemies. You will remember from the story in 1 Kings that Solomon built the wall of Jerusalem and made a marriage alliance with Pharaoh king of Egypt.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about a leader who ruled your community or country strongly. Talk about how the leader was in control of everything. List the things that the leader did to make himself strong from the day he first became the leader. Pay attention to the words and phrases you use to describe the way the leader made himself strong and took full control. Pause this audio here.

Although Solomon made himself strong over Israel, Solomon was only able to do so because Yahweh, Solomon's God, was with Solomon. When a king was successful, the Israelites said that it was because Yahweh was with that king. Yahweh was the true king of Israel, and Yahweh chose which man would rule as Yahweh's representative. Yahweh had chosen Solomon, and therefore Yahweh protected Solomon and made him able to take control of the kingdom of Israel. Yahweh made Solomon very great. Yahweh had promised that Yahweh would make Solomon great. It is possible that the storyteller is referring to how Yahweh made Solomon great and gave him power and honor throughout Solomon's rule, not just at the beginning of Solomon's rule.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about a person who was very successful. Tell about how God, the spirits, or ancestors protected that person, blessed him, and helped him succeed. What special language would you use to say that God, the spirits, or the ancestors made that person able to become successful? Pause this audio here.

In the second scene, King Solomon spoke to all Israel. It is likely that King Solomon called a great gathering, or assembly, of all the people of Israel. It was common for kings to call for such gatherings at important times, especially at the beginning of the king's rule. The storyteller focuses on the levels of leaders who were there at the gathering. The storyteller likely does this to show that the people of Israel were united and loyal to King Solomon. King Solomon spoke to the leaders of Israel's military. Israel's army had fighting units made up of 1,000 soldiers each. Each unit of 1,000 soldiers had its leader. There were many of these units. Their leaders are the commanders of thousands. The military units of 1,000 were further broken down into units of 100 soldiers, each with its leader. These are the commanders of hundreds. King Solomon also spoke to the judges of Israel. The people often called rulers or leaders of Israel "judges." In this story, it is likely that the judges that King Solomon spoke to are the judges who decided which person was right or wrong when two people or groups had an argument. King Solomon also spoke to all the leading men of Israel who were heads of families. You will remember that there were 12 tribes in Israel, and each tribe was made up of clans or large family groups. From the days of Moses, the Israelites had tribal leaders as well as leaders of clans or large family groups.

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Stop here and do this activity as a group: Act out a scene where a military commander has harmed a person or their property. The person whom the commander harmed or his family should go to their clan leader and explain what happened and ask for justice. Their clan leader should then take them before a judge to ask for justice. Pay attention to the words and phrases that you use for military commander, clan leader, and judge. Pause this audio here.

In the third scene, King Solomon and all the people who had gathered went to the high place that was at Gibeon. A high place usually refers to a dedicated place of worship set up on a high place, like a hill or mountain. But many of the high places of Israel were not on hills or mountains. It is better to think of a high place as a shrine or a sacred place of worship.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Describe a physical place that your community or another community you know goes to offer sacrifices. Talk about what the place looks like and how important it is. Pay attention to the words and phrases you use when you name this place. Make sure you choose a general name that you can also use to describe a similar worship place that belongs to another group of people. Pause this audio here.

King Solomon and the people went to the high place that was at Gibeon because the Tent of Meeting for God was there. Gibeon was one of the cities of the Levites, in the territory of Benjamin. Gibeon was about 10 kilometers northwest of Jerusalem.

Stop here and look at a map of the journey from Jerusalem to Gibeon. Pause this audio here.

This is the same tent that Moses, who served Yahweh faithfully, had made in the wilderness. Yahweh had asked Moses to make a temporary house that people made of skins. Yahweh said that Yahweh would speak with the people of Israel from the Tent of Meeting. The Israelites, therefore, called it the Tent of Meeting, the tabernacle, or the tent of Yahweh's presence. The storyteller adds a comment to explain to us that the ark of God was not in the Tent of Meeting like it was when the Israelites first made the tent. Earlier, King David had taken the ark from Kiriath Jearim to Jerusalem and put it in another tent at the place King David had prepared for it.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Have someone tell a story. As the person is telling the story, he should pause the story to explain or add some information about what he has been saying. For example, the person could be speaking of the story of a great harvest that your community has enjoyed and then pause the story to make a comment about someone who did not plant anything at planting time. Pause this audio here.

But the bronze altar that Bezalel, the son of Uri and grandson of Hur, had made was there standing in front of the Tent of Meeting. Bezalel had made this altar by mixing two metals, copper and tin, to make a metal called bronze. The altar was standing before the Tent of Meeting because that is what Yahweh had commanded. Sometimes the word tabernacle refers to the entire Tent of Meeting, including the fence around it. In this case, it refers only to the two rooms in the main tent, the Holy Place and the Most Holy Place.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a picture of the entire Tent of Meeting with the bronze altar standing before the Tent of Meeting. Pause audio here.

In the fourth scene, King Solomon and the people with him worshipped or asked Yahweh for advice there. It is possible that the storyteller means that Solomon and the people went to sacrifice at Gibeon often. King Solomon went up to the bronze altar in front of Yahweh's Tent of Meeting and offered 1,000 burnt offerings on the altar. It is unlikely that Solomon himself made the offerings. Normally, priests would kill, cut up, and burn the entire animal on the altar, apart from its skin. It is likely that Solomon offered the burnt offerings to dedicate himself and his rule over Israel to Yahweh.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 1:1–6 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four scenes.

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The characters in this passage are:

- Yahweh
- King Solomon
- King David
- All the people of Israel
- The military commanders of thousands
- The military commanders of hundreds
- The judges of Israel
- The leading men of Israel who are heads of the families, or clans
- Moses
- Bezalel, the son of Uri and grandson of Hur
- And the priest who offered Solomon's sacrifices—the storyteller does not mention the priests, but they were likely there

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

King Solomon took firm control of the kingdom of Israel because Yahweh was with Solomon. Yahweh made Solomon very great.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Solomon, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel happy and blessed. Yahweh is giving me control of Israel; or
- I am aware and alert for danger within Israel as well as from outside; or
- I am determined to secure myself as king.

Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel pleased with Solomon; or
- I am happy to give Solomon the power to defeat his enemies; or
- I feel loved by my obedient son Solomon. I will give Solomon favor and success.

Continue the drama.

King Solomon spoke to all the people of Israel and to their military leaders, judges, and the heads of the families of Israel.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Solomon, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel excited. This is a special day for Israel; or
- I am happy to honor Yahweh with all Israel; or
- I feel very happy to see the loyalty and unity my people have.

Ask the person playing the commanders, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We feel honored by our king; or
- We love King Solomon, and we will serve Solomon loyally; or

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- We are encouraged by our young king's wisdom. Solomon has done a very good job so far.

Ask the person playing judges and heads of families, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We are very pleased with the purpose of this gathering. When Solomon's father became king, David called all the leaders of Israel, and they went and brought the ark of Yahweh. King Solomon wants us to worship Yahweh at Gibeon and ask for Yahweh's help; or
- We are proud of our young king's wisdom and success; or
- We feel great hope for the future of our people and nation.

Continue the drama.

King Solomon and all the people who had gathered went to the high place at Gibeon because the Tent of Meeting that Moses had made was there. The bronze altar that Bezalel, the son of Uri, had made was also there. But King David had brought the ark of God to Jerusalem.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the people of Israel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We feel like rejoicing and celebrating; or
- We feel awe and amazement. We are at the tent of Yahweh's presence. We hope and pray that Solomon will serve Yahweh as faithfully as Moses did; or
- We feel excited to see the work Yahweh is doing in Israel today. Yahweh has given Solomon wisdom to rule just as Yahweh gave Bezalel wisdom to make the bronze altar.

Ask the person playing King Solomon, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel humbled to be in this holy place; or
- I feel sad that the ark was separated from the Tent of Meeting and that the people still have not got a permanent place to worship Yahweh; or
- I am determined to do the work Yahweh has given me. I will build the temple.

Continue the drama.

King Solomon and the people of Israel worshipped Yahweh there. And King Solomon offered 1,000 burnt offerings.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the heads of families, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We feel a great desire that Yahweh would guide our king; or
- We feel blessed to have a king like this who leads the whole nation to worship Yahweh.

Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am honored by my people; or
- I am pleased by the sweet smell of the burnt sacrifices; or
- I have heard and will answer Solomon.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 1:1–6 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Solomon, the son of David, established himself in his kingdom, and Yahweh, Solomon's God, was with Solomon. A kingdom is the territory or the people that a king rules. Yahweh is a name that God gives himself. This name means something like "I am," or "I am who I am." God is a less personal or more general name that people sometimes used to refer to Yahweh. This is the God who created everything, the most powerful spiritual being.

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Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **kingdom**, **Yahweh**, and **God**. Look up kingdom, Yahweh, and God in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Solomon spoke to all Israel, to the commanders, judges, leaders, and heads of families. Israel is the land that Yahweh promised to Abraham and his descendants. At some point, the people of Israel fought among themselves and divided the land into two kingdoms. At this point, Israel refers to the whole kingdom before it was divided. A commander is the military officer who is in charge of other soldiers. Israel's military commanders were in charge of either 1,000 or 100 soldiers. A judge is a person who judges actions that people do and decides if what those people have done is right or wrong, and therefore if a person is guilty or innocent of breaking a law. A judge will punish the person if the judge decides that the person is guilty of doing wrong. The leaders were the chiefs or leading men in all Israel. The heads of families were specifically the chiefs or the most important men from each clan, or large family group, in Israel. It is likely that leaders and heads of families refer to the same group of men.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **Israel**, **commanders**, **judges**, **leaders**, and **heads**. Look up Israel and judges in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Solomon and all the assembly went to the high place at Gibeon because the Tent of Meeting that Moses, the faithful or loyal servant of Yahweh, had made in the wilderness was there. "All the assembly" refers to all the people who had gathered together for a common purpose. Because Yahweh chose the people of Israel, people usually call gatherings of the people of Israel the "assembly" of Yahweh. The Tent of Meeting is another name for the tabernacle. This is where the Israelites worshipped Yahweh. The people called it the Tent of Meeting because it was where the Israelites could meet Yahweh. A servant is a person who does work for someone else. People sometimes call someone who worships and obeys Yahweh a servant of Yahweh. A wilderness is a lonely, barren place without water. There are almost no trees or bushes growing in a wilderness. The ground is dry and rocky, and there are wild animals roaming around. People do not live in the wilderness.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **assembly**, **Tent of Meeting**, **servant**, and **wilderness**. Look up **tabernacle**, servant, and wilderness in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

But David had brought the ark of God to Jerusalem. The bronze altar that Bezalel, the son of Uri, had made was also there in front of the tabernacle. The ark of God is the oblong box that people made of acacia wood that Yahweh asked Moses to make. Sometimes people call this box the ark of the covenant. Yahweh spoke to Moses from above the ark. Bronze is a metal that people made by combining copper and tin. An altar is a place where people make offerings or sacrifices to God. The people of Israel burned their animal sacrifices on the bronze altar. The tabernacle was a portable temple that the Israelites carried with them during their years of traveling in the wilderness. This was the place where the Israelites kept the ark of the covenant and where the people worshiped God.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **ark**, **bronze**, **altar**, and **tabernacle**. Look up **ark of the covenant**, bronze, and altar in the Master Glossary for more information. Remember that the storyteller calls the ark the "ark of God" in this story. Remember that "tabernacle" is another way to say the Tent of Meeting. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Solomon offered 1,000 burnt offerings on the bronze altar. A burnt offering is a form of sacrifice that people bring to Yahweh. When a person brings Yahweh a burnt offering, he kills an animal and burns this animal completely on an altar. The people brought Yahweh burnt offerings as a way to completely dedicate themselves to Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **burnt offering**. Look up burnt offering in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

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Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (951 KB)
- Setting the Stage (4.9 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (7.5 MB)
- Embodying the Text (4.1 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (4.4 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.2 MB)

2 Chronicles 1:7–13

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 1:7–13 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 1:7–13 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 1:7–13 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

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Pause this audio here.

In the last story, Solomon became the king of Israel after his father, David, died. Solomon gathered together the people of Israel and their leaders and went to make offerings to Yahweh at the bronze altar that was at the high place in Gibeon.

This story happened on the night of that same day that Solomon offered the burnt offerings to Yahweh. Solomon was still at the high place in Gibeon. That night, Yahweh appeared to Solomon. Yahweh told Solomon to ask Yahweh for anything that Solomon wanted. The storyteller does not tell us how Yahweh appeared to Solomon. The storyteller does say that it was at night. Solomon would have been asleep and dreaming. Yahweh sometimes appears to people in their dreams.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell stories of people in your community who received messages from God, the spirits, or the ancestors while they were dreaming. What messages did those people receive? Pause this audio here.

Solomon told Yahweh that Yahweh had already shown great kindness to Solomon's father, David, and that Yahweh had continued to be kind by making Solomon king after David. Yahweh had promised David that Yahweh would bless David and make some of David's descendants kings of Israel. Solomon told Yahweh that Yahweh had fulfilled Yahweh's word, or promise to David, because Yahweh had made Solomon king of the people of Israel. It is also possible that Solomon was actually asking Yahweh to fulfill Yahweh's promise rather than saying that Yahweh had already fulfilled it.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In the previous discussion, you talked about people who had received a message from God, the spirits, or the ancestors in a dream. Now discuss whether those messages were about true things that actually happened or not. Pause this audio here.

Solomon said that the people of Israel were as many as the dust of the earth or the grains of dust. Yahweh had promised Jacob, the ancestor of the 12 tribes of Israel, that the people of Israel would become as many as the dust of the earth. Solomon is saying that he has very many people to rule over.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Collect some sand or dust in your hand and try to count the grains one by one. Pause audio here.

Solomon then asked Yahweh to give Solomon wisdom and knowledge to go out and to come in before the people of Israel. In Israel, because the leaders led the warriors out when they went to war and led the warriors back home after the war, to go out and to come in became another way to talk about leading people. Solomon is asking Yahweh to give Solomon wisdom or the ability to make good decisions that would make Yahweh happy. Solomon also asks for knowledge. Solomon wants to understand things about Yahweh, to know right from wrong, and to learn important truths. Knowledge is a special gift from Yahweh, but also something people try to learn. When people have knowledge, those people have the ability to make wise decisions. Knowledge is just the first step to becoming wise. Solomon is asking Yahweh to help Solomon think clearly so Solomon can be a good king and make smart, helpful choices. It is likely that when Solomon prays for wisdom, Solomon is also asking for the skills to build the temple.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Discuss the different ways in which a king or great chief leads his people. For example, how does a king lead in war, in building projects, in legal cases, or religiously? What skills or characteristics does a leader need to be successful in all these areas of leadership? Pause this audio here.

Solomon told Yahweh that Solomon asked for wisdom and knowledge because no one would be able to judge or rule the many and important people of Yahweh.

Yahweh was pleased that Solomon did not ask for possessions, riches, honor, or even for Yahweh to kill Solomon's enemies or to give Solomon a long life. Yahweh said that Solomon's heart desire was wisdom and knowledge to rule the people of Yahweh. The people of Israel believed that a person's heart controls that person's thinking, choices, and ability to know right from wrong. The heart's desire is the thing that someone really wants.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Which part of the body does your community believe our desires come from? Pause audio here.

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Yahweh said that because of this, Yahweh would give Solomon the thing that Solomon had asked for—wisdom and knowledge. Yahweh said that Yahweh would also give Solomon the things that Solomon had not asked for—possessions, riches, and honor. Yahweh also said that Yahweh would give Solomon these things more than any king that had come before Solomon or any that would come after Solomon. It is not clear whether Yahweh meant that Yahweh would give Solomon more of these things than any of the kings of Israel or more than Yahweh would give the kings of all the nations.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about the wisest, richest, and most respected king or leader that your community has ever had. Give examples of that person's wisdom, riches, and the respect people gave him. Where did the king or leader get these things from? Pause audio here.

Then Solomon left the Tent of Meeting that was at Gibeon, where he had gone to offer burnt offerings to Yahweh, and went back to Jerusalem. It is likely that Solomon went back to Jerusalem in the morning after the night Solomon had the dream.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of the Tent of Meeting and a map of the journey from Gibeon to Jerusalem. Pause this audio here.

Solomon ruled over Israel from Jerusalem.

This story is important because it shows the people of Israel that King Solomon cared more about being a good king and doing what Yahweh wanted than about being rich and powerful.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 1:7–13 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has two scenes.

In the first scene: Yahweh appeared to Solomon at night and told Solomon that Yahweh would give Solomon anything that Solomon asked for. Solomon asked Yahweh to give Solomon wisdom and knowledge to rule Yahweh's great people, Israel. And Yahweh said that Yahweh would give Solomon wisdom and knowledge and more possessions, riches, and honor than any other king before or after Solomon.

In the second scene: Solomon left Gibeon and the Tent of Meeting that was there and went back to Jerusalem. Solomon ruled Israel.

The characters in this passage are:

- Yahweh
- King Solomon
- King David
- The people of Israel
- And the other kings that came before and after Solomon

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first scene, God appears to Solomon. You will remember that in the last story, Solomon offered burnt offerings to Yahweh. In this story, Solomon is still at the high place in Gibeon, but it is now nighttime. Solomon is asleep and dreaming. God appears to Solomon and tells Solomon that God will give Solomon anything that Solomon asks for. God sometimes spoke to people in dreams.

Solomon answered Yahweh. Solomon began by reminding Yahweh how Yahweh had treated Solomon's father, David. Solomon said that Yahweh had shown great kindness to Solomon's father, David, and continued to be kind by making Solomon king after his father, David. Solomon is saying that Yahweh had shown steadfast love and was loyal to David because Yahweh had made a promise and agreement with David. Yahweh had promised David that David's family would rule Israel, and now Solomon, David's son, was king.

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Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about someone that God, the spirits, or ancestors loved and protected. Describe how God, the spirits, or the ancestors remained loyal to that person and never left the person. Pay attention to the words and phrases you use to describe this kind of love. Pause this audio here.

Solomon talks about how Solomon wants Yahweh to treat Solomon. The scene begins with a word that shows that Solomon is not talking about the past anymore. Solomon asks Yahweh God to fulfill his word because it is Yahweh who had made Solomon king of Israel. Yahweh's word is the promise that Yahweh had made to David. It is also possible that Solomon is saying that Yahweh had already fulfilled the word or promise that Yahweh had made to David because Solomon has become king. Solomon said the people of Israel were as many as the dust of the earth.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about the largest group of people you have ever seen in your life. What special language can you use to say how many people they were? Use words or phrases that describe a number of people too many to count. Pause this audio here.

Solomon asked Yahweh for wisdom and knowledge to go out and come in before the people of Israel. The leaders of Israel went out before the people when going to war and came in before the people when returning from war. For this reason, people used the phrase "to go out and to come in" as a special way of saying to lead people.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell stories of the greatest leader that your community or country has ever had. Discuss and describe the different ways he led your people. How do you talk about the way this person led the people? How will you say that Solomon asked Yahweh for wisdom and knowledge to go out and to come in before the people of Israel? Pause this audio here.

Solomon wanted wisdom and knowledge so he could lead well. A person who has wisdom is able to make good decisions that lead to good results. People who have certain skills, like the ability to build or to make something beautiful, are also wise. It is Yahweh who gives wisdom to people. When a person has knowledge, that person has a good understanding of things. People gain knowledge by learning information or skills.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about someone in your community who learned something that they did not know and continued learning for many years so that they became the most experienced or wisest person in that subject. For example, you may want to talk about someone who learned something like ruling or hunting. Pay attention to the words and phrases that you use to describe the knowledge this person learned and the wisdom they had after many years. Pause this audio here.

Solomon asked Yahweh a question to make a statement. Solomon said that no one could judge or rule Yahweh's great people. Solomon is saying that if Yahweh does not help Solomon, Solomon will not be able to be a good king. Solomon calls Israel Yahweh's great people. Solomon meant two things when he called Yahweh's people great. Firstly, Yahweh was the true king of Israel, and therefore the people of Israel were Yahweh's people, or very important people. Secondly, the people of Israel were very many.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about how you will refer to Yahweh's great people. Remember that they are great because they are important as well as many. Pause this audio here.

Yahweh was happy because Solomon had not asked for possession, riches, honor or respect, long life, or for Solomon's enemies to die. Yahweh was happy because the desire of Solomon's heart was wisdom and knowledge to rule well. In Israel, people believed the heart helped you think, choose, and know right from wrong.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about something you really want. Explain why you want it so much. How do you describe the feeling you have of wanting something so much? How will you talk about the desires of Solomon's heart? Pause this audio here.

Yahweh said Yahweh would give Solomon the wisdom and knowledge that Solomon had asked for. Yahweh also said Yahweh would give Solomon the things Solomon had not asked for. Yahweh said that Yahweh would give Solomon more wisdom, knowledge, possessions, riches, and honor than any king before or after Solomon. It is not clear if Yahweh meant only the kings of Israel or all kings. Yahweh does not say that Yahweh would give Solomon a long life or kill Solomon's enemies. Solomon had already killed some of Solomon's enemies.

In the second scene, Solomon left the Tent of Meeting in Gibeon and went back to Jerusalem. Solomon likely returned in the morning after the dream. Solomon had gone to Gibeon with the people of Israel and their leaders,

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but the storyteller does not mention those people here. Solomon ruled Israel from Jerusalem. Gibeon was one of the cities of the Levites, in the territory of Benjamin. It was about 10 kilometers northwest of Jerusalem.

Stop here and look at a map of the journey from Jerusalem to Gibeon. Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 1:7–13 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has two scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Yahweh
- King Solomon
- King David
- The people of Israel
- And the other kings that came before and after Solomon

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

In the first scene, Yahweh appeared to Solomon at night and told Solomon that Yahweh would give Solomon anything that Solomon asked for.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Yahweh, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I feel honored by Solomon; or
- I am pleased with Solomon’s burnt offerings and his dedication to me; or
- I love Solomon as I loved his father, David. I want to know if Solomon will be faithful to me as David was.

Ask the person playing Solomon, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am amazed by Yahweh; or
- I feel very afraid of Yahweh’s glory; or
- I feel so happy. Yahweh has answered my prayers.

Continue the drama.

Solomon answered Yahweh and said that Yahweh had shown Solomon’s father, David, great kindness.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Solomon, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I feel great joy. My heart is full of praise for Yahweh. Yahweh’s word is true, and Yahweh keeps his promises; or

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- Yahweh is a faithful God. Yahweh kept his word to David, and I desire the same love and loyalty Yahweh gave my father; or
- I love Yahweh. I feel that Yahweh loves me for the sake of my father, David.

Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel honored; or
- I love to keep my promises, and I love those who recognize my faithfulness; or
- I am happy that Solomon knows I am the one who made Solomon king of Israel.

Continue the drama.

Solomon asked Yahweh to give Solomon wisdom and knowledge to rule Yahweh's great people, Israel.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Solomon, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel overwhelmed by my job as the king of Yahweh's many important people; or
- I am scared that I will fail and make Yahweh angry; or
- I feel desperate for Yahweh's help.

Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am glad that Solomon has not been selfish and asked for things for himself, but has asked for what Solomon needs to rule My people well; or
- Solomon wants what I also want and this makes me very pleased with Solomon; or
- I love how Solomon loves me and loves people.

Continue the drama.

Yahweh said that Yahweh would give Solomon wisdom and knowledge and more possessions, riches, and honor than any other king before or after Solomon.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel very pleased with what Solomon has requested; or
- I love that Solomon is humble and knows that he needs my help to be a good king; or
- I am happy to bless Solomon more than any other king because Solomon's desire is to please me.

Ask the person playing Solomon, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Wow! I am amazed at Yahweh's generosity; or
- I feel loved by Yahweh; or
- I feel like I have a relationship with Yahweh, like the strong relationship my father, David, had with Yahweh.

Ask the person playing the other kings that came before or after, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am amazed by the wealth and greatness of King Solomon; or
- We wish we were as famous and that Yahweh would honor us like he honored Solomon; or
- We feel jealous of Solomon.

Continue the drama.

In the second scene, Solomon left Gibeon and went from the Tent of Meeting back to Jerusalem. Solomon ruled Israel.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Solomon, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am happy, blessed, and ready to rule; or
- I know Yahweh will be with me, and I feel more confident and prepared; or
- I feel loved by Yahweh. I feel secure and safe because Yahweh keeps his promises.

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Ask the person playing the people of Israel, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- We are very happy. Our King Solomon rules us very well; or
- We feel blessed, rich, and prosperous; or
- We feel that we are a special nation that Yahweh loves. Yahweh has blessed us with a good king.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 1:7–13 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

That night, **God** appeared to Solomon and asked Solomon to ask for anything, and God would give it to Solomon. God is a general name for Yahweh. God refers to God who created everything. God is the most powerful spiritual being. Use the same word or phrase for God as you used in previous passages. For more information on God, refer to the Master Glossary.

Solomon told Yahweh that Yahweh had shown great kindness, or steadfast love, to Solomon’s father, David, by making Solomon king. Kindness refers to how Yahweh treats people who are under Yahweh’s authority. This kindness is the steadfast, or loyal, love of Yahweh. Yahweh treated David with kindness because Yahweh had promised to do so, and Yahweh never breaks Yahweh’s promises.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **kindness** or **steadfast love**. Look up steadfast love in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Use the same word or phrase for **king** as you used in previous passages. For more information on king, refer to the Master Glossary.

Solomon asked **Yahweh** God to fulfill Yahweh’s word or promise. Use the same word or phrase for Yahweh as you used in previous passages. For more information on Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary.

Solomon said that it was Yahweh who had made Solomon king over a people who are as many as the dust of the earth. The people of Israel were too many to count.

Solomon asked Yahweh to give Solomon wisdom and knowledge so that Solomon might be able to go out and come in before the people. Solomon told Yahweh that no one would be able to judge Yahweh’s great people. A person who has wisdom understands many things because they have experienced many things. That person is able to make good decisions that lead to good results. When a person has certain skills, like the ability to build or to make something beautiful, the Bible also says that this person has wisdom. It is Yahweh who gives wisdom to people. Knowledge is similar to wisdom; when someone has knowledge, that person has understanding. People can gain understanding more quickly, perhaps, than they can gain wisdom. This kind of knowledge also helps people lead others, make good choices, and understand the situation clearly. It is not just about knowing a lot of facts.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **wisdom** and **knowledge**. Look up wisdom in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

To go out and come in before the people is to lead the people. It is special language that usually refers to a king or commander leading his warriors to war, but here it means all the different ways that king Solomon would lead Israel. When someone judges or rules, that person usually decides cases and punishes those who are wrong, but not in this case. Solomon asks Yahweh, “Who is able to judge your great people?” Solomon means that no one can rule the people fairly.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **judge**, especially when it means to govern or rule a group of people fairly. Look up judge in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Yahweh said that Solomon's **heart desire** was not **possessions**, **riches**, or **honor**, or for Yahweh to kill Solomon's enemies, or for a long life for himself, but for wisdom and knowledge. A person's heart desire is the thing that the person wants more than anything else. Possessions and riches refer to things like land, animals, silver, or gold. If you have different words in your language to refer to these things, use two different words. If not, use one word. Honor may refer to beauty, respect, riches, or signs that God is with Solomon.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **heart desire**, **possessions**, **riches**, and **honor**. Look up **heart** in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Then Solomon went to Jerusalem from the **high place** at Gibeon, from before the **Tent of Meeting** or tabernacle. And Solomon ruled Israel. Use the same words or phrases for "high place" and "Tent of Meeting" as you used in previous passages. For more information on the Tent of Meeting, or tabernacle, refer to the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

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Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (968 KB)
- Setting the Stage (4.9 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (5.8 MB)
- Embodying the Text (4.3 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (4.0 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.2 MB)

2 Chronicles 1:14–17

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 1:14–17 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 1:14–17 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

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Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 1:14–17 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous story, Solomon asked God for wisdom and knowledge to be a good leader for Israel. God promised to make Solomon wise. God also promised that Solomon would be wealthy and famous. In this story, the storyteller describes the powerful army that Solomon built up for Israel.

Solomon's army owned many horses and chariots. At that time, having horses and chariots made an army more powerful. A soldier could ride a horse, and the horse could run faster than humans, so the soldier on a horse could catch and kill more people than a soldier on foot.

A chariot is a kind of cart that horses pull into battle. At least two soldiers ride in the chariot. One soldier controls the horses while the other soldier can shoot arrows or stab enemy soldiers with his sword. The soldiers inside the chariot are also somewhat protected by the walls of the chariot.

Stop here and look at a picture of a chariot with soldiers inside. Pause this audio here.

Solomon had 1,400 chariots. When you listened to three different versions of this passage, some might have said that Solomon had 12,000 horses, while others said that Solomon had 12,000 horsemen. A horseman is a person who knows how to handle horses. Bible scholars do not agree on whether the original language means that Solomon had 12,000 horses or that Solomon had 12,000 horsemen.

Solomon stationed some of his horses and chariots in Jerusalem, and Solomon stationed others in special cities in Israel that Solomon built just for them. This made it easier to defend the country from invaders, because no matter where an enemy attacked, there would always be a chariot city close by.

Solomon bought horses from Egypt and also from a place called Kue. Bible scholars are not certain exactly where Kue was located, but some think it might have been located northwest of Israel, in the southeastern part of the modern-day country of Turkey. This area is sometimes called Cilicia. When you listened to three different versions of this passage, you might have heard the storyteller call this place Kue, or you might have heard the storyteller call this place Cilicia.

Stop here and look at a map of the Middle East that shows Israel and Turkey. Note the location of Cilicia. Pause this audio here.

Toward the end of this passage, the storyteller tells us how much Solomon paid for his chariots and horses. The price of a chariot was about 600 shekels of silver, and the price of a horse was about 150 shekels of silver. This was equal to about seven kilograms of silver for a chariot and about two kilograms of silver for a horse. The storyteller adds that Solomon's men sold chariots and horses to the kings of the Hittites and the kings of the Arameans.

As the storyteller tells us these things, the storyteller reminds us of just how rich Solomon was. Silver, gold, and cedar wood were all valuable, expensive items, but they were very common in Israel during Solomon's day. This meant that not only was Solomon very rich, but Solomon made his people quite rich as well.

Cedar wood was a kind of wood that was very good for building. Cedar was very strong, lasted a long time, and had a pleasant smell and color. The Israelites thought that the best cedar came from Lebanon, the country just north of Israel.

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Stop here and look at a picture of a cedar tree. Have you ever seen a building that people made from cedar wood? What was it like?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 1:14–17 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has one scene.

In the first scene: The storyteller tells us about Solomon's chariots and horses. The storyteller also tells us that Solomon was so rich that valuable materials like silver, gold, and cedar were extremely common in Israel.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Solomon
- Solomon's horsemen and charioteers
- Solomon's royal merchants
- And the kings of the Hittites and Arameans

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first scene, the author tells us about Solomon's chariots and horses. If you have already translated the book of 1 Chronicles, then you have already translated the word for chariot. It would be helpful to go back and listen to how you translated chariot in that book.

Stop here and listen to the first part of 1 Chronicles chapter 18, if it is available in your language. In this story, King David defeated King Hadadezer and took his chariots. Pay attention to how you translated the word chariot. Pause this audio here.

Solomon had 1,400 chariots, and either 12,000 horses or 12,000 horsemen. Bible scholars do not agree on whether the original language means to say "horses" or "horsemen" in this passage. Either translation choice is acceptable.

Stop here and discuss these questions: How common are horses in your culture? If horses are not common now, was there a time in the past when horses were common? What words do you use for a person who knows how to handle horses? What words do you have for a person who is a soldier who rides horses? Pause this audio here.

Solomon kept some of his horses, chariots, and charioteers in the chariot cities Solomon had built all over Israel, but Solomon kept some of them in Jerusalem to protect the capital city. Solomon bought horses from Egypt and from a place called Kue. Bible scholars are not certain exactly where Kue was. Bible scholars do know that during Solomon's time, an area in southeastern Turkey had a reputation for breeding excellent horses. Sometimes people called this area "Cilicia." When you listened to three different versions of this passage, you might have heard that Solomon bought horses from Egypt and Kue, or that Solomon bought horses from Egypt and Cilicia. Either translation choice is acceptable.

Stop here and look at a map that shows the location of Israel and the location of Cilicia. Pause this audio here.

Solomon bought a chariot for seven kilograms of silver and a horse for two kilograms of silver. Solomon's traders not only bought chariots and horses for Israel, but they also sold chariots and horses to the kings of the Hittites and the Arameans. The Hittites and Arameans were enemies of Israel, so it is not clear why Solomon's traders sold horses and chariots to these people. Perhaps Solomon was so rich and so powerful that Solomon no longer had to worry about attacks from the Hittites and the Arameans.

While the storyteller is describing Solomon's army, the storyteller mentions again that there was so much silver in Israel that it was as common as stones. The storyteller also claims that cedar trees were as common as sycamore trees in the lowlands. The Israelites had to import good-quality cedar into Israel from Lebanon, and it was expensive. In contrast, sycamore trees were very common in an area called Shephelah, which was the low

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hills in the region of Judah. Both of these statements mean that Solomon was so rich that Solomon could buy a lot of expensive things.

Stop here and look at a picture of a cedar tree. Does the cedar tree look like any trees that grow in your area? Next, look at a picture of a sycamore tree. Does this tree look like any trees that grow in your area? Pause this audio here.

In your language, it may be unnatural or confusing for the storyteller to first talk about Solomon's chariots and horses, then talk about Solomon's silver, gold, and cedar, and then go back to talking about Solomon's chariots and horses again. If this is the case, it is acceptable to move the storyteller's comments about silver, gold, and cedar to either the beginning or the end of this story.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 1:14–17 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has one scene.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Solomon
- Solomon's horsemen and charioteers
- Solomon's royal merchants
- And the kings of the Hittites and Arameans

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

> Solomon built up a large force of 1,400 chariots and 12,000 horsemen. Solomon stationed some of them in the chariot cities and some near Solomon in Jerusalem. The king made silver and gold as common in Jerusalem as stone, and he made cedar as common as the sycamore trees that grow in the foothills of Judah. Solomon's horses came from Egypt and Kue, and the king's merchants bought them from Kue at the standard price. They bought a chariot from Egypt for about seven kilograms of silver, and a horse for about two kilograms of silver. And they also exported chariots and horses to the kings of the Hittites and the Arameans.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Solomon, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I hope that these chariots and horsemen will keep our nation safe for many years to come; or
- I am making Israel the most powerful nation on earth; or
- I am very happy that my people now have great riches.

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Ask the people playing Solomon's royal merchants, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am so proud that our country has enough money to buy good horses and chariots; or
- I am happy that our people have such a great king as Solomon; or
- I am glad that we can make extra money by selling horses and chariots to the Hittites and Arameans.

Ask the people playing Solomon's horsemen and charioteers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Finally, our country has an army as powerful as Egypt's; or
- I feel proud to serve in such a strong army; or
- I am grateful to King Solomon for providing such good chariots and horses for our army.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 1:14–17 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Solomon built up a large force of 1,400 **chariots** and 12,000 horsemen. Be sure to translate the word chariot the same way that you did in previous books of the Bible. If necessary, listen again to the beginning of 1 Chronicles chapter 18, when King David defeats Hadadezer and takes his chariots.

Stop here. If you decide to use the word "**horsemen**," decide how you will translate it into your language. Pause this audio here.

Solomon stationed some of them in the chariot cities and some near Solomon in Jerusalem. Cities are larger settlements that often have a wall around them.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **chariot cities**. Pause this audio here.

> The **king** made silver and gold as common in Jerusalem as stone, and the king made cedar as common as the sycamore trees that grow in the foothills of Judah. Be sure to translate king the same way that you did in previous passages. See the Master Glossary for more information on king.
>
> Stop here and look again at a picture of a **cedar** tree and a **sycamore** tree. Decide what words you will use for these two trees. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **Judah**. Refer to the Master Glossary for more information about Judah. Pause this audio here.

> Solomon's horses came from Egypt and Kue, and the king's merchants bought them from Kue at the standard price.
>
> Stop here and look again at a map of the Middle East that shows the locations of Israel, Turkey, and Cilicia. Decide whether you will use the name **Kue** or **Cilicia** for the place the horses came from. Pause this audio here.
>
> Solomon's traders bought a chariot from Egypt for about seven kilograms of silver, and a horse for about two kilograms of silver. And the traders also exported chariots and horses to the kings of the **Hittites** and the **Arameans**. Be sure to translate Hittites and Arameans the same way you did in previous passages. If you have already translated the book of Genesis, then you have already translated the word Hittite. If necessary, go back and listen to the beginning of Genesis chapter 36, which lists the wives of Esau. Esau's wife, Adah, was the daughter of Elon the Hittite. You translated "Arameans" in 1 Chronicles chapter 18, in the story when King David defeats King Hadadezer and the Aramean army.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

2 Chronicles 1:14–17

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (949 KB)
- Setting the Stage (3.0 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (3.8 MB)
- Embodying the Text (2.4 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.3 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.2 MB)

2 Chronicles 2:1–18

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 2:1–18 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 2:1–18 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 2:1–18 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

You can also listen to your translation of the same story in 1 Kings 5:13–18 if you have already translated it. Since the storyteller tells this story in another way, pay attention to the differences in the order of the scenes as well as some of the details.

Pause this audio here.

This story starts with King Solomon's order to build a temple where people can worship the Name of Yahweh and a royal palace for King Solomon. People can gather at the temple to worship Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, where do people usually gather to worship their gods? Who builds those places? Pause this audio here.

Then King Solomon assigned workers to work on the project. Solomon assigned 70,000 workers to carry rocks that 80,000 other workers would cut out of the mountainside. The people will use these rocks to build the temple. Three thousand six hundred men will supervise these workers.

King Solomon sent a message to King Hiram of Tyre. Tyre was just north of Israel, in the present-day country of Lebanon. King Solomon knows that his father, King David, had a good relationship with King Hiram. King Solomon asks King Hiram to send cedar wood, just like when King Hiram sent cedar wood for King David in the past. At that time, people knew about Lebanon for its thick forests, which grew valuable cedar trees. Cedar wood is tough and beautiful. King Hiram sent wood for David's palace before, but this time King Solomon asks King Hiram for timber because King Solomon is about to build a temple that Solomon will dedicate to Yahweh.

King Solomon explains what the people will do at the temple to obey Yahweh's law. [The Israelites will burn incense, a mix of gum and spices that smell good. The Israelites will set out holy or special bread each week. The Israelites will offer burnt offerings every morning and evening, on every Sabbath, at the New Moon Festival, and on the other feast days.]{.mark} The Sabbath was the seventh day of the week, and the Israelites did not work on that day; instead, the Israelites rested and honored Yahweh. In Old Testament times, the Israelites celebrated the festival of the New Moon at the beginning of each month, when the people could see the new moon rise in the sky. During this festival, the Israelites stopped their work, offered special sacrifices, and blew ram's horn trumpets to celebrate. These are the same things that people have been doing at Yahweh's tabernacle.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what practices or rituals do you do to worship God? Pause this audio here.

King Solomon plans to build a great temple for Yahweh. Solomon knows that Yahweh is the greatest of all the gods. In fact, Solomon knows that Solomon cannot build a temple that Yahweh can live in—in fact, even the heavens where Yahweh lives are not big enough for Yahweh!

King Solomon asks King Hiram to send someone who is skilled in craftsmanship. King Solomon specifically asks for a skilled worker to work with precious metals like gold, silver, bronze, and iron.

Stop here and look at a picture of gold, silver, bronze, and iron. Pause this audio here.

The skilled worker should also know how to work with high-quality materials like cloth or yarn, which people dyed to be the colors blue, purple, and red. These were expensive colors, so they often represented royalty. These were the same colors Yahweh had told the Israelites to use for the tabernacle.

King Solomon also wanted a skilled worker who knew how to do "engravings," or carvings into wood, stone, or metal. King David already prepared skilled workers in Judah and Jerusalem, his capital city, in the past to build the temple, but you will remember that Yahweh did not allow King David to build the temple for Yahweh.

Stop here and look at pictures of blue, purple, and red cloth. Pause this audio here.

Then King Solomon asks King Hiram to send King Solomon lots of wood from cedar trees, juniper trees, and algum trees. We do not know if the juniper trees are juniper, cypress, or fir trees. We also do not know what type of tree the algum trees are. Some people think algum was a type of juniper tree, while others think it was a sandalwood tree. Since people will use this wood to build a large and magnificent temple, it was probably high-quality wood that people can polish and make shiny.

2 Chronicles 2:1–18

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of cedar, Lebanese juniper, sandalwood, and cypress trees. Pause this audio here.

King Solomon is willing to pay King Hiram's workers with 2,000 tons of wheat grain, 2,000 tons of barley grain, 400,000 liters of wine, and 400,000 liters of oil. Israel produces a great amount of wheat, barley, wine, and olive oil. These were the most common foods that people in Israel ate.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What are the most common things that you grow for food in your land? What things do you normally trade with other people for? Pause this audio here.

King Hiram replies to King Solomon through a letter. King Hiram starts his letter and declares that King Solomon is proof that Yahweh loves the people of Israel. Then King Hiram praises Yahweh, who is the God of Israel, and who made heaven and earth. King Hiram continues to praise Yahweh, who gave King David a wise son, who is intelligent and full of discernment.

King Hiram will send the skilled craftsman named Huram-Abi. Huram-Abi's mother was from the Israelite tribe of Dan, and Huram-Abi's father was from Tyre. The tribe of Dan is one of the 12 tribes of Israel. Huram-Abi works with precious metals, high-quality yarn, and a special cloth that people wove from the flax plant called linen. Huram-Abi can engrave and make any design that someone gives to him. Huram-Abi will work with the skilled workers of King Solomon and those of King David to build the temple. Then King Hiram asks Solomon to send the wheat, barley, wine, and olive oil that King Solomon promised to give the workers. Finally, King Hiram tells how Hiram's workers will transport the timbers from Lebanon to Jerusalem. The workers will cut the timbers and will make wood into rafts to float on the sea south to Joppa, another town along the coast of the sea. Then, from Joppa, King Solomon's workers can take the timbers to Jerusalem.

Stop here and look at a map of Israel and Lebanon that shows Jerusalem, and also Tyre and Joppa along the coast. Pause this audio here.

King Solomon takes a census, or counts, all the foreigners who live in Israel, as King David had done before him. King Solomon counts 153,600 foreigners. King Solomon probably only counts the men. These are foreigners from other nations who live in Israel.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how do you gather or force workers to build something for your whole people group? What kinds of people have to do the work? How does the leader treat those people? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller reminds us that from these foreigners, King Solomon assigns 70,000 men to carry the rocks and 80,000 men to be stonecutters in the hills. King Solomon also assigns 3,600 foremen to supervise the workers.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how do you count how many people are in the nation? How do the leaders know who is part of different people groups? How do leaders treat the foreigners in their country?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 2:1–18 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four scenes.

In the first scene: King Solomon orders his people to build a temple for Yahweh and a palace for King Solomon.

In the second scene: King Solomon asks King Hiram of Tyre to send King Solomon an expert craftsman and a lot of wood.

In the third scene: King Hiram of Tyre agrees to Solomon's request.

In the fourth scene: King Solomon takes a census of the foreigners in Israel for the building project.

The characters in this passage are:

2 Chronicles 2:1–18

- King Solomon
- Yahweh
- King Hiram of Tyre
- Huram-Abi the craftsman
- Workers who will carry large rocks
- Workers who will cut the large rocks
- Supervisors
- Workers of King Hiram
- And foreigners in Israel

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first scene, King Solomon orders the people to build a temple for the name of Yahweh and a royal palace for King Solomon. Though the storyteller mentions King Solomon's palace, the storyteller does not tell the story of how people built it. In that culture, someone's name represented who they were, so Solomon said that Solomon wanted Yahweh himself, or Yahweh's name, to live in the temple Solomon would build for Yahweh.

The storyteller first tells us about the workers that King Solomon forced to cut stones for the temple. However, we know from later in the story that King Solomon took a census, or counted all the foreigners, before Solomon chose these workers. King Solomon gathered 80,000 workers who would quarry and cut the large rocks, and 70,000 workers who would carry the rocks from the mountainside to Jerusalem. Solomon also assigned 3,600 officers who would supervise the workers. If it would be clearer in your language, you can talk about the workers who cut the stone before you talk about the workers who move the stones.

In the second scene, King Solomon sends a message to King Hiram of Tyre and asks King Hiram to send cedar timbers, just like what King Hiram did for King David when King David built a house for himself. Solomon emphasizes the fact that this time Solomon is building a temple for Yahweh. Solomon uses a word that means "Look!" or "Pay attention!" King Solomon will not only build his own house, but King Solomon will also build a temple for Yahweh, Solomon's God. Solomon emphasizes that Yahweh is Solomon's God. Solomon is completely devoted to Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will show that Solomon emphasizes that Solomon is building a temple for Yahweh, unlike what David built before. Pause this audio here.

It will be a temple where people can go, do their religious duties, and worship Yahweh. People will do all the important things that people did in the tabernacle. You will remember that the Israelites burn incense in the tabernacle, and they set out the special bread of the presence on the table. Every week, the priests set out 12 loaves of bread on the golden table in the Holy Place in the tabernacle. In this temple, people will make burnt offerings every morning and evening, just as you remember they did in the tabernacle. People will make these burnt offerings on the Sabbath, during the New Moon Festivals, and at every other special festival, just like they did in the tabernacle. Yahweh has told the Israelites that they should do these things forever.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will show the regular actions that Solomon says the Israelites will do regularly in the temple. Review how you have translated incense, bread of the presence, burnt offerings, Sabbath, and New Moon Festivals in other books of the Bible. Pause this audio here.

This temple will be great because God is great, greater than other gods! Solomon asks several questions that Solomon does not expect anyone to answer. Solomon asks, "But who is able to build a temple for him, since the heavens, even the highest heavens, cannot contain him? Who then am I to build a temple for him, except as a place to burn sacrifices before him?" Solomon does this to show that Solomon understands that Solomon cannot build a house for Yahweh to live in. Even the heavens are not big enough to hold all of Yahweh. In this case, the "heavens, even the highest heavens," refer to the sky and everything above the earth.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will show that Solomon understands that Solomon cannot build a house for Yahweh. How will you talk about the heavens being unable to hold all of Yahweh? Pause this audio here.

That is why King Solomon asks King Hiram to send a very skillful craftsman who can work with the other craftsmen and workers who build the temple. King Solomon wants a craftsman who is skilled in working with precious metals and precious fabrics and is also skillful in carving wood, stone, and metal. King Solomon also asks King

Hiram to send a lot of wood for the building project. King Solomon wants the temple to be great and wonderful. King Solomon even assures King Hiram that King Solomon will send food to pay King Hiram's workers. Solomon promises to send 20,000 cors of ground wheat grain, 20,000 cors of barley grain, 20,000 baths of wine, and 20,000 baths of olive oil. This is about 2,000 tons of wheat, 2,000 tons of barley, and 400,000 liters of olive oil and wine. These are very large amounts of wheat, barley, wine, and oil! You may just say that King Solomon sent King Hiram 20,000 measures each of wheat, barley, wine, and oil because we are not sure exactly how much of each of these things Solomon sent.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will talk about how much of each item Solomon will send to King Hiram. If you have already translated 1 Kings 5:1–12, use the same units of measurement that you used in that passage. Pause this audio here.

In the third scene, King Hiram agrees to Solomon's request. King Hiram sends a letter to King Solomon. In the letter, King Hiram recognizes that Yahweh loves the Israelites very much. Yahweh has made Solomon king of Israel because Yahweh loves them so much! Then King Hiram also blesses, or praises, Yahweh because Solomon is wise and has a lot of knowledge. After that, King Hiram informs King Solomon that King Hiram will send Huram-Abi, who is a very skilled craftsman. Huram-Abi will supervise and work with the other craftsmen. Then King Hiram agrees to Solomon's payments and asks Solomon to do what Solomon has promised. Hiram speaks very respectfully to Solomon. Hiram calls David and Solomon my lord, or master, and Hiram calls himself Solomon's servant!

Stop here and discuss as a group: How do two leaders of different people groups or countries usually talk to each other in a way that shows they respect each other? Pause this audio here.

King Hiram's workers are ready to supply all the wood that King Solomon needs. King Hiram's workers will make the wood into rafts and deliver them to Joppa. And then from Joppa, King Solomon's workers will bring the wood to Jerusalem.

Stop here and look at the map that shows the wood moving from Tyre to Joppa to Jerusalem. Pause this audio here.

In the fourth scene, King Solomon makes a record, or census, of all the male foreigners who are living in the land of Israel, as his father David did. We are not sure if this means that King Solomon uses the numbers David counted, or if King Solomon makes this record in a similar way to the way his father, David, did. The census numbers 153,600 people.

The storyteller reminds us that from this census, Solomon assigns 80,000 workers to quarry and cut the rocks. Then King Solomon assigns 70,000 workers to carry the rocks from the mountainside to Jerusalem, where they will build the temple. Then King Solomon assigns the remaining 3,600 as foremen to supervise the workers. These are the same groups of men that the storyteller told us about at the beginning of the passage. This means that Solomon must have taken the census before Solomon assigned the men to these jobs.

Stop here and discuss as a group: [How will you make it clear that these are the same groups of men from the beginning of the story? Pause this audio here.]{.mark}

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 2:1–18 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Solomon
- Yahweh
- King Hiram of Tyre
- Huram-Abi the craftsman

2 Chronicles 2:1–18

- Workers who will carry large rocks
- Workers who will cut the large rocks
- Supervisors
- Workers of King Hiram
- And foreigners in Israel

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

In the first scene, King Solomon orders the people to build a temple for Yahweh and a royal palace for King Solomon. King Solomon gathers the workers who will quarry and cut the large rocks, and then King Solomon gathers the workers who will carry the rocks from the mountainside to Jerusalem. Solomon assigns the supervisors to supervise the work.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Solomon, "What were you thinking when you decided to build a temple for Yahweh?" The person might answer things like:

- I must do what my father, David, wanted and build a temple for Yahweh; or
- I think I need to honor Yahweh because Yahweh brought peace to Israel. I will build a temple to honor Yahweh.

Continue the drama.

In the second scene, King Solomon sends a message to King Hiram of Tyre and asks King Hiram to give cedar timbers because King Solomon will build a temple for Yahweh and a palace for Solomon. King Solomon also asks King Hiram to send a very skillful craftsman who can work with the other craftsmen and workers to build the temple. In return, King Solomon will send food to the workers.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Solomon, "What were you feeling or thinking when you asked King Hiram for his support in building the temple?" The person might answer things like:

- I think King Hiram will not refuse me in honor of my father, King David's treaty with King Hiram;
- I think King Hiram has the workers and resources I need to help build the temple.

Continue the drama.

In the third scene, King Hiram supports King Solomon's plan to build the temple. King Hiram sends a letter that recognizes that Yahweh loves the Israelites very much. King Hiram also praises Yahweh because Yahweh chose a wise king to rule Israel. Then King Hiram informs King Solomon that King Hiram sent Huram-Abi, a very skilled craftsman. Huram-Abi will work alongside the craftsmen of King Solomon and King David as they build the temple.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Hiram, "What were you feeling or thinking when King Solomon asked you to support King Solomon as he builds a temple for Yahweh?" The person might answer things like:

- King Solomon honors me when he asks me to help build the temple for Yahweh; or
- I had a treaty with King David. Now I want to keep that treaty with his son, King Solomon.

Ask the person playing Huram-Abi, "What were you feeling or thinking when you found out that you would help build the temple in Jerusalem?" The person might answer things like:

- King Hiram honors me because he has chosen me to help build the temple for Yahweh; or

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- I think this is my chance to worship Yahweh through my skills.

Continue the drama.

In the fourth scene, King Solomon counts all the foreigners who are living in the land of Israel and assigns some of them as workers and foremen.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing foreigners that King Solomon assigns to work on building the temple, "What were you feeling or thinking when you found out that you would help build the temple?" The people might answer things like:

- We feel honored for such an opportunity to help build the temple for Yahweh; or
- We feel we belong to the people of Israel; or
- I do not like that Solomon is forcing us to do this very hard work. Let Solomon find someone else to do this work!

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 2:1–18 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Solomon orders the people to build a temple for the **Name of Yahweh** and a royal palace for Solomon. Yahweh is God's personal name. In that culture, someone's name represented who that person was, so Solomon said that he wanted Yahweh himself, or Yahweh's Name, to live in the temple Solomon would build for Yahweh. A temple is a place where people worship God. It is a place where God meets with people. Kings and rulers live in a palace with their families.

Use the same word for Yahweh that you have used previously. For more information on Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for the **temple**. Look up the word temple in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for a **palace**, or a king's house. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

King Solomon gathers the workers who will quarry and cut the large rocks and the workers who will carry the rocks from the mountainside to Jerusalem. Solomon assigns the foremen or overseers to supervise the work.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for each group of **workers** and **overseers**. Pause this audio here.

Solomon sends a message to **King** Hiram of Tyre and asks King Hiram to give **cedar** timbers for building the temple and palace. Use the same words for king and cedar that you have used in previous passages. Refer to king in the Master Glossary for more information.

King Solomon says that people will burn incense in the temple. Incense is a mixture of sweet-smelling spices that makes a sweet-smelling smoke when people burn it.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for the **incense**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. If you have translated the book of Exodus, listen to Exodus 30:34–38. Pause this audio here.

Solomon also says that people will put the bread of the Presence in the temple. The bread of the Presence was 12 loaves of bread that priests put on the table in the Holy Place of the tabernacle, and later, in the temple.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for the **bread of the Presence**. Look up the phrase "bread of the Presence" in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. If you have translated 1

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Chronicles 9:32, you may listen to your translation to hear how you translated this type of bread there. Pause this audio here.

Solomon says that people will give **burnt offerings** morning and evening, on the Sabbaths, new moons, and other special festivals that Yahweh, the **God** of **Israel**, commanded the people to celebrate. Burnt offerings are animal sacrifices that people give, which the priest completely burns on the altar. The Sabbath is a special day of rest and worship. The new moon is the first day when people see a new moon in the sky. The Israelites had a special festival on that day. There are also other festivals that Yahweh told the people to celebrate each year. Use the same words for burnt offering, God, and Israel that you have used previously. See the Master Glossary for more information about burnt offerings, God, and Israel.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **Sabbath**, **new moon**, and **festivals**. Look up Sabbath and "festival of the new moon" in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Solomon says that the house that Solomon will build for God is great because the God of Israel is greater than all other gods. But God is so great that no one can build a house big enough for God. God is bigger than the highest heavens. Some people worship other supernatural beings or gods who are not Yahweh. Yahweh is greater than these false gods. In this context, "heavens" refers to the sky and everything above the earth.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **gods** and **heavens**. Look up gods and heavens in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Solomon also asks King Hiram to send a very skillful craftsman who knows how to work with metals like gold, silver, **bronze**, and iron. The craftsman must be able to work with purple, red, and blue precious fabrics and who can engrave or carve in wood, stone, and metal. This craftsman will work with the other craftsmen in **Jerusalem** and **Judah** that Solomon's father, **David**, provided. Use the same words for bronze, Jerusalem, Judah, and David that you have used in previous passages. Refer to the Master Glossary for more information about bronze, Jerusalem, Judah, and David.

Stop here and look again at a photo of **purple**, **red**, and **blue** cloth. Discuss as a group how you will describe the purple, red, and blue cloth. Pause this audio here.

King Solomon asks King Hiram to send King Solomon lots of wood from cedar trees, juniper trees, and algum trees, because Hiram's **servants** are skilled at cutting trees. We do not know whether the trees are juniper, cypress, or fir. We also do not know what type of tree the algum trees are. Some people think algum was a type of juniper tree, while others think it was a sandalwood tree. Use the same word for servant that you have used in previous passages. Refer to servant in the Master Glossary for more information.

Stop here and look at a picture of cedar, Lebanese juniper, sandalwood, and cypress trees, if needed. How will you call **cedar**, **juniper**, and **cypress** trees in your language? If you have translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and decide how you will translate **algum wood** into your language. If necessary, look again at the pictures of a sandalwood tree and a juniper tree, which might look like the trees that the storyteller mentions here. Will you use a word for an existing kind of wood from your language, or will you translate it to sound like the word in the original language? Pause this audio here.

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Solomon promises to send 20,000 cors of ground wheat grain, 20,000 cors of barley grain, 20,000 baths of **wine**, and 20,000 baths of olive oil to the workers who cut the wood. A cor is a dry measurement equal to about 6 bushels or 220 liters. A bath is a liquid measure equal to about 22 liters. This is about 2,000 tons of wheat, 2,000 tons of barley, and 400,000 liters of olive oil and wine. These are very large amounts of wheat, barley, wine, and oil! You may just say that King Solomon sent King Hiram 20,000 measures each of wheat, barley, wine, and oil. Use the same word for wine that you have used in previous passages. Refer to the Master Glossary for more information about wine.

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Stop here and discuss as a group how you will talk about how much of each item Solomon will send to King Hiram. If you have already translated 1 Kings 5:1–12, use the same units of measurement that you used in that passage. Pause this audio here.

King Hiram sends a letter back to King Solomon. Hiram says, "**Praise** or **bless** Yahweh, the God of Israel. God has given King David a **wise** son, who is intelligent and full of understanding." Use the same words for praise or bless and wise that you have used in previous passages. For more information, refer to praise, bless, and wisdom in the Master Glossary.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will describe that Solomon is wise and understands a lot of things. The words for being **intelligent** and **understanding** describe someone who knows a lot of facts but also understands how to use that knowledge for the good of other people. Pause this audio here.

King Hiram tells Solomon that Hiram has sent Hamur-Abi, a skilled craftsman, to work with Solomon's craftsmen and the craftsmen of "my lord David." When Hiram calls David "my **lord**," Hiram is using a term of respect and authority. Use the same word for lord that you have used in previous passages. For more information, refer to lord in the Master Glossary.

King Solomon takes a census of all the foreigners living in Israel, just like Solomon's father, King David, had done. A census is when a ruler or government counts the number of people. A person is a foreigner or a stranger in a country when they are in a country that is not where that person was born. There are different types of foreigners. In this context, foreigners are non-Israelites who are living permanently in Israel.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **foreigner**. Use the same word for foreigners that you have used in other books of the Bible, when it is this kind of foreigner. For more information about foreigners, refer to the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **census**, or when a leader counts the number of a certain type of people in his kingdom.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

2 Chronicles 2:1–18

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (994 KB)

- Setting the Stage (6.6 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (7.1 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.7 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (8.3 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.2 MB)

2 Chronicles 3:1–14

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 3:1–14 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 3:1–14 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 3:1–14 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passage, you heard about Solomon's preparations to build the temple. Solomon got the materials and workers to help build a temple for Yahweh.

In this passage, Solomon begins to build a temple for Yahweh. This temple is a place where people will worship Yahweh.

The information in this passage is also in 1 Kings 6:1–13 and 1 Kings 6:14–38. If you have already translated those passages, stop here and listen to your translation as a group. Pause this audio here.

Solomon builds the temple in Jerusalem on Mount Moriah, the place where Abraham went to sacrifice Abraham's son, Isaac. Solomon's father, David, chose this place to build Yahweh's temple because Yahweh appeared to David there. Before Yahweh appeared to David, this place belonged to a man named Araunah, who was a Jebusite, someone who was part of the Jebus people. Some translations call Araunah by the name Ornan. This was the threshing floor or the place where Araunah threshed or separated his grain from the rest of the plant. Solomon begins to build the temple on the second day of the second month of the year in Israel. Solomon begins to build during the fourth year Solomon is king over Israel.

Stop here as a group and look at a map of Jerusalem and Mount Moriah. Look at a picture of a threshing floor. Pause this audio here.

King Solomon lays the foundation for the temple of Yahweh, which is 60 cubits, or 30 meters, long and 20 cubits, or 10 meters, wide. A cubit is a way to measure how long something is. One cubit is about as long as the distance between a man's elbow and the tips of his fingers, or about 50 centimeters. At this time, the people of Israel probably had two different lengths for a cubit, and Solomon uses the older standard measurement for a cubit. The portico or porch at the front of the temple is 20 cubits, or 10 meters, wide, like the rest of the building. A portico, which people sometimes call a porch, is part of a structure that has columns instead of walls to hold up the roof. The portico is probably only 20 cubits high. Solomon uses pure gold to cover the inside of the portico.

2 Chronicles 3:1–14

Solomon covers the inside of the main area of the temple with wood planks. This wood could be from cypress, fir, or juniper trees. Those types of wood were very hard and lasted a long time. Solomon covers the wood planks with pure gold and makes designs of palm trees and decorative chains on the walls. Palm trees are tall trees in Israel, and palm trees can be symbols of fertility, life, plentiful crops, and Yahweh's blessing on Yahweh's people. Solomon uses expensive stones to make the main area of the temple beautiful and uses gold from the land of Parvaim, which probably means the gold was pure or of very good quality. We are not sure where Parvaim may have been located. Solomon covers the ceiling beams, door frames, walls, and doors in the main area of the temple with gold. Men carve pictures of angels called cherubim on the walls. You will remember from 1 Chronicles that cherubim are winged creatures that are part human and part animal. The cherubim represent Yahweh's majesty and Yahweh's presence. Cherubim also protect Yahweh's property and serve as a throne for a king.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of palm trees, expensive stones, and gold metal. Pause this audio here.

King Solomon also builds the room called the Most Holy Place. Any place, person, or object that people dedicate to Yahweh is holy. The Most Holy Place is a place set apart for Yahweh's presence to live.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What kinds of places or objects in your culture do people set apart to use for special reasons? Pause this audio here.

The Most Holy Place is 20 cubits, or 10 meters, long, just like the rest of the temple building. This room is also 20 cubits wide. Workmen use 600 talents of pure gold to cover the inside of the room. A talent is a way to measure how heavy something is, and 600 talents would weigh the same as about 21 metric tons. However, this amount may not be exact. Instead, 600 talents could represent how much gold there would be if each of the 12 tribes of Israel gave 50 tons of gold, or it could represent one year of income for Solomon.

Solomon uses gold nails for the Most Holy Place that weigh about 50 shekels. A shekel is another way to measure how heavy something is, and 50 shekels would weigh the same as about 600 grams. People probably made the nails out of iron and then covered the nails with gold. Solomon also covers the upper rooms with gold. We are not sure what these upper rooms may have been, but this may refer to the open space between the Most Holy Place and the ceiling of the rest of the temple.

For the Most Holy Place, men carve two cherubs out of wood, and the men cover the cherubim with gold. Together, the two cherubim's wings measure 20 cubits, or 10 meters, and the wings touched both sides of the room. The cherubim stand on their feet and look out from the Holy of Holies toward the main room of the temple. Solomon probably uses the cherubim to protect the Most Holy Place and to represent Yahweh's presence that lived there.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of cherubim. Pause this audio here.

Solomon weaves a curtain with fine linen and blue, purple, and red yarn and sews pictures of cherubim in it. Yarn is a thread that people spin and then use to weave cloth, and linen is cloth that people weave from flax plants. The curtain separates the main area of the temple from the Most Holy Place because Yahweh's presence lived in the Most Holy Place. Only the high priest, after he had made sacrifices for his sins, could enter Yahweh's presence one time per year.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a curtain. Look at a picture of blue, purple, and red yarn.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 3:1–14 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: Solomon begins to build Yahweh's temple in Jerusalem, on Mount Moriah. David chose this place to build Yahweh's temple because Yahweh had appeared to David there.

2 Chronicles 3:1–14

In the second scene: Solomon builds the foundation of the temple. The foundation is 60 cubits long and 20 cubits wide. The portico at the front is also 20 cubits wide and 20 cubits high. Solomon covers the inside of the temple with gold and carves cherubim on the walls.

In the third scene: Solomon builds the Most Holy Place at the rear of the temple, and it is 20 cubits long and 20 cubits wide. Gold covers the upper parts of the room as well. Solomon builds two cherubim and covers them with gold. The wings touch opposite walls of the Most Holy Place, and the wings touch each other in the middle of the room. Solomon also weaves a curtain that separates the Most Holy Place from the main area of the temple.

The characters in this passage are:

- Solomon
- Workers who build the temple and decorate the temple
- And Yahweh

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first scene, Solomon begins to build a temple for Yahweh. Solomon builds the temple in Jerusalem, on Mount Moriah. Yahweh had sent Abraham to sacrifice Isaac on Mount Moriah, but we are not sure if this mountain in Jerusalem is the same Mount Moriah where Abraham traveled. However, this site in Jerusalem is the place that David, Solomon's father, chose as the place to build a temple for Yahweh. Yahweh appeared to David at this place. At the time that Yahweh appeared to David, Araunah the Jebusite used this site as a place to thresh grain. The storyteller talks about Mount Moriah and David because these things are important to the people of Israel. The place where Solomon builds the temple should show how important Yahweh's temple should be to the Israelites.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Talk about a place that is important to people in your culture. What kind of language do you use to let people know this place is important? Pause this audio here.

Solomon begins construction on the second day of the second month of the year, which would have been in the middle of spring, when the weather gets warmer and plants begin to grow. Solomon starts building in his fourth year as king over Israel.

In this passage, even though the storyteller talks about how Solomon builds the temple, Solomon actually directs many men to build and to decorate the temple. When the storyteller says Solomon built the temple, we know that Solomon directs his workers to do the work.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you talk about this so that people will understand that many people worked on the temple even though the passage only talks about Solomon? Pause this audio here.

In the second scene, Solomon begins to build the foundation of the temple. In Solomon's culture, a foundation is part of the structure of a building that supports the building and provides stability. People usually placed strong rocks at the bottom of the structure and built on top of that. The foundation of the temple is 60 cubits long and 20 cubits wide, using the older cubit measurement. During this time, people probably used two different lengths to measure a cubit, and Solomon used the older standard length. The portico or porch at the entrance to the temple was 20 cubits wide and 20 cubits high.

Solomon covers the inside of the temple with pure gold. First, Solomon covers the walls of the temple with wood planks, and then Solomon covers those planks with gold. The walls have pictures of palm trees and decorative chains on them. Solomon probably carves the pictures of palm trees and chains on the wooden walls. People made chains out of metal links that they connected together. Solomon uses expensive or precious stones to decorate the temple and to make it beautiful. The workmen may have laid these stones in patterns on the floor of the main area of the temple. The gold Solomon uses comes from the land of Parvaim, but we do not know where this land may have been. Solomon covers the ceiling beams, doorframes, walls, and doors with gold. Solomon orders craftsmen to carve pictures of cherubim, or angels, into the walls of the temple.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How do people in your culture decorate important religious places? How do people talk about these special places? Pause this audio here.

In the third scene, Solomon builds the Most Holy Place. The Most Holy Place is 20 cubits long and 20 cubits wide. From another passage in the Bible, we know that the Most Holy Place is also 20 cubits high. Solomon uses 600

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talents of fine gold to cover the walls of the Most Holy Place. This amount of gold may be the exact amount used, or it may represent a gift from the 12 tribes of Israel or a donation from Solomon's income.

Solomon uses gold nails in the construction of the Most Holy Place. The gold nails weigh about 50 shekels. Workers probably make these nails from iron and cover them with gold. Solomon also covers the upper parts of the Most Holy Place with gold. We do not know exactly what the upper parts of the Most Holy Place were.

Inside the Most Holy Place, Solomon carves two cherubim, or angels. Men probably make the cherubim from wood and then cover the cherubim with gold. Each cherub has two wings. The total length of the cherubim's wings is 20 cubits. The first cherub has one wing that measures 5 cubits long, and the wing touches one wall of the Most Holy Place. The other wing of the first cherub also measures 5 cubits, and it touches one of the wings of the second cherub in the middle of the Most Holy Place. In the same way, the second cherub has one wing that measures 5 cubits long and touches the wall on the other side of the Most Holy Place. The second wing of the second cherub also measures 5 cubits long, and it touches the wing of the first cherub in the middle of the Most Holy Place. Again, the total length of all the cherubim's wings is 20 cubits. The cherubim stand on their feet, and the cherubim look out from the Most Holy Place toward the main area of the temple.

Solomon's workmen make a curtain that separates the main area of the temple from the Most Holy Place. Craftsmen weave the curtain with fine linen and cloth that people wove with blue, purple, and red yarn. The craftsmen weave cherubim into the design of the curtain.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 3:1–14 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Solomon
- Workers who build the temple and decorate the temple
- And Yahweh

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Solomon begins to build Yahweh's temple in Jerusalem, on Mount Moriah. David chose this place to build Yahweh's temple because Yahweh had appeared to David there, where Araunah the Jebusite threshed grain. Solomon begins to build the temple in mid-spring, on the second day of the second month of the year. Solomon had been king for four years when Solomon began to build the temple.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am happy that David chose this place for my temple because this place is important; or

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- I am pleased that Solomon is continuing the work of building my temple that Solomon's father, David, began.

Continue the drama.

Solomon builds the foundation of the temple using the old measure of a cubit. The foundation is 60 cubits long and 20 cubits wide. The portico at the front of the temple is also 20 cubits wide, and it is probably 20 cubits high. Solomon covers the entire inside of the temple with pure gold. Solomon uses wood planks for the walls of the temple and then covers those planks with gold. In the gold, Solomon's men carve palm trees and chain patterns to decorate the walls. Solomon uses expensive stones to decorate the temple. The pure gold Solomon uses comes from the land of Parvaim. Solomon covers the ceiling beams, doorframes, walls, and doors in the temple with gold and decorates the walls with cherubim.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing workers who build and decorate the temple, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We are happy to get to build the temple for Yahweh; or
- We work hard to make Yahweh's temple beautiful according to Solomon's plans; or
- We are proud to use our strength and our skills to serve Yahweh.

Continue the drama.

Solomon builds the Most Holy Place at the rear of the temple. The Most Holy Place is 20 cubits long and 20 cubits wide. Solomon covers the inside with 600 talents of pure gold and uses nails that craftsmen covered with gold that weigh 50 shekels. Solomon covers the upper parts of the room with gold as well. Solomon builds two cherubim and covers each cherub with gold. Each cherub has two wings, and each wing is 5 cubits long. The first cherub has one wing that touches a wall, and its other wing touches a wing of the second cherub. The second cherub has one wing that touches the other wall, and one wing that touches the wing of the first cherub. The cherubim stand on their feet and look out from the Most Holy Place toward the main area of the temple. Solomon also weaves a curtain made of blue, purple, and red yarn and fine linen. Workers sew images of cherubim into the curtain, and people hang the curtain so that it separates the Most Holy Place from the main area of the temple.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Solomon, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel excited to build Yahweh's temple and to decorate it with such beautiful materials; or
- I feel humbled that Yahweh allows me to build the temple even though my father, David, planned to build it.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 3:1–14 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

If you have already translated 1 Kings 6:1–13 and 1 Kings 6:14–38, listen to your translation again to remind yourselves which words you used to translate that passage. Pause this audio here.

Solomon begins to build the **temple** for **Yahweh**. The temple is the place where the Israelites worshiped Yahweh. Yahweh is the name God gave himself. This name reminds people of God's covenant with the Israelites. Use the same words or phrases for temple and Yahweh that you used in previous passages. For more information on temple and Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary.

Solomon builds the temple in **Jerusalem**, where Yahweh appeared to Solomon's father, **David**. David established Jerusalem as the capital of Israel. Use the same words or phrases for Jerusalem and David as you used in previous passages. For more information on Jerusalem and David, refer to the Master Glossary.

Solomon lays the foundation for the temple of **God**, and it is 60 cubits long and 20 cubits wide. Use the same word for God as you have used previously, and refer to God in the Master Glossary for more information.

The portico at the front of the temple is 20 cubits long and 20 cubits high. A cubit is a way to measure how long something is. One cubit is about as long as a man's arm from his elbow to his fingertips, or 50 centimeters. A

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portico, which people sometimes call a porch, is part of a structure that has columns instead of walls to hold up the roof.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **cubit** and **portico**. Look up cubit in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Solomon covers the entire main hall with wood planks that people made from **cypress**, **fir**, or **juniper** trees. Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for this wood. Use the same word you have used in the previous passage.

Solomon covers the entire inside of the temple with pure **gold**. Gold is a yellow precious metal that people use to make jewelry and for decoration. Use the same word or phrase for gold as you used in previous passages.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of gold metal. Pause this audio here.

Solomon covers every part of the inside of the temple with gold. Solomon covers the ceiling beams, door frames, walls, and doors with gold. People make ceiling beams from wood. Then, people place these beams across the tops of a building's walls to help support the roof. People make door frames out of wood to decorate and give stability to a doorway. People use walls to help give structure to a building and to hold up the roof. People use doors as openings to move into and out of a building, and as openings to move between rooms of a building.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **ceiling beams**, **door frames**, **walls**, and **doors**. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words or phrases that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Solomon uses wood panels for the walls and covers them with gold. Solomon uses expensive stones to decorate the temple. Solomon also carves pictures of palm trees, chain patterns, and cherubim into the gold walls. A cherub is a type of angel, and cherubim means more than one angel. Cherubim seem to guard especially holy or sacred places.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of **cherubim**. Discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for cherubim. Look up cherubim in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Solomon builds the Most Holy Place, and it is 20 cubits long and 20 cubits wide. The Most Holy Place contained the two cherubim that Solomon carved and the ark of the covenant. Yahweh lived in the Most Holy Place, and no one was allowed to enter the Most Holy Place except Yahweh's high priest.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **Most Holy Place**. Look up Most Holy Place in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this phrase in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Solomon weaves a curtain that Solomon made of fine linen and blue, purple, and red yarn to separate the Most Holy Place from the rest of the temple. A curtain is a piece of material that people hang from the top to create a covering or screen.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of blue, purple, and red yarn. Look at a picture of a **curtain**. Discuss what word or phrase you will use for curtain, and remind yourselves of the words you used for the colors blue, purple, and red in the previous passage. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

2 Chronicles 3:1–14

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (461 KB)
- Setting the Stage (3.5 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (3.7 MB)
- Embodying the Text (2.3 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.8 MB)
- Speaking the Word (708 KB)

2 Chronicles 3:15–4:10

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 3:15–4:10 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 3:15–4:10 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 3:15–4:10 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passage, you heard about how Solomon built Yahweh's temple at the site that David, Solomon's father, had chosen. Solomon covered the entire inside of the temple, which includes the main hall and the Most Holy Place, with gold. Solomon carved decorations into the walls and placed a curtain in front of the Most Holy Place.

Stop here and listen: If you have already translated 1 Kings 7:13–39, which contains the same information, listen to your translation of that passage as a group. Pause this audio here.

2 Chronicles 3:15–4:10

In this passage, the storyteller continues to describe how Solomon decorates the outside of the temple and makes objects for people to use in worship. However, the storyteller does not tell us exactly who does the work. From another passage in the Bible, we know Solomon commands a man named Huram from the city of Tyre to create all the bronze objects outside the temple.

In front of the temple, Solomon builds two pillars. We know from another passage in the Bible that Solomon makes these pillars out of bronze. Solomon probably makes these pillars for decoration, and the pillars are probably not connected to the temple building. These pillars measure about 35 cubits or 16 meters high. People use cubits to measure length. In another passage of the Bible, the storyteller measures each pillar to be 18 cubits high. In this passage, the storyteller might be talking about how long the two pillars are when someone lays them down one after the other. Together, the pillars measure 35 cubits long. Or the storyteller might be adding up different measurements of just one pillar, like the pillar's height, width, and circumference, to get the same measurement of 35 cubits.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a pillar. Pause this audio here.

On top of each pillar, Solomon puts a bronze capital, or a special decorative top. These capitals measure 5 cubits or 2.5 meters high. Solomon decorates the capitals with bronze chains that may have looked like braids. Solomon makes 100 bronze images that look like pomegranates and hangs them from the chains. Pomegranates are reddish fruits about the size of a human fist. Solomon attaches the pomegranates to the chains. From another passage in the Bible, we know Solomon decorates each capital with 2 chains and 200 pomegranates.

Stop here and look at a picture of metal braided chains and a picture of pomegranates. Pause this audio here.

Solomon sets the pillars in front of the temple. Solomon puts one pillar to the right or south of the temple entrance. Solomon names this pillar Jakin, which means, "Yahweh will establish." Solomon puts the other pillar to the left or north side of the temple entrance. Solomon names this pillar Boaz, which means, "strength is in Yahweh." Solomon may name the pillars this way to remind the people that Yahweh lives in the temple.

Solomon makes an altar out of bronze that measures 20 cubits or 9 meters long, 20 cubits or 9 meters wide, and 10 cubits or 4.5 meters high. These measurements may be for the base or foundation of the altar, and stairs may have led up to a platform. An altar is a place where people make sacrifices to Yahweh. An altar is like a table or platform where people put sacrifices, and people often burn these sacrifices on the altar.

Stop here as a group and look at a drawing of the altar. Discuss as a group: How do people worship gods in your culture? Pause this audio here.

Then Solomon makes a large round basin from bronze, and Solomon names the basin "the Sea." The Sea measures 10 cubits, or 4.5 meters, across from edge to edge and 5 cubits, or just over 2 meters, high. People use a piece of string to measure around the rim of the Sea. The rim is 30 cubits or 13.5 meters around the circumference. Below the rim of the Sea, Solomon places figures to decorate the Sea. These figures may look like oxen bulls, but in another passage in the Bible, the storyteller says these decorations look like gourds, which are melon-like fruits. Solomon uses 10 figures for every cubit all the way around the Sea and places them in two rows. Solomon casts the figures at the same time as the Sea and uses one mold for it all.

Solomon places the Sea on the figures of 12 large bulls that people probably make out of bronze or stone. These bulls are much larger than the decorations around the rim of the Sea. Three bulls face north, three face west, three face south, and three face east. The Sea sits on the backs of the bulls, and the bulls all face outward. The Sea is about a handbreadth thick, or about the width of four fingers or 8 centimeters. Solomon shapes the edge of the Sea to look like the rim of a cup or like the petals of a lily. A lily is a large red or white flower with petals that curve outward from the center. In this passage, the storyteller says the Sea holds 3,000 baths of water. In another passage in the Bible, the storyteller says the Sea holds 2,000 baths of water. We do not know exactly how many liters are in one bath, but the Sea probably holds between 40,000 and 80,000 liters of water.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a bull and a picture of a lily. Pause this audio here.

Next, Solomon makes 10 smaller basins for washing. Solomon probably places five basins on the south side and five basins on the north side of the temple entrance, or Solomon may place the basins on the south and north sides of the Sea. People use the basins to wash either the things they use to offer burnt offerings or to wash the

2 Chronicles 3:15–4:10

animals before people sacrifice the animals. A burnt offering is a form of sacrifice that people bring to Yahweh. However, priests use the Sea to wash their hands and feet.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of the smaller wash basins. Pause this audio here.

Solomon then makes 10 lampstands out of gold, and Solomon makes them exactly the way Yahweh says people should make these lampstands. Yahweh may have told King David how to make the lampstands, and then David told Solomon. We do not know exactly how the lampstands looked, but they probably had several wicks like candles that people could light. Solomon places the lampstands inside the main hall of the temple, with five on the south side and five on the north side. Solomon also makes 10 tables and places them in the main hall of the temple with the lampstands, 5 on the south side and 5 on the north side. From another passage in the Bible, we know Solomon probably makes the tables out of wood and covers them with gold. We do not know if Solomon puts the lampstands on the tables or if Solomon uses the tables for the bread that represents Yahweh's presence. Solomon also makes 100 small gold bowls. People probably use these bowls to hold the blood of animals before they sprinkle the blood on the altar.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a gold lampstand. Pause this audio here.

Solomon builds walls around the inner court where only priests could enter. Solomon also builds walls and doors for the larger court, where any person could enter. Solomon covers the doors with bronze.

Stop here and look at a diagram of the two different courtyards in Solomon's temple. Pause this audio here.

Solomon places the Sea on the southeastern side of the temple.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 3:15–4:10 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: Solomon makes two large bronze pillars to stand in the front entrance of the temple. Solomon decorates the pillars with chains and pomegranates and names the pillars Jakin and Boaz.

In the second scene: Solomon makes the altar and the Sea. Solomon decorates the Sea with figures and places the Sea on the backs of 12 large bull statues that all face outward.

In the third scene: Solomon makes 10 wash basins, 10 gold lamp stands, 10 tables, and 100 small gold bowls. Solomon builds walls and doors for the inner and outer courtyards. Solomon puts the Sea at the southeast corner of the temple.

The characters in this passage are:

- Solomon
- Huram—even though the storyteller does not mention Huram's name in this passage, we know Huram is the main worker
- Workers who help Huram
- And Yahweh

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In scene one, Solomon makes two large bronze pillars for the front of the temple. We know from another passage in the Bible that Solomon did not actually make the pillars. Instead, Solomon commands a man named Huram from the city of Tyre to cast or mold objects out of bronze. Even though the storyteller says Solomon makes the pillars and many other bronze objects in this passage, we know that Solomon commands Huram to make things out of bronze.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you show that Solomon himself did not do the construction work on the temple, but Solomon ordered workers to do it? Pause this audio here.

2 Chronicles 3:15–4:10

As you translate this passage, you may find several different ways to interpret some of the words and measurements. You may want to follow the interpretation of the Bible you use for translation. Pause this audio here.

Solomon makes the pillars 35 cubits tall. Solomon also makes capitals, or decorative tops, for the tops of each pillar that measure 5 cubits high. Solomon decorates the capitals with bronze chains and images of pomegranates. Each pillar has two chains with 100 pomegranates attached to each chain. Solomon puts the pillars in front of the temple entrance. Solomon puts one pillar on the south or right side of the entrance, and Solomon names the pillar Jakin, which means "Yahweh will establish." Solomon places the other pillar on the north or left side of the temple entrance, and Solomon names this pillar Boaz, which means "strength is in Yahweh." We do not know if these pillars hold up the roof of the porch, or if they are standing on their own.

In the second scene, Solomon makes a bronze altar that measures 20 cubits long, 20 cubits wide, and 10 cubits high. You will remember that a cubit measures about 50 centimeters long. We do not know exactly how the altar looks, but we know people use it to offer animals as burnt offerings when they worship Yahweh. Next, Solomon makes a large, round bronze basin and names it "the Sea." The Sea measures 10 cubits across from rim to rim, and the Sea is 5 cubits high. To measure all the way around the Sea, people use a piece of string that measures 30 cubits.

Below the rim all the way around the Sea, Solomon places decorations in two rows. For every cubit around the Sea, Solomon uses 10 figures for decoration. In this passage, the storyteller says the figures look like bulls. Bulls are large animals with four legs. These bulls were probably oxen, which means someone had castrated them. In another passage in the Bible, however, the storyteller says the decorations around the Sea look like gourds, which are fruits that look like melons. Solomon makes the Sea and the figure decorations all at once with the same mold.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you describe the decorations Solomon uses around the Sea? Remember that you can follow the interpretation of the Bible you use for translation when different interpretations of the same words may exist. Pause this audio here.

Solomon places the Sea on 12 large figures that look like bulls. The Sea sits on the backs of the bulls, and the bulls face outward. Three bulls face in each direction, north, west, south, and east. The Sea measures a handbreadth thick, and Solomon makes the rim curve outward like the rim of a cup or the petals on a lily. The Sea can hold 3,000 baths. People use baths to measure the volume of liquids. We are not sure exactly how many liters may be in a bath, but the Sea probably held between 40,000 and 80,000 liters.

In the third scene, Solomon makes 10 smaller wash basins out of bronze. Solomon puts the wash basins outside the temple, 5 on the south side and 5 on the north side. People use these smaller wash basins to wash the things they use to sacrifice animals or to wash the animals that people will burn as offerings to Yahweh. But the priests use the Sea to wash their hands and feet.

Next, Solomon makes 10 lampstands out of gold according to the instructions Yahweh had given. Solomon puts these lampstands inside the main hall of the temple, 5 on the south side of the hall and 5 on the north side. Solomon also makes 10 tables for the main hall inside the temple. Solomon puts 5 on the south and 5 on the north side of the main hall. Solomon may have placed the lampstands on the tables.

Solomon makes 100 small gold bowls. People use these bowls to hold the blood from the animals they sacrifice, and then people sprinkle the blood on the altar.

Solomon makes walls for the inner courtyard where only priests could go. Solomon also makes walls and a door for the larger courtyard where any person could go. Solomon covers the doors to the courtyards with bronze. Solomon places the Sea outside the temple on the southeast side.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Solomon places each object in a specific location. Look at a diagram that shows where Solomon placed the objects. How will you describe the location of each object based on the diagram? Pause this audio here.

Cultures have different ways to describe directions like north, south, east, and west. You will remember that the sun rises in the east. How will you describe the different directions for your culture? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

2 Chronicles 3:15–4:10

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 3:15–4:10 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Solomon
- Huram—even though the storyteller does not mention Huram's name in this passage, we know Huram is the main worker
- Workers who help Huram
- And Yahweh

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Solomon tells Huram to make two bronze pillars for the front of the temple. On top of each pillar, Solomon puts a capital, bronze chains, and bronze images of pomegranates for decoration. Solomon places one pillar on the south side of the temple entrance, and Solomon names that pillar Jakin. Solomon places the other pillar on the north side of the entrance, and Solomon names that pillar Boaz.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Huram, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am happy that I can use my bronze-working skills to help Solomon make Yahweh's temple beautiful; or
- I feel honored because I get to work on Yahweh's temple.

Continue the drama.

Solomon builds a bronze altar, and Solomon makes the large, round bronze basin called the Sea. The Sea measures 10 cubits rim to rim and 5 cubits high. People use a string that is 30 cubits long to measure around the Sea. Solomon decorates the Sea under its rim with two rows of figures that look like bulls. Solomon uses 10 bulls for every cubit around the Sea. Solomon makes the Sea and the decorative figures at the same time from the same mold.

Solomon places the Sea on 12 larger figures that look like bulls. The bulls face outward, three in each direction, and the sea sits on their backs. The Sea measures a handbreadth thick, and its rim curves out like the rim of a cup or the petal of a lily. The Sea can hold about 3,000 baths of water.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel pleased to see my people spend so much time and resources to honor me; or
- I feel happy because I know that, even though I could make my own house, Solomon and my people work hard to honor me by building this beautiful temple for me to live in.

Continue the drama.

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Solomon makes 10 smaller wash basins for the outside of the temple. Solomon places 5 basins on the south side and 5 basins on the north side of the temple. People use these basins to wash the things they use to offer burnt offerings, but priests use the Sea to wash their hands and feet.

Next, Solomon makes 10 lampstands and 10 tables from gold. Solomon places these objects inside the main hall of the temple, 5 of each on the south side and 5 of each on the north side. Solomon also makes 100 gold bowls for sprinkling blood.

Solomon builds the walls of the inner courtyard that only priests can use. Solomon also builds walls and doors for the larger outer courtyard, where any person can enter. Solomon covers the courtyard doors with bronze. Solomon places the Sea outside the temple on the southeast corner.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Solomon, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel hopeful that Yahweh will like all the objects we make for Yahweh's temple; or
- I feel confident that Yahweh's temple will be beautiful and will use the best materials available.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 3:15–4:10 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Stop here and listen: If you have already translated 1 Kings 7:13–39, which contains the same information, listen to your translation of that passage as a group. Pause this audio here.

Solomon makes two bronze metal pillars for the front entrance of the **temple**. People usually make tall vertical structures called "pillars" out of metal, wood, or stone. Pillars may help to support a building, or people may use pillars as decoration. Israelites worship Yahweh in the temple. Use the same word or phrase for temple as you have used in previous passages. For more information on temple, refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a **pillar**. Discuss what word or phrase you will use for pillar. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Solomon makes the pillars 35 cubits long. People use cubits to measure length, and a cubit measures about 50 centimeters. Use the same word or phrase for **cubit** as you used in previous passages. For more information on cubit, refer to the Master Glossary.

Solomon places a capital on top of each pillar. The word capital is special language that refers to an object that Solomon uses to decorate the top of each pillar. Because these pillars probably do not support the roof of the temple, the capitals sit on the top of each pillar.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **capital**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Solomon makes chains and images of pomegranates to decorate the capitals on the pillars. People probably weave bronze metal together to make chains that look like braids. Pomegranates are reddish fruits about the same size as a human's fist. People probably make images of these pomegranates out of bronze metal.

Stop here and look at a picture of **chains** and a **pomegranate**. Discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for chain and pomegranate. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Solomon makes an **altar** out of **bronze**. An altar is a place where people make sacrifices to Yahweh. An altar is like a table or platform where people put sacrifices, and people often burn these sacrifices on the altar. Bronze is a metal that people make by combining copper and tin. Use the same word or phrase for altar and bronze as you used in previous passages. For more information on altar and bronze, refer to the Master Glossary.

2 Chronicles 3:15–4:10

Solomon makes the Sea out of metal and places decorations that may look like bulls just below the rim. A bull is a male ox.

Stop here and look at a picture of a **bull** as a group. If you choose to use the interpretation that says these are bulls, discuss what word or phrase you will use for bull. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Solomon makes the Sea about one handbreadth thick. People use a handbreadth, which measures about 4 fingers or 8 centimeters, to measure how thick something is.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **handbreadth**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Solomon makes the rim of the Sea curve outward like the rim of a cup or the petals on a lily. A lily is a large red or white flower with petals that curve out away from its center.

Stop here and look at a picture of a **lily**. Discuss what word or phrase you will use for lily. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Solomon makes the Sea large enough to hold 3,000 **baths**. We do not know exactly how much a bath might be, but the Sea probably holds between 40,000 and 80,000 liters of water. Baths measure the volume of liquid. Use the same word or phrase for bath as you used in previous passages.

Solomon makes 10 wash basins to place outside the temple. People use the wash basins to clean the things people use to make **burnt offerings**. A burnt offering is a form of sacrifice that people bring to Yahweh. Look up burnt offering in the master Glossary for more information. Use the same word that you have used in previous passages.

Although people use the wash basins to clean the things for burnt offerings, priests use the Sea to wash themselves. Priests are people who work in the temple of Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **priest**. Look up priest in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Solomon makes 10 lampstands and 100 small bowls out of **gold**. Gold is a precious yellow metal. Use the same word or phrase for gold as you have used in previous passages.

People light wicks on lampstands to use as a source of light.

Stop here and discuss what word or phrase you will use for **lampstand**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

2 Chronicles 3:15–4:10

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (513 KB)
- Setting the Stage (4.1 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (3.5 MB)
- Embodying the Text (2.2 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.9 MB)
- Speaking the Word (707 KB)

2 Chronicles 4:11–5:1

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 4:11–5:1 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 4:11–5:1 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 4:11–5:1 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passage, the storyteller explained that Huram made the two pillars, the incense altar, the Sea, and the 10 basins out of bronze. The storyteller then told how Solomon directed workers to make other objects for the inside of the temple out of gold. Solomon finally directed workers to make courtyards and doors for the courtyards.

In this passage, the storyteller gives a list of the furnishings, or the furniture and decorations, for the temple. Solomon directs Huram to make some objects out of bronze. Solomon directs other workers to make objects out of gold.

Stop here and listen as a group: If you have already translated 1 Kings 7:40–51, which contains the same information, listen to your translation now. Pause this audio here.

Huram makes small bowls for ashes, shovels, and small basins. People use the small bowls to carry ashes from the altar where people burn sacrifices. These shovels were tools with a broad, flat blade and a handle that may have been between 0.5 meters and 2 meters long. People use small shovels to move hot coals and to scoop ashes from the altar. People use small basins to catch the blood from animal sacrifices. These basins are probably a little bit

bigger than the bowls people use to carry ashes. People worship Yahweh by making sacrifices on the altar, and then people sprinkle the blood from the basins onto the altar, so people call these basins “sprinkling basins.”

Stop here and look at a picture of a small bowl, a small shovel, and a small basin. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller gives a summary of all the work King Solomon gives Huram to complete for Yahweh’s temple. This is what Huram makes out of bronze. Huram makes the two bronze pillars with the bowl-shaped capitals on top. You will remember that people use capitals as decorative tops on pillars. Huram also makes the chains that decorate the capitals. Huram makes 400 images of pomegranates. Huram uses two rows of pomegranates to decorate each chain on the bowl-shaped capitals, and Huram places one capital on top of each pillar. You will remember that pomegranates are reddish fruits about the size of a human fist. Huram makes the movable stands, and each stand holds a water basin. Huram makes the Sea and the 12 figures that look like bulls that hold up the Sea. Huram makes the bowls for ashes, shovels, and meat forks. These forks have two sharp points on the end, and people use the forks to handle meat that people offer for sacrifices. Huram makes all the bronze objects that people need to make sacrifices.

Huram makes each of these items just as King Solomon directed Huram to do. Huram makes the objects out of bronze that people have rubbed with a cloth to make the bronze shiny. You will remember that people make bronze by combining copper and tin together. People use these bronze objects in Yahweh’s temple.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a pillar, a capital, chains, a pomegranate, a wash basin in a movable stand, a bull, and a meat fork. Pause this audio here.

King Solomon orders his workers to make these objects out of bronze. The workers melt the bronze until it becomes liquid. Then the workers dig molds out of clay in the ground and pour the liquid bronze into the clay molds. When the bronze cools, it hardens into the shape of the mold. The workers do this in the lower plain of the Jordan River between the towns of Succoth and Zarethan. The plain of the Jordan refers to the lower valley of the Jordan River, which is south of the Dead Sea. Succoth was a town east of the Jordan River and west of the Jabbock River. Zarethan was a town east of the Jordan River, but we do not know exactly where it may have been. In some translations, people call this town by the name of Zeredah. This land contained a lot of clay that workers used to make clay molds. Solomon does not ask his workers to weigh the objects Huram makes out of bronze because Huram makes so many objects. So, no one can calculate how much bronze Solomon’s workers used to make the objects for the temple.

Stop here as a group and look at a map of the plain of the Jordan River. Find the cities of Succoth and Zarethan. Pause this audio here.

King Solomon also directs workers to make all the gold furnishings for the inside of Yahweh’s temple. Solomon makes the gold altar for incense. Solomon makes the gold table where people put the bread of the Presence. Every week on the Sabbath day, or religious day of rest, people put fresh bread on the table as an offering to Yahweh. Workers probably make the altar and the table out of wood and cover the wood with gold. Solomon makes lampstands out of high-quality gold, and Solomon makes lamps to go with the gold stands. The lampstands probably have a cylindrical shape with tops and bottoms that flare outward. People probably make the lamps out of ceramic, and they have a wick that people made of flax that uses olive oil as fuel. These lamps burn inside the main hall of the temple on each side of the door that goes into the entrance to the Most Holy Place, in the way Yahweh ordered. Solomon makes gold flowers that decorate the lampstands. Solomon also makes gold tongs, a tool with two arms joined at one end that people can use to pick things up. People probably use gold tongs to trim wicks or to remove burned wicks from the lamps. Solomon makes these objects out of solid gold.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of the incense altar, a lampstand with a lamp, and a pair of tongs. Pause this audio here.

Solomon also makes wick trimmers or shears that people use to cut wicks to maintain the lamps, sprinkling basins, dishes for holding incense, and censers or firepans people use to carry burning incense. Solomon’s workers make the doors to the Most Holy Place and the doors of the main hall of the temple out of gold.

Stop here and look at a picture of a wick-trimmer and a censer. Pause this audio here.

2 Chronicles 4:11–5:1

When King Solomon finishes all his work for Yahweh's temple, Solomon gathers all the things his father David had dedicated to Yahweh. David had given various valuable articles to Yahweh. People made some of these articles from silver and gold. Solomon puts all these things in the treasure room, or the rooms where Solomon keeps valuable treasures, inside Yahweh's temple.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Where might people keep valuable treasures in your culture?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 4:11–5:1 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has two scenes.

In the first scene: Solomon had asked Huram to make several items out of polished bronze for Yahweh's temple, and Huram finishes that work. Workmen pour liquid bronze into clay molds in the ground in the plain of the Jordan River Valley. Solomon does not ask anyone to weigh the bronze, so no one knows how much bronze Huram uses.

In the second scene: Solomon's workers make the furnishings for Yahweh's temple out of high-quality gold. When Solomon knows the workers have finished, Solomon puts all the articles, including silver and gold, that King David had dedicated to Yahweh in the treasure room of the temple.

The characters in this passage are:

- Huram
- Solomon
- Solomon's workers
- And Yahweh

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first scene, Huram makes objects out of bronze for people to use in Yahweh's temple. Huram makes small bowls for ashes, small shovels, and small basins for sprinkling blood. In some Bible translations, and in the earlier story in 2 Chronicles, the storyteller calls Huram by a longer name, "Huram-Abi." Huram and Huram-Abi are the same person.

Stop here and discuss as a group which name you will use, "Huram" or "Huram-Abi." You should use the same name as the translation of the Bible you normally use. Pause this audio here.

King Solomon had directed Huram to make these items for Yahweh's temple out of bronze, and Huram completed the work. In this passage, the storyteller gives a summary of all the work Huram completed for Yahweh's temple. The storyteller has described most of these items already in previous passages.

Huram made the two large pillars that stand at the entrance to the temple. On top of each pillar rests a bowl-shaped capital, or decorative top. Huram decorated the capitals with chains. Huram placed two rows of chains on each capital. Huram decorated the chains with images that look like pomegranates. Pomegranates are reddish fruits about the size of a human fist. Huram made 400 images of pomegranates. Huram used two rows of pomegranates to decorate each chain on the bowl-shaped capitals, and Huram placed one capital on top of each pillar.

Huram also made water basins on movable stands. People used these basins to wash the things they used for burnt offerings. Huram made a large water tank called the Sea, and Huram made the 12 images that look like bulls that support the Sea. Priests used the Sea to wash themselves. Huram made the small bowls for ashes, the small shovels, and the meat forks. In another passage in the Bible, the storyteller says Huram made sprinkling basins and does not mention meat forks, but we know people could use either object when they made sacrifices. These forks have two sharp points on the end, and people use the forks to handle meat that people offer for

2 Chronicles 4:11–5:1

sacrifices. Huram made all the bronze objects out of polished bronze that people rubbed with cloth until the bronze looked shiny.

Stop here and discuss as a group: The storyteller uses this passage to give a summary, or a list, of what Huram makes. Listen to your translation of 2 Chronicles 3:15–4:10 where the storyteller already talked about these objects that Huram made. Use this passage to remember how you already described these objects. Use the same words here for these objects as you used in previous passages. Pause this audio here.

Solomon directed Huram and other workers to make these objects for Yahweh's temple. Solomon's workers cast the items by melting bronze and then pouring it into clay molds that the workers had dug in the ground. The workers did this in the lower plain of the Jordan River between the towns of Sukkoth and Zarethan. Solomon did not ask any worker to weigh any of the bronze because Solomon made so many objects out of bronze. So, no one calculated how much bronze the workers used to make objects for Yahweh's temple.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you talk about the way Huram casts these objects in clay? Pause this audio here.

In the second scene, Solomon also makes the furnishings for the inside of Yahweh's temple out of pure or high-quality gold. However, even though the storyteller says Solomon makes these objects, Solomon does not actually do the work himself. Solomon directs his workers and craftsmen to make these objects out of gold.

Solomon makes the incense altar and the table that holds the bread of the Presence. Solomon makes lampstands and the lamps that go on the lampstands. Solomon places these lamps on their stands outside the Most Holy Place in the way Yahweh ordered. Solomon makes gold flowers to decorate the lampstands, and Solomon makes solid gold tongs to trim or to remove the wicks from the lamps. Solomon makes wick trimmers, basins for sprinkling blood, dishes for incense, and censers to hold burning incense. Solomon also makes the doors to the Most Holy Place and to the main hall of the temple out of gold.

Stop here as a group and listen to your translations of Exodus 37:17–24 and Exodus 37:25–38:8. In these passages, Moses describes some similar objects that people made for the tabernacle. If you have already translated these passages, use your translations to help you talk about these objects that Huram made for the temple. Pause this audio here.

If it helps you, look again at a picture of a pillar, a capital, chains, a pomegranate, a water basin in a movable stand, a bull, a meat fork, the altar, a lampstand with a lamp, a pair of tongs, a wick-trimmer, and a censer. Pause this audio here.

When Solomon makes all the objects for Yahweh's temple, Solomon brings all the gold and silver furnishings that his father, King David, had dedicated to Yahweh. Solomon puts these things in the treasure room in Yahweh's temple.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What kinds of furnishings do you use for sacred places in your culture? How will you describe the special furnishings Solomon uses for Yahweh's temple? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 4:11–5:1 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has two scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Huram
- Solomon
- Solomon's workers
- And Yahweh

2 Chronicles 4:11–5:1

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Huram makes bowls for ashes, shovels, and small basins out of bronze. Now we hear a summary of the work King Solomon asks Huram to do. Huram makes many items out of bronze. Huram makes the two large pillars that stand at the entrance to the temple. On top of each pillar, Huram puts a bowl-shaped capital, or top. Huram decorates the capitals with chains. Huram places two rows of chains on each capital. Huram decorates the chains with 400 images that look like pomegranates. Huram also makes water basins on movable stands. Huram makes a large water tank called the Sea, and Huram makes the 12 images that look like bulls that support the Sea.

Huram makes all these objects out of bronze that workers polish until it looks shiny. Solomon's workers cast the items in clay molds that they dig in the ground. The workers do this work in the lower plain of the Jordan River between the towns of Succoth and Zarethan. Solomon does not ask any worker to weigh any of the bronze because Solomon makes so many objects out of bronze. So, no one calculates how much bronze the workers use to make objects for Yahweh's temple.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Huram, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel pleased because I have completed the work Solomon gave me to do for Yahweh's temple; or
- I feel happy when I see all the beautiful things I have made for Yahweh's temple.

Ask the person playing Solomon, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel certain that Yahweh is pleased with Huram's work; or
- I think the Israelite people and the other nations around us will feel impressed when they see Yahweh's temple.

Continue the drama.

Solomon also makes the furnishings for the inside of Yahweh's temple out of high-quality gold. Solomon makes the altar for incense and the table that holds the bread of the Presence. Solomon makes lampstands and lamps and puts them in front of the Most Holy Place. Solomon makes the gold flowers that decorate the lampstands, and Solomon makes solid gold tongs. Solomon makes wick trimmers, basins for sprinkling blood, dishes for incense, and censers to hold burning incense. Solomon also makes the doors to the Most Holy Place and the doors at the entrance to the main hall of the temple out of gold.

When Solomon completes all the objects for Yahweh's temple, Solomon brings all the gold and silver furnishings that his father, King David, had dedicated to Yahweh. Solomon puts these things in the treasure room in Yahweh's temple.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel pleased to see the beautiful temple Solomon made for me to live in; or
- I feel love for Solomon and for my people, the Israelites. My people have worked very hard to make me a beautiful place to live.

Ask the people playing Solomon's workers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We feel weary because Solomon has required us to work very hard to build Yahweh's temple and to craft the objects in it; or
- We feel happy that we have finished Yahweh's temple; or
- We feel satisfied to see the beauty of Yahweh's temple.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 4:11–5:1 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Stop here and listen as a group: If you have already translated 1 Kings 7:40–51, which contains the same information, listen to it now. Pause this audio here.

Huram completes the items Solomon asked him to make for **God**'s **temple**. God refers to the God who created everything. God is the most powerful spiritual being who made a covenant with the Israelites. Israelites worship God in the temple. Use the same words or phrases for God and temple as you used in previous passages. For more information on God and temple, refer to the Master Glossary.

Huram makes two **pillars** for the front entrance of the temple. People usually make tall vertical structures called pillars out of metal, wood, or stone. Pillars may help to support a building, or people may use pillars as decoration. Use the same word or phrase for pillar as you used in previous passages.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a pillar. Pause this audio here.

Huram puts a **capital** on the top of each pillar. The word capital is special language that people use to talk about the decorative top of a pillar in Solomon's temple. Huram shapes the capitals to look like bowls and decorates the capitals with **chains** and **pomegranates**. People probably weave metal together in the shape of a braid to make these chains. Pomegranates are reddish fruits about the same size as a human's fist. Use the same words or phrases for capital, chains, and pomegranate as you used in previous passages.

Stop here and look at a picture of a capital, chains, and a pomegranate. Pause this audio here.

Huram makes water basins in movable stands, the Sea and the bulls that support it, bowls and shovels for ashes, and meat forks that people use to handle meat from sacrifices. Huram makes all the objects for the temple of **Yahweh** out of **bronze** that people polish so that it looks shiny. Bronze is a type of metal made from copper and tin. Use the same words or phrases for Yahweh and bronze as you used in previous passages. For more information on Yahweh and bronze, refer to the Master Glossary.

Huram and the other workers cast the bronze objects in the plain, or flat area, around the Jordan River between the towns of Succoth and Zarethan. The Jordan River is a long river that runs through Israel from north to south.

Stop here and look at a map of the **Jordan River** as a group. Discuss what word or phrase you will use for "Jordan River." Look up Jordan River in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Solomon makes the **furnishings** for Yahweh's temple. Furnishings include furniture and other items people use to decorate a building or a room. Use the same word or phrase for furnishings as you used in previous passages.

Solomon makes objects for Yahweh's temple out of **gold**. Gold is a precious yellow metal. Use the same word or phrase for gold as you used in previous passages.

Solomon makes the incense **altar** and the table for the **bread of the Presence**. An altar is a place where people make offerings or sacrifices to a god. The Israelites made sacrifices on the altar to Yahweh. Priests put 12 loaves of bread on a table just outside the Most Holy Place to remind the Israelites that Yahweh lives in the temple. The people call this the bread of the Presence. Use the same word or phrase for altar and for "bread of the Presence" as you used in previous passages. For more information on altar, refer to the Master Glossary.

Solomon makes lampstands with lamps and puts them in front of the door to the **Most Holy Place**. These lampstands probably have a cylindrical shape with tops and bottoms that flare outward. Use the same word or

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phrase for Most Holy Place as you have used previously, and refer to Most Holy Place in the Master Glossary for more information.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a **lampstand**. Discuss what word or phrase you will use for lampstand. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Solomon makes tongs, wick trimmers, and censers for the temple. People make tools like tongs with two short arms joined at one end. People probably use tongs to pick things up or to remove burnt wicks. People probably make wicks out of flax that people can light with fire. People use wick trimmers to cut the wicks to keep the wicks from getting too long and burning too quickly. People use a censer to carry hot coals or burning incense.

Stop here and look at a picture of **tongs**, a picture of **wick trimmers**, and a picture of a **censer**. Discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for tongs, wick trimmer, and censer. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Solomon places the items David dedicated to Yahweh in the treasuries in the temple. People put expensive and important gifts for Yahweh in the treasuries that Solomon made in Yahweh's temple.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **treasuries**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word or phrase that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

2 Chronicles 5:2–14

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 5:2–14 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 5:2–14 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.

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3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 5:2–14 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous story, King Solomon finished building and furnishing the temple. While the previous story showed all of the new items and parts of the temple, this story focuses more on items that King Solomon still needs to bring to the temple and how the Israelites move these items to the temple. This is the same story as the story in 1 Kings 8:1–11, but with a few different details.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: If you have already translated 1 Kings 8:1–11, listen to your translation of that passage. Pause this audio here.

Stop here as a group and review the photo of King Solomon's temple. Pause this audio here.

King Solomon cannot complete the temple fully until the ark of the covenant, the Tent of Meeting, and any furnishings the priests use in the Tent of Meeting are in the temple. King Solomon asks the elders and heads or chiefs of the Israelite tribes to gather together and to join the people who will bring the ark of the covenant, the Tent of Meeting, and the furnishings to the temple. You will remember that the Tent of Meeting is the temporary tent that the Israelites used to meet with Yahweh before Solomon built the temple.

Stop here as a group and look at a photo of the ark of the covenant. Pause this audio here.

Stop and look at a photo or illustration of the Tent of Meeting and furnishings. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Think of a time when you were close to completing a task, but you had to wait for someone else to come or something else to happen before you could finish. How did you feel? Discuss this question with the group. Pause this audio here.

It is important to pay attention to the people that King Solomon gathers together for this process. The term "elders" likely refers to the older men who oversee the people of Israel, and "heads" or "chiefs" likely refers to the men who are in charge of leading their households and different tribes. It is possible that these are all the same leaders, but it is also possible that there are different sets of leaders who help look after the people of Israel.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Think about the types of leadership in your community. Discuss as a group the different kinds of leaders and who takes care of the different groups of people in your community. Pause this audio here.

King Solomon wants the elders to walk with the people who will carry the ark, the Tent of Meeting, and the furnishings from Zion to King Solomon's location north of Zion. People sometimes use Zion as another name for Jerusalem or the City of David. It is likely that the storyteller uses Zion here to show that King Solomon is moving the ark from King David's Jerusalem to the new location of the temple in a different place.

It is also important to notice the time of year when King Solomon starts this process. The storyteller says that King Solomon chooses the seventh month. The seventh month means the seventh month when Solomon finished the temple, and not the seventh month in the time that the storyteller wrote the story. The seventh month is likely the same as mid-September or October today.

At this time of year, the Israelites celebrated a feast called the Festival of Tabernacles. The Festival of Tabernacles was likely a perfect time for King Solomon because the festival celebrates when the Israelites left Egypt and had to live in temporary shelters. The festival also celebrates how Yahweh gave the Israelites a permanent place to live after the Israelites wandered for years in the desert. The Festival of Tabernacles is a pilgrimage feast, which means that the tribes of Israel travel to Jerusalem for this festival. This also means that the elders, chiefs, and men of Israel are in Jerusalem at the time that King Solomon asks for them to come to the temple. It is likely that King Solomon finished the temple and then waited for this festival so that the people who were allowed to

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transport the ark of the covenant, the Tent of Meeting, and the furnishings could easily bring everything to the new temple. This also means that the people of Israel could all be at the temple together to see the dedication.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Think of celebrations or festivals you have in your community that help you remember specific days or events. How do you celebrate? Pause this audio here.

Only men from the tribe of Levi can carry the pieces from Zion to the new temple. The priests, who are from the tribe of Levi, are the only people Yahweh has allowed to carry the ark of the covenant. The Levites who are not priests are allowed to carry the Tent of Meeting and the furnishings from the Tent of Meeting. It is likely that King Solomon and the people of Israel traveled with the priests and other Levites. It is also likely that King Solomon and the people of Israel sacrificed cattle and sheep during the journey, as well as at the temple. The storyteller says that the people sacrificed so many cattle and sheep that people could not keep count of them all.

Stop here and look at pictures of cattle and sheep. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and look at a picture of what a priest looked like and the clothing they wore. Pause this audio here.

When the priests arrive at the temple, the priests carry the ark of the covenant into the temple's inner room, called the Most Holy Place. It is important to remember that there are two rooms within the building where the priests perform their priestly duties. The Holy Place is a room or space where all priests can go. Only the high priest can go into the Most Holy Place, which some people call the Inner Sanctuary.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a photo or diagram of the Holy Place and the Most Holy Place. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what places or areas can only certain people go into? Pause this audio here.

The priests place the ark of the covenant under the wings of two cherubim angels that people made from olive wood and covered in gold. The cherubim are probably a larger version of the smaller cherubim that used to rest on the corners of the ark. The larger cherubim spread their wings over the entire ark and the carrying poles to show that this is Yahweh's resting place. The carrying poles for the ark are so long that a priest can see the poles as they are standing in the Holy Place, but not outside the Holy Place. This likely means that the poles press into the curtain that separates the Holy Place and the Most Holy Place. The storyteller says that the poles are still attached to the ark, but this likely means that the poles are there at the time the storyteller writes this. It is likely that the storyteller shares this section to help the reader visualize the new space of the temple.

Stop here and look at an illustration of cherubim. Also, look at an illustration of what the cherubim looked like in Solomon's temple. Pause this audio here.

It is important to remember that Moses put two tablets in the ark of the covenant. These flat stones represent the covenant that Yahweh made with the Israelites on Mount Horeb, also known as Mount Sinai. The storyteller says that these two tablets, which show God's covenant with Israel after they were free from Egypt, are the only items inside the ark of the covenant.

Stop here and look at an illustration of the two tablets that Moses put into the ark of the covenant. Pause this audio here.

After the priests leave the ark of the covenant in the Most Holy Place, the storyteller shares a new part of the story. The storyteller talks more about the Levites in this passage than in the 1 Kings story. It is likely that the storyteller wants to make sure that the listener knows that there are more people than just priests participating in the temple dedication.

Stop here and discuss as a group: The storyteller chose to include more information on the Levites in this passage than in the 1 Kings passage. Why might you sometimes retell a story and include different details at different times? Pause this audio here.

All of the priests who were at the temple and who were participating in this process needed to be spiritually clean. Yahweh gave the priests certain rituals to do in order to be ready to serve Yahweh. All priests would pray and wash their hands in the holy water in the basin. This means that all of the priests purified themselves regardless of whose turn it was, so they would be ready to serve. Because there are probably more priests and

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Levites than they need at one time, the priests and Levites take turns serving in the temple. Also, there are different tasks that the Levites perform.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How do you prepare for important work that you have to do? What rituals or routines do you perform in order to prepare? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: In your culture, what do priests do to prepare to serve or do their job? How do people prepare themselves to worship God? Pause this audio here.

In this next part, the storyteller specifically shares about the groups of Levites who make music. The Levite musicians Asaph, Heman, Jeduthun, and their relatives stand on the east side of the altar.

Asaph is a Levite who has served in Jerusalem, while Heman and Jeduthun are Levites who served in the tabernacle in Gibeon. All of the Levitical singers and musicians are wearing fine linen. This is important because Yahweh told them to wear this to show they are purified and prepared to serve. All of the musicians play cymbals, harps, and lyres. Cymbals are two small, metal instruments that a person can hold and strike together with one hand. Both harps and lyres are stringed instruments that a person can pluck with their fingers. The storyteller also says that 120 priests join the other Levitical musicians and play trumpets. A trumpet is a long and slender instrument that is often silver or bronze. A person plays a trumpet by blowing into the mouthpiece to make sounds or music. When the singers sing along with the trumpets, the people hear such a perfect song that it sounds like the singers and musicians are making one unified sound to Yahweh!

Stop here and look at photos of cymbals, a harp, a lyre, a trumpet, and fine linen. Pause this audio here.

While the musicians play, the singers sing about Yahweh. The singers sing, “He is good. His steadfast love continues forever.” The Israelites often sing this in worship to remind each other of all that Yahweh has done for them. This phrase is a phrase that the people of Israel use often to worship Yahweh and to remind each other of all that Yahweh has done for the people.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What phrases do you say or sing in your community that you often repeat? What religious phrases or songs do people repeat? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller then returns to a retelling of the similar passage in 1 Kings 8:1–11.

Then, a cloud fills the temple. The cloud is the presence and glory of Yahweh, and the cloud is so thick that the priests cannot do their priestly duties. It is important to remember that when Moses finished building the Tent of Meeting, a cloud covered the tent and Yahweh’s glory filled the space. The storyteller likely uses this same description to show that Yahweh’s presence is now in the new temple and that Yahweh is blessing the temple.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Think of a time when a room was so full that you could not go in. This could be a time when there were too many people in a room, when a room was too hot, or even when a room was filled with smoke. Imagine how it felt, and then discuss the cloud that filled the temple. Discuss how this might have felt and how you would feel.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 5:2–14 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has six scenes.

In the first scene: King Solomon summons the elders and chiefs of the people of Israel.

In the second scene: The priests bring the ark of the covenant to the temple, and the Levites bring the Tent of Meeting and furnishings to the temple.

In the third scene: The people of Israel sacrifice cattle and sheep.

In the fourth scene: The priests bring the ark of the covenant into the Most Holy Place.

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In the fifth scene: The priests purify themselves.

In the sixth scene: The priests leave the Holy Place, and the priests sing as Yahweh's presence fills the temple.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Solomon
- Yahweh
- Elders and chiefs of the people of Israel
- Priests who carry the ark of the covenant
- Levites who carry the Tent of Meeting and furnishings
- People of Israel
- Priests who play the trumpets
- Asaph, Heman, and Jeduthun
- And the Levites who are singers and musicians, including family members of Asaph, Heman, and Jeduthun

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first scene, King Solomon summons the elders and chiefs of the people of Israel. This is important because the leaders and chiefs are in charge of looking after the people and communicating King Solomon's commands to the people. Remember that the term "elders" likely refers to the older men who oversee the people of Israel, and "heads" or "chiefs" likely means the men who are in charge of leading their household and different tribes.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What words or phrases do you use in your culture for leaders or chiefs? How can you best translate this? Pause this audio here.

In the first scene, King Solomon has just finished building the temple. King Solomon wants the priests to bring the ark of the covenant and the Levites to bring the Tent of Meeting and furnishings from Zion to the temple near where King Solomon lives. Although the storyteller does not say this specifically, the people of Israel are gathering in Jerusalem for the Festival of Tabernacles and can travel easily to King Solomon. King Solomon likely knows that the temple is not finished until the priests and Levites bring these items. King Solomon also likely chooses the Festival of Tabernacles in the seventh month as a time to do this because the festival requires all people of Israel to travel to Jerusalem.

Stop here as a group and review the picture of King Solomon's temple. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: In this passage, a festival is a gathering where people celebrate an event or special occasion. In your language, how would you translate "festival"? Pause this audio here.

In the second scene, once the elders and leaders gather together with Solomon, the priests and Levites prepare to go to the temple. The priests carry the ark of the covenant with the poles. The other Levites carry the Tent of Meeting and the other furnishings from the Tent of Meeting. The elders and chiefs travel with the priests and Levites who transport all that King Solomon has asked for.

Stop here as a group and look at a photo of the ark of the covenant, the Tent of Meeting, and the furnishings. Pause this audio here.

It is important to remember that Yahweh said that the priests are the only ones who can carry or touch the poles of the ark. It is also important that only the other Levites carry the Tent of Meeting and furnishings, because Yahweh gave the Levites the duty to care for the temple.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Think about the roles and duties in your culture that only certain people can perform. What are examples of these types or roles and duties? How can you use this information to talk about the Levites in this passage? Pause this audio here.

In the third scene, the priests, Levites and other leaders arrive at the temple and see King Solomon sacrificing cattle and sheep. It is possible King Solomon walked ahead of the ark and arrived at the temple first. The people of Israel are sacrificing so many cattle and sheep that it is impossible to count all of the sacrifices! Solomon and the people dedicate the temple to Yahweh and honor Yahweh with these sacrifices.

Stop here and look at pictures of cattle and sheep. Pause this audio here.

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Stop here and discuss as a group: In your culture, what word could you use for sacrifices, and how could you explain the amount of sacrifices? How could you talk about something that no one can count because there are so many of them, such as dust or grains of sand? Pause this audio here.

In the fourth scene, the priests carry the ark of the covenant to the place where Yahweh always wanted it to be. This is often known as its proper place, the Inner Sanctuary, or the Most Holy Place. Only the priests are able to enter any of these spaces. The priests place the ark of the covenant under the outspread cherubim wings, and the priests leave the poles in the ark and then leave.

Stop here and look at a photo or illustration of cherubim. Also, look at a photo or illustration of what the cherubim looked like in Solomon's temple. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Look again at the cherubim. Discuss as a group how you can describe the cherubim and how you can show the difference between a real angel and the carved angel. Pause this audio here.

In the fifth scene, the priests have all made themselves pure by making sure they are spiritually clean. The Levites are singing and playing instruments. Asaph, Heman, and Jeduthun are with their male sons and male relatives as they all sing and play the cymbals, harps, and lyres. One hundred and twenty priests join the other Levitical musicians, and the priests play the trumpets. The singers, musicians, and priests who play the trumpets join together to make music and offer up one unified sound to worship Yahweh. The singers sing these words about Yahweh: "He is good. His steadfast love continues forever."

Stop here and look at a photo of cymbals, a harp, a lyre, a trumpet, and fine linen. Pause this audio here.

In the sixth scene, a cloud fills the temple as the priests and Levites leave the Holy Place. The priests and Levites sing and play music. The cloud is Yahweh's presence and glory. The cloud is so thick that the priests cannot carry out their priestly duties, and the priests have to leave the sanctuary. Yahweh often showed that Yahweh was in a space when Yahweh filled that space with a cloud or bright light. The cloud is important because it shows that Yahweh now fills the temple and rests in the place that King Solomon built to honor Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you describe the cloud? In your culture, how do you show that something like a cloud represents a person? Think about objects in your culture that represent a person when you cannot see the person. For instance, a throne or crown can represent a king's power. Discuss how you can describe Yahweh in the cloud. Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 5:2–14 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has six scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Solomon
- Yahweh
- Elders and chiefs of the people of Israel
- Priests who carry the ark of the covenant
- Levites who carry the Tent of Meeting and furnishings
- People of Israel
- Priests who play the trumpets
- Asaph, Heman, and Jeduthun
- And Levitical singers and musicians, including family members of Asaph, Heman, and Jeduthun

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

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First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

After King Solomon finishes building the temple, King Solomon asks the elders and chiefs of the people of Israel to meet Solomon in Jerusalem so the people can celebrate together as the priests carry the ark of the covenant into the temple. King Solomon asks the priests to carry the ark of the covenant with its poles and the other Levites to carry the Tent of Meeting and its furnishings to the new temple.

All of the people of Israel are in Jerusalem for the Festival of Tabernacles, including the priests, the Levites, and the elders and chiefs whom King Solomon had asked to come.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing priests, "What are you feeling or thinking?" A person might answer things like:

- What an honor to carry the ark to the temple! or
- We must be careful! or
- We must not forget anything!

Continue the drama.

Once the elders and all leaders gather together with Solomon, the priests and Levites go to the new temple. The priests walk and carry the ark of the covenant, and the other Levites also walk and carry the Tent of Meeting and its furnishings. King Solomon, the elders, the other chiefs of the tribes of Israel, and the Israelites travel to the temple as well.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the other Levites, "What are you feeling or thinking?" A person might answer things like:

- We must carry everything carefully for Yahweh; or
- I am very tired from walking and carrying everything! or
- I wonder what the temple will look like!

Continue the drama.

When all of the elders, leaders, priests, and other Levites reach King Solomon, they see the rest of the people of Israel. The people of Israel are sacrificing so many cattle and sheep for Yahweh that it is impossible to count all of the sacrifices!

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Solomon, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Finally, everyone has arrived! or
- I can now dedicate the temple properly! or
- Surely Yahweh will be pleased with all of these sacrifices!

Ask the people playing the people of Israel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" A person might answer things like:

- There cannot possibly be any more animals left! or
- I wonder what Yahweh thinks about all of this! or

2 Chronicles 5:2–14

- I feel excited to have the temple completed!

Continue the drama.

The priests then carry the ark of the covenant into the Most Holy Place. The priests place the ark of the covenant, with the two stone tablets that Moses put into the ark, under the cherubim that will cover the ark of the covenant and the poles.

Ask the people playing the priests, "What are you feeling or thinking?" A person might answer things like:

- I am so relieved that we brought the ark here safely! or
- I am in awe of the cherubim! or
- I must make sure the curtain is closed.

Continue the drama.

The priests leave the Holy Place. The priests have all made themselves holy by making sure they are spiritually clean. The priests have washed their hands in the water basin and performed other priestly rituals. The Levites who are musicians are playing the cymbals, harps, and lyres. Asaph, Heman, and Jeduthun, as well as their sons and family, play instruments on the east side of the altar. One hundred and twenty priests join in and play trumpets with the musicians. As the Levites and priests play, the singers join in perfectly to worship Yahweh by singing, "He is good. His love continues forever."

Ask the people playing Asaph, Heman, and Jeduthun, "What are you feeling or thinking?" A person might answer things like:

- I love to play instruments for Yahweh! or
- I hope this pleases Yahweh! or
- I feel so honored to be here!

Ask the people playing priests with trumpets, "What are you feeling or thinking?" A person might answer things like:

- We must play loudly for everyone to hear! or
- Wow, we blend perfectly with the voices! or
- I feel thankful to Yahweh!

Continue the drama.

Then, a cloud fills the entire temple. The cloud is Yahweh's presence, and Yahweh shows that Yahweh is pleased with the temple. The cloud is so thick that the priests cannot enter the temple to perform their priestly duties. Yahweh's presence fills the temple, and all of the people can see that Yahweh is pleased and that Yahweh is now in the temple.

Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- King Solomon has truly honored and obeyed me! or
- Everything looks exactly like I wanted it to; or
- I love King Solomon and the people of Israel!

Ask the people playing the priests, "What are you feeling or thinking?" A person might answer things like:

- How can we perform our duties in the temple if we cannot get in? or
- I can feel Yahweh's presence here! or
- We must help the people of Israel understand what is happening.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 5:2–14 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

2 Chronicles 5:2–14

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

In this passage, King Solomon summons the elders and chiefs of the people of Israel. The elders led the entire population of the people of Israel. The chiefs are leaders of different groups or tribes of people. King Solomon chooses to do this during the time of the Festival of Tabernacles. You will remember that the people of Israel celebrated the Festival of Tabernacles to remember when Yahweh provided the people with shelter after they left Egypt.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **chiefs**, **elders**, and the **Festival of Tabernacles.** Remember that the storyteller does not use the title of the Festival of Tabernacles in this story. Look up elders, **king**, **Israel**, and Festival of Tabernacles in the Master Glossary for more information.

King Solomon wants the **priests** and other Levites to bring the **ark of the covenant**, the Tent of Meeting, also known as the **tabernacle**, and the "**holy**" or special tent furnishings from their location in Jerusalem, also called Zion, north to where King Solomon has built the **temple**. Remember that the priests and Levites were both part of the tribe of Levi. Priests offered sacrifices to Yahweh for the people of Israel. Other Levites served the temple in other ways, such as playing music, singing, and doing other tasks for the temple. The ark of the covenant was the oblong chest that people had made of wood and covered in gold. The presence of Yahweh rested on top of the ark on the atonement seat. The tabernacle was the movable tent where Yahweh's presence rested. The temple became the permanent building for Yahweh's presence and the ark of the covenant. Use the same words or phrases for holy, priests, ark of the covenant, tabernacle, and temple as you used in previous passages. For more information on holy, priest, ark of the covenant, tabernacle, and temple, refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop here as a group and look at a photo or diagram of the Holy Place and the Most Holy Place. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **Zion** and **Levites**. Look up Levite and Zion in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The people of Israel **sacrifice** so many cattle and sheep that no one can keep count of the amount of animals. Cattle refers to any kind of cow, ox, or bull. Use the same word or phrase for sacrificing as you used in previous passages. For more information on sacrifice, refer to the Master Glossary.

The priests take the ark of the covenant through the **Inner Sanctuary** into the **Most Holy Place**. The priests place the ark of the covenant under the **cherubim** with wings that stretch over the entire length of the ark and the carrying poles. The carrying poles were so long that when the priests stood in the Holy Place, the priests could see the poles pressing into the curtain from the Most Holy Place. Use the same words or phrases for sanctuary, Most Holy Place, and cherubim as you used in previous passages. For more information on sanctuary, Most Holy Place, and cherubim, refer to the Master Glossary.

After the priests leave the **Holy Place** or sanctuary, Levite musicians are standing to the east of the **altar**. The priests have **consecrated** or made themselves holy by cleaning their bodies and committing themselves to Yahweh. Asaph, Heman, and Jeduthun, along with their sons and families, play the cymbals, harps, and lyres while they wear fine linen clothing. One hundred and twenty priests join in by playing trumpets. Cymbals are two small, metal instruments that a person can hold and strike together with one hand. Both harps and lyres are stringed instruments that a person can pluck with their fingers. Trumpets are metal instruments with a mouthpiece, slender body, and a flared part at the bottom where the sound escapes. As the musicians play, the singers **praise** Yahweh and sing the words, "He is good. His **steadfast love** continues forever." For more information on Holy Place, altar, consecrate, praise, and steadfast love, refer to the Master Glossary.

Then, a cloud fills the temple, and **Yahweh's** presence and glory enters into the temple to stay and rest there. The cloud is so thick that the priests cannot enter to perform their priestly duties in the temple. Use the same word or phrase for Yahweh as you have used previously, and refer to the Master Glossary for more information about Yahweh.

2 Chronicles 6:1–11

Stop here as a team and look and images of linen, cymbals, harps, lyres, and trumpets, if needed. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **cloud**, **linen**, **cymbals**, **harps**, **lyres**, **trumpets**, and **glory**. Look up glory in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

2 Chronicles 6:1–11

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear [2 Chronicles 6:1–11]{.mark} and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of [2 Chronicles 6:1–11]{.mark} three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of [2 Chronicles 6:1–11]{.mark} in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passage, Yahweh saw all that King Solomon and the people of Israel did. When the priests placed the ark of the covenant in the Most Holy Place, Yahweh responded when he filled the temple with a thick cloud. In this passage, King Solomon speaks to Yahweh in a prayer and then addresses the people of Israel in response to Yahweh's presence in the temple.

2 Chronicles 6:1–11

Stop here and review the photo of King Solomon's temple. Pause this audio here.

This passage is almost exactly the same as 1 Kings 8:12–21 that you may have translated previously.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: If you have already translated 1 Kings 8:12–21, listen to your translation of that passage. Pause this audio here.

King Solomon begins his prayer when Solomon talks about what Yahweh has previously said. In the book of Leviticus, Yahweh spoke to Moses and told Moses not to allow Moses' brother Aaron to go into the Most Holy Place. Yahweh also said that Yahweh would come in a dark cloud in the Holy Place over the ark of the covenant. This was a sign that Yahweh was pleased and was present in the tabernacle. When Yahweh shows up in a dark and thick cloud this time, Yahweh does the same thing as Yahweh did in the time of Moses. King Solomon realizes this and tells Yahweh that King Solomon has built a magnificent temple for Yahweh to live in forever.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Remember that the people of Israel likely knew the story of Moses and Yahweh's presence in the tabernacle. How do you think the people felt when they saw this happen? How would you feel if you saw this with your own eyes instead of only hearing about it? Pause this audio here.

After King Solomon prays to Yahweh, King Solomon then turns away from the temple and faces the assembly, or the group of the people of Israel. Assemblies are large groups of people who gather together for a common reason. King Solomon then blesses the people. Again, King Solomon does the same act that Moses did at the tabernacle. King Solomon sees all that has happened, and King Solomon honors Yahweh and then speaks Yahweh's blessings over the people of Israel.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Think about the most important or famous person in your country or beyond. This could be a king or a leader. How does this person bless people in your culture? How would you feel if this person recognized you and spoke kind words to you? Pause this audio here.

King Solomon begins his blessing and speech by praising Yahweh, the God of Israel. The title of "God of Israel" reminds the Israelites that Yahweh is Israel's God, whom the people should worship. [King Solomon says he praises Yahweh because Yahweh has fulfilled Yahweh's promises through Yahweh's hands, or Yahweh's power.] {.mark} Yahweh fulfilled his promise to Solomon's father, King David, that Solomon would be king and build the temple. King Solomon likely wants to remind the people that Yahweh is faithful and trustworthy.

In the next section, King Solomon speaks words that Yahweh has already spoken. These words are not King Solomon's interpretation of Yahweh's words. King Solomon quotes Yahweh when Solomon says these words: "Since the day I brought my people Israel out of Egypt, I have not chosen a city in any tribe of Israel for people to build a temple in so that my name might be there, nor have I chosen anyone to be ruler over my people Israel. But now I have chosen Jerusalem for my name to be there, and I have chosen David to rule my people Israel." Yahweh means that people will honor and respect Yahweh's name, which is Yahweh himself, and the people will not worship other names in Jerusalem.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Refer back to the 1 Kings 8:12–21 translation. What is different about this section? In your culture, how often do people tell the same stories but include different true details? Pause this audio here.

In this part of the passage, King Solomon likely shares what Yahweh said to King David, to explain why King David did not build the temple sooner. Yahweh wanted King David to rule over the people of Israel, but Yahweh did not give King David permission or instructions to build a temple.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Imagine that you are King David. How would you feel if you were king and you wanted to build a temple, but Yahweh would not let you? Describe your feelings and thoughts. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: In your culture, who do people allow to build or create holy places like temples? Who chooses when it is the right time or place to make these holy places? Pause this audio here.

King Solomon then quotes Yahweh again to remind the people of Israel why King Solomon built the temple. Yahweh did not let King David build the temple, even though Yahweh loved King David and King David wanted to build the temple to honor Yahweh's name. However, Yahweh did have a plan. Yahweh told King David that King David's son, King Solomon, would build the temple. Yahweh makes sure that King David understands the word

2 Chronicles 6:1–11

"son" when he says that David's "flesh and blood" would be the one to build the temple. When Solomon repeats Yahweh's words, King Solomon reminds the people of Israel that Yahweh is faithful and is in control of all things, including time.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Think of a time when you thought someone would choose you for a special role, but the person chose someone else. Share with the group how you felt. Pause this audio here.

After King Solomon reminds the people of what Yahweh said, King Solomon then confirms that what Yahweh said has happened. Yahweh has kept all of Yahweh's promises. Solomon is king and has built the temple for Yahweh, just as Yahweh promised. Again, King Solomon says that he has built the temple for "Yahweh, God of Israel."

Stop here and look at a picture of a throne. Pause this audio here.

To finish King Solomon's reminder to the people, King Solomon explains that King Solomon has built a place for the ark of the covenant. In the ark are the stone tablets. These tablets are a reminder of Yahweh's covenant with the people of Israel after Yahweh led the people of Israel out of Egypt. King Solomon reminds the people of Israel that Yahweh made promises to their ancestors. Yahweh will keep those promises just like Yahweh kept his promises to David.

Stop here and look at a picture of the ark of the covenant. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and look at a picture of the stone tablets. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how do you pass information down through generations so that people will know what happened during their ancestors' lives? How do you keep a record of all that has happened?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of [2 Chronicles 6:1–11]{.mark} in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has two scenes.

In the first scene: King Solomon faces the temple and speaks to Yahweh.

In the second scene: King Solomon turns around and blesses the people of Israel. King Solomon reminds the people of how Yahweh keeps his promises.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Solomon
- Yahweh
- People of Israel
- And King David

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In this passage, King Solomon is the only one who speaks. King Solomon speaks first to Yahweh and then to the people of Israel. King Solomon praises Yahweh, tells the story of what Yahweh has done, and reminds the people that Yahweh keeps Yahweh's promises.

In the first scene, King Solomon faces the temple and speaks to Yahweh. King Solomon reminds Yahweh, and anyone listening, that Yahweh previously said that Yahweh would live in a dark cloud. King Solomon is referring to another time when Yahweh spoke to Moses. King Solomon then offers the new temple to Yahweh so that Yahweh can have a place to live in forever. When King Solomon says he built the temple, King Solomon represents all of the people who helped build the temple; King Solomon did not build the temple by himself. The storyteller shows that King Solomon pays attention to Yahweh's previous words and shows that he knows what Yahweh is doing.

2 Chronicles 6:1–11

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your language, how will you translate this part so that people will understand that King Solomon's words are words that Yahweh has already said in earlier passages? How will you make it clear that Solomon is speaking about Yahweh, and Solomon is speaking directly to Yahweh? Pause this audio here.

In the second scene, King Solomon turns away from the temple and turns towards the people. Solomon speaks to the people of Israel. The storyteller says that the people are standing as an assembly or group, so King Solomon is likely talking to people who are actively listening to Solomon. King Solomon blessed the people.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what type or types of blessings do people speak over people? Think of examples of how people might speak words to people for comfort or to remind those people of how Yahweh blesses them. Pause this audio here.

King Solomon talks about both what Yahweh does now and what Yahweh has said and done in the past. King Solomon starts by praising "Yahweh, the God of Israel" for helping King Solomon do what Yahweh told King David with Yahweh's mouth that King Solomon would do. It is important to notice the small difference here from the parallel passage in 1 Kings 8:12–21. King Solomon says here that Yahweh's "hands," not just Yahweh's "hand," kept Yahweh's promises. These mean the same thing. The storyteller does not mean that Yahweh's actual hands built the temple. But the storyteller likely means that Yahweh made it possible through Yahweh's power and strength for King Solomon and the people to complete the temple.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: When you tell a story in your language and culture, how do you show that something happens now and that something happened in the past? What words would you use to help someone understand when something happened? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how will you talk about the "hand, or strength, of Yahweh" in this passage? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Solomon uses the phrases "with his hand" and "with his mouth" to describe Yahweh's actions. How can you show Yahweh's actions in your language? Pause this audio here.

King Solomon then talks about what Yahweh said to King David. After the people of Israel left Egypt, Yahweh did not give a specific place for anyone to build a temple, and Yahweh had not chosen anyone to rule. Yahweh did not choose any person to rule because Yahweh ruled the Israelites. However, eventually Yahweh did choose Jerusalem as the place where people would honor Yahweh's name. Yahweh also blessed King David and chose King David to rule over the people of Israel.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How can you show the difference between the way a person speaks their own words and the way a person quotes another person's words? Pause this audio here.

King Solomon then explains that his father, King David, "had it in his heart" to build a temple for Yahweh. In the Hebrew language, people talk about the heart as the place where people think and feel. King David desired to build the temple to honor Yahweh's name. Again, King Solomon says, "Yahweh, God of Israel," and King Solomon is using two names to describe Yahweh.

King Solomon then tells the people that King Solomon's father, King David, wanted to build a temple for Yahweh. Then King Solomon again quotes Yahweh's words that Yahweh spoke to King David. Yahweh told King David that Yahweh was pleased that King David wanted to build a temple for Yahweh. However, Yahweh tells King David that King David will not be the one who builds the temple. Instead, Yahweh chose King Solomon, King David's own "flesh and blood," to build the temple for Yahweh. In this case, flesh and blood means King David's son, not King David's own skin and blood.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your language, how do you show that someone is related to someone else? How can you translate phrases like "flesh and blood" so that people can understand what these ideas mean? Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Why do you think King Solomon repeats Yahweh's promises? What are some reasons why it is helpful to repeat stories or phrases? Pause this audio here.

King Solomon finishes this prayer when Solomon makes it clear to the people that Yahweh has kept the promises that Yahweh made to King David. King Solomon now sits on Israel's throne and rules over the people of Israel.

King Solomon has also built the temple for Yahweh and has placed the ark of the covenant in the temple. King Solomon also reminds the people that the covenant is in the ark of the covenant. The covenant refers to the tablets, which represent the covenant that Yahweh made with Moses and the people of Israel when Yahweh freed the people of Israel from Egypt.

Stop here and look at a picture of a throne. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and look at a picture of the ark of the covenant. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and look at a picture of the stone tablets. Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of [2 Chronicles 6:1–11]{.mark} in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has two scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Solomon
- Yahweh
- People of Israel
- And King David

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

After King Solomon built a temple for Yahweh, King Solomon faced the temple and spoke to Yahweh. King Solomon said that in a previous time, Yahweh said Yahweh would dwell in a dark cloud. The dark cloud is now inside the temple, which means that Yahweh has accepted the temple that Solomon has built.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Solomon, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I hope Yahweh approves of this temple! or
- I am so glad we have this temple now after having to move the tabernacle! or
- I feel proud of what I have accomplished.

Continue the drama.

After King Solomon spoke to Yahweh, King Solomon turned around and faced all of the people of Israel who were standing in front of him. King Solomon blessed the people.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the people of Israel, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I must be quiet and listen to King Solomon! or

2 Chronicles 6:1–11

- I am excited to hear what King Solomon is going to say to us! or
- Look at this beautiful temple!

Continue the drama.

King Solomon praises Yahweh by saying, “Praise be to Yahweh, the God of Israel!” King Solomon then tells the people why Solomon is praising Yahweh. King Solomon praises Yahweh because Yahweh has fulfilled the promise that Yahweh made to King David.

Pause this drama. Ask the person playing Yahweh, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I remember exactly what King Solomon is saying! or
- I love it when King Solomon honors me! or
- It makes me happy when King Solomon sees what I have done for Solomon!

Continue the drama.

King Solomon speaks about what Yahweh did when Solomon reminds the people of Israel of the time that Yahweh led the people of Israel out of Egypt. After the people left Egypt, Yahweh did not choose a place anywhere in Israel for anyone to build a temple, and Yahweh did not choose anyone to rule over the people of Israel. However, Yahweh eventually chose Jerusalem as the place where people would honor Yahweh’s name, and Yahweh chose King Solomon’s father, King David, to rule the people of Israel.

Pause this drama. Ask the person playing King Solomon, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I want the people to see Yahweh’s faithfulness! or
- I am in awe of all Yahweh has done! or
- I wonder why Yahweh chose me!

Continue the drama.

King Solomon then tells the people of Israel that Solomon’s father, King David, wanted to build a temple for Yahweh. King Solomon then tells the people of Israel what Yahweh said to King David. Yahweh told King David that King David was right to want to build the temple for Yahweh. But Yahweh then told King David that King David could not be the person to build the temple. Instead, Yahweh said that King Solomon would build the temple.

Pause this drama. Ask the person playing King David, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I wish I could build the temple! or
- I am thankful that my son will get to build the temple; or
- I am sad that I will not get to see the temple.

Continue the drama.

King Solomon then finishes his speech when Solomon declares that Yahweh has fulfilled the promises that Yahweh made to King David and lists the promises. King Solomon now sits on the throne of Israel and has built the temple for Yahweh. King Solomon placed the ark of the covenant in the temple with the stone tablets in the ark to represent the covenant that Yahweh made.

Pause this drama. Ask the person playing the people of Israel, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- Wow! Look at all Yahweh has done! or
- I feel like I can trust Yahweh when Yahweh speaks! or
- I am glad that Yahweh approves of our king!

2 Chronicles 6:1–11

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of [2 Chronicles 6:1–11]{.mark} in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

After Yahweh's presence fills the **temple**, **King** Solomon faces the temple and speaks to Yahweh. King Solomon says that Yahweh previously said that Yahweh would live in a dark **cloud**. King Solomon says that Solomon has built a beautiful temple for Yahweh where Yahweh can live forever. Use the same words or phrases for temple, king, and cloud as you used in previous passages. Look up temple and king in the Master Glossary for more information.

After King Solomon speaks to Yahweh, King Solomon turns around and faces the **assembly** of Israel. Assembly likely means the people of Israel all together. King Solomon praises or **blesses Yahweh**, the **God** of **Israel**, and tells the people of Israel that Yahweh has fulfilled with Yahweh's hands what Yahweh told King Solomon's father, King David, with Yahweh's mouth. Use the same words or phrases for assembly, bless, Yahweh, God, and Israel as you used in previous passages. Look up Israel, praise, Yahweh, God, and bless in the Master Glossary for more information.

King Solomon says that King David had it in his **heart** to build a house for Yahweh. Yahweh told King David that Yahweh had not chosen any city in any **tribe** of Israel for anyone to build a temple. However, Yahweh did choose for King David to rule over the people of Israel. Refer to the Master Glossary for more information about heart, and use the same words or phrases for heart and tribe as you used in previous passages.

Yahweh said that King David's son, King David's own "flesh and blood," would build the temple.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **flesh and blood**. If you have already translated this phrase in another book of the Bible, use the same phrase that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Finally, King Solomon reminds the people of Israel that King Solomon placed the **ark of the covenant** in the temple. The ark of the covenant contains the stone tablets that represent the **covenant** Yahweh made with the people's ancestors when Yahweh rescued the people of Israel's ancestors from Egypt. Use the same words or phrases for ark of the covenant and covenant as you used in previous passages. Look up ark of the covenant and covenant in the Master Glossary for more information.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

2 Chronicles 6:12–21

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

2 Chronicles 6:12–21

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 6:12–21 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 6:12–21 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 6:12–21 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

This passage in 2 Chronicles is a parallel or similar passage to the passage in 1 Kings 8:22–30 that you previously translated. If you have already translated 1 Kings 8:22–30, stop here and review your translation of that passage.

Pause this audio here.

In this passage, King Solomon continues to pray to Yahweh in front of the people of Israel. This passage contains two sections within King Solomon's prayers. In the first part of King Solomon's prayers, King Solomon praises Yahweh for how Yahweh has kept and fulfilled Yahweh's covenant or promise to King Solomon's father, King David. In the second part of this prayer, King Solomon asks that Yahweh listen to the Israelites' prayers.

As King Solomon continues to pray to Yahweh, King Solomon stands facing the bronze temple altar, with the people of Israel behind King Solomon. It is important to remember that this is the altar that is in front of the temple building. The storyteller includes extra information in this passage that is not included in 1 Kings 8:22–30. The storyteller says that King Solomon built a bronze platform in the middle of the temple court. The platform was 5 cubits long, 5 cubits wide, and 3 cubits tall. In modern measurements, King Solomon's platform would be 2.3 meters long, 2.3 meters wide, and 1.07 meters tall. A cubit is an ancient measurement that is equal to the length from a person's elbow to the tip of that person's middle finger. King Solomon likely built this platform so that Solomon could speak to all the people more easily and so people could see and hear Solomon better. At this moment, King Solomon stands first and then kneels down on the platform as King Solomon stretches out his hands to heaven and begins to pray.

Stop here and look at an image of King Solomon's temple, including the altar. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and look at an image of the platform that King Solomon built in the temple courtyard. Pause this audio here.

King Solomon begins when King Solomon declares that Yahweh is the most powerful God in all the earth and in all of heaven. In other words, King Solomon means that no other god that people worship can compare to Yahweh. This is important because other people groups outside of the people of Israel worshipped many gods during King Solomon's time. King Solomon honors Yahweh as the only God that the people of Israel worship.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what kinds of gods do people in your area worship? How do people worship these gods? How do you show that you only worship Yahweh? Pause this audio here.

2 Chronicles 6:12–21

King Solomon describes Yahweh as the God who keeps Yahweh's "covenant of love" with the people of Israel. [The people of Israel are Yahweh's servants who walk in, or obey, Yahweh's ways and commands with their whole heart. In this prayer, King Solomon shows that it is humble and respectful to call yourself someone's servant. This is why King Solomon calls several people Yahweh's servants throughout the prayer.]{.mark} [Yahweh shows his covenant love to the people of Israel who follow Yahweh]{.mark} and all of Yahweh's commands. In this covenant, both Yahweh and the people of Israel promise to act in a certain way. Yahweh promises to love and protect the people of Israel, and the people of Israel promise to keep Yahweh's commands and to walk the path where Yahweh leads. To walk the path of Yahweh means to obey Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what types of agreements or covenants do you have? What types of covenants do leaders make with their people? Think about your family structure and community structure. How do people agree and then hold each other accountable to the agreements? Pause this audio here.

King Solomon again declares that Yahweh has kept the promises that Yahweh made to King David. In this moment, King Solomon means how Yahweh fulfilled his promise to David in Solomon's time. Yahweh has chosen King Solomon as the next king after King David, and Yahweh has allowed King Solomon to build the temple.

After King Solomon speaks of Yahweh's faithfulness, King Solomon asks Yahweh to continue to be faithful in future generations. King Solomon asks Yahweh to once again keep a covenant that Yahweh made with King David. King Solomon quotes Yahweh's words when King Solomon says that Yahweh promised King David that the people of Israel would always have a king on the throne of Israel. But David's descendants must obey Yahweh as David did. After King Solomon speaks about the original covenant, King Solomon asks Yahweh to be faithful [to continue to keep]{.mark} the covenant and the words that Yahweh spoke to King David.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how important are words and verbal agreements in your contracts or pledges to other people? Think of a time when you wanted to encourage a trustworthy person to keep a promise they made to another person. How did you help this person continue to keep their promises? Pause this audio here.

King Solomon then prays that Yahweh will pay attention to the prayers that the people of Israel will pray. King Solomon asks Yahweh if Yahweh would live on earth with humans, even though the heavens cannot contain the power of Yahweh. Heavens can mean the sky, where Yahweh lives, or both things! King Solomon says that even the grand temple that King Solomon has built for Yahweh is still too small for such a powerful God! King Solomon knows that the temple cannot contain Yahweh, and King Solomon continues to explain what King Solomon means in this prayer.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, where do people believe that gods live? Pause this audio here.

King Solomon does not expect Yahweh to contain himself in the temple. Instead, King Solomon describes what King Solomon hopes Yahweh will do. King Solomon desires for Yahweh to hear King Solomon's prayer to give King Solomon mercy. King Solomon simply wants Yahweh to hear King Solomon and to give Yahweh's attention to King Solomon. In this case, King Solomon is likely not praying a prayer only for himself. Instead, King Solomon is likely asking Yahweh to listen to King Solomon now and in the future, because King Solomon is going to pray for the people of Israel.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how do you show Yahweh's ability to be both God over all things and also a God who listens to your prayers? Pause this audio here.

King Solomon asks Yahweh to pay attention to what is happening. In other words, King Solomon wants Yahweh to pay attention to the prayers of Yahweh's people at all times. King Solomon then refers to when Yahweh said that people would worship Yahweh's Name in one place. This is the moment that King Solomon shows what King Solomon is actually praying for. King Solomon does not expect Yahweh to contain himself in the temple, but King Solomon does want Yahweh's Name present in the temple. In biblical times, someone's name showed who that person was, so King Solomon wants the people of Israel to only worship Yahweh in the temple.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what types of places do people go to when they worship deities? How do people interact with deities in these places?

2 Chronicles 6:12–21

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 6:12–21 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: King Solomon faces the altar to pray to Yahweh.

In the second scene: The storyteller pauses the story to describe the platform King Solomon built earlier and stands on now to pray.

In the third scene: King Solomon prays to Yahweh.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Solomon
- People of Israel
- King David
- Yahweh
- And platform builders

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

This passage shows a portion of King Solomon's longer prayer as Solomon dedicates the temple to Yahweh. Most of the characters in the story either watch King Solomon pray, or King Solomon speaks about these people or to them. It is good for you to still have the characters present and to show who King Solomon prays to and who King Solomon refers to throughout the passage.

In the first scene, King Solomon prepares to pray to Yahweh. King Solomon faces the altar in the court outside the courtyard of the temple. The assembly of Israel, or that special group of Israelites who have come together for this important purpose, likely stands behind King Solomon.

Stop and discuss this question as a group: In your language, how do you show action or show specific ways that a person stands or moves? For example, how can you make sure the listener understands that the people were behind King Solomon? Pause this audio here.

In the second scene, the storyteller says that King Solomon had built a platform. This means that the storyteller is telling us about something that has already happened. This section gives context and can help us understand how the temple looked. The temple builders, under King Solomon's supervision, built the platform 5 cubits long, 5 cubits wide, and 3 cubits tall. In modern measurements, the builders built the platform 2.3 meters long, 2.3 meters wide, and 1.07 meters tall.

Stop and discuss this question as a group: In your language, when you tell a story, how do you talk about the way someone made an item that a person uses in the story? When would you choose to tell the story of how someone made the item? How can you best translate this part of the passage? Pause this audio here.

In the third scene, King Solomon begins to pray and thank Yahweh. King Solomon recognizes that Yahweh is the God above all other gods when King Solomon says that there is no other god in the highest part of heaven or the lowest place under the earth or on earth that compares to Yahweh. In other words, King Solomon says that Yahweh is the greatest god of all gods anywhere. King Solomon then shows Yahweh as a personal and present God when King Solomon shows that Yahweh makes covenants with Yahweh's people and loyally loves his people, the Israelites. King Solomon also says that the people of Israel keep Yahweh's commands with all their heart. When someone does something "with all their heart," that person does that thing happily and well.

Stop and discuss this question as a group: King Solomon has changed from talking about Yahweh to talking to Yahweh. How will you make it clear that King Solomon is talking to Yahweh here? Pause this audio here.

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King Solomon recognizes that Yahweh kept Yahweh's earlier covenant with King David when Yahweh chose King Solomon to be king and allowed King Solomon to build the temple. Solomon says that Yahweh said the promise with Yahweh's mouth, and Yahweh kept Yahweh's promise with his hand, or with Yahweh's power. King Solomon is saying that the Israelites can see that Yahweh kept his promise because Yahweh has made King Solomon, David's son, king of Israel, and King Solomon has built the house for Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you translate that Yahweh said a promise with Yahweh's mouth and kept the promise with Yahweh's hand, or power? Pause this audio here.

King Solomon now asks Yahweh to keep another specific covenant that Yahweh made with King David. King Solomon quotes Yahweh when King Solomon refers to how Yahweh promised King David that Yahweh would continue to give the people of Israel a king from King David's family line as long as David's descendants followed Yahweh's commands, just as King David did. King Solomon wants Yahweh to continue this covenant with King Solomon.

Stop and discuss this question as a group: This section has a quote from Yahweh inside King Solomon's prayer. In your language, how can you translate this to show when Solomon speaks his own words and when Solomon quotes Yahweh? Pause this audio here.

King Solomon asks Yahweh to hear the prayers of King Solomon and Yahweh's people. First, King Solomon asks this question: "Will God really live on earth? The heavens cannot hold you, and neither can this temple!" Solomon means that Solomon does not believe that Yahweh is supposed to live only in the temple on earth. King Solomon understands that if heaven cannot contain Yahweh, a temple that people built cannot contain Yahweh either. King Solomon is asking a question that he does not expect Yahweh to answer. Instead, Solomon is praising Yahweh for being so great that Yahweh cannot live in one place.

Stop and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate this section to show that King Solomon believes that Yahweh can live anywhere, and no one place is the only place Yahweh lives? Pause this audio here.

King Solomon begs Yahweh to respond to the prayers that King Solomon and the people of Israel pray now and will pray in the future. King Solomon asks Yahweh to open Yahweh's eyes and to give full attention to Yahweh's people's prayers and to what happens in the temple during the day and the night, or all the time. To open your eyes to something means to pay attention and watch what happens, just as a person with their eyes open can see and pay attention to something.

Stop and discuss this question as a group: In your language, how do you speak about the way that someone pays attention to something or someone? Pause this audio here.

King Solomon asks Yahweh to hear and listen to King Solomon and the people of Israel when they pray anytime during the day or night. King Solomon again quotes Yahweh when King Solomon says that Yahweh once promised that Yahweh's "Name would be there" in one place for people to worship Yahweh. King Solomon probably wants to show that Yahweh promises to be present in the temple to meet with the people. King Solomon finishes this part of the prayer when Solomon asks Yahweh to hear the supplications of Yahweh's people when they pray in the temple. Supplication is a way that people can pray to Yahweh. In this case, the people are strongly asking Yahweh to do something for the people.

Stop and discuss this question as a group: In your language, how do you strongly ask God to do something for you? Pause this audio here.

You will notice that King Solomon speaks about himself in this section as if Solomon were speaking about someone else. King Solomon calls himself Yahweh's "servant."

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you show that Solomon is talking about himself when Solomon refers to Yahweh's servant? Pause this audio here.

King Solomon asks Yahweh to forgive the people of Israel when Yahweh hears the prayers that the people pray "towards this place," the temple. If the Israelites were not near the temple, the Israelites could face the direction of the temple to pray, to show that the Israelites were praying to Yahweh. King Solomon expects that Yahweh will hear these prayers and Yahweh will forgive his people of their disobedience. Yahweh will answer these prayers from heaven, the place where Yahweh lives.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 6:12–21 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Solomon
- People of Israel
- King David
- Yahweh
- And platform builders

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Before King Solomon prayed to dedicate the temple to Yahweh, King Solomon turned to face the altar in the temple court. The people of Israel stood behind King Solomon.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the people of Israel, “What are you feeling or thinking?” A person might answer things like:

- I wonder what King Solomon is going to say? or
- I feel like I can trust King Solomon to lead us! or
- I need to focus on what King Solomon will pray for!

Continue the drama.

When King Solomon was building the temple, King Solomon’s builders built a platform for King Solomon. The builders built the platform in the center of the temple courtyard. The builders made the platform 5 cubits long, 5 cubits wide, and 3 cubits tall. This means that the builders made the platform 2.3 meters long, 2.3 meters wide, and 1.07 meters tall.

Pause this drama. As the people playing the builders, “What are you feeling or thinking?” A person might answer things like:

- We must get these measurements correct! or
- I feel proud to build this temple! or
- I wonder what King Solomon will say when he stands on this platform!

Continue the drama.

King Solomon stood and then knelt down on the platform. As King Solomon stretched his hands out to heaven, King Solomon began his prayer when Solomon praised Yahweh and recognized that no other god exists anywhere

2 Chronicles 6:12–21

on earth, or above the earth, that can ever compare to Yahweh. King Solomon recognized that Yahweh is trustworthy to keep Yahweh's covenants with people who keep Yahweh's commands. King Solomon also recognized that Yahweh kept the covenant that Yahweh made with King David when Yahweh chose Solomon to be king and allowed King Solomon to build the temple.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I love my servant, King Solomon! or
- I feel honored by King Solomon! or
- I remember the covenant I made with King David.

Continue the drama.

King Solomon then asked Yahweh to keep another covenant that Yahweh had made with King David. King Solomon asked Yahweh to always provide a new king from King David's family line to sit on Israel's throne. King Solomon also recognized that David's descendants must keep Yahweh's commands in order to continue to rule Israel. King Solomon asked Yahweh to keep this promise.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Solomon, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I hope Yahweh continues to be trustworthy! or
- I wonder if Yahweh is hearing my prayers! or
- I feel nervous that Yahweh will change his mind!

Continue the drama.

King Solomon again recognizes how big and powerful Yahweh is. King Solomon asks, "But, will God really dwell on earth with humans?" King Solomon recognizes that heaven cannot contain Yahweh's power, and the temple is not supposed to contain Yahweh either. Instead, King Solomon asks Yahweh's Name to rest in the temple, as Yahweh promised in another covenant to Moses. King Solomon asks Yahweh to open Yahweh's eyes to all that happens in the temple, both day and night. King Solomon desires for Yahweh to hear the prayers that both King Solomon and the people of Israel will pray in the temple. King Solomon asks Yahweh to hear the pleas of the people and to forgive the people of Israel when Yahweh hears the people's prayers.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Solomon is right! Nothing can contain me! or
- I am honored to have my Name in the temple! or
- I will hear the people's prayers!

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 6:12–21 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

In this passage, Solomon turns away from the **assembly** of **Israel** and faces the **altar** of Yahweh. In the temple, the altar is a large structure where priests make burnt animal sacrifices. King Solomon stretches out his hands to heaven and prays to **Yahweh**. Heaven is the place where Yahweh lives with his angels. Use the same words or phrases for assembly, altar, Yahweh, Israelites, and Israel as you have in previous passages. For more information, refer to these words in the Master Glossary.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **heaven**. Look up heaven in the Master Glossary for more information. Pause this audio here.

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King Solomon stands and then kneels down on a bronze platform that stands 5 **cubits** long, 5 cubits wide, and 3 cubits tall. This equals about 2.3 meters long, 2.3 meters wide, and 1.07 meters tall. A person can measure a cubit by measuring the distance between their elbow and the tip of their middle finger. Each cubit is about 44 to 53 centimeters long. Use the same word or phrase for cubits as you used in previous passages. For more information on cubits, refer to the Master Glossary.

Solomon says that Yahweh, the **God** of Israel, kept his **covenant** of **steadfast love** with Yahweh's **servants**, who are Solomon, David, and the Israelites. This covenant is a commitment that requires both people to keep promises to each other. Yahweh's servants keep this covenant with all their **hearts**. Use the same words or phrases for God, covenant, steadfast love, heart, and servants as you have used in previous passages. God, covenant, steadfast love, heart, and servant are in the Master Glossary.

King Solomon reminds Yahweh that Yahweh had promised that there would be a descendant of David on the **throne** of Israel forever if the Israelites follow Yahweh's laws. Yahweh's laws are the instructions that Yahweh gives his people to follow. Use the same word or phrase for throne as you have used in previous passages.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **descendants** and **law**. Descendants and law are in the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

King Solomon recognizes that King Solomon's **temple** cannot contain Yahweh! King Solomon knows that Yahweh's **Name** is the most important part of the temple. Use the same words or phrases for temple and the Name of Yahweh as you have used in previous passages. Temple is in the Master Glossary.

King Solomon asks Yahweh to hear the prayers and supplications of the people of Israel. When someone prays, that person is talking to God. Supplication is a type of prayer when people ask humbly, but very strongly, for Yahweh to hear them and answer them.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **supplication** and **pray**. Look up prayer in the Master Glossary for more information about the different types of prayers to Yahweh. If you have already translated these types of prayers in another book of the Bible, you may be able to use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

King Solomon asks that Yahweh hear the people's prayers and then forgive the people. When Yahweh forgives people, Yahweh has mercy on those people and does not punish them as they deserve.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **forgive**. Forgive is in the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

2 Chronicles 6:22–39

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 6:22–39 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 6:22–39 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 6:22–39 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

This passage is very similar to the passage you may have already translated for 1 Kings 8:31–53. If you have already translated this passage, listen to your translation of 1 Kings 8:31–53.

Pause this audio here.

In this passage, King Solomon continues the prayer to Yahweh that Solomon began to pray in the previous passage. In this section, King Solomon makes seven requests to Yahweh. King Solomon mostly talks to Yahweh about the whole nation of Israel. In each request, King Solomon gives examples of what may happen, and then King Solomon asks Yahweh to respond in a certain way.

First, King Solomon speaks to Yahweh about oaths or promises that people might make to one another because one person has done something wrong to someone else. In this case, both people must stand before the altar in front of the temple and allow Yahweh to judge who is telling the truth. King Solomon asks Yahweh to hear both people's arguments and then punish the guilty person and show who is innocent.

Stop here and look at an image of the temple and an image of the altar in the temple courtyard. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how do people decide who is telling the truth and who is lying? How do people decide if someone is guilty or innocent? Pause this audio here.

King Solomon knows how the people of Israel have disobeyed Yahweh before, and Yahweh has allowed enemy armies to conquer the people. In Solomon's second request, King Solomon asks Yahweh for something in the future. Solomon asks Yahweh to hear the people of Israel when the people repent and turn back to Yahweh after an enemy army defeats the people of Israel because they disobeyed. King Solomon asks Yahweh to hear from heaven and listen to the people's prayers in the temple.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Think of a time when you prayed for a situation that had not happened yet. What did you pray, and why? Pause this audio here.

In King Solomon's third request, King Solomon speaks to Yahweh about drought. Drought can happen when there is no rain for a long period of time. Again, King Solomon seems to expect that drought will happen, and King Solomon also recognizes that Yahweh may bring the drought because of the people's sins. King Solomon asks Yahweh to listen and respond to the people of Israel when the people of Israel realize that they have sinned and turn back to Yahweh and pray. King Solomon prays that Yahweh would forgive the people of Israel. Then King

2 Chronicles 6:22–39

Solomon asks that Yahweh would teach the people of Israel how to live in the right way. Finally, King Solomon asks that Yahweh would end the drought and send rain on the land that Yahweh promised to the people of Israel as their inheritance.

Stop here and look at an image of the effects of drought. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and look at an image of land that is flourishing from rain. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Think about a time when your land had no rain for a long time. What happened to the plants? What happened to the animals and people? How did you feel and respond? Pause this audio here.

In King Solomon's fourth request, King Solomon speaks to Yahweh about any kind of disaster in the land. First, King Solomon talks about famine and "plague" or terrible sickness. Famine means that people have no food. Terrible sickness means that people have diseases, and that the diseases have spread to many people. King Solomon then lists specific events that could happen, such as hot and dry winds, moisture that rots crops, locusts or grasshoppers, and people who attack from another country. Locusts and grasshoppers are both insects that can easily destroy crops when they eat the crops quickly. A siege happens when an enemy surrounds a city and prevents the people in the city from trading or receiving any supplies or food. In time, the people in the city would have no choice but to leave their city and fight. Again, King Solomon knows the typical problems that Solomon's people will have.

Stop here and look at an image of a blighted plant. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and look at an image of a plant with mildew. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and look at images of grasshoppers and locusts. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Think about your community's history and even your family's history. Talk about a time when you or your community experienced a terrible sickness or drought. Share your experiences with the group. Pause this audio here.

The people of Israel must recognize the suffering they have "in their hearts" and turn to Yahweh. King Solomon says that the people will spread their hands to the temple to show that the people know that God, who lives in the temple among the people of Israel, is the source of the people's help. The people must pray and strongly ask for Yahweh's forgiveness. King Solomon then simply asks Yahweh to do two things: forgive and act. King Solomon recognizes that only Yahweh knows every person's motives and attitudes, and King Solomon asks Yahweh to choose how to respond to each person. King Solomon asks Yahweh to remind each person who Yahweh is and that they should honor Yahweh for as long as the people live in Yahweh's land that Yahweh has given to the people of Israel.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you normally pray in your culture? What kinds of things do you normally pray for? Pause this audio here.

In King Solomon's fifth request, King Solomon speaks to Yahweh about foreigners who are not Israelites but who hear and believe in Yahweh. King Solomon asks Yahweh to hear the foreigner's prayers, because the foreigner has heard people speak about Yahweh's power and strength. King Solomon then boldly asks Yahweh to do whatever the foreigner asks. King Solomon believes that the foreigner can tell all people about the character of the God of Israel, so that all people, not just the Israelites, will fear Yahweh. Lastly, King Solomon wants all people to know that the temple bears Yahweh's name and Yahweh's name alone. Then people will know that the temple is the place where God is present and that they should worship God there.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Think about a time when you prayed for or were kind to foreigners who used to be your enemies. Share your story with the group. Pause this audio here.

In King Solomon's sixth request, King Solomon speaks to Yahweh and asks Yahweh to give victory to the people of Israel when Yahweh tells the people to fight a war with enemies. King Solomon describes to Yahweh that the people will look toward the city that Yahweh has chosen for the people of Israel. The people will also look toward where the temple is as the people pray. When this happens, King Solomon asks Yahweh to hear the people's prayers and supplications, to make the Israelites strong, and to cause the Israelites to defeat their enemies.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what do people do with their bodies when they pray? Pause this audio here.

Finally, King Solomon talks about the times when the Israelites will sin [and when enemy armies will force the Israelites to leave their own land and be slaves in a foreign land.]{.mark} Even though Yahweh is angry when the Israelites sin, King Solomon asks Yahweh to listen to the Israelites' prayer when they turn back to Yahweh and obey him. The Israelites must confess that they have sinned and decide to change before Yahweh will forgive the Israelites and save them.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 6:22–39 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has seven scenes. Even though King Solomon is praying during the whole passage, it may be easier to act out Solomon's separate requests as separate scenes.

In the first scene: King Solomon asks Yahweh to judge people when one person accuses another person of doing something wrong.

In the second scene: King Solomon asks Yahweh to save the Israelites from their enemies, to return the Israelites to the land Yahweh gave them, and to forgive the Israelites when they pray and turn back to Yahweh.

In the third scene: King Solomon asks Yahweh to forgive the Israelites when they pray and to send rain to end the drought.

In the fourth scene: King Solomon asks Yahweh to forgive the Israelites when they pray and to stop disease and disaster from happening.

In the fifth scene: King Solomon asks Yahweh to hear foreigners when they pray to Yahweh.

In the sixth scene: King Solomon asks Yahweh to give the Israelites victory when Yahweh sends the Israelites to fight enemies.

In the seventh scene: King Solomon asks Yahweh to hear and forgive the Israelites when they pray and to release them from captivity by their enemies.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Solomon
- Yahweh
- People of Israel—this group can act out any part of the drama with people of Israel
- Two people at the altar
- Enemies of Israel—this group can act out any part of the drama with enemies
- Foreigners
- All peoples of the earth
- The Israelites' ancestors
- And Moses

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In this passage, each scene represents a different part of King Solomon's prayer to Yahweh. Each scene seems to act as a shorter prayer within the larger prayer. King Solomon speaks to Yahweh about seven situations that will probably happen in Israel. These situations are things that Yahweh has talked about before. Yahweh has promised that Yahweh will act in the way that Solomon asks Yahweh to now. Just like the beginning of this prayer, Solomon asks Yahweh to do what Yahweh promised. King Solomon also asks Yahweh to show mercy on the people of Israel when they repent.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how do you pray for things or situations that might happen in the future? Pause this audio here.

King Solomon seems to use a pattern when he prays. King Solomon recognizes that something will happen. King Solomon then mentions whether or not the people's sins have caused the thing to happen. King Solomon says that the people must be sorry and ask for Yahweh's forgiveness. Solomon asks that Yahweh hear the people and forgive the people. Lastly, Solomon asks that Yahweh give something to the people in a specific way. This is a common pattern for most scenes.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Think back through each section and notice the pattern. Notice how King Solomon uses a lot of the same phrases throughout the prayer. How can you show this pattern in your translation? You will probably want to translate these phrases in the same way throughout the prayer. Pause this audio here.

In the first scene, King Solomon speaks to Yahweh about what to do if someone accuses a neighbor of doing something against the person. In this situation, a neighbor can mean a friend or any other person. King Solomon says that both people will stand in front of the altar in the temple courtyard and take an oath, or a strong promise, that they are innocent. King Solomon then asks Yahweh to judge who is telling the truth. King Solomon asks Yahweh to punish the person who does something wrong and to also clear the innocent person of any judgment.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how do people talk when those people want to emphasize that they are telling the truth? What kinds of words or phrases do you have that might be the same as what King Solomon uses for "oath" in this passage? Pause this audio here.

In the second scene, King Solomon speaks to Yahweh about when the Israelites sin and when Yahweh allows enemies to defeat the Israelites. King Solomon uses the word "when," which means that King Solomon expects this situation to happen at some point. However, King Solomon asks Yahweh to hear when the Israelites pray and make supplication to Yahweh. You will remember that when people make supplication, people are very sincerely and humbly begging Yahweh to do something for them. King Solomon also asks Yahweh to forgive the Israelites and return the Israelites to the land that Yahweh gave to their ancestors.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your language, how can you describe supplication? Take time to review the words you used in the last passage for how the Israelites talk to Yahweh through supplication and prayer. Discuss which terms you can use in this passage. Pause this audio here.

In the third scene, King Solomon speaks to Yahweh about when the Israelites sin and when Yahweh "shuts up the heavens," which means that Yahweh stops rain from falling from the sky.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will translate that Yahweh has "shut up the heavens," or stopped rain from falling from the sky. Pause this audio here.

When there is a drought, it does not rain for a very long time. A drought can make it difficult for people to grow crops and make food. Again, King Solomon recognizes that the people of Israel may sin against Yahweh and cause the drought. King Solomon asks Yahweh to hear the prayers of the people and to forgive the people. King Solomon also asks Yahweh to teach the people of Israel the right way to act and then to send rain down onto the land that Yahweh gave as an inheritance to the people of Israel. Many years before, Yahweh gave the land of Israel as a gift to the Israelites. This is not the same as an inheritance that a person receives after someone dies. Yahweh provides the land of Israel, this special place, for the Israelites because Yahweh loves and provides for the Israelites.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you describe that Yahweh has given the land to the people of Israel as an inheritance? Pause this audio here.

In the fourth scene, King Solomon begins to list different types of disasters that could happen to the people of Israel. King Solomon says that the people of Israel could experience famine or plague. Famine is when a large part of the population cannot grow crops and has no food. King Solomon lists different ways that this may happen, like blight, mildew, locusts, or grasshoppers, which all destroy plants that people eat. King Solomon also talks about when an enemy besieges or surrounds an Israelite city. Then the people inside would run out of food. King

Solomon finishes the list by saying “whatever disaster or disease” and seems to make sure that he is listing every possible disaster. When these disasters happen, the people can pray to Yahweh, just as Yahweh said the people can. The people of Israel must recognize the suffering they “hold in their hearts.” This means that the Israelites recognize that they are suffering because they have sinned. Yahweh knows what is “in our hearts,” or what we think or feel. The Israelites have sinned. The Israelites must ask God to forgive them and must stop sinning. King Solomon asks Yahweh to hear the prayers and forgive the people. King Solomon also asks Yahweh to deal with each person so that each person will always “fear,” or honor, Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your language, what words do you have like “fear” that can have different meanings? How can you show that fear means to honor Yahweh in this passage? Pause this audio here.

In the fifth scene, King Solomon speaks to Yahweh about foreigners who may hear about Yahweh and travel to where the people of Israel live. King Solomon asks Yahweh to hear the prayers of the foreigners who believe and pray towards the temple. King Solomon knows that if Yahweh hears a foreigner’s prayer and answers the prayer, the people of Israel and all people will see what Yahweh does and how Yahweh answers, and will know who Yahweh is and fear Yahweh. King Solomon wants everyone to know that the temple only exists for people to honor and praise Yahweh’s name. When King Solomon talks about Yahweh’s strength and power, Solomon says that Yahweh’s name is great, Yahweh has a mighty hand, and Yahweh has an outstretched arm. This means that Yahweh is strong and powerful and deserves the highest honor.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In this passage, King Solomon says that the temple exists for Yahweh’s name. In your culture, how do names show the character and reputation of a person? How can you translate this passage to show why Yahweh’s name and reputation were important in the temple? How will you translate that Yahweh has a mighty hand and outstretched arm, or that Yahweh has great power? Pause this audio here.

In the sixth scene, King Solomon asks Yahweh to give the people of Israel victory when Yahweh sends the people of Israel to fight against other nations. The people of Israel must turn in the direction of the city where Yahweh is, and the people must pray towards the temple. King Solomon asks Yahweh to hear the prayers and pleas and to cause the Israelites to win!

In the seventh scene, King Solomon speaks to Yahweh about captivity. King Solomon recognizes that the people of Israel will sin. King Solomon also says that Yahweh will allow other nations to capture the people of Israel and keep them in captivity. This is the punishment that Yahweh promised if the Israelites continued to sin against Yahweh. However, King Solomon asks Yahweh to see and hear when the people of Israel turn back to Yahweh with their heart and soul and pray for Yahweh’s forgiveness. King Solomon uses the words “sin,” “wrong,” and “evil” to show how much they realize that they have acted in horrible ways against Yahweh. King Solomon knows that the people must show that they need forgiveness and must ask Yahweh with sincere prayers to forgive them.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 6:22–39 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has seven scenes. Even though King Solomon prays a prayer for the whole passage, it may be easier to act out the separate requests as separate scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Solomon
- Yahweh
- People of Israel—this group can act out any part of the drama with people of Israel
- Two people at the altar
- Enemies of Israel—this group can act out any part of the drama with enemies
- Foreigners
- All peoples of the earth

- The Israelites' ancestors
- And Moses

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

First, King Solomon prays to Yahweh about oaths that people swear when they disagree. King Solomon says that when a person brings harm to another person, the two people stand in front of the temple altar and make an oath and promise that they have not done a harmful act. King Solomon then asks Yahweh to judge the two people and to condemn the guilty person and show the innocence of the person who has not done a harmful act.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the guilty person, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am afraid of what Yahweh will do! or
- I feel anxious that everyone will know what I did! or
- I should not have done this sin!

Continue the drama.

Second, King Solomon prays to Yahweh about when the Israelites sin and when Yahweh allows enemies to defeat the Israelites. When the Israelites turn back to Yahweh and praise Yahweh sincerely, King Solomon asks that Yahweh listen. Then Yahweh can forgive the people and bring the people of Israel back to the land that Yahweh promised to the people of Israel.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Solomon, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Please hear my prayer, Yahweh! or
- I have faith that Yahweh will hear me! or
- I hope the people of Israel remember this prayer.

Continue the drama.

Third, King Solomon prays to Yahweh about drought in the land. King Solomon knows that Yahweh can make the rain stop when the people of Israel do not follow Yahweh. When drought happens in this way, King Solomon asks Yahweh to hear the people of Israel when the people pray to Yahweh and no longer sin. King Solomon also asks Yahweh to teach the people the right way to live and to send rain down on the land that Yahweh gave to the people of Israel as an inheritance.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am sad when my people sin against me! or
- King Solomon is very wise; or
- I want to listen to my people when they pray.

Continue the drama.

Fourth, King Solomon prays to Yahweh about famine and plagues. King Solomon recognizes the different ways that famine can happen. King Solomon knows that the people of Israel will sin and that Yahweh will then allow blights, mildew, locusts, and grasshoppers to destroy their crops and enemies to besiege their cities. King Solomon asks Yahweh to hear the people when they are in the middle of any disaster or disease and begin to pray. King Solomon asks Yahweh to see the people as they spread their hands towards the temple and pray to Yahweh for forgiveness. King Solomon then asks Yahweh to forgive the people and to deal with each person because of what they think in their hearts. Yahweh knows what people think and how to treat each person so that each person will always fear and honor Yahweh.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the Israelites, "What are you feeling or thinking?" A person might answer things like:

- We are going to lose all of our crops! or
- I am scared of what is going to happen next! or
- Why is this happening to us?

Continue the drama.

Fifth, King Solomon prays to Yahweh about how to treat foreigners who travel to Israel because they have heard about Yahweh. King Solomon recognizes that the foreigners will likely arrive because the foreigners have learned about Yahweh's great name, mighty hand, and outstretched arm! King Solomon then asks that Yahweh would hear the foreigner's prayer and give the foreigner whatever they ask for. King Solomon believes that all people will see what Yahweh does, will honor Yahweh, and will know that people honor Yahweh in the temple.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the foreigner, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am so grateful to know Yahweh! or
- I trust that Yahweh will answer! or
- I must tell other people about Yahweh!

Continue the drama.

Sixth, King Solomon prays to Yahweh for victory for the people of Israel when Yahweh sends the Israelites to fight with their enemies in different places. King Solomon asks Yahweh to cause the Israelites to win when the people pray towards the city and temple.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the people of Israel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We need Yahweh's help! or
- We must remember to pray to ask Yahweh for help; or
- I feel afraid to go to war!

Continue the drama.

Seventh, King Solomon speaks to Yahweh about possible captivity in the future. King Solomon realizes that the people of Israel may sin against Yahweh, and then enemies may capture the people. King Solomon asks Yahweh to hear the people as they pray from the different lands and ask for forgiveness. King Solomon asks Yahweh to forgive the people.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 6:22–39 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

King Solomon begins to pray for neighbors, or people, who must take oaths before the **altar** in the **temple**. When two people disagree, those people must stand before the altar and take an oath or a strong promise to say that they are innocent. For more information on altar and temple, refer to the Master Glossary, and use the same words or phrases as you have in previous passages.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **oath** and **neighbor**. In this case, a neighbor can mean any person you interact with. Refer to the Master Glossary for more information about oath and neighbor. Pause this audio here.

King Solomon asks Yahweh to hear from **heaven,** where Yahweh lives, then **judge** Yahweh's **servants** and condemn the guilty person and vindicate the innocent person. In this passage, a servant is someone who is devoted to Yahweh. You will remember that when someone judges another person, they decide if that person is guilty or innocent. To condemn a person means to punish a person. To vindicate means to say that someone is innocent. For more information on heaven, judge, and servants, refer to the Master Glossary, and use the same words or phrases as you have in previous passages.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **guilty**. Refer to the Master Glossary for more information about guilty. Pause this audio here.

King Solomon then speaks to Yahweh about future moments when the people of **Israel** might sin against Yahweh and another army defeats the Israelites. King Solomon asks Yahweh to hear the people when they **pray** for **forgiveness** and **praise** or thank Yahweh. King Solomon says that the people will pray in **supplication** in the temple. You will remember that supplication means to pray sincerely and humbly. In other words, the people of Israel need to show that they mean what they are praying. Then King Solomon asks Yahweh to forgive the people's sins. Sin is when a person does anything that goes against what Yahweh asks them to do. Use the same words or phrases for Israel, pray, forgive, supplication, and praise as you did in previous passages. Look up Israel, pray, forgive, and praise in the Master Glossary for more information.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **sin**. Look up sin in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

King Solomon then says that Yahweh shuts up the heavens so that it does not rain**,** which means that Yahweh brings drought. King Solomon talks about "heavens" to mean the sky from which rain falls, and not the place where Yahweh lives.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **heaven**. If you have already translated heaven to mean "sky" in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Look up heaven in the Master Glossary for more information. Pause this audio here.

King Solomon asks Yahweh to hear the prayers of the people and to send rain to the land that Yahweh gave to the people of Israel as their inheritance. In this passage, King Solomon also says that Yahweh calls the Israelites his inheritance, or treasure. This means that the land belongs to the Israelites because Yahweh has given it to them, and that the people of Israel belong to Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **inheritance**. If you have already translated this idea in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

King Solomon then speaks to Yahweh about famine and plague. Famine happens when people experience a widespread loss of crops and food. Plague happens when diseases, illnesses, or disasters spread to many people. King Solomon also lists other things that cause famine, such as blight, mildew, grasshoppers, locusts, and a siege on a city. Blight is when hot and dry winds blow and destroy crops. Mildew is when plants become too damp and rot. To besiege a city means that people from another land surround a city so that people cannot leave the city or receive supplies from outside the city walls.

Stop here and look at the photos again of a land that has experienced blight or mildew. Look at photos of grasshoppers and locusts. Discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **famine**, **plague**, **disease**, **blight**, **mildew**, **grasshoppers**, **locusts**, and **siege**. Refer to the Master Glossary for more information about

siege. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Yahweh knows people's **hearts**, and Yahweh wants everyone to fear Yahweh. You will remember that a person's heart is the way that people in the Bible talked about where a person's thoughts, feelings, and decisions happen. When someone fears Yahweh, that person honors and respects Yahweh very much. Use the same word or phrase for heart as you have used previously, and refer to heart in the Master Glossary for more information.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will translate that people should **fear** Yahweh. For more information, refer to "fear of God" in the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

King Solomon wants Yahweh to protect the land that Yahweh gave to the **ancestors** of the people of Israel. Ancestors are people in a person's family who are older than that person or lived before that person. Use the same word or phrase for ancestors as you used in previous passages.

King Solomon then speaks to Yahweh about the foreigner who might hear about Yahweh and travel to where the people of Israel live. King Solomon asks Yahweh to hear the foreigner when the foreigner prays towards the temple. Solomon talks about foreigners who do not live in the land of Israel, but come from far away just to pray to Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **foreigner**, when it means a person who does not regularly live in the land. Look up foreigner in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

King Solomon then speaks to Yahweh about the people of Israel going to war. King Solomon asks **Yahweh** to bring victory to the people of Israel when they pray to Yahweh in the city and temple that honors Yahweh. Use the same word or phrase for Yahweh as you used in previous passages. Look up Yahweh in the Master Glossary for more information.

King Solomon then prays to Yahweh about captivity. King Solomon again knows that the people will likely sin and that captors, or enemies who capture the people, will take the people and hold them captive in another land. When someone holds someone captive, they force that person to stay in one place.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **captive** and **captor**. Pause this audio here.

King Solomon asks Yahweh to hear the people when they repent or turn away from their sins and return to follow Yahweh. The people stop acting in wrong and wicked ways.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **repent** and **wicked**. Look up repent and wicked in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

King Solomon says that the people turn back to Yahweh with their "**heart and soul**," which means they show that they are completely devoted to Yahweh. Use the same words or phrases for "heart and soul" as you used in 1 Kings 2:4, and refer to the Master Glossary for more information about soul.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

2 Chronicles 6:40–7:3

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

2 Chronicles 6:40–7:3

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 6:40–7:3 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 6:40–7:3 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 6:40–7:3 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this passage, King Solomon finishes praying to Yahweh for Yahweh's blessing. It is important to remember that this prayer is a part of a longer series of prayers that King Solomon has prayed. King Solomon has just built the temple for Yahweh and for people who worship Yahweh. Yahweh promised King Solomon's father, King David, that King Solomon would become king and would build the temple. Yahweh has fulfilled Yahweh's promises.

Stop and look at a photo or illustration of King Solomon's temple as a group. Pause this audio here.

King Solomon has completed the temple and asks Yahweh to show favor and for Yahweh's presence to permanently live in the temple. It is important to remember that in previous passages, the Israelites brought the ark of the covenant to the temple. King Solomon commanded the people to bring the ark because King Solomon knew that the ark represented the presence of Yahweh. King Solomon can now pray for Yahweh's presence and blessing over the temple.

Stop and, as a group, look at a photo or illustration of the ark of the covenant. Pause this audio here.

Stop and look at a diagram of Solomon's temple, including the inner sanctuary and holy rooms. Pause this audio here.

Stop and discuss this question as a group: Think of a time when you finished a huge task or a process that took a long time. How did you feel once you completed it? Pause this audio here.

King Solomon asks Yahweh to open his eyes and ears to every prayer that people will offer in the temple. King Solomon is asking Yahweh to be aware and to watch and listen to the prayers of Yahweh's people.

Stop and discuss this question as a group: Describe the emotions you feel when you want something important to happen. Think of the thoughts and feelings you have and share with the group. Pause this audio here.

2 Chronicles 6:40–7:3

King Solomon asks Yahweh to arise, or act, and come rest, or live, in the temple. This means that Yahweh will be present forever in the temple. King Solomon also says Yahweh should come with the ark of the covenant. King Solomon recognizes that the ark of the covenant represents where Yahweh has lived among his people. It is important to remember that Yahweh's presence was with the ark and brought victory to Israel. Both the temple and the ark show that Yahweh is with the Israelites. King Solomon says that the ark represents Yahweh's strength or power.

Stop and discuss this question as a group: Think of a time when you prayed and asked God to fix a problem in your life or to answer your prayer. What happened after you prayed? Pause this audio here.

King Solomon prays for Yahweh to bless the priests by "clothing them in salvation." King Solomon is actually asking for Yahweh's blessing and salvation to cover or be with the priests like clothing. The priests experience Yahweh's salvation and show how Yahweh saves the people. The priests have important responsibilities in the temple, and the priests need Yahweh to help them do all of their duties. King Solomon continues by praying in hope that the people of Israel who are faithful and loyal to Yahweh will rejoice and worship Yahweh because of Yahweh's goodness to the people.

Stop here and look at a photo of what a priest would normally wear. Pause this audio here.

Stop and discuss this question as a group: Imagine that a king or the highest leader in your community prayed for you or honored you in front of the entire community. How would you react or feel? Pause this audio here.

In the last section of the prayer, King Solomon prays for himself. King Solomon asks Yahweh not to reject King Solomon. King Solomon is likely asking Yahweh humbly to bless King Solomon and to show King Solomon favor as King Solomon leads the people of Israel. Yahweh has anointed or set apart King Solomon to lead the people of Israel. In this moment, King Solomon asks for blessings for himself and the future kings of Israel. King Solomon then mentions King David and Yahweh's blessing on King David. As King David's son, King Solomon knows that Yahweh has blessed King David, and King Solomon asks for Yahweh to give the same steadfast, or faithful love, to King Solomon.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how do you remember your ancestors or other important people in your life? Think of a time when you felt the same blessings in life that your ancestors also felt. Share your experience with the group. Pause this audio here.

After King Solomon finishes his prayer, Yahweh responds. Yahweh sends down fire from heaven, or the sky, to the altar. The fire completely burns up the sacrifices that people offered when they moved the ark of the covenant, as well as the burnt offerings for the temple. Yahweh sends fire and his glory to show that Yahweh accepts and approves of both the temple and the sacrifices that King Solomon, the priests, and the people offered. Yahweh also shows his power when Yahweh sends the fire!

Show a photo or illustration of fire coming down from heaven to the altar. Pause this audio here.

It is important to remember that the temple included outdoor spaces as well, because most people could only go to certain parts of the temple. Only priests and the high priest could go inside the inner courtyard and the holy places. King Solomon likely prays in the outer courtyards before anyone enters the temple area.

Stop and review the diagram of Solomon's temple, including the inner courtyard and holy rooms as well as the outdoor spaces. Pause this audio here.

When Yahweh's glory fills the temple, the priests cannot enter the temple because there is no space. The priests are not afraid or unwilling to go in, but Yahweh's glory fills the temple completely, and the priests cannot go in. The priests and the people see Yahweh accept the sacrifices and offerings, and Yahweh's glory above the temple. The people of Israel bow down to honor and worship Yahweh.

Stop and look at a photo of people kneeling or bowing to the ground. Pause this audio here.

Stop and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how do people show respect for a person in authority? For example, in some cultures, people bow. In other cultures, people may clap their hands. Discuss as a group how your culture might respond. Pause this audio here.

2 Chronicles 6:40–7:3

The people of Israel begin to worship Yahweh and to offer praise to Yahweh. The people of Israel respond to Yahweh's presence by saying, "He is good; His steadfast love continues forever." The people of Israel often respond like this to Yahweh's goodness, faithfulness, and steadfast love. The priests also sang this in earlier passages.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 6:40–7:3 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: King Solomon prays for Yahweh to hear the Israelites' prayers and take care of the Israelites.

In the second scene: Yahweh sends down fire to accept the sacrifices and burnt offerings, and Yahweh's glory fills the temple. The priests see Yahweh's glory and cannot enter the temple.

In the third scene: The people of Israel see the fire and the glory above the temple, so the people bow down and worship Yahweh.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Solomon
- Yahweh
- Priests
- People of Israel
- And King David

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first scene, King Solomon finishes his series of prayers when Solomon asks Yahweh to hear the Israelites' prayers and take care of the Israelites. Solomon uses a word to start his prayer that shows that Solomon is coming to the end of his prayer and is summarizing what Solomon has been praying for.

Stop and discuss this question as a group: In your language, how can you show the transition to the end of King Solomon's prayer? Pause this audio here.

King Solomon uses poetic language in his prayer to Yahweh. King Solomon first asks Yahweh to watch and hear what King Solomon is about to pray, and to continue doing this for every prayer that the people of Israel pray in the temple.

Stop and discuss this question as a group: In your language, how will you describe God seeing or hearing something when you cannot see God? How does your culture describe God as having human experiences like seeing or hearing? How can you translate the poetic language of Solomon's prayer? Pause this audio here.

King Solomon also asks for Yahweh to arise and rest in the temple, along with the ark of the covenant. Yahweh was not sitting, but when King Solomon asks Yahweh to "arise," Solomon is asking Yahweh to act. Yahweh was not sleeping, but when King Solomon asks Yahweh to rest, Solomon is asking Yahweh to be present and live in the temple.

King Solomon then prays that Yahweh would bless and cover the priests in Yahweh's salvation. Solomon compares salvation, or the way Yahweh saves, to a garment that people wear. Just like clothes are with people wherever they go, Solomon asks Yahweh's salvation to be with the priests. The priests can then show Yahweh's salvation to the people, like a person can show what clothes that person wears. King Solomon is asking Yahweh to help the priests carry out the duties that Yahweh has given to the priests. King Solomon then prays that the faithful and loyal people of Israel will praise Yahweh for Yahweh's goodness. It is likely that King Solomon is asking Yahweh to also help the people of Israel to see all of the good that Yahweh has done and will continue to do.

2 Chronicles 6:40–7:3

Stop and discuss this question as a group: In your language, how will you describe Yahweh covering the priests with salvation like a person covers themselves in clothes? Pause this audio here.

King Solomon ends his prayers by asking Yahweh to accept and anoint King Solomon as the King of Israel. You will remember that leaders poured oil over the heads of new kings to show that Yahweh had chosen them to be king. Therefore, storytellers often referred to kings with the phrase "anointed person." King Solomon asks Yahweh to remember Yahweh's steadfast love for King David. Yahweh loved King David, and King Solomon desired for Yahweh to love Solomon in that way too.

In the second scene, Yahweh responds to King Solomon's prayer. Yahweh sends down fire from heaven, or the sky, to burn up the sacrifices and burnt offerings that the people placed on the altar. Yahweh shows that Yahweh approves of the temple that Solomon built. Yahweh's glory fills the entire temple and leaves no room for anything else. It is likely that Yahweh showed Yahweh's presence, or glory, with something people could see or feel, like a bright light or a cloud. Yahweh's glory filled the temple so much that the priests could not enter the temple.

Stop and discuss this question as a group: In your language, how will you describe the fire from heaven, or the sky? How can you translate Yahweh's glory in this passage? Pause this audio here.

Stop and discuss this question as a group: How can you describe that the priests cannot enter the temple sanctuary because of Yahweh's glory? Discuss possible ways to translate this. Pause this audio here.

In the third scene, the people of Israel see Yahweh's fire on the altar, and the people can see Yahweh's presence over the temple. The people of Israel [responded when they bowed down to the ground and worshipped Yahweh.] {.mark} The people kneeled on the pavement, which was the flat stones that made the floor in the courtyard. The people of Israel said, "He is good; His steadfast love continues forever." In this case, "he" refers to Yahweh, and the people of Israel use this phrase in the same way that they use it in other moments to show how they feel about what Yahweh has done.

Stop here and look at a picture of natural stone similar to the floor in the temple. Pause this audio here.

Stop and discuss this question as a group: Review how you translated the words, "He is good, his love endures forever," in 2 Chronicles 5:13 and translate it the same way you did before. Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 6:40–7:3 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Solomon
- Yahweh
- Priests
- People of Israel
- And King David

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

2 Chronicles 6:40–7:3

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses:

After King Solomon built the temple, King Solomon stood before the people of Israel and prayed to Yahweh. King Solomon prayed to Yahweh and asked Yahweh to watch and hear King Solomon's prayers and every prayer that people prayed in the temple.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Solomon, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I hope Yahweh answers my prayers! or
- I must take care of the people of Israel!

Ask the people playing the people of Israel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- I hope Yahweh hears our prayers; or
- We feel honored that King Solomon is praying for us; or
- Wow! Look at what King Solomon has built for Yahweh!

Continue the drama.

King Solomon then prayed and asked Yahweh to come and fill the temple and to live with the ark of the covenant.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Solomon, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel worried about what Yahweh will do! or
- The ark of the covenant is finally here! or
- Surely Yahweh will answer!

Continue the drama.

King Solomon also prayed that Yahweh give the priests Yahweh's salvation and blessing.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing a priest, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I do not want to do anything to upset Yahweh! or
- I must do all I can to bless Yahweh and to help the people of Israel; or
- I am grateful King Solomon is praying for me!

Continue the drama.

After Solomon prayed for the priests, King Solomon prayed for Yahweh's faithful people. King Solomon prayed that the people of Israel would always rejoice because of Yahweh's goodness.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am happy that King Solomon really wants my blessing! or
- I love that my people are praying to me! or
- I want my people to always remember how good I am to them.

Continue the drama.

King Solomon finished his prayers and asked Yahweh not to reject king Solomon, but instead to remember the love Yahweh showed to David.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Solomon, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I really need Yahweh's blessing! or
- I wish my father could see the temple; or

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- I want Yahweh to love me as loyally as Yahweh loved my father, David.

Continue the drama.

After King Solomon finished praying, Yahweh sent fire down from heaven and burned up all of the sacrifices and burnt offerings that people placed on the altar in the temple. Yahweh's glory then completely filled the temple and left no room for anything or anyone else.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Solomon, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Yahweh has answered my prayers! or
- Yahweh must really approve of the new temple! or
- I feel so grateful for all that Yahweh has done!

Continue the drama.

Yahweh's glory filled the temple so much that the priests could not enter the temple.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the priests, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- How will we perform our duties? or
- Yahweh is here! or
- I am in awe of Yahweh!

Continue the drama.

When the people of Israel saw the fire on the altar and Yahweh's glory over the temple, the people of Israel immediately worshipped Yahweh. The people of Israel bowed all the way to the ground and said, "Yahweh is good. Yahweh's love endures forever."

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Israelites, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- I am overjoyed that Yahweh is here! or
- I must bow because Yahweh is so powerful! or
- I must never doubt that Yahweh will come!

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 6:40–7:3 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

King Solomon prays to **Yahweh** to listen to the people when the people **pray** in the **temple** that King Solomon built for Yahweh. King Solomon asks Yahweh to see and hear all that King Solomon is praying and to hear and see every prayer that people will pray in the temple. King Solomon specifically says "Yahweh **God**" in this passage when Solomon speaks to Yahweh.

Use the same words or phrases for God, prayer, temple, and Yahweh as you used in previous passages and throughout. For more information on God, pray, Yahweh, or temple, refer to the Master Glossary.

King Solomon prayed for Yahweh to come to the temple and to make the temple Yahweh's resting place. King Solomon also mentions the **ark of the covenant** and asks Yahweh to rest in the temple, much like Yahweh has rested on the ark of the covenant. In this passage, Solomon calls the ark the "ark of Yahweh's strength" rather than the ark of the covenant, because the ark was a symbol of Yahweh's presence and Yahweh's strength. King Solomon wants the temple to be the place that Yahweh fills. For more information on "ark of the covenant," refer to the Master Glossary, and remember that Solomon calls the ark the "ark of Yahweh's strength" in this passage.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **resting place**. Pause this audio here.

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King Solomon prayed that Yahweh would clothe the **priests** in salvation. This likely means that King Solomon wants Yahweh to clothe the priests in salvation as the priests serve in the temple. Use the same word or phrase for priests as you used in previous passages and throughout. For more information on priests, refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **salvation**. Look up salvation in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word or phrase that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

King Solomon asks Yahweh to make Yahweh's faithful, or godly, people rejoice in Yahweh's goodness. Faithful people are people who are godly, or who continually follow Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will say **faithful**, or **godly**, people. Pause this audio here.

To finish the prayers, King Solomon prays for Yahweh to not reject the anointed one, or person. Anointed one refers to the person who is currently the king that Yahweh has chosen. King Solomon also refers to Yahweh's steadfast love for King David, who is Yahweh's **servant**, and King Solomon prays for Yahweh to love King Solomon in the same way. Use the same word or phrase for servant as you used in previous passages. For more information on servant, refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **steadfast love** and **anointed one**. Look up **anoint** in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Immediately after King Solomon finishes praying, Yahweh sends down fire from heaven, or the sky, onto the **sacrifices** and **burnt offerings** that were on the altar. Yahweh's **glory** then fills the temple. Yahweh's glory fills the temple so much that the priests cannot enter. For more information on heaven, sacrifice, burnt offering, or glory, refer to the Master Glossary, and translate these words in the same way you have translated them in previous passages.

When the **Israelites** see Yahweh's glory over the temple, the people of Israel immediately bow down to the ground to worship Yahweh. Solomon says that Yahweh is good, which means kind, joyful, or pleasing. Use the same word or phrase for Israelites as you have used previously, and refer to Israelites in the Master Glossary for more information.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **good**, **bow**, or **worship**. Look up bow and worship in the Master Glossary for more information.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

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Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

2 Chronicles 8:1–18

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 8:1–18 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 8:1–18 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

B Setting the Stage (2 Chronicles 8:1–18)

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 8:1–18 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passage, Solomon finished building the temple of Yahweh and the royal palace. Yahweh appeared to Solomon and said that if Solomon was faithful to Yahweh, Solomon's descendants would reign over Israel forever. But if Solomon or his descendants turned away from Yahweh and worshiped other gods, Yahweh would remove the people of Israel from their land and reject the temple Solomon had built for Yahweh. In this passage, the storyteller describes Solomon's building projects.

If you have already translated the book of 1 Kings, then you have already translated one version of this story. It might be helpful to go back and listen to how you translated that story. If the book of 1 Kings is available in your language, stop here and listen to 1 Kings 9:10–25. Pause this audio here.

It took Solomon 20 years to finish building the temple and the king's palace. Afterward, Solomon focused on building new cities and making existing cities stronger. King Hiram of Tyre gave Solomon some cities in new territory. This means that those cities used to be part of Hiram's territory, but now they were in Solomon's territory. Bible scholars do not know where these cities were located; most likely, they were located in the northern part of Israel, near the border with Hiram's territory.

Solomon's army attacked and conquered a place called Hamath Zobah. Bible scholars are not sure if this is the name of a town or a region. Solomon also rebuilt or fortified towns named Tadmor, Upper Beth Horon, Lower Beth Horon, and Baalath. Tadmor is located northeast of Israel, on the edge of a desert. Upper Beth Horon and Lower Beth Horon were two cities very close to each other. These cities were located in a valley near Jerusalem; Lower Beth Horon was down in the bottom of the valley, while Upper Beth Horon was located at the top of the valley. Bible scholars are not sure where Baalath was located.

Stop here and look at a map that shows the locations of the cities of Tadmor, Upper Beth Horon, and Lower Beth Horon. Pause this audio here.

Solomon built cities to store extra goods in. These cities are called storage cities or supply centers. A king might store things like grain, oil, or wine in a storage city. Or a king might use a city to store materials for battle, like weapons and things soldiers use to protect themselves in battle.

King Solomon used forced labor, or slaves, for his building projects. This was very common in the ancient world. The people Solomon used as slaves were the descendants of the Canaanites that the Israelites had not been able to drive out of the land of Israel. These people were descendants of the Hittites, Amorites, Perizzites, Hivites,

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and Jebusites. The Law that Yahweh gave to Moses for Israel did not allow Solomon to make Israelites slaves, so Solomon made the Canaanites do the hard labor of building cities. The Israelites served Solomon as soldiers, officers, government officials, and overseers.

Stop here and discuss these questions: How common is forced labor or slavery in your area? If it is not common now, was it ever common in the past? Which people were slaves? What do you think about the fact that King Solomon had slaves? Pause this audio here.

Solomon had a strong army, which included chariots and charioteers. A chariot is a kind of cart that horses pull, with at least two soldiers riding in the chariot. People used chariots to fight battles. One soldier controlled the horses, while the other soldier could shoot arrows or stab his opponents with his sword. A charioteer is a soldier who is specially trained to ride in a chariot.

Stop here and look at a picture of a chariot with its horses and charioteers. Pause this audio here.

Early in his reign, Solomon married the daughter of Pharaoh, the king of Egypt. Before Solomon finished building the king's house, Pharaoh's daughter lived in the City of David. Most Bible scholars believe that the City of David was an older part of Jerusalem, where King David once lived, and that Solomon built the king's house in a different part of Jerusalem. When Pharaoh's daughter moved into the house that Solomon built for her, Pharaoh's daughter just moved from one part of Jerusalem to another. In this scene, the storyteller explains that Solomon had another reason why Solomon wanted to move his Egyptian wife out of the City of David—the ark of the covenant had once stayed there in a tent. Solomon felt that the ark made that place holy. Because Solomon's wife was Egyptian, she was not a worshipper of Yahweh, and so Solomon felt it was not acceptable for her to be in a space where the ark of the covenant had once been.

Once Solomon had finished building the temple of Yahweh, Solomon assigned the priests and the Levites to do the daily activities in the temple. The Levites were one of the 12 tribes of Israel. Yahweh chose the Levites to be in charge of taking care of the temple and leading all of the activities there. The priests were descendants of Aaron, the brother of Moses. The gatekeepers of the temple were also Levites. The gatekeepers' most important job was to guard the entrances to the temple. But the gatekeepers also took care of all the things inside the Temple, including the special flour and wine that the priests used every day. Solomon did all of this just as Moses and King David had commanded. Solomon also made all the offerings and sacrifices at the temple that the Israelites' religious law required.

King Hiram of Tyre also gave Solomon ships to sail on the ocean. Solomon went to see these ships in two cities called Ezion Geber and Elath.

Stop here and look at a map of Israel that shows the locations of Ezion Geber and Elath. Keep looking at this map during the following discussion. Pause this audio here.

Ezion Geber and Elath were far to the south in the territory of Edom. Solomon controlled this territory, so it was no problem for Solomon to keep his ships there.

Stop here and look at a picture of a ship. Pause this audio here.

From Ezion Geber and Elath, Solomon sent ships to Ophir to bring back gold. Bible scholars do not agree about where Ophir was located, but it was probably somewhere in Arabia or northeastern Africa.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 8:1–18 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four scenes.

In the first scene: After Solomon completed building the temple of Yahweh and the king's house, Solomon rebuilt and fortified many cities throughout Israel.

2 Chronicles 8:1–18

In the second scene: The storyteller describes the people who did the work of building the temple of Yahweh, the king's house, and building up cities. The storyteller also tells us that Solomon moved his wife from the City of David to the new palace Solomon had built for her when it was finished.

In the third scene: Solomon assigned the priests, Levites, and gatekeepers to do their duties in the temple of Yahweh. Solomon made offerings and sacrifices at the temple and observed all the religious holidays.

In the fourth scene: Solomon goes to two port cities in the far south of Israel to see the ships that Hiram, king of Tyre, sent Solomon. These ships sailed to Ophir and brought back 15,000 kilograms of gold.

The characters in this passage are:

- Solomon
- Hiram
- The Israelite people
- The Amorite, Hittite, Perizzite, Hivite, and Jebusite people
- Solomon's Israelite soldiers, servants, charioteers, and horsemen
- Pharaoh's daughter
- The Levites and priests
- The officers and captains on the ships that Hiram gave Solomon
- And Yahweh

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first scene, at the end of 20 years, King Solomon finished building the temple of Yahweh and Solomon's own palace. Hiram gave Solomon some cities. This means that those cities now became part of Solomon's kingdom. These cities existed before they became part of Solomon's kingdom, so Solomon only had to make the cities bigger, stronger, or better.

Stop here and discuss these questions: Think of as many ways as you can in your language to describe a situation where a person takes something that already exists and makes it bigger, stronger, or better. Which of these words could you use to describe Solomon making these cities bigger, stronger, or better? Pause this audio here.

If you have already translated the book of 1 Kings, you might remember that Solomon gave King Hiram 20 towns in the northern part of Israel. Here, we find out that Hiram also gave some towns to Solomon. This means that those towns used to be part of Hiram's territory, but now they were part of Solomon's territory. The storyteller does not mention why Solomon and Hiram exchanged these towns. Most Bible scholars think this exchange had something to do with payment for the cedar wood that Hiram gave to Solomon.

When the storyteller says that Solomon settled Israelites in these cities, it probably does not mean that Solomon forced these people to go to these cities against their will. Solomon probably just encouraged Israelites to go live in those cities.

Solomon conquered a place called Hamath Zobah. Bible scholars do not agree on what "Hamath Zobah" means. There was a town called Hamath north of Israel. But there was also a region called Hamath and a region called Zobah. These two regions were within the territory called Aram, which King David conquered before Solomon was born.

Stop here and look at a map that shows the locations of Israel, the town of Hamath, the region of Hamath, and the region of Zobah. Continue looking at this map during the following discussion. Pause this audio here.

Bible scholars are not sure if this statement means that Solomon conquered a town called Hamath in the region called Zobah, or if Solomon conquered the region called Hamath and the region called Zobah. Bible scholars are also not sure why Solomon had to conquer, or re-conquer, territory that Solomon's father had already conquered. It is possible that either the town of Hamath Zobah tried to rebel against Solomon's rule, or that the entire region of Hamath and Zobah tried to rebel against Solomon's rule. Because we are not certain, most Bible translations simply say that Solomon conquered Hamath Zobah and do not say whether it was a town or a region.

Solomon rebuilt, or fortified, a city called Tadmor. Tadmor is located near a water source but is surrounded by desert. Tadmor was located about 485 kilometers north of Jerusalem. This city is also sometimes called Palmyra.

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You may have heard both names for this city when you listened to different versions of this passage. We recommend that you use the name Tadmor for this city.

Solomon built storage cities in the region of Hamath. Solomon built many other storage cities, or supply centers, all through the territory that Solomon controlled. A king might store things like grain, oil, salt, or wine in a storage city. The king stored these things for use in case there was not enough food. The king might also use a city to store supplies for battle, like weapons and protective items for soldiers. If the country went to war, these supplies would help the people to be better prepared than their enemy.

Stop here and discuss these questions: In your country, how do people store extra supplies? Where do people store the supplies? Who controls the supplies? How does the military or national government store its battle supplies? Pause this audio here.

Solomon made Upper Beth Horon and Lower Beth Horon into fortified cities. This means that Solomon built walls around the cities, with gates and bars to control who could go in and out. Walls, gates, and bars also made it easier to defend these cities from attackers.

Stop here and discuss how you will describe a fortified city. Pause this audio here.

Solomon also built up a town called Baalath. Bible scholars are not sure where Baalath was located. Baalath was somewhere in the territory of the tribe of Dan, which was west and northwest of Jerusalem. But the tribe of Dan was not able to stay in this land and lost it to the Philistines. The tribe of Dan moved north and eventually settled in a city called Dan.

In the second scene, the storyteller tells us about the people who did the building work for Solomon. The Hittites, Amorites, Perizzites, Hivites, and Jebusites were all descendants of a man named Canaan. Yahweh told the Israelites to drive all of the Canaanites out of the land, but the Israelites did not drive them all out. Some groups of Canaanites still lived in parts of the Israelite territory. These are the people Solomon used to do forced labor. It was against the Law that Moses gave to Israel for the Israelites to do forced labor. If Solomon used Israelites for his building projects, Solomon would have to hire these Israelites and pay them as regular workers. It cost less to use forced labor, so Solomon made the Canaanites do the construction work on Solomon's building projects.

You might have heard a few different ways to say this when you listened to different versions of this passage. Some translations say Solomon conscripted the forced laborers. Other translations say that Solomon raised slave labor, while yet others simply say that King Solomon used forced labor to build the cities. Each of these is just a different way to say that King Solomon forced the non-Israelites in Solomon's territory to do this hard physical work, and that these people did not have the choice to say no.

Stop here and discuss this question: What are some ways in your language that you can say that Solomon forced the Canaanites to do this difficult work, and that the Canaanites did not have the choice to say no or change jobs? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller also says that the Amorites, Hittites, Perizzites, Hivites, and Jebusites are still slaves in Israel "to this day." This statement means that those people were enslaved in Israel at the time that the storyteller wrote this story down. It does not mean that those people are still slaves now.

Solomon could not make the Israelites do forced labor. The Israelites were the leaders and overseers of the people who did the work. In this scene, the storyteller uses four different words or phrases to describe the roles that the Israelites filled for Solomon's building projects. The first phrase is "men of war," which means men who fight in wars. You can also translate this as "soldiers" or "fighting men."

Stop here and try to think of as many words as you can in your language that have this meaning. Pause this audio here.

The second phrase is "chief captains." This is a phrase that describes the highest leaders of a group of people. You might have heard it translated as "officers," "chief officers," or "captains of his officers."

Stop here and try to think of as many words as you can in your language that have this meaning. Pause this audio here.

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The third phrase is “commanders of chariots.” If an army has many chariots, that army needs someone to tell the charioteers what to do in the battle. The commander of chariots probably rode in a chariot himself, but the commander’s job was to tell the other charioteers where to go and what to do.

Stop here and discuss how to translate “commanders of chariots” in your language. Pause this audio here.

The fourth word the storyteller uses is a word for men who work with horses. This might be a soldier who rides on horses or a soldier who rides in a chariot. You might have heard this word translated as “cavalry,” “horsemen,” or “charioteer.”

Stop here and try to think of as many words as you can in your language that have this meaning. Pause this audio here.

There were 250 chief officers who were overseers of the workers on Solomon’s building projects.

When Solomon finished building the royal palace, Solomon moved his wife, Pharaoh’s daughter, from her previous house in the City of David to the palace Solomon had built for her. Solomon had a religious motivation for this move. Solomon’s father, King David, had brought the ark of the covenant into the City of David, where it stayed in a tent for many years. Solomon felt this made the City of David holy, because the ark represented the very presence of Yahweh. But Solomon’s wife, who was Pharaoh’s daughter, was Egyptian and did not worship Yahweh. Solomon felt it was not appropriate for Pharaoh’s daughter to be in a place where the ark of the covenant had once been.

In the third scene, the storyteller says that Solomon regularly made burnt offerings to Yahweh on the altar in the temple for the Sabbaths, New Moon festivals, and three yearly feasts. Solomon did all of this in order to obey the Law of Moses, which describes how the Israelites had to worship Yahweh. The Sabbath was the seventh day of the week, and all the Israelites were supposed to rest and do no work on that day. The priests in the temple made a special offering on the Sabbath in addition to the normal daily offering. The storyteller tells us that Solomon came to the temple every Sabbath to participate in this offering. The night that there was a new moon was considered the beginning of a new month for the Israelites. At this time, the Israelites also made special sacrifices in the temple.

The three yearly feasts were called the Festival of Unleavened Bread, or Passover; the Festival of Weeks, or Pentecost; and the Festival of Tabernacles. If you have already translated the book of Deuteronomy, then you have already translated the names of these three festivals. It would be helpful to go back and listen to the part of Deuteronomy where Yahweh commands the Israelites to observe these three feasts.

Stop here and listen to Deuteronomy chapter 16 if it is available in your language. Pay close attention to the names you chose for the Festival of Unleavened Bread, the Festival of Weeks, and the Festival of Tabernacles. Pause this audio here.

Solomon was the one who assigned the priests and Levites to take care of the temple. Solomon followed instructions that Solomon’s father, David, had left for Solomon. David had probably written these instructions down. One instruction was for the Levites to lead the people to praise Yahweh. Many of the Levites were musicians and singers, and one of their jobs was to lead the Israelites in singing songs of worship to Yahweh.

The storyteller calls David “the man of God.” This means that David loved God with all his heart and was close to God. David was dedicated to doing what God wanted. In the Bible, the term “man of God” often refers to a prophet, and many people do consider King David to be a prophet. But in this passage, the phrase “man of God” describes David’s devotion to God.

Stop here and talk about different ways that you could describe King David’s devotion to God in your language. Pause this audio here.

At the end of this scene, the author provides a summary statement. The author says that all of the instructions that David had given concerning the priests, the Levites, and their work in the temple were done in detail. This shows that the author wants the audience to know for sure that people did everything correctly that David had said to do, and that all of Solomon’s work was successful.

In scene four, Solomon traveled south to Ezion Geber and Elath to see the ships that King Hiram gave him. The two cities were located on the coast of a large, narrow body of water. You might have heard different names

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for this body of water when you listened to three different versions of the story. Some versions call it the Red Sea, others call it the Gulf of Aqaba. But most translations say that the cities were located on the coast or the seashore. Any of these translation choices is acceptable.

A ship is a very large boat, large enough to sail on the ocean. The boat had to be large enough to sail over large ocean waves and carry a lot of people and a lot of cargo for many days on the ocean.

Stop here and look at a picture of a ship on the ocean. Pause this audio here.

A sailor is a person who knows how to steer and control a ship. In the original language, the author calls these sailors "men, or servants, who know the sea." A large ship required many sailors to do different tasks to control the ship.

Stop here and discuss how you will translate "men who know the sea" into your language. Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 8:1–18 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Solomon
- Hiram
- The Israelite people
- The Amorite, Hittite, Perizzite, Hivite, and Jebusite people
- Solomon's Israelite soldiers, servants, charioteers, and horsemen
- Pharaoh's daughter
- The Levites and priests
- The officers and captains on the ships that Hiram gave Solomon
- And Yahweh

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

At the end of 20 years, during which Solomon built the temple of Yahweh and his own palace, Solomon built up the cities that Hiram had given him and settled Israelites in them. Solomon went to Hamath Zobah and captured it. Solomon also built up Tadmor in the desert and built storage cities in Hamath. Solomon rebuilt Upper Beth Horon and Lower Beth Horon as fortified cities, with walls, gates, and bars. And Solomon built Baalath and all his storage cities, and built cities for his chariots and horses. Solomon carried out all his plans for building in Jerusalem, Lebanon, and throughout all the territory that Solomon ruled over.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Solomon, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

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- I feel confident that my country is strong and wealthy; or
- I feel happy that I was able to complete so many building projects; or
- I feel grateful to Yahweh for making me so successful.

Ask the person playing the Israelite people, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am happy that we have such a good king to lead our people; or
- I feel safe because we have a strong army and many storage cities; or
- I feel proud because my people are the strongest people in this part of the world; or
- I feel satisfied that all our hard work has brought good results.

Continue the drama.

Solomon used for forced labor all the people of Canaan, whom the Israelites had not killed when they took possession of the land. These included Hittites, Amorites, Perizzites, Hivites, and Jebusites, and their descendants are still slaves to this day. But Solomon did not use Israelites for forced labor. Israelites were the soldiers, officers, chariot commanders, and horsemen. There were 250 officials in charge of the forced labor who worked on the building projects. And Solomon moved his wife, the daughter of Pharaoh, from the City of David to the palace that Solomon built for her. Solomon said, "My wife must not live in King David's house, because the ark of Yahweh has been there, and it is holy ground."

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the Hittites, Amorites, Perizzites, Hivites, and Jebusites, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am angry that my people are slaves; or
- I feel hopeless. First, our people lost our land, and now we are forced to build temples and palaces for our enemies; or
- I hate the Israelites. I wish my people could get away from the Israelites.

Ask the person playing King Solomon, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am relieved that we have finally completely conquered these Canaanites; or
- I feel hopeful that our people will continue to be wealthy and powerful for a long time; or
- I am pleased with the good work that my people have done.

Ask the people playing the Israelite soldiers, officers, commanders, and charioteers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel happy and secure because our army is so big and strong; or
- I feel hopeful that our country has a bright future because of all the things that King Solomon has done; or
- I feel bad for these Canaanite slaves, but somebody has to do the hard labor; or
- I feel proud to serve such a good king in such a strong army.

Ask the person playing Pharaoh's daughter, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am angry that my father made me marry this Israelite and leave Egypt; or
- I feel honored to be a queen in Israel; or
- I miss worshipping my gods in the temples of Egypt; or
- I do not like that my own husband thinks I am unclean and not worthy to go into the temple of his God.

Continue the drama.

Then Solomon presented burnt offerings to Yahweh on the altar Solomon had built in front of the entry room of the temple. Solomon offered the sacrifices for the Sabbaths, the New Moon festivals, and the three yearly festivals—the Festival of Unleavened Bread, the Festival of Weeks, and the Festival of Tabernacles—just as Moses had commanded. Following the rules that Solomon's father, David, had made, Solomon organized the daily work of the priests in singing hymns and doing their work. Solomon also organized the gatekeepers into divisions for the gates of the temple, because this is what David, the man of God, had ordered. They did not turn aside from what the king had commanded concerning the priests and the Levites and the storehouses. So Solomon made

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sure that the people did all the work related to building the temple of Yahweh, from the day people laid the temple's foundation to the day people finished the building.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Solomon, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am so happy that the temple of Yahweh is finished and I can finally make sacrifices in it; or
- I know that my father, David, would be very happy to see this temple I have built and see all the worship people are doing in the temple; or
- I am grateful to Yahweh for allowing me to build Yahweh's temple.

Ask the people playing the priests and the Levites, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am amazed at how large and beautiful this temple is; or
- I am grateful that we have such a beautiful place to work and to worship Yahweh; or
- This temple is impressive, but it is nothing compared to how great Yahweh is.

Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am pleased that my people are following my directions and worshipping me; or
- This temple will be a place of great importance for thousands of years to come; or
- I am happy that everything is going according to plan.

Continue the drama.

Later, Solomon went to Ezion Geber and Elath, on the seashore in the land of Edom. Hiram sent him ships that Hiram's own officers commanded with experienced crews of sailors. These ships sailed to Ophir with Solomon's men and brought back to Solomon over 15,000 kilograms of gold.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing Solomon's men, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- I am impressed because these ships are so big and valuable, and now they are ours! or
- I am amazed at how much gold we are bringing back to King Solomon; or
- I am happy because King Solomon will surely be pleased with all this gold; or
- It is a good time to be an Israelite! Our people are wealthy and powerful!

Ask the person playing King Solomon, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am grateful to Hiram for building these ships for me; or
- Now my people need to learn how to build our own ships and sail the ships; or
- I am happy with the large amount of gold that my sailors have brought back to Israel!

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 8:1–18 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

At the end of 20 years, during which Solomon built the **temple** of **Yahweh** and his own **palace**, Solomon built up the cities that Hiram had given him, and Solomon settled **Israelites** in them. Solomon went to **Hamath Zobah** and captured it. Be sure to translate temple, Yahweh, palace, and Israelites in the same way you did previously. See the Master Glossary for more information on temple, Yahweh, and Israelites. Be sure to translate the name Hamath the same way as you did in chapter seven. Be sure to translate the name Zobah the same way as you did in 1 Chronicles chapter 18.

Solomon also fortified Tadmor in the **wilderness** and built storage cities in Hamath. Be sure to translate wilderness the same way you did in chapter one. See the Master Glossary for more information on wilderness. Remember that a storage city is a city where a king might store food and weapons. Be sure to translate "storage city" the same way you did previously.

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Stop here and discuss how you will translate the name **Tadmor** into your language. Pause this audio here.

He rebuilt **Upper Beth Horon** and **Lower Beth Horon** as fortified cities, with walls, gates, and bars. Be sure to translate the name Beth Horon the same way as you did in chapter 6 of 1 Chronicles.

Stop here and decide how you will translate "**fortified cities**" into your language. Pause this audio here.

And Solomon built Baalath and all his storage cities, and all the cities for Solomon's **chariots** and horsemen. Be sure to translate chariot the same way you did in chapter one of this book.

Stop here and decide how you will translate the name **Baalath**. Pause this audio here.

Solomon finished all his plans for building in Jerusalem, Lebanon, and throughout all the territory that Solomon ruled over.

Solomon used for forced labor all the people of **Canaan**, whom the Israelites had not destroyed when they took possession of the land. These included the **descendants** of the **Hittites**, **Amorites**, **Perizzites**, **Hivites**, and **Jebusites**, as it is to this day. Be sure to translate descendants, Canaan, Israelites, Hittites, Amorites, Perizzites, Hivites, and Jebusites the same way that you have in previous books of the Bible. See the Master Glossary for more information on descendants and Canaan.

Stop here and decide how you will say in your language that Solomon made the Canaanites do **forced labor** to build his cities. Pause this audio here.

But Solomon did not use Israelites for forced labor. Israelites were the soldiers, officers, chariot commanders and horsemen. There were 250 officials in charge of the forced labor who worked on the building projects.

Stop here and decide how you will translate the word "**horsemen**" into your language. Pause this audio here.

And Solomon moved his wife, the daughter of **Pharaoh**, from the City of David to the palace that Solomon built for her. Solomon said, "My wife must not live in King David's house, for the **ark of Yahweh** has been there, and it is **holy** ground, or special ground for Yahweh." Make sure to translate Pharaoh the same way that you did in 1 Chronicles chapter four. Make sure to translate holy the same way that you have in previous passages. In this passage, the storyteller calls the ark of the covenant the "ark of Yahweh." See the Master Glossary for more information on Pharaoh, ark of the covenant, and holy.

Then Solomon presented **burnt offerings** to Yahweh on the **altar** Solomon had built in front of the entry room of the temple. Solomon offered the sacrifices for the **Sabbaths**, the New Moon festivals, and the three yearly festivals—the Festival of Unleavened Bread, the Festival of Weeks, and the Festival of Booths—just as Moses had commanded. Be sure to translate burnt offering and altar the same way you have in previous passages. Be sure to translate Sabbath the same way that you did in chapter two of this book. Refer to the Master Glossary for more information about burnt offerings, Sabbath, and altar.

The Master Glossary also has more information about the religious festivals of Israel that are mentioned here: the **New Moon festival**, the **Festival of Unleavened Bread**, the **Festival of Weeks**, and the **Festival of Tabernacles**. Be sure to translate the **Festival of Unleavened Bread**, the **Festival of Weeks**, and the **Festival of Tabernacles** the same way you did in Deuteronomy chapter 16. If you have translated the book of Numbers, use the same term for "New Moon festival" that you used in Numbers 10:10.

Following the rules that Solomon's father, David, had made, Solomon organized the daily work of the **priests** in singing hymns and doing their work. Solomon also organized the gatekeepers into divisions to guard the gates of the temple, because this is what David, the man of **God**, had ordered. The people did not turn aside from what the **king** had commanded concerning the priests and the **Levites** and the storehouses. So Solomon made sure that the people did all the work related to building the temple of Yahweh, from the day people laid the temple's **foundation** to the day people finished the building. Be sure to translate foundation, priests, Levites, God, and king in the same way that you did for previous passages. See the Master Glossary for more information on God, king, priests, and Levites.

Later, Solomon went to Ezion Geber and Elath, on the Red Sea in the land of Edom. If you have already translated the book of Deuteronomy, then you have translated the names Ezion Geber and Elath.

Stop here and listen to Deuteronomy chapter two, listening for how you translated the names Ezion Geber and Elath. Pause this audio here.

Edom is the name of the land where the descendants of Esau lived. Be sure to translate Edom the same way that you did in previous books of the Bible. Solomon built ships in Ezion Geber, and Hiram sent his own officers and servants who knew the sea to help Solomon's men sail the ships. These ships sailed to Ophir and brought back to Solomon over 450 **talents**, or 15,000 kilograms of gold. Use the same word or phrase for talent as you have used in previous passages, and refer to talent in the Master Glossary for more information.

Stop here and decide how you will translate "**servants who knew the sea**." See the Master Glossary for more information on **servant**.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

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Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (587 KB)
- Setting the Stage (3.5 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (8.0 MB)
- Embodying the Text (4.7 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (3.7 MB)
- Speaking the Word (807 KB)

2 Chronicles 9:1–12

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 9:1–12 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 9:1–12 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

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Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 9:1–12 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous story, King Solomon built cities throughout the land of Israel to make the country stronger and to serve as storage cities and cities for Solomon's chariots and horsemen. Solomon also built ships that traveled to Ophir and brought back large amounts of gold. In this story, the Queen of Sheba comes and visits Solomon in Jerusalem. The Queen of Sheba asks Solomon questions to test Solomon's wisdom and is impressed by everything she sees. King Solomon and the Queen of Sheba give each other gifts, then the Queen of Sheba goes back to her own country.

In this story, the storyteller tells the events out of order. First, the storyteller tells us about the Queen of Sheba's visit to Solomon. Next, the storyteller says that Solomon's ships not only brought back gold from Ophir, but also wood and precious stones. At the end of the story, the storyteller adds that Solomon gave the Queen of Sheba more gifts than she gave Solomon. Then the Queen of Sheba left and went back to her country.

A king often hosted the leaders of other countries in his palace. One king might send his officials to another king's palace to make an agreement, end a conflict, or to show respect. Solomon probably hosted leaders from many other countries during Solomon's 40 years as king, but there was something special about the Queen of Sheba's visit. The Queen of Sheba heard that Solomon was not only very rich and had great wisdom, but she also heard about Solomon's God, Yahweh.

A queen is usually the wife of a king. But sometimes a queen could rule her country all by herself. In biblical times, some queens had a lot of power, while other queens did not. Bible scholars are not sure where Sheba was located. Some scholars think Sheba was located in Arabia, while other scholars think it was located in northeast Africa. The Queen of Sheba traveled with a large group of people and brought expensive gifts with her. This shows that Sheba was probably a wealthy and powerful nation.

The Queen of Sheba visited Solomon because she wanted to ask Solomon questions to see how wise Solomon really was. When the Queen of Sheba talked with Solomon, Solomon answered all the queen's questions and showed her that Solomon was indeed very wise.

Stop here and discuss these questions: Tell a story in your language about someone who tests the wisdom or knowledge of another person. How does this person test the other person? Does the person use riddles, stories, questions, or something else? If you do not know any stories like this, do you know any riddles or questions that people use to show whether a person is wise and educated? If so, say them out loud. Pause this audio here.

The Queen of Sheba brought gifts for Solomon. It was common at that time for kings and queens to give each other gifts to show respect to each other. It was also a way for the king or queen to show how wealthy he or she was. The Queen of Sheba brought gold, spices, and precious stones. The queen brought these things on animals called camels. A camel is a large animal that is common in places where the weather is hot and dry. Camels can survive for a long time without drinking water. Camels are also easy for people to train and can carry a lot of weight, so people in this part of the world often used camels to carry goods while they traveled.

Stop here and look at a picture of a camel next to a person. Pause this audio here.

The Queen of Sheba was very impressed by Solomon, his palace, and everything in Solomon's palace. The Queen of Sheba said that, although she had heard very good things about Solomon, what she saw in person was even better than what had been reported to her. The Queen of Sheba blessed Solomon and Solomon's officials, and she praised Yahweh who made Solomon king. Then the Queen of Sheba left and returned to her own country.

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Stop here and discuss these questions: In your culture, when a person is successful, to whom do they usually give the credit for their success? Pause this audio here.

King Solomon also gave gifts to the Queen of Sheba. Either the number of gifts or the value of gifts King Solomon gave to the Queen of Sheba was greater than that which the queen gave to Solomon.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 9:1–12 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: The Queen of Sheba visits Solomon. The queen brings Solomon gifts and asks Solomon hard questions to see how wise Solomon really is.

In the second scene: The storyteller tells us that Solomon's ships had brought back not only a lot of gold, but also algum wood and precious stones.

In the third scene: King Solomon gives the Queen of Sheba more gifts than she gave Solomon. Then the Queen of Sheba goes back to her own country.

The characters in this passage are:

- The Queen of Sheba and her servants
- Solomon and Solomon's servants
- King Hiram's sailors
- Solomon's men
- And the musicians in the temple

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

If you have already translated the book of 1 Kings, then you have already translated a similar story. It would be helpful to go back and listen to how you translated that story.

Stop here and listen to the end of 1 Kings chapter 9 and the beginning of 1 Kings chapter 10 if it is available in your language. Pause this audio here.

In this story, the storyteller tells the events out of order. In your language, it might not be possible to tell a story out of order like this. Even if it is possible, it might be too confusing for your hearers to hear someone tell the story in this way. If this is the case, you may choose to rearrange the events of the story so that they are in the order in which they happened.

Stop here and discuss whether you will tell this story in the order that the events occurred, or if you will tell the story in the order the storyteller records the events in the Bible. Pause this audio here.

If you choose to tell the events of the story in the order in which they happened, this is the way you would tell it:

First, Solomon's men and Hiram's sailors brought back algum wood and precious stones in their ships. Solomon used the algum wood to build structures in the temple of Yahweh and the royal palace. Solomon also used some of the wood to make musical instruments. Then, the Queen of Sheba visited Solomon. The Queen of Sheba brought gifts to Solomon and tested his wisdom with hard questions. When the Queen of Sheba saw that Solomon truly was very wise, and that Jerusalem, the temple of Yahweh, and the palace were very beautiful, the queen was amazed. The queen praised Solomon and Yahweh. Then the Queen of Sheba said that even though she heard wonderful reports about Solomon and Yahweh, the reports were not half as good as what she saw when she went to Israel. Solomon gave the Queen of Sheba everything she wanted, then the queen went back to her own country.

Here is how the storyteller tells the story in 2 Chronicles:

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In the first scene of this passage, the Queen of Sheba heard about the fame of King Solomon. A queen is usually the wife of a king, but it is possible that a queen could rule her country all by herself. The queen was usually the highest-status female in the country, and she was often of higher status than everyone except the king.

Stop here and decide what word you will use for "queen." Pause this audio here.

The Queen of Sheba heard that Solomon was very famous. This means that people had spread the news about Solomon's wealth, power, and wisdom all over the world. People in faraway places knew about the things Solomon had achieved and were impressed. People also respected Solomon for his wisdom.

Stop here and discuss how you will say in your language that Solomon was famous. Pause this audio here.

The Queen of Sheba wanted to visit Solomon so that she could test Solomon's wisdom by asking him hard questions. The queen wanted to find out for herself if Solomon really was as wise as everyone said he was. The queen chose questions that would be difficult to answer because the answers needed good understanding or insight.

Stop here and discuss how you will say in your language that the Queen of Sheba tested Solomon's wisdom with difficult questions. Pause this audio here.

The Queen of Sheba did not travel by herself. The queen brought along a large number of servants and helpers. The queen probably also brought soldiers to protect her from attacks on the way. You might have heard different words or phrases for this group of people when you listened to three different versions of this story. These are different ways of saying that many people traveled with the Queen of Sheba.

Stop here and discuss how you could say in your language that many people traveled with the Queen of Sheba. Pause this audio here.

The Queen of Sheba brought many gifts to Solomon. The queen used camels to carry these goods. A camel is an animal that lives in hot, dry areas. A camel can travel for a long time without drinking water. Camels are very useful animals to help people travel through dry areas.

Stop here and look again at a picture of a camel. If your language does not have a word for "camel," discuss how you could translate the word "camel" into your language. Pause this audio here.

The Queen of Sheba brought gold, precious stones, and spices as a gift for Solomon. These spices were not the kind of spices people use to cook food. These were sweet-smelling substances that people used for perfume, incense, or to prepare a body for burial.

Stop here and discuss this question: What words can you think of in your language for these kinds of spices? Pause this audio here.

The Queen of Sheba asked Solomon hard questions. The queen talked with Solomon about all the things that were in her heart, or on her mind. This means that the Queen of Sheba talked to Solomon about all the difficult topics that she wanted answers to. In the original language, a person's heart is where that person feels and thinks. What is in a person's heart shows who that person truly is.

Stop here and discuss these questions: In your culture, what part of a person's body do you say is the source of that person's feelings and thoughts? Do you have any sayings about how a person's feelings and thoughts come from this part of the body? How could you translate the phrase "the queen spoke to Solomon about all that was in the queen's heart" into your language? Pause this audio here.

King Solomon told the Queen of Sheba everything she wanted to know. Different Bible translations explain this in different ways. All of these translations mean the same thing—Solomon answered all of the queen's questions, and none of the queen's questions were too hard for Solomon.

After the Queen of Sheba talked with Solomon, the queen realized that Solomon truly was very wise. Some translations say that the Queen of Sheba saw Solomon's wisdom. This might sound awkward in your language, because no one can actually see wisdom. In the original language, to see something can also mean to experience something, to know something, or to understand something. So this is a way to say that the Queen of Sheba realized that Solomon was very wise.

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Stop here and discuss how you will translate the phrase “the Queen of Sheba had seen all the wisdom of Solomon” into your language. Pause this audio here.

The Queen of Sheba saw Solomon’s palace and thought it was beautiful. The queen was impressed by the quality, quantity, and variety of food that Solomon served to his guests and officials.

The Queen of Sheba was also impressed by “the seating of his servants.” Bible scholars are not sure what this phrase means. It might mean that Solomon had many officials and that they all ate luxurious meals in Solomon’s palace. This would show that Solomon was very rich, because the king had to pay for all those people to eat in his palace. It might mean that Solomon provided very beautiful places for Solomon’s officials to live. This would also show that Solomon was rich and generous to the people who worked for Solomon. It might also mean that the offices and rooms where Solomon’s officials worked were large and beautiful. Whatever this phrase means, it shows that the Queen of Sheba was impressed with the way that Solomon operated his palace.

The Queen of Sheba was also impressed by the clothing of Solomon’s servants. One type of servant was a cupbearer. The cupbearer was a high-ranking official in the king’s court. The cupbearer’s main job was to taste the king’s drink before the king did to make sure it was not poisoned. But the cupbearer could have other jobs as well. If you have translated the book of Genesis, then you have already translated the word “cupbearer.” It would be helpful to go back and listen to how you translated this word in Genesis.

Stop here and listen to Genesis chapter 40 if it is available in your language. Pay close attention to how you translated the word “cupbearer.” Pause this audio here.

The Queen of Sheba was impressed by the sacrifices that Solomon made at the temple of Yahweh. Some translations include the idea that Solomon had to go up a stairway in order to go up to the temple and make the sacrifices.

After the Queen of Sheba saw how beautiful Solomon’s palace was, the storyteller says that “there was no spirit left in her.” In the original language, the word for spirit is also the word for breath. To have no breath left means the person is shocked by what they have just experienced. In this case, the Queen of Sheba was shocked in a good way. The queen was amazed by how beautiful Solomon’s palace was and by how wise Solomon was. The Queen of Sheba had expected to see good things in Solomon’s palace, but everything was much better than she thought it would be.

Stop here and try to think of ways you could say in your language that the Queen of Sheba was so impressed by everything in Solomon’s palace that there was no breath left in her. Pause this audio here.

The Queen of Sheba told Solomon that she had heard reports of Solomon’s wisdom and the things he had done, but the queen did not believe it until she came and saw it with her own eyes. This is a common way to say that the queen found out for herself that all the reports were true. In this case, the Queen of Sheba saw Solomon’s palace, heard his wisdom, ate his food, and saw all the riches that he had.

Stop here and discuss how you would describe Solomon’s wealth, wisdom, and achievements in your language. Pause this audio here.

After the Queen of Sheba talked to Solomon and heard Solomon’s wisdom for herself, the queen said that people had not even told her half of what there was to tell. This means that although the queen had heard that Solomon was a wise person, Solomon’s wisdom was far greater than what the queen had heard.

Stop here and discuss how you will describe what the Queen of Sheba meant when she said that people had not even told her half of what Solomon had done. Pause this audio here.

When you listened to three different versions of this story, you might have heard the Queen of Sheba say, “How happy your people must be!” or you might have heard her say, “How happy your wives must be!” The word for “people” and the word for “wives” are very similar in the original language, and Bible scholars do not agree on which one the Queen of Sheba meant here. Some translations leave this unclear by saying something like “How happy are the people who serve you.” We recommend that you base your translation on whichever word is in the Bible your local church uses.

When the Queen of Sheba says that Solomon’s people or wives must be happy, the queen means that they are very blessed or fortunate because of all the good things Solomon has done for them. The queen means that the

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people have good lives, with everything they need to be prosperous and secure. The people do not have to worry about their safety or their basic needs, and they can be proud of their people and their country. This would make the people feel happy most of the time.

Stop here and discuss how you might translate “How happy your people must be” into your language. Pause this audio here.

Next, the Queen of Sheba says, “Blessed be Yahweh your God.” This statement has a different meaning than when the Queen of Sheba said that Solomon’s people were blessed. This statement is a way to praise or worship Yahweh. This statement means that Yahweh is a very good God, and Yahweh deserves for people to praise Yahweh because of it.

The Queen of Sheba said that Yahweh set Solomon on the throne. This is a way to say that Yahweh made Solomon king of Israel. The queen also says that Yahweh set Solomon on the throne to rule for Yahweh. This means that Solomon’s rule as king was supposed to reflect Yahweh’s law and character. It is pretty amazing that a non-Israelite would realize that Yahweh was the true King of Israel and that Solomon ruled on Yahweh’s behalf.

Stop here and try to think of situations where a person of lower status represents a person of higher status, or does a task on behalf of a person of higher status. For example, an employee might purchase goods or arrange a sale on behalf of his employer; a messenger might deliver a message on behalf of a chief; a judge might make a decision on behalf of the government. How might these situations be similar to how Solomon rules Israel on Yahweh’s behalf? Pause this audio here.

Finally, the Queen of Sheba said that Yahweh made Solomon king over Israel because Yahweh loved Israel. The queen realized that Yahweh’s intention was for Israel to last forever. The queen said that Yahweh made Solomon king over Israel in order to maintain justice and righteousness. In ancient Israel, the king was the highest human authority in the land. The king was responsible for everything that happened in his country. The people could come to the king if they needed a fair judge to help with a conflict, solve a problem, or right a wrong. The king was supposed to protect those who were poor and weak and punish those who did wrong. The king was also supposed to always follow Yahweh’s law and do what was right.

Stop here. Tell a story about a leader or ruler who did something wise and just. Then tell a story about a leader or ruler who did something evil or unjust. How important is it that leaders are just and righteous in all they do? What bad things might happen if leaders are not just and righteous? Pause this audio here.

Then the Queen of Sheba gave Solomon more than 4,000 kilograms of gold, as well as a large amount of spices and precious stones. When the storyteller says, “There have never been any other spices as fine as those that the Queen of Sheba gave Solomon,” this could mean several things. It could mean that Solomon never received any other spices as good as those spices. Or it could mean that no king in Israel ever received spices as good as those spices.

Now the second scene takes us back to some things that happened long before the Queen of Sheba came to visit Solomon. The ships of King Hiram, which are the same ships that sailed to Ophir and brought back gold, also brought back precious stones and algum wood. When you listened to three different versions of this story, you might have heard the name Hiram pronounced “Huram.” This is just a different way to say the same person’s name.

Bible scholars are not sure exactly what kind of wood algum wood was, but it was good for constructing large buildings like Yahweh’s temple and the royal palace. Most translations of the Bible call it “algum wood.” The word “algum” sounds like the word for these trees in the original language. But a few translations call it “sandalwood” or “juniper wood.” Sandalwood is a kind of tree that grows in Asia. Sandalwood is one of the most expensive kinds of wood in the world.

Stop here and look at a picture of a sandalwood tree. Pause this audio here.

Juniper trees grow all over the world. Some juniper trees have very strong wood that is useful for building.

Stop here and look at a picture of a juniper tree. Pause this audio here.

When you listened to three different versions of the passage, you might have heard that “the king used the algum wood to make supports for the house of Yahweh,” or you might have heard that the king made railings for

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the house of Yahweh, or you might have heard that the king made steps for the house of Yahweh. Bible scholars are not sure what kind of structure Solomon made from the algum wood, so any of these translation choices is acceptable.

The Israelites also used algum wood to make musical instruments. King Solomon used the wood to make harps and lyres for his musicians. A harp is a musical instrument that people make of wood and use strings to make sound. A harp is usually shaped like a triangle. A lyre also uses strings to make sound, but people arrange the strings differently on the wood. A lyre is usually shaped more like a rectangle or oval.

Stop here and look at a picture of a harp and a lyre. What kind of stringed instruments do you have in your country? Are any of these instruments like a harp or a lyre? Pause this audio here.

Solomon's ships brought back precious stones. These are stones that are rare and very beautiful. Because these stones are rare and beautiful, people will pay a lot of money for these stones. Solomon used precious stones to decorate Yahweh's temple. The priests' garments also contained precious stones. Women liked to use precious stones to make jewelry.

Stop here and discuss these questions: What precious stones do your people value? What do you use the stones for? Pause this audio here.

In scene three, we return to the story of Solomon and the Queen of Sheba. Solomon gave the Queen of Sheba gifts. It was the normal custom for kings and queens to give each other gifts as a sign of respect and also to show how rich the king or queen was. This is what the storyteller calls the "royal generosity." But King Solomon gave the Queen of Sheba even more than the customary amount of gifts. Solomon gave the Queen of Sheba whatever she requested. Then the Queen of Sheba returned to her own land with her servants.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 9:1–12 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- The Queen of Sheba and her servants
- Solomon and Solomon's servants
- King Hiram's sailors
- Solomon's men
- And the musicians in the temple

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

When the Queen of Sheba heard that Solomon was very famous, she came to Jerusalem to test Solomon with difficult questions. The queen arrived with a large group of attendants, with camels loaded with spices, large

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quantities of gold, and precious stones. When the queen met with Solomon, the queen talked with Solomon about everything that was in her heart. Solomon had answers for all of the queen's questions—nothing was too hard for the king to explain to the queen. When the Queen of Sheba realized how wise Solomon was, and when she saw the palace Solomon had built, the excellent food on his tables, the seating of his officials, the service of his waiters and their excellent clothing, his cupbearers and the sacrifices he made at the temple of Yahweh, the queen was completely amazed.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Solomon, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am glad that this clever woman has come to visit me; or
- This queen has truly brought me excellent gifts; or
- I feel pleased to have such an excellent conversation with someone who values wisdom.

Ask the person playing the Queen of Sheba, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel happy and honored to have the chance to talk with such an insightful person; or
- It feels good to know someone who can answer these tricky questions; or
- I have never seen a person or a place like this before!

Continue the drama.

The queen said to the king, "The report I heard in my country about your achievements and your wisdom is true. But I did not believe these things until I came and saw them myself. In fact, I had not even heard about half of your great wisdom! It is far beyond what I was told. How happy your people must be! How happy are your servants, who stand here day after day and listen to your wisdom! Blessed be Yahweh your God, who has delighted in you and has placed you on the throne as king to rule for him. Because your God loves Israel and desires for this kingdom to last forever, your God has made you king over the Israelites so you can rule with justice and righteousness." Then the queen gave the king a gift of more than 4,000 kilograms of gold, great quantities of spices, and precious jewels. Never before had there been spices as fine as those that the Queen of Sheba gave to King Solomon.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Solomon, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel proud that my country and I have made such a good impression on this woman; or
- I like the Queen of Sheba. Perhaps we can be allies with this queen's country; or
- I am glad that the Queen of Sheba is giving glory to Yahweh, because Yahweh is the one who made all of this possible.

Ask the person playing the Queen of Sheba, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Solomon's God has blessed Solomon abundantly; or
- I want my country to be as rich and as beautiful as Israel; or
- I can only say good things about Solomon and his wisdom; or

Continue the drama.

Now the servants of Hiram and the servants of Solomon had brought gold from Ophir, and they also brought back algum wood and precious jewels. The king used the algum wood to make supports for the temple of Yahweh and the royal palace, and to make lyres and harps for the musicians. Never before had people seen such beautiful things in Judah.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing King Hiram's sailors and Solomon's men, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

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- We are happy that we are bringing back so many valuable things to King Solomon; or
- We are excited that our country is so rich and has so many beautiful things; or
- It was fun to sail out on the ocean!

Ask the person playing Solomon, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Hiram's sailors and my men have done a very good job; or
- I am happy that my country now owns so many valuable goods; or
- I want to make sure that I make the best use of these excellent ships.

Continue the drama.

So King Solomon gave the Queen of Sheba everything she asked for, besides all the gifts that Solomon had given her out of the royal bounty. Then the queen and all her servants returned to their own country.

Ask the person playing Solomon, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I want to show the Queen of Sheba that I am wealthy and generous, so I will give the queen more gifts than she gave me; or
- I hope that the Queen of Sheba will tell her people that I am even wiser than what they had heard; or
- I am truly happy that the Queen of Sheba visited and brought gifts.

Ask the person playing the Queen of Sheba, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Solomon is not only wise, but Solomon is generous too; or
- I wish I could stay in Israel longer; or
- I am grateful for all of Solomon's wonderful gifts.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 9:1–12 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage. If you have already translated the book of 1 Kings, you may go back and listen to how you translated this story in that book.

Stop here and listen to the end of 1 Kings chapter 9 and the beginning of chapter 10. Pause this audio here.

When the Queen of Sheba heard that King Solomon was very famous, the queen came to Jerusalem to test Solomon with difficult questions.

Stop here and decide how you will translate "**queen**" and "**famous**." See the Master Glossary for more information on a queen. Pause this audio here.

The Queen of Sheba arrived with a large group of attendants, with camels loaded with spices, large quantities of gold, and precious stones. When the queen met with Solomon, she talked with Solomon about everything that was in her heart. Solomon had answers for all of the queen's questions. Nothing was too hard for Solomon to explain to the queen. When the Queen of Sheba realized how wise Solomon was, and when she saw the **palace** Solomon had built, the excellent food on his tables, the seating of his officials, the service of his waiters and their excellent clothing, his **cupbearers** and the **burnt offerings** he made at the **temple** of **Yahweh**, the queen was completely amazed. Be sure to translate burnt offering, palace, temple and Yahweh the same way you did in previous passages. See the Master Glossary for more information on burnt offering, temple and Yahweh. Be sure to translate cupbearer the same way you did in previous stories.

If necessary, listen again to Genesis chapter 40 to hear how you translated cupbearer in a previous story. Pause this audio here.

The Queen of Sheba said to the king, "The report that I heard in my country about your achievements and your **wisdom** is true. But I did not believe these things until I came and saw them myself. In fact, I had not even heard about half of your great wisdom! It is far beyond what I was told." Be sure to translate wisdom the same way that you have in previous passages. See the Master Glossary for more information on wisdom.

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"How happy your people must be! How happy your officials must be, who continually stand in your presence and hear your wisdom! **Blessed** be Yahweh your **God**, who has delighted in you and has placed you on the **throne** as king to rule for him." In this case, to say "Blessed be Yahweh" is a way to praise or worship Yahweh. Be sure to translate "Blessed be Yahweh" the same way you have in previous passages. See the Master Glossary for more information on blessed when it refers to praising God. Also, be sure to translate God and throne the same way you have in previous passages. See the Master Glossary for more information on blessed and God.

"Because your God loves **Israel** and wants Israel to last forever, your God has made you **king** over the Israelites so you can rule with justice and righteousness." When a king rules with justice and righteousness, he rules fairly and rightly. The king punishes the people who have done wrong things, and the king protects the weak and poor people from other people who would harm the weak and poor. You may use the two words for justice and righteousness, or you may describe the way the king rules. See the Master Glossary for more information on king and Israel, and translate king and Israel in the same way as previously.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will translate that the king rules with **justice** and **righteousness**. You can refer to justice and righteousness in the Master Glossary, but remember that you may also describe how the king rules fairly and rightly. Pause this audio here.

Then the Queen of Sheba gave the king a gift of more than 120 **talents**, or 4,000 kilograms, of gold, great quantities of spices, and precious jewels. Never before had there been spices as fine as those that the Queen of Sheba gave to King Solomon. A talent is a measure of weight. Refer to the Master Glossary for more information about talent, if you choose to use it here.

> And also, the ships of Hiram, which brought gold from Ophir, brought in from Ophir a very great amount of **algum wood** and precious stones. Use the same word or phrase for algum wood that you used in 2 Chronicles 2:8.
>
> The king made the algum wood into supports for the temple of Yahweh and for the palace, and the king also made lyres and harps for the musicians.
>
> Stop here and decide what word you will use for "**lyre**" and what word you will use for "**harp**." Look again at pictures of a harp and a lyre if you need to. Pause this audio here.
>
> And no one has seen anything like that in the land of Judah.
>
> So King Solomon gave the Queen of Sheba everything she asked for, besides all the gifts that Solomon had given the queen out of the royal bounty. Then the Queen of Sheba and all her servants returned to their own country. Royal bounty is the gifts that a king would normally give to an important visitor.
>
> Stop here and decide how you will translate "**royal bounty**" into your language.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

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Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (624 KB)
- Setting the Stage (2.5 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (10.1 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.5 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.9 MB)
- Speaking the Word (833 KB)

2 Chronicles 9:13–31

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 9:13–31 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 9:13–31 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 9:13–31 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous story, the storyteller told us about the Queen of Sheba's visit to King Solomon. In this story, the storyteller tells us more about how rich Solomon was. The storyteller describes the throne that Solomon built inside the palace, the gifts Solomon received from visitors, and the number of chariots and horses that Solomon owned. At the end of the passage, Solomon dies, and people bury Solomon in Jerusalem. Solomon's son Rehoboam becomes king after Solomon.

In biblical times, kings were considered powerful and important if they were very rich. This passage shows us that King Solomon was extremely rich. However, Yahweh had told the Israelites that their king should not own a large number of horses, store up large amounts of silver and gold, or marry many wives. The kings of Israel were supposed to be different from the kings of the people around Israel. When Solomon bought many horses and chariots and collected large amounts of silver and gold, Solomon disobeyed Yahweh.

Solomon received almost 23,000 kilograms of gold each year. This is a very large amount of gold. In addition, Solomon received money and goods through taxes on Solomon's own people and from people in the lands around Israel.

Stop here and discuss these questions: How do the leaders of your country get money to run the country? Do you have to pay taxes? What sorts of things do you have to pay taxes on? Pause this audio here.

In this story, the storyteller describes some of the ways Solomon used his gold. Solomon used some of the gold to make large and small shields. A shield is a piece of equipment that soldiers use to defend themselves in battle. A shield could protect a soldier from arrows, swords, or objects that people threw at the soldier.

Stop here and look at a picture of a shield. Pause this audio here.

But the gold shields that Solomon made were not for soldiers to use in battle. Gold is a very soft metal and is not good to use as a shield. Solomon made these shields as a decoration for the House of the Forest of Lebanon. This house was a large building in Jerusalem. Bible scholars believe that Solomon sometimes took the shields out of the House of the Forest of Lebanon and used the shields during ceremonies. This would have shown the people how rich their king was.

Solomon used gold and ivory to make a large, beautiful throne in Solomon's palace. A throne is a special seat that only the king can sit on. Ivory is white and comes from the tusks of elephants. Sometimes, people collected the tusks from elephants that died of natural causes, but people also killed elephants just to get the tusks.

Stop here and look at a picture of an elephant. Note the size and color of the tusks. Pause this audio here.

Ivory is very beautiful and easy to carve. People used ivory to make jewelry and art. Solomon used ivory to decorate his throne. Solomon's throne was very large, with six steps leading up to the throne. The lions next to the armrests and on the steps were not real lions; they were statues of lions. A lion is a large, wild cat that was common in Israel during Solomon's time. Lions are very strong and can easily kill a human. There are very few animals that can kill a lion, so many Israelites considered lions to be the most powerful animals in Israel. Because of this, some people call the lion "the king of the animals" and use lions to symbolize kings. The lion statues around Solomon's throne were probably covered in gold, too.

Stop here and look at a picture that shows what Solomon's throne might have looked like. Pause this audio here.

Solomon had so much gold that Solomon was able to make everyday items, like cups, plates, forks, and spoons, out of gold. Solomon had so much gold that people considered silver, another valuable metal, relatively worthless in Solomon's time. The storyteller says that silver was as common as stones in Jerusalem. Jerusalem is built on hills that are very rocky, and Jerusalem stone is famous for its quality as a building material. So stones were extremely common in Jerusalem. Sycamore trees were common in the lowlands of Judah. Cedar trees were not common in Israel, and the Israelites had to import them from Tyre and other areas further north. Cedar was expensive, but Solomon was so rich that he was able to buy a large amount of cedar wood for Solomon's building projects.

Solomon had a fleet, or large group, of ships that sailed on the ocean with Hiram's servants. These ships brought goods and animals from faraway countries. It is likely that this fleet of ships sailed in the Mediterranean Sea. It was a different group of ships from the ships Solomon stationed at Ezion Geber in the far south of Israel.

Although Solomon was very rich, Solomon was also famous for his wisdom. People from all over the world came to Jerusalem to visit Solomon and to listen to Solomon's wisdom. And when the people came, they brought Solomon gifts. This is another way that Solomon became rich.

Solomon also owned many chariots and horses. This meant that Solomon had a powerful army. Throughout Israel, Solomon had 4,000 stalls for his horses. A stall is a small room inside a building where people can keep a horse. People put horses into stalls to protect the horses from wild animals and thieves. Usually, each stall contained one horse, so Solomon probably had 4,000 horses for his chariots. Solomon also had 12,000 charioteers. A charioteer is a soldier who rides in a chariot. Solomon stationed the chariots in Jerusalem and in other cities throughout Israel.

Next, the storyteller describes exactly how much territory Solomon controlled.

Stop here and look at a map of Solomon's kingdom. Note the location of the Euphrates River, the land of the Philistines, and the border with Egypt. Pause this audio here.

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Solomon controlled the territory from the Euphrates River to the border of Egypt, except for the land of the Philistines.

While Solomon was king, people wrote down everything Solomon did in other books. The names of these books were "The Book of Nathan the prophet," "The Prophecy of Ahijah from Shiloh," and "The Visions of Iddo the Seer." These books were available to the Israelites at the time the storyteller was alive, but we no longer have these books. Some of the prophecy of Ahijah from Shiloh, and possibly some of the visions of Iddo the Seer, were about Jeroboam, the son of Nebat. Jeroboam was an enemy of Solomon and Solomon's son, Rehoboam. We will learn more about Jeroboam in the next few stories.

Solomon reigned as king over Israel for 40 years, the same length of time as his father, David. Solomon was buried in Jerusalem, and his son Rehoboam became king after Solomon.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 9:13–31 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has six scenes.

In the first scene: The storyteller tells us how much gold Solomon received each year and describes the shields Solomon made from the gold.

In the second scene: The storyteller tells us about the throne that Solomon built in the palace.

In the third scene: The storyteller tells us more about Solomon's wealth and the items that Solomon's trading ships brought to Solomon.

In the fourth scene: The storyteller tells us that many people came to visit Solomon in order to hear Solomon's wisdom, and the people brought marvelous gifts with them.

In the fifth scene: The storyteller tells us about Solomon's military power and all the land that Solomon ruled over.

In the sixth scene: The storyteller tells us that people record more stories about Solomon's reign as king in other books. After 40 years as king of Israel, Solomon died and was buried in Jerusalem. Solomon's son Rehoboam became king.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Solomon
- Traders, traveling merchants, kings of the Arabians, and governors of territories
- Solomon's sailors and Hiram's sailors
- The kings who came to Jerusalem to hear Solomon's wisdom
- Solomon's horsemen
- And Solomon's son Rehoboam

If you have already translated the book of 1 Kings, then you have already translated one version of this story. It might be helpful to go back and listen to how you translated that story.

Stop here and listen to the second half of 1 Kings chapter 10, after the Queen of Sheba's visit to Solomon. Pause this audio here.

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first scene, the storyteller says that Solomon received 666 talents, or almost 23,000 kilograms, of gold each year. Solomon might have received this amount of gold when the rulers of the countries around Israel gave valuable money and things to Solomon. Sometimes, a less powerful ruler gives valuable things to a more powerful ruler. If the less powerful ruler pays these things, the more powerful ruler agrees not to attack and invade the less powerful ruler's country.

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In addition to this large amount of gold, Solomon also received money from taxes that Solomon charged merchants and traders. Anyone who did business in Israel had to pay a certain amount of tax to the king. Also, if any traders wanted to travel through Israel's land, Solomon's officials could charge the traders money to do so. This money became part of the king's income.

The Arabian kings were the rulers of the lands to the southeast of Israel. The storyteller says that the money they paid to Solomon was not included in the 23,000 kilograms of gold that Solomon received each year.

Stop here and look at a map of Israel and Arabia. What name does your language have for the place called Arabia? Pause this audio here.

The phrase "governors of the land" or "governors of the territories" probably refers to the governors of different areas inside Israel. A governor managed part of the country for the king. For example, in Israel, there might have been one governor who was responsible for managing the territory that belonged to each tribe. One job of a governor was to collect tax from the people and give it to the king.

Stop here and discuss these questions: In your country, what do you call the people who are responsible for managing different areas of the country? Could you use any of these words to translate the word "governor"? If not, what words could you use for a person who is responsible for managing one part of a country? Pause this audio here.

King Solomon hired artists to make golden shields. Solomon did not make the shields himself. The artists made large shields and small shields. Most Bible scholars believe that people made the shields from a strong yet lightweight material like wood and then overlaid the shields with gold. The larger shields required about seven kilograms of gold, and the smaller shields required about three kilograms of gold. Gold is a soft metal and is a poor material to use to make shields, so people probably did not use the shields in battle. Solomon probably used the shields as a decoration for the House of the Forest of Lebanon.

The House of the Forest of Lebanon was the largest building in Solomon's palace. Solomon built this building from cedar wood that came from Lebanon. People may have used this house as a gathering place for large groups of people, or it might have been a place to store weapons. If you have already translated the book of 1 Kings, then you have already translated the name of this building.

In the second scene, Solomon hires men to build a throne that is unlike any other throne in the world. Solomon did not build the throne himself. Solomon's throne was on a raised platform with six steps leading up to the throne. When you listened to three different versions of this passage, some of them might have said that Solomon made the throne from ivory and then overlaid it with the finest gold. Most Bible scholars think it was unlikely that Solomon would have covered ivory with gold, because ivory was expensive and also very beautiful.

Stop here and look at a picture of some ivory objects. Pause this audio here.

Most Bible scholars believe that Solomon built the throne, overlaid it with gold, and then placed ivory decorations on certain parts of the throne. There was a gold footstool in front of the throne. Each step leading up to Solomon's throne had a figure of a lion on each side, and there was also a figure of a lion next to each armrest on the throne. The lion was a symbol of the tribe of Judah, which was the tribe Solomon belonged to. The lion also represented royalty.

Stop here and look at a picture of a lion. Pause this audio here.

In scene three, the storyteller says that all of Solomon's drinking cups were gold and that all of the utensils in the House of the Forest of Lebanon were pure gold. This shows that Solomon had so much gold that Solomon could afford to use the gold for everyday items like cups and utensils.

Silver is another valuable metal that people commonly used in Biblical times to make coins, jewelry, utensils, or other items. In this scene, the storyteller says that people considered silver nothing during Solomon's days. This is a way to say that silver had very little value, or was worthless, during Solomon's reign as king, because everyone used so much gold. The people of Israel were very rich during Solomon's lifetime.

Solomon had a fleet of ships called "the ships of Tarshish." Tarshish was a city located on the far western end of the Mediterranean Sea. Israel was located on the far eastern end of the Mediterranean Sea. A ship had to sail about 1,600 kilometers to go from Israel to Tarshish.

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Stop here and look at a map of the Mediterranean Sea that shows the location of Israel and the approximate location of Tarshish. Pause this audio here.

Solomon's fleet of ships sailed on the Mediterranean Sea and could sail very long distances. Some versions of this passage might have called these ships "merchant ships" or "trading ships." Every three years during Solomon's reign, these ships brought back gold, silver, ivory, and animals. Bible scholars are not certain what kind of animals these were. Some versions of this passage say that the animals were "apes and peacocks," while other versions say the animals were "apes and baboons" or "apes and monkeys."

Monkeys are small to medium-sized, four-legged animals that have hands similar to human hands. Monkeys also have tails.

Stop here and look at a picture of a monkey. Pause this audio here.

Apes are large monkeys. Some apes can be larger than humans. Apes do not have tails.

Stop here and look at a picture of an ape. Pause this audio here.

A baboon is a specific type of medium-sized monkey.

Stop here and look at a picture of a baboon. Pause this audio here.

A peacock is a kind of bird. Peacocks have very colorful, beautiful tail feathers. People use these feathers for decorations. Women even wear peacock feathers on their hats or clothing.

Stop here and look at a picture of a peacock. Pause this audio here.

If your language does not have a word for any of these animals, you can provide a description. For example, instead of "peacocks," you could say "birds with brightly colored feathers." Or, if your language does not have a word for "apes," you could say "very large monkeys."

In scene four, the storyteller reminds us that Solomon was the richest and wisest king of his time. Kings from all over the world came to see Solomon and hear Solomon's wisdom. The storyteller reminds us that God had put this wisdom in Solomon's heart. The Israelites considered the heart to be the place where a person's thoughts, feelings, and wisdom come from.

Stop here and discuss this question: In your culture, what part of the body do you consider thoughts, feelings, and wisdom to come from? Pause this audio here.

Each person who came to see Solomon brought a gift. Some people brought silver and gold; others brought clothes, weapons or spices. Some people brought horses and mules. A mule is an animal that is very similar to a horse, but mules can work harder and are easier to handle than horses. To produce a mule, people mate a female horse with a male donkey.

Stop here and look at a picture of a mule. Pause this audio here.

In the fifth scene, the storyteller describes Solomon's military power and the area Solomon ruled over. Solomon had 4,000 stalls for his horses and chariots. When you listened to three different versions of this passage, some might have said that Solomon had 12,000 horses, while others said that Solomon had 12,000 horsemen. A horseman is a person who knows how to handle horses. Bible scholars do not agree on whether the original language means that Solomon had 12,000 horses or that Solomon had 12,000 horsemen. Some scholars think that translating the word as "horses" makes more sense in this passage than translating the word as "horsemen," but either choice is acceptable.

Solomon ruled over a large territory that stretched beyond the borders of the land that Yahweh had given to the 12 tribes of Israel. The northern border of Solomon's territory was the Euphrates River. This is the modern-day name of a large river that flows through the modern-day countries of Syria and Iraq. Some translations of this passage just say "the river," but we recommend that you include the name of the river so that people understand where this river is.

Stop here and look at a map of the Middle East that shows the Euphrates River. Pause this audio here.

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Even Solomon, with all his power, did not conquer the territory of the Philistines. The Philistines were a people group that lived along the coast of the Mediterranean Sea between the territory of Israel and the territory of Egypt. The Israelites often had conflict with the Philistines.

In the middle of this scene, the storyteller mentions again that silver was so abundant in Israel that it was as common as stones. The storyteller also says that cedars were as common as sycamore trees in the lowlands. The Israelites had to import good-quality cedar into Israel from Lebanon, and this cedar was expensive. In contrast, sycamore trees were very common in an area called Shephelah, which was in the foothills of Judah. Both of these statements mean that Solomon was so rich that he could buy a lot of expensive things.

In the sixth scene, the storyteller mentions that other people wrote down all the stories about Solomon in three other books. The storyteller introduces this scene using a question that does not expect an answer: "Now the rest of the acts of Solomon, first and last, are they not written in the book, or words, of Nathan the prophet, in the prophecy of Ahijah the Shilonite and in the visions of Iddo the Seer concerning Jeroboam the son of Nebat?" This question means that a hearer can read more about Solomon's reign in those three books. Nathan the prophet is most likely the same Nathan who was also alive during King David's lifetime. A prophet was a person who received messages from Yahweh to give to other people.

Ahijah the Shilonite was an Israelite prophet who lived at the same time as Solomon and his son Rehoboam. Ahijah was from the town of Shiloh. Ahijah received prophecy from Yahweh about Jeroboam, the son of Nebat. "Prophecy" is a word for revelation from God. A prophecy can be an instruction from God to do something, a warning from God to stop doing something bad, information about what will happen in the future, or it could be words of encouragement and hope. Prophets can receive prophecies in different ways, but all true prophecy comes from God.

Stop here and discuss these questions: In your language, how do you talk about messages that come from God? How do you make sure that a message is really from God? Pause this audio here.

Jeroboam was an Israelite who did not like Solomon and Solomon's son, Rehoboam.

Iddo the Seer lived a little bit later, during the reign of Rehoboam and his son Abijah. "Seer" is another word for "prophet." "Seer" means "someone who sees," as in, that person can see revelations from Yahweh.

Iddo the Seer had enough visions to collect the visions into a book. In this case, a vision is a revelation from God.

After 40 years as king of Israel, Solomon "slept with his fathers" or "rested with his ancestors." This is a way to say that Solomon died, just as all of Solomon's ancestors had died. This phrase shows that the Israelites believed that after a person died, that person's soul was at rest, like being asleep. The person's soul was not active or aware of things happening on earth.

Stop here and discuss these questions: What different ways do you have in your language to say that someone died? Which of these sayings describes that the person's soul is at rest or asleep? Which of these sayings describes that the person's ancestors have also died and are at rest? Decide how you will translate this phrase. Pause this audio here.

Solomon's son Rehoboam became the next king after Rehoboam's father died.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 9:13–31 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has six scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Solomon
- Traders, traveling merchants, kings of the Arabians, and governors of territories

- Solomon's sailors and Hiram's sailors
- The kings who came to Jerusalem to hear Solomon's wisdom
- Solomon's horsemen
- And Solomon's son Rehoboam

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Every year, King Solomon received around 23,000 kilograms of gold. This was in addition to the taxes from the merchants and traders. And all the kings of Arabia and the governors of the country brought gold and silver to Solomon. Solomon made 200 large shields and covered each shield with about seven kilograms of hammered gold. And Solomon made 300 small shields, and overlaid each shield with about three kilograms of hammered gold. The king placed these shields in the House of the Forest of Lebanon.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Solomon, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am happy that I have so much gold and can make all these beautiful things; or
- All this gold and silver will make our country more secure; or
- I feel powerful and important because I have so much wealth.

Ask the people playing the traders and merchants, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- These taxes and fees are really a burden; or
- I need to find a way not to pay so much tax; or
- It is not fair that we work so hard only for so much of our money to go to the king.

Ask the people playing the kings of Arabia, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- It makes me angry to pay tribute to Solomon, but our army cannot defeat Solomon's army; or
- I feel sad that we are losing our gold to a foreigner; or
- I resent the fact that Solomon is more powerful than we are.

Ask the people playing the governors of the country, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am happy that our country is so prosperous; or
- I do not like paying taxes when the king wastes it on making golden shields; or
- Did Yahweh not say that our king should not collect a lot of gold?

Continue the drama.

Then the king made a large throne decorated with ivory and overlaid with the finest gold. The throne had six steps and a footstool covered with gold in front of it. There were armrests at either side of the seat, and a lion stood next to each armrest. Twelve lions stood on the steps, one at each end of each step. No one had ever made anything like this throne for any other kingdom.

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Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Solomon, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am so proud of this beautiful throne that my workers have made! or
- I feel strong and powerful when I sit on this throne; or
- I hope other kings will come visit me and be impressed by my throne.

Continue the drama.

People made all of King Solomon's cups from gold, and people made all of the utensils in the House of the Forest of Lebanon from pure gold. No one made anything from silver, because silver had very little value in Solomon's day. The king had a fleet of trading ships at sea with the ships of King Hiram. Once every three years, the ships came back bringing gold, silver, ivory, apes, and peacocks.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Solomon, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am glad that I have so much gold, silver, and other valuable goods; or
- Our partnership with Hiram has brought us a lot of valuable goods; or
- I wish my father, David, could have seen these days when Israel is so rich and powerful.

Ask the people playing Solomon and Hiram's sailors, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I really enjoy sailing to Tarshish and bringing back so many good things to the king; or
- I am glad that our country has so much gold; or
- I wonder why the king needs these apes and peacocks?

Continue the drama.

King Solomon was greater than all the kings of the earth in riches and in wisdom. All the kings on the earth came to see Solomon and to hear the wisdom that God had put in Solomon's heart. Year after year, everyone who visited Solomon brought a gift—items that people made of silver and gold, clothing, weapons, spices, horses, and mules.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Solomon, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am glad that my wisdom can help so many people; or
- I am thankful that Yahweh gave me the gift of wisdom; or
- I am amazed by all the gifts the people are bringing to me.

Ask the people playing the kings who came to hear Solomon's wisdom, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel honored that the great King Solomon is willing to see me; or
- I hope that King Solomon can tell me what to do about the problems in my country; or
- It was definitely worth the trip and the cost to come see such a wise king!

Continue the drama.

Solomon had 4,000 stalls for horses and chariots, and 12,000 horsemen. Solomon kept them in the chariot cities and also with Solomon in Jerusalem. Solomon ruled over all the kings from the Euphrates River to the land of the Philistines, as far as the border of Egypt. The king made silver as common as stones in Jerusalem, and the king made cedar as common as sycamore trees in the foothills. Solomon imported his horses from Egypt and many other countries.

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Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Solomon, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel proud that our army has grown so large; or
- I hope that these chariots and horsemen will keep our nation safe for many years to come; or
- I want Israel to be the most powerful nation on earth.

Ask the people playing Solomon's horsemen and charioteers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Finally, our country has an army as powerful as Egypt; or
- I feel proud to serve in such a strong army; or
- I am grateful to King Solomon for providing such good chariots and horses for our army.

Continue the drama.

The rest of the events in Solomon's reign, from beginning to end, are recorded in The Book of Nathan the Prophet, and the book of prophecy of Ahijah from Shiloh, and also in The Visions of Iddo the Seer, concerning Jeroboam son of Nebat. Solomon reigned in Jerusalem over all Israel for 40 years. Then Solomon rested with his fathers, and people buried Solomon in Jerusalem, the City of David his father. Then Solomon's son Rehoboam became the next king.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Solomon, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am grateful to Yahweh for giving me such a long life as king; or
- I hope my son Rehoboam will be a good king of Israel; or
- I hope that I did enough to make Israel strong and secure for a long time.

Ask the person playing Rehoboam, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel sad that my father has died; or
- I am happy to become king of Israel; or
- I am worried about taking care of such a large territory and so many people.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 9:13–31 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

The book of 1 Kings contains a similar story to this story.

If you want to go back and listen to that story in your language, then stop here and listen to the second half of 1 Kings chapter 10, after the Queen of Sheba's visit to Solomon. Pause this audio here.

Every year, **King** Solomon received 666 **talents**, or around 23,000 kilograms of gold. This was in addition to the taxes from the merchants and traders. And all the kings of Arabia and the governors of the country brought gold and silver to Solomon. Be sure to translate king the same way you have in previous passages. If you use the word for "talent" instead of the metric weight, use the same word for talent as you have used previously. See the Master Glossary for more information on king and talent.

Stop here. If your language does not have a name for the place called "**Arabia**," you may translate this name to sound like the original name. Also, decide how you will translate "**governor**" into your language. A governor managed part of the country for the king. Pause this audio here.

King Solomon made 200 large shields and covered each one with about 600 **shekels**, or seven kilograms, of hammered gold. And Solomon made 300 small shields, and overlaid each one with about three kilograms of hammered gold. If you use the word for shekel instead of metric weight, use the same word for shekel that you have used previously. See the Master Glossary for more information about shekel.

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Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a **shield**. Decide how you will translate "shield" into your language. Pause this audio here.

The king placed these shields in the **House of the Forest of Lebanon**. Be sure to translate "House of the Forest of Lebanon" the same way you did in previous books of the Bible.

Stop here if necessary and listen to the beginning of 1 Kings chapter 7, if it is available in your language. If 1 Kings is not available in your language, then decide how you will translate "The House of the Forest of Lebanon." Pause this audio here.

Then the king made a large **throne** decorated with ivory and overlaid with the finest gold. Be sure to translate throne the same way you did in previous passages.

Stop here and decide how you will translate "**ivory**" into your language. Pause this audio here.

The throne had six steps and a footstool covered with gold in front of the throne. There were armrests at either side of the seat, and a lion stood next to each armrest. Twelve lions stood on the steps, one at each end of each step. No one had ever made anything like this throne for any other **kingdom**. Be sure to translate kingdom the same way you did in previous passages. See the Master Glossary for more information about kingdom.

Stop here. If your language does not have a word for **lion**, decide how you will describe a lion for your hearers. Pause this audio here.

The king had a fleet of trading **ships** at sea with the ships of King Hiram. Once every three years, the ships came back bringing gold, silver, ivory, apes, and peacocks. Use the same word for ships that you have used in previous stories in 2 Chronicles.

Stop here and decide how you will translate "**apes**" and "**peacocks**" into your language. You may also use the words "baboons" and "monkeys." Pause this audio here.

King Solomon was greater than all the kings of the earth in riches and in **wisdom**. All the kings on the earth came to see Solomon and to hear the wisdom that **God** had put in Solomon's **heart**. Year after year, everyone who visited Solomon brought a gift—items made of silver and gold, clothing, weapons, spices, horses, and mules. Be sure to use the same words for wisdom, heart, and God as you did in previous passages. See the Master Glossary for more information on wisdom, heart, and God.

Stop here and decide what word you will use for "**mule**." If necessary, look again at a picture of a mule. Pause this audio here.

Solomon had 4,000 stalls for horses and **chariots**, and 12,000 horsemen. Solomon kept them in the chariot cities and also with Solomon in Jerusalem. Solomon ruled over all the kings from the **Euphrates River** to the land of the **Philistines**, as far as the border of Egypt. Be sure to use the same words for chariots, "Euphrates River," and Philistines that you have in previous books of the Bible.

If necessary, stop here and listen again to Genesis chapter 2 to remember how you translated the name "Euphrates River." Pay close attention to the middle of the chapters when the author names the four rivers. The Euphrates is the fourth river. Pause this audio here.

If you need to remember how you translated "Philistines," then stop here and listen to Genesis chapter 26 if it is available in your language. At the beginning of the story, Isaac goes to Gerar, to Abimelech, king of the Philistines. Pause this audio here.

People recorded the rest of the events in Solomon's reign, from beginning to end, in the book, or word, of Nathan the **prophet**, and the book of prophecy of Ahijah from Shiloh, and also in The Visions of Iddo the Seer, concerning Jeroboam, the son of Nebat. Be sure to translate "prophet" the same way as you did in previous books of the Bible. Remember that most people wrote histories like this down on scrolls, which were long pieces of animal skin or paper that people rolled around two long sticks on either end.

If necessary, stop here and listen to the beginning of 1 Chronicles 17 to remember how you translated the word "prophet." Prophet is in the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

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"Prophecy" is another word for a message or revelation from God. There are different kinds of prophecies in the Bible. One of the most common kinds of prophecies was messages that told the people to stop disobeying God. But a prophecy could also describe something that was going to happen in the future, give people instructions about how to do things in a way that pleased God, or give the people encouragement.

Stop here and decide how you will translate the word "**prophecy**." See the Master Glossary for more information on prophecy. Pause this audio here.

The word "**seer**" is another word for prophet. This word is based on the word "to see." This word means that the person can see things that other people cannot see, such as visions from Yahweh or messages from Yahweh.

If necessary, stop here and listen to the beginning of 1 Samuel 9 to remember how you translated "seer" in that book. Look in the Master Glossary under the word "prophet" for more information on "seer." Pause this audio here.

A **vision** is a kind of prophecy, or message, from Yahweh. When a prophet has a vision, the prophet sees something that other people cannot see. If necessary, stop here and listen again to the beginning of Genesis chapter 15, where Abram has a vision. See the Master Glossary for more information on vision.

If you have already translated 1 Kings, be sure to translate the names **Ahijah**, **Shiloh**, **Jeroboam**, and **Nebat** the same way you did there.

Stop here and listen again to the first half of 1 Kings chapter 11 to hear how you previously translated those names. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: What will you call these histories? If you use the word for **scroll** or book in the titles, refer to scroll in the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

Then Solomon's son **Rehoboam** became the next king. If you have already translated 1 Kings, then you have already translated the name Rehoboam.

Stop here, if necessary, and listen to the beginning of 1 Kings chapter 12 to remember how you translated this name. If 1 Kings chapter 12 is not available in your language, then decide how you will translate the name Rehoboam.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

2 Chronicles 9:13–31

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (633 KB)
- Setting the Stage (4.0 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (8.2 MB)
- Embodying the Text (4.8 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (4.6 MB)
- Speaking the Word (803 KB)

2 Chronicles 10:1–7

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 10:1–7 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 10:1–7 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 10:1–7 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous story, King Solomon died, and Solomon's son, Rehoboam, became the new king. Solomon's temple was in Jerusalem, Israel's capital city, and Rehoboam also lived in Jerusalem. Now, the northern tribes of Israel gather in Shechem in the north of Israel to recognize Rehoboam as their new king. Jeroboam leads the northern tribes as they ask Rehoboam to give them less work and make their lives easier. In this story, Rehoboam asks his older advisers how Rehoboam should answer the people of Israel. This story is the first part in a two-part story.

This story is the start of a new section in the book of 2 Chronicles and a new part of the history of the people of Israel as they lived with a divided kingdom. This story is very similar to the story in 1 Kings 12:1–15. The storyteller knows that most people who listen to this story in 2 Chronicles already have heard the similar story in 1 Kings. If you have already translated the similar story in 1 Kings 12:1–15, you should translate this story the same way as the story in 1 Kings in most places, except for the places where there are some small differences in the story.

Stop here and listen to your translations of the passages in 1 Kings 12:1–15 now, if your team has already translated these similar passages in 1 Kings. Pause this audio here.

As the story begins, Rehoboam goes to Shechem, which is an important religious city in the north of Israel in the land of the tribe of Ephraim. Shechem was the first religious center of the 12 tribes of Israel when the Israelites first came into the land of Canaan. The northern tribes of Israel had already gathered in Shechem to renew their loyalty to David's grandson, Rehoboam, as their new king. However, some people think that because the northern tribes did not travel to Jerusalem to make Rehoboam king, this shows that these tribes already planned to leave Rehoboam and make their own kingdom.

Stop here as a group and look at a map that includes Shechem. Pause this audio here.

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Also, stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about a time when your community, village, city, or nation chose a new leader. How did your community choose this leader? What did you like or dislike about the new leader? Pause this audio here.

Jeroboam, the son of Nebat, is another important person in this story. We know from some similar stories in 1 Kings that Jeroboam was from the tribe of Ephraim and that Jeroboam was a servant of King Solomon in the past. King Solomon tried to kill Jeroboam, so Jeroboam ran away to live in Egypt. Now, in this story, Jeroboam hears the news that King Solomon has died and that Solomon's son, Rehoboam, is the new king in Israel. The storyteller gives background information that Jeroboam was living in exile in Egypt while King Solomon was still alive.

Stop here as a group and look at a map that includes Egypt. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller says that Jeroboam returns from Egypt when Jeroboam hears the news about the death of Solomon and the new king. Remember that in the similar story in 1 Kings, it was not clear if Jeroboam immediately returned from Egypt at this point in the story, or if the storyteller said that Jeroboam had been living in Egypt in exile for a while. But either way, the storyteller now says that the northern tribes send for Jeroboam to come help them. We are not sure if Jeroboam is still in Egypt or already in Israel when the tribes ask Jeroboam to come help them.

In the next part of the story, Jeroboam and the northern tribes of Israel ask Rehoboam to lighten their heavy load of work. The people say that Rehoboam's father, Solomon, put a heavy yoke on them, and the people want Rehoboam to make their yoke, or burden, lighter. A yoke is a wooden bar that joins together the necks of two cows or oxen so that the two animals can work together. King Solomon forced the people to build Solomon's temple, his palace, and other buildings. It is likely that the people also had to pay heavy taxes to Solomon.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a yoke. Pause this audio here.

Jeroboam and the people tell Rehoboam they will be loyal to Rehoboam if Rehoboam makes their lives easier. The people do not ask Rehoboam to take away their burdens completely, but to make the people's burdens less than their burdens were during the rule of Rehoboam's father, Solomon. It was common during Rehoboam's time for a new king to do what the people requested in exchange for their loyalty to him as their new king.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Think about your previous discussion about a time when your community chose a new leader. Describe how your new leader was different from your previous leader. What did the new leader do or say to make the people like the leader? Pause this audio here.

Rehoboam tells Jeroboam and the people to leave for three days, probably so that Rehoboam can think about how to answer the people's request to lighten their heavy load of work. Rehoboam does not pray to Yahweh or talk to a prophet about what Rehoboam should do. Instead, Rehoboam talks with two different groups of advisors during these three days. First, Rehoboam consults the elders, or older advisers, who served his father, King Solomon. These older, experienced advisers tell Rehoboam to be a servant to the people today, so that in the future, the people will always be Rehoboam's servants. In this story, the advisors want Rehoboam to act like a servant to his people and speak kindly to the people in order to keep the loyalty of the northern tribes. Some people think the older advisers want Rehoboam to be kind to the people now, and then later, Rehoboam will be free to be harsh to the people.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 10:1–7 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four scenes.

In the first scene: The northern tribes of Israel prepare to make Rehoboam their new king in the city of Shechem.

In the second scene: The northern tribes of Israel send for Jeroboam to come back from his exile in Egypt. Jeroboam comes back to Israel.

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In the third scene: Jeroboam and the people ask Rehoboam to take away some of their hard work. Rehoboam says to come back to Rehoboam in three days.

In the fourth scene: Rehoboam asks the older advisers for advice. The older advisers tell Rehoboam to answer the people with kind words.

The characters in this passage are:

- Rehoboam
- The northern tribes of Israel
- Jeroboam, the son of Nebat
- Older advisers who served King Solomon in the past
- And Yahweh

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

Remember that before this story, King Solomon died, and now King Solomon's son, Rehoboam, is the new king of Israel. This story is the start of a new section in the book of 2 Chronicles. In this story, and in the following stories, we will see that because of King Rehoboam's choices, Israel divides into a northern kingdom and a southern kingdom. Remember, this story is very similar to two stories in 1 Kings 12:1–15, and it is often best to translate the story in the same way that you translated the two stories in 1 Kings. Remember, this is the first part in a two-part story.

In the first scene, the northern tribes of Israel gather in Shechem, a city in the north of Israel. Shechem is 65 kilometers north of Jerusalem, between Mount Ebal and Mount Gerizim. Shechem is in the land of the tribes of Ephraim and Manasseh. Rehoboam also goes to Shechem because the northern tribes want to recognize Rehoboam as their new king.

Stop here as a group and look at a map that includes Shechem again, if needed. Pause this audio here.

Also, stop here and discuss this question as a group: What is the most natural order to translate this scene of the story? It is probably best to translate this in the same way that you did in the 1 Kings story. Some translation examples include:

- All Israel gathered in Shechem to make Rehoboam their king, so then Rehoboam went to Shechem too; or
- Rehoboam went to Shechem because all Israel had gathered in Shechem to make Rehoboam their king.

Pause this audio here.

In the second scene, Jeroboam hears the news that King Solomon died and that Rehoboam is the new king of Israel. Remember that the storyteller gives background information that Jeroboam was living in exile in Egypt because King Solomon tried to kill Jeroboam while King Solomon was still alive.

Stop here as a group and look at a map that includes Egypt again, if needed. Pause this audio here.

Also, stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story that includes some background information about one of the characters. Pay attention to how you introduce the background information about the character. How will you translate this background information about Jeroboam? It might be better to say first that Jeroboam fled to Egypt, and then later Jeroboam heard the news. It is probably best to translate this in the same way that you did in the 1 Kings story. Pause this audio here.

Jeroboam returns from Egypt to Israel. Remember that it may be that some people go to Egypt to get Jeroboam, or that Jeroboam has already come back to Israel before this story happens. Most translations do not say that Jeroboam comes back to Israel, but we know from the next scene that Jeroboam is in Shechem now. In any case, the Israelites have asked Jeroboam to come with them to talk to King Rehoboam.

In the third scene, Jeroboam and the people of Israel talk to King Rehoboam. Jeroboam and the people remind Rehoboam that Solomon, Rehoboam's father, gave the people a heavy yoke of work. Remember that people put a yoke on two animals to help the animals work together.

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During the time of Rehoboam, people used a yoke as special language for heavy burdens of work. Remember also that the people do not have a physical yoke on their necks. Solomon gave the people a lot of work, and Solomon made the people pay a lot of taxes to Solomon.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a yoke again, if needed. Pause this audio here.

Also, stop here and discuss as a group: Talk about hard work in your culture. How will you translate this part of the story about the heavy yoke of work that King Solomon put on the people of Israel? It is probably best to translate this in the same way that you did in the 1 Kings 12:1–15 story. Pause this audio here.

Now the people want Rehoboam to lessen their harsh labor and the heavy yoke of work. Some people think that harsh labor and heavy yoke are two ways to say the same thing about the hard work that Solomon forced the people to do. Other people think the heavy yoke means the heavy taxes that the king made the people pay, in addition to the harsh labor as well. The people say that if Rehoboam lessens their work, the people will serve Rehoboam as their king. The people want Rehoboam to be a different kind of king than Solomon was.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate harsh labor and heavy yoke in this story? Also, how will you show the contrast between the hard work that Solomon made the people do in the past and the lighter load of work that the people want Rehoboam to give to them now? It is probably best to translate this in the same way that you did in the 1 Kings story. A few translation examples are:

- Now, if you lighten the demands your father made and do not make us work as hard, we will serve you; or
- Lighten the harsh labor demands and the heavy taxes that your father imposed on us. Then we will be your loyal subjects; or
- But if you make our work easier, we will serve you and do whatever you ask.

Pause this audio here.

Rehoboam tells Jeroboam and the people to leave for three days. Remember that Rehoboam probably wants three days to think about how to answer the people's request. The people agree and leave for three days. It may be more natural to translate this part of the scene with the exact words that Rehoboam said to the people, or with a description of what Rehoboam said to the people.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story that includes some parts where the characters talk to each other. Do you say the exact words that the characters say to each other, or do you tell a description of what they said? What is the best way to translate this part of the story where Rehoboam tells the people to come back in three days? It is probably best to translate this in the same way that you did in the 1 Kings story. Some translation examples include:

- Rehoboam told the people, "Go away for three days and then come back"; or
- Rehoboam told the people to come back in three days to hear Rehoboam's answer.

Pause this audio here.

In the fourth scene of this story and the first scene of the following story, Rehoboam asks two different groups for advice about how to answer the people's request. You could also translate this as "consulted" different groups of people.

In the fourth scene, Rehoboam talks with the older advisers who were alive during Solomon's time. Other ways to translate older advisers could be "elders" or "older men who advised Solomon." In the original language, it says these advisers stood before Solomon, which means these advisers gave Solomon advice about what to do. Rehoboam asks the older advisers, "How do you advise me to answer these people?" Again, it may be better to translate this as a description of what Rehoboam said: "Rehoboam asks the older advisers how they thought Rehoboam should respond to the people."

The older advisers tell Rehoboam that Rehoboam should serve the people and that Rehoboam should speak good words to the people. The older advisers want Rehoboam to be kind to the people and lessen the people's harsh load of work. The older advisers say that if Rehoboam is kind to the people, then the people will always serve Rehoboam.

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Stop here and discuss as a group: Think about a time when you or someone you know gave conditions to someone else in order to get the person to do something. For example, a father might tell his child that if his child helps with the father's work, the father will give the child a gift. What is the best way to translate this part of the story about the way that the older advisers tell Rehoboam that Rehoboam must act so that the people will always serve Rehoboam? Some translation choices include:

- If you are a servant for the people today, and if you give the people a good answer, then the people will always serve you; or
- Serve the people and give the people a good answer today. Then the people will always serve you.

Also, decide if you want to include the exact words that the older advisers told Rehoboam to say or if you want to say, "The older advisers told Rehoboam that he should help the people and give the people a good answer, and then the people will serve Rehoboam." It is probably best to translate this in the same way that you did in the 1 Kings story. Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the story and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 10:1–7 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Rehoboam
- The northern tribes of Israel
- Jeroboam, the son of Nebat
- Older advisers who served King Solomon in the past
- And Yahweh

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The people of Israel traveled to Shechem to make Rehoboam their king. So, Rehoboam went to Shechem too.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the people of Israel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We are not sure if we can trust Rehoboam as our new king. We need to talk with Rehoboam before we decide to make Rehoboam our king; or
- It is our duty to follow Rehoboam as our new king. Rehoboam's father, Solomon, was our king before, and now we must follow Solomon's son, Rehoboam; or
- We hope that Rehoboam will be kinder to us than his father, Solomon, was.

Continue the drama.

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In the past, King Solomon tried to kill Jeroboam, so Jeroboam fled to live in Egypt. Now Jeroboam hears the news that Rehoboam is the new king of Israel, and Jeroboam returns from Egypt to Israel. The people of Israel ask Jeroboam to come back to help Israel, so Jeroboam comes back to Israel.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Jeroboam, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am happy to finally come back to my home in Israel; or
- I was afraid that Solomon would kill me, but now it is safe for me to come home because I am not afraid of this new king, Rehoboam; or
- I wonder why the people of Israel want me to come help them now. Could this be part of the prophecy that the prophet Ahijah made about me?

Continue the drama.

Jeroboam and the people of Israel talk to King Rehoboam. The people say, "Your father, King Solomon, made us work very hard. But if you make our work easier, we will serve you and do whatever you ask." Rehoboam tells the people to come back in three days to hear Rehoboam's answer to the people's request. So, the people leave for three days.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the people of Israel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We think that our request is reasonable for King Rehoboam to lessen our heavy work. We are not asking Rehoboam to take away our work, but to lessen the work; or
- We hope that Rehoboam listens to our request because we cannot keep working this hard and paying this many taxes as we did for Rehoboam's father, King Solomon; or
- This is our chance to finally get the king to listen to us! We will be loyal to this new king if he gives us something in return; or
- We are hopeful that the king will think carefully about our request during these three days.

Also, ask the person playing Rehoboam, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Why are these people coming to talk to me like this? The people should make me king and then let me go back home to Jerusalem. The people should be grateful that I traveled here to Shechem to see the people; or
- I need to be careful how I answer the people because I want their loyalty and support. I know that the people worked very hard for my father, King Solomon, but I also enjoy the life that I have as king in Jerusalem, and I do not want the people to stop working or paying taxes to me; or
- I am not sure what to do yet, so I will take a few days to think about my answer and ask some advisers for advice about what to do.

Continue the drama.

King Rehoboam talks with the older advisers who served Rehoboam's father, King Solomon, when King Solomon was alive. Rehoboam asks the older advisers, "What answer do you think I should give to the people?" The older advisers tell Rehoboam, "If you are a servant for the people today, and if you give the people a good answer, then the people will always serve you."

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the older advisers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We think that Rehoboam should say anything he can to make the people happy, so the people will support Rehoboam as their new king. It does not matter if Rehoboam plans to keep his promises to the people or not. In the future, Rehoboam can be harsher with the people, but today, Rehoboam should speak kindly to the people; or
- We think it is important to carefully listen to the people and speak kindly to the people. Rehoboam needs the support of the northern tribes of Israel. Rehoboam should not do anything now that would make these people of Israel mad at Rehoboam. Otherwise, the people may not support Rehoboam as their new king; or

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- We are honored that the new king came to ask us for advice first. We have the most experience, and we know how to handle the requests of the different tribes of Israel.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 10:1–7 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Rehoboam became the new king of the Israelites in the previous passage. The Israelites are the descendants of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. David was the first king of Israel, and David's son, Solomon, was the second king of Israel. Rehoboam is Solomon's son. We know from a different passage in 1 Kings that Rehoboam was the son of an Ammonite woman whose name was Naamah.

In this passage, **Israel** and **Israelites** refer to the northern tribes of Israel. These northern tribes of Israel talk to King Rehoboam at Shechem in the north of Israel. Shechem later becomes the first capital of the northern kingdom of Israel. Translate Israel and Israelites the same as you have in previous passages. For more information on Israel and Israelites, refer to Israel and Israelites in the Master Glossary.

Jeroboam returns from his exile in **Egypt**. Egypt is the land where the Israelites lived in slavery for 400 years before Yahweh rescued the people during the time of Moses and Aaron. Jeroboam was in Egypt because, in the past, **King** Solomon tried to kill Jeroboam. A king is someone who rules over a city or territory. Translate Egypt and king the same as you have in previous passages. For more information on king, refer to the Master Glossary.

The people of Israel ask King Rehoboam to lighten their heavy yoke of work that King Solomon gave to the people. A yoke is a wooden collar with two openings that people use to tie two oxen or two other animals together. In the Bible, sometimes a yoke means slavery or hard work.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate **yoke** in this passage? Remember your discussion from step three about how to translate this part of the passage. Will you use the word yoke here, or translate it as heavy work, harsh demands, or something else? It is probably best to translate this in the same way that you did in the 1 Kings passage.

Pause this audio here.

King Rehoboam first asks the **elders**, or the older advisers, for advice on how to answer the people. Elders are people with authority in the community who are usually leaders of their families. These elders were advisers to King Solomon while Solomon was alive.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate **elders** in this passage? You may want to translate "elders" the same as in previous passages, but these elders may have a more specific job to advise the king. It is probably best to translate this in the same way that you did in the 1 Kings passage. For more information on elders, refer to the Master Glossary.

Pause this audio here.

The older advisers tell King Rehoboam that if Rehoboam is a **servant** to the people today, then the people will always be the king's servants in the future. A servant is someone who does work for their master. Translate servant the same as you have in previous passages. For more information on servant, refer to the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

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Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (861 KB)
- Setting the Stage (4.3 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (8.4 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.6 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.2 MB)
- Speaking the Word (928 KB)

2 Chronicles 10:8–19

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 10:8–19 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 10:8–19 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 10:8–19 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous story, Jeroboam and the northern tribes of Israel ask Rehoboam to give the people less work and make their lives easier. Rehoboam asks his older advisers how Rehoboam should answer the people of Israel. Now, Rehoboam asks his younger advisers for their advice, and Rehoboam decides to listen to the advice of his younger advisers instead of the advice of his older advisers. This is the second part of a two-part story.

This story is very similar to two passages in 1 Kings. The storyteller knows that most people who listen to these stories in 2 Chronicles already have heard the similar stories in 1 Kings 12:1–15 and 1 Kings 12:16–24. If you have

already translated the similar passages in 1 Kings, you should translate this passage in the same way as the passages in 1 Kings in most places, except for the places where there are some small differences in the passage.

Stop here and listen to your translation of the passages in 1 Kings 12:1–15 and 1 Kings 12:16–24 now, if your team has already translated these similar passages in 1 Kings. Pause this audio here.

Rehoboam does not listen to the advice of Rehoboam's older advisers, which is surprising because people in Israel respected the advice of older advisers. Instead, Rehoboam asks his younger advisers what they recommend Rehoboam should do. It is likely that Rehoboam already plans to follow the advice of the younger advisers before Rehoboam hears their answer. We know from a story in 1 Kings that Rehoboam was 41 years old when he became king, and these younger advisers are the same age as Rehoboam. These young men grew up with Rehoboam and do not have the same years of experience and wisdom as Rehoboam's older advisers.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Who do you talk to for advice in your community? Talk about a time when you asked a few different people for advice about the same situation. How was the advice different? How did you choose which advice to follow? Pause this audio here.

The younger advisers tell Rehoboam to be even harsher than Rehoboam's father, King Solomon. The younger advisers want Rehoboam to show the people that Rehoboam is very strong and show that Rehoboam's easiest demands will be worse than the hardest work Solomon made the people do. The younger advisers use a proverb, or wise saying, that Rehoboam's little finger is thicker than his father Solomon's loins, or waist. Some people think the little finger is a polite way to refer to the male sexual organ.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell some proverbs, or wise sayings, in your language. Practice explaining what each proverb means. Pause this audio here.

The younger advisers also say that Rehoboam should make the yoke even heavier for the people. The men say Solomon punished, or disciplined, the people with whips, which means Solomon was harsh on the people. A whip has a long handle, which people often made of wood, and a flexible cord that a person used to hit another person.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a whip. Pause this audio here.

The advisers say that Rehoboam should punish the people with whips that sting like scorpions.

A scorpion is an insect in Israel that has a poisonous sting. This could mean that Rehoboam should punish the people more than Solomon did. Or it could mean that Rehoboam will punish the people with whips that have pieces of sharp metal in them, which will cut into a person's body like the point of a scorpion's sting. If the tribes of Israel do not listen to King Rehoboam, then King Rehoboam will painfully punish the people.

Stop here and look at a picture of a scorpion and a picture of a whip with metal in the cord. Pause this audio here.

Jeroboam and the people come back to Rehoboam after three days, and King Rehoboam chooses to follow the advice of the younger advisers. King Rehoboam speaks harshly, or unkindly, to the people, and Rehoboam rejects the advice of the older advisers. This also shows that King Rehoboam rejects the wisdom of his father, King Solomon, whom people knew was very wise. If Rehoboam had listened to his people, Israel would have had an opportunity to remain one unified nation, but because King Rehoboam did not listen to his people, the nation of Israel later divided into two parts. Rehoboam adds to people's oppression. This is similar to what Pharaoh, the king of Egypt, did when Pharaoh made the Israelites work harder instead of making their burdens lighter.

Next, the storyteller tells us that the events in this story are really from Yahweh. The reason Yahweh allowed these things to happen was that these things fulfilled the promise that Yahweh made through Ahijah the prophet in a story in 1 Kings. The prophet Ahijah was from Shiloh, and Ahijah had told Jeroboam that Yahweh would give Jeroboam 10 of the tribes of Israel. In the prophecy, Ahijah said this was a punishment on Solomon because Solomon stopped following Yahweh and Solomon followed the gods of the other nations around Solomon. We see that Rehoboam acted foolishly when Rehoboam listened to bad advice, but the final reason that the kingdom of Israel split is that Yahweh made it happen. Yahweh is in control of everything.

The northern tribes of Israel realize that Rehoboam will not listen to their request to lessen their heavy load of work. The people tell King Rehoboam that the people have no place in the kingdom of David now. In the original translation, the people ask King Rehoboam, "What part do we have in David, and what part do we have in the

son of Jesse?" The people do not want an answer to their question. The people know that David was Rehoboam's grandfather, the son of Jesse, and a descendant of the tribe of Judah. David and David's family have nothing to do with the people in the north of Israel.

The people from the northern tribes of Israel also say that they should all go home to their tents. A tent is a temporary home where people live. Tents are another way to talk about home. The people want the descendants of David to take care of themselves and their own people. The northern tribes no longer feel like they are a part of the people of Israel.

Stop here and look at a picture of a tent. Pause this audio here.

The northern Israelites go home. However, King Rehoboam still rules over the Israelites, who were originally from the northern tribes but who now live in the cities and towns of Judah in the south of Israel. We know that Rehoboam also rules over all the other people in Judah as well.

Stop here and look at a map that shows the kingdoms of Israel and Judah. Pause this audio here.

Rehoboam sends out Adoniram, the man who was in charge of forcing the people to build buildings for the kings of Israel. Rehoboam probably sends Adoniram because Rehoboam wants the people of Israel to know that Rehoboam will be harsh with the people and increase their heavy yoke of work. But the Israelites do not listen to Adoniram, and the people kill Adoniram by throwing stones at him. The people probably do this to show Rehoboam that the people do not respect Rehoboam as their king, and the people will not do any more building projects for Rehoboam.

As the story ends, Rehoboam quickly gets in his chariot and flees to Jerusalem, the capital of Israel. This means that Rehoboam was in the northern part of Israel before this, maybe to go with Adoniram. A chariot is a two-wheeled cart that horses pull in battle, but sometimes kings rode on chariots, too.

Stop here and look at a picture of a chariot and a map that includes Jerusalem. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller says that Israel, meaning the northern tribes of Israel, has been rebelling against the family of David since the time when Rehoboam refused to listen to the people. The northern tribes of Israel refused to let a descendant of David be their king. The storyteller told these stories long after the stories happened, so the people of Israel had been rebelling for a long time.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 10:8–19 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has six scenes.

In the first scene: Rehoboam rejects the advice of the older advisers. Instead, Rehoboam asks his younger advisers for advice. The younger advisers tell Rehoboam to be harsh to the people.

In the second scene: Jeroboam and the people come back to Rehoboam after three days. Rehoboam speaks harshly to the people. Rehoboam says he will be even harsher than his father, Solomon, was to the people.

In the third scene: King Rehoboam does not listen to the people. Yahweh causes this to happen in order to fulfill the promise that Yahweh made to Jeroboam through the prophet Ahijah.

In the fourth scene: The people say that they have no place in the Kingdom of David now. The people go home to their tents. However, Rehoboam still rules over the people from the northern tribes of Israel who now live in the land of the tribe of Judah.

In the fifth scene: Rehoboam sends Adoniram, the man in charge of forcing the people to build buildings. The people kill Adoniram with stones. Rehoboam escapes and flees in his chariot to Jerusalem.

In the sixth scene: The northern tribes of Israel have been rebelling against the family of David ever since these stories happened.

The characters in this passage are:

- Rehoboam
- The northern tribes of Israel
- Jeroboam, the son of Nebat
- Older advisers who served King Solomon in the past
- Younger advisers who are Rehoboam's age
- Yahweh
- The prophet Ahijah, the Shilonite
- And Adoniram

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

Remember that in the previous story, Jeroboam and the northern tribes of Israel asked Rehoboam to give the people less work. Rehoboam asked his older advisers for advice, and now, Rehoboam asks his younger advisers for their advice. Rehoboam decides to listen to the advice of his younger advisers instead of the advice of Rehoboam's older advisers. This is the second part in a two-part story.

In the first scene, Rehoboam rejects the advice of the older advisers. Instead, Rehoboam asks the younger advisers what to do. In the original language, the storyteller calls these younger advisers "young boys" or "children" because these advisers are inexperienced. But these younger advisers are actually grown men like Rehoboam. It may be more natural in your language if you include the information about what the people asked Rehoboam to do before Rehoboam asks the younger advisers for advice.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you show the contrast between the advice of the older advisers and what Rehoboam decides to do? It is probably best to translate this in the same way that you did in the 1 Kings story. Pause this audio here.

The younger advisers repeat what the people said to Rehoboam. Again, you can include the exact words that the people said to Rehoboam, or a description of the words. It might be good to do the same thing here that you did earlier when Rehoboam asked the younger advisers for advice. It is probably also best to translate this in the same way that you did in the 1 Kings story.

The younger advisers tell Rehoboam a proverb, or wise saying, to show that Rehoboam should act even harsher than Rehoboam's father, Solomon. The younger advisers say that Rehoboam's little finger is thicker than his father Solomon's "loins," or waist. Remember that the proverb means that the easiest work that Rehoboam requires will be worse than the hardest things that Solomon required. Remember that some people think that "little finger" means the male sexual organ.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate this proverb? It might be best to translate the meaning of the proverb, as in: "I will be much harsher than my father was!" It is probably best to translate this in the same way that you did in the 1 Kings story.

Pause this audio here.

The younger advisers give two different examples of how Rehoboam will be harsher than his father, Solomon. The advisers say that Solomon gave a heavy yoke of work to the people. Rehoboam should make the yoke even heavier for the people. The men also say that Solomon punished the people with ordinary whips, but Rehoboam should punish the people with whips that sting like scorpions. Remember, this probably means that Rehoboam will punish the people even more than Solomon did. In each example, the younger advisers emphasize the difference between how Solomon acted in the past and how the younger advisers think Rehoboam should act now.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate this part of the story to show the contrast between the work that Solomon gave to the people and the work that Rehoboam will give to the people? It is probably best to translate this in the same way that you did in the 1 Kings story. Pause this audio here.

In the second scene, Jeroboam and the people come back to Rehoboam after three days. Remember that this is when Rehoboam told Jeroboam and the people to come back. Rehoboam speaks harshly to the people. Rehoboam rejects the advice of the older advisers and instead, Rehoboam follows the advice of the younger advisers.

Rehoboam does not repeat the proverb again, but Rehoboam does repeat the two examples that the younger advisers gave to him about how Rehoboam will make life even harder for the people.

In the third scene, the storyteller gives more information about the ultimate reason for all of the events in this story. This comment from the storyteller is not a part of the main action of the story. Yahweh caused these things to happen, meaning Yahweh is the one controlling everything, including the unhappiness of the people of Israel and Rehoboam's choice not to listen to the people. Remember that we know from 1 Kings that Yahweh spoke through the prophet Ahijah to Jeroboam. Ahijah told Jeroboam that Yahweh would give 10 of the tribes of Israel to Jeroboam.

Now, in this story, we see that Yahweh will fulfill the promise to Jeroboam because Rehoboam did not listen to the people of Israel. Remember that we will learn in later stories about how the tribes of Israel split into two kingdoms, with Rehoboam leading the southern kingdom and Jeroboam leading the northern kingdom.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story that includes a statement about why the event in the story happened. How will you translate the end of this story to show how Yahweh accomplished Yahweh's word, or Yahweh's will? It is probably best to translate this in the same way that you did in the 1 Kings story. Pause this audio here.

In the fourth scene, the northern tribes of Israel tell Rehoboam that they have no place in the kingdom of David. The people ask, "What part do we have in David, and what part do we have in the son of Jesse?" Remember that the people do not want an answer to this question, but the people want to show Rehoboam that they feel there is no place for them now in the Kingdom of David.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Would it be best to translate this as a question or as a statement? Another way to translate this part of the story is: "We have nothing to do with King David, and we have nothing to do with this grandson of Jesse." Again, it is probably best to translate this in the same way that you did in the 1 Kings story. Pause this audio here.

The people of Israel also say they should go back to their own homes. Then, the people go home. Remember that the northern tribes of Israel do not accept a descendant of David as their king, but Rehoboam does rule over some of the people in the northern tribes who live in the land of the tribe of Judah in the south of Israel.

In the fifth scene, Rehoboam sends Adoniram to the people. Remember that Adoniram was in charge of forcing people to build buildings for Israel. The people of Israel kill Adoniram by throwing stones at Adoniram. Rehoboam escapes and quickly runs away in his chariot to Jerusalem.

Finally, in the last scene, the storyteller says that the northern tribes of Israel have been in rebellion against the house, or family, of David from that time until now. Remember that this shows that the events in this story are very important for the rest of the story of the divided kingdom of Israel.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the story and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 10:8–19 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has six scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Rehoboam
- The northern tribes of Israel
- Jeroboam, the son of Nebat
- Older advisers who served King Solomon in the past
- Younger advisers who are Rehoboam's age
- Yahweh
- The prophet Ahijah, the Shilonite

- And Adoniram

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

But Rehoboam rejects the advice of the older advisers. Instead, Rehoboam asks the younger advisers what to do. These younger advisers also served Rehoboam, and they were the same age as Rehoboam. Rehoboam asks the younger advisers, "What should I answer the people who asked me to give them less work than my father gave them?"

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Rehoboam, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I do not want the people to think I am weak. If I follow the advice of the older advisers, people will say I am weaker than my father, King Solomon; or
- I prefer to see what the advisers of my own age think about this situation. I trust the people my own age more than the older advisers that my father had; or
- The people of Israel seem to complain a lot. I do not think that my father made the people work very hard; or
- I hope that my younger advisers give me better advice than the older advisers gave me. I think I will decide to follow the advice of the younger advisers, even before I know what their advice is.

Continue the drama.

The younger advisers tell Rehoboam that Rehoboam should reject the request of the people. The people complained that Rehoboam's father, Solomon, made them work very hard. The people wanted Rehoboam to give the people less work. The younger advisers say that Rehoboam should be even harsher than Solomon was. The younger advisers say that Rehoboam should tell the people, "My little finger is thicker than my father's waist!" The younger advisers also think Rehoboam should make the people's work even harder. Solomon punished the people with ordinary whips, but Rehoboam should punish the people with whips that sting like scorpions!

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the younger advisers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- Rehoboam should listen to our advice because Rehoboam knows us, and we know Rehoboam. We have the best ideas for how Rehoboam can be a strong king of Israel; or
- We think it would be a bad idea to follow the advice of the older advisers. Those old men do not know the new way of doing things. Rehoboam will show them what a real king looks like, one who is even tougher than King Solomon was; or
- These people of Israel need to know that they cannot come and talk to King Rehoboam like this. The people should respect the new king and not ask the king for things. Rehoboam will be even stronger and harsher than Rehoboam's father was!

Continue the drama.

Jeroboam and the people come back to Rehoboam on the third day. This is just as King Rehoboam told the people to do. Rehoboam talks harshly to the people. Rehoboam rejects the advice of the older advisers and instead follows the advice of the younger advisers. Rehoboam tells the people, "My father made you work hard, but I will make you work even harder! My father punished you with ordinary whips, but I will punish you with whips that sting like scorpions!"

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Rehoboam, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I like the advice of my younger advisers better than the advice of my older advisers. I am the king, so I can decide what I want to do; or
- I am ready to be an even harsher and more demanding king than my father was! or
- These people need to respect me. These people should never have asked me to lessen their heavy load of work because now they will need to work even harder.

Also, ask the people playing the people of Israel, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The people might answer things like:

- We are very disappointed that Rehoboam did not listen to us; or
- We are shocked that Rehoboam plans to be even harsher than his father was; or
- We do not plan to serve Rehoboam as our king now. We gave Rehoboam a chance to be kind to us in return for our loyalty. Rehoboam did not take the chance, and now we know that we are not welcome in the kingdom of Rehoboam. We must start to make other plans with Jeroboam as our leader.

Continue the drama.

Rehoboam refused to listen to the people of Israel. Yahweh caused this to happen in order to fulfill the promise that Ahijah the Shilonite spoke to Jeroboam, the son of Nebat.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the people of Israel who are listening to this story, generations after it happened, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The people might answer things like:

- We wish that Rehoboam had chosen to listen to the people of Israel. Maybe then there would never have been a divided kingdom of Israel; or
- We trust that Yahweh’s ways are always good, even though we do not understand why Yahweh makes things happen; or
- We remember the promise that Ahijah the Shilonite made to Jeroboam in a previous story, and now we see that Yahweh keeps his promises that Yahweh makes.

Continue the drama.

The people of Israel realize that King Rehoboam has refused to listen to their requests to lessen their heavy load of work. The people say, “King David was not from one of our families, and the family of Jesse has nothing to do with us. Let us all go home. The family of David can take care of his own people.” So, the people of Israel went to their homes. Rehoboam still rules over the northern tribes of Israel, who live in the cities of the tribe of Judah in the south of Israel.

Ask the people playing the people of Israel, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The people might answer things like:

- Rehoboam will be sorry that he did not listen to us; or
- We will never let a man from the family of David rule as our king. We have nothing in common with the people of Israel from the south, from David’s family; or
- We wonder who our new king will be? We do not want Rehoboam as our king, but we do not know who might be our king; or
- Those of us who live in the south, in the land of the tribe of Judah, are not happy that Rehoboam is ruling over us. But we do not have a choice because we are so close to Jerusalem.

Continue the drama.

King Rehoboam sends out Adoniram, the man who was in charge of forced labor. The people of Israel killed Adoniram with stones. Rehoboam hurried to get on his chariot, and Rehoboam fled to Jerusalem. Israel has been rebelling against the family of David since the time of this passage.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Rehoboam, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I will show the people of Israel that they must listen to me, and the people must do my building projects for me! or
- I am shocked that the people of Israel killed Adoniram! How will I complete my building projects now? or
- I want nothing to do with the people of the northern tribes of Israel. I had to escape quickly so that the people would not try to kill me as well! or
- I am afraid that the people of the northern tribes of Israel will kill me!

Also, ask the people playing the people of Israel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We tried to ask Rehoboam for lighter work, but Rehoboam refused. Now we are ready to fight back against Rehoboam; or
- Rehoboam will never be our king; or
- Adoniram deserved to die because Adoniram forced us to do many work projects to build things for Solomon and Rehoboam; or
- We wish that we had been able to catch Rehoboam before he ran away to Jerusalem.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 10:8–19 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

The people of the northern tribes of Israel ask Rehoboam to lighten their heavy **yoke** of work.

Remember that a yoke is a wooden collar with two openings that people use to tie two oxen or two other animals together. In the Bible, sometimes a yoke means slavery or hard work.

It is probably best to translate this in the same way that you did in the previous 2 Chronicles passage and in the 1 Kings passage.

Rehoboam rejects the advice of the older advisors, or **elders**. Translate elders in the same way you have previously, and refer to elder in the Master Glossary for more information about elder.

Rehoboam also asks the young men with whom he grew up for advice. Other ways to translate this could be younger advisers, young advisers, or younger officials.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate **young men** in this passage? Pause this audio here.

Jeroboam and the people of the northern tribes of Israel return to **King** Rehoboam after three days. A king is someone who rules over a city or territory. Translate king the same as you have in previous passages. For more information on king, refer to the Master Glossary.

The events in this passage were from **Yahweh**. Yahweh is God's personal name. Translate Yahweh the same as you have in previous passages. For more information on Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary.

Yahweh caused these events to happen in order to fulfill the **word** that Yahweh spoke to Jeroboam through Ahijah the Shilonite. The word that Yahweh spoke to Jeroboam was a promise from Yahweh. Translate "word" the same as you have in previous passages. For more information on word, refer to the Master Glossary.

The people of Israel say that they have nothing to do with **David**, the son of Jesse. In this passage, **Israel** and **Israelites** refer to the northern tribes of Israel. David was the first king of Israel. Translate Israel, Israelites, and David the same as you have in previous passages. For more information on Israel and Israelites, refer to the Master Glossary.

Rehoboam rules over the people from the northern tribes of Israel who now live in the cities of **Judah**. A **city** is a settlement of people with a wall around it. Judah is one of the tribes of Israel, but people often used the name "Judah" to talk about the two tribes in the south that still followed Rehoboam as their king. Translate city and Judah the same as you have in previous passages. Refer to Judah in the Master Glossary for more information.

Rehoboam escaped in his **chariot** to **Jerusalem**. A chariot is a two-wheeled cart that horses pull. Jerusalem is the capital city of Israel. Translate chariot and Jerusalem the same as you have in previous passages.

Israel rebelled or revolted against the house, or family, of David from that time until now. The "house of David" means the descendants of David, the first king of Israel.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate "**house of David**" in this passage? For more information on "house of David," refer to the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

2 Chronicles 10:8–19

Audio Content

- Setting the Stage (6.3 MB)
- Embodying the Text (6.4 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.3 MB)
- Speaking the Word (966 KB)

2 Chronicles 11:1–12

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 11:1–12 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 11:1–12 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.

2 Chronicles 11:1–12

5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 11:1–12 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous story, Rehoboam refused to listen to the people's request to make their work easier. Instead, Rehoboam followed the advice of his younger advisers when Rehoboam made the work harder for the people. The story ended when King Rehoboam escaped on his chariot to Jerusalem, and the tribes of Israel divided into two kingdoms, one in the north and one in the south. Now, Rehoboam arrives in Jerusalem, and Rehoboam prepares for war against the northern tribes of Israel. However, Rehoboam does not go to war because the man of God, Shemaiah, receives a message from Yahweh that all the people of Israel in Judah and Benjamin should not fight against the other Israelites. Rehoboam also builds up many cities in the land of Judah and in the land of Benjamin.

This first part of this story is very similar to another story in 1 Kings. You should translate the first part of this story in the same way as you did in 1 Kings 12:16–24, except in some places where there are some small differences.

Stop here and listen to your translation of 1 Kings 12:16–24 now, if your team has already translated this similar passage. Pause this audio here.

Rehoboam arrives in Jerusalem, which is the capital city of Israel and now the capital of Rehoboam's kingdom of the tribes of Judah and Benjamin in the south of Israel. Remember that Rehoboam ran away in his chariot to Jerusalem in the previous story.

Stop here as a group and look at a map that includes Jerusalem. Pause this audio here.

Rehoboam is ready for a war against the rebellious northern tribes of Israel who refuse to recognize Rehoboam as their king. We know from 1 Kings 12:16–24 that the northern tribes of Israel chose Jeroboam as the new king of the northern tribes of Israel. Now, Rehoboam chooses 180,000 fighting men from the tribes of Judah and Benjamin to fight against the northern tribes of Israel. King Rehoboam wants to reunite the north and south of Israel into one kingdom, with Rehoboam as the king over all of the tribes of Israel.

But Shemaiah, the man of God, hears a word, or message, from Yahweh. Yahweh tells Shemaiah to give a message to Rehoboam and to all the Israelites in Judah and Benjamin. The message from Yahweh says that Rehoboam and the people of the southern kingdom of Judah should not fight against their brothers or relatives, the other Israelites. Instead, Yahweh tells the people to go home because Yahweh caused this thing to happen. You will remember that in an earlier story, the prophet Ahijah had said that Yahweh would take away 10 of the tribes of Israel from Rehoboam.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about a time when two people or groups of people wanted to fight each other, but someone else convinced the people or groups of people not to fight each other. How did the person convince the other people not to fight? Pause this audio here.

The people listen to the message that Shemaiah tells them. The people do not go to fight against Jeroboam, the leader of the northern tribes of Israel. We know from the similar story in 1 Kings 12:16–24 that the people all go back to their homes.

Rehoboam lives in Jerusalem, and Rehoboam builds up 15 cities on important roads around Jerusalem to protect the land of Judah and Benjamin. The cities were already there, but Rehoboam makes the cities stronger and more secure to protect against enemy attacks. Rehoboam does this by building walls around the towns. It probably took a few years to build up these cities.

Stop here as a group and discuss a time when your village, town, city, country, or community prepared for a fight or a battle against another group of people. What did your community do to prepare for the fight? Pause this audio here.

The cities of Bethlehem, Etam, Tekoa, and Beth Zur protected Jerusalem from enemies to the east and southeast of Judah. These cities were on a main road east of Jerusalem that went from the north to the south. Rehoboam

2 Chronicles 11:1–12

probably strengthens these cities to protect his land against attacks from the Moabites and the Ammonites in the east.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a map that includes the 15 cities that Rehoboam builds up. Find the cities of Bethlehem, Etam, Tekoa, Beth Zur, and Jerusalem. Also, find the land of the Moabites and the Ammonites. Pause this audio here.

It seems like Rehoboam is most worried that Egypt will attack because many of the cities protected Jerusalem from enemies coming from the southwest. Rehoboam also builds up the cities of Azekah, Soco, Adullam, Gath, Mareshah, and Lachish. These cities were in the south and west of the land of Judah, and they protected Judah from an Egyptian attack from the south or west, or maybe from a Philistine attack from the west.

Stop here and, as a group, look at the map that includes the 15 cities that Rehoboam builds up. Find the cities of Azekah, Soco, Adullam, Gath, Mareshah, Lachish, and Jerusalem. Also, find the land of the Egyptians and the Philistines. Pause this audio here.

Rehoboam also builds up the cities of Zorah and Aijalon on the northwest side of Judah, and the cities of Hebron, Adoraim, and Ziph in the south of Judah. Hebron, Adoraim, and Ziph probably protected Judah from an Egyptian attack.

Stop here and, as a group, look at the map that includes the 15 cities that Rehoboam builds up. Find the cities of Zorah, Aijalon, Hebron, Adoraim, Ziph, and Jerusalem. Pause this audio here.

Rehoboam makes these strongholds, or fortified cities, secure. Rehoboam puts commanders or captains in each of the cities, so that each city has military leaders in case of war. Rehoboam also puts supplies of food, olive oil, and wine in the cities. Wine is a fermented drink that people make from grapes. These supplies will allow people to stay inside the city for a long time if an enemy attacks.

Rehoboam also puts shields and spears in each fortified city. Shields are barriers that people can hold to protect themselves from an enemy attack. Spears are weapons with a blade at the end of a stick.

Stop here as a group and look at pictures of a shield and a spear. Pause this audio here.

Because Rehoboam has these fortified cities, Rehoboam controls the land of the tribes of Judah and Benjamin.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 11:1–12 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four scenes.

In the first scene: Rehoboam chooses 180,000 fighting men from the tribes of Judah and Benjamin. Rehoboam prepares for war against the northern tribes of Israel.

In the second scene: Yahweh sends a message to Shemaiah, the man of God, to tell Rehoboam and all the Israelites in Judah and Benjamin that they must not fight against the other Israelites. All of the people obey the message from Yahweh.

In the third scene: Rehoboam lives in Jerusalem. Rehoboam builds up 15 cities in the land of Judah and Benjamin.

In the fourth scene: Rehoboam put officers, food, and supplies in each of the cities that Rehoboam built up.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Rehoboam
- Tribe of Judah
- Tribe of Benjamin
- 180,000 fighting men from the tribes of Judah and Benjamin
- Shemaiah, the man of God

2 Chronicles 11:1–12

- Yahweh
- The relatives of the people of the kingdom of Judah—these relatives live in northern Israel
- Jeroboam
- And the commanders in the fortified cities

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

Remember that in the previous story, Rehoboam chose to make the work harder for the people, and the people rebelled against Rehoboam. The people killed Adoniram, the man in charge of Rehoboam's building projects, and Rehoboam ran away to Jerusalem. Remember that the first part of this story is very similar to 1 Kings 12:16–24, and it is best to translate this part of the story in a similar way to how you translated 1 Kings 12:16–24.

In the first scene, Rehoboam arrives in Jerusalem. Rehoboam gathers together all of the men of the tribes of Judah and Benjamin. In the original language, "gathers together" means that Rehoboam calls together the men to fight. Rehoboam chooses 180,000 fighting men. Other ways to translate "fighting men" could be "warriors," "men who are fit for war," "best soldiers," or "skilled soldiers."

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate "fighting men" in this story? Remember to translate it in the same way that you did in 1 Kings 12:16–24. Pause this audio here.

Rehoboam wants to fight against the northern tribes of Israel to take back the northern land for Rehoboam's own kingdom. Remember that the kingdom of Israel was united under one king with Rehoboam's father, King Solomon, but now there are two separate kingdoms. King Rehoboam is the king of Judah in the south, and we know from the similar passage in 1 Kings that King Jeroboam is the king of Israel in the north. Remember that now "Israel" means the northern tribes of Israel, and not the united kingdom of Israel.

The second scene begins with a strong contrast between King Rehoboam's plans to reunite the kingdom of Israel and Yahweh's plans to divide the kingdom of Israel. Yahweh sends a message to a prophet to tell King Rehoboam not to attack the northern kingdom. You will remember that "man of God" is another way to talk about a prophet.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you show the contrast between Rehoboam's plans and the message that Yahweh sent to the prophet, Shemaiah? It is probably best to translate this in the same way that you did in 1 Kings 12:16–24. Pause this audio here.

Shemaiah, the man of God, hears a word from Yahweh. In other words, Yahweh speaks to Shemaiah, the man of God. First, the storyteller says who Shemaiah should tell the message to. Yahweh tells Shemaiah to deliver this message to Rehoboam and to all the Israelites in Judah and Benjamin. In the similar passage in 1 Kings, Shemaiah tells this message to all the people of Judah and Benjamin instead of saying "all the Israelites in Judah and Benjamin." The people of Judah and Benjamin are the same people as the Israelites of Judah and Benjamin. In this passage, the storyteller emphasizes that Judah and Benjamin are the true Israelites of the kingdom of Israel, and the northern tribes of Israel are the rebellious people.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate this part of the story to show that the message is for all of the people of Israel in the southern kingdom, the land of the tribes of Judah and Benjamin? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller says the message that Shemaiah should say. Shemaiah says, "This is what Yahweh says to do. Do not go fight against your brothers, the Israelites. Go home, all of you, because I caused all of this to happen." You can translate brothers as relatives or "your own people."

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Would it be best to translate the message that Shemaiah says to Rehoboam and the people, or to tell the summary of what the message says? For example: "The message is that Yahweh says not to go fight against their brothers, the other Israelites. Yahweh also says for all the people to go home because Yahweh is the one who caused all of these things to happen." It is probably best to translate this in a similar way to how you translated the 1 Kings story. Pause this audio here.

In the last part of the second scene, the people of the southern tribes of Judah and Benjamin listen to the message from Yahweh that Shemaiah tells them. The people all obey Yahweh, and the people do not go to fight against Jeroboam and the northern tribes of Israel.

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Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What is the best way to show that the people listen to the word from Yahweh? One translation could be “the people obeyed Yahweh.” Pause this audio here.

Scenes three and four in this story are the first part in a three-part story about the beginning of Rehoboam’s rule as the king of Judah in Jerusalem. This three-part story is not in the similar passages in 1 Kings. The storyteller in 2 Chronicles focuses more on the southern kingdom of Judah than on the northern kingdom of Israel. In this passage, the storyteller describes how Rehoboam fortifies, or builds up, many cities in Judah and Benjamin to protect the kingdom of Judah.

In the third scene, Rehoboam lives in Jerusalem, which is in the land of Judah. You could say that Rehoboam rules in Jerusalem because Rehoboam is the king of Judah.

Rehoboam builds up the defenses for 15 cities around Jerusalem. Remember that Rehoboam wants to protect his kingdom from enemy attacks, probably mostly from an attack from Egypt. Rehoboam probably tells people to build strong walls around these cities to defend his kingdom. Rehoboam does not build the cities himself because Rehoboam is the king. Rehoboam tells other people to build up the cities. Remember that the cities of Bethlehem, Etam, Tekoa, and Beth Zur protected the east and southeast of the kingdom of Judah. Bethlehem is 8 kilometers south of Jerusalem, Etam is 11.5 kilometers south of Jerusalem, Tekoa is 16 kilometers south of Jerusalem, and Beth Zur is 8 kilometers north of Hebron.

Stop here as a group and, if needed, look again at a map that includes Bethlehem, Etam, Tekoa, Beth Zur, and Jerusalem. Pause this audio here.

Also, stop here and discuss as a group: Think about ways that you protect your cities and villages from attack from the enemy. In this case, Rehoboam asks the cities to build strong walls around them. How will you describe the way that the people build up or protect their cities from the enemy attacking them? Here are some translation ideas:

- Rehoboam turns the towns into strongholds to protect the land of Judah; or
- Rehoboam makes these cities more secure against attacks; or
- Rehoboam builds walls around these cities to protect Judah from their enemies.

Pause this audio here.

Rehoboam also builds up the cities to the south and west of Jerusalem. These cities are Azekah, Soco, Adullam, Gath, Mareshah, and Lachish. Azekah and Soco are cities 30 kilometers southwest of Jerusalem, and Adullam is 25 kilometers southwest of Jerusalem. Some people think that Gath is the same city as the Philistine city of Gath. Other people believe that Gath was a different city in Judah, also called Moresheth Gath. Mareshah is 40 kilometers southwest of Jerusalem. Lachish was an important city on the road to Egypt, about 45 kilometers from Jerusalem.

Stop here as a group and, if needed, look again at a map that includes Azekah, Soco, Adullam, Gath, Mareshah, Lachish, and Jerusalem. Pause this audio here.

Rehoboam also builds up the cities of Zorah and Aijalon in the north. Zorah is 20 kilometers west of Jerusalem, and Aijalon is 20 kilometers northwest of Jerusalem. The cities of Ziph, Adoraim, and Hebron protect the southern part of the kingdom of Judah. Hebron is 30 kilometers southwest of Jerusalem, Ziph is 7 kilometers southeast of Hebron, and Adoraim is 8 kilometers west of Hebron.

Stop here as a group and, if needed, look again at a map that includes Zorah, Aijalon, Hebron, Adoraim, Ziph, and Jerusalem. Pause this audio here.

In the final part of the third scene, the storyteller says that Rehoboam fortifies these cities in Judah and Benjamin. The storyteller gives a summary again of where Rehoboam builds up Rehoboam’s cities.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: W[hat is the most natural way for you to organize this information about where Rehoboam builds up these cities? Pause this audio here.]{.mark}

In the fourth scene, Rehoboam makes the strongholds secure. Most people agree that these strongholds are the same as the 15 cities that Rehoboam built in the third scene, and not different strongholds. A stronghold is a city with strong walls that defends the city against its enemies.

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Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What do you call cities like this in your language? Do you have a special name for these kinds of cities, or do you just say they are cities with protection around them? Pause this audio here.

Rehoboam does a few more things to prepare these cities to defend Judah against their enemies. Rehoboam puts captains, or army commanders, in each of the cities. Rehoboam also puts food, olive oil, and wine in the cities for the people to eat and drink. Finally, Rehoboam puts shields and spears in the cities for the men to use to defend themselves and fight against their enemies. These 15 cities are ready for an enemy attack because the cities have a commander to organize people to fight, supplies, weapons, and walls.

Stop here as a group and look again at pictures of a shield and a spear, if needed. Pause this audio here.

In the final part of the fourth scene, the storyteller says that Rehoboam controlled the areas of the tribes of Judah and Benjamin because of these fortified cities. We know from a previous passage that the other tribes of Israel rebelled against Rehoboam, David's grandson. Only the people in Judah and Benjamin were still loyal to Rehoboam.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What is the best way to say that the reason Rehoboam could control the land of the tribes of Judah and Benjamin was that Rehoboam had these 15 fortified cities? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 11:1–12 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Rehoboam
- Tribe of Judah
- Tribe of Benjamin
- 180,000 fighting men from the tribes of Judah and Benjamin
- Shemaiah, the man of God
- Yahweh
- The relatives of the people of the kingdom of Judah—these relatives live in northern Israel
- Jeroboam
- And the commanders in the fortified cities

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Rehoboam arrives in Jerusalem. Rehoboam gathers together all the men of Judah and Benjamin. Rehoboam chooses 180,000 fighting men to go to war with Rehoboam against the northern tribes of Israel. Rehoboam,

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Solomon's son, wants to restore the kingdom to himself so that Rehoboam will rule over all the tribes of Israel again.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the 180,000 fighting men, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We are ready to fight for the true king of Israel, King Rehoboam; or
- We are angry at the northern tribes of Israel because they are rebelling against King Rehoboam; or
- We are glad that we are loyal to King Rehoboam, the son of King Solomon, who was the son of King David. We hope that King Rehoboam wins the fight against the northern tribes of Israel.

Continue the drama.

Shemaiah, a man of God, hears a message from God. God says to Shemaiah, "Tell this to Rehoboam, the son of Solomon, the king of Judah. Say this also to the Israelites of Judah and Benjamin. This is what Yahweh says to do: 'Do not go fight against your brothers, the Israelites. Go home, all of you, because I caused all of this to happen.'" The people obey Yahweh's words, and the people do not attack Jeroboam.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing Rehoboam and all the Israelites of Judah and Benjamin, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We are surprised that Yahweh told us to go home and not to fight to restore the kingdom of Israel; or
- We are confused about why Yahweh wants us not to fight against Jeroboam, but we are ready to obey Yahweh's commands; or
- We do not understand why Yahweh said that Yahweh caused these things to happen.

Continue the drama.

Rehoboam lives in Jerusalem. Rehoboam builds up many cities in Judah to protect Judah from their enemies. These cities are Bethlehem, Etam, Tekoa, Beth Zur, Soco, Adullam, Gath, Mareshah, Ziph, Adoraim, Lachish, Azekah, Zorah, Aijalon, and Hebron. These are the cities that Rehoboam builds up in the land of Judah and Benjamin.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing all the Israelites of Judah and Benjamin, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We are glad that Rehoboam wants us to make these cities very strong to protect us from our enemies; or
- We are worried that our enemies from Egypt in the southwest will come to Judah and attack our kingdom; or
- We wonder why Rehoboam does not want more fortified cities on the northern border of Judah to protect us from an attack from Jeroboam and the northern tribes of Israel.

Continue the drama.

Rehoboam makes the cities strong, and Rehoboam also puts commanders in each city. Rehoboam puts supplies of food, olive oil, and wine in each city. Rehoboam puts shields and spears in all the cities, and Rehoboam makes the cities very strong. Rehoboam controls the land of Judah and Benjamin because Rehoboam fortifies these cities in the land of Judah.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Rehoboam, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am proud of how these 15 cities are ready to defend my kingdom of Judah; or
- My kingdom is prepared for an attack from any direction, but especially from Egypt in the southwest; or
- I want my fighting men to have the supplies, weapons, and defenses that they need to successfully defend our kingdom against any enemies; or
- I wish that I could control all of the tribes of Israel, but for now, I am glad to control the land of the tribes of Judah and Benjamin. I hope that in the future, Yahweh will help me restore all of the tribes of Israel to my kingdom.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 11:1–12 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

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In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Rehoboam arrives in **Jerusalem**. Jerusalem is the capital city of Israel, and now the capital city of the southern kingdom of Judah. Translate Jerusalem the same as you have in previous passages.

Rehoboam calls together the whole house, or family, of the tribes of **Judah** and **Benjamin**. Judah and Benjamin are two tribes of Israel. Often, people called the two tribes in the south that still followed Rehoboam as their king, "Judah." Translate Judah and Benjamin the same as you have in previous passages.

Stop here and discuss how you will talk about the whole **house**, or tribes, of Judah and Benjamin. Remember that a house can refer to an entire group of people who have something in common. Refer to **household** and Judah in the Master Glossary for more information about "house of Judah." Pause this audio here.

Rehoboam wants to fight against the people of **Israel** to restore Rehoboam's **kingdom**. In this passage, Israel refers to the northern tribes of Israel. A kingdom is the territory or the people that a king rules. Translate Israel and kingdom the same as you have in previous passages. For more information on Israel and kingdom, refer to the Master Glossary.

The man of God, Shemaiah, hears a word of **Yahweh** to give to Rehoboam and to all Israel in Judah and Benjamin. In the Old Testament, sometimes God spoke through his prophets, or people who received messages from God. In this passage, the storyteller calls the person who receives a message from God a "man of God." "A word of Yahweh" is similar to a "word of God." Yahweh is God's personal name. Israel in Judah and Benjamin means all the people who live in the southern kingdom of Israel, which is the people of the tribes of Judah and Benjamin. Translate Yahweh the same as you have in previous passages. For more information on Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate "man of God" and "word of Yahweh" in this passage? Check how you translated this in the 1 Kings passage. For more information on "word of Yahweh," refer to "**word**" in the Master Glossary. For more information on "man of God," refer to "**prophet**" in the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

Shemaiah tells Rehoboam not to fight against his fellow **Israelites**, or relatives. All the Israelites were descended from Jacob, the grandson of Abraham, so they were all members of the same very large family group! Translate Israelites in the same way as you have previously, and refer to Israelites in the Master Glossary for more information.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you talk about the Israelites as **relatives**, or brothers, of the people of Judah? Pause this audio here.

Rehoboam builds up 15 cities in the land of Judah. A **city** is a large settlement with a wall around it. One of the cities is **Bethlehem**, which is the birthplace of King David. Another city is **Hebron**, which is the city where David first became king. Translate "city" the same as you have in previous passages. Translate Bethlehem and Hebron the same as you have in other parts of the Old Testament.

Rehoboam puts **shields** and **spears** in each fortified city, or city that Rehoboam had built up. Shields are barriers that people can hold to protect themselves from an enemy attack. People can make shields from wood, metal, or both. Spears are weapons with a blade at the end of a stick. Translate shields and spears the same as you have in previous passages.

Stop here as a group and look at pictures of a shield and a spear again, if needed. Pause this audio here.

Rehoboam puts **commanders** and supplies of food, olive oil, and **wine** in each of the 15 fortified cities. Commanders are military leaders. Wine is fermented grape juice. Translate wine and commander the same as you have in other parts of the Old Testament. For more information on wine, refer to the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

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First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

2 Chronicles 12:1–16

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 12:1–16 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 12:1–16 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 12:1–16 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous stories, we heard how the people of Israel who wanted to obey Yahweh moved from the northern kingdom of Israel to the southern kingdom of Judah. This made King Rehoboam and Judah strong, because the people followed Yahweh. Now, in this story, we will hear what happened after Rehoboam became strong.

Stop here and listen: If you have already translated 1 Kings 14:21–31, which contains the same information as this story, listen to your translation of that passage as a group. Pause this audio here.

As the story begins, we hear that after Rehoboam became strong, Rehoboam and all the people of Judah stopped obeying Yahweh's law. So, in the fifth year that Rehoboam was king, Shishak, the king of Egypt, came and attacked Jerusalem.

People called the kings of Egypt "pharaohs." Most people believe that Shishak was the pharaoh from 931 B.C. to 910 B.C. or from 945 B.C. to 924 B.C.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How does a person become the most important leader in your culture? If that leader dies, how do people decide who will be the next leader? Pause this audio here.

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So Shishak and all of the soldiers with Shishak came to fight against the people in Jerusalem. You will remember that Jerusalem was not only where Rehoboam lived, but Jerusalem was also the city where King David had built the royal palace and where King Solomon had built the temple, the place where the Israelites worshiped Yahweh. The storyteller says that Shishak came with 1,200 chariots and 60,000 horsemen, or men to help drive the chariots and fight from the chariots. Shishak also brought a countless number of soldiers from Egypt, including Libyans, Sukkites, and Cushites or Nubians. These were all people who had come from other countries to live in Egypt. Libyans were people who came from the coast of North Africa, west of Egypt. We are not sure who the Sukkites were, but the Sukkites may have come from the desert west of Egypt. Some translations call the Cushites or Nubians "Ethiopians," but these people did not come from the land we call Ethiopia today. These people came from Cush or Nubia, which was the land south and east of Egypt. With all of these soldiers, Shishak fought against and took control of all of the strong, protected cities in Judah until Shishak came to Jerusalem, toward the northern end of Judah.

Stop here as a group and look at a map that shows Egypt, the lands west of Egypt where these people groups might have come from, and Israel to the north. Pause this audio here.

Stop here as a group and look at a map of Israel that shows the kingdom of Judah. Find the city of Jerusalem in Judah. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story about people who live in one place but who come from different places and cultures. Tell how these people live and work together, even though these people may look and act differently from one another. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller says that at this time, the prophet Shemaiah came to Rehoboam and the leaders of Judah in Jerusalem. Shemaiah told these men that Shemaiah had a message from Yahweh. This message was that because the people of Judah had turned away from Yahweh, Yahweh would now turn away from Judah, so that Shishak's army would beat Judah in battle. However, when the leaders of Judah heard this message, the leaders acted humbly and said that Yahweh was right to punish the leaders. So Yahweh spoke to Shemaiah again. This time, Yahweh said that because the leaders were sorry for the bad things they had done, Yahweh would keep the leaders alive. However, Yahweh would still allow King Shishak to defeat Judah and make the people serve Shishak. Yahweh wants the people of Judah to see how difficult it is to serve foreign kings. Then the people will understand that it is always better to serve Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story about a parent who instructs a child to keep the child safe. Tell how the child disobeys those instructions and does something dangerous. Then tell how the parent disciplines the child because the parent loves the child and wants the child to learn to be safe. Pause this audio here.

Because Yahweh promised to protect the leaders, we know that Shishak's army did not destroy Jerusalem. However, the storyteller says that when Shishak came to Jerusalem, Shishak took away all of the valuable things from Yahweh's temple and from the king's palace. Shishak even took away the gold shields that King Solomon had made. So King Rehoboam made bronze shields to replace the gold shields. Bronze is a less expensive metal than gold. Rehoboam gave these bronze shields to the officers of the royal guard who stood at the door of the king's house to protect the king. Every time King Rehoboam went to the house of Yahweh to worship, the guards came and carried those shields. And when the king left the temple, the guards took the shields back to the guardroom, a special place in the temple where the guards kept the ceremonial equipment that the guards used to serve the king.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what ceremonial items do you use when you do a job for a king or important leader? Pause this audio here.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a shield. Pause this audio here.

When Rehoboam acted humbly and admitted that Rehoboam had done wrong, Yahweh turned his anger away from Rehoboam so that Shishak did not completely destroy Judah. Instead, God caused good things to happen in Judah. And King Rehoboam became powerful as king once again in Jerusalem. The storyteller says that Rehoboam was 41 years old when Rehoboam first became king of Judah, and Rehoboam reigned in Jerusalem for a total of 17 years. The storyteller also reminds us that out of all the towns in Israel, Jerusalem was the town where Yahweh chose for people to come and worship Yahweh.

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Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, where do people go to worship God or the local spirits or gods? Who decides the correct place or places where people should worship? Pause this audio here.

Rehoboam's mother was Naamah, one of the many non-Israelite women Solomon married and had children with. Naamah was from the Ammonite people who lived northeast of the Dead Sea. And Rehoboam did many bad things because Rehoboam did not choose to fully serve Yahweh.

The story says that many things happened while Rehoboam was king of Judah, and the prophet Shemaiah wrote about these things in a book, or scroll. The storyteller also says that the prophet Iddo wrote about Rehoboam in Iddo's book of family histories. However, we know that these writings no longer exist, so we cannot read these writings to learn more about Rehoboam. The storyteller does remind us that Rehoboam was always at war with Jeroboam, the king of the northern kingdom of Israel.

Finally, Rehoboam died, and people buried Rehoboam's body near Rehoboam's ancestors in the old part of Jerusalem that people called the City of David. In ancient Israel, people usually buried a king's body in a tomb, which is a special cave or room that people carved into a large rock. Then Reboboam's son Abijah became the next king of Judah.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 12:1–16 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define this passage's scenes, characters, and setting. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has five scenes.

In the first scene: King Rehoboam stops obeying Yahweh, so King Shishak of Egypt comes to attack Judah with so many soldiers that no one can count them all. Shishak takes control of Judah's cities all the way to Jerusalem.

In the second scene: Shemaiah the prophet tells Rehoboam and the leaders of Judah that Yahweh has abandoned Judah because the people of Judah have abandoned Yahweh. However, when Rehoboam and the leaders hear this, they humble themselves and agree that Yahweh is right. And so Yahweh says Yahweh will not destroy Judah completely.

In the third scene: King Shishak attacks Jerusalem and steals the expensive things from the temple and the royal palace. But because Rehoboam humbles himself, Yahweh does not destroy Rehoboam and the leaders of Judah.

In the fourth scene: King Rehoboam grows strong as king in Jerusalem, and Rehoboam reigns as king for 17 years. But Rehoboam does evil things as king because Rehoboam does not choose to follow Yahweh fully.

In the fifth scene: Rehoboam dies, and Rehoboam's son Abijah becomes the next king of Judah.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Rehoboam
- Yahweh
- All of the people of Judah, the southern kingdom of Israel
- King Shishak of Egypt
- King Shishak's army
- Soldiers from the countries of Libya, Suk, and Ethiopia
- Shemaiah, Yahweh's prophet
- The leaders of Judah
- The guards at Rehoboam's palace
- Rehoboam's mother, Naamah, who was an Ammonite
- The prophet Iddo
- Rehoboam's ancestors
- And Abijah, Rehoboam's son

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As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first scene, the storyteller says that after Rehoboam had taken control of the kingdom and become a strong king, Rehoboam abandoned the law of Yahweh, and all of the people of Israel did too. Here, "all of Israel" means all of the people who lived in the southern kingdom of Judah. You will remember that the law was all of the commandments or instructions that Yahweh had given to the people of Israel through Moses.

So in the fifth year after Rehoboam became king, because the people had been unfaithful to Yahweh and stopped obeying Yahweh, King Shishak came up from Egypt to attack Jerusalem. You will remember that after Yahweh brought the Israelites out of slavery in Egypt, Yahweh told Moses that if the Israelites obeyed Yahweh, Yahweh would protect the people, but if the people stopped obeying Yahweh, Yahweh would allow the Israelites' enemies to defeat the Israelites. So here, Yahweh allows the Egyptians to attack the kingdom of Judah because the people have stopped obeying Yahweh.

King Shishak comes up from Egypt with 1,200 chariots and 60,000 horsemen. You will remember that a chariot was a special cart with two wheels that horses would pull. Two special soldiers, called horsemen, would ride in a chariot into battle. One soldier would drive the chariot while the other soldier would fight. Chariots made an army very strong and difficult to defeat.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a chariot. Pause this audio here.

Shishak also brought with him a very large number of other soldiers who lived in Egypt. The storyteller says that no one could count the number of soldiers Shishak brought because there were so many soldiers. The storyteller says these people included Libyans, Sukkites, and Cushites or Ethiopians. All of these people with Shishak captured the fortified cities of Judah, which probably means the larger cities or towns in Judah that people had built walls around to protect those cities. Finally, Shishak and his army came to Jerusalem, the city where Rehoboam lived.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you talk about a very large number of people? Pause this audio here.

Next, the storyteller says that the prophet Shemaiah came to Rehoboam and the leaders of Judah, who had all come to Jerusalem when Shishak attacked the other cities. You will remember that the storyteller told us about Shemaiah in a previous story, where Yahweh sent Shemaiah to give Rehoboam a message. In this story, Shemaiah gives another message from Yahweh. This time, Shemaiah says that Yahweh tells Rehoboam and the leaders of Judah that because they have abandoned Yahweh, Yahweh will now abandon them. This means that Yahweh will no longer protect the people from their enemies, just as Yahweh had warned the Israelites through Moses many generations ago.

But when the leaders of Judah heard this message that Shemaiah spoke from Yahweh, the leaders humbled themselves. This means that the leaders agreed that the leaders had done wrong and that the leaders were now sorry. The leaders also said Yahweh was right to punish the leaders because the leaders had done wrong.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a child who disobeys that child's parent. Tell how the parent tells the child that they must discipline the child. Finally, tell how the child admits they had done wrong and that the child deserves punishment. Pay attention to the words you use to describe how the child acts when the child says this. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller says that when Yahweh saw how the leaders humbled themselves, the word of Yahweh again came to Shemaiah. This means that Yahweh told Shemaiah another message to tell the leaders. Yahweh said that because the leaders humbled themselves, Yahweh would not let Shishak destroy the leaders, and Yahweh would not pour out Yahweh's wrath on Jerusalem. To pour out is special language that shows that when Yahweh feels angry, Yahweh usually does something to show that Yahweh is angry. Although Yahweh would not pour out Yahweh's anger, the leaders of Judah would have to serve Shishak. This way, the leaders would learn that it is better to serve Yahweh than to serve a foreign king.

So when Shishak, the king of Egypt, came up against or attacked Jerusalem, Shishak carried off the treasures from Yahweh's temple and from the royal palace. This means that Shishak's army took the most valuable things that the people of Judah owned. The storyteller says that Shishak even took the gold shields that Solomon

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had made. You will remember from 2 Chronicles 9 how King Solomon had made 200 shields from gold. The storyteller says that King Rehoboam made bronze shields to replace the gold shields. The storyteller does not say when Rehoboam did this, but this probably means that sometime after Shishak took the shields, Rehoboam had craftsmen make new shields from bronze. Then Rehoboam assigned these shields to the commanders of the guard on duty at the entrance to the royal palace. Whenever King Rehoboam went to Yahweh's temple, the guards went with Rehoboam and carried the shields. And afterward, the guards took the shields back to the guardroom, or the place where the guards stored the shields.

The storyteller says that because Rehoboam humbled himself, Yahweh's wrath turned from Rehoboam so that Rehoboam was not killed. This means that Yahweh held back Yahweh's anger and did not punish Rehoboam like Yahweh had planned. The storyteller also says there were good things in Judah during this time. This may mean that people had all that they needed and lived safely and comfortably. But it is even more likely that the storyteller means that even though people sinned in Judah during this time, many people were basically faithful to God. So King Rehoboam regained his power as king in Jerusalem.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a parent who felt very angry because of how a child disobeyed the parent. Tell how the parent decided not to discipline the child even though the child deserved discipline. Pay attention to the words you use to describe how the parent felt angry, but how the parent did not take any angry actions. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller says that Rehoboam was 41 years old when Rehoboam first became king, and Rehoboam reigned as king of Judah for 17 years in Jerusalem. The storyteller also reminds us that Yahweh himself chose Jerusalem out of all the tribes of Israel to put Yahweh's name there. You will remember that in that culture, a person's name represented that person's character or their self. This means that Yahweh chose Jerusalem as the place where the people of Israel would come to worship Yahweh and where Yahweh's presence would stay in the temple.

Rehoboam's mother's name was Naamah, and Naamah was an Ammonitess, a woman from the country of Ammon. The storyteller also reminds us that Rehoboam did evil and sinned. Rehoboam did not set his heart to seek Yahweh. This means that Rehoboam did not want to obey Yahweh, and that Rehoboam did not serve Yahweh or ask what Yahweh wanted Rehoboam to do.

The storyteller asks a question that he does not expect anyone to answer: "All of the acts of Rehoboam, or the things that Rehoboam did as king, are they not written in the records of Shemaiah the prophet and of Iddo the seer?" You will remember that a seer is like a prophet. These men wrote down the important things that Rehoboam did so that people would remember these things. These men probably wrote these things down on scrolls, or long pieces of animal skin or paper that people rolled around two long sticks. However, we know that these writings no longer exist today.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do people in your culture keep important stories or information about the past? How do you talk about the way people keep this information? Pause this audio here.

King Rehoboam and King Jeroboam were constantly at war with each other. Then Rehoboam rested with his fathers, or ancestors, and people buried Rehoboam in the City of David. "Rested" is a nice way to say that Rehoboam died. To bury a dead body means to put that person's body into a place in the ground where no one can see the body. In ancient Israel, people usually buried the body of a king in a tomb, which is a special cave or room that people carved into a large rock. The City of David was the older part of the city of Jerusalem that existed when David was king. And then Rehoboam's son Abijah became the next king after Rehoboam.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about how someone died and what people did with that person's body. Pay attention to the words you use to talk about these things. Then talk as a group about how you will translate this part of the story so people will understand. Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 12:1–16 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

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This passage has five scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Rehoboam
- Yahweh
- All of the people of Judah, the southern kingdom of Israel
- King Shishak of Egypt
- King Shishak's army
- Soldiers from the countries of Libya, Suk, and Ethiopia
- Shemaiah, Yahweh's prophet
- The leaders of Judah
- The guards at Rehoboam's palace
- Rehoboam's mother, Naamah, who was an Ammonite
- The prophet Iddo
- Rehoboam's ancestors
- And Abijah, Rehoboam's son

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

After Rehoboam had taken control of Judah and become a strong king, Rehoboam and all the people of the kingdom rejected Yahweh and stopped obeying Yahweh's commands. So because the people disobeyed, Shishak, the king of Egypt, came and attacked Jerusalem. This happened during the fifth year after Rehoboam became king. Shishak came from Egypt with 1,200 chariots, 60,000 horsemen, and a countless number of soldiers that included Libyans, Sukkites, and Cushites. And Shishak captured the fortified cities of Judah and came as far north as Jerusalem.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I told the Israelites long ago that if the people obeyed me, I would protect the people, but if the people did not obey me, I would allow their enemies to defeat them; or
- I love my people, the Israelites, and want them to obey me and worship only me, so it makes me angry when the Israelites worship idols; or
- If Rehoboam and the people are going to worship idols and do these evil things, I will do whatever it takes to stop them.

Continue the drama.

Then the prophet Shemaiah came to Rehoboam and the leaders of Judah, who had all gathered together in Jerusalem because they were afraid of Shishak. And Shemaiah said, "This is what Yahweh says, 'You have turned away from me. So now I will turn away from you, and I will let Shishak defeat you in battle.'" But when the leaders heard what Yahweh said, Rehoboam and the rest of the leaders humbled themselves and said, "What Yahweh does is fair." When Yahweh saw that the leaders humbled themselves, Yahweh gave another message to Shemaiah. Yahweh said, "Because the leaders have humbled themselves, I will not destroy them. Instead, I will rescue the leaders from their enemy. I will not let Shishak destroy Jerusalem because of my anger. But I will

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let Shishak defeat the leaders and make them serve Shishak. This way, the leaders will learn that it is better to serve Yahweh than to serve other kings."

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing Rehoboam and the other leaders of Judah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We should not have disobeyed Yahweh. Yahweh always protected our ancestors when they obeyed Yahweh, and we need Yahweh's protection now; or
- We feel so relieved that Yahweh decided he would not kill us! or
- I hope Shishak does not treat us too badly or take too much of our wealth and power away from us.

Continue the drama.

When King Shishak of Egypt and his army fought against Jerusalem and defeated them, Shishak took away all of the expensive things from Yahweh's temple and from Rehoboam's palace. Shishak even took all of the gold shields that Solomon had made. So Rehoboam made bronze shields to replace the gold shields. Rehoboam gave the shields to the officers of the guards who protected the door of the king's palace. Whenever the king went to Yahweh's temple, the guards went with the king and carried the shields. And afterward, the guards brought the shields back to the storage room.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Rehoboam, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am very grateful that Shishak did not kill me, but I feel sad and ashamed that I lost all those beautiful things my father, Solomon, made; or
- These bronze shields are not nearly as beautiful and impressive as the gold ones Solomon made, but hopefully, people will still be impressed when they see the large number of men I have to guard me.

Continue the drama.

Because Rehoboam humbled himself, Yahweh stopped being angry against Rehoboam. This is why Yahweh did not allow Shishak to destroy the kingdom of Judah. In fact, God caused some good things to happen in Judah. King Rehoboam made himself powerful in Jerusalem and continued to be king there. Rehoboam was 41 years old when he first became king, and Rehoboam reigned in Jerusalem for 17 years. Jerusalem was the town that Yahweh chose from all the clans in Israel to be the place where people would come to worship Yahweh. Rehoboam's mothers's name was Naamah, and Naamah was from the country of Ammon. Rehoboam did very bad things because Rehoboam did not choose to fully serve Yahweh. Shemaiah the prophet wrote about everything that Rehoboam did as king in Shemaiah's book, and Iddo the prophet also wrote these things in Iddo's book of family histories. The armies of Rehoboam, king of Judah, and Jeroboam, king of Israel, were always fighting.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Shemaiah the prophet, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I wrote the stories about King Rehoboam so people would not forget these things; or
- These stories will help our people remember how Yahweh has been faithful to Israel even when Israel was not faithful to Yahweh; or
- Rehoboam did many evil things, but I hope these stories will remind people to obey Yahweh.

Continue the drama.

Rehoboam died, just like his ancestors died. And the people buried Rehoboam's body in the part of Jerusalem that people call the City of David. And Rehoboam's son Abijah became the new king of Judah.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Rehoboam, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am grateful that I was able to be king for so many years; or

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- Shishak took a lot of wealth and power from me, but I am happy that Yahweh allowed me to live and that good things happened in Judah after that; or
- Although I was sorry when Yahweh said he would punish us, the truth is that I liked serving the idols and doing the things Yahweh said not to do.

Ask the person playing Abijah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- My father was king for a long time, and I hope I can be king for a long time too; or
- I know my father worshiped idols of the gods from other people groups, so I will worship those idols too; or
- My father always fought with King Jeroboam, so I will fight Jeroboam too.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 12:1–16 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

When Rehoboam's **kingdom** was established, Rehoboam and all of **Israel** abandoned Yahweh's **law**. A kingdom is the territory that a king rules. You will remember that at this time, Israel was divided into two kingdoms with two different kings. Although people called the southern kingdom "Judah" and the northern kingdom "Israel," all of the people were still part of the nation of Israel. But in this story, "Israel" specifically refers to the people living in the southern kingdom of Judah. The law means the set of instructions God gave the people of Israel. For more information about kingdom, Israel, and law, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same words or phrases for kingdom, Israel, and law as you used in previous passages.

Shishak came with 1,200 **chariots** and attacked Judah's "fortified," or strong, **cities**. These cities probably had walls around them for protection. Use the same words for chariots and for cities as you have used in previous passages.

When Shishak comes to attack Jerusalem, Shemaiah, the **prophet,** comes to Rehoboam and the princes of Judah to give a message, or "**word**," from **Yahweh**. A prophet is a person who gives messages from God to the people. A message, or word, might be an instruction from God about something that needs to be done, or it might tell about something that is going to happen in the future. But most of the time, these messages were warnings to the people to stop disobeying God. The name Yahweh is the personal name for God that showed the close relationship that God had with the people of Israel. When people hear this name of God, the people are reminded especially of the covenant, the special promise, that God had made with the Israelites at the time of Moses. Use the same words or phrases for prophet, word, and Yahweh as you used in previous passages. For more information on prophet, word, and Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary.

When they heard this message from Yahweh, King Rehoboam and the princes, or leaders, of Judah **humbled** themselves and said that Yahweh was righteous. To humble themselves means that the princes, or leaders, admitted they were wrong. Use the same word or phrase for humbled as you used in previous passages.

In this story, a prince means a person who rules or holds authority over other people, like a chief or main leader. A righteous person is someone who does what is right, fair, or just.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **princes** and **righteous**. Look up righteousness in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

When the leaders humble themselves, Yahweh says that Yahweh will not pour out Yahweh's wrath on Jerusalem **by the hand of** Shishak. The storytellers in the Bible often use the word hand as special language to mean a person's power or strength. Use the same word or phrase for "by the hand of" as you used in previous passages.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **pour out his wrath**. Look up wrath in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this phrase in another book of the Bible, use the same phrase that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

However, Yahweh says that Yahweh will make Rehoboam and the leaders of Judah to be Shishak's **servants** or **slaves** so that they will learn the difference between serving Yahweh and serving the kings of other **lands**. A

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servant is a person who does work for someone else. If a servant does not get paid for his work and does not have the freedom to leave his master when he wants, then people call the servant a slave. Here, the word lands means the territory or areas of land that other kings rule. Use the same words or phrases for servants or slaves, and lands, as you used in previous passages. Refer to servants in the Master Glossary for more information.

Shishak took treasures from the **temple** and the **palace**. Translate king's house, or "palace," and temple in the same way you have in previous passages. Temple is in the Master Glossary.

Shishak took the **shields** of **gold**, so Rehoboam made shields of **bronze** to replace those shields. A shield is something that soldiers use to protect themselves from an enemy's attack. People usually made shields with a wooden frame and covered that frame with animal hide or leather. Shields that people covered with metal were not common because, although this kind of shield provided better protection, it was also heavier and more difficult to carry. Gold is a very expensive metal that is yellow in color and does not tarnish. Bronze is also a yellow metal, but bronze is less expensive and does tarnish. Use the same words or phrases for shields, gold, and bronze as you used in previous passages.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a shield that is covered in metal, if needed. Pause this audio here.

Rehoboam did **evil** because Rehoboam did not set Rehoboam's **heart** to seek Yahweh. Evil is the opposite of good. A person who is evil willingly does bad things that hurt other people. When people stop obeying God, those people begin to do evil actions. In the Bible, people often use the heart as special language to mean the place where a person's thoughts, feelings, and decisions happen. Someone with a "wicked heart" thinks evil things and makes evil decisions. And someone with a "good heart" wants to do the right things and feels sad when they have sinned. Use the same word or phrase for "hearts" as you used in previous passages. For more information on heart, refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **evil**. Look up evil in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller says that Shemaiah the **prophet** and Iddo the **seer** wrote down all of the important things that happened during Rehoboam's time as king in Iddo's book of genealogies. A genealogy is a list of people who have the same ancestor. A seer is another word for a prophet. For more information on prophet, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same words or phrases for prophet and seer as you used in previous passages.

The storyteller calls these books the "words" of Shemaiah and of Iddo. Remember that these are probably **scrolls** that people wrote on. If you use the word for scrolls in your translation, refer to the Master Glossary for more information about scrolls.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **genealogies**. For more information, refer to genealogy in the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

At the end of the story, the storyteller says that Rehoboam **slept with his fathers** and they buried Rehoboam in the **City of David**. "Slept with his fathers" is special language that is a nice way to say that Rehoboam died and that people buried Rehoboam near the same place people had buried Rehoboam's "fathers," which here means ancestors. You will remember that people usually buried kings in a cave or room that people had carved out of rock, but this word for buried is a general word for how someone puts a dead body in a cave or a grave in the ground. You will remember that people called this part of Jerusalem the "City of David" because it was the part of the city that existed when David was king. Use the same words or phrases for "slept with his fathers" and "City of David" as you used in previous passages.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **buried**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

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First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

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Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 13:13–14:1 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 13:13–14:1 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 13:13–14:1 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous story, King Abijah of Judah and Abijah's army, and King Jeroboam of Israel and Jeroboam's army, came together in one place to fight a battle. But before the soldiers began to fight, King Abijah went up on a hill and spoke loudly so that King Jeroboam and everyone else could hear. King Abijah said that King Jeroboam had disobeyed Yahweh and made idols to worship instead of worshiping Yahweh. But the people of Judah continue to worship Yahweh. And so Yahweh is with Judah and will not let Jeroboam and the kingdom of Israel win this battle.

In this story, we will now learn what happens during the battle. First, the storyteller explains that while Abijah was still speaking, King Jeroboam set an ambush by secretly sending some of Jeroboam's soldiers to a place on the other side of Abijah's army, so those soldiers could attack the army of Judah by surprise from behind. So now Jeroboam had soldiers ready to fight both in front of Abijah's army and behind Abijah's army.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do people in your culture fight battles? What are some common war strategies or decisions that leaders make in a battle to surprise the enemy and help win the battle? Pause this audio here.

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This is a very dangerous situation for the soldiers of Judah. When soldiers fight an enemy, it is very important to see the enemy so the soldiers can block an attack and know how and when to fight back. But when a soldier is watching and fighting an enemy in front, that soldier cannot see what is happening behind the soldier or block an attack from behind. So when an enemy attacks from both in front and behind like this, that enemy can easily kill the soldiers.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when soldiers made a decision in a battle to surprise their enemy. Pause this audio here.

When the army of Judah turns around and sees the soldiers Jeroboam has sent to attack them from behind, the soldiers of Judah realize they are in great danger. So the army of Judah cries out or shouts for Yahweh to help Judah. And the priests, who help the Israelites worship and obey Yahweh, blow their trumpets. You will remember from the book of Numbers that Yahweh had told the priests to blow their trumpets whenever the Israelites needed Yahweh's help in battle. Then the men of Judah shout very loudly. Soldiers often did this when they would attack an enemy to show the soldiers' strength and to make the enemy afraid. And when the men of Judah shouted, God defeated Jeroboam and all Israel. In the Bible, God often uses things like sickness, wild animals, or floods to punish people, but here God gives the army of Judah the power to punish Israel.

The soldiers of Israel ran away from the soldiers of Judah, and God caused the soldiers of Judah to win the battle. Abijah's soldiers killed 500,000 well-trained soldiers of Israel. These were all of Israel's best soldiers. That day, the people of Israel lost the battle, and the people of Judah won, because they trusted Yahweh, the God their ancestors worshiped.

Abijah and his soldiers went after Jeroboam's soldiers and captured some of Jeroboam's cities. Abijah and his soldiers took control of Bethel and its surrounding villages, Jeshanah and its surrounding villages, and Ephron and its surrounding villages. All of these cities and their villages were in the territory of the tribe of Benjamin. Bethel was about 16 kilometers north of Jerusalem, Jeshanah was about 25 kilometers north of Jerusalem, and Ephron was about 6.5 kilometers northeast of Bethel and 21 kilometers northeast of Jerusalem.

Stop here as a group and look at a map of Israel. Find the cities of Bethel, Jeshanah, and Ephron in the territory of Benjamin. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller explains that after this battle, Jeroboam never became powerful again during Abijah's reign. Finally, Yahweh punished Jeroboam so that Jeroboam became sick and died. But Abijah became more and more powerful. In those days, one way that a king showed he was powerful was to have many wives and children. Abijah married 14 wives and had 22 sons and 16 daughters.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a person who had a very large family with many children. What did people think about that person because the person had a large family? Pause this audio here.

King Abijah did many other things while Abijah was king of Judah. And the prophet Iddo wrote down the things that Abijah did and said in Iddo's book. Unfortunately, Iddo's book no longer exists today, so no one knows what that book said about Abijah.

Finally, Abijah died, and people buried Abijah just like people had buried Abijah's ancestors. The people buried Abijah in the part of Jerusalem that people called the City of David. Abijah's son Asa became the next king of Judah. And during Asa's reign, the country was at peace or without any war for 10 years.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 13:13–14:1 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: King Jeroboam of Israel secretly sends men to the other side of the army of Judah so that the army of Israel can fight Judah from both sides at the same time. But when Judah's army sees that they will have to fight the battle on both sides, Judah's army cries to Yahweh for help, and Yahweh helps the army.

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In the second scene: Abijah's army defeats the army of Israel, and the Israelite soldiers run away. But Abijah's army runs after the Israelite army and kills 500,000 soldiers. Abijah's army is able to do this because the people rely on Yahweh. Abijah also takes cities and villages from Jeroboam.

In the third scene: We learn that Jeroboam never got his power back after Jeroboam lost this battle to Abijah. Yahweh caused Jeroboam to die, but Abijah grew very powerful. And Abijah had many wives and children. Then Abijah died, Abijah's son Asa became king, and the people lived in peace for 10 years.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Jeroboam
- The army of Israel
- King Abijah
- The army of Judah
- God, whose name is Yahweh
- The priests
- The people of the cities of Bethel, Jeshanah, and Ephron and their villages
- King Abijah's wives and children
- King Abijah's fathers, or ancestors
- King David
- And Asa, Abijah's son

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first scene, Jeroboam sets an ambush. This means that Jeroboam secretly sends some of Jeroboam's soldiers around to the back side of Judah's army so that Jeroboam's soldiers can fight Judah's army from both the front and the back.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you talk about a surprise attack from behind, like Jeroboam uses to fight the army of Judah in this story? If needed, remember the discussion you had as a group in step two. How will you talk about this part of the story in your translation? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller makes it clear that when the army of Judah looks around, Judah's soldiers are surprised that Israel's soldiers have secretly come behind them. So the army of Judah cries out to Yahweh. This means that the soldiers pray loudly or shout for Yahweh to save them. Also, the priests blow the trumpets. Trumpets are instruments that people use to make a very loud musical sound. Craftsmen made the priests' trumpets from metal, and this kind of trumpet was long and straight. A priest would put the end of a trumpet against his lips and blow short blasts of air into the trumpet to make a loud noise.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a trumpet. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss how you will show in your translation that the army of Judah is surprised by the soldiers of Israel behind them. Pause this audio here.

Then the men of Judah raise the battle shout. This means that the men all shout together at one time to make a very loud noise. And when the men shout, God defeats or strikes Jeroboam and all the Israelites in front of Abijah and the soldiers of Judah. The Israelite soldiers run away from the soldiers of Judah, and God gives the Israelite soldiers into the "hand" of the army of Judah. In this special language, a person's hand represents power. So the storyteller is saying that God caused the soldiers of Judah to win the battle by giving the soldiers power to defeat Israel.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about how God gave someone power to defeat someone else. How do you talk about the way God gives that person power over someone or some other group? Pause this audio here.

Abijah and his soldiers strike the army of Israel with great force. This means that Judah's soldiers fight Israel's army with their weapons and kill many of Israel's soldiers. Abijah's army kills half a million, or 500,000, of Israel's best soldiers. All of these soldiers of Israel fall dead, which means that the soldiers of Judah wound these soldiers so badly in battle that the soldiers fall down on the ground and die. Thus, the men of Judah defeat the men of Israel. Israel's army no longer has the power to fight Judah's army and win. And Judah's army wins the battle,

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because the people of Judah rely on Yahweh, the God of their fathers. This does not mean that God is the God of the people of Judah's actual fathers, but of their ancestors or forefathers.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you talk about your forefathers or the important ancestors who came long before you? How will you talk about this in your translation? Pause this audio here.

Then King Abijah's army chases King Jeroboam's army and captures three of Israel's cities and the villages around those cities. Those cities are Bethel, Jeshanah, and Ephron.

Now the storyteller explains what happens after the battle. The storyteller says that Jeroboam did not recover Jeroboam's power in the days of Abijah. This means that King Jeroboam was not able to grow Jeroboam's army big and powerful again during the time that Abijah was king of Judah. And Yahweh struck Jeroboam down, and Jeroboam died. This probably means that after some time had passed, Yahweh caused Jeroboam to become sick, so that Jeroboam died.

But, in contrast to Jeroboam, Abijah grew mighty. This means that Abijah continued to get more military and political power. The storyteller also says that Abijah married 14 wives and had 22 sons and 16 daughters.

Now, the storyteller says that Iddo the prophet wrote down all the important information about what Abijah did as king and the important things Abijah said in Iddo's book. You will remember that in this time, a book was different from the books we use today. Usually, a book was a scroll, a type of ancient book where people wrote everything on one very long piece of paper or animal skin and then rolled that paper or animal skin around a stick. You will remember that the storyteller mentioned Iddo's book earlier in 2 Chronicles. Unfortunately, Iddo's book no longer exists.

Finally, the storyteller says that Abijah slept with his fathers, and they buried Abijah in the City of David. "Slept with his fathers" is special language that is a nice way to say that Abijah died, and that people buried Abijah's body near the bodies of Abijah's ancestors in the old part of Jerusalem that people called the City of David. You will remember that in those days, people usually buried a king's body in a tomb, which is a special cave or room that people carved into a large rock. Then Asa, Abijah's son, reigned in Abijah's place. This means that Asa became the next king of Judah. And in Asa's days, or the time Asa was king, the land had rest for 10 years, which means people experienced peace and did not have war.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story about a time when no war, famine, or other bad things happened in your community. Pay attention to the words you use to describe that time. How will you describe the time of peace that people experienced in this story when Asa was king? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 13:13–14:1 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Jeroboam
- The army of Israel
- King Abijah
- The army of Judah
- God, whose name is Yahweh
- The priests
- The people of the cities of Bethel, Jeshanah, and Ephron and their villages
- King Abijah's wives and children
- King Abijah's fathers, or ancestors
- King David
- And Asa, Abijah's son

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As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

In the first scene, we learn that during the last story, while King Abijah was speaking to Jeroboam and the army of Israel, Jeroboam secretly sent some of Jeroboam's soldiers to attack Judah's army from behind. So, as this story begins, Israel's army was now ready to attack Judah's army both from the front and from the back. Then the army of Judah looked behind them, and the army saw that they would have to fight Israel both from in front and from behind. So the soldiers of Judah shouted to Yahweh for help. And the priests blew the trumpets, and the men of Judah shouted a war shout. And when the men shouted, God made King Abijah and the soldiers of Judah defeat King Jeroboam and all Jeroboam's soldiers.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Jeroboam, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Abijah said I cannot defeat Abijah's army, but I have been smarter than Abijah! or
- There is no way Judah can win if we attack Judah's army from both sides.

Ask the person playing King Abijah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Jeroboam's army should be able to defeat our army from behind, but I know Yahweh will help us win this battle.

Ask the people playing the soldiers of Judah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- This is a dangerous situation, but we trust Abijah that Yahweh will not let Jeroboam defeat us; or
- We will fight bravely and trust that Yahweh will help us win!

Continue the drama.

In the second scene, Israel's army ran away from Judah's soldiers, and God caused Judah's soldiers to win the battle. King Abijah's soldiers killed many of King Jeroboam's soldiers. Five hundred thousand of Jeroboam's best soldiers fell down and died. That day, the people of Israel lost the battle, and the people of Judah defeated Israel. Judah was able to win because Judah depended on Yahweh, the God of their fathers.

Then King Abijah and Abijah's soldiers ran after King Jeroboam and Jeroboam's soldiers. King Abijah captured three cities—Bethel, Jeshanah, and Ephron—and the villages around those cities.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Jeroboam, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel confused and afraid. I thought I could easily beat Abijah by attacking Abijah's army from behind. But instead, Abijah's army is destroying my army!

Ask the person playing King Abijah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I knew Yahweh would help us win!

Ask the people playing the soldiers of Judah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We could not win this battle on our own. We only won because Yahweh helped us.

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Continue the drama.

King Jeroboam never became powerful again during Abijah's reign as king of Judah. Then Yahweh caused Jeroboam to become sick, so that Jeroboam died. But Abijah became very strong. Abijah married 14 wives and had 22 sons and 16 daughters. The other events that took place while Abijah ruled as king of Judah, including what Abijah said and did, are in the book that the prophet Iddo wrote. And Abijah died, and people buried Abijah with his ancestors. And Abijah's son Asa became the next king of Judah. And the country was at peace for 10 years while Asa was king.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel angry that Jeroboam worships idols instead of me. But I also feel angry that Jeroboam thought he could defeat Abijah, who worships me; or
- I gave Jeroboam many opportunities to turn away from worshiping idols and to worship and obey me instead. But Jeroboam would not listen; or
- Because Jeroboam would not obey, I not only punished Jeroboam by allowing Abijah to defeat Jeroboam, but I also put Jeroboam to death.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 13:13–14:1 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

As the story begins, the storyteller says that Jeroboam set an ambush. To ambush means to attack by surprise from a hidden place. So this means that Jeroboam secretly sent some of Israel's soldiers to a place where the army of Judah would not expect Israel to attack.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **ambush**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

When the army of Judah saw the soldiers behind them, the army cried out to **Yahweh** for help, and the **priests blew the trumpets**. You will remember that the priests were people who worked in the temple of God in Jerusalem. God had appointed priests to be between God and the people. Priests made it possible for people to come before God and to have a good relationship with God. In the book of Numbers, we hear how Yahweh gave instructions that when the people went to battle, the priests must blow the trumpets so that Yahweh would save the people from their enemies. Use the same word or phrase for Yahweh, priests and for "blew the trumpets" as you used in previous passages. For more information on Yahweh and priests, see the Master Glossary.

When the army of **Judah** ran after the army of Israel, **God** gave Israel **into their hand**, and Judah **struck them with great force**. In the Bible, the phrase "into their hand" means to give someone power or control over someone else, and to strike with great force means to attack with great physical strength. Use the same words or phrases for Judah, God, and "into their hand" as you used in previous passages. See the Master Glossary for more information about Judah and God.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for "**struck them with great force**." If you have already translated this phrase in another book of the Bible, use a similar phrase here. Pause this audio here.

When Abijah's men attacked Israel, the soldiers of Israel fell dead. This means that these soldiers of Israel were wounded so badly in the battle that the soldiers fell down on the ground and died.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **fell dead**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

All of these soldiers of Israel who died were **chosen men**. This means that the leaders of Jeroboam's army chose these men to be soldiers, so these men knew how to fight. Use the same word or phrase for chosen men as you used in previous passages.

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The men of Judah prevailed and subdued the soldiers of Israel. To subdue means that you conquer or defeat someone. To prevail means that you have succeeded or won.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **subdue** and **prevail**. If you have already translated these ideas in another book of the Bible, use similar words to those you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Abijah took three **cities** and those cities' surrounding **villages** from Jeroboam. Cities are usually larger settlements with walls around them, and villages are smaller settlements with no walls. Use the same words or phrases for cities and smaller villages as you used in previous passages.

After Abijah died, Abijah's son Asa reigned in Abijah's place. To **reign** means to be the king and to have the authority and power to rule the country. So when Asa "reigns in his place," it means that Asa becomes the new king of Judah just as Abijah had been king of Judah. Use the same word or phrase for reign as you used in previous passages.

Then Judah had rest or peace for 10 years. This means that people experienced calm, quiet, or an absence of war.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **rest** or **peace**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

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Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 14:2–15 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 14:2–15 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.

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4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 14:2–15 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the last story, King Jeroboam of Israel tried to trap King Abijah and the army of Judah by attacking from the front and back. The people of Judah cried out to God, the priests blew their trumpets, and the men shouted. God helped Judah's army win the battle, and Abijah became a strong king of Judah. Later, Abijah died, people buried Abijah, and Abijah's son Asa became the next king of Judah.

The storyteller says that King Asa does things that Yahweh, his God, thinks are good and right. Asa follows Yahweh's ways, and Yahweh is pleased with Asa. The phrase "Yahweh, his God" means that Yahweh is Asa's personal God—the one Asa worships, trusts, and obeys. Asa has a special relationship with Yahweh.

Now the storyteller starts to tell us the good and right things that King Asa does. The storyteller will keep talking about King Asa's good actions in the next story, too.

King Asa obeys what Yahweh has commanded. Asa removes the altars for foreign gods and takes away the high places. A "high place" was a place of worship, often on a hill or a raised platform with steps, where people made sacrifices to idols. Asa also breaks into pieces the sacred pillars, or stones people use to worship other gods. These were standing stones that people set up to honor different gods. Asa also cuts down the Asherah poles. These were wooden poles or trees that other people groups used to worship the goddess Asherah in Judah. People set these poles or trees up, made them holy, and treated them like they were the goddess.

Stop here and look at the images of a high place, sacred stones, and Asherah poles. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Where are the places where people in your community worship gods? What do people call these places? Pause this audio here.

King Asa tells the people of Judah to seek Yahweh. To seek Yahweh means to trust and obey Yahweh. Yahweh is the God that the ancestors of the people of Judah worshiped. Asa orders the people of Judah to follow Yahweh's laws and commandments. At the time of King Asa's reign, the Israelites had God's laws, which Moses had written down.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What do your leaders say you must do to follow the gods in your land? What kind of things do you have to do to make these gods happy? What happens if you do not do what the gods want? Pause this audio here.

King Asa destroys the high places and the altars for burning incense to other gods in every city of Judah. Because of the good and right things that King Asa does, the people of Judah live in peace while Asa is king.

King Asa strengthens the defenses of the cities of Judah. Asa strengthens or rebuilds the walls, towers, gates, and bars around the cities. Asa can do all this because the land is peaceful. No army attacks King Asa during those years, because Yahweh gives Asa peace.

King Asa tells the people of Judah that they should make their cities strong and put walls around the cities. The people should build watchtowers and make gates with bars to lock the gates. These defenses will work together to make the cities of Judah hard to attack. These are probably the same cities that King Solomon and King Rehoboam had made strong before, but later an enemy named Shishak destroyed them. Asa's strong cities probably help protect the roads that lead to important places like Jerusalem. Asa says to the people of Judah that the land still belongs to them because the people of Judah have followed the commands of Yahweh their God. That is why Yahweh gave the people of Judah peace with all the countries around them. Yahweh gave King Asa and Judah peace because Yahweh was keeping his promise. Yahweh had promised to give Israel, including the land of Judah, peace and safety if the people obeyed Yahweh. And the people succeed in building well-protected cities, and everything goes well for the people.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a picture of a city wall from the time of King Asa. Pause this audio here.

2 Chronicles 14:2–15

King Asa has an army of 300,000 men from the tribe of Judah. Each soldier carries a large shield and a spear. Asa also has 280,000 soldiers from the tribe of Benjamin. These soldiers carry small shields and bows. A bow was a wooden weapon that people used to shoot arrows at enemies from far away. It is possible that each tribe had its own special job in the army, and so the armies of Judah and Benjamin had different weapons. All the soldiers are strong and brave fighters. Having a strong and well-equipped army shows that Asa is a good king. Asa trusted God and led Asa's people well.

Stop here and, as a group, look at the picture of the items the soldiers of Judah carried—a spear and a large shield. Now look at the items the soldiers of Benjamin carried—a bow and a small shield. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How does your people's army work? Do the soldiers all do the same job, or do the soldiers work in different groups that do different jobs and use different weapons? Pause this audio here.

A man named Zerah, who is a Cushite, comes to fight King Asa's army. Zerah leads a huge army with thousands of soldiers and 300 chariots. Zerah and his men march all the way to the city of Mareshah. We do not know much about Zerah or why Zerah started this war. In the Bible, people sometimes called the land of Cush "Ethiopia." That area is now part of Sudan, southern Egypt, and Ethiopia. Mareshah was a strong city in Judah. Cush was about 1,000 to 1,200 kilometers away from Mareshah.

Stop here and, as a group, look at the map and follow the journey Zerah and his army took to get from Cush to Mareshah in Judah. Pause this audio here.

So King Asa comes with his army to fight Zerah. The men of Asa and the men of Zerah take their places, ready for battle, in the Valley of Zephathah near Mareshah.

Then King Asa prays to Yahweh, Asa's God. Asa says to Yahweh that Yahweh is the only one who can help weak people fight against strong armies. Asa asks Yahweh to help the people of Judah because the people of Judah trust in Yahweh. Asa says the people of Judah have come to fight the huge army of Zerah to honor Yahweh. Asa says that Yahweh is the God of Judah and asks Yahweh not to let people win against Yahweh.

Yahweh defeats the army of the Cushites when King Asa and the soldiers from the tribe of Judah attack the Cushites. The Cushite people run away. King Asa and his soldiers chase the Cushites all the way to Gerar City, which is outside the land of Judah. The storyteller says that "the Cushites now fall until none remains alive." This may mean that so many people from Cush die that the Cushites are not able to go on fighting, or it could mean that all the people from Cush die. Yahweh and his army defeat the Cushites completely. The men of Judah carry away a large amount of plunder, or valuable things, from the Cushites.

Stop here and, as a group, follow on the map the journey King Asa's army takes when they chase the Cushite army from the Valley of Zephathah to Gerar City. Pause this audio here.

The soldiers from Judah attack and defeat all the cities near Gerar City, which, like Gerar, are outside the land of Judah. The soldiers from Judah kill many people and destroy the cities. The people in those cities are very scared of Yahweh, so the people in those cities do not fight back well. The soldiers from Judah take plunder from the cities because the people in the cities have many valuable things.

Asa's army also attacks the tents of the sheep and camel herdsmen and takes lots of sheep and camels. The herdsmen are not soldiers in Zerah's army. Then Asa and his army return to Jerusalem.

Stop here and, as a group, look at the map and follow the journey King Asa and his army took when they went from the city of Gerar back to Jerusalem.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 14:2–15 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has nine scenes.

2 Chronicles 14:2–15

In the first scene: The storyteller tells us that King Asa does things that Yahweh, Asa's God, thinks are good and right, and the storyteller explains what those things are. Asa destroys things that people use to worship idols. Asa removes the foreign altars, takes away the high places, breaks into pieces the sacred stones, and cuts down the Asherah poles.

In the second scene: King Asa tells the people of Judah to seek Yahweh, the God whom the ancestors of the people of Judah worshiped. Asa orders the people of Judah to obey Yahweh's laws and commandments.

In the third scene: King Asa destroys the high places and the altars for burning incense to other gods in every city of Judah. Because of the good and right things that King Asa does, the people of Judah live in peace while Asa is king.

In the fourth scene: King Asa strengthens the defenses of the cities of Judah. Asa can do all this because no army attacks King Asa during those years, because Yahweh gives Asa peace. King Asa tells the people of Judah that the people should make their cities strong and put walls around the cities, build watchtowers, and make gates with bars to lock the gates. Asa tells the people of Judah that they still have the land because the people follow Yahweh's commands. Yahweh gives the people peace with other nations. The people succeed in building well-protected cities, and everything goes well for the people.

In the fifth scene: The storyteller tells us about the size of King Asa's army. King Asa has an army of 300,000 men from the tribe of Judah and 280,000 soldiers from the tribe of Benjamin. The armies of each tribe use different armor and have different weapons. All the soldiers are strong and brave fighters.

In the sixth scene: A Cushite named Zerah comes to fight King Asa's army with a huge army and 300 chariots. Zerah and his men march all the way to the city of Mareshah. King Asa comes with his army to fight Zerah. The soldiers on both sides line up ready to battle in the Valley of Zephathah near Mareshah.

In the seventh scene: King Asa prays to Yahweh and says only Yahweh can help weak people win against strong armies. Asa asks Yahweh to help Judah because the people trust Yahweh and have come to fight Zerah's big army to honor Yahweh.

In the eighth scene: Yahweh defeats the army of Cush when King Asa and his army attack the Cushites. The Cushite people run away. King Asa and his soldiers chase the Cushites all the way to Gerar City. Many or all people from Cush die, and the Cushites are not able to go on fighting. Yahweh and the army of Judah defeat the Cushites completely. The men of Judah carry away a large amount of plunder from the Cushites.

In the ninth scene: Asa and his army attack and defeat all the cities near Gerar City. Asa's soldiers take plunder from the cities because the people in the cities have many valuable things. Asa's army also attacks the tents of the herdsmen and takes lots of sheep and camels. Then Asa and his army return to Jerusalem.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Asa of Judah
- Yahweh
- People of the tribe of Judah
- The army of the tribe of Judah
- The army of the tribe of Benjamin
- Zerah the Cushite
- The Cushite army
- People in the cities near Gerar City
- And herdsmen in tents near Gerar City

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

Asa has just become the new king of Judah. The storyteller tells us that Asa does what is good and right "in the eyes of Yahweh his God." This means that Asa follows Yahweh's ways, and Yahweh is pleased with Asa. By saying that Yahweh was "his" or "Asa's" God, the storyteller shows that Yahweh was Asa's personal God.

Now the storyteller begins to tell us what the good and right things were that King Asa did.

2 Chronicles 14:2–15

Asa removes the foreign altars, which were altars of foreign gods, and takes away the high places where people made sacrifices to idols. Asa also breaks into pieces the sacred stones people used to worship other gods. Asa also cuts down the Asherah poles, which people used to worship the goddess Asherah. Asa does not destroy any of those things himself, but Asa's workers do.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate "altars of foreign gods," "high places," "pillars or sacred stones," and "Asherah poles." Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your language, how do you say it when a king tells his people to do something, and the people do it, but everyone says the king did it? Talk about a time when a ruler in your people group gave an order, the workers did the job, but people talked about it as if the ruler had done the job himself. Pause this audio here.

King Asa tells the people of Judah to seek Yahweh. To seek Yahweh meant to trust Yahweh and to obey Yahweh. Yahweh is "the God of their fathers," which means that Yahweh is the God whom the ancestors of the people of Judah worshiped. Asa orders the people of Judah to obey "the law and commandment," which refers to all of Yahweh's laws and commandments.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What words do you use in your language to talk about God's laws and commandments? What do your people call general rules or ways to act that everyone in your community must follow? Pause this audio here.

King Asa also destroys the high places and the altars for burning incense to other gods in every city of Judah. Remember that Asa does not destroy the high places himself, but Asa's workers do. Because of the good and right things that King Asa does, the people of Judah live in peace while Asa is king.

King Asa "builds up" strong cities. Asa does not build new cities, but Asa's workers repair the walls around the cities while the land of Judah is at peace. No army attacks King Asa during those years, because Yahweh gives Asa peace, or rest. Here, the word for peace is not the usual one. Instead, it comes from the same word as Sabbath, which means rest in the original language. King Asa tells the people of Judah that the people should make their cities strong and put walls around the cities. The people should build watchtowers and make gates with bars to lock the gates. Tall, strong stone walls all around the city will keep enemies out. High towers of stone or brick that people build into the walls will allow guards to watch for danger from far away. People will use the gates to go in and out of the city and use wooden or metal bars to close the gates at night and during attacks. These defenses will work together to make the cities of Judah hard to attack. Asa says to the people of Judah, "The land is still ours, because we have followed the commands of Yahweh our God. That is why Yahweh gave us peace with all the countries around us." When King Asa says, "we have followed the commands of Yahweh," King Asa refers to himself and to all the people of Judah. And the people succeed in building well-protected cities, and everything goes well for the people.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a picture of a city wall from the time of king Asa. Pause this audio here.

Now the storyteller tells us about the size of King Asa's army. King Asa has an army of 300,000 men from the tribe of Judah. Each soldier carries a large shield and a spear. Asa also has 280,000 soldiers from the tribe of Benjamin. These soldiers carry small shields and bows. All the soldiers are strong and brave fighters.

Stop here and, as a group, look at the picture of the items the soldiers of Judah carried—a spear and a large shield. Now look at the items the soldiers of Benjamin carried—a bow and a small shield. Pause this audio here.

A man named Zerah, who is a Cushite, comes to fight King Asa's army. Zerah leads a huge army that the original language calls "a thousand times thousands" of soldiers, along with 300 chariots. This number is not exact, but it shows that the army was very large. Zerah and Zerah's men march all the way to the city of Mareshah. In the Bible, people sometimes called the land of Cush "Ethiopia." That area is now part of Sudan, southern Egypt, and Ethiopia. Mareshah was a strong city in Judah. Cush was about 1,000 to 1,200 kilometers away from Mareshah. It would take Zerah and Zerah's army around 45 to 60 days to walk from Cush to Mareshah.

Stop here and, as a group, look at the map and follow the journey Zerah and Zerah's army took to get from Cush to Mareshah in Judah. Pause this audio here.

2 Chronicles 14:2–15

King Asa comes with his army to fight Zerah. The soldiers on both sides line up, ready to battle, in the Valley of Zephathah near Mareshah. The valley is probably north of Mareshah, but no one knows for sure.

Then King Asa prays to Yahweh, Asa's God. Asa says, "Yahweh, you are the only one who can defend weak people against many people. Help your people, Yahweh our God, because we are trusting in you. It is because we trust in your name that we have come to fight this great army. Yahweh, you are our God, so do not let human beings defeat you."

Yahweh defeats the army of the Cushites when King Asa and the soldiers from the tribe of Judah attack the Cushites. The Cushite people run away. King Asa and his soldiers chase the Cushites all the way to Gerar City. Gerar was a Philistine city between Gaza and Beersheba, about 40 kilometers southwest of Mareshah. The storyteller says that "the Cushites now fall until none remain alive." This may mean that so many people from Cush die that the Cushites are not able to go on fighting, or it could mean that all the people from Cush die. Yahweh and his forces defeat the Cushites completely. "His forces" refers to Asa's army, which was also Yahweh's army. The storyteller clearly states that it is Yahweh who wins the victory, not Judah's army. The men of Judah carry away a large amount of plunder, or valuable items, from the Cushites.

Stop here and, as a group, follow on the map the journey King Asa's army takes when they chase the Cushite army from the Valley of Zephathah to Gerar City. Pause this audio here.

The soldiers from Judah attack and defeat all the cities near Gerar City. The word for "defeat" in the original language means both to kill the people and destroy the cities. The people in those cities are very scared of Yahweh, so the people in those cities do not fight back well. The soldiers from Judah take plunder from the cities because the people in the cities have many valuable things.

Stop here and, as a group, talk about the words you use in your language when you describe how people defeat a city, which involves killing people and destroying the buildings. What word or words will you use in this story? Pause this audio here.

Asa's army also attacks the tents of the herdsmen and takes lots of sheep and camels. Here, the word for "attack" in the original language means "to kill." Asa's army kills the herdsmen and takes the animals. Then Asa and his army return to Jerusalem. Jerusalem was 70 to 80 kilometers away from Gerar. It takes Asa's army between three and five days to return to Jerusalem.

Stop here and, as a group, look at the map and follow the journey King Asa and his army took when they went from the city of Gerar back to Jerusalem. Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 14:2–15 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has nine scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Asa of Judah
- Yahweh
- People of the tribe of Judah
- The army of the tribe of Judah
- The army of the tribe of Benjamin
- Zerah the Cushite
- The Cushite army
- People in the cities near Gerar City
- And herdsmen in tents near Gerar City

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

2 Chronicles 14:2–15

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

King Asa does things that Yahweh, Asa's God, thinks are good and right. Asa gets rid of things people use to worship idols. Asa removes the foreign altars, takes away the high places, breaks into pieces the sacred stones, and cuts down the Asherah poles.

King Asa tells the people of Judah to seek Yahweh the God that the ancestors of the people of Judah worshiped. Asa orders the people of Judah to obey Yahweh's laws and commandments.

King Asa destroys the high places and the altars for burning incense to other gods in every city of Judah. Because of the good and right things that King Asa does, the people of Judah live in peace while Asa is king.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Asa, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am angry that the previous kings of Judah allowed people to worship foreign gods in Judah! It is sinful to worship other gods. We must worship Yahweh alone; or
- I am happy that from now on we will do what is right in the eyes of Yahweh my God; or
- We must remove and destroy the places and items of idol worship. Then Yahweh will forgive us and bless the tribe of Judah.

Continue the drama.

King Asa strengthens the defenses of the cities of Judah. Asa can do all this because no army attacks King Asa during those years, because Yahweh gives Asa peace. King Asa tells the people of Judah that the people should make their cities strong and put walls around the cities, build watchtowers, and make gates with bars to lock the gates. Asa tells the people of Judah that the people still have the land because the people follow Yahweh's commands. Yahweh gives the people peace with other nations. The people succeed in building well-protected cities, and everything goes well for the people.

King Asa has an army of 300,000 men from the tribe of Judah. Each soldier carries a large shield and a spear. Asa also has 280,000 soldiers from the tribe of Benjamin. These soldiers carry small shields and bows. All the soldiers are strong and brave fighters.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing people of the tribe of Judah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We thank Yahweh for giving us a good king. King Asa listens to Yahweh and does what Yahweh says; or
- We are happy that Yahweh has given our tribe peace, and we have had no war with other countries;
- We feel safe with King Asa. Asa ordered the workers to strengthen our cities, and our tribe has a large army.

Continue the drama.

A Cushite named Zerah comes to fight King Asa's army with a huge army and 300 chariots. Zerah and his men march all the way to the city of Mareshah. King Asa comes with Asa's army to fight Zerah. The soldiers on both sides line up ready to battle in the Valley of Zephathah near Mareshah.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Zerah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel confident that we can win against the people of Judah because we have a huge army and the people of Judah are weak and easy to defeat; or
- I feel excited because we can take control of Judah's cities, and steal their treasures, land, and animals; or
- I feel proud of my huge army and chariots. My army will not let me down.

Continue the drama.

King Asa prays to Yahweh and says only Yahweh can help weak people win against strong armies. Asa asks Yahweh to help Judah because the people trust Yahweh and have come to fight Zerah's big army to honor Yahweh.

Yahweh defeats the army of Cush when King Asa and his army attack the Cushites. The Cushite people run away. King Asa and his soldiers chase the Cushites all the way to Gerar City outside of Judah. Many or all people from the region of Cush die, and the Cushites are not able to go on fighting. Yahweh and his army, which is the army of Judah, defeat the Cushites completely. The men of Judah carry away a large amount of plunder from the Cushites.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Asa, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel so grateful to Yahweh. I prayed to Yahweh and Yahweh defeated the army of Zerah; or
- I feel relieved that the people of Judah are safe again; or
- I feel safe because Yahweh is our God. Yahweh cares for us and blesses us with peace when we live as Yahweh says we should.

Continue the drama.

Asa and his army attack and defeat all the cities near Gerar City which are also outside of Judah. Asa's soldiers take plunder from the cities because the people in the cities have many valuable things. Asa's army also attacks the tents of the herdsmen and takes lots of sheep and camels. Then Asa and his army return to Jerusalem.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 14:2–15 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

King Asa did what was good and right in the eyes of Yahweh, Asa's God. Use the same word or phrase for king as you used in previous passages. For more information on king, refer to the Master Glossary.

Yahweh is God's personal name. Use the same name for Yahweh that you have used in previous passages. For more information on Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary.

God is the general name for God, the creator of the universe. Use the same word or phrase you used in previous passages. Look up God in the Master Glossary for more information.

Asa removed the foreign altars and took away the high places. Asa also broke into pieces the pillars, or sacred stones people used to worship other gods. Asa also cut down the Asherah poles.

Stop here and look at the images of a high place, a sacred stone, and Asherah poles. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **sacred stones** and **Asherah poles**. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Use the same words or phrases for **altar** and **high places** as you used in previous passages. For more information on "altar," refer to the Master Glossary.

The **kingdom** of Israel was at peace. Use the same word or phrase for kingdom that you have used previously, and refer to kingdom in the Master Glossary for more information.

Asa made the **cities** of **Judah** stronger. Asa and his workers could do all this because the land was peaceful. No army attacked King Asa during those years, because Yahweh gave Asa peace.

Use the same words for Judah and cities as you used in previous passages. Judah is in the Master Glossary.

2 Chronicles 14:2–15

Here, the word for **peace** is not the usual one. Instead, it comes from the same word as Sabbath, which means rest in the original language. Use the same word or phrase here for “peace” or “rest” that you used in 2 Chronicles 14:1.

King Asa tells the people of Judah to seek Yahweh, “**the God of their fathers**.” This means that Yahweh is the God that the ancestors worshipped. Asa orders the people of Judah to obey Yahweh’s **laws** and **commandments**. Use the same words or phrases for “the God of their fathers,” laws, and commandments, as you used in previous passages. For more information on laws and commandments, refer to the Master Glossary.

King Asa builds up **strong cities** while the land of Judah is at peace. Use the same word or phrase for “strong city” as you used in previous passages.

King Asa has an army of 300,000 men from the tribe of Judah. Each soldier carries a large shield and a spear. Asa also has 280,000 soldiers from the tribe of Benjamin. These soldiers carry small shields and bows. A bow was a wooden weapon that people used to shoot arrows at enemies from far away.

Stop here and, as a group, look at the picture of the items the soldiers of Judah carried—a spear and a large shield. Now look at the items the soldiers of Benjamin carried—a bow and a small shield. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **bow**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

A Cushite named Zerah comes to fight King Asa’s army with a huge army and 300 **chariots**.

Use the same word or phrase for chariot as you used in previous passages.

The men of Judah carry away a large amount of plunder from the Cushites. Plunder means the valuable things people take, like money, animals, or goods, from enemies after a battle.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **plunder**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Asa’s army also attacks the tents of the herdsmen and takes lots of sheep and camels.

Herdsmen are people who take care of animals like sheep, goats, or cows and lead these animals to places where the animals can eat and drink.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **herdsmen**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

2 Chronicles 18:1–8

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

2 Chronicles 18:1–8

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 18:1–8 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 18:1–8 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 18:1–8 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passage, the storyteller told us about when Jehoshaphat followed Yahweh and was a good king of Judah. Now, the storyteller starts to tell us of a time when Jehoshaphat makes mistakes and visits King Ahab in Israel. We can also find this story in 1 Kings 22:1–9, but with some differences.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: If you have already translated 1 Kings 22:1–9, listen to your translation of that passage. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller starts the story by telling us again that Jehoshaphat had lots of money and many people respected Jehoshaphat. Even though Jehoshaphat did not need money or respect, Jehoshaphat made an alliance, a formal relationship, with Israel by marrying his son to Ahab's daughter. The alliance meant Jehoshaphat and Ahab did not fight each other. The two kings would work together and support each other.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Tell a story of a time when two people married or made a formal relationship to make two families or groups of people work together and support each other. Pause this audio here.

After Jehoshaphat married his son to Ahab's daughter, Jehoshaphat goes to visit Ahab. We do not know exactly how many years there were between the marriage and the visit, but it was probably more than three years. Jehoshaphat leaves Jerusalem and goes to visit Ahab in the city of Samaria, in Israel. Jehoshaphat probably travels to Samaria with a large number of people. In the time of King Jehoshaphat, it was normal for kings to travel with many servants and officials. When Jehoshaphat is in Samaria, Ahab tells his people to kill lots of sheep and "cattle," or oxen. Sheep and cattle are both large animals, and when people cook one of these animals, the animal will feed lots of people.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of sheep. Pause this audio here.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of cattle. Pause this audio here.

The people probably do not kill the animals for a sacrifice to please Yahweh. Ahab probably gives the sheep and cattle to Jehoshaphat and the people with Jehoshaphat as part of a big feast. The feast is to celebrate the visit of Jehoshaphat and all the people with Jehoshaphat. Ahab wants Jehoshaphat to feel special and important. Ahab wants Jehoshaphat to help Ahab attack Ramoth in Gilead.

Stop here as a group and look at a map of Israel, Judah, and western Syria. Find the cities of Jerusalem, Samaria, and Ramoth in Gilead. Pause this audio here.

2 Chronicles 18:1–8

You may remember that Ramoth Gilead was part of the land Yahweh gave to the tribe of Gad and was a city of refuge where the Levites lived. However, the people of Aram attacked and now control Ramoth Gilead. After the last war between Israel and Aram, the king of Aram said he would give Ramoth Gilead back to the king of Israel. The king of Aram did not give Ramoth Gilead back to Ahab, and now Ahab wants the city back. Syria is another name for Aram. The Aramean people are the same people as the Syrian people.

Ahab wants Jehoshaphat to help to fight the Arameans at Ramoth Gilead and to help get back control of Ramoth Gilead. Jehoshaphat tells Ahab that Jehoshaphat and Ahab are united like being one person. Jehoshaphat says that the fighting people of Judah and Israel are one people together. Jehoshaphat will support Ahab in the war to fight the Arameans. Jehoshaphat tells the king of Israel that the two kings must ask Yahweh for guidance before the kings do anything else. In the time of the kings of Israel and Judah, the kings used prophets to ask for guidance from God.

The king of Israel gathers the prophets so that the kings can ask for guidance. There are about 400 prophets. We do not know if the prophets were all men or if they were both men and women. The prophets were people who said they spoke messages from God. It is possible that the prophets all served the king of Israel. The king of Israel asks if the kings should go to war to fight against the people in Ramoth Gilead or hold back and not attack. The king of Israel does not expect the prophets to go to war.

The prophets tell the kings that God will give Ramoth Gilead into the king of Israel's "hand" or control. The prophets use polite language and do not address the kings directly. Jehoshaphat does not trust the prophets' answer. Jehoshaphat does not think any of the prophets bring a message from Yahweh. Jehoshaphat asks the king of Israel if all the prophets of Yahweh are gone or if there is still one prophet that the kings can ask for guidance. The king of Israel tells Jehoshaphat about the one prophet of Yahweh whom the kings can talk to. The king of Israel hates the prophet of Yahweh because, in all the time the prophet has brought messages, the messages for the king are never good news. The prophet always prophesies bad things to happen to the king of Israel. The king of Israel names the prophet as Micaiah, who is the son of Imlah. Imlah was probably Micaiah's father.

Jehoshaphat replies directly to the king of Israel but addresses him as the king. Jehoshaphat uses polite language to tell the king of Israel that the king should not say bad things about a prophet of Yahweh.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Tell a story about a time when you needed to tell someone politely that the person was doing something wrong. Maybe the person was older than you or a very important person in your community. Pause this audio here.

The king of Israel calls one of his officials over to him and asks the official to bring Micaiah, son of Imlah, to the two kings. The king wants Micaiah to come to the two kings as soon as possible.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 18:1–8 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: The storyteller tells us that Jehoshaphat is rich, well respected, and has a formal relationship with Ahab.

In the second scene: Jehoshaphat visits Ahab in Samaria, and Ahab gives a big feast for Jehoshaphat. At the feast, Ahab persuades Jehoshaphat to fight with Ahab against Ramoth Gilead. Jehoshaphat wants to help Ahab but wants to hear from Yahweh first.

In the third scene: The king of Israel gathers 400 prophets and asks the prophets if Israel should fight Ramoth Gilead. The prophets tell the king of Israel to fight because God will give Ramoth Gilead to the king of Israel. Jehoshaphat wants to hear from a prophet of Yahweh. The king of Israel says that Micaiah is the only prophet

2 Chronicles 18:1–8

of Yahweh. The king of Israel hates Micaiah because Micaiah always prophesies bad things for the king of Israel. The king of Israel asks an official to bring Micaiah to the two kings.

The characters in this passage are:

- The storyteller
- Jehoshaphat, king of Judah
- Ahab, king of Israel
- Jehoshaphat's people
- Four hundred prophets
- And the king of Israel's official

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the previous passage, the storyteller told us Jehoshaphat followed Yahweh, became powerful, and was a successful king of Judah. Now the storyteller wants to tell us about the time Jehoshaphat visits Ahab, the king of Israel. The storyteller begins the story by reminding us that Jehoshaphat is wealthy, with lots of money and valuable things. The storyteller also tells us that Jehoshaphat has a lot of honor, has respect from lots of people, and is well known by lots of people. Jehoshaphat has allied himself with Ahab; Jehoshaphat has made a formal relationship with Ahab by marrying Jehoshaphat's son to Ahab's daughter.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What do you call a formal relationship between two leaders where the leaders will help each other and possibly fight to protect each other's countries? Pause this audio here.

A few years after Jehoshaphat and Ahab became allies, Jehoshaphat visits Ahab in Samaria. You may remember that the storyteller in 1 Kings tells us that Jehoshaphat visits Ahab in the third year after Aram made peace with Israel. But the storyteller in this story only gives a general idea of when Jehoshaphat visits Ahab. Jehoshaphat goes down from Jerusalem, which is on top of a hill, to Samaria, which is lower down. Samaria is north of Jerusalem.

Stop here as a group and, if needed, look at a map of Israel, Judah, and western Syria. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you say Jehoshaphat went down to see the king of Israel? Remember that "going down" means that Jehoshaphat traveled from a higher place to a lower place. Pause this audio here.

When Jehoshaphat visits Ahab, Ahab kills sheep and cattle to celebrate the visit and to provide food for a feast.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of sheep if needed. Pause this audio here.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of cattle if needed. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller tells us that Ahab urges Jehoshaphat to help Ahab attack Ramoth Gilead. The storyteller uses language to tell us that Ahab wants Jehoshaphat to do something that is not good.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you talk about someone who tries to get someone to do something that is not good or the right thing to do? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller uses Ahab's and Jehoshaphat's titles as kings of Israel and Judah when the storyteller says what Ahab asks Jehoshaphat. Ahab wants Jehoshaphat and Jehoshaphat's fighting men to help attack the people at Ramoth Gilead. Now, the storyteller stops naming Ahab as the king of Israel. Jehoshaphat replies to say that the two kings are united and will work together as one fighting people. The people of Judah will join the people of Israel in a war against Aram at Ramoth Gilead.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: If you have one, what particular saying or phrase do you use to say that you and another person or group of people will do something together, like you are one person or group? Pause this audio here.

At the same time as Jehoshaphat agrees to fight with Ahab, Jehoshaphat also says that the kings should ask Yahweh for guidance. The storyteller stops naming Ahab and only uses the title "the king of Israel."

The king of Israel gathers together prophets. We do not know how long it takes for the prophets to come to the kings. The prophets are probably part of the people living in the king's household and probably come to the

2 Chronicles 18:1–8

kings on the same day or the next day. The group of prophets probably included men and women. The king of Israel asks the prophets if Israel and Judah should go to war to attack and fight the people of Ramoth Gilead, or not go to war. The prophets all reply that God will give Ramoth Gilead into the king's hand. The prophets use the word "hand" to symbolize power. The prophets say the king of Israel will have power over Ramoth Gilead. The prophets do not call God by God's personal name.

Jehoshaphat asks if there is no prophet of Yahweh in the group that the kings can ask for guidance. Jehoshaphat thinks that it is possible that there are no prophets of Yahweh advising the king of Israel.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you ask someone politely if a person is in a town or village if you do not know if that person is still there or has gone away? Pause this audio here.

The king of Israel tells Jehoshaphat that there is one prophet whom the kings can use to ask questions to Yahweh. The king of Israel tells Jehoshaphat about the one prophet of Yahweh who is in Israel. The king of Israel says that he hates the prophet and sees the prophet as an enemy. The prophet's messages for the king of Israel are never good. The king of Israel names the prophet as Micaiah, son of Imlah. Jehoshaphat tells the king of Israel that the king of Israel should not speak in that way. The king of Israel should not say bad things about Micaiah because Micaiah is a prophet of Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you tell somebody not to say bad things

about another person? Pause this audio here.

The king of Israel asks one of his officials to come to the king and asks the official to bring Micaiah to the two kings.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 18:1–8 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- The storyteller
- Jehoshaphat, king of Judah
- Ahab, king of Israel
- Jehoshaphat's people
- Four hundred prophets
- And the king of Israel's official

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

The storyteller tells us that Jehoshaphat is rich, that everyone respects Jehoshaphat, and that Jehoshaphat has a formal relationship with Ahab.

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Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the storyteller, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Jehoshaphat is a powerful king of Judah; or
- I told you Jehoshaphat followed Yahweh. But Jehoshaphat made an alliance with Ahab, who did not follow Yahweh; or
- Now I will tell you about a mistake Jehoshaphat made.

Continue the drama.

Jehoshaphat visits Ahab in Samaria, and Ahab gives a big feast for Jehoshaphat and his people. At the feast, Ahab persuades Jehoshaphat to fight with Ahab against Ramoth Gilead. Jehoshaphat wants to help Ahab but wants to hear from Yahweh first.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Jehoshaphat, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Ahab has made a big feast for us. Ahab is trying to impress us and make us feel welcome; or
- I am happy to help Ahab because our families are connected; or
- It is important to consult Yahweh. I do not want to fight if Yahweh does not tell us to fight; or
- I am worried that Ahab does not care about Yahweh.

Ask the person playing Jehoshaphat's people, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We are very impressed by this amazing big feast for us; or
- We feel very welcome in Samaria.

Ask the person playing the king of Israel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I want Jehoshaphat to help me get control of Ramoth Gilead and make it part of Israel again; or
- I am happy that Jehoshaphat wants to help me; or
- I have lots of prophets who will bring messages to me from God. I do not care which god the prophets talk to.

Continue the drama.

The king of Israel gathers 400 prophets and asks the prophets if Israel should fight Ramoth Gilead. The prophets tell the king of Israel to fight because God will give Ramoth Gilead to the king of Israel. Jehoshaphat wants to hear from a prophet of Yahweh. The king of Israel says that Micaiah is the only prophet of Yahweh. The king of Israel hates Micaiah because Micaiah always prophesies bad things for the king of Israel. The king of Israel asks an official to bring Micaiah to the two kings.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the king of Israel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am excited. All the prophets say that I should attack Ramoth Gilead. God is with me and will give me the victory; or
- Why does Jehoshaphat care about Yahweh? Yahweh's prophet never says anything good to me. I do not want to talk to Yahweh's prophet; or
- If I want Jehoshaphat to help me, I will need to get Micaiah to come and prophesy.

Ask the person playing the 400 prophets, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We want the king to like us, so we tell the king, "Yes, go and fight Ramoth Gilead"; or
- You, the king of Israel, are powerful. Of course, you will win; or
- Listen to all of us. We can tell you what God is saying.

Ask the person playing Jehoshaphat, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- There are so many prophets, but I do not think these prophets speak messages from Yahweh; or
- I do not trust these prophets; or
- I must hear from Yahweh before I go with Israel and take my army to fight Aram in Ramoth Gilead; or

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- The king of Israel does not respect Micaiah, Yahweh's prophet. I do not like what the king of Israel says about Micaiah.

Ask the person playing the king of Israel's official, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I must find Micaiah quickly; or
- I wonder what Micaiah will say this time. I hope Micaiah does not make my king angry.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 18:1–8 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Jehoshaphat has great **wealth** and **honor**. Wealth is when a person has lots of money and possessions. A person with honor is a person whom people respect and value because the person makes good choices and has good behavior. Use the same words or phrases for wealth and honor as you used in previous passages.

Jehoshaphat allied himself with Ahab through marriage. Jehoshaphat made a formal relationship between Judah and Israel by marrying Jehoshaphat's son to Ahab's daughter.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **allied through marriage**. Pause this audio here.

Ahab slaughtered **sheep** and **cattle** for Jehoshaphat. Use the same words or phrases for sheep and cattle as you used in previous passages. Ahab killed the animals for the group of visitors to eat as part of a feast.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for "**slaughtered**," or killed, an animal. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The **king** of **Israel** asked the king of **Judah** to go to attack Ramoth Gilead. Use the same words or phrases for king, Israel, and Judah as you used in previous passages. For more information on king, Israel, and Judah, refer to the Master Glossary.

Jehoshaphat told the king of Israel to seek counsel or advice from **Yahweh**. Yahweh is God's personal name. In this passage, God is called Yahweh. Be sure to translate Yahweh in the same way as you have in previous passages, and remember that Yahweh is in the Master Glossary.

The king of Israel gathered the **prophets**. Use the same word or phrase for prophets as you used in previous passages. For more information on prophet, refer to the Master Glossary.

The prophets say that **God**, the most powerful being, will give Syria to the king of Israel. Use the same word or phrase for God as you used in previous passages. For more information on God, refer to the Master Glossary.

God will give Ramoth Gilead into the king's "**hand**" or into the king's power. Use the same word or phrase for "into the king's hand" as you used in previous passages.

The king of Israel says that Micaiah never **prophesies** anything good about the king. Use the same word or phrase for prophesies as you used in previous passages. For more information on prophecy, refer to the Master Glossary.

The king of Israel asks an official to bring Micaiah to the kings. An official is a person who serves the king and helps the king run the country. An official has high status in the king's household and does not do domestic tasks.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **official**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

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Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (1.1 MB)
- Setting the Stage (5.7 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (6.5 MB)
- Embodying the Text (4.3 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.5 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.2 MB)

2 Chronicles 18:9–27

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 18:9–27 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 18:9–27 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 18:9–27 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

2 Chronicles 18:9–27

This passage continues the story where the kings of Judah and Israel meet together in Samaria, in Israel. The kings want to know if the fighters of Judah and Israel should attack the Arameans at Ramoth Gilead. Syria is another name for Aram, and the Aramean people are the same people as the Syrian people. The kings heard 400 prophets tell the kings to attack, but Jehoshaphat, the king of Judah, wanted to hear from Yahweh.

Stop here and look at a map that shows Israel and the cities of Samaria and Ramoth Gilead. Pause this audio here.

We can also find this story in 1 Kings 22:10–28, but with some differences.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: If you have already translated 1 Kings 22:10–28, listen to your translation of that passage. Pause this audio here.

The kings wear special clothes or robes that show they are kings. Special servants made the robes from fine material and decorated the robes with special signs and patterns.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What special clothes or decorations does your king or most important leader wear to show that they are the king? Pause this audio here.

The kings are sitting on their thrones, their special seats. The kings are at the threshing floor near the gate of the city of Samaria. The threshing floor is an open area with a flat, level, stone surface. People went to the threshing floor to beat or break the outer coating off the grains of wheat or other grains.

Stop here and look at a picture of people using a threshing floor to separate wheat grains from other parts of the plant. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What open spaces do your leaders use for special times when the leaders are with your people? Are these spaces inside or outside of buildings, or inside or outside of the cities or towns? Pause this audio here.

The threshing floor was probably outside the city gate so that the wind blew the light outer coating of the grain away. Big walls surrounded the city of Samaria to protect the city. People used big gates in the city walls to go in and out of the city.

Stop here and look at a picture of a city gate in the wall of a city. Pause this audio here.

There is lots of space for people at the threshing floor. You will remember that in David's time, two important events with the ark of the covenant happened on a threshing floor. The kings probably think the threshing floor is an important place to hear from God.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What place or places in your city, or where you live, are special for you to hear from God? Pause this audio here.

The prophets are with the kings and are giving their messages and talking, or possibly dancing and shouting. One of the prophets is called Zedekiah and is the son of Kenaanah. Kenaanah is probably the father of Zedekiah. Zedekiah made horns from iron. Iron is a hard metal, and people use iron to make tools and weapons. Zedekiah probably shaped the iron to look like the horns on a bull, which is an adult male cow.

Stop here and look at a picture of a bull with horns and imagine the horns made from iron. Pause this audio here.

Sometimes bulls are dangerous. If a bull attacks a person, the bull hits a person with its horns and pushes its horns into the person's body. A bull might hurt or gore a person and cause the person to die. Zedekiah probably put the iron horns on a helmet. Zedekiah tells the king of Israel that Yahweh said the king of Israel would use the horns to gore or make a big, bloody hole in the Arameans. The king would destroy or completely defeat the Arameans. Zedekiah probably gave the helmet to the king as a symbol of the words. You might remember that Zedekiah's words are very similar to the blessing Moses gave to the tribes descended from Joseph in Deuteronomy 33:17. But Zedekiah does not say that the king must be faithful to Yahweh like Moses said the tribes should be.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Listen to Deuteronomy 33:17 in your own language, if possible. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller tells us that all the other prophets at the threshing floor say the same thing as Zedekiah. All the prophets encourage the king of Israel to attack the Syrians at Ramoth Gilead and win the battle. The prophets say Yahweh will give Ramoth Gilead into the king of Israel's hand, into the king's power.

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A messenger, a person who carries a message, went to order Micaiah to come to the kings. The messenger speaks to Micaiah and tells Micaiah to pay special attention and know that all the prophets are saying the same thing. The prophets are all saying what the king of Israel wants to hear. The messenger tells Micaiah to give a message like the other prophets and say what the king wants to hear. Micaiah replies to the messenger and uses the words of a strong oath or promise. Micaiah will only say what God wants Micaiah to say. Micaiah says, "My God," the God whom Micaiah worships. In 1 Kings, the storyteller says "Yahweh" instead of God.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about a time when someone has told you to say something to keep another person happy. Maybe the person asked you to say something that was not true or to leave out some important information. Why did the person not want you to say the truth? Pause this audio here.

Micaiah arrives at the threshing floor and meets with the kings. The king of Israel asks Micaiah the same question that he asked the 400 prophets. Micaiah answers the king and tells the king to attack and win. Micaiah says someone will give the Arameans into the king's hand or power. Micaiah does not mean what he says. The king of Israel knew that Micaiah was not giving a true prophecy.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about a time when you heard someone talk, and you knew that the person did not mean what they said. The way the person said it showed that the person did not expect people to believe the person. How did the person sound when the person said the untrue thing? Pause this audio here.

The king of Israel is frustrated with Micaiah. The king speaks harshly to Micaiah for not telling the truth. We do not know when or if Micaiah has told the king other things that are not true.

Micaiah answers the king of Israel's question with what Micaiah saw in a vision. We do not know when Micaiah saw this vision. Yahweh sends a vision to Micaiah to be a message for people. Micaiah saw the people of Israel spread out all over a hill. Micaiah uses special language to describe how the people look on the hill. Micaiah says the people look like a group of sheep who do not have a shepherd. Sheep live in open places with lots of grass and small plants. Normally, a shepherd works to keep sheep together to help protect the sheep and move them from one place to another. When no shepherd is with the sheep, the sheep wander all over the place, do not stay together, and are not safe. Micaiah sees people, not sheep. The people listening to Micaiah are used to seeing sheep on hills and know that it is wrong for a group of sheep not to have a shepherd.

Stop here and look at a picture of a group of sheep on a hillside, and imagine the sheep all over the hillside instead of together in a group. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: If you see a group of people scattered over a large area, what might you compare those people to? How would you help someone understand what the group of people looked like? Pause this audio here.

Micaiah tells the king what Yahweh says to Micaiah. Yahweh says the people have no master, no person to tell the people what to do and to look after the people. Yahweh says that each person is to go home in peace or safely and not fight.

The king of Israel then talks to Jehoshaphat, the king of Judah. The king of Israel uses a question that he does not expect Jehoshaphat to answer. The king of Israel uses the question to say that Micaiah has done just what the king of Israel expected Micaiah to do.

Micaiah tells the king of Israel about another vision from Yahweh. Micaiah tells the king of Israel to hear a message from Yahweh. Micaiah talks about a vision. We do not know when Micaiah saw the vision. In the vision, Micaiah saw Yahweh sitting on a throne, a special seat for a king. Many heavenly beings stood around Yahweh on all sides of the throne. Yahweh asked the heavenly beings to say who would go to Ahab, the king of Israel, and try to persuade Ahab to attack Ramoth Gilead. Yahweh said that Ahab will die if Ahab attacks Ramoth Gilead. The heavenly beings gave different responses to Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about a time someone asked a group of people to do something that the people did not want to do or would find difficult to do. How did the group of people respond? What did the people say to each other or the person who asked the question? Pause this audio here.

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In the vision, a spirit, a heavenly being, stood in front of Yahweh and said it will entice the king of Israel. The spirit is a supernatural being who lives and serves Yahweh in heaven. The spirit is not the Holy Spirit or a demon. The spirit said it will be a deceiving spirit in the mouths of the King of Israel's prophets. Someone who deceives a person makes a person believe something that is not true. The spirit made the prophets believe what the prophets said. Yahweh knew that the spirit would persuade Ahab to attack Ramoth Gilead. Micaiah tells the king of Israel that Yahweh sent the spirit who made the prophets tell Ahab to attack Ramoth Gilead. Yahweh has decided and declared that Ahab will have a terrible end.

Zedekiah, son of Kenaanah, is angry. Zedekiah slaps Micaiah on the face to insult Micaiah.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What ways do people use to insult other people in your community? Pause this audio here.

Zedekiah also uses a question that he does not expect Micaiah to answer. Zedekiah asks how or why the spirit of Yahweh has gone from Zedekiah to Micaiah. Zedekiah is not talking about the Holy Spirit or a demon. Zedekiah is talking about a spiritual being who carries the message from Yahweh. Zedekiah does not think that Micaiah has replaced Zedekiah as the main person to receive messages from Yahweh. Zedekiah thinks that Zedekiah is better than Micaiah. Micaiah responds to Zedekiah and tells Zedekiah that Zedekiah will know the answer to his question on a day in the future. In the future, there will be a time when Zedekiah will hide in the most protected room inside a building or in the middle of the city. This may be when the Arameans defeat the Israelites, or a time when Zedekiah hides from Israelites because Zedekiah gives false prophecies to the Israelites.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: If you want to hide from people who want to hurt you, where would you go to hide? Pause this audio here.

After Micaiah told the king a prophecy that the king did not like, the king of Israel gives an order to the people who serve the king. The king of Israel tells people to take Micaiah away and take Micaiah back to Amon and Joash. Amon was the governor, or the most important official, of the city of Samaria. We do not know if Joash was a male offspring of the king. The king's son might be a special title for someone who is a royal official and responsible for safety in the city.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Who in your community is responsible for looking after the safety of your people? What title or special name, if any, do they have? Pause this audio here.

The king of Israel commands Amon and Joash to put Micaiah in prison. A prison is a strong building. If someone puts a person in a prison, the person cannot leave the building. People will guard the person in the prison, and there are locks or barriers on the door to stop the person from opening the door and leaving.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your community, what do you do with people who disobey the rules in your community or who might be a danger to other people in the community? Pause this audio here.

The king of Israel orders Amon and Joash to only feed Micaiah enough food and water for Micaiah to stay alive. In Israel, bread that people made from wheat flour was not a special food.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What do you do with people who disobey your most important leader and say bad things about your most important leader? Pause this audio here.

The king wants the order to last until the time the king of Israel returns safely from attacking Ramoth Gilead.

Micaiah responds to the king of Israel's order to say that if the king comes back safely from the battle, Yahweh did not speak through Micaiah. Micaiah uses the outcome of the battle to show the people of Israel whether Micaiah is a prophet of Yahweh or a false prophet. Micaiah then speaks to everyone who can hear him. Micaiah tells everybody to hear the warning from Yahweh.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 18:9–27 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has five scenes.

In the first scene: As the kings wait for Micaiah to arrive, the two kings sit outside the city of Samaria with many prophets in front of them. One of the prophets, Zedekiah, has iron horns like a bull. Zedekiah says Yahweh says the kings will defeat the Arameans with the iron horns. The prophets make a loud noise and tell the kings to attack Aram at Ramoth Gilead because the kings will win the battle.

In the second scene: The messenger tells Micaiah to give the king the same prophecy as the other prophets. Micaiah says he will say what Yahweh tells him to say.

In the third scene: Micaiah says the false prophecy, but the king of Israel knows Micaiah is not giving a prophecy from Yahweh. Micaiah speaks about a vision from Yahweh where Micaiah sees Israelites who have lost their leader. The king of Israel is angry.

In the fourth scene: Micaiah speaks about another vision where Yahweh wants a spirit to persuade Ahab to attack Ramoth Gilead. Yahweh says Ahab will die if Ahab attacks Ramoth Gilead. A spirit agrees to deceive the king. Micaiah tells the king and everyone around the king that Yahweh put a spirit in the prophets to speak false prophecies. Zedekiah slaps and insults Micaiah. Micaiah says Zedekiah will understand one day in the future when Zedekiah hides away in an inner room.

In the fifth scene: The king of Israel orders people to take Micaiah back to Amon and Joash, and for Amon and Joash to put Micaiah in prison with basic food and water until the king of Israel returns from attacking Ramoth Gilead. Micaiah says if the king returns, Yahweh did not speak through Micaiah and warns everyone to listen to the prophecy.

The characters in this passage are:

- King of Israel
- Jehoshaphat, king of Judah
- 400 prophets
- Zedekiah, son of Kenaanah
- A messenger
- Micaiah
- Yahweh
- Heavenly beings
- A spirit, one of the heavenly beings
- And the king of Israel's officials

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

This story follows immediately after the previous story, when all the prophets prophesied that the kings would be successful if the kings attacked Ramoth Gilead. The two kings are now sitting together outside the gates of Samaria at an open space where the people of Samaria can thresh or beat their grain. The kings are wearing special clothes and sitting on special seats, called thrones. We do not know how much time has passed between the first time the prophets gathered and this time at the threshing floor. All the prophets make a lot of noise and dance and chant as they prophesy. One prophet is called Zedekiah. Zedekiah has made two horns from iron. Zedekiah says that Yahweh has a message. When Zedekiah says "you," it is only to one person, the king of Israel. As a bull gores with its horns, so will the king of Israel push or gore the men of Aram until the king destroys them.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a bull with horns if needed. Pause this audio here.

At the threshing floor, in front of the kings, all the prophets are saying similar things. All the prophets tell the king of Israel to attack Ramoth Gilead and win. Yahweh will give Ramoth Gilead into the hand or the power of the king of Israel. The prophets use polite language and do not address the king directly. The prophets do not tell Jehoshaphat to attack.

A messenger for the king of Israel had gone to get Micaiah and bring Micaiah to the kings. As the messenger and Micaiah are coming back to the kings, the messenger tries to give advice to Micaiah. The messenger uses special language to draw attention to the importance of what the messenger tells Micaiah. The messenger wants Micaiah to know that the words of the prophets are in one accord; all the prophets say the same thing. The

messenger wants Micaiah to say the same prophecy as the 400 prophets. The storyteller indicates that Micaiah's response will not be what the messenger wants to hear. Micaiah will not agree with the messenger. Micaiah uses a strong promise to say that Micaiah will only say what Micaiah's God tells Micaiah to say.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What words or phrases do you use to make a strong promise or oath that you will do something? Pause this audio here.

Micaiah comes to the king of Israel. The king of Israel asks the same question to Micaiah as he asked the 400 prophets. Micaiah tells the king to go up, to attack and be victorious or win. Micaiah says Ramoth Gilead will be given into the king's hand or his power. Micaiah uses words that mean the opposite of what Micaiah seems to say. Usually, a person talks like this to mock or insult someone. The king hears how Micaiah talks and is frustrated with Micaiah.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you use your voice tone and body language to obviously show your audience that you are saying something that is not true or that you do not believe is correct? Try out saying things to each other in this way. Pause this audio here.

The king uses the question, "How many times must I make you swear to only tell the truth?" to say how the king feels about Micaiah.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Have one person pretend to be frustrated with another person in the group and use questions to express how they feel about something the person has done. An example might be for the person to say, "How many times do I need to ask you to put away your clothes?" or "Why do you always forget to do what I ask?" Notice if you use questions to show that frustration or if you show frustration in another way. Pause this audio here.

Micaiah then speaks about a vision from Yahweh. Micaiah saw the people of Israel scattered on the hills. The people are not together in one group but spread out. Micaiah says the people were like sheep without a shepherd. Yahweh told Micaiah that the people have no master or leader. Yahweh said to let each person go home in peace. When a person goes somewhere in peace, that person does not fight and is safe.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How can you help people to understand that Micaiah is describing a vision that Yahweh gave to Micaiah rather than something that is actually happening in the story? Pause this audio here.

After Micaiah tells the king of Israel about the vision, the king of Israel speaks to Jehoshaphat, king of Judah. The king of Israel speaks about Micaiah. The king of Israel does not expect Jehoshaphat to answer the question, "Did I not tell you that Micaiah never prophesies anything good about me?"

Micaiah gives another prophecy. We do not know if the story of Micaiah giving this prophecy follows immediately from the story before, or if it is a completely different time Micaiah gave a prophecy to the king of Israel. We do not know when Micaiah saw the second vision. Micaiah tells the people listening to hear the word or the message from Yahweh. In Micaiah's vision, Yahweh sits on his throne. There are heavenly beings around Yahweh on the left and right of Yahweh. Micaiah describes the group of heavenly beings as a group that contains many, many beings. The heavenly beings serve Yahweh and do what Yahweh wants to be done. Yahweh asks all the heavenly beings if one of the beings will go to persuade Ahab to attack the people in Ramoth Gilead using words or actions that are not true. But Yahweh says Ahab will die if Ahab attacks Ramoth Gilead.

Micaiah uses special language to say the heavenly beings speak and that each being says a different thing. Each being says a different response to Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your language, how would you describe it when lots of people talk at one time and give different responses to a question? Pause this audio here.

Then one of the beings, a spirit, moves to be in front of Yahweh. The spirit is a heavenly being, not the Holy Spirit or a demon. The spirit says that it will persuade Ahab to attack Ramoth Gilead. Yahweh asks the spirit how the spirit will persuade Ahab. The spirit tells Yahweh that it will go from heaven to Ahab's prophets in Israel. In Israel, the spirit will make all Ahab's prophets say lies. Yahweh tells the spirit that the spirit will be successful and to go persuade Ahab.

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Micaiah tells the king of Israel and the other people listening to Micaiah that the spirit came to the prophets. The spirit made the prophets say untrue prophecies. Yahweh has decided that other nations will destroy and kill the king of Israel. Zedekiah, the son of Kenaanah, is one of the people listening to Micaiah. Zedekiah moves close to Micaiah and slaps or hits Micaiah in the face. A person slaps another person with an open hand, and it makes a loud noise when the hand hits the face.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What different words do you use when one person hits another person in the face? Pause this audio here.

Zedekiah uses a question to insult Micaiah. Zedekiah asks how the spirit from Yahweh went from Zedekiah to Micaiah. Zedekiah questions why Yahweh would speak to Micaiah and not Zedekiah. Micaiah replies to Zedekiah to say that Zedekiah will know the answer to Zedekiah's question one day in the future. Zedekiah will know when he goes to hide away from people in a room away from the outside walls of the city or building. We do not know when Zedekiah knows the answer to his question or what happens to Zedekiah at that time.

After Micaiah tells the king of Israel about the visions, the king of Israel is angry. The king of Israel tells his officials to take hold of Micaiah and take Micaiah back to Amon and Joash. The king of Israel tells the people who hold Micaiah to give a message to Amon and Joash. The king of Israel uses special words to show that what follows is a royal command for Amon and Joash. The king wants Amon and Joash to put Micaiah in prison and only give Micaiah small amounts of bread and water to eat and drink. The king wants Micaiah to only have enough bread and water to keep Micaiah alive.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How would you describe the amount of food that Amon and Joash will give to Micaiah in prison? Pause this audio here.

The king wants Micaiah to be in prison until the king comes back safely after fighting the Arameans. Micaiah speaks to the king of Israel to say that if the king comes back, Yahweh did not speak through Micaiah. Micaiah then speaks to everybody to tell everybody to hear or remember what Micaiah said.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How would you tell a large group of people to listen carefully and remember something that you say? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 18: 9–27 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has five scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- King of Israel
- Jehoshaphat, king of Judah
- 400 prophets
- Zedekiah, son of Kenaanah
- A messenger
- Micaiah
- Yahweh
- Heavenly beings
- A spirit, one of the heavenly beings
- And the king of Israel's officials

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

As the kings wait for Micaiah to arrive, the two kings sit outside the city of Samaria with many prophets in front of them. One of the prophets, Zedekiah, has iron horns like a bull. Zedekiah says Yahweh says the kings will defeat the Arameans with the iron horns. The prophets make a loud noise and tell the kings to attack Aram at Ramoth Gilead because the kings will win the battle.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Jehoshaphat, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- What a noise and strange sight. Are these men speaking from Yahweh or something else? or
- This man, Zedekiah, is sure that Israel will win the battle; or
- I need to hear from a prophet who speaks messages from Yahweh.

Ask the person playing the king of Israel, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- All these prophets are saying the same thing. These prophets must be right! or
- I feel excited and very important. Zedekiah says that I will win if I fight at Ramoth Gilead; or
- Look at the iron horns that Zedekiah wears! I will push back and hurt the Arameans like a bull pushes and hurts people.

Ask the person playing Zedekiah, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- Look at me! I know that Israel will be strong and dangerous like a bull; or
- Listen to me and my message. It is time for Israel to take back Ramoth Gilead; or
- The other prophets say the same as me. I feel powerful and excited.

Continue the drama.

The messenger tells Micaiah to give the king the same prophecy as the other prophets. Micaiah says he will say what Yahweh tells Micaiah to say.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the messenger, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am worried that Micaiah will make the king angry; or
- I hope Micaiah will give a good prophecy like the other prophets; or
- I do not think Micaiah will please my king today.

Ask the person playing Micaiah, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I know that I will make the king angry again; or
- I want to be faithful to Yahweh; or
- Yahweh, please give me your words to speak today.

Continue the drama.

Micaiah says the false prophecy, but the king of Israel knows Micaiah is not giving a prophecy from Yahweh. Micaiah speaks about a vision from Yahweh where Micaiah sees Israelites who have lost their leader. The king of Israel is angry.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Micaiah, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I know that these words are not true. All of your prophets are telling you lies; or
- I am worried and sad because I can see that my king will die; or

- Thank you, Yahweh, for showing me your vision and giving me the words to tell the king.

Ask the person playing the king of Israel, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I do not like Micaiah; or
- I want to hear what Yahweh thinks; or
- This is what I expected. Now I feel angry and frustrated; or
- Micaiah is embarrassing me in front of Jehoshaphat.

Ask the person playing Jehoshaphat, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- This will be interesting. Is Micaiah a prophet from Yahweh or just like all the other prophets? or
- Micaiah is making his king angry. I want to hear from Yahweh; or
- I feel relieved. This man is a prophet of Yahweh.

Continue the drama.

Micaiah speaks about another vision where Yahweh wants a spirit to persuade Ahab to attack Ramoth Gilead. Yahweh says Ahab will die if Ahab attacks Ramoth Gilead. A spirit agrees to deceive the king. Micaiah tells the king and everyone around the king that Yahweh put a spirit in the prophets to speak false prophecies. Zedekiah slaps and insults Micaiah. Micaiah says Zedekiah will understand one day in the future when Zedekiah hides away in an inner room.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Micaiah, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am scared, but I must tell the king about my vision from Yahweh; or
- I know telling this truth offends everyone; or
- Zedekiah hates me; or
- One day, Zedekiah will know everything that he has done wrong; or
- I feel sorry for Zedekiah. Zedekiah will be afraid, and I hope he asks Yahweh for help.

Ask the person playing Yahweh, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- Here is a final test for Ahab. I know Ahab will fail and people will kill him; or
- Here are my words for Ahab and his people; or
- I am pleased with Micaiah, who speaks the truth and brings my warning to Ahab.

Ask the person playing the heavenly beings, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- We are here to serve Yahweh; or
- How can we persuade Ahab? What is the best way to tempt Ahab to attack Ramoth Gilead?

Ask the person playing the spirit, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I have a good idea and know how I can entice Ahab; or
- I am sad to know that I will be successful; or
- It is always good to do what Yahweh wants.

Ask the person playing Zedekiah, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I feel horrified. How can Micaiah say this about all of us? or
- I am so angry with Micaiah; or
- What does Micaiah mean? What day will come when I hide somewhere?

Continue the drama.

The king of Israel orders people to take Micaiah back to Amon and Joash, and for Amon and Joash to put Micaiah into prison with basic food and water until the king of Israel returns from attacking Ramoth Gilead. Micaiah says if the king returns, Yahweh did not speak through Micaiah and warns everyone to listen to the prophecy.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the king of Israel, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- Micaiah has gone too far. How can Micaiah say that all my prophets lied to me? or
- I do not believe Micaiah; or
- I have heard enough. Micaiah makes me angry; or
- I hope Micaiah suffers while I go to fight Ramoth Gilead.

Ask the person playing the king of Israel's officials, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Micaiah has offended our king; or
- We must tell Amon and Joash the king's punishment of Micaiah; or
- We are pleased to take Micaiah to be punished.

Ask the person playing Micaiah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I knew the king would be angry; or
- I feel relieved that I spoke the truth, but I am frightened; or
- Everyone will know that I spoke the truth when the king dies at Ramoth Gilead.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 18:9–27 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

The **kings** of **Israel** and **Judah** sit on their **thrones** and wear **royal robes**. Use the same words or phrases for king, Israel, Judah, throne, royal, and robes as you used in previous passages. For more information on king, Israel, Judah, and robe, refer to the Master Glossary.

The kings are at the threshing floor, the open space for people to separate grains from the outer parts of the plant.

Stop here and look at a picture of people using a threshing floor to separate wheat grains from other parts of the plant. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **threshing floor**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The threshing floor is next to the entrance **gate** of the city. Use the same word or phrase for "gate of the city" as you used in previous passages.

The **prophets** are **prophesying**. Use the same words or phrases for prophets and prophesy as you used in previous passages. For more information on prophets and prophesy, refer to the Master Glossary.

Zedekiah made **iron** horns. Zedekiah made from iron two horns like the horns on a bull. Use the same word or phrase for iron as you used in previous passages. The horns were not musical instruments.

Stop here and look at a picture of a bull with horns. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **horns**. For more information about horns, refer to the Master Glossary. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Zedekiah tells the kings that Yahweh says the kings will gore or badly wound the **Arameans** with the horns. Use the same word or phrase for Arameans as you used in previous passages, and remember that another word for Arameans is Syrians.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **gore**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Yahweh will give Ramoth Gilead into the king's **hand** or into the king's power. Yahweh is God's personal name. Use the same words or phrases for Yahweh and "into the king's hand" as you used in previous passages.

The **messenger** spoke to Micaiah. Use the same word or phrase for messenger as you used in previous passages.

Micaiah will only say what **God** says to Micaiah. Use the same word or phrase for God as you used in previous passages. For more information on God, refer to the Master Glossary.

Micaiah uses the words "**As surely as the Yahweh lives**," as a promise or oath.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrase you will use for this phrase. Look up **oath** in the Master Glossary. If you have already translated this phrase in another book of the Bible, use the same phrase that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Micaiah says he saw the people of Israel scattered on the hills. The people were spread out over the hill.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **scattered**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The people looked like **sheep** without a shepherd. Use the same word or phrase for sheep as you used in previous passages. A shepherd is a person who protects and cares for sheep.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **shepherd**. Look up shepherd in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Each person can go home in **peace**. The people can go home without fighting and be safe. Use the same word or phrase for peace as you used in previous passages. For more information on peace, refer to the Master Glossary.

Micaiah tells the people to hear the **word** of Yahweh. Micaiah wants the people to hear Yahweh's message. Use the same word or phrase for word as you used in previous passages. For more information on word, refer to the Master Glossary.

The host of heaven is around Yahweh. The host of heaven is the heavenly beings who do Yahweh's work.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **host of heaven**. Look up **heaven** in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this phrase in another book of the Bible, use the same word or phrase that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

A spirit came to Yahweh. The spirit is a supernatural being that Yahweh created who lives in heaven with Yahweh. This spirit is not the Holy Spirit, and it is not evil.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **spirit**. Look up spirit in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Zedekiah is the **son** of Kenaanah. Use the same word or phrase for son as you used in previous passages. For more information on son, refer to the Master Glossary.

Zedekiah slapped Micaiah in the face.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **slapped**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Zedekiah will one day hide in an **inner room**. An inner room is a safe place inside a building. Use the same word or phrase for "inner room" as you used in previous passages.

Amon is the **governor** of the city. A governor is a senior official in charge of a city. Use the same word or phrase for governor as you used in previous passages.

The king of Israel wants Amon to put Micaiah in prison. A prison is a solid building that stops a person who is inside the building from going outside the building.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **prison**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The king of Israel wants Micaiah to have a small amount of simple food to eat, like **bread** and water. Use the same word or phrase for bread as you used in previous passages.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

2 Chronicles 18:9–27

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (968 KB)
- Setting the Stage (11.1 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (9.5 MB)
- Embodying the Text (6.6 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (5.4 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

2 Chronicles 18:28–34

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 18:28–34 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 18:28–34 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 18:28–34 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

This passage finishes the story about Jehoshaphat's visit to the king of Israel. You will remember that the king of Israel in this story is probably Ahab. In this story, the storyteller does not name the king of Israel. You will remember that the king of Israel wants to attack the Arameans at Ramoth Gilead. Micaiah the prophet told the king of Israel that if the king attacked the Arameans, the king would die.

After the kings hear Micaiah's message from Yahweh, the kings ignore the prophecy and go to attack the Arameans at Ramoth Gilead. Syria is another name for Aram. The Aramean people are the same people as the Syrian people. The storyteller uses the story from 1 Kings to retell the story in this book of 2 Chronicles. There are a few differences between this story in 2 Chronicles and the earlier story in 1 Kings.

Stop here and listen to your translation of the passage 1 Kings 22:29–40 in your own language, if possible. Pause this audio here.

The king of Israel and Jehoshaphat go from Samaria in Israel to Ramoth Gilead. Ramoth Gilead is about 45 kilometers northeast of Samaria. The kings go to attack the Arameans in Ramoth Gilead.

Stop here and look at a map of Israel and find the cities of Samaria and Ramoth Gilead. Pause this audio here.

The king of Israel talks to Jehoshaphat. We do not know when the conversation between the two kings happens. It might happen in Samaria or on the way to Ramoth Gilead. The king of Israel tells Jehoshaphat that he, the king of Israel, will go into the battle in disguise. The king will wear clothes and other items that do not make him look like a king. The king of Israel does not want the Arameans to recognize the king of Israel.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about a time when people or a person wore a disguise. Why did the person or people wear a disguise? Pause this audio here.

The king of Israel wants Jehoshaphat to wear royal robes in the battle. The king wants Jehoshaphat to look like a king. At Ramoth Gilead, the king of Israel puts on a disguise and starts to fight the battle. The king does not fight the Arameans alone. The king fights the battle with Jehoshaphat and soldiers from Israel and Judah.

Before the battle starts, the king of Aram gives orders or commands to his commanders or captains who ride chariots. The commanders lead the Aramean fighters in the battle and tell the fighters what to do.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Who leads the people in your army or group of fighters? What special title do these people have to show that they have authority over the other fighters? Pause this audio here.

The commanders fight from chariots. A chariot is an open, two-wheeled vehicle. Horses pull the chariot along, and a person or people ride in the chariot and fight from the chariot. A person in the chariot uses strips of leather that go from the horses' heads to the person's hands to guide the horses. The strips of leather are "reins." A soldier in a chariot moves quickly in battle.

Stop here and look at a picture of a soldier in a chariot with horses. Pause this audio here.

The king of Aram tells the commanders not to fight with anybody who is not the king of Israel. The king of Aram does not want the commanders to fight with everyone—not the small, ordinary soldiers or the great, important army commanders from Israel—but only with the king of Israel.

In the battle, the commanders see Jehoshaphat. Jehoshaphat looks like a king. The commanders think Jehoshaphat is the king of Israel. The commanders tell the people who drive the chariots to turn the chariots. The commanders go towards Jehoshaphat to attack Jehoshaphat. Jehoshaphat cries out or gives a shout. We do not know what Jehoshaphat shouts. Jehoshaphat's shout may be a call for help or a battle cry, a special phrase to call to the fighters of Judah. The shout tells the Arameans that they are about to fight the wrong person.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about the battle cries that your people use now or in the past to encourage each other in battles. How do the battle cries help to identify the people fighting in the battle? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller tells us that Yahweh helps Jehoshaphat. The storyteller says God makes the Aramean soldiers move away from Jehoshaphat. When the commanders hear Jehoshaphat, the commanders know that Jehoshaphat is not the king of Israel. Now, the commanders do not follow or try to fight Jehoshaphat.

People continue to battle. An Aramean soldier draws his bow. The soldier pulls back on the bow string and fires an arrow from the bow into the battle.

Stop here and look at a picture of a man drawing a bow to fire an arrow. Pause this audio here.

The soldier does not know that the soldier hit the king of Israel with the arrow. The Aramean soldier hit the king of Israel by chance.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about a time when something happened without a person meaning to make it happen or possibly by accident. Pause this audio here.

The arrow hit the king of Israel between the pieces of the king's armor. People wear armor to protect themselves in a battle. People make armor from hard leather or flat or shaped pieces of metal. People connect the armor together with straps. There are small gaps between the pieces of armor. A breastplate is a special piece of armor that covers a person's chest.

Stop here and look at a picture of a soldier with armor. Notice the pieces of armor, the breastplate, and the gaps between the different pieces or sections of armor. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What do your soldiers wear to protect their bodies during a battle? How do your soldiers connect the different pieces of armor together? Which areas of the body does armor not protect? Pause this audio here.

The king of Israel is in a chariot. Another person drives the chariot for the king of Israel. The king of Israel tells the driver to use the driver's hands to pull on the reins to the horses to turn the chariot around.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Have one person pretend to be a horse, and another person pretend to drive the horse. Take two long pieces of string, rope, or fabric and give one pair of ends to the "horse" and another pair of ends to the "driver." Have the "driver" pull on one string to turn the "horse" to one side. Then use the other string to turn the "horse" to the other side. Pause this audio here.

The driver takes the king in the chariot away from the people fighting the battle. The king tells his driver that the king is wounded and hurt. The battle continues as people fight each other. The king of Israel stays in his chariot. The king uses the chariot to support his body to stay upright. The king of Israel looks towards the Arameans in the battle.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Find a cup or something similar to use as a chariot. Now get something about the length and width of your thumb and place it in the cup. Find a way to make your item stay upright in the cup. What do you need to make it stay upright and facing one way? Pause this audio here.

The king watches the battle until the end of the day. The king of Israel dies at sunset as the sun goes down.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 18:28–34 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has six scenes.

In the first scene: The king of Israel and Jehoshaphat, the king of Judah, go to attack Ramoth Gilead. The king of Israel tells Jehoshaphat to wear royal robes in the battle, but the king of Israel will wear a disguise.

In the second scene: The king of Israel puts on a disguise and attacks Ramoth Gilead.

In the third scene: Before the battle, the king of Aram tells his chariot commanders to only fight the king of Israel.

In the fourth scene: In the battle, the chariot commanders see Jehoshaphat and attack Jehoshaphat. Jehoshaphat shouts for help. Yahweh helps Jehoshaphat and leads the Arameans away. The Arameans realize it is not the king of Israel and stop chasing Jehoshaphat.

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In the fifth scene: An Aramean soldier fires an arrow from his bow into the battle. The arrow hits and hurts the king of Israel. The king's chariot driver takes the king away from the battle.

In the sixth scene: The king uses his chariot to hold himself up to watch the battle. The king dies at sunset.

The characters in this passage are:

- King of Israel
- Jehoshaphat
- King of Aram
- Chariot commanders
- Yahweh
- Aramean soldier
- The king of Israel's chariot driver
- And the armies of Judah, Israel, and Aram

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In this passage, the storyteller continues the story of the king of Israel and Jehoshaphat. The king of Israel and Jehoshaphat go up to Ramoth Gilead to attack the Arameans at the city. Before the battle, the king of Israel talks to Jehoshaphat about the battle plan. The king of Israel will wear a disguise when the king goes into the battle. The king of Israel wants Jehoshaphat to wear royal robes. The storyteller then tells us that the king of Israel puts on a disguise and goes to fight the Arameans at Ramoth Gilead.

In the next scene, the storyteller tells us about the king of Aram's plan. Before the battle, the king of Aram gives an order to his chariot commanders. The king does not want the commanders to fight with anyone except the king of Israel. The king of Aram uses the special phrase "small or great" to mean everyone.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What words or phrases do you use to mean everyone who is in a place or at an event? Pause this audio here.

At the battle at Ramoth Gilead, the chariot commanders obey the order from the king of Aram and look for the king of Israel. The commanders see Jehoshaphat and think that Jehoshaphat is the king of Israel. The commanders turn or move to attack Jehoshaphat. Jehoshaphat shouts or cries out. Yahweh hears and helps Jehoshaphat. God moves the Aramean commanders away from Jehoshaphat. The chariot commanders hear Jehoshaphat and know that Jehoshaphat is not the king of Israel. The chariot commanders stop chasing after Jehoshaphat.

In another part of the battle, an Aramean soldier draws or pulls the string of his bow back to fire an arrow.

Stop here and look at a picture of a man drawing a bow to fire an arrow, if needed. Pause this audio here.

The soldier releases the arrow into the battle. The soldier's arrow strikes the king of Israel by chance. The soldier does not plan to hit the king of Israel with the arrow.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you describe something that happens by chance? Pause this audio here.

The soldier's arrow hits the king of Israel between the pieces of the king's armor and the king's breastplate.

Stop here and look at a picture of a soldier with armor, if needed. Pause this audio here.

After the arrow hits and hurts the king of Israel, the king of Israel tells his chariot driver to turn the chariot around. The king wants the driver to turn the chariot away from the battle and drive the chariot to a place away from the fighting.

The battle lasts all day, and people fight hard all day.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Talk about how fighting in a battle can change from being less intense to more intense. Notice how you describe soldiers fighting more and harder with each other. Pause this audio here.

The king of Israel stays in his chariot. The king uses the chariot to help stay upright in the chariot and look at the Arameans in the battle. The king of Israel uses the chariot for support.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about a time someone needed to use an object to help to keep standing upright. Notice what words you use to describe how the person used the object to help them stand. Pause this audio here.

The king of Israel dies at sunset.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 18:28–34 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has six scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- King of Israel
- Jehoshaphat
- King of Aram
- Chariot commanders
- Yahweh
- Aramean soldier
- The king of Israel's chariot driver
- And the armies of Judah, Israel, and Aram

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

The king of Israel and Jehoshaphat, the king of Judah, go to attack Ramoth Gilead. The king of Israel tells Jehoshaphat to wear royal robes in the battle, but the king of Israel will wear a disguise.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the king of Israel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I want Ramoth Gilead back. I do not care about Micaiah's prophecies; or
- I am feeling clever. I will hide, and the Arameans will not find me; or
- Jehoshaphat will look like a king. The Arameans will try to kill Jehoshaphat and not me.

Ask the person playing Jehoshaphat, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I want to help the king of Israel get Ramoth Gilead back from the king of Aram; or
- It is very strange that the king of Israel does not want to look like a king in the battle; or
- I want my soldiers to see me and know I am with them in the battle.

Continue the drama.

The king of Israel puts on a disguise and attacks Ramoth Gilead.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the king of Israel, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- The Arameans cannot see where I am; or
- I will be safer in ordinary clothes; or
- It is time to get my city back.

Continue the drama.

Before the battle, the king of Aram tells his chariot commanders to only fight the king of Israel.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the king of Aram, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I want the king of Israel to be dead; or
- My best fighters must look out for the king of Israel.

Ask the person playing the chariot commanders, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- We are proud to serve our king; or
- We will find the king of Israel; or
- We will kill the king of Israel and keep Ramoth Gilead for Aram.

Continue the drama.

In the battle, the chariot commanders see Jehoshaphat and attack him. Jehoshaphat shouts for help. Yahweh helps Jehoshaphat and leads the Arameans away. The Arameans realize it is not the king of Israel and stop chasing Jehoshaphat.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the chariot commanders, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- We can see the king! Let us go and kill the king; or
- We think we are wrong. The person does not sound like the king of Israel; or
- Turn away! We will not chase this person. We need to find the king of Israel.

Ask the person playing Jehoshaphat, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I want to help Israel get back Ramoth Gilead; or
- Attack the Arameans! or
- Come and help me! or
- Why did those soldiers turn away from me? Maybe Yahweh heard me!

Ask the person playing Yahweh, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I hear Jehoshaphat. Jehoshaphat wants help; or
- I do not want Jehoshaphat to die today; or
- Come away from that man. That man is not the king of Israel.

Continue the drama.

An Aramean soldier fires an arrow from his bow into the battle. The arrow hits and hurts the king of Israel. The king’s chariot driver takes the king away from the battle.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Aramean soldier, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I will defend Ramoth Gilead; or
- There are so many Israelites that I do not need to aim; or
- I wonder if my arrows are stopping Israelites?

Ask the person playing the king of Israel, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I have been hit by an arrow! I need to leave the battle and go somewhere safe; or

2 Chronicles 18:28–34

- I feel worried. I am bleeding a lot.

Ask the person playing the king of Israel's chariot driver, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I will take my king out of the battle; or
- I am worried about my king. The arrow has hurt my king.

Continue the drama.

The king uses his chariot to hold himself up in his chariot to watch the battle. The king dies at sunset.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the king of Israel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I want to watch the battle, but I feel weak and cannot stand up; or
- I can see my blood around my feet; or
- Yahweh was right, I am going to die today; or
- I should have listened to Micaiah.

Ask the person playing the armies of Judah, Israel, and Aram, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We will fight to win back Ramoth Gilead for Israel; or
- Keep fighting, our king is watching us; or
- Keep fighting. The sun is going down, and we will win today.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 18:28–34 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

The **king** of **Israel** and the king of **Judah** went to attack Ramoth Gilead. Use the same words or phrases for king, Israel, and Judah as you used in previous passages. For more information on king, Israel, and Judah, refer to the Master Glossary.

The king of Israel wears a disguise.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **disguise**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Jehoshaphat wears **royal robes**. Use the same word or phrase for royal robes as you used in previous passages. For more information on robes, refer to the Master Glossary.

The king of **Aram** gives orders to his **chariot commanders**. Use the same words or phrases for Aram or Syria, chariot, and commanders as you used in previous passages.

Yahweh helps Jehoshaphat. Yahweh is God's personal name. Use the same word for Yahweh as you used in previous passages, and look up Yahweh in the Master Glossary if needed.

God made the chariot commanders move away from Jehoshaphat. Use the same word for God as you used in previous passages and look up God in the Master Glossary if needed.

Someone "drew his bow." The man pulled back on the string of the bow and shot an arrow.

Stop here and look at a picture of a man drawing a bow to fire an arrow, if needed. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrase you will use for **drew his bow**. If you have already translated this phrase in another book of the Bible, use the same words or phrase that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The arrow hit the king of Israel between the sections or pieces of his armor and his breastplate. A breastplate is a special piece of armor that covers a person's chest.

Stop here and look at a picture of a soldier with armor, if needed. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **armor**. If you have already translated this phrase in another book of the Bible, use the same words or phrase that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **breastplate**. If you have already translated this phrase in another book of the Bible, use the same words or phrase that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The king spoke to his chariot driver. The chariot driver is the person who guides the horses that pull the chariot.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **driver**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

2 Chronicles 20:20–30

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 20:20–30 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 20:20–30 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 20:20–30 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

This story is about Yahweh fighting the battle for Judah when three enemy armies try to attack Jerusalem.

You will remember in the previous story that Yahweh answered Jehoshaphat's prayer. Yahweh gave a message through the Levite Jahaziel that Yahweh would fight the battle for the people of Judah. Yahweh told the people to go out and meet the enemy armies the next day, to stand still and watch Yahweh fight the battle for Judah. Then the people of Judah bowed down and worshiped Yahweh.

This story begins the next day with the faithful obedience of the people of Judah. Judah's army gathers early in the morning. Just before the army marches, Jehoshaphat encourages the people of Judah to believe that Yahweh will give Judah success. Jehoshaphat is reminding the people what Yahweh said about this particular situation. The main idea of the story is not the amount of faith the people had, but Yahweh's love that never ends and Yahweh's great power.

Something special happens here. Usually, kings send armies with weapons to fight. But Jehoshaphat does something different. Jehoshaphat asks his people for advice, and then Jehoshaphat puts singers in front of the army. These singers do not shout war cries. Instead, the singers sing praise songs to Yahweh.

The singers use words from well-known praise songs: "Give thanks to Yahweh, because His steadfast love continues forever." The people thank Yahweh because Yahweh always keeps his promises to Yahweh's people. You may remember that the Levite singers sang this song when David brought the ark of the covenant to Jerusalem. The Levites also sang this song when people dedicated the temple. The singers also praise Yahweh's holy splendor. The singers praise how perfect and pure Yahweh is, different from everyone else.

[Stop and discuss: What kinds of songs do people in your community sing, especially during celebrations? Sing a song that many people know and can sing at different times. Pause this audio here.]{.mark}

At the same time that the singers begin to praise Yahweh, Yahweh sets an ambush that defeats the armies. An ambush occurs when one person attacks another when the second person does not expect anyone to attack. Yahweh does not use the army of Judah to set the ambush. Yahweh uses the three different armies to defeat each other. The armies of Moab and Ammon attack and destroy the army of Mount Seir. Then the armies of Moab and Ammon destroy each other. The army of Judah arrives at the place on the edge of the wilderness where Yahweh told Judah to wait and look. The army of Judah looks out into the valley toward the enemy armies. Yahweh has already defeated the armies. There are only dead bodies. No one had escaped.

[The people of Judah take the plunder or spoils of the enemy armies. The people of Judah find many things among the dead armies—weapons, clothes, and valuable items. It takes the people of Judah three days to gather everything. Sometimes Yahweh told his people not to take things from defeated enemies. Other times, Yahweh allowed or celebrated it. Here, Yahweh does not stop the people.]{.mark}

[Stop and think about what armies carry into battle. What supplies does an army need? Or think about a long trip that you have taken. What things did you take with you? In your culture, what reward or prize does the winner of a battle or other contest receive? In a battle, who do the dead soldier's possessions belong to? Pause the audio here.]{.mark}

On the fourth day, the army assembles in a valley near Tekoa to praise Yahweh and march back to Jerusalem. That is why from that point onward, people called the valley by the name "Beracah," which means "to bless, or say good things."

[The army and singers return to Jerusalem with joy. The people play music to praise Yahweh. The people use three kinds of instruments. Harps are big instruments with many strings that players pluck with fingers. Lyres are smaller instruments with strings that players also pluck. Trumpets are long metal tubes that players blow into to make loud sounds. The people use these instruments to show their joy and praise to Yahweh. At other times, the people might play these same instruments for other occasions that were not religious.]{.mark}

Stop here and look at pictures of an ancient harp, lyre, and metal trumpet. Discuss the different kinds of instruments that you have in your community. Which instruments have strings? Which instruments do people play by blowing into the instrument to make a sound? Pause the audio here.

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When the other nations hear about how Yahweh fought the enemies of Judah, the fear of God came upon those nations. The fear of God sometimes refers to "awe and respect" rather than fear. But in this context, the other nations were terrified. When the fear of Yahweh comes upon those nations, the fear [suddenly fills them completely. It is like something powerful covering the nations or taking control of them. Fear controls everything those nations do. The nations cannot escape this fear. When the nations hear about Yahweh's power, the nations have this kind of strong fear.]{.mark}

[Jehoshaphat's kingdom was at peace. No enemies attack from any direction. The nations around Judah are afraid of Yahweh's power. The nations remember how Yahweh destroyed the huge armies. This is what Jehoshaphat prayed for in the previous story. Yahweh rules over all nations. No one can stand against Yahweh. Yahweh keeps his promises to Yahweh's people.]{.mark}

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 20:20–30 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four scenes.

In the first scene: The army of Judah assembles to march to the battle. The army is full of faith, and singers lead the army as they praise Yahweh.

In the second scene: Before the enemy armies reach the army of Judah, the enemy armies begin to fight against each other, so that the armies slaughter each other.

In the third scene: Judah's army arrives in the wilderness and finds all of the enemy soldiers dead on the ground. Judah is able to take so much valuable plunder that the people are there for three days.

In the fourth scene: Judah's army and the singers gather in the Valley of Beracah to praise God and march back to Jerusalem in joyous victory.

The characters in this passage are:

- Yahweh
- King Jehoshaphat
- The people of Judah and Jerusalem
- The singers and musicians
- The army of Judah
- The armies of the Moabites, Ammonites, and people from Mount Seir
- And the kingdoms of the lands

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

Before this part of the story, King Jehoshaphat called the people to fast and pray at the temple in Jerusalem because three enemy armies were coming to attack Judah. Yahweh answered by saying that Yahweh would fight for the people, and Judah just needed to trust Yahweh and go to the wilderness near Tekoa to watch what Yahweh would do.

In the first scene, early the next morning, Judah's army gathers to march to the wilderness of Tekoa, which is about 16 kilometers from Jerusalem. The enemy armies are coming north to Tekoa from Hazazon Tamar. Judah's army is marching south from Jerusalem to meet the enemy armies.

Stop and look at a map of Judah that includes Tekoa and Jerusalem, Moab, Ammon, and Mount Seir. Notice where the armies are coming from as they go toward each other in Tekoa. Pause the audio here.

As the people of Judah leave Jerusalem, King Jehoshaphat stops and speaks to the people. Jehoshaphat tells everyone to trust Yahweh and believe Yahweh's prophets. Jehoshaphat promises the people that if they do, the people will win the battle.

Jehoshaphat then talks with the people and chooses singers to go in front of the army. These singers lead the way, singing and praising Yahweh as the army marches toward the wilderness of Tekoa. The storyteller does not tell us who these singers are. Most people believe that the singers and musicians are men from the Korahite and Kohathite clans of Levi. These Levites were responsible for worship music in the temple. However, it is possible that Jehoshaphat also chose men from the army to sing.

In the original language, the storyteller describes that the singers sang in holy clothing or beauty. The meaning of "holy clothing" or "holy beauty" is unclear. Some translations say that the appointed singers were to praise Yahweh in the splendor of his holiness, or to praise Yahweh for his majestic beauty and holiness. Other translations say that the appointed singers were praising Yahweh while dressed in holy clothing, showing that the singers were Levites.

[Stop and discuss:]{.mark} What version of this part of the passage have you heard before? Which version would people in your area be familiar with? Discuss how you want to translate this part. We recommend that you use the accepted translation in your area. Pause this audio here.

The singers sang some well-known psalms or praise songs: "Give thanks to Yahweh, because His steadfast love continues forever." You remember that the Levite singers sang this song when David brought the ark of the covenant to Jerusalem. The Levites also sang this song when the people dedicated the temple. This song is also the chorus or repeated portion of Psalm 136. If you have already translated one of these passages into your language, use the same translation here.

[Stop and discuss: If you have already translated one of these passages, listen to your recording of one of these passages in your language:]{.mark}

- [The story of David bringing the ark of the covenant to Jerusalem in 1 Chronicles 16:34; or]{.mark}
- [The story of the dedication of the Temple in 2 Chronicles 5:13; or]{.mark}
- [Psalm 136:1.]{.mark}

[Pause this audio here.]{.mark}

In the second scene, as soon as the singers begin to praise Yahweh in Jerusalem, Yahweh sets an ambush that defeats the armies. An ambush occurs when one person attacks another when the second person does not expect anyone to attack. Yahweh does not use the army of Judah to set the ambush. Yahweh uses the three different armies to defeat each other. Yahweh causes confusion among the enemy armies in the wilderness. The armies of Moab and Ammon turn against the army from Mount Seir and fight and kill all of its soldiers. The army from Mount Seir is the Meunites. After that, the armies of Moab and Ammon start fighting each other until they are all destroyed. While this is happening, the army of Judah is still marching to the place Yahweh told them to go, ready to watch Yahweh fight for Judah. The army of Judah is too far away to know what is happening among the enemy armies.

[Stop and discuss: Tell part of a story about things starting at the same time in different places. Maybe morning activities that begin in several villages when the sun rises, or work that starts in different fields when the morning birds sing. Pay attention to how the storyteller connects these events. How will you translate the idea that the singing in Jerusalem began at the exact moment the fighting started in the wilderness? Pause the audio here.]{.mark}

In the third scene, the army of Judah comes to a watchtower or overlook at the edge of the wilderness. [A watchtower or lookout tower was a tall building where people could stand and look far into the distance. People build a watchtower high up, often on a hill, mountain, or city gate. Guards in the watchtower could see enemies coming from far away. The guards could warn the people to get ready. In this story, the watchtower was in the wilderness, probably on high ground where guards could see across the desert. We do not know if this was an actual watchtower building or an area people used as a lookout point.]{.mark}

Stop and look at a picture of a watchtower. Discuss how you might translate watchtower or lookout point in your language. If possible, translate this watchtower in a general way, where it can mean a building or a natural area where people can look out from. Pause the audio here.

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From the watchtower, men from Judah's army see that all the enemy soldiers in the wilderness of Tekoa are dead. Judah's army did not have to fight. Judah just obeyed Yahweh, marched to the place Yahweh told them, and saw what Yahweh had done to make the enemy armies destroy each other.

Then, for three days, the army of Judah collects the plunder or spoils—valuable things left by the enemy, like weapons, equipment, clothes, and other goods. There is so much plunder that the people cannot carry all the plunder back to Jerusalem.

Stop and discuss: How will you translate the idea of so much plunder from war that people cannot carry it all? [Pause the audio here.]{.mark}

In the fourth scene, it is now the fourth day. The army of Judah gathers in a valley near Tekoa to praise Yahweh. This event is so special that people start calling it the Valley of Beracah, which means the Valley of Blessing. A blessing is when someone says or wishes something good about or to another person. This reminds the people that they blessed and praised Yahweh at this place. The Valley of Beracah was near Tekoa, but we do not know the exact place.

King Jehoshaphat leads the army from the Valley of Beracah back to the temple in Jerusalem with great joy. Everyone returns to Jerusalem and goes to the temple, where the people had prayed for help four days earlier. This time, the people of Judah come to the temple singing praise to Yahweh. The storyteller lists some of the musical instruments the people played to praise Yahweh: harps, lyres, and trumpets.

All the nearby nations are now afraid of Yahweh because Yahweh fought for Israel. [Sometimes the storyteller calls the people "Israel," and sometimes the storyteller calls the people "Judah." Long ago, all 12 tribes were one nation called Israel. Later, the nation split. The northern part kept the name Israel. The southern part became the kingdom of Judah. This story happens in the southern kingdom of Judah. But sometimes the storyteller still uses the old name Israel because these are still Yahweh's special people, descended from Jacob, who was called Israel.]{.mark}

After these events, [peace comes to Jehoshaphat's kingdom. When Yahweh gives rest on every side, this means two things. First, no enemies attack from any direction—north, south, east, or west. Second, the people live quietly without worry. Yahweh makes all the nations around the people stay peaceful. This rest is Yahweh's gift to Jehoshaphat and his people.]{.mark}

[Stop and talk about how you describe this kind of peace in your community. How do people describe times when there are no threats from other nations in any direction? Pause the audio here.]{.mark}

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 20:20–30 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Yahweh
- King Jehoshaphat
- The people of Judah and Jerusalem
- The singers and musicians
- The army of Judah
- The armies of the Moabites, Ammonites, and people from Mount Seir
- And the kingdoms of the lands

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Early the next morning, the army of Judah leaves Jerusalem for the wilderness of Tekoa. Just as the army was leaving, King Jehoshaphat stood and addressed everyone. King Jehoshaphat said, "Listen to me, people of Jerusalem and Judah. Believe in Yahweh your God, and Yahweh will keep you strong in battle. Believe Yahweh's prophets, and you will be successful."

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the people of Jerusalem and Judah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" They might answer things like:

- No one can stop Yahweh our God; or
- My faith and belief are mostly strong, but I have a little bit of doubt; or
- I will keep praying.

Continue the drama.

Jehoshaphat consults with the people and then appoints singers to sing to Yahweh and to praise Yahweh for his holiness and greatness. The singers march at the front of the army as they go out. These are the singers' words: "Give thanks to Yahweh because his faithful love continues forever."

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Jeshoshaphat, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Every song and step forward is building my confidence in Yahweh; or
- Our army should march like this every time.

Ask the people playing the singers and musicians, "What are you feeling or thinking?" They might answer things like:

- I am a little nervous. We have never led the army into battle before; or
- Our hearts are full of praise. Yahweh is great and powerful. Yahweh is faithful to fight our battles for us; or
- This is a strange idea to put singers and musicians in front of the army. I will do my part, but I am not sure that it is going to help.

Continue the drama.

At the moment the singers begin to praise, Yahweh sets an ambush among the invading armies. The armies of Ammon and Moab and Mount Seir come to fight against Judah and are defeated. Here is how the armies are defeated. The Ammonite and Moabite armies attack the army of Mount Seir. Ammon and Moab completely destroy the army of Mount Seir. Then the Ammonite and Moabite armies attack and completely destroy each other.

The army of Judah comes to the place that overlooks the wilderness. The army of Judah looks out at the vast army. The army of Judah discovers that all the enemy soldiers are lying dead on the ground. Not one of the enemy soldiers has escaped.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the army of Judah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" They might answer things like:

- Our hearts are full of praise and wonder; or

- The battle is already won! or
- I thought I had faith, but even when I see what has happened, it is hard to believe what I am seeing.

Continue the drama.

So the king and his men go down to carry off the plunder. There, the men find so much equipment, clothing, and other articles of value that they are not able to carry them all back to Jerusalem. It takes the men three days to gather everything.

On the fourth day, the army of Judah gathers in a nearby valley. The army praises God in the valley. From that point onward, people begin to call that place the Valley of Beracah, which means the Valley of Blessing. Then Jehoshaphat leads all the people of Jerusalem and Judah back to Jerusalem. The army of Judah is full of joy because Yahweh has given them a reason to rejoice over the defeat of their enemies. The army enters Jerusalem and goes to the temple of Yahweh. People are praising Yahweh with harps and lyres and trumpets.

Then the surrounding kingdoms hear about how Yahweh had fought against the enemies of Israel. These kingdoms have a great fear of God. [No enemies attack from any direction. The kingdom has complete peace all around.]{.mark}

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the kingdoms near Judah, “What are you feeling or thinking?” They might answer things like:

- This God Yahweh has more power than we have; or
- We do not want to be the next kingdom to try to attack Judah; or
- Our gods have never done anything like that. Yahweh is more powerful.

Ask the person playing King Jehoshaphat, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am so happy that our hearts have turned completely to Yahweh; or
- I am thankful for the blessing of God on our people; or
- I am enjoying that there are no more battles right now.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 20:20–30 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

King Jehoshaphat tells the people of **Judah** and **Jerusalem** to have faith, or to believe in **Yahweh** their **God** and Yahweh’s **prophets**. Translate Judah, Jerusalem, Yahweh, God, and prophets as you have previously. For more information on Judah, Jerusalem, Yahweh, God, and prophets, refer to the Master Glossary.

To have faith in someone is to believe that what that person says about himself is true. You then trust that person and are committed to do what that person tells you to do.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **faith** or believe. Look up faith in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The singers praise Yahweh for the splendor of his holiness. In the original language, the storyteller describes that the singers sang in holy array or beauty. The meaning of “holy clothing” or “holy beauty” is unclear. Some translations say that the appointed singers were to praise Yahweh in the splendor of his holiness, or to praise Yahweh for his majestic beauty and holiness. Other translations say that the appointed singers were praising Yahweh while dressed in holy clothing, showing that the singers were Levites.

[Holy means Yahweh is completely different from everyone and everything else. Yahweh is pure and perfect in every way. Nothing about Yahweh is common or ordinary. Splendor means something so beautiful it shines. When

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these words come together—holy splendor—they show how Yahweh's perfect purity shines out in beautiful glory. Many songs in the Bible praise Yahweh's holy splendor.]{.mark}

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **holy beauty** or **holy clothing**. Pay attention to how the Bible in your majority language translates this portion of the passage. [Have each team member share what words or phrases people use in your language to describe something or someone that is very beautiful, special, or perfect. Talk about how you describe someone who is pure and set apart, like God.]{.mark} Look up **holy** in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Before marching to battle, Judah's singers praise Yahweh for his steadfast or loyal love, or lovingkindness, that continues forever. [Some Bibles call this "loving kindness" or "faithful kindness." This means Yahweh never stops loving and being kind to Yahweh's people. This is Yahweh's covenant love. This love is special, like a strong promise that cannot break. Yahweh made promises to take care of his people, and Yahweh always keeps these promises. Yahweh shows this love by helping and protecting Yahweh's people. This love and kindness never end.] {.mark} Translate this phrase as you have previously. For more information on **steadfast love**, refer to the Master Glossary.

Yahweh sets an **ambush** for the invading armies. An ambush is a surprise attack. An ambush is when people hide and wait for their enemies to come close, and then suddenly attack them when the enemies are not expecting it. [Yahweh made something happen that surprised the enemy armies and led to their defeat. Yahweh caused the enemy armies to turn against each other and fight among themselves. Use the same word or phrase for ambush as you used in previous passages.]{.mark}

The army of Judah comes to the watchtower or lookout area in the **wilderness**, or desert. Use the same word for wilderness that you have used previously. Wilderness is in the Master Glossary.

[A watchtower or lookout tower was a tall building where people could stand and look far into the distance. We do not know if, in this story, this was an actual watchtower building or an area people used as a lookout point.]{.mark}

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **watchtower** or lookout area. Look at a picture of a watchtower, if needed. Refer to **lookout tower** in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The army of Judah looks out over the enemy army and sees the dead enemy soldiers. Judah's army took away **plunder** from the defeated invading armies. Plunder [means valuable things like money, clothes, animals, or goods that people take from enemies after a battle. When one army wins, that army collects or takes these things from the people it defeated. Plunder is what is left behind or found after a fight, and the winners take it home. Use the same word or phrase for plunder as you used in previous passages.]{.mark}

When the people of Judah return to Jerusalem after plundering the defeated armies, they return to the **temple**, praising Yahweh with musical instruments: **harps**, **lyres**, and **trumpets**. Translate temple, harp, lyre, and trumpet as you have previously. For more information on temple, refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop here if needed, and look at pictures of a harp, lyre, and metal trumpet. Pause this audio here.

The **fear of God** came upon the neighboring nations when they heard how Yahweh had defeated the enemies of Judah. The [fear of God means that people saw how powerful and holy Yahweh is. After this miracle, the other nations were filled with fear and respect for God because they realized Yahweh is mighty and protects his people. Translate fear of God as you have previously. For more information on "fear of God," refer to the Master Glossary.]{.mark}

[When the **nations** fear God, the **kingdom** of Judah has **peace**. Peace is to live in harmony with others without fighting. Translate nation, kingdom, and peace as you have previously. For more information on nation, kingdom, and peace, refer to the Master Glossary.]{.mark}

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

2 Chronicles 20:31–37

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 20:31–37 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 20:31–37 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 20:31–37 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous story, the army of Judah marched into the wilderness of Tekoa to face the armies of the Ammonites and the Moabites, and the army of the people of Mount Seir. Jehoshaphat tells the people to trust Yahweh, their God, and the singers march in front of the army praising Yahweh. As the people sing, Yahweh makes the Ammonites and Moabites turn against the men of Mount Seir, and then the Ammonites and Moabites fight each other until no one is left. When the army of Judah arrives, they find all the enemies already dead and collect plunder for three days. Then Jehoshaphat's army returns to Jerusalem with joy, and Yahweh gives Jehoshaphat's kingdom peace.

In this story, the storyteller summarizes King Jehoshaphat's reign in Judah. A different storyteller also tells this story in 1 Kings 22:41–50.

Stop here and listen to your translation of 1 Kings 22:41–50 if you have already translated this passage. Pause this audio here.

Jehoshaphat rules the kingdom of Judah. Jehoshaphat is 35 years old when he becomes king of Judah, and Jehoshaphat rules in Jerusalem for 25 years, from about the year 872 to the year 848 before Jesus. Jehoshaphat's mother's name is Azubah. Silhi is the father of Azubah.

King Jehoshaphat follows the example of his father, Asa, and does not stop following it. Jehoshaphat does things that please Yahweh.

However, Jehoshaphat does not take down the high places, or shrines on the hilltops, where people worship other gods. But, you may remember that the storyteller said in an earlier story in 2 Chronicles 17:6 that Jehoshaphat removed the shrines on hilltops from Judah. This means that either Jehoshaphat did not finish his work or Jehoshaphat stopped watching carefully for new shrines on hilltops. For example, Jehoshaphat's father, Asa, also removed shrines on hilltops from Judah. But by the time Jehoshaphat ruled, people had built more of those shrines on hilltops. The people often worshipped Yahweh at the shrines on hilltops, but that was also wrong. Some people also worshipped false gods like Baal and Asherah there. Yahweh wanted the people to worship only Yahweh and not other gods, and Yahweh wanted Yahweh's people to only give offerings and sacrifices at the temple in Jerusalem. By worshipping at shrines on hilltops, the people of Israel show that they strongly turned toward idol worship and mixed the worship of Yahweh with idols. So, the storyteller partly blames the people of Judah because the people did not remove the shrines on the hilltops. The storyteller says that the people of Judah, even at this point in the story, still do not really want to follow the God of their ancestors.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Talk about the religions in your culture. How can you tell whether people are or are not fully obeying the god or gods of these religions? Pause this audio here.

Many other things happen while Jehoshaphat is king. From start to finish, Jehu, the son of Hanani, writes these things in a book or scroll called the history, or records, of Jehu. Jehu's writings are part of a bigger book called the "Book of the Kings of Israel." The name "Israel" here really means Judah. By saying "Israel," the storyteller possibly shows that the kingdom of Judah remains the true Israel—the nation that trusts Yahweh. Jehu is a prophet, and Jehu does not write only ordinary history like a royal record. Jehu's writings likely include prophecies, warnings, rebukes, and Yahweh's judgment of Jehoshaphat as a king. Jehu writes history as a prophet who writes under Yahweh's direction. There is no remaining copy of Jehu's writing.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Who records the history of rulers or kings in your people group? What things do these people record about the rulers and their time as leaders? Pause this audio here.

Now the storyteller talks about a specific event from King Jehoshaphat's reign. The storyteller says, "After this, Jehoshaphat, king of Judah, makes an alliance with Ahaziah, king of Israel." Ahaziah becomes king of Israel in the 17th year of Jehoshaphat's reign and rules for two years. This means Jehoshaphat makes the alliance during that time, after Judah defeats the armies of Moab, Ammon, and Mount Seir, and after the time of peace that follows. You will remember these events from the last story. Then the storyteller says, "He does evil." In the original language, we cannot tell if "he" means King Ahaziah of Israel or King Jehoshaphat of Judah. Many people think it is Ahaziah who does evil. These people say the word "evil" describes how Ahaziah usually acts, not just one bad choice. But others think it is Jehoshaphat who does evil. These other people say Jehoshaphat makes a serious mistake when Jehoshaphat chooses to join with Ahaziah. Still others say the word "evil" really describes Ahaziah, because the word is too strong to describe Jehoshaphat.

King Jehoshaphat agrees with King Ahaziah to build several large trading ships that can travel very far, even to a place called Tarshish. In 1 Kings 22, the storyteller says that Jehoshaphat builds "ships of Tarshish." "Ships of Tarshish" or "Tarshish ships" are names for big, strong trading ships people made for long sea trips. Other Old Testament storytellers use this phrase too. Jehoshaphat and Ahaziah build these ships in the city of Ezion Geber. Ezion Geber is an important port city on the north side of the Gulf of Aqaba in Edom, which is now under Judah's control. Jehoshaphat had gained control over the area around Ezion Geber after Jehoshaphat pushed back the attack from the Moabites, Ammonites, and the people of Mount Seir in the previous story. Long ago, King Solomon made a lot of money through sea trade from this port. This history likely makes Jehoshaphat want to start sea trade again, so Jehoshaphat joins with Ahaziah to build ships for trading.

Stop here and, as a group, find Tarshish and Ezion Geber on the map. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a picture of a ship of Tarshish. Pause this audio here.

2 Chronicles 20:31–37

Then the prophet Eliezer, the son of Dodavahu, warns King Jehoshaphat. Prophet Eliezar comes from the city of Mareshah in southern Judah. This is the only time the Bible mentions the prophet Eliezer. Eliezer prophesies or tells Jehoshaphat that Yahweh will destroy the ships Jehoshaphat builds because Jehoshaphat makes an alliance with King Ahaziah. Because of this, something destroys the ships, and the ships cannot sail to faraway lands. The storyteller does not say what exactly happens to the ships.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 20:31–37 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has six scenes.

In the first scene: The storyteller summarizes Jehoshaphat's reign. Jehoshaphat rules the kingdom of Judah. Jehoshaphat is 35 years old when Jehoshaphat becomes king of Judah, and Jehoshaphat rules in Jerusalem for 25 years. Jehoshaphat's mother's name is Azubah. Silhi is Azubah's father.

In the second scene: King Jehoshaphat follows the example of his father, Asa, and does not stop following it. Jehoshaphat does things that please Yahweh.

In the third scene: Jehoshaphat does not take down the shrines on the hilltops where people worship other gods. The people of Judah, even at this time in their story, still do not really want to follow the God of their fathers.

In the fourth scene: The storyteller finishes the story of King Jehoshaphat's rule. The storyteller says that many other things happen while Jehoshaphat is king. From start to finish, Jehu, the son of Hanani, writes these things in a book or scroll that people call the history, or records, of Jehu. Jehu's writings are part of a bigger book called the "Book of the Kings of Israel."

In the fifth scene: The storyteller talks about a specific event from King Jehoshaphat's reign when Jehoshaphat makes an alliance with Ahaziah, king of Israel. The storyteller then says, "He does evil," which likely refers to how Ahaziah usually acts. But some people think that the words point to Jehoshaphat, who makes a serious mistake when he chooses to join with Ahaziah. King Jehoshaphat makes an agreement with King Ahaziah to build large trading ships that can travel to faraway places like Tarshish. Jehoshaphat and Ahaziah build these ships in the port city of Ezion Geber.

In the sixth scene: The prophet Eliezer, the son of Dodavahu, warns King Jehoshaphat. Eliezer prophesies, or tells Jehoshaphat, that Yahweh will destroy the ships Jehoshaphat builds because Jehoshaphat makes an alliance with King Ahaziah. Because of this, something destroys the ships, and they cannot sail to faraway lands like Tarshish.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Jehoshaphat of Judah
- Yahweh
- The people of Judah
- Jehu, the son of Hanani, a prophet who records the details of Jehoshaphat's reign
- Ahaziah, king of Israel
- And prophet Eliezar, son of Dodavahu

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In this story, the storyteller summarizes the rule of King Jehoshaphat of Judah. The storyteller also talks about these events in 1 Kings 22:41–50. The storyteller follows the normal way of talking about a king's rule. The storyteller says how long Jehoshaphat rules and gives the name of Jehoshaphat's mother.

Jehoshaphat rules the kingdom of Judah. Jehoshaphat is 35 years old when Jehoshaphat becomes king of Judah. Jehoshaphat rules in Jerusalem for 25 years, from about the year 872 to the year 848 before Jesus. For the first three years, Jehoshaphat co-reigns with Jehoshaphat's father, Asa. Jehoshaphat's mother's name is Azubah. Silhi

is Azubah's father. People know Silhi is Azubah's father and not Azubah's mother because, in the Bible, when people call a woman the daughter of someone, the name is almost always her father's name. That was the normal way to show family lines. Also, the words in the original language make it clear that Silhi is a male.

Stop here and, as a group, discuss the following question: What do people in your culture say when they talk about a king's or ruler's time as leader? What important things about that person's rule do people talk about? What family members in the king's or ruler's family do people think are important to mention? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller says that Jehoshaphat walks in the way of Asa, his father, which means that King Jehoshaphat follows the example of his father, Asa. The word "father" here means biological father. The storyteller then explains how closely Jehoshaphat follows his father and says that Jehoshaphat does not turn away from the way of his father. This means that Jehoshaphat does not stop following his father Asa's example. Jehoshaphat does things that are right in the eyes of Yahweh, which means Jehoshaphat does things that please Yahweh.

Stop here and, as a group, discuss the following question: How will you say that Jehoshaphat walks in the way of his father Asa or follows Asa's example? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller now uses language that shows that the negative things that happen next contrast with the positive things in Jehoshaphat's reign that the storyteller has just talked about. However, Jehoshaphat does not take down the high places, or shrines on the hilltops, where people worship other gods. This is despite what the storyteller says in a story in 2 Chronicles 17:6 from an earlier part of Jehoshaphat's reign, where Jehoshaphat removes the shrines on hilltops from Judah. Therefore, Jehoshaphat either does not finish his work, or Jehoshaphat stops watching for new shrines on hilltops so that Jehoshaphat can destroy those shrines. So the storyteller partly holds the people of Judah responsible for not removing or rebuilding the shrines on the hilltops. The storyteller says that the people of Judah have not yet made their hearts ready to follow the God of their fathers. The word "fathers" here means ancestors, not biological fathers. This means that the people of Judah, even at this point in the story, still have not chosen to fully obey God.

Now the storyteller uses a common way he often uses in the books of 1 and 2 Chronicles to finish the story of a king's rule. The storyteller says that many other things happen while Jehoshaphat is king. From start to finish, Jehu, the son of Hanani, writes these things in a book or scroll that people called the chronicles, or records of Jehu. Jehu's writings are part of a bigger book that people called the "Book of the Kings of Israel." The name "Israel" here really means Judah. In 2 Chronicles, the storyteller often calls the southern Kingdom of Judah by the name "Israel."

Stop here and, as a group, discuss the following question: What is the usual way in your culture to finish telling the story of a king's rule? Pause this audio here.

Now the storyteller talks about a specific event from King Jehoshaphat's reign. The storyteller says, "After this, Jehoshaphat, king of Judah, makes an alliance with Ahaziah, king of Israel." "After this" refers to the time after Judah defeats the armies of Moab, Ammon, and Mount Seir, and after the time of peace that follows. Then the storyteller says, "He does evil." In the original language, we cannot tell if the storyteller is talking about King Ahaziah of Israel or King Jehoshaphat of Judah. It is more likely that the storyteller talks about Ahaziah, and the word "evil" describes how Ahaziah usually acts.

Stop here and, as a group, discuss the following question: How will you decide who the words "He does evil" are talking about? How will you translate these words? If you can keep this vague in your translation, that would be best. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller says that King Jehoshaphat makes an agreement with King Ahaziah to build ships to go to Tarshish. But the words "ships to go to Tarshish" may be a mistake. The storyteller probably means "ships of Tarshish." Ships of Tarshish were big, strong trading ships that could travel very far, even to a distant place called Tarshish. No one is sure of the location of Tarshish, but many consider Tarshish to be in the western Mediterranean region or the ancient city called Carthage. People made these ships from strong wood, often cedar or other durable timber. The ships usually had one large square sail, though some may have had two sails for longer journeys. Jehoshaphat and Ahaziah do not actually build the ships themselves, but Jehoshaphat and Ahaziah oversee their workers who build the ships. Jehoshaphat and Ahaziah build these ships in the city of Ezion Geber, an important port city on the north side of the Gulf of Aqaba in Edom, which is under Judah's control.

Stop here and, as a group, find Tarshish and Ezion Geber on the map. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a picture of a ship of Tarshish. Pause this audio here.

Then the prophet Eliezer, the son of Dodavahu, warns King Jehoshaphat. Prophet Eliezer comes from the city of Mareshah in southern Judah. Eliezer prophesies or tells Jehoshaphat that Yahweh will destroy the ships Jehoshaphat builds because Jehoshaphat makes an alliance with King Ahaziah. The storyteller says that because of this, something destroys the ships, and they cannot go to Tarshish. We do not know what happened, but Yahweh may have used natural events like a violent storm, strong winds, or rough seas to destroy the ships. Here, "Tarshish" does not mean the place Tarshish, but it means faraway lands. Because Yahweh destroys the ships due to Jehoshaphat's alliance with Ahaziah, the ships can no longer sail to faraway lands.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 20:31–37 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has six scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Jehoshaphat of Judah
- The people of Judah
- Jehu, the son of Hanani, a prophet who records the details of Jehoshaphat's reign
- Ahaziah, king of Israel
- And prophet Eliezar, son of Dodavahu

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

The storyteller summarizes Jehoshaphat's reign. Jehoshaphat rules the kingdom of Judah. Jehoshaphat is 35 years old when Jehoshaphat becomes king of Judah, and Jehoshaphat rules in Jerusalem for 25 years. Jehoshaphat's mother's name is Azubah. Silhi is Azubah's father.

King Jehoshaphat follows the example of his father, Asa, and does not stop following it. Jehoshaphat does things that please Yahweh.

However, Jehoshaphat does not take down the shrines on the hilltops where people worship other gods. Even at this point in the story, the people of Judah still do not really want to follow the God of their fathers.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Jehoshaphat, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am grateful. Yahweh has helped me to obey Yahweh all my life. I did my best to follow the example that my father, King Asa, had set; or
- I am very upset that I have not managed to get rid of all the shrines on hilltops where people worship other gods. My workers destroyed the shrines at first, but then the people of Judah rebuilt the shrines; or

2 Chronicles 20:31–37

- I am disappointed that the people of Judah, even now, do not want to follow Yahweh, the God of their fathers, with their whole hearts.

Continue the drama.

The storyteller finishes the story of King Jehoshaphat's rule. The storyteller says that many other things happen while Jehoshaphat is king. From start to finish, Jehu, the son of Hanani, writes these things in a scroll that people called the chronicles, or records, of Jehu. Jehu's writings are part of a bigger book that people called the "Book of the Kings of Israel."

The storyteller now talks about a specific event from King Jehoshaphat's reign when Jehoshaphat makes an alliance with Ahaziah, king of Israel. The storyteller then says that the way Ahaziah usually acts is evil. But some people think that the word "evil" points to Jehoshaphat, who makes a serious mistake when he chooses to join with Ahaziah. King Jehoshaphat makes an agreement with King Ahaziah to build large trading ships that can travel to faraway places like Tarshish. Jehoshaphat and Ahaziah build these ships in the port city of Ezion Geber.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Ahaziah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am happy that King Jehoshaphat decided to make an alliance with me to build several ships of Tarshish in the port city of Ezion Geber; or
- I hope that the ships will help me and King Jehoshaphat make a lot of money for our kingdoms when we trade with faraway countries. We will use the ships to sell and buy goods from distant lands, just like King Solomon did; or
- I am pleased that King Jehoshaphat follows Yahweh. Perhaps Yahweh will bless our alliance.

Continue the drama.

Then the prophet Eliezer, the son of Dodavahu, warns King Jehoshaphat. Eliezer prophesies, or tells Jehoshaphat, that Yahweh will destroy the ships Jehoshaphat builds because Jehoshaphat makes an alliance with King Ahaziah. Because of this, something destroys the ships, and they cannot sail to faraway lands.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Prophet Eliezer, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am afraid of King Jehoshaphat. I must tell Jehoshaphat that Yahweh is very unhappy about Jehoshaphat's alliance with evil King Ahaziah; or
- I trust that Yahweh will protect me when I tell Jehoshaphat that Yahweh will destroy the ships they build; or
- I love Yahweh because he always keeps his word. Yahweh destroyed the ships of Tarshish that Jehoshaphat and Ahaziah built, as Yahweh said he would do.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 20:31–37 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Jehoshaphat rules the **kingdom** of Judah. Jehoshaphat is 35 years old when Jehoshaphat becomes **king** of **Judah**. Although the storyteller just says that Jehoshaphat ruled over Judah, we know that Judah is a kingdom. You may choose to say "the kingdom of Judah" if you need to.

Use the same words or phrases for kingdom, Judah, and king as you used in previous passages. For more information on kingdom, Judah and king, refer to the Master Glossary.

King Jehoshaphat follows the example of his father, Asa, and does not stop following it. Jehoshaphat does things that please Yahweh.

The word **father** means biological father here. Use the same word for father as you used in previous passages.

Yahweh is God's personal name. Use the same name for Yahweh as you used in previous passages. For more information on Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary.

2 Chronicles 23:1–15

However, Jehoshaphat does not take down the **shrines on the hilltops** where people worship other gods. The people of Judah, even at this point in the story, still had not set their **hearts** on God. In other words, the people did not really want to follow the God of their fathers. The God of their fathers is Yahweh, the **Creator God**. The word fathers here means ancestors, not biological fathers. Use the same word or phrase for "shrines on the hilltops" or **high places** as you used in previous passages. Use the same word for the Creator God as you used in previous passages. For more information on **God**, refer to the Master Glossary. If you use your word for heart in your translation, refer to heart in the Master Glossary.

From start to finish, Jehu, the son of Hanani, writes these things in a book or **scroll** called the history, or records, of Jehu. Jehu's writings are part of a bigger book called the "Book of the Kings of Israel." Use the same word or phrase for scroll as you have used in previous passages. Refer to scroll in the Master Glossary for more information.

Use the same words or phrases for **Israel** as you used in previous passages. For more information on Israel, refer to the Master Glossary.

Jehoshaphat made an alliance with King Ahaziah of Israel. Either Jehoshaphat or Ahaziah was **wicked**, or evil. Use the same word or phrase for wicked as you have used previously, and refer to wicked in the Master Glossary for more information.

Then the prophet Eliezer, the son of Dodavahu, warns King Jehoshaphat. Eliezer **prophesies**, or tells Jehoshaphat, that Yahweh will destroy the **ships** Jehoshaphat builds because Jehoshaphat makes an alliance, or agreement, with King Ahaziah. Use the same words or phrases for prophesy and ships as you used in previous passages. For more information on prophesy, refer to the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

2 Chronicles 23:1–15

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 23:1–15 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 23:1–15 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

2 Chronicles 23:1–15

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 23:1–15 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the last story, Jehu killed King Ahaziah of Judah. Then King Ahaziah's mother, Athaliah, made herself queen of Judah and killed the rest of the royal family members so that no one could become king. But Ahaziah's sister, Jehosheba, who was married to Yahweh's high priest, Jehoiada, hid Ahaziah's baby son, Joash, in Yahweh's temple so that Athaliah could not find and kill Joash.

This story happens almost seven years later, when Joash is now seven years old. At this time, Jehoiada, the high priest, decides it is time to take action. So Jehoiada secretly meets with the commanders or leaders of the military. These men are Azariah son of Jeroham, Ishmael son of []{.mark}Jehohanan, Azariah son of Obed, Maaseiah son of Adaiah, and Elishaphat son of Zicri. Jehoiada makes a covenant or special agreement with these men. Then these men travel all around the kingdom of Judah and gather all of the Levites and the heads of all the Israelite families and bring all of these men to Jerusalem, the capital city.

When this large crowd of men arrives in Jerusalem, all of the men gather at the house of Yahweh, the temple, where Joash is hiding. All of the men make a covenant or special agreement to make Joash the new king. Then Jehoiada, the high priest, speaks to all of the men. Jehoiada says that Ahaziah's son Joash will become the new king so that the promise Yahweh made to King David long ago will happen. You will remember that Yahweh had promised David that one of David's descendants would always be king over Israel.

Next, Jehoiada gives all of the men instructions. First, Jehoiada says that of all of the priests and Levites whose turn it is to serve Yahweh at the temple, a third of those men must guard the gates into the temple area. Another third of those men must guard the palace, and the last third must stand near the Foundation Gate, which was probably a gate in the wall that surrounded the temple and the royal palace. Jehoiada also says that all of the other men who are not priests or Levites must gather together in the temple courtyards, which are open areas just outside the temple. Jehoiada also reminds people that no one but the priests and Levites who are supposed to be working at the temple at that time may go into the temple itself. This is because Yahweh only allows the men who are holy or ceremonially clean to go into Yahweh's house. Finally, Jehoiada says the Levites must surround Joash while the Levites hold swords or sharp weapons. If anyone tries to come into the temple area, the Levites must kill that person. These Levites must bring Joash safely into the temple area, and these Levites must also protect Joash when the time comes to leave the temple. With all of these people in place to guard Joash in this way, no one will be able to harm Joash.

Stop here and look at a drawing of what the temple and royal palace area might have looked like. Look at the temple itself, the inner and outer courtyards of the temple, and the wall that protected the temple and palace from the rest of the city of Jerusalem. Pause this audio here.

So the Levites and all the men of Judah who have gathered together do exactly as Jehoiada has said. Each of the commanders gathers all of his men together, including the men who are to serve on the Sabbath and those who are not. Then Jehoiada gives all of the commanders of the Levites weapons, including spears and large and small shields that once belonged to King David's men. People had stored all of these weapons and shields at the temple. Then Jehoiada instructs all of these men to stand around Joash with the weapons, ready to protect Joash. So all of the men position themselves in a semi-circle around the altar and the front of the temple, from the south side of the temple to the north side of the temple. You will remember that the temple faced to the east. So by standing in this way, the men fully protect Joash from anyone who might try to come near to harm Joash.

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Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about an important person whom other people must protect. How do people organize themselves to protect the person? Where do the people stand, or how do the people move when they guard the person? What tools or weapons do the people carry? Pause this audio here.

Then Jehoiada and his sons bring Joash, King Ahaziah's son, out of the temple and put the king's crown on Joash's head. The men also give Joash a copy of the covenant, which is all of the written instructions or rules the king must obey as part of the king's agreement with Yahweh. Then the men proclaim or announce that Joash is now the king, and the men anoint Joash by pouring oil over his head. Finally, everyone shouts loudly, "Let the king live forever!"

Now, Athaliah, the queen, hears people running and cheering for the king. The storyteller does not tell us where Athaliah is at this time, but Athaliah is probably in the royal palace, which is near the temple. It seems that because Jehoiada and all the men kept the plans secret, Athaliah was not aware of these things until now. So when Athaliah hears all of the people shouting about the king, Athaliah probably feels very surprised and concerned. So Athaliah goes to the temple where all the people are gathered.

The storyteller does not explain how Athaliah gets past the guards into the temple area, but when Athaliah arrives, she sees Joash, the new king, standing beside the pillar at the entrance to the temple. The storyteller does not say what this pillar is, but we know from other passages in the Bible that there were two large pillars in front of the temple. Athaliah also sees the commanders of the military and the men who play the trumpets standing there with King Joash. And Athaliah also hears the people celebrating and playing loud sounds on the trumpets and musical instruments.

Athaliah tears her clothes or the robe Athaliah wears. You will remember that in that culture, people would rip or tear their clothes to show other people that they felt very shocked or upset. Then Athaliah says loudly, "Treason! Treason!" Treason is when you help your leader's enemies take away your leader's power or hurt your leader. So here, Athaliah seems to be saying that Jehoiada and everyone else who has helped make Joash the king have betrayed or been unfaithful to Athaliah as queen.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story about someone in your community who felt very upset or sad because of something surprising and bad that people did. Tell what that person did to show how they felt. Pause this audio here.

Then Jehoiada tells the commanders or leaders of the military to take Athaliah away. Jehoiada tells the commanders to kill anyone who tries to follow behind to protect Athaliah or to set Athaliah free. Jehoiada tells the commanders not to kill Athaliah in the temple. To kill someone in the temple would make the temple ceremonially unclean, so Jehoiada is saying that the men must kill Athaliah outside. So the commanders force Athaliah to walk with them through the horses' entrance to the king's palace, and there the guards kill Athaliah.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 23:1–15 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has six scenes.

In the first scene: Jehoiada makes a covenant or agreement with the five men who are the commanders of the military. Then these men go to the different parts of the kingdom of Judah. The men gather all the Levites and the leaders of family groups and bring them all back to Yahweh's temple in Jerusalem.

In the second scene: Jehoiada speaks to the large crowd of men who have gathered at the temple. Jehoiada says the men will make Joash the new king. Jehoiada gives detailed instructions to organize all of the men to protect the temple area and Joash himself. Then all of the men organize themselves, and Jehoiada gives the men weapons to protect Joash.

In the third scene: Jehoiada brings Joash out of the temple, where the crowd can see Joash. The men put the crown on Joash's head and give Joash the written instructions for how to obey Yahweh. The men also anoint Joash with oil, and then everyone shouts, "Long live the king!"

In the fourth scene: Athaliah hears the noise that the people are making, so Athaliah goes to the temple to see what the people are doing.

In the fifth scene: When Athaliah arrives at the temple, Athaliah sees Joash standing by the pillar. Athaliah also sees the commanders and the people who are blowing trumpets standing beside the king and all the people celebrating. Then Athaliah tears her clothes and says, "Treason! Treason!"

In the sixth scene: Jehoidah commands the commanders to take Athaliah out of the temple. Jehoidah says not to kill Athaliah in the temple. The commanders follow Jehoidah's orders and then kill Athaliah.

The characters in this passage are:

- Jehoiada, the high priest
- Military commanders: Azariah son of Jeroham, Ishmael son of Jehohanan, Azariah son of Obed, Maaseiah son of Adaiah, and Elishaphat son of Zicri
- Levites
- Heads or leaders of all of the Israelite families
- Joash, the new king
- God, whose name is Yahweh
- Priests, who are also Levites
- Athaliah, the queen
- People of Judah who are celebrating
- And trumpeters

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

We hear this same story about King Joash in 2 Kings 11:13–21, although some of the details of the story are different. So if you have already translated 2 Kings, you can go back and listen to 2 Kings chapter 11 to remember how you translated it.

Stop here and listen to 2 Kings 11:13–21. Listen for any ways that this story in 2 Chronicles is either the same or different from the story in 2 Kings. Pause this audio here.

In the first scene, the storyteller says that in the seventh year, Jehoiada took courage. "The seventh year" means that nearly seven years have passed since the last story, when Jehosheba hid Joash away in the temple so that Athaliah could not find Joash and kill Joash. So now, in the seventh year, Jehoiada takes courage. This means that Jehoiada strengthens his position or takes some action to take control of the situation. Jehoiada begins by entering into a covenant with the commanders of hundreds of men, who are the top leaders of the military. This covenant means that Jehoiada makes an agreement with these men. These men's names are Azariah son of Jeroham, Ishmael son of Jehohanan, Azariah son of Obed, Maaseiah son of Adaiah, and Elishaphat son of Zicri. You will remember that in Bible times, people often said the name of a person's father as well as that person's own name so that everyone would know exactly which person they talked about.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your community, when more than one person has the same personal name, what else do you say when you talk about that person so that everyone knows exactly which person you mean? For example, do you also say that person's family name, the name of the person's father or mother, the name of the village or place where that person lives, or something else? Pause this audio here.

After Jehoiada and these commanders agreed about what they would do, each of the men went throughout the kingdom of Judah and gathered the Levites and the heads of Israelite families from each city. The storyteller does not say if Jehoiada and these men went to each place together or if the men went separately to different places. But we know that these men then brought all of the men they had gathered back to Jerusalem. We know this because, as the second scene begins, the storyteller says that when all of these people came to Jerusalem, everyone who had assembled made a covenant with the king in the "house of God," which means in Yahweh's temple. You will remember that a covenant is a special agreement that two people or groups of people make,

where each one makes a promise either to do or not do certain things. The storyteller does not say exactly what the people agree to do or not do, but the people probably agree to protect Joash and to make Joash their new king. Then Jehoiada said to everyone gathered, “Behold, the king’s son!” “Behold” is special language that means “Look!” or “Pay attention!” Jehoiada calls Joash “the king’s son” because Joash is the son of Ahaziah, who had been Judah’s king until Jehu killed King Ahaziah in a previous story. Then Jehoiada continues to speak and says that the king’s son, meaning Joash, will reign, just as Yahweh promised David’s sons, which means David’s descendants. You will remember that “to reign” means to rule and have authority as king, so Jehoiada is saying that Joash will be the new king. Athaliah, who has been acting like the queen, is not one of David’s descendants. But Joash is David’s descendant. So when Joash becomes king, Yahweh’s promise will happen. This shows us how important it is that Joash become king, and it also shows that Yahweh will support this plan.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How does someone become the head leader in your culture? Does a person become the next leader automatically because of the family they are born into, or do people talk together and choose who the next leader will be? What happens if someone who is not supposed to be the leader tries to make themselves the leader? Pause this audio here.

Now, Jehoiada tells everyone what they must do. First, Jehoida says that one-third of the priests and Levites who are going on duty on the Sabbath day must serve as guards at the gates where people enter the temple area. You will remember that the priests and Levites help people worship Yahweh at the temple, and the Sabbath day is the special day of the week when everyone rests from their work. You will also remember that the priests and Levites each had certain days where they did their work, and certain days where they rested while other priests and Levites worked. So here, Jehoiada is saying that the priests and Levites who are to work on this day must divide up into three equal groups and then one of those groups must act as guards at the gates into the temple area to protect it. Jehoiada then says that another one of those three groups must guard the royal palace, which is where the king lives. And the final group must stand and protect the Foundation Gate. The storyteller does not say what the Foundation Gate is, but this is probably the gate in the wall that surrounds the temple and the royal palace within the city of Jerusalem.

Jehoiada also says that all of the other men in the crowd who are not priests or Levites must gather together in the temple courtyards, which are the open areas just outside the temple. Jehoiada says not to let anyone except the priests and Levites who are supposed to be working at the temple go into the temple itself, because only these men are holy or ceremonially clean and allowed to go into Yahweh’s house.

Finally, Jehoiada says the Levites must surround Joash while they hold swords or sharp weapons. You will remember that a sword is a long, sharp weapon with a handle, and that soldiers use swords to kill people in battle. If anyone tries to come into the temple area, the Levites must kill that person. And the Levites must not only bring Joash safely into the temple area, but the Levites must also protect Joash when the time comes to leave the temple.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a sword. Pause this audio here.

After Jehoiada finishes giving these instructions to the people, the Levites, including the priests, who are a special group of Levites, do just as Jehoiada, the high priest, ordered. Each leader takes or gathers and organizes his men, both those men who were to go on duty on the Sabbath and those who were going off duty. Here, the storyteller says that Jehoiada had not said any of the men could leave when it was time to go off duty, so all of the priests and Levites are here to help.

Jehoiada gives the commanders of the Levites spears, as well as the large and small shields that had belonged to King David. You will remember that a spear is a sharp, pointed weapon that people make from metal and then attach to a long pole, and shields are something that soldiers carry to protect themselves from their enemy. People had stored these things at the temple, so Jehoiada now gets these things out of storage and gives them to the men to use.

Jehoiada stations or organizes all of these men, each with his weapon in his hand, into position so that they are all around Joash, the new king. These men stand near the altar and the temple from the south side of the temple to the north side. In this way, the men protect Joash so that no enemy can come near Joash from any side.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a spear and a picture of a shield. Pause this audio here.

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In the third scene, Jehoiada and the other men bring out Joash, the king's son. The men place the king's crown on Joash's head. You will remember that a crown is a special decorative item that a person wears on the top of their head. A crown shows that this person has power and authority that only the king would have.

The men also give Joash a copy of the covenant or laws that the king must obey as part of their agreement with Yahweh. People have written all of these instructions on a scroll, which is a very long piece of paper or animal skin that people roll up around a stick so that they can easily store it away or carry it from place to place.

Then the men announce that Joash is the king, and the men anoint Joash, which means the men pour oil over Joash's head to show that Yahweh set apart or specially chose Joash to serve as king.

And finally, everyone says loudly together, "Long live the king!" which is a way to say that the people want Joash to live a long life and serve as king for a very long time.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a scroll and a picture of a crown. Pause this audio here.

In the fourth scene, Athaliah hears the noise of people running and the loud noise of people cheering for the king. The storyteller does not say who is running or where Athaliah is at this time, but Athaliah is probably in the palace. And it may be that other people in the palace are also surprised to hear the crowd cheering and are running toward the temple to see what is happening. So Athaliah also goes to the temple.

In the fifth scene, when Athaliah arrives at the temple, Athaliah looks and sees the king standing by the pillar at the entrance to the temple. The storyteller does not say which pillar this is, but we know from 1 Kings 7:15–22 that Solomon's workers built two large, decorated pillars that stood in front of the temple. Athaliah also sees the commanders and the trumpeters, or the men whose job it was to blow the trumpets, standing beside the king. You will remember that a trumpet is a type of musical instrument that people use to make a loud noise. Athaliah also sees and hears all of the people celebrating and blowing trumpets, and Athaliah sees the musicians playing their musical instruments and leading the celebration.

Stop here and look at a picture of what the two columns in front of the temple might have looked like. Pause this audio here.

So when Athaliah sees all of these things, Athaliah immediately tears her clothes. This means that Athaliah pulls strongly against her outer robe so that the cloth tears apart. Then Athaliah cries out, or says in a very loud voice, "Treason! Treason!" This is another way to say, "You are traitors! You have betrayed me!" In other words, Athaliah accuses the people of being disloyal to Athaliah.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story about a time when people betrayed or were disloyal to a leader by secretly helping someone else to become the new leader. What words do you use to describe what these people did? Pause this audio here.

In the sixth scene, the high priest, Jehoiadah, tells the military commanders to take Athaliah outside the temple courtyard. Jehoidah tells the men to do this with Athaliah between the rows of soldiers so that Athaliah cannot escape.

Jehoidah says to use a sword to kill anyone who follows Athaliah. Although Jehoidah does not say, Jehoidah probably means to kill anyone who follows closely behind Athaliah to try to protect her or free her from the guards. Although Jehoidah does not tell the commanders exactly what to do with Athaliah, Jehoidah says not to kill Athaliah in the temple. So the commanders know that Jehoidah means to kill Athaliah once they leave the temple area. The men lay hands on Athaliah, which means the men hold onto Athaliah like a prisoner so that Athaliah cannot escape. Then the men take Athaliah to the horses' entrance to the king's house or palace. You will remember that a horse is a large animal that people, such as kings or soldiers, would ride. So this was probably some sort of gate or entrance into the part of the palace where the guards kept the horses. Then, when the men arrive at this place, the men kill Athaliah.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a horse. Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 23:1–15 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has six scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Jehoiada, the high priest
- Military commanders: Azariah son of Jeroham, Ishmael son of Jehohanan, Azariah son of Obed, Maaseiah son of Adaiah, and Elishaphat son of Zicri
- Levites
- Heads or leaders of all of the Israelite families
- Joash, the new king
- God, whose name is Yahweh
- Priests, who are also Levites
- Athaliah, the queen
- People of Judah who are celebrating
- And trumpeters

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

After nearly seven years, Jehoiada decided that it was time to take action. So Jehoiada made an agreement with the military commanders of hundreds of soldiers. Those men were Jeroham’s son Azariah, and Jehohanan’s son Ishmael, and Obed’s son Azariah, and Adaiah’s son Maaseiah, and Zicri’s son Elishaphat. These men traveled to all of the cities in Judah and brought together all of the Levites and the heads of the Israelite families.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Jehoiada the priest, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- Athaliah is a bad woman who murdered people so that Athaliah could be queen. But Yahweh never meant for Athaliah to be queen. Yahweh promised that one of David’s ancestors would always be king in Israel. And that ancestor is Joash! or
- We have hidden Joash for almost seven years now. It is time to make Joash king!

Ask the people playing the commanders, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The people might answer things like:

- We respect Jehoiada and are happy to help Jehoiada carry out this plan; or
- We know that Athaliah will be angry and try to stop this plan, so we will keep this plan a secret and make sure no one takes the news back to Athaliah, the queen.

Continue the drama.

When all of these people came to Jerusalem, these people made an agreement with Joash, the king’s son, in God’s house, the temple. Jehoiada said to all the men, “The king’s son will be king as Yahweh promised David’s descendants. Now this is what you must do. A third of you priests and Levites who are going to be on duty on the Sabbath are to guard the temple gates. Another third of you priests and Levites must guard the palace. And

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the other third of priests and Levites must stand at the Foundation Gate. The rest of you will remain in the open area or courtyard around Yahweh's temple. Do not let anyone enter the temple of Yahweh except the priests and Levites on duty. Those priests and Levites may enter the temple because they are ritually pure, but the others are to obey Yahweh's instructions and not enter. The Levites are to surround the king, and each man must hold a weapon in his hand. You must kill anyone who comes into Yahweh's house. Stay close to the king wherever the king goes."

So the Levites and all of the other people of Judah did what Jehoiada the priest told the people to do. Each one of the leaders took his men, both those who were to come on duty on the Sabbath and those who were going off duty, because Jehoiada the priest had not let any of them go home. Jehoiada gave the commanders of the Levites the spears and the large and small shields. These weapons had belonged to King David, and people had stored these weapons in the temple. Jehoiada stationed all the men with their weapons in their hands around the king. The men stood near the altar and the temple from the south side to the north side of the temple.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Jehoiada, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I know that Queen Athaliah will be very angry when she finds out that Joash is alive and that we are making Joash king. Athaliah will probably try to kill Joash if she can, so I must create a very good plan to protect Joash.

Ask the people playing the commanders, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The peoplemight answer things like:

- Jehoiada has made a very good plan. We have lots of men here with weapons to stand between Joash and anyone who might come close to hurt Joash. We have men at the gate of the wall to make sure no one can come inside. And we even have men at the palace to protect Joash when we are ready to go there with Joash later.

Ask the people playing the Levites who are guarding Joash, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We hope no one comes close to try to hurt Joash, but if someone does, we are ready to protect Joash; or
- We are glad that people kept all of these spears and shields here at the temple. These will help us protect Joash much better than if we only had our swords.

Continue the drama.

Then Jehoiada and Jehoiada's sons brought the king's son, Joash, and placed the crown on Joash's head. The men gave Joash a copy of the laws that instructed how Joash must rule as king, and they announced to everyone that Joash was now the king. The men also anointed Joash with oil, and everyone shouted, "Long live the king!"

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Joash, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am only a child, just seven years old. I have no idea how to be a king! or
- I am glad these men gave me these written instructions. Maybe if I do what the instructions say, I will know what to do, even though I am just a child and have never been a leader; or
- I always wanted to leave the temple and see what it was like outside, but it was never safe for me to leave before. Now that I can finally come outside, all of these people are looking at me. I feel overwhelmed!

Continue the drama.

When Athaliah heard the sound of people running and cheering for the king, Athaliah went to Yahweh's temple to see what people were doing there.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Athaliah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I hear people shouting about a king, but there is no king anymore. After Ahaziah died, I killed everyone in the family who could become the next king; or
- I do not know why people are shouting about a king, but I am worried. I had better go see what this is all about.

Continue the drama.

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Athaliah looked and saw the king standing by the pillar at the door of the temple. Athaliah also saw the commanders of the military and the trumpeters who were beside the king. All the people were happy, and people were playing trumpets. The musicians were also playing instruments and leading people in the celebration. Then Athaliah tore her clothing apart and shouted, "You have betrayed me! You have betrayed me!"

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Athaliah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am shocked that every one of the leaders hid this from me. No one who knew this secret came to tell me! or
- I thought for sure I had killed every one of David's descendants who might challenge me as queen. I am shocked to find out that Joash is still alive.

Ask the people playing all the people celebrating, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We are so happy to have a proper king to rule and protect us! or
- We never liked having Athaliah as the queen. Athaliah is a bad woman who killed her own family to make herself powerful, so no one can trust Athaliah; or
- We know that Yahweh said one of David's descendants will also be our king. Joash is David's descendant and the person who was supposed to be king, so that must mean Yahweh will bless Joash and us, too.

Continue the drama.

Jehoiada the priest sent out the army commanders of hundreds, who were in charge of the troops and said to these men, "Bring Athaliah out between the rows of guards so that she cannot escape. And kill anyone who follows Athaliah." Jehoiada the priest had said, "Do not kill Athaliah in Yahweh's temple." So the men caught Athaliah and killed her at the entrance of the Horse Gate that enters the palace courtyard.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the commanders, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We are used to fighting and killing enemies in battle, but to have to kill an older woman makes us feel uncomfortable, especially when Athaliah used to give us orders; or
- We do not like to kill Athaliah, but Athaliah killed her own family and tried to kill Joash too, so this is the right thing to do; or
- We never liked Athaliah. Athaliah was an evil woman, so we feel relieved and happy now that Athaliah is no longer alive to threaten Joash or any of us.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 23:1–15 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Jehoiada made a **covenant** with the commanders of hundreds of soldiers. [A covenant is a strong and serious agreement where people or groups promise to do certain things for each other and trust each other to keep those promises.]{.mark} When people make a covenant, the people swear an oath and say, "I will keep my promise. If I do not, God may punish me." Use the same word or phrase for covenant as you used in previous passages. For more information on covenant, refer to the Master Glossary.

Then each of these leaders went throughout Judah and gathered the **Levites** and the heads of fathers' **households** of Israel. The Levites are people who belong to the tribe of Levi, one of the 12 tribes of Israel. The "heads of fathers' houses" refers to the men in each family and clan, or large family group, of Judah who were the leaders of those families and clans. Use the same words or phrases for Levites and "heads of fathers' houses" as you used in previous passages. For more information, look up Levites and household in the Master Glossary.

Sometimes the word **Israel** refers to all the descendants of Jacob together. It then means the same as Israelites, or as people of Israel. Other times, the word Israel refers to the land, or the territory, where the Israelites lived.

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You will remember that during this time, the land of Israel was divided into two kingdoms: people usually called the kingdom to the north “Israel” and the kingdom to the south Judah“. However, in this story, the storyteller uses “Israel” to refer to Judah, the southern kingdom. Use the same word or phrase for “Israel” as you used in previous passages. For more information, look up Israelites in the Master Glossary.

Then all of these men came to **Jerusalem**. For more information, look up Jerusalem in the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for Jerusalem as you used in previous passages.

And the people gathered together in a special gathering or **assembly**, and made a covenant with the **king** at the **house of God**. A king is someone who rules over a city or territory, like a region or country. **God** is the general word for Yahweh, the true God who created everything. And the “house of God” is another way to refer to the **temple**. Use the same words or phrases for assembly, king, God, and “house of God” or temple as you used in previous passages. For more information, look up king, God, and temple in the Master Glossary.

Jehoiada said that **Yahweh** had promised that **David’s sons** would always reign over Israel. Yahweh is God’s personal name, and David refers to King David. Here, “sons” means David’s descendants. Use the same words or phrases for Yahweh, David, and sons or **descendants** as you used in previous passages. For more information, look up Yahweh, David, and descendant in the Master Glossary.

Jehoiada gives detailed instructions to the **priests** and the Levites. You will remember that the priests are Levites who are descendants of Aaron. The priests worked in the temple to serve Yahweh by offering sacrifices on behalf of the people, and the other Levites helped the priests to do that important work. Use the same word or phrase for priests as you used in previous passages. For more information, look up priest in the Master Glossary.

Jehoiada gave instructions for the Levites who were going on duty on the **Sabbath**. The Sabbath is the seventh day of the week for the Israelites. It is a day of rest and worship to God. Use the same word or phrase for Sabbath as you used in previous passages. For more information, look up Sabbath in the Master Glossary.

Jehoiada says not to let anyone go inside the temple except the priests and the **ministering** Levites, because these men are **holy**. To minister means to serve, and to be holy means to be ceremonially clean or set apart. Use the same words or phrases for minister and holy as you used in previous passages. For more information on holy, see the Master Glossary.

The men stood around the **altar** and the temple from the south side of the temple to the north side. You will remember that the altar was the place where people made offerings and sacrifices to God. Use the same word or phrase for altar as you used in previous passages. For more information on altar, see the Master Glossary.

The men **anointed** Joash as king. Use the same word or phrase for anointed as you used in previous passages. For more information on anoint, see the Master Glossary.

The trumpeters were people whose job it was to blow a trumpet. Trumpets were long, straight instruments that people had made from hammered metal, either silver or bronze. People used these trumpets in times of war to sound the alarm, but people also used the trumpets to produce music in times of celebration.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a trumpet. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **trumpeter**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Jehoiada told the people to put anyone who followed Athaliah **to the sword**. Use the same word or phrase for killing people with a sword as you have used in previous stories.

Jehoiada told the priests to put Athaliah to death at the Horse Gate into the **palace**, or the king’s house. Use the same word or phrase for palace that you have used previously.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

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First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

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Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 26:1–15 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 26:1–15 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 26:1–15 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous story, the storyteller told about the end of King Amaziah of Judah. This passage tells about some of the life of Amaziah's son, King Uzziah, and what Uzziah did as the king of Judah. In other stories in the Bible, storytellers call Uzziah by another name, "Azariah."

The people of Judah made Uzziah king in place of his father, Amaziah. Uzziah was 16 years old. Uzziah is the king who rebuilt Elath and restored control of Elath to Judah. Uzziah did this after Amaziah had died.

Elath was a city more than 300 kilometers to the south of Jerusalem in the territory of Edom. Elath was a port on a large body of water called the Gulf of Aqaba. The Gulf of Aqaba is the eastern branch of the Red Sea. Whichever kingdom controlled the port could become more wealthy by trading with faraway nations.

Stop here as a group and look at a map of the kingdom of Judah in the context of the larger region. Note where Jerusalem is and where the boundary of Judah is compared to the city of Elath on the Gulf of Aqaba. Note where Mount Sinai, the Red Sea, and Egypt are. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What goods do your community trade with others? What locations are important for trading? Pause this audio here.

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Uzziah was 16 years old when he became king. Uzziah was king in Jerusalem for 52 years. Uzziah's mother's name was Jecoliah. Jecoliah was from Jerusalem. Uzziah did things that pleased Yahweh in the same way Uzziah's father did. A man named Zechariah taught Uzziah to respect and obey God. It is likely Zechariah was a priest or a trusted advisor, but we do not know more information about Zechariah. Uzziah served God during the time Zechariah was with Uzziah. During the time Uzziah served Yahweh, God made Uzziah successful.

King Uzziah and his army warred against the Philistines and broke the walls that protected three Philistine cities: Gath, Jabneh, and Ashdod. The Philistines had been enemies of Israel for centuries. Uzziah ordered the people of Judah to rebuild cities of Judah near Ashdod and in other places in the Philistine land. God helped Uzziah's kingdom fight against the Philistines.

Stop here as a group and look at the map from earlier of the kingdom of Judah in the context of the larger region. Note where the Philistine territory is and the cities of Ashdod, Gath, and Jabneh. Pause this audio here.

God helped Uzziah and his army fight against the Arabs who lived in Gur Baal. God helped Uzziah and his army fight against the Meunites. The Meunites or Ammonites regularly paid tribute to Uzziah since Uzziah was very powerful. The tribute would have been money or something valuable. In that time, a weak nation would give tribute to a stronger nation so that the stronger nation would not destroy the weak nation. People who lived throughout the land from Jerusalem to Egypt knew that Uzziah was very powerful.

Stop here as a group and look at the map from earlier of the kingdom of Judah in the context of the larger region. Note the probable locations of the Arabs and Meunites that Uzziah's army defeated. These places were likely along the trade route from Jerusalem to Elath. So Uzziah's victory in these areas gave Uzziah greater control of Elath and made Uzziah more powerful. Pause this audio here.

Uzziah ordered his people to build towers in Jerusalem at the Corner Gate, the Valley Gate, and at the angle in the wall. A tower was a tall structure that soldiers could stand on top of to help the soldiers see the enemy from far away. Soldiers who stood on the tower could attack the enemy before the enemy broke into the city. Uzziah did this to protect his city and make it stronger.

Stop here as a group and discuss this question: Where would people in your culture go to protect themselves? What do people in your culture do to see far away, hide, or attack enemies? Pause this audio here.

Uzziah ordered the people of Judah to build towers in the open land away from the towns. These towers would stand tall like trees in a field. People would stand on top of the towers in the field to watch their livestock, protect their animals from wild beasts, and see enemies coming from far away.

Stop here as a group and do this activity: Have someone in your group stand on the ground and describe what they can see far away. Now have that person safely go to a higher level, look in the same direction as the first person, and describe what they can see far away. What difference do you hear? How could this help when you or your animals are in an open field? Pause this audio here.

Uzziah ordered the people to dig many cisterns. Cisterns were large holes in rocks that the people used to catch rainwater. People would cut or dig out a large hole in a giant rock. Then the people would use another material to seal the rock so the cistern would not leak water. Uzziah had the people dig cisterns because Uzziah had a lot of livestock in the low hills and in the open plain. Uzziah had people work his fields and grape vines in the hills and in the fertile fields. Uzziah had a lot of farms and vineyards because Uzziah loved to grow food from the ground.

Uzziah had a strong army that practiced for war. The army was always ready to go to war. The army stayed organized with groups of soldiers. Jeiel kept count of the soldiers and supplies. Maaseiah was also an army leader, but we do not know what Maaseiah's job was. Hananiah was one of the royal generals, and he led Jeiel, Maaseiah, and the whole army. There were 2,600 family leaders in charge of the fighting men. These family leaders had authority over 307,500 men. These soldiers trained for war and stayed ready to fight King Uzziah's enemies.

Uzziah provided equipment to his whole army. Uzziah gave the soldiers shields, helmets, and armor to put over their bodies and protect themselves. People made small shields out of wood or metal. People made the helmets and coats of armor out of leather or metal. The helmets and coats of armor protected people's bodies. Uzziah

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gave the soldiers weapons to fight enemies. Uzziah gave the soldiers spears, bows and arrows, and slings to throw stones. People made the weapons out of wood, stone, leather, and metal.

Stop here as a group and look at pictures of the army's equipment in this passage. What kind of equipment does your culture use to protect soldiers? What kind of weapons does your culture use to fight enemies or animals? How would you describe the army's equipment? Pause this audio here.

Skillful men of Judah invented powerful weapons of war. In Jerusalem, Uzziah ordered men to build these devices on top of the towers and corners of the city walls. These clever inventions enabled soldiers to shoot arrows and throw large stones down onto enemies. Uzziah became very famous in faraway places. God helped Uzziah until Uzziah became powerful.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 26:1–15 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: Uzziah becomes king and is famous because Uzziah rebuilds Elath. Uzziah has a mother named Jecoliah and an advisor named Zechariah. The storyteller says Uzziah followed God as long as Zechariah was alive.

In the second scene: Uzziah's army makes war against other nations. The army of Judah wins the battles because God is with the army.

In the third scene: Uzziah makes his kingdom more secure by ordering the people of Judah to build towers of defense in the city and the fields. Uzziah has a lot of workers on his farms and in his vineyards. Uzziah develops a strong and organized army and gives the army good equipment to defend Judah and attack enemies. God is with Uzziah until Uzziah becomes powerful.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Amaziah, Uzziah's father
- King Uzziah
- The people of Judah
- Jecoliah, Uzziah's mother
- Zechariah, Uzziah's advisor
- Yahweh
- The Philistines
- The Arabs
- The Meunites, and possibly the Ammonites
- Jeiel, the secretary of Judah's army
- Maaseiah, the officer of Judah's army
- Hananiah, the royal general of Judah's army
- Family leaders of Judah's army
- And Judah's soldiers

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first scene, the storyteller transitions from King Amaziah to Amaziah's son, Uzziah. When Uzziah was 16 years old, all the people of Judah made Uzziah king in place of his father. The Bible does not say Amaziah died before Uzziah became king. This is different from the formula of previous passages, where a king rests with his fathers, people bury the king, and the king's son becomes the new king. We know from other passages that Amaziah was a prisoner after he lost a battle. It is possible that the people of Judah made Uzziah king instead of Amaziah because the Israelite army captured Amaziah.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will translate the idea that people made Uzziah king "in place of" Uzziah's father. How will you show the exchange of kings without saying that the previous king died? Pause this audio here.

Uzziah was the king who rebuilt Elath and restored Elath to Judah's control after Amaziah's death. Uzziah's army would have recaptured the city of Elath before Uzziah had his people rebuild the city. Throughout this passage, the storyteller emphasizes Uzziah's victories. Uzziah did not win the wars and build defenses by himself, but Uzziah led the people of Judah to do these good things for the kingdom of Judah.

Stop here and look at a map of the kingdom of Judah. Note the locations of Jerusalem and the city of Elath on the Gulf of Aqaba. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this as a group: How do people in your culture tell the culture's history to younger generations? How do people talk about important victories from the past? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller repeats a familiar formula in Chronicles for introducing a new king. The storyteller states the new king's age, the number of years the new king reigned, where the king lived, who the new king's mother was, and where the mother was from. Uzziah became king at 16 years old, and Uzziah reigned in Jerusalem for 52 years. Jecoliah was Uzziah's mother's name, and Jecoliah was from Jerusalem. The storyteller continues the formula and states whether the king followed Yahweh: "Uzziah did right things in the eyes of Yahweh, just like Amaziah, Uzziah's father, had done."

Uzziah sought God during the days of Zechariah. In the books of Chronicles, a king who seeks God is a way to say that the king served Yahweh or followed Yahweh's commands. Zechariah taught Uzziah to fear God, or to honor God and do what God commands. During the time that Uzziah sought Yahweh, or tried to follow Yahweh, while Zechariah was alive, God gave Uzziah success.

In the second scene, we learn about Uzziah's wars and that God helped the kingdom of Judah defeat enemies. King Uzziah and his army attacked the Philistines and broke the walls of three Philistine cities: Gath, Jabneh, and Ashdod. Usually, an army would not destroy the whole wall, but the army would create a large hole in the wall so soldiers could run through the hole.

Stop and discuss how you will describe what King Uzziah and his army did to the walls of the three cities: they broke enough of the wall to allow the army to go through. Pause this audio here.

Uzziah commanded his people to rebuild cities of Judah near Ashdod and among other Philistine lands.

Stop here as a group and look again at the map of the kingdom of Judah in the context of the larger region. Note where the Philistine territory is and the cities of Ashdod, Gath, and Jabneh. Pause this audio here.

God helped Uzziah's kingdom fight against the Philistines. God helped Uzziah and Uzziah's army fight against the Arabs who lived in Gur Baal. God helped Uzziah and Uzziah's army fight against the Meunites. We do not know the specific ways God helped Uzziah win these wars. The Meunites or Ammonites regularly paid tribute to Uzziah since Uzziah was very powerful. A tribute is money or other valuable things that a weaker nation gives to a stronger nation so that the stronger nation does not destroy the weaker nation. A nation will give a tribute to another nation as a payment for protection or to keep peace.

Stop and discuss how you will translate the idea of paying tribute to another country. Pause this audio here.

The Meunites and Ammonites are two different people groups. Many translations of the Bible mention both groups, while other translations only mention the Meunites. In the original language, the spelling of these two people groups is almost identical, and we do not know which one paid tribute to King Uzziah. If the Meunites paid tribute to Uzziah, the Meunites probably began paying Uzziah after they lost the war. People living from Jerusalem to Egypt knew that Uzziah was very powerful.

Stop and discuss: What does the translation you listened to call these two groups? Did the translation use the same name or different names? Discuss what names you will use in your translation for these groups. If you do not know if you should use the same name or two different names here, we recommend you follow the example of the accepted translation in your area. Pause this audio here.

In the third scene, we learn ways Uzziah made his kingdom safer and stronger.

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Uzziah commanded his people to build towers in the city of Jerusalem. The people built the towers at the Corner Gate, the Valley Gate, and at the angle in the wall. Uzziah had the people make those places stronger. The Corner Gate was at the northwest corner of Jerusalem. The Valley Gate was on the western side of Jerusalem. Uzziah made the Corner and Valley Gates to the west, facing the land of the Philistines, stronger. The new towers protected these western entrances to Jerusalem. We do not know where the angle in the wall was, but it is where the city wall turned or curved in a different direction, in a way that was probably different from a corner.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a picture of a city wall with a tower. Pause this audio here.

Uzziah commanded the people to build towers in the open land away from the towns. The passage uses the same word for towers in the field as towers at the gates and on the wall. Soldiers stood on top of these towers to watch for approaching enemies. The soldiers would then send a message to the city that enemies were approaching. The soldiers could also shoot their arrows at the enemy soldiers when the enemy was close.

Uzziah also had the people dig many cisterns out of large rocks in the open land in order to catch water when it rained. In this way, Uzziah's livestock could receive water out in the western foothills and plains where there were no reliable water sources.

Stop here as a group and discuss how you will translate "cisterns." Pause this audio here.

Uzziah had a lot of livestock in the western foothills and plains. Uzziah also had a lot of people working in Uzziah's fields and in Uzziah's vineyards because Uzziah loved to grow crops.

Uzziah had a strong army that practiced for war. The army was always ready to go to war. The army stayed organized with groups of soldiers. Jeiel counted and organized the soldiers and the supplies. Maaseiah was an army leader, commander, or officer with some authority. Hananiah was one of the royal generals, and he led Jeiel, Maaseiah, and the whole army. There were 2,600 family leaders in charge of the mighty fighting men. These family leaders had authority over 307,500 men. The whole army trained for war and stayed ready to fight King Uzziah's enemies.

Stop here as a group and discuss how you translate types of military officers or positions. Pause this audio here.

Uzziah gave to the soldiers shields, helmets, armor, spears, bows and arrows, and slings to throw stones. Skillful men of Judah invented powerful weapons of war. In Jerusalem, Uzziah ordered men to build these devices on top of the towers and corners of the city walls. We do not know what these weapons looked like. We only know that soldiers used these devices to shoot arrows and throw large stones down from the towers onto the enemies. Uzziah became very famous in faraway places. To end the passage, the storyteller repeats an idea but uses new words. God helped Uzziah until Uzziah became powerful.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 26:1–15 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has 3 scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Amaziah, Uzziah's father
- King Uzziah
- The people of Judah
- Jecoliah, Uzziah's mother
- Zechariah, Uzziah's advisor
- Yahweh
- The Philistines
- The Arabs
- The Meunites, and possibly the Ammonites

- Jeiel, the secretary of Judah's army
- Maaseiah, the officer of Judah's army
- Hananiah, the royal general of Judah's army
- Family leaders of Judah's army
- And Judah's soldiers

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

The people of Judah made Uzziah king in place of Uzziah's father when Uzziah was 16 years old.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the people of Judah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel desperate. I do not want a 16-year-old to rule us, but we need a king now; or
- I am confident that Uzziah will be a great king for us.

Continue the drama.

After Amaziah died, King Uzziah was the one who regained control of Elath and rebuilt Elath for Judah. Uzziah became king at 16 years old, and Uzziah ruled in Jerusalem for 52 years. Jecoliah was Uzziah's mother's name, and Jecoliah was from Jerusalem. Uzziah did right in the eyes of Yahweh, just like Uzziah's father, Amaziah.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Jekoliah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- My son is too young to be king! I am scared that people will hate my son; or
- My son is smart, and I am happy that my son is following Yahweh like Amaziah; or
- I am concerned my son will be too ambitious like Amaziah.

Continue the drama.

During the days of Zechariah, Uzziah sought God and obeyed God. Zechariah instructed Uzziah in the fear of Yahweh. As long as Uzziah sought God, God made Uzziah prosperous.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Zechariah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am honored that Uzziah trusts me to teach him about Yahweh; or
- I am happy Uzziah is making good choices to follow Yahweh; or
- I hope Uzziah continues to trust Yahweh even after I am gone.

Continue the drama.

Uzziah and his army went to war against the Philistines and broke through the walls of Gath, Jabneh, and Ashdod. Uzziah had people rebuild a town of Judah near Ashdod and in other places in the Philistine territory.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Philistines, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am sad we lost three cities to Uzziah; or
- Uzziah's kingdom is trying to take over our land. I am angry and I want to get revenge.

Continue the drama.

God helped Uzziah and his army fight the Philistines, the Arabs who lived in Gur Baal, and the Meunites. The Meunites or Ammonites regularly paid taxes to Uzziah. People from Judah all the way to Egypt knew Uzziah's name and how powerful Uzziah became.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Meunites, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I will gladly pay Uzziah a lot of money so that Uzziah does not totally destroy our culture; or
- I hate to pay Uzziah, but I will pay Uzziah because we need access to Elath to sell our produce.

Continue the drama.

King Uzziah had people build towers at the Corner Gate, the Valley Gate, and the curve in the wall. Uzziah had the people make the towers stronger. Uzziah had people build towers and hewn cisterns in the open fields because Uzziah had a lot of livestock in the western foothills and plains. Uzziah had people farm his fields and work in his vineyards because Uzziah loved the land of Judah.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the people of Judah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- King Uzziah makes us feel safe with all these towers. No enemies would dare attack us now; or
- Look at all the good food we are producing for the king and all the animals we are herding for the king. I hope the king will share some of the wealth with us.

Continue the drama.

Uzziah had a strong army that practiced for war. The army was always ready to go to war. The army stayed organized with groups of soldiers. Jeiel counted and organized the soldiers and the supplies. Maaseiah was an army leader. Hananiah was one of the royal generals, and he led Jeiel, Maaseiah, and the whole army. There were 2,600 family leaders in charge of the mighty fighting men. These family leaders had authority over 307,500 men. The whole army trained for war and stayed ready to fight King Uzziah's enemies.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Jeiel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- King Uzziah is a mighty king because we have so many men in our army; or
- I feel confident our army is ready for war.

Continue the drama.

Uzziah gave to the soldiers shields, helmets, armor, spears, bows and arrows, and slings to throw stones. Skillful men of Judah invented powerful weapons of war. In Jerusalem, Uzziah ordered men to build these devices on top of the towers and corners of the city walls. These clever inventions enabled soldiers to shoot arrows and throw large stones down onto enemies. Uzziah became very famous in far away places. God helped Uzziah until Uzziah became powerful.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Uzziah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- God has made me powerful. No one can take what belongs to Judah; or
- I feel proud. Look at my army, my defense towers, my farms, and all I accomplished at Elath.

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Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 26:1–15 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

All the people of **Judah** made Uzziah **king** in place of Uzziah's father, Amaziah. Uzziah had authority over all the land, people, and resources of the kingdom of Judah. Use the same words for Judah and king that you have used previously. For more information on Judah and king, refer to the Master Glossary.

Uzziah reigned in **Jerusalem** and did what was right in the eyes of **Yahweh.** Yahweh is God's personal name. Use the same words for Jerusalem and Yahweh that you have used before. For more information on Jerusalem and Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary.

Uzziah sought **God**, and Zechariah taught Uzziah to **fear God**, or to respect God's commands and follow God. Use the same words or phrases for God and "the fear of God" as you have before. For more information on God and "fear of God," refer to the Master Glossary.

Uzziah went to war against the Philistines. Uzziah built **cities** in the region of Ashod and in the Philistine territory. Use the same word for cities that you have used previously.

Uzziah had people build **towers** at the city gates, along the city wall, and out in the fields, or **wilderness**, where no one lived. The storyteller uses the same word for these tall, protective structures in the field and near the city wall. Use the same word for tower and wilderness that you have translated previously, and for more information, refer to "lookout tower" and wilderness in the Master Glossary.

Stop here and look at a picture of a city wall with a tower, if needed. Pause this audio here.

Uzziah had a lot of livestock. Livestock includes the kinds of animals people keep for food and milk, like cows, bulls, oxen, sheep, and goats.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **livestock**. Pause this audio here.

Uzziah had many people work in his fields and **vineyards**. You will remember from other stories in 1 Chronicles and other books of the Old Testament that a vineyard is a type of farmland where grapes grow on a vine. People use grapes to make wine. Use the same word for vineyard that you have used previously, and remember that vineyard is in the Master Glossary.

Uzziah had a **scribe** named Jeiel. Use the same word or phrase for scribe as you used in 2 Chronicles 24:11, and refer to scribe in the Master Glossary for more information.

Hananiah was the king's **high official**, and Maaseiah was an **army officer** who worked for Hananiah. Use the same words or phrases for a king's high official and an army officer as you have used in previous passages.

Uzziah gave to the soldiers **shields**, **helmets**, **armor**, **spears**, **bows** and **arrows**, and **slings** to throw stones. Translate the names of these words in the same way that you have previously.

Stop here as a group and, if needed, look at pictures of the army's equipment: a shield, a helmet, armor, a spear, a bow and arrows, and a sling.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

2 Chronicles 26:1–15

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (915 KB)
- Setting the Stage (5.9 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (7.8 MB)
- Embodying the Text (5.0 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.4 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

2 Chronicles 26:16–23

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 26:16–23 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 26:16–23 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 26:16–23 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

The previous passage tells of the good things King Uzziah did to protect Judah and make it prosperous. God helped Uzziah until Uzziah became powerful. This passage tells how King Uzziah became prideful and failed to obey God. Uzziah became sick for the rest of Uzziah's life.

After Uzziah became powerful, Uzziah became too prideful. Uzziah's pride destroyed Uzziah. King Uzziah disobeyed Yahweh, Uzziah's God. Uzziah entered the temple of Yahweh to burn incense, or sweet-smelling spices, on the altar of incense. You will remember that Yahweh told Moses that only priests could enter Yahweh's temple to serve Yahweh with incense.

But Azariah the priest followed Uzziah into the temple with 80 other brave priests of Yahweh. All the priests confronted King Uzziah. The priests told Uzziah that he was not supposed to offer incense to Yahweh. Only the

priests, descendants of Aaron, could burn incense. God chose only the priests to serve Yahweh in this way. The priests told Uzziah to leave the holy place because Uzziah had acted unfaithfully toward God. The priests said that Yahweh God would not honor Uzziah or give Uzziah a good reputation.

Stop and look at a diagram of the temple and pictures of incense, a censer for incense, and the altar of incense, if needed. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell about a time when a leader or important person in your culture did something wrong. What did others around the leader do about it? How is talking to leaders in your culture the same or different from what the priests did to Uzziah? Pause this audio here.

Uzziah became very angry at the priests. Uzziah had a bowl of incense in his hands. Uzziah was ready to burn the incense. While Uzziah was angry at the priests, leprosy or skin disease appeared on Uzziah's forehead. The priests saw the leprosy appear while Uzziah stood near the altar of incense. Azariah the high priest and all the priests saw the leprosy appear on Uzziah's forehead. The priests hurried Uzziah out of the temple. Uzziah himself went quickly when Uzziah realized Yahweh had punished Uzziah.

King Uzziah had leprosy or a skin disease until the day Uzziah died. For the rest of Uzziah's life, Uzziah lived in a house separated from other people. Because Uzziah had this skin disease, Uzziah could never go back to Yahweh's house, the temple. You will remember that Yahweh gave the law to Moses that no one with a skin disease could enter the temple. A person with a skin disease, like King Uzziah, was ritually unclean. Yahweh said in Yahweh's law that someone with a skin disease had to live away from that person's family and other people.

Stop here as a group and discuss this question: When in your culture does someone have to be alone or stay away from other people? What do you do when someone has a contagious disease or is ritually unclean? Pause this audio here.

Because Uzziah had leprosy or a skin disease, Uzziah was unable to act like a king would normally do. Uzziah's son, Jotham, managed the royal household and ruled the nation of Judah.

The prophet Isaiah, son of Amoz, wrote about all the things that King Uzziah did. This is not the same book as the prophecy of Isaiah that we have in the Bible. We do not know what happened to these missing writings from Isaiah.

So Uzziah died, and people buried Uzziah in the field that belonged to the kings. This field was near the royal burial place. The people did not bury Uzziah's body with the other kings of Judah because Uzziah had leprosy. Jotham, Uzziah's son, became king in Uzziah's place.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 26:16–23 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has two scenes.

In the first scene: King Uzziah goes into Yahweh's temple to burn incense, which is lawful only for priests to do. Azariah and 80 other priests confront Uzziah. Uzziah gets angry at the priests, and Yahweh makes Uzziah sick with a skin disease. Uzziah quickly leaves the temple.

In the second scene: Uzziah lives alone for the rest of his life because Uzziah has leprosy. Uzziah never goes back to the temple. Uzziah's son Jotham rules the kingdom instead of Uzziah. Uzziah dies, and people bury Uzziah in a field. Jotham becomes king.

The characters in this passage are:

- Yahweh
- King Uzziah
- Azariah, Yahweh's high priest
- Eighty priests of Yahweh

- Jotham, Uzziah's son
- And the people of Judah

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

"But King Uzziah became too prideful after Uzziah became powerful." The first scene begins with a word that shows the story is continuing from the previous story, but in a different way. The storyteller contrasts Uzziah's sin with Uzziah's victories from the previous passage. Pride is a sin against Yahweh. In the original language, the storyteller says that Uzziah's "heart was lifted up" to show that Uzziah became arrogant. Someone who is prideful, or arrogant, is convinced they are good and that they can do no wrong. When Uzziah first became king, Uzziah followed Yahweh closely. After Uzziah became powerful, Uzziah did not obey Yahweh. Uzziah followed his own way.

Stop here as a group and tell a story from your culture where a character is doing something, and then the character suddenly does something different that seems against what the character first did. Pay attention to the word or phrase you use to show the story continues in the same way, as well as the word or phrase you use to show the story suddenly changes. Pause this audio here.

King Uzziah acted in a proud way when Uzziah thought he did not have to follow Yahweh's rules. Uzziah acted unfaithfully, or disobeyed Yahweh. King Uzziah's sin caused Yahweh to destroy the rest of King Uzziah's reign as king. Uzziah was unfaithful to Yahweh, Uzziah's God, when Uzziah went into the temple of Yahweh to burn incense on the altar of incense. You will remember from earlier stories in the Bible that the incense altar was inside the holy place, the front room of the temple. God commanded only the priests to enter the holy place to burn incense, keep the lamps burning, and do other rituals of worship to Yahweh. Before the priests could enter the temple, the priests had to wash themselves according to Yahweh's commands in order to become ritually clean. Uzziah was prideful because Uzziah thought he did not have to follow Yahweh's rules.

Stop here as a group and discuss this question: What places in your culture can only certain people go to? What responsibilities or actions can only certain people do? Consider places and actions for only men, only women, or perhaps only the elderly or the leaders. What happens if someone does what that person is not supposed to do? Pause this audio here.

But Azariah the high priest and 80 other priests of Yahweh had great courage and went into the temple after the king. The storyteller uses the same word as at the start of this passage to show that the story is continuing but in an opposite way than before. The storyteller calls the priests men of great courage, which usually describes brave soldiers. The priests stood against Uzziah and told Uzziah that he could not offer incense to Yahweh because that duty was only for priests, the descendants of Aaron. Only priests are able to burn incense because Yahweh has consecrated or set priests apart from other people for this special purpose. The priests told the king that the king must leave the temple and that Yahweh God would not honor Uzziah for burning incense.

The king already had a "censer" or bowl of incense in his hands, and the king became very angry at the priests. A censer is a small bowl or pan that the priests used to burn incense. A craftsman made the censer from metal. The censer had a handle so a person could carry the censer to the altar.

Stop here and look at a picture of a censer of incense. Pause this audio here.

We do not know what Uzziah said or did when he was angry, but Uzziah did not do what the priests said. Uzziah was standing near the altar of incense. While Uzziah was showing his anger, the priests suddenly saw a skin disease appear on Uzziah's forehead. We do not know exactly what the skin disease looked like. Perhaps Uzziah's skin changed color or blisters formed. The priests immediately recognized the leprosy, and the priests moved quickly to get Uzziah out of the temple. Uzziah quickly moved out of the temple when he realized Yahweh had struck Uzziah with leprosy. This is special language to show that Yahweh had punished Uzziah with leprosy. Yahweh made Uzziah sick in an instant. It happened in a brief moment. You may remember that leprosy is what the people called a contagious skin disease that caused people to be ceremonially unclean. You may simply call this a contagious skin disease.

In the second scene, King Uzziah had leprosy or a skin disease for the rest of his life. Uzziah died with the disease. Uzziah lived by himself in a separate house for the rest of Uzziah's life. Uzziah could not have contact with

anyone. Uzziah could never return to the temple, or house of Yahweh. Jotham, Uzziah's son, ruled the kingdom and managed everyone in the king's house.

The storyteller uses a common formula to end the stories of a king. The storyteller says that someone wrote about the king's life, and then the storyteller says the king died, people buried the king's body, and the king's son became the next king. The prophet Isaiah, son of Amoz, wrote down everything King Uzziah did from beginning to end. Uzziah "slept with his fathers" or died. People buried Uzziah in a cemetery, or a burial field that belonged to the kings, rather than in the burial caves where people buried the other kings. In the original language, the word refers to a field or an open place where people buried dead bodies. This field was near the kings' burial caves. People had to bury Uzziah's body in a separate place from the other kings since Uzziah had a skin disease. Uzziah's son, Jotham, became the new king.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 26:16–23 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has two scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Yahweh
- King Uzziah
- Azariah, Yahweh's high priest
- Eighty priests of Yahweh
- Jotham, Uzziah's son
- And the people of Judah

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

"But King Uzziah became too prideful after he became powerful." King Uzziah's pride caused Uzziah to act unfaithfully, and then destroyed Uzziah. Uzziah sinned against Yahweh his God when Uzziah went into Yahweh's temple to burn incense on the altar of incense.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the people of Judah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am worried. Our king is so powerful and he is ignoring God; or
- When you are powerful, you get to do whatever you want. That is just how kings act.

Continue the drama.

But Azariah the priest followed Uzziah into the temple with 80 other brave priests of Yahweh. All the priests confronted King Uzziah. The priests told Uzziah that he was not supposed to offer incense to Yahweh. Only the

priests, descendants of Aaron, could burn incense. God chose only the priests to serve Yahweh in this way. The priests told Uzziah to leave the holy place because Uzziah acted unfaithfully toward God. The priests said that Yahweh God would not honor Uzziah or give Uzziah a good reputation.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the priests, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- The king is powerful, but we must obey God even if it is hard; or
- I am scared to confront the king by myself, but with Azariah and the other priests, I think Uzziah will listen to us.

Continue the drama.

Uzziah became furious at the priests. Uzziah had a bowl of incense in his hands. Uzziah was ready to burn the incense. While Uzziah was angry at the priests, leprosy or skin disease appeared on Uzziah's forehead.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the Uzziah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am the king! I defeated our enemies and I can worship God however I want to; or
- These priests are wrong to talk against me. God will show these priests that I am in charge.

Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- My priests honor my name, and I will be strong to defend my priests; or
- I am sad and angry that Uzziah has stopped obeying me. I cannot let Uzziah ignore my laws.

Continue the drama.

The priests saw the leprosy appear while Uzziah stood near the altar of incense. Azariah the high priest and all the priests saw the leprosy appear on Uzziah's forehead. The priests hurried Uzziah out of the temple. Uzziah himself went quickly when he realized Yahweh had punished Uzziah.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Azariah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am sad that King Uzziah ignored Yahweh's laws and can never come back to the temple; or
- I was shocked when I saw the leprosy on Uzziah's forehead!

Continue the drama.

King Uzziah was a leper until the day he died. For the rest of Uzziah's life, Uzziah lived in a house separated from other people. Because Uzziah was a leper, Uzziah could never go back to Yahweh's house, or temple. Uzziah's son, Jotham, managed the royal household and ruled the nation of Judah.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Uzziah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I regret that I did not follow Yahweh like Zechariah taught me to do. I wish Zechariah were still alive to help me; or
- I am so angry that I can never go back to the temple again or rule like a good king. Now everyone will think I am weak.

Continue the drama.

All the other things King Uzziah did, from beginning to end, are recorded in another book. The prophet Isaiah, son of Amoz, wrote everything down. So Uzziah died, and people buried Uzziah in the burial field that belonged to the kings. The people did not bury Uzziah's body with the other kings of Judah because Uzziah had leprosy. Jotham, Uzziah's son, became king in Uzziah's place.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 26:16–23 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

2 Chronicles 26:16–23

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

This passage uses both God's personal name, **Yahweh**, and the word for the creator, **God.** Sometimes the storyteller uses these words together, such as "Yahweh, Uzziah's God," to emphasize Yahweh's power or Yahweh's special relationship with Yahweh's people. Use the same words for Yahweh and God that you have used before. For more information on Yahweh and God, refer to the Master Glossary.

"Uzziah entered the **temple** of Yahweh." You will remember that the temple of Yahweh is the special place where God promised that God's presence would live. Sometimes in the Bible and in this passage, the temple is called "the house of Yahweh." Use the same words or phrases for temple or "house of Yahweh" as you have done before. For more information, refer to temple or "**house of God**" in the Master Glossary.

Uzziah went into the temple to burn incense, or sweet-smelling spices, on the **altar of incense** or the altar for burning incense. You will remember that Yahweh instructed Moses to build an altar for burning sacrifices of grain and animals. Yahweh also instructed Moses to build an altar for burning incense, which is the altar Uzziah went towards. Translate "altar" the same way you have previously, and specify in your language that this is the altar for burning incense. For more information on altars, refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop here and look at a picture of the altar of incense, if needed. Pause this audio here.

Azariah was the **high priest**, and Azariah went into the temple with 80 other **priests**. All the priests confronted **King** Uzziah. Translate high priest, priest, and king in the same way you have previously. For more information on high priest, priest, and king, refer to the Master Glossary.

The king already had a censer, or bowl of incense, in his hands, and he became very angry at the priests. A censer is a small bowl or pan that the priests used to burn incense. A craftsman made the censer from metal. It had a handle so a person could carry the censer to the altar.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **censer**. Look at a picture of a censer of incense, if needed. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

God **consecrated** or set apart only the descendants of Aaron, who were priests, to serve in the temple. No one besides priests had this special job. God also consecrated the **sanctuary** or **holy place** where the altar of incense was. Uzziah went into the sanctuary, where it was unlawful for Uzziah to go. Use the same words for consecrated and sanctuary or holy place as you have used before. For more information on consecrate, sanctuary, and holy place, refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop and look at a diagram of the temple that shows the location of the holy place, if needed. Pause this audio here.

The priests saw leprosy appear on Uzziah's forehead. In the Bible, leprosy refers to a skin disease. Yahweh said in his law that someone with leprosy was ceremonially unclean and unable to worship Yahweh in Yahweh's temple.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for leprosy. Look up **leprosy** in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Jotham, Uzziah's son, was in charge of the **palace** or the king's **household**. Use the same word for palace or household that you have used previously. You may use whichever word—palace or household—works best in your language. For more information on household, refer to the Master Glossary.

"The **prophet** Isaiah, son of Amoz, wrote everything down." A prophet was a messenger of Yahweh. Use the same word for prophet as you have used before. For more information on prophet, refer to the Master Glossary.

Uzziah "slept with his fathers." This is a common phrase in the books of Kings and Chronicles to say that a king died. Use the same phrase you have used previously to say that a king died. In Uzziah's case, people did not bury him with the other kings because Uzziah had leprosy. People buried Uzziah in a burial field that belonged to the kings, instead of the burial caves with the other kings. In the original language, the word refers to a field or an

open place where people were buried. It is important in your translation to make clear that Uzziah "sleeping with his fathers" is different from people burying Uzziah with his fathers.

Stop here as a group and discuss what words or phrases you will use to describe the place where Uzziah was buried.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

2 Chronicles 26:16–23

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (924 KB)
- Setting the Stage (2.8 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (4.7 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.8 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (3.7 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

2 Chronicles 27:1–9

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 27:1–9 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 27:1–9 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.

2 Chronicles 27:1–9

5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 27:1–9 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the last story, Yahweh struck King Uzziah with a contagious skin disease because the king tried to burn incense in the temple. This was a job only the priests could do. So Uzziah's son, Jotham, began to rule the people of Judah alongside his father.

After Uzziah died, Jotham became Judah's next king. Jotham began to rule when he was 25 years old, and Jotham ruled for 16 years. It is most likely that those 16 years include the time Jotham ruled alongside his father, as well as the time Jotham ruled alone after Jotham's father died. Jotham's mother was Jerusha, and Jotham's grandfather's name was Zadok.

The storyteller describes Jotham as a good king who did what was right in the eyes of Yahweh. In other words, Jotham tried to live in a way that pleases Yahweh, just like Jotham's father, Uzziah. But unlike Uzziah, Jotham did not enter the temple, since only priests could go inside to offer sacrifices. Though Jotham follows Yahweh, the people of Judah continue their very bad practices of worshiping false gods. We know from 2 Kings 15 that Jotham does not destroy the high places, or the shrines where people go to sacrifice to false gods.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do leaders in your community influence the spiritual lives of their people? How do you see people acting differently from their leaders in the way people practice their religion? Pause this audio here.

While Jotham is king, Jotham does many building projects. Jotham has his men build the Upper Gate of the temple, which is at the northern entrance of the temple area. We are not sure if Jotham builds a new Upper Gate or if Jotham just builds on top of the structure that was already there.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What kinds of building projects bring people together when they work on them in your community? What building projects do people do to protect their land or communities? Pause this audio here.

Jotham also does a lot of work on the city wall at the hill of Ophel, which was a part of Jerusalem. Jotham's men build cities in the hilly country or mountains of Judah, as well as strong buildings and towers in the forests. The towers would have allowed the people of Judah to see over the forests and see their enemies coming from far away.

Jotham also has military success as the king of Judah. Jotham goes to war with and defeats the Ammonites. The Ammonites lived to the east of the Jordan River in what is now modern-day Jordan.

Stop here as a group and look at a map that shows where Ammon is in relation to Jerusalem. Pause this audio here.

Jotham forces the Ammonite people to pay Jotham a tribute, or taxes, for three years. The Ammonites give Jotham 100 talents, or around 3 tons, of silver, 1,600 metric tons of wheat, and 1,600 metric tons of barley every year. Both wheat and barley are types of grain. These were huge amounts of barley and grain. In this culture, people used barley to feed animals and wheat to make bread.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a picture of grains of barley and wheat. In your community, what things do people think are valuable enough to exchange or pay for goods? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller tells us that Jotham becomes very powerful because Jotham is careful to obey Yahweh faithfully. As with previous kings, the storyteller says that we can learn more about Jotham and what Jotham did as king in the book or scroll that someone wrote about the Kings of Israel and Judah.

Jotham dies, and the people bury Jotham with his ancestors in Jerusalem, the City of David. This was how people usually buried kings in those days, with other former kings. Jotham's son Ahaz becomes the next king of Judah.

2 Chronicles 27:1–9

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 27:1–9 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: Jotham becomes the next king of Judah when Jotham is 25 years old. Jotham rules from Jerusalem for 16 years. Jotham rules the people in a way that is pleasing to Yahweh. But the people of Judah continue to follow other gods instead of Yahweh.

In the second scene: Jotham and his men build the upper gate of the temple, build new towns, and establish new forts and towers near Jerusalem. Jotham and his men defeat the Ammonites and make the Ammonites pay taxes of silver, barely, and wheat for three years.

In the third scene: Jotham dies, and the people bury Jotham near his ancestors in Jerusalem. Jotham's son Ahaz becomes the next king of Judah.

The characters in this passage are:

- Jotham
- Uzziah
- Yahweh
- The people of Judah
- Jotham's men who help Jotham build
- The Ammonites
- And Ahaz

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

It is important to remember that at this time, Israel was divided into two kingdoms: the northern kingdom of Israel and the southern kingdom of Judah.

The storyteller uses the same format as previous passages to introduce Jotham as the king of Judah. Jotham was the son of Uzziah. Jotham became king when Jotham was 25 years old, reigned from Jerusalem, and ruled as king for 16 years. Jotham's mother was Jerusha, and Jotham's grandfather was Zadok.

It is important to remember that Jotham began to rule while his father, Uzziah, was still king, after Yahweh struck Uzziah with a contagious skin disease. Jotham most likely ruled for 10 years alongside his father before Jotham took over as king after his father died.

Jotham did what was right in the eyes of Yahweh, just like Jotham's father Uzziah. In other words, Jotham lived and ruled in a way that was pleasing to Yahweh. As you remember, Uzziah also lived in a way that was mostly pleasing to Yahweh. However, Uzziah disobeyed Yahweh when Uzziah tried to burn incense in the temple. Unlike his father, Uzziah, Jotham does not disobey Yahweh in this way.

The people continue in their corrupt ways of doing things. This most likely refers to the people continuing to worship false gods in the high places.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: When something or someone is corrupt, they are ruined, spoiled, or flawed. How will you describe corrupt ways of doing things in your language? Pause this audio here.

During Jotham's time as king, Jotham built the Upper Gate of the temple. We do not know if Jotham built or rebuilt the Upper Gate. It is best to follow whatever translation you are listening to.

Jotham also built new cities and established new forts and towers near Jerusalem. Forts are well-protected, strong groups of buildings with a strong wall, while towers are very tall structures. Jotham built the towers in wooded areas where it was difficult for someone who stood on the ground to see far away. So the towers were particularly important to allow people to see enemies coming from far away.

2 Chronicles 27:1–9

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Think about your discussion in the previous step about how people protect their land and community. How will you talk about the forts and towers in your translation? Pause this audio here.

Jotham and his men go to war with and defeat the Ammonite king and his army. Jotham forces the Ammonite people to pay Jotham taxes for three years. The Ammonites pay Jotham 100 talents, or around 3 tons, of silver, 10,000 cors of wheat, and 10,000 cors of barley. Ten thousand cors would have been around 1,500 or 1,800 metric tons. This was a huge amount of wheat and barley.

Jotham becomes powerful because Jotham walks steadfastly before Yahweh. This is special language that means Jotham was careful to obey Yahweh in all that Jotham did.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What word or phrase will you use in your language to say that Jotham was careful to obey Yahweh in all that Jotham did? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller tells us we can find all of Jotham's acts as king in the book, or scroll, that someone wrote about the kings of Israel and Judah. This book no longer exists.

King Jotham dies, and the people bury Jotham with his ancestors in Jerusalem. This is the same phrase the storyteller always uses to end a king's history, so you will remember that people usually buried kings in a cave that they had cut out of rock. King Jotham's son, Ahaz, becomes the next king of Judah.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 27:1–9 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Jotham
- Uzziah
- Yahweh
- The people of Judah
- Jotham's men who help Jotham build
- The Ammonites
- And Ahaz

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Act out Jotham becoming the next king of Judah when Jotham is 25 years old. Jotham rules from Jerusalem for 16 years. Jotham rules the people in a way that is pleasing to Yahweh. The people of Judah continue their corrupt practices.

2 Chronicles 27:1–9

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Jotham, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel determined. I will not repeat the mistakes of my father; or
- I feel discouraged. I wish the people would turn away from false gods and only worship Yahweh; or
- I feel humble. I want to rule in a way that pleases Yahweh.

Continue the drama.

Act out Jotham's men rebuilding the upper gate of the temple, building new cities, and establishing new forts and towers near Jerusalem. Jotham and his men go to war with and defeat the Ammonites. Jotham forces the Ammonites to pay taxes of silver, barley, and wheat for three years.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Jotham's men, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel happy. Jotham is a good king. Jotham makes our cities stronger; or
- I am hopeful. I can see Yahweh's favor on Jotham. Yahweh will protect us from our enemies; or
- I feel encouraged. We defeated our enemies, and now our enemies are paying to make us even stronger!

Continue the drama.

Act out Jotham dying and the people burying Jotham near his ancestors in Jerusalem. Jotham's son Ahaz becomes the next king of Judah.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 27:1–9 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Jotham becomes the next **king** and rules from **Jerusalem**. A king is someone who rules over a city or territory, like a region or a country. Jerusalem was the capital city of Judah. Use the same word or phrase for king and Jerusalem as you used in previous passages. For more information on king and Jerusalem, refer to the Master Glossary.

Jotham did "**what was right in the eyes of Yahweh**," or Jotham lived in a way that was pleasing to Yahweh. Be sure to use the same word or phrase for "what was right in the eyes of Yahweh" as you used in previous passages. For more information on Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary.

Jotham follows after his father, but he does not enter the temple of Yahweh. The Temple, or the house of Yahweh, was located in Jerusalem. It was the place where the people worshipped Yahweh. Only priests could enter the temple to make sacrifices on behalf of the people. Use the same word or phrase for temple as you used in previous passages. For more information on the **temple**, refer to the Master Glossary.

Jotham and his men built new **cities**, **strongholds**, and **lookout towers** in **Judah**. A city was an area where a large number of people lived and did business. Cities included various structures for living and community life. This kind of stronghold was a group of strong buildings with a strong wall that people built to protect themselves from danger. Be sure to translate city, stronghold, lookout towers, and Judah in the same way you have in previous passages. For more information on stronghold, lookout tower, and Judah, refer to the Master Glossary.

Jotham conquers the Ammonites, and the Ammonites have to pay Jotham a tax for three years. The tax includes 100 **talents** of silver. A talent is a unit of measurement that is around 34 kilograms or 75 pounds. One hundred talents of silver would be around 3.4 tons of silver. Use the same word or phrase for talent as you used in previous passages. For more information on talent, refer to the Master Glossary.

The Ammonites also have to pay Jotham 10,000 **cors** of wheat and 10,000 cors of barley. A cor is a unit that people used to measure grain. Weights and measures differed at different times in the Bible, so modern equivalents for the measurements are not always the same. Most scholars agree that a cor equaled between 6.5 and 14 bushels.

2 Chronicles 28:1–8

A bushel was around 8 liters. These 10,000 cors of wheat would have weighed around 1,600 to 1,800 metric tons. Be sure to translate cor in the same way you have in previous passages.

The storyteller says that people can read about the acts of Jotham in the book or **scroll** about the kings of Israel and Judah. This was a historical account of the kings of Israel and Judah. However, this book no longer exists. Be sure to translate scroll in the same way you did in previous passages, and refer to scroll in the Master Glossary for more information.

Jotham dies, and the people bury Jotham with his ancestors in the City of David. This refers to the custom where people buried kings in the same place as former kings. Be sure to translate "they bury Jotham with his ancestors in the City of David" in the same way you have in previous passages.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

2 Chronicles 28:1–8

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 28:1–8 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 28:1–8 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 28:1–8 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

2 Chronicles 28:1–8

In the previous story, the storyteller told us what happened during Jotham's time as king of Judah. Jotham followed Yahweh, completed many building projects, and defeated the Ammonites in war. When Jotham died, Jotham's son, Ahaz, became the next king.

Ahaz was 20 years old when Ahaz began to rule from Jerusalem. Ahaz ruled for 16 years as king.

Unlike Ahaz's ancestor, King David, Ahaz does not do what is right in the eyes of Yahweh. In other words, Ahaz does not live in a way that pleases Yahweh. Instead, Ahaz acts like the kings of the northern kingdom of Israel, who continually disobeyed Yahweh. The storyteller compares Ahaz to the northern kings to show how bad Ahaz truly was. Ahaz behaves so badly that Ahaz tells people to make metal statues of Baal, the Canaanite god of storms and fertility. The people pour melted liquid metals, such as gold, silver, bronze, or iron, into molds and allow the metal to cool and harden to make metal idols. The people then use the metal idols to worship the god Baal.

Stop here and look at a picture of a metal idol of Baal. In your culture, what kinds of objects or symbols do people use to show respect or devotion to spirits or gods? Pause this audio here.

Ahaz was so far from Yahweh that Ahaz made offerings in the Valley of Ben Hinnom, southwest of Jerusalem, and even burned Ahaz's own sons as a sacrifice.

Stop here as a group and look at a map that shows Jerusalem and the Valley of Ben Hinnom. Pause this audio here.

The people who lived in the land before the Israelites did many evil things. Specifically, the Ammonites burned their children in fire to worship their god Molech. But Yahweh took the land away from those people and gave the Israelites specific laws that forbid child sacrifices. The Israelites viewed child sacrifice as something hateful and a disgusting violation against Yahweh. When Ahaz sacrifices his son to the false god, Ahaz shows just how wicked Ahaz has become.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do people in your culture talk about the difference between religious practices that cause people to live well and religious practices that cause harm? Pause this audio here.

Ahaz not only sacrifices his sons, but Ahaz also offers sacrifices and worships at the high places, on the hilltops, and under every green tree. The high places were places where people worshiped and made sacrifices to other gods who were not Yahweh, the one true Creator God. The people offered animals and burned incense, or sweet-smelling spices, to their gods. The high places, hilltops, and beneath green trees were all common places for non-Israelites to worship their gods. The Israelites considered these places to be unclean and unfit for worship to Yahweh.

Because of Ahaz's disobedience, Yahweh gives Ahaz into the hands of the king of Aram, which means Yahweh allows the king of Aram to defeat Ahaz. We know from 2 Kings 16 that Rezin was the King of Aram, or Syria. King Rezin's army not only defeats Ahaz, but he takes many of the people of Judah prisoner and forces them to move to the city of Damascus. Damascus was the capital city of Aram.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story of a time when a leader's choices led the whole community into trouble. Pause this audio here.

Yahweh also allows Ahaz to be in the hand of, or under the power of, King Pekah of Israel. Pekah's army killed 120,000 experienced soldiers in Ahaz's army. Yahweh allows King Pekah to defeat Ahaz and his army because they did not worship Yahweh as their ancestors did, but instead worshiped false gods. During the battle, Zicri, a champion fighter from the clan of Ephraim, kills three important men. Ephraim was one of the tribes of Israel, and Ephraim belonged to the northern kingdom. Zicri kills Maaseiah, one of the sons of King Ahaz. It is unclear if Maaseiah was an actual son of the king or if this was a title. Zicri also kills Azrikam, the commander of the palace, or the official who was in charge of the palace and Elkanah, who was second in command to the king.

Once the soldiers from the northern kingdom of Israel win the battle, the soldiers take 200,000 women and children as prisoners. The women and children from Judah were also relatives of the Israelites, because they were descendants of Jacob. The Israelite soldiers take a large amount of valuables from the people of Judah and carry the plunder and the people back to the capital city of Samaria in Israel.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a map that shows Judah, Israel, and Syria, as well as the cities of Damascus, Jerusalem, and Samaria.

2 Chronicles 28:1–8

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 28:1–8 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four scenes.

In the first scene: Ahaz becomes the king of Judah when he is 20 years old, and Ahaz rules for 16 years. While Ahaz is king, Ahaz does not act in a way that pleases Yahweh. Ahaz orders people to make metal images to worship Baal. Ahaz goes to the valley of Ben Hinnom and sacrifices his sons in the fire to worship a false god. Ahaz makes offerings and worships false gods at the high places, on the hill tops, and under every green tree.

In the second scene: Yahweh allows Rezin, the King of Aram, or Syria, to come against King Ahaz and defeat him. The Aramian army defeats the people of Judah and forces many of the people to move to the city of Damascus.

In the third scene: Yahweh allows Pekah, the king of Israel, to come against King Ahaz. The Israelite army kills 120,000 strong soldiers of Judah. An Israelite soldier, Zicri, kills three important men during the battle: Maaseiah, Ahaz's son; Azrikam, the official in charge of Ahaz's palace; and Elkanah, the second in command to Ahaz.

In the fourth scene: The Israelite soldiers force 200,000 women and children from Judah to be prisoners, even though they are relatives. The Israelite soldiers take many valuable items from Judah, and the soldiers force the prisoners to go to their capital city, Samaria.

The characters in this passage are:

- Ahaz
- Ahaz's sons
- Rezin, king of Aram or Syria
- The Aramian army
- Pekah, king of Israel
- The Israelite army
- The men of Judah
- Zicri
- Maaseiah
- Azrikam
- Elkanah
- And the 200,000 women and children prisoners from Judah

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

The storyteller uses the same format as previous passages to introduce Ahaz as the king of Judah. Ahaz became king when Ahaz was 20 years old, reigned from Jerusalem, and ruled as king for 16 years.

Unlike Ahaz's father, David, Ahaz did not do what was right in the eyes of Yahweh. It is important to remember that David was not the actual father of Ahaz, but rather, David was the ancestor of Ahaz. "Did not do what was right in the eyes of Yahweh" is special language that means Ahaz did not act in a way that was pleasing to Yahweh. Instead of serving Yahweh, Ahaz worshiped false gods.

Ahaz walked in the way of the kings of Israel. It is important to remember that here, Israel refers to the northern kingdom of Israel and not to the nation as a whole. The storyteller saw these Israelite kings as evil because most of them did not follow Yahweh. The storyteller is not referring to how Ahaz physically walked. Rather, the storyteller is saying that Ahaz acted like or imitated the kings of Israel because Ahaz had no desire to obey Yahweh.

Ahaz made cast idols for worshipping the Baals. Ahaz did not make the idols himself, but most likely ordered people to make the metal images for Ahaz. Baal was a Canaanite god of storms and fertility.

2 Chronicles 28:1–8

Ahaz also goes to the Valley of Ben Hinnom to burn incense and make offerings. Ahaz also sacrifices his sons in the fire to worship a false god.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a picture of the Valley of Ben Hinnom. Pause this audio here.

It is important to remember that the Ammonite people often practiced child sacrifice to worship their god, Molech. Yahweh's law strictly forbade child sacrifice, so the Israelites saw it as a disgusting or detestable act against Yahweh. You will remember that detestable things are things that Yahweh hates.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story about someone who did something absolutely horrible. Pay attention to the words and phrases you use to talk about this horrible thing. Pause this audio here.

When Ahaz sacrificed his sons, Ahaz acted like the people who used to live in the land of Israel before Yahweh allowed the Israelites to conquer the land. It is important to notice that the storyteller says Ahaz sacrificed more than one son, while 2 Kings 16 says Ahaz only sacrificed one son.

Ahaz offered sacrifices and burned incense, or sweet-smelling spices, at the high places, on the hilltops, and under every green tree. It is important to remember that the high places, hill tops, and beneath green trees were all common places for non-Israelites to worship their gods. This was another way to say that Ahaz made offerings at every place where people were not supposed to worship Yahweh.

The storyteller says it is because Ahaz continued to disobey Yahweh that Yahweh gave Ahaz into the hand of the King of Aram, or Syria. When someone is "in the hand" of someone else, that person is under the power of that person. In other words, Yahweh allows King Rezin to defeat King Ahaz and take many of Ahaz's people prisoner to the city of Damascus in Aram.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story of someone who was under the power or authority of someone else. Pay attention to what words or phrases you use to describe someone who is under the control of someone else. Pause this audio here.

Yahweh also gives Ahaz into the hand of, or under the power of, King Pekah of Israel. During one battle, King Pekah's soldiers kill 120,000 experienced soldiers of Judah. Israel defeats Judah because Ahaz and the people of Judah had abandoned Yahweh, the God of their ancestors. The storyteller says this because the storyteller wants to remind us that Yahweh specially chose the people of Judah as his own people, and yet the people chose to reject Yahweh.

During the battle, Zicri, a champion fighter from Israel, kills three important men: Maaseiah, Ahaz's son; Azrikam, the official in charge of Ahaz's palace; and Elkanah, the second in command to Ahaz.

The Israelite army takes many valuable items from Judah, and the Israelite army forces 200,000 women and children of Judah to be prisoners. The Israelite army takes the valuables and forces the prisoners to go to Samaria, the capital city of Israel. It is important to remember that the people living in the kingdoms of Israel and Judah were relatives because they were all descendants of Jacob.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 28:1–8 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Ahaz
- Ahaz's sons
- Rezin, king of Aram or Syria
- The Syrian army
- Pekah, king of Israel

- The Israelite army
- The men of Judah
- Zicri
- Maaseiah
- Azrikam
- Elkanah
- And the 200,000 women and children prisoners from Judah

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Act out Ahaz becoming the king of Judah when Ahaz is 20 years old. Ahaz rules for 16 years. While Ahaz is king, Ahaz does not act in a way that pleases Yahweh. Ahaz has people make metal images to worship Baal. Ahaz goes to the valley of Ben Hinnom and sacrifices his sons in the fire to worship a false god. Ahaz makes offerings and worships false gods at the high places, on the hilltops, and under every green tree.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the people of Judah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel offended. How could our king sacrifice his children to a false god? or
- I feel scared. If King Ahaz is this desperate, he must feel threatened by our enemies; or
- I feel sad. King Ahaz has completely walked away from Yahweh. Our nation will suffer because of King Ahaz's disobedience.

Continue the drama.

Act out Yahweh allowing Rezin, the king of Aram, to attack King Ahaz in Jerusalem and conquer him. The Syrian army defeats the people of Judah and forces many of the people to move to the city of Damascus.

Act out how Yahweh allows Pekah, the king of Israel, to come against King Ahaz. The Israelite army kills 120,000 strong soldiers of Judah. An Israelite soldier, Zicri, kills three important men during the battle: Maaseiah, Ahaz's son; Azrikam, the official in charge of Ahaz's palace; and Elkanah, the second in command to Ahaz.

Act out how the Israelite soldiers force 200,000 women and children from Judah to be prisoners. The Israelite soldiers take many valuable items from Judah, and the soldiers force the prisoners to go to Samaria.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the prisoners, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel shocked. These soldiers are our relatives! How could they do this to us? or
- I feel panicked. I do not want to leave my homeland; or
- I am afraid. I want to go back to my family.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 28:1–8 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

2 Chronicles 28:1–8

Ahaz becomes the next **king** of Judah, and Ahaz rules from **Jerusalem**. A king is someone who rules over a city or territory, like a region or a country. Jerusalem was the capital city of the kingdom of Judah. Use the same words or phrases for king and Jerusalem as you used in previous passages. For more information on king or Jerusalem, refer to the Master Glossary.

Ahaz does not do **what is right in the eyes of Yahweh**. In other words, Ahaz does not act in a way that pleases Yahweh. Yahweh is God's personal name and shows God's special relationship with his people. Use the same word or phrase for "what was right in the eyes of Yahweh" as you used in previous passages. For more information on **Yahweh**, refer to the Master Glossary.

Ahaz walks in the ways of the kings of **Israel**. Here, Israel refers to the northern kingdom of Israel, not to the nation as a whole. Use the same word or phrase for Israel, meaning the northern kingdom, as you used in previous passages. For more information on Israel, refer to the Master Glossary.

Ahaz even has people make metal **idols** for worshiping **Baal**. Baal refers to the male Canaanite god of fertility and storms. An idol is an object people made out of wood, stone, or metal in order to worship a god. Use the same word or phrase for Baal and idol as you used in previous passages. For more information on Baal and idols, refer to the Master Glossary.

Ahaz burns incense to, or **sacrifices**, in the Valley of Ben Hinnom. In Jewish culture, people only burned incense or sacrificed on the altar in the temple. You may say that Ahaz burns incense in the Valley of Ben Hinnom, or you may say that Ahaz sacrifices or makes **offerings**. If you use sacrifices or offerings in your translation, refer to sacrifices or offerings in the Master Glossary for more information, and use the same words or phrases for sacrifices or offerings as you have used previously.

Ahaz also burns his children in the fire. Child sacrifice was something people in the nations in the land did before Yahweh forced those people out and gave the land to the Israelites. Yahweh considers these actions **detestable**. Use the same word or phrase for detestable as you used in 2 Chronicles 15:8.

A **nation** is a group of people who live together in the same country and have the same ruler, such as the Ammonites. Here, "**Israelites**" refers to God's chosen people, the descendants of Jacob, who lived in the land of Israel. Use the same word or phrase for nation and Israelites as you used in previous passages. For more information on nation and Israelites, refer to the Master Glossary.

Ahaz made offerings at every **high place, on the hilltops, and under every spreading tree**. These were all places where non-Israelites worshiped false gods. This was another way to say that Ahaz made offerings at every place where people were not supposed to worship Yahweh. Use the same word or phrase for "high place, on the hilltops, and under every spreading tree" as you used in previous passages.

So Yahweh gives Ahaz **into the hand of** the king of Aram and the king of Israel. "Into the hand of" means under the power of someone. In this case, Ahaz was under the power of his enemies, who defeated Ahaz in battle. Use the same word or phrase for "into the hand of" as you used in previous passages.

The king of Israel defeats 120,000 soldiers of **Judah**. Judah refers to the southern kingdom of Israel. The capital city of Judah was Jerusalem. Use the same word or phrase for Judah as you used in previous passages. For more information on Judah, refer to the Master Glossary.

Yahweh allowed Israel to defeat Judah's soldiers because Judah had abandoned Yahweh, the **God** of their ancestors. God refers to God who created everything. God is the most powerful spiritual being who chose the Israelites as his special people. Use the same word for God as you have in previous passages. For more information on God, refer to the Master Glossary.

Zicri killed Azrikam, the officer in charge of the **palace**. The palace was the king's house. Use the same word for palace as you used in previous passages.

The Israelite soldiers defeat their relatives, take many valuables, and force 200,000 women and children to become prisoners. The Israelites take the prisoners and **plunder** to **Samaria**. Samaria was the capital city of the northern kingdom of Israel. Use the same word or phrase for plunder and Samaria as you used in previous passages. For more information on plunder and Samaria, refer to the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

2 Chronicles 28:9–15

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 28:9–15 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 28:9–15 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 28:9–15 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the last story, we heard how King Ahaz of Judah, the southern kingdom, did not follow Yahweh but instead worshipped foreign gods. So Yahweh allowed Judah's enemies, including Israel, the northern kingdom, to defeat Judah. The soldiers of Israel killed many of Judah's soldiers. Israel's army also brought 200,000 people, including women and children, from Judah back to the city of Samaria as prisoners. In this story, we will now hear what Yahweh tells the people of Israel to do with those prisoners.

The story begins when one of Yahweh's prophets, Oded, comes out of the city of Samaria to speak to the army of Israel. The Israelite army has just returned from Judah with the prisoners. You will remember that Samaria is the capital city of the northern kingdom of Israel.

Stop here as a group and look at a map that shows the southern kingdom of Judah and the northern kingdom of Israel. Find the city of Samaria on the map. Pause this audio here.

Oded tells the army that Yahweh was angry with Judah, and that is why Yahweh allowed the army of Israel to defeat Judah. But now, Yahweh is angry with Israel because Israel's soldiers killed Judah's people in a very angry and cruel way.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story about some soldiers who fought a battle in a very angry and cruel way. What did those soldiers do that was different from how people normally expect soldiers to behave in battle? Pause this audio here.

Oded also says that the soldiers now plan to make all of these people from Judah Israel's slaves. You will remember that in the law that Yahweh gave to Moses, in the book of Leviticus, Yahweh allowed an Israelite to work as a servant to another Israelite for a time to pay off a debt. But Yahweh said the people were never to make another Israelite a slave. So it would be very wrong for the soldiers to do this.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What do people think about slavery in your culture? If people take slaves, how do those people treat those slaves? Which types of people are you allowed to take slaves from? Would you ever take slaves from people who are related to you? Pause this audio here.

Oded also reminds the soldiers that although the people of Judah sinned, the people of Israel have sinned too. You will remember the story from earlier in this book and in 1 Kings of how the 10 northern tribes first formed their own kingdom, with Jeroboam as king. At that time, King Jeroboam created idols for the people to worship so that the people would not have to go to Jerusalem in Judah to worship at Yahweh's temple. So Israel has done the same kinds of sinful things that Judah has done.

Oded warns the soldiers that Yahweh is very angry with Israel, just as Yahweh was angry with Judah. Oded says the soldiers must release these people and let the people go back home to Judah.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, when an army wins a battle against another army, how do people explain why those people were able to win? Pause this audio here.

Four of Israel's leaders now speak to the soldiers and repeat the same warning Oded just gave. The leaders say that the soldiers cannot bring these prisoners to Samaria. The leaders say that the people of Israel are already very guilty of sin against Yahweh and that Yahweh is very angry.

So the soldiers let the prisoners go free. The soldiers also give everything the soldiers took during the battle to the leaders. Then, from those things, the leaders give the people from Judah clothing to cover their bodies and sandals to put on their feet. The leaders also give the people food and drink and take care of the people's wounds from the battle. The leaders give anyone who is unable to walk a donkey to ride. Then the leaders take all of the people back to the city of Jericho in Judah so the people can be with their relatives. People call Jericho the city of palm trees.

Stop here as a group and again look at the map of Israel that shows the southern kingdom of Judah and the northern kingdom of Israel. Find Jericho on the map. Pause this audio here.

Stop here as a group and look at pictures of sandals, a donkey, and palm trees. Pause this audio here.

Finally, the leaders return to Samaria, their home in the kingdom of Israel.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 28:9–15 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four scenes.

In the first scene: Oded, one of Yahweh's prophets, comes out of the city of Samaria to speak to the army of Israel as the army returns with prisoners from Judah. Oded says that Yahweh let Israel defeat Judah because

2 Chronicles 28:9–15

Yahweh was angry with Judah. But Israel has sinned too, so Yahweh will punish Israel if they keep these people from Judah as prisoners.

In the second scene: Four of Israel's leaders speak to Israel's army. The leaders repeat Oded's warning.

In the third scene: Israel's army lets Judah's people go free.

In the fourth scene: Israel's leaders give the people from Judah clothes and sandals to wear and food and drink. The leaders also take care of the people's battle wounds. Then the leaders take all of the people back home to Judah.

The characters in this passage are:

- Oded, Yahweh's prophet
- Yahweh
- Soldiers from the northern kingdom of Israel
- All the people of the southern kingdom of Judah
- The prisoners from Judah
- And four leaders from the northern kingdom: Azariah, Jehohanan's son; Berekiah, Meshillemoth's son; Jehizkiah, Shallum's son; and Amasa, Hadlai's son

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

You will remember that in the last story, the army of Israel, the northern kingdom, killed many people in Judah during a battle. Then the army brought many prisoners back to the city of Samaria, in the northern kingdom.

Stop here as a group and again find the city of Samaria on the map of Judah and Israel, if needed. Pause this audio here.

Now, as the first scene begins, the storyteller explains that one of Yahweh's prophets, Oded, lives in Samaria. You will remember that a prophet is a person who gives messages from God to the people. Oded comes out of the city to meet the army as the army approaches Samaria. Then Oded speaks to the army. In the original language, Oded begins with a word that means "Look!" or "Pay attention!" Then Oded tells the army why Israel was able to defeat Judah in the battle. Oded says that Yahweh, the God of the people's ancestors, was angry with Judah. You will remember that although Yahweh has always been the Israelites' God, the people have worshiped other gods instead of Yahweh for a long time. So Oded probably calls Yahweh the God of the Israelites to remind the people that Yahweh is the God their ancestors worshiped.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: The storyteller refers to Yahweh as the God of the people's ancestors. How do you talk about who your ancestors worshiped, whether it was God or the local gods or spirits? Pause this audio here.

Oded says that it was because Yahweh was angry with Judah that Yahweh gave Judah into Israel's hand. This is special language that means that Yahweh gave the army of Israel power and control over Judah. But although Yahweh allowed this to happen, Israel's army killed the army of Judah in a very angry and cruel way, without mercy. Oded says this reached up to heaven, which is special language that means that God, who is in heaven, saw what the army did.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you talk about soldiers who fight in a way that is very cruel or who show no mercy even when they win the battle? If needed, think about the story you told in step two and how you described the soldiers in your story. Pause this audio here.

Now, Oded says that the army plans to make these people of Judah and Jerusalem, both male and female, slaves to the people of the northern kingdom of Israel. You will remember that Judah is one of the tribes of Israel, but Judah is also the name of the southern kingdom. Jerusalem is the capital city of Judah. Jerusalem was also the capital city of all of Israel before the people divided into two different kingdoms. Jerusalem is where Solomon built Yahweh's temple. Oded asks the army a question that Oded does not expect anyone to answer. Oded asks the men, "But are you not also guilty of sins against Yahweh your God?" Oded asks this question to show the army that just like Yahweh punished Judah, Yahweh will also punish Israel if the army disobeys Yahweh and takes these people as slaves.

Oded tells the army to hear Oded, which means to pay attention to Oded. Oded says to send all of these prisoners back home. Oded reminds the army that these people are the men's relatives. You will remember from a previous story that most of the people who live in the southern kingdom are from the tribes of Judah and Benjamin, but some people from other Israelite tribes also live in Judah. Either way, all of these people come from the same 12 tribes of Israel, and all of the people are related. Oded says the army must send all of the people back home because Yahweh's wrath or burning anger is on the army, which means that Yahweh feels very angry with the army and plans to punish the people.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your language, how do you talk about someone who feels very, very angry? Pause this audio here.

In the second scene, the storyteller says that some chiefs or leaders of Ephraim confront the soldiers. You will remember that Ephraim is one of the tribes that live in the northern kingdom, but here the storyteller uses Ephraim to mean the entire northern kingdom. The storyteller says these leaders are Azariah, Jehohanan's son; Berekiah, Meshillemoth's son; Jehizkiah, Shallum's son; and Amasa, Hadlai's son. These four leaders speak to the army and repeat the same warning that Oded just gave. The leaders say that the army must not bring the prisoners into the city, because if they do, it will make the people's sin and guilt before Yahweh even worse than it already is. The leaders say that the people are already very guilty and that Yahweh's wrath, or anger, is very great toward the people of the northern kingdom.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you talk about people who deserve punishment because of the wrong things those people have done? Pause this audio here.

In the third scene, the soldiers release the prisoners and all the things the soldiers took during the battle. The soldiers do this in front of the leaders and all of the other people who have gathered together.

In the fourth scene, the storyteller says that the men whom people mentioned by name rise up and take the prisoners. We are not sure what the storyteller means by "the men whom people mentioned by name." The storyteller may use this phrase to refer to the four leaders, Azariah, Berekiah, Jehizkiah, and Amasa. Or the storyteller may mean that the leaders specifically choose other men to help the prisoners. Also, "rose up" does not mean that the men were first lying down. This is special language that means the men take action. First, the men give the prisoners clothes and sandals to wear from the spoils, or all the things the army took from Judah during the battle. The men also give the people food and drink because the people are probably very hungry and thirsty after the battle and the journey to Samaria. The men also anoint the people. This means the men put olive oil on people's wounds. Many people were probably injured in the battle, and at this time, people often used oil from olives, a type of fruit, to put on wounds as medicine.

Then the men carried the feeble people on donkeys. This means that people who were weak or injured and could not walk rode on donkeys, which are large animals with four legs. The men took all of the people, whom the storyteller reminds us are kinfolk or relatives of the men, to Jericho, which people call "the city of palm trees."

Stop here as a group and again find the city of Jericho on the map of Judah and Israel, if needed. Pause this audio here.

Stop here as a group and look again at pictures of sandals, a donkey, and palm trees, if needed. Pause this audio here.

Finally, the men returned home to Samaria in the northern kingdom of Israel.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 28:9–15 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Oded, Yahweh's prophet
- Yahweh
- Soldiers from the northern kingdom of Israel
- All the people of the southern kingdom of Judah
- The prisoners from Judah
- And four leaders from the northern kingdom: Azariah, Jehohanan's son; Berekiah, Meshillemoth's son; Jehizkiah, Shallum's son; and Amasa, Hadlai's son

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Oded is one of Yahweh's prophets, and Oded lives in Samaria. Oded goes out to meet Israel's army as they return to Samaria. Oded says to the army, "Yahweh, the God of your ancestors, was angry with Judah. That is why Yahweh let you defeat Judah. But you killed the people with so much violence that even God in heaven is shocked. And now you want to make these people from Judah and Jerusalem your slaves. But you have sinned too, and you are guilty before Yahweh your God. Now listen to me! You have the same ancestors as these people you have captured. So free these people and let them go home. Otherwise, Yahweh will be very angry and will punish you."

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing Israel's army, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We must be a very good army, because we completely defeated Judah's army; or
- The gods that we worship must be very pleased with us, because we won a great victory today! or
- We will show these people from Judah how strong we are. We will take everything Judah's people have and make them our slaves.

Ask the people playing the prisoners from Judah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We feel very scared. These men killed many of our families in a brutal way, and we do not know what these men will do to us now; or
- Even though we often fight with our relatives, we did not expect these men to treat us this badly.

Ask the person playing Oded, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- These soldiers think they won this battle by their own strength, but it was Yahweh who let them win; or
- Yahweh was angry with Judah because they served other gods, but the northern kingdom is guilty of the same sins; or
- These people have served other gods for so long that I have to remind them that Yahweh is their God; or
- These soldiers think that they are successful today, but they do not realize that God is about to punish them.

Continue the drama.

Now, four of the leaders of the northern kingdom of Israel speak to the army and tell the army that the army is doing wrong. These leaders are Azariah, son of Jehohanan; Berekiah, son of Meshillemoth; Jehizkiah, son of Shallum; and Amasa, son of Hadlai. These men tell the army, "Do not bring these prisoners here. If you do that,

Yahweh will consider us guilty of sin. You are making our sins and faults even greater. We are already very guilty, and Yahweh is very angry with us."

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the soldiers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We feel surprised. We thought our leaders would be happy that we won the battle and that we brought back all of these good things and these people to be our slaves; or
- We feel shame. We were very strong and powerful in battle, but Oded and our leaders have made us look foolish; or
- We feel afraid. We thought the gods were happy with us, but now our ancestors' God, Yahweh, might punish us!

Ask the people playing the four leaders, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We feel afraid that Yahweh will punish our people; or
- All of this wealth and power that the army has taken will do us no good if Yahweh punishes us.

Continue the drama.

So, in front of the leaders and all of the people, the soldiers let all of the prisoners go free, and the soldiers laid down all of the things they had taken during the battle.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing soldiers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We fought very hard to win, and we feel like we deserve to keep these things, but we do not want to receive punishment; or
- I think Oded was right. These people are our relatives, and we should not have been so harsh with these people.

Continue the drama.

The leaders choose some men to help the people from Judah. Out of all of the things the soldiers brought back from battle, the men take clothes and give them to the people from Judah who are naked. The men also give people sandals to put on their feet. The men give people food and drink, and the men put oil on people's wounds. The men put people who are weak on donkeys, and then the men bring all of these people, who are the men's relatives, back to Jericho, the city of the palms.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the people from Judah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We are surprised that the soldiers and the leaders listened to Oded; or
- We are so happy that we do not have to be slaves, and that we can go home.

Continue the drama.

Then the men from Israel go back home to the city of Samaria.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 28:9–15 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Oded, a **prophet** of **Yahweh**, comes out to meet the army when the army comes back to **Samaria**. A prophet is a person who gives messages from God to the people. Yahweh is God's personal name. Use the same words or phrases for prophet, Samaria, and Yahweh as you used in previous passages. For more information on prophet, Samaria, and Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary.

Oded reminds the soldiers that Yahweh is the **God** of their **fathers**. In the Bible, "God" refers to God who created everything. This is the general word for God. Here, the word "fathers" means ancestors. Use the same words or

phrases for God and fathers as you used in previous passages. For more information on God, refer to the Master Glossary.

Oded says that the Israel army killed the Judah army in a rage that reached up to **heaven**. This is special language that means that God in heaven saw what the army did. Heaven refers to the place where God lives with his angels. Use the same word or phrase for heaven as you used in previous passages. For more information on heaven, refer to the Master Glossary.

Oded says the army now plans to make these people slaves, or to force these people to serve the Israelites. A slave is the property of a master. The master can sell the slave to someone else, just as he can sell his other property. A slave works without pay and is not free to leave their master. Some masters treated slaves cruelly. The storyteller just says that the Israelites want to make the people they captured from Judah serve them forcefully. You may need to say that the Israelites wanted to make the captives from Judah their slaves. If so, translate slave in the same way you have previously, and refer to **slave** in the Master Glossary for more information.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use to show that the soldiers wanted to force the people from Judah to serve the Israelites. Pause this audio here.

Oded reminds the army that these people are their **brothers**, which means relatives. Use the same word or phrase for brothers or relatives as you used in previous passages.

Some chiefs or leaders of **Ephraim** speak to the army. Ephraim is one of the tribes of Israel, but here Ephraim refers to the whole northern kingdom of Israel. Use the same word or phrase for Ephraim as you used in previous passages.

The leaders say that the people's **sins** and **guilt** are very great. Sin is rebellion against God. Guilt means that someone has done something wrong and deserves punishment. Use the same words or phrases for sins and guilt as you used in previous passages. For more information on sin and guilt, refer to the Master Glossary.

So the soldiers let go of the prisoners and the **plunder** in the presence of the **princes**, or high officials, and all of the **assembly**. Plunder means all of the valuable things that an army takes from the enemy in battle. "Princes" is another word for important leaders, and "assembly" means a large group of people who gather together for a special purpose. Use the same words or phrases for plunder, princes, and assembly as you used in previous passages.

The leaders give the people from Judah clothing, sandals, and food and drink from the plunder the army took during the battle. Sandals are a type of footwear with a leather sole that people tie to the bottom of their foot with leather thongs or straps.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **sandals**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The leaders anoint the people. To anoint someone means to pour sweet-smelling oil over that person. Many times in the Bible, to anoint meant to pour oil over a person or object to show that the person or thing was holy, or dedicated to God. But here, to anoint means to put oil on people's wounds to help the wounds heal.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **anoint**. Look up anoint in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The men carry the feeble people on donkeys. To be feeble means to fall down from weakness or to be unable to walk. A donkey is a large animal with four legs that people in Israel often rode or used to carry heavy burdens.

Stop here and discuss as a group what words or phrases you will use for **feeble** and **donkeys**. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The leaders take the people back to Jericho, the "city of palm trees." These are date palm trees. Date palms are slow-growing, evergreen trees with arching gray-green fronds that can grow up to 10 feet long. This kind of palm tree grows a sweet fruit that people call dates.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for "**city of palm trees**." If you have already translated this phrase in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Finally, the men return to Samaria in the northern kingdom of Israel.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

2 Chronicles 28:9–15

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (840 KB)
- Setting the Stage (3.2 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (5.8 MB)
- Embodying the Text (4.3 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (3.9 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

2 Chronicles 28:16–27

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 28:16–27 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 28:16–27 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.

5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 28:16–27 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the last story, we learned that Yahweh was angry with the kingdom of Judah because the people had done evil and worshiped other gods. As punishment, Yahweh began to allow Judah's enemies, including the northern kingdom of Israel, to defeat Judah in battle. Now, in this story, we will learn how Judah's king, Ahaz, continues to reject Yahweh and turn to foreign gods for help, and how this hurts Ahaz even more.

As the story begins, we learn that Judah's enemies have continued to attack and defeat Judah, so King Ahaz sends someone to take a message to the king of Assyria to ask for help. We know this is Tiglath Pileser III, who was king of Assyria from 744 B.C. to 727 B.C. Assyria was a country in northern Mesopotamia, the area that today is northern Iran.

Stop here as a group and look at a map that shows Assyria and Judah. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller specifically mentions how the Edomites had attacked Judah and carried away prisoners, and how the Philistines had raided or attacked some of Judah's cities in the lower hills to the west side of Judah and also to the south of Judah. You will remember that the Edomites lived in the land south of Judah, and the Philistines lived in the land west of Judah along the Mediterranean Sea. The storyteller says that the Philistines had taken control of the cities of Beth Shemesh, Aijalon, Gederoth, Soco, Timnah, and Gimzo and also the smaller villages that surrounded those cities.

Stop here as a group and look at a map of Judah that also shows Edom and Philistia. Find each of these cities on the map. Pause this audio here.

Now we learn why these countries were able to defeat Judah. The storyteller says that Yahweh humbled the king of Judah, King Ahaz, because the king turned away from Yahweh and encouraged the people to do wicked things. And so, when King Ahaz sends word to the king of Assyria, Tiglath-Pileser, to ask for help, Tiglath-Pileser oppresses Ahaz instead of helping. Ahaz takes many expensive things from Yahweh's temple, from Ahaz's own house, and even from the leaders who work for King Ahaz, and gives these things to Tiglath-Pileser as payment for his help, but this does not help Ahaz.

When all of these bad things happened, King Ahaz should have asked Yahweh for help, but instead, Ahaz asked the gods of Judah's enemies for help. Ahaz offered sacrifices to the gods that people worshiped in Damascus, the capital city of Aram, or Syria. Ahaz said that if those gods had helped Ahaz's enemies, then Ahaz would ask those gods to help Ahaz, too. But the storyteller says that those gods ruined Ahaz and Judah rather than helping.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell about a time someone tried to fix a bad choice they had made, but that person just made it worse. Pause this audio here.

Ahaz took all of the valuable things out of God's temple and destroyed those things. Ahaz also shut the doors of Yahweh's temple so that no one could go into the temple anymore. Instead, Ahaz had people build altars where people could worship foreign gods at the corner of every street in Jerusalem. And in every town in Judah, Ahaz had people build places to sacrifice to foreign gods there, too. All of these things made Yahweh, the God that Ahaz's ancestors worshiped, very angry.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Where do people worship God, or local spirits or gods, in your community? What are the right ways to worship those local spirits or gods? What happens if someone decides to worship another way? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller finishes his story by reminding us that people wrote other important stories about King Ahaz in the book, or scroll, about the kings of Judah and Israel. You will remember that this book is not in the Bible and no longer exists. The storyteller also says that when Ahaz died, people buried Ahaz in Jerusalem, but the people did not put Ahaz's body in the tomb of the kings of Israel. The storyteller probably says this to show that people did not honor Ahaz because Ahaz was wicked and disobeyed Yahweh. However, this is different than what we

hear in 2 Kings 16, where that storyteller says that people buried Ahaz with his ancestors. We are not sure why these are different, but it may mean that the people buried Ahaz near his ancestors, but not in the royal tomb. Finally, after Ahaz died, Ahaz's son Hezekiah became the next king.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 28:16–27 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has six scenes.

In the first scene: The Edomites and Philistines have once again attacked and defeated Judah, so King Ahaz asks the king of Assyria to help protect Judah.

In the second scene: The storyteller reminds us that Yahweh allowed these enemies to defeat Judah because King Ahaz had turned away from Yahweh and caused the people to sin.

In the third scene: Instead of protecting Judah, Assyria causes trouble, even though Ahaz gives the king of Assyria expensive things from Yahweh's temple as payment.

In the fourth scene: King Ahaz sacrifices to the gods of his enemy, so that those gods will help Ahaz. But instead, those gods destroy Ahaz.

In the fifth scene: Ahaz destroys the objects in Yahweh's temple and shuts the doors to the temple so no one will worship there. Instead, Ahaz makes sacred places where people can worship foreign gods. All of these actions make Yahweh very angry.

In the sixth scene: The storyteller tells how King Ahaz dies and how Ahaz's son Hezekiah becomes the next king.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Ahaz of Judah
- Edomite army
- Prisoners from Judah
- Philistine army
- People who live in and near Judah's cities that the Philistines capture
- King Tiglath-Pileser of Assyria and his army, although the storyteller does not mention the army
- Yahweh
- Foreign gods
- And Hezekiah, Ahaz's son

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first scene, the storyteller begins by saying that at that time, King Ahaz sent to the king of Assyria for help. Here, the phrase "at that time" does not refer to the same time as the last story, when Syria and the king of Israel attacked Judah. Instead, it refers to a later time when Edom and Philistia attacked. Also, although the storyteller only says Ahaz "sent word," we know that this means the king sent someone to take a message from Ahaz to the king of Assyria. The storyteller will say later in the story that this is King Tiglath-Pileser.

Stop here as a group and again look at a map that shows Assyria and Judah, if needed. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you talk about when one person sends another person to carry a message to a third person who is far away? How will you translate the way King Ahaz sends this message here? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller says that King Ahaz sent this message because the Edomites had again invaded Judah and taken people away as captives or prisoners. Also, the Philistines had attacked cities in the Shephelah and the Negev of Judah. The Shephelah refers to the land in Judah where the hills are not very high. The Shephelah is west of the hill country of Judah but east of the Mediterranean seacoast. The Shephelah is south of the Aijalon Valley in

an area about 65 kilometers long and 20 kilometers wide. The Negev refers to the southern part of Judah, where the land is very dry, or like a desert.

Stop here as a group and look at pictures of the Shephelah and the Negev wilderness. Pause this audio here.

The Philistines took control of Beth Shemesh. There are four different cities in the Old Testament called Beth Shemesh, but most people believe that this Beth Shemesh was located on the northwest border of Judah, about 24 kilometers west of Jerusalem. The Philistines also took Aijalon, which people believe was about 20 kilometers northwest of Jerusalem, and Gederoth, which people believe was [about 18 kilometers southwest of Lod on the Ramle-Al Mughar road. The Philistines took Soco with its villages.]{.mark} There are three different cities in the Old Testament called Soco, but this is likely the Soco located in the Shephelah, about 30 kilometers southwest of Jerusalem. The Philistines took Timnah with its villages. Timnah was located on the northern border of Judah, about 6.5 kilometers north of Beth Shemesh. And finally, the Philistines took Gimzo, which was located in the lowland region near the Philistine plain, about 5 kilometers southeast of Lod off the Jerusalem road in the Aijalon Valley. The storyteller says that the Philistines settled in these cities and the villages around these cities, which means to live in those places permanently.

Stop here as a group and again look at a map of Judah that shows the likely location of each of these cities. Pause this audio here.

In the second scene, the storyteller says that Yahweh humbled Judah because Ahaz, king of Israel, had encouraged the people to do wicked things, and because Ahaz himself had been unfaithful to Yahweh. You will remember that the nation of Israel was divided into two different kingdoms at this time. One of these kingdoms was the northern kingdom, which people called Israel. The other kingdom was the southern kingdom, which people called Judah. We know that Ahaz was the king of the southern kingdom of Judah, but the storyteller may call Ahaz the "king of Israel" to remind us that Ahaz is acting just as badly as the people of the northern kingdom, who worshiped other gods.

In the third scene, because Ahaz has done these wicked things, when Ahaz asks King Tiglath-Pileser of Assyria for help, Tiglath-Pileser instead comes against Ahaz, which means he attacks Ahaz instead of helping. In the original language, we are not sure if the storyteller says that Tiglath-Pileser did not make Ahaz strong by helping Ahaz, or if the storyteller says that Tiglath-Pileser could not overpower Ahaz or defeat him. Either way, we understand that Tiglath-Pileser made things worse for Ahaz and not better.

The storyteller says that Ahaz took or stole things from Yahweh's house, the temple. Ahaz also took things from his own palace, the house where Ahaz lived as the king. And Ahaz also took things from the "princes" or leaders of Judah who worked for the king. Ahaz then gave all of these expensive things to Tiglath-Pileser as a way to pay for Assyria's help, but the storyteller says this did not help Ahaz. In other words, Tiglath-Pileser did not help, even though Ahaz paid Tiglath-Pileser to help.

In the fourth scene, the storyteller says that when Ahaz is distressed, or when all these bad things happen, Ahaz acts even more unfaithfully to Yahweh. Ahaz makes sacrifices to the gods of Damascus that defeated Ahaz. Remember that Damascus is the capital city of Syria, so these are the gods that the Syrians worship. And Ahaz said, "Because the gods of the kings of Syria helped those kings, I will sacrifice to those gods so that those gods may help me too." Here, the storyteller may mean that Ahaz said this out loud to himself, or it may mean that Ahaz simply thought this thing. Either way, the storyteller tells us this so we will know why Ahaz made sacrifices to these other gods. However, the storyteller says these gods ruined Ahaz and all of Israel, which means that the gods only made things worse, not better. When the storyteller says Israel here, we do not know if he refers to Judah, the kingdom where Ahaz rules, or to the northern kingdom, where people also worshiped foreign gods.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story about a person who does something that people would not expect. Then tell people what that person thought that caused the person to act that way. Pay attention to the way you explain this. Pause this audio here.

In the fifth scene, the storyteller says that Ahaz gathered together the vessels of the house of God and cut the vessels into pieces. You will remember that the house of God means Yahweh's temple in Jerusalem. The "vessels" refer to the various holy items in the temple that the priests used to worship Yahweh. Apparently, Ahaz destroys these things to prevent people from worshiping Yahweh. Then Ahaz closes the doors to the temple. This probably

means that Ahaz locks the doors so that no one can enter the temple to worship Yahweh anymore. Instead, Ahaz makes altars in every corner in Jerusalem. This probably means that Ahaz commands people to build these altars, or places for people to worship these gods, in many places around the city of Jerusalem. Also, in every city of Judah, Ahaz makes high places to burn incense to other gods. High places probably refers to places on hills where people would make special shrines to foreign gods. The storyteller says that all of these things provoked Yahweh, the God of Ahaz's ancestors, to anger. This means that Yahweh felt very angry that Ahaz did all of this.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story about a time when someone in your community did something that people thought angered God or the local gods or spirits. What did that person do? How did people talk about those things the person did? How did people feel about those actions? Pause this audio here.

In the last scene, the storyteller uses the same kind of formal talk he used to describe other kings. First, the storyteller says that everything that happened when Ahaz was king, and everything Ahaz did, is in the scroll or book of the kings of Judah and Israel. You will remember that a scroll is a type of ancient book where people wrote everything on one very long piece of paper and then rolled that paper around a stick. The storyteller says that Ahaz "slept with his fathers." This is a nice way to say that Ahaz died, just as Ahaz's ancestors before Ahaz did. People buried Ahaz in the city of Jerusalem, but people did not place Ahaz's body in the tombs of the kings of Israel. And finally, Hezekiah, Ahaz's son, succeeded Ahaz as king. This means that Hezekiah became the next king after Ahaz.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 28:16–27 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has six scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Ahaz of Judah
- Edomite army
- Prisoners from Judah
- Philistine army
- People who live in and near Judah's cities that the Philistines capture
- King Tiglath-Pileser of Assyria and his army, although the storyteller does not mention the army
- Yahweh
- Foreign gods
- And Hezekiah, Ahaz's son

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Then King Ahaz sent people to King Tiglath-Pileser, the king of Assyria, to ask for help. Ahaz did this because the Edomites had again come and attacked Judah and taken people away as prisoners. And at the same time, the Philistines had raided the cities and towns in Judah's low hills and also the Negev. The Philistines captured

and settled in Beth Shemesh, Aijalon, and Gederoth, as well as Soco, Timnah, and Gimzo, along with the villages around those cities.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Ahaz, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I keep losing battles to my enemies. I need to do something to stop this! or
- Now we have even fewer people and cities to protect ourselves; or
- I am not sure if I can trust the Assyrians, but I know they have a strong army. Maybe I can pay the Assyrians to help us.

Continue the drama.

Because of the evil things King Ahaz did, Yahweh made the kingdom of Judah low. Ahaz had led his people to do evil things, and Ahaz himself disobeyed Yahweh.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am the one who protects my people, but now my people worship other gods instead of me. These other gods cannot help the people! or
- I will stop protecting my people so that the people will see that these gods can do nothing for them; or
- Ahaz has rejected me, so now I will reject Ahaz.

Continue the drama.

King Tiglath-Pileser of Assyria comes to Ahaz. But instead of helping, Tiglath-Pileser gives Ahaz even more trouble. Ahaz takes some of the things from Yahweh's temple, from Ahaz's palace, and from the officials of Judah, and Ahaz gives these expensive things to Tiglath-Pileser as payment. But this does not help Ahaz.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Ahaz, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I do not want to give these expensive things away, but if it can help save my kingdom, it is worth it!

Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I allowed these things to happen so Ahaz would remember to obey and worship me. But instead, Ahaz steals things from my temple to pay a human king to help.

Ask the person playing King Tiglath-Pileser, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- My army is bigger and stronger than Judah's. I cannot completely defeat Judah in battle, but I will gladly take these expensive things from them.

Continue the drama.

King Ahaz disobeyed Yahweh even more when all of these bad things happened. Ahaz made sacrifices to the gods of Damascus, who had defeated Ahaz in battle, because Ahaz thought, "The gods of the kings of Aram have helped those kings, so I will also sacrifice to those gods. Then those gods will help me too." But worshiping those gods ruined Ahaz and all the people of Judah.

Pause the drama. Ask the people of Judah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- Our enemies stole some of our people and cities. We must do something to protect ourselves! or
- If Yahweh allowed these bad things to happen, maybe other gods can help instead; or
- We will do whatever our king tells us to do.

Continue the drama.

2 Chronicles 28:16–27

King Ahaz gathered up and destroyed all of the sacred things from Yahweh's temple. Ahaz shut and locked the doors of the temple so that no one could go in to worship Yahweh anymore. Then Ahaz set up altars at the corner of every street in Jerusalem, and Ahaz built sacred places to burn sacrifices to foreign gods in every town in Judah. This made Yahweh, the God that Ahaz's ancestors worshiped, very angry.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Ahaz continues to disobey me and treat me with great disrespect; or
- Ahaz not only disobeys me and worships other gods, but Ahaz makes other people disobey me too; or
- I will punish Ahaz and the people of Judah for doing these things.

Continue the drama.

King Ahaz did many things while he was king, and people wrote about all of these things in the book "The History of the Kings of Judah and Israel." Then Ahaz died, and people buried Ahaz with his ancestors. People buried Ahaz in Jerusalem, but the people did not bury Ahaz in the tombs of the kings of Israel. After Ahaz died, Ahaz's son Hezekiah became the next king of Judah.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the people of Judah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- The good kings of Judah in the past always worshiped Yahweh, but Ahaz changed all of that; or
- It seems like all of the changes Ahaz made in Judah made things worse for us, not better; or
- We need to show respect, but Ahaz was not a very good king. So we will bury Ahaz in Jerusalem, but not in the tombs where people buried the most important kings.

Ask the person playing Hezekiah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- My father stopped people from worshiping Yahweh, our ancestors' God; or
- My father thought these other gods would make us stronger, but worshiping those gods made everything worse; or
- I do not want to be like my father. My father did not leave a good legacy as king.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 28:16–27 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

As the story begins, **King** Ahaz sends a message to the king of Assyria to ask for help. Use the same word or phrase for king as you used in previous passages. King is in the Master Glossary.

Assyria was a country in northern Mesopotamia, the area that today is northern Iran.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **Assyria**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The **Edomites** had once again defeated Judah and carried away captives or prisoners. You will remember that the Edomites were the ancestors of Esau, Jacob's brother. Jacob, who God later named Israel, was the ancestor of the Israelites. Use the same word or phrase for Edomites as you used in previous passages.

The Philistines had also made raids and taken several **cities** in the **foothills** and the Negev wilderness. Translate cities the same as you have in previous passages. The foothills refer to the land in Judah where the hills are not very high. These foothills are west of the hill country of Judah but east of the Mediterranean seacoast. Use the same word or phrase for foothills as you used in previous passages.

Stop here as a group and look again at a picture of the foothills, if needed. Pause this audio here.

The Negev refers to the Negev wilderness, the southern part of Judah, where the land is very dry, or like a desert.

Stop here as a group and look again at a picture of the Negev wilderness, if needed. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for the **Negev wilderness**. If you use the word for wilderness, refer to wilderness in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Yahweh **humbled** Judah. **Yahweh** is God's personal name, and to humble people means to make those people submit, to bring them low, or to make them lose face. Use the same words or phrases for Yahweh and humbled as you used in previous passages. For more information on Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary.

Yahweh humbled Judah because King Ahaz had promoted wickedness or caused Judah to act sinfully. Wickedness means evil, or the opposite of good, and to sin means to rebel against God. But here, King Ahaz does not just do wicked or sinful things himself. Instead, Ahaz does wrong as the leader of Judah and causes other people to do sinful or wicked things.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **promoted wickedness** or **caused Judah to act sinfully**. Look up **wickedness** and **sin** in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

King Tiglath-Pileser of Assyria **afflicted** Ahaz, even though Ahaz paid him with many things. To afflict means to oppress or restrict either physically or emotionally. This does not necessarily mean that the Assyrians made war with Judah, but it does mean that Tiglath-Pileser made things even harder for Ahaz. Use the same word or phrase for afflicted as you used in previous passages.

King Ahaz **sacrificed** to the **gods** of Damascus. When the Israelites would make a sacrifice to Yahweh, it either meant to kill an animal and then burn the animal on an altar, or to give a gift to Yahweh of food items, oil, or sweet-smelling spices. But here, King Ahaz instead makes sacrifices to the foreign gods of Judah's enemies. Use the same words or phrases for sacrifice and gods as you used in previous passages. For more information on gods and on the kinds of sacrifices that people made to Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary.

Ahaz destroyed the **vessels** in Yahweh's **temple**. Vessels refer to the items the priests would use in the temple for worship. Use the same words or phrases for vessels and temple as you used in previous passages. For more information, look up temple in the Master Glossary.

Ahaz made **altars** all around Jerusalem. An altar is a place where people make offerings or sacrifices to God, but Ahaz made these altars to make offerings to foreign gods. Use the same word or phrase for altars as you used in previous passages. For more information on the kind of altar that people made to worship Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary.

Ahaz also made **high places**. People from these other countries would often make the shrines or places where they worshiped their gods on naturally high places, like hills, so Ahaz did the same thing in Judah. Use the same word or phrase for high places as you used in previous passages.

People wrote about everything King Ahaz did in a **book** or **scroll** about the kings of Judah and Israel. You will remember that in that time, a book or "scroll" was usually a long piece of leather or paper that people wrote on and then rolled up around a stick. This way, people could easily carry or store the scroll until they wanted to read it. Use the same word or phrase for book or scroll as you used in previous passages, and refer to the Master Glossary for more information about scroll.

Ahaz **slept with his fathers**. Slept is a nice way to say that Ahaz died, and "fathers" means Ahaz's ancestors. Use the same word or phrase for "slept with his fathers" as you used in previous passages.

The storyteller says that people did not bury Ahaz in the **tombs** of the kings. A tomb is a place where people bury a dead body. These were often caves or rooms that people would hollow out of rock to hide the body from view. Use the same word or phrase for tomb as you used in previous passages. For more information about tomb, refer to the Master Glossary.

Finally, after Ahaz died, Ahaz's son Hezekiah **reigned** in Ahaz's place. To reign means to rule or act with power as king. Use the same word or phrase for reign as you used in previous passages.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

2 Chronicles 28:16–27

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (840 KB)
- Setting the Stage (3.4 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (7.2 MB)
- Embodying the Text (4.9 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (4.4 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

2 Chronicles 29:1–17

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 29:1–17 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 29:1–17 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 29:1–17 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous story, we learned how King Ahaz served other gods and kings instead of Yahweh and caused the people of Judah to sin, too. These things made Yahweh very angry. When Ahaz died, people did not honor Ahaz by burying his body with the other kings in Jerusalem. Then Ahaz's son, Hezekiah, became the new king of Judah.

In this story, we learn more about King Hezekiah. Remember that 2 Kings 18:1–12 has similar information about Hezekiah.

Stop here as a group and listen to your translation of 2 Kings 18:1–12 if you have already translated that passage. Pause this audio here.

Hezekiah was 25 years old when he became king, and Hezekiah was king for 29 years. Hezekiah lived in Jerusalem. Hezekiah's mother was Abijah, and Abijah's father was Zechariah. Many men in the Bible had the name Zechariah, so we are not sure which Zechariah this is. However, we know this is not the man who wrote the book of Zechariah in the Bible.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your community, what are some common names that more than one person has? Tell a story about a time when someone talked about one person, but people thought that person talked about a different person who had the same name. Tell what happened because people misunderstood. Pause this audio here.

King Hezekiah does good things that please Yahweh. Shortly after Hezekiah becomes king, Hezekiah opens the doors of Yahweh's temple. Hezekiah also has people repair these doors. You will remember from the previous stories that it was Hezekiah's father, King Ahaz, who shut the temple doors so people could not come to worship Yahweh anymore. But now, Hezekiah begins to undo the evil things Ahaz did.

Hezekiah gathers the Levites and priests outside the temple. You will remember that the Israelites were 12 tribes. One tribe was the Levites, and the Levites who descended from Moses' brother Aaron were the priests. The priests were responsible for offering sacrifices to Yahweh on the people's behalf. The priests took care of the temple and taught the people how to worship God. The other Levites helped the priests.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your community, which people are responsible for religious duties? How do people get those responsibilities? Pause this audio here.

Hezekiah tells the Levites and priests to make themselves holy and to make the temple holy. Hezekiah says the ancestors of Judah's people were unfaithful to Yahweh and did evil things. Those people closed the temple doors and stopped serving Yahweh. So Yahweh became very angry with all the people. Yahweh punished Judah's people. The surrounding nations were horrified and surprised when they saw how Yahweh punished Judah. The people of those other nations talked badly about the people of Judah. Hezekiah says that the Levites and priests know that these things are true because they saw them happen. The people of Judah's ancestors died in battle, and the people's sons, daughters, and wives became prisoners in other countries. All of these things happened because of the evil things the people of Judah did.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your community, how do people act toward a person when they believe that God is punishing that person? What do people say to each other about that person? Pause this audio here.

Hezekiah has decided that the people of Judah must make a covenant or agreement with Yahweh that the people will once again serve Yahweh and only Yahweh. Hezekiah hopes that when the people of Judah do this, Yahweh will stop being angry at the people.

Hezekiah tells the Levites and priests that they must begin working at the temple because Yahweh chose these men to serve Yahweh and offer sacrifices. So the Levites prepare themselves to work in the temple. Here, the storyteller gives the name of each of the Levite men who serve as a leader of a family group. These leaders organize all the men in their groups, and together, all the men ritually cleanse themselves and the temple.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a large group of people with many smaller groups who all needed to work together. Tell how each smaller group had its own leader and how the leaders worked together to organize all of the people. Pause this audio here.

2 Chronicles 29:1–17

You will remember that the law that Yahweh gave to Moses included detailed instructions for how to make people and things holy before Yahweh. In the law, Yahweh said that only the priests could go into the inner part of the temple, so here, it is the priests who cleanse these parts. The priests bring out everything that is unclean. We do not know what these things are, but these are probably things Ahaz brought into the temple to worship other gods. The men bring all these things to the Kidron Valley. The Kidron Valley was a place on the east side of Jerusalem where people buried dead bodies. You will remember that the law said dead bodies were unclean, so we are not surprised that the men take these unclean things to this unclean place. You may also remember from an earlier story in 2 Chronicles 15:16 how King Asa brought idols to this valley to destroy the idols with fire.

Stop here as a group and look at a map that shows Jerusalem and the Kidron Valley. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what makes a person or thing ceremonially unclean or unholy? How do people treat a person or thing that is unholy? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller says the priests and Levites began purifying, or making the temple holy, on the first day of the month. It took eight days to purify the temple courtyards and another eight days to purify the temple itself. So the men finished the work on the 16th day of that same month.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 29:1–17 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has five scenes.

In the first scene: The storyteller gives general information about Hezekiah's time as king. We also learn that Hezekiah does what Yahweh says is right, just as King David did.

In the second scene: Hezekiah opens the temple so people can go inside, and Hezekiah repairs the temple.

In the third scene: Hezekiah tells the Levites and priests to purify themselves and the temple. Hezekiah reminds the men of the evil things the people's ancestors did. Hezekiah says it is because people did these evil things that Yahweh became angry and Judah's people suffered and died. But Hezekiah says the people will make a covenant with Yahweh so that Yahweh will stop being angry with Judah.

In the fourth scene: Hezekiah tells the Levites and priests to begin serving Yahweh and to help the people worship Yahweh.

In the fifth scene: All the Levites and priests begin to do their priestly work again. The men purify themselves and the temple. The men follow all of Yahweh's instructions.

The characters in this passage are:

- Hezekiah, Judah's king
- Abijah, who is Zechariah's daughter and Hezekiah's mother
- Yahweh
- King David, Hezekiah's ancestor
- The Levites
- The priests, who are also Levites
- The people of Judah
- The people's ancestors
- And the leaders of the Levite clans

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first scene, the storyteller gives the same information about Hezekiah as the previous kings. We hear that Hezekiah was 25 years old when Hezekiah became king. Hezekiah reigned or was in power as king in Jerusalem for 29 years. Hezekiah's mother was Abijah, and Abijah was the daughter of Zechariah. We are not sure which Zechariah this was.

Hezekiah did what was right in Yahweh's eyes, just as Hezekiah's father, King David, had done. This is special language that means that Hezekiah did the things Yahweh approved of. David was Hezekiah's ancestor. You will remember that many times in the Bible, "father" means an ancestor, not a person's literal father.

In the second scene, we hear that in the first year Hezekiah reigned as king, in the first month, Hezekiah opened the doors of Yahweh's temple and repaired the doors. This could mean that Hezekiah became king sometime during one year, and then, when the next year began, Hezekiah opened the temple. Or, more likely, this means Hezekiah began to reign in the first month of the year and immediately opened the temple. You will remember that for the Israelites, each year began at the time of year we call mid-March. So the storyteller shows that Hezekiah began to care for Yahweh's temple very soon after Hezekiah became king. You will remember that when the storyteller says Hezekiah repaired the temple doors, this probably means that Hezekiah told his workers to repair the doors, not that Hezekiah did the work himself.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you talk about when Hezekiah began to work on the temple in your translation? Pause this audio here.

In the third scene, Hezekiah gathers the priests and Levites in the open place on the east. We are not sure what this place is, but we know it is east of the temple. This may refer to a place near one of the eastern gates of Jerusalem or perhaps the eastern courtyard in front of the temple, which faced east. We also do not know how Hezekiah gathers the men together. It may be that Hezekiah tells some of his workers to travel around and tell all of the priests and Levites to come to the temple.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you talk about the place where Hezekiah gathers the men? You should translate this so it does not say an exact location, just like the storyteller does not say the exact location. For example, you might say something like, "the open place east of the temple" or "the gathering place east of the temple." Pause this audio here.

Hezekiah speaks to this large group of men. First, Hezekiah tells the Levites that they must pay attention to what Hezekiah says. You will remember that priests are a special kind of Levite, so when Hezekiah says "Levites," Hezekiah means all of the men, including the priests. Hezekiah tells the men to consecrate themselves, or to make themselves holy. Hezekiah also tells the men to consecrate the temple. Hezekiah calls Yahweh "the God of your fathers." Again, "fathers" means ancestors. Hezekiah probably says this to remind the Levites that although the people of Judah have been worshiping other nations' gods, Yahweh has always been the Israelites' God, and this is Yahweh's temple.

Hezekiah says the men must carry the dirty things out of the Holy Place. Hezekiah is not saying there is literally garbage or dirt in the temple. Hezekiah means the men must remove the idols and other unholy things from the temple. The sanctuary, or Holy Place, refers to the middle part of the temple, not the Most Holy Place, where only the high priest could enter once a year.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how do you talk about things that are ceremonially unclean, or unfit for people to use in worship? Pause this audio here.

Hezekiah says the men's fathers were unfaithful. Again, "fathers" means ancestors, so Hezekiah refers to the way the previous generations of people worshipped other gods instead of Yahweh. The people did what was evil in Yahweh's sight. This is special language that means the people did what Yahweh said was very wrong.

Again, Hezekiah calls Yahweh the people's God. But Hezekiah says the people have left Yahweh, have turned their faces from where Yahweh lives, and have turned their backs. These are three similar ways to say the same idea. It seems Hezekiah wants the people to remember that Yahweh did not leave the people, but the people left Yahweh. Yahweh's presence is at the temple, but the people quit going to the temple. Instead, the people worshipped idols. Literally, when people quit going to the temple to worship Yahweh, the people no longer faced toward the temple. However, Hezekiah also uses this as a symbol to show how the people's relationship to Yahweh changed. When the people worshipped idols instead of Yahweh, the people no longer knew Yahweh, like a person who walks away from another person so that only their back faces that person.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Mark out an area on the ground to represent a person's house. Choose one person from your group to stand in that house. Next, have some people from your group come to that house to visit the person and become friends. Now, choose another person from your group and have that person stand

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some distance away from the house. Have the people who had been visiting the person at the house leave that person and instead go visit the new person. Pay attention to how the people walk away from the house and how they stand with their backs facing the house. Pause this audio here.

The people's ancestors also shut the doors of the vestibule or porch. This was the open area right in front of the doors that opened into the temple. You will remember that in the last story, we learned how Hezekiah's father, King Ahaz, shut these doors so people could not go into the temple.

The people's ancestors also put out the lamps and no longer burned incense or offered burnt offerings in the sanctuary, or Holy Place, to Israel's God. You will remember in the books of Exodus and Leviticus how Yahweh instructed the priests to always keep these lamps burning in the temple. Yahweh had also given the priests the responsibility to burn incense and make burnt offerings to Yahweh on behalf of the people. The Holy Place refers to the whole temple area, not just a specific part of the temple. And Israel refers specifically to the kingdom of Judah. You will remember that at this time, the nation of Israel was divided into two kingdoms: the kingdom that people called Judah in the south, and the kingdom that people called Israel in the north. But both kingdoms were part of the nation of Israel.

Stop here as a group and tell a story about two separate communities that were the same people group but did not get along with each other. How did the people talk about each other? Pause this audio here.

Because of the wrong things people did, Yahweh became very, very angry at the people of Judah and Jerusalem. Yahweh made people from other nations feel horrified and surprised when they saw how Yahweh punished Judah. People hissed or made the whistling sound that people make when they want someone to feel ashamed. Hezekiah says the Levites know these things are true because they have seen it with their own eyes. This is special language that means the men have seen these things happen.

In the original language, Hezekiah uses a special word to draw extra attention to what Hezekiah says next. The men's fathers, or ancestors, have "fallen by the sword." This phrase refers to the way an enemy uses a sword, a sharp weapon, to badly wound a person in battle so that the person falls down on the ground and dies. Also, the men's sons, daughters, and wives are in captivity. This means that Judah's enemies took the men's wives and children away to other countries as prisoners. Hezekiah reminds the men that this happened because Yahweh was very angry with them.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you talk about the way a person dies in a violent way in battle? Pause this audio here.

Hezekiah says it is in Hezekiah's "heart" to make a covenant with Yahweh, Israel's God. In the Bible, the heart is special language for the place where a person's thoughts, feelings, and decisions happen. A covenant is a special promise that people make to each other. So Hezekiah has decided that the people of Judah must promise to be faithful to Yahweh. The people must do this so that Yahweh will no longer be angry with the people.

In the fourth scene, Hezekiah calls the men "my sons." This is special language that shows the close relationship the Levites have with the king. Hezekiah says not to be lazy or neglect the work Yahweh gave the men. Yahweh chose these men to stand in Yahweh's presence, to minister to Yahweh, and to be Yahweh's ministers. Each of these phrases means almost the same thing: to serve Yahweh and lead other people in worship. Hezekiah says these three different ways to emphasize it more strongly. Hezekiah also says Yahweh chose these men to burn incense to Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How do you emphasize something in a stronger way by the way you say it? If you do not have similar phrases like this in your language, how will you emphasize what Hezekiah says? Pause this audio here.

In the fifth scene, the storyteller says the Levites arise. This is special language that means the men got ready to do what Hezekiah said to do. The storyteller gives a list of each Levite clan and its leaders. From the Kohathite clan, the leaders are Mahath, Amasai's son, and Joel, Azariah's son. From the Merarite clan, the leaders are Kish, Abdi's son, and Azariah, Jehallel's son. From the Gershonite clan, the leaders are Joah, Zimmah's son, and Eden, Joah's son. From Elizaphan's descendants, the leaders are Shimri and Jeiel. From Asaph's descendants, the leaders are Zechariah and Mattaniah. From Heman's descendants, the leaders are Jehiel and Shimei. And from Jeduthan's descendants, the leaders are Shemaiah and Uzziel.

Each of these leaders gathers the men of their clan together. The men make themselves ritually clean and holy to serve Yahweh. Then the men go in to clean Yahweh's temple. The men do what King Hezekiah commands, according to Yahweh's law. This could refer to how Yahweh instructed Hezekiah to cleanse the temple, but it more likely refers to Yahweh's instructions in the law. So the priests go into Yahweh's temple and remove the things that make the temple impure. The priests bring these things out to the temple courtyard. Then the Levites carry these things away to the Kidron Valley. You will remember that the Kidron Valley was a valley to the east of Jerusalem.

Stop here as a group and again look at a map that shows Jerusalem and the Kidron Valley, if needed. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller ends by telling how long it took the priests and other Levites to finish this work. The men began to consecrate, or make the temple holy, on the first day of the first month. On the eighth day of the month, the men finished making the courtyard holy and reached the porch of Yahweh's temple. Then, for eight more days, the men continued to make holy the inside of Yahweh's temple. Finally, the men finished on the 16th day of the first month.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 29:1–17 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has five scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Hezekiah, Judah's king
- Abijah, who is Zechariah's daughter and Hezekiah's mother
- Yahweh
- King David, Hezekiah's ancestor
- The Levites
- The priests, who are also Levites
- The people of Judah
- The people's ancestors
- And the leaders of the Levite clans

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Hezekiah becomes Judah's king when Hezekiah is 25 years old. Hezekiah rules Judah from the city of Jerusalem for 29 years. Hezekiah's mother's name is Abijah. Abijah is the daughter of a man whose name is Zechariah. Hezekiah does things that please Yahweh, just like Hezekiah's ancestor, King David, did.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am happy that Hezekiah wants to serve me and do what is right; or
- I will allow Hezekiah to be Judah's king for a long time.

Ask the person playing Hezekiah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I want to be a better king than my father, Ahaz, was; or
- I want to serve Yahweh. I will try to be like my ancestor, King David.

Continue the drama.

During King Hezekiah's first month as king, Hezekiah opens the doors of Yahweh's temple and has people fix the doors.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the workers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We are happy that we can help make these doors beautiful again.

Ask the people playing the people of Judah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- Some of us remember when King Ahaz closed Yahweh's temple. We are glad to see the temple open again; or
- Some of us are too young to remember when people worshipped at this temple. We do not know Yahweh.

Continue the drama.

Hezekiah gathers the priests and Levites on the east side of the temple. Then Hezekiah speaks to all of the men: "You people from Levi's tribe, listen to me! Make yourselves holy for Yahweh, and also make Yahweh's temple holy. Yahweh was your ancestors' God. Get rid of the dirty things from the inner room of the temple. Our ancestors did not keep their promises to Yahweh. Our ancestors did evil things that Yahweh, our God, did not like. Our ancestors abandoned Yahweh. Our ancestors turned their backs on the place where Yahweh lives. Our ancestors ignored Yahweh altogether. Our ancestors also closed the doors at the entrance of the temple and made the fire stop burning in the lamps. Our ancestors no longer burned incense for Yahweh in the inner room or made burnt offerings to Israel's God. Because of this, Yahweh has become angry with Judah and the city of Jerusalem. Yahweh has made people from other nations feel shocked and horrified when they see Yahweh's people, so that those people greatly disrespect Yahweh's people. You have seen this yourselves. This is why people killed our ancestors in battle, and why people have taken our sons, our daughters, and our wives as prisoners. So today, I want to renew the strong agreement we made with Yahweh, the God of Israel's people, so that Yahweh will stop being angry with us."

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Hezekiah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel ashamed that my father, Ahaz, led the people of Judah to worship idols; or
- I do not want Yahweh to be angry with us. I hope Yahweh will forgive us.

Ask the people playing the Levites, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- I think King Hezekiah is right. Yahweh has been punishing us; or
- I agree with King Ahaz. We must obey and serve Yahweh; or
- King Hezekiah acts very differently than King Ahaz did. Hezekiah is a wise king.

Continue the drama.

"Do not be lazy any longer, my sons. Yahweh chose you to stand in Yahweh's presence and to serve Yahweh. Yahweh chose you to be Yahweh's workers and to burn Yahweh's offerings."

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the Levites, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We can tell that Hezekiah cares about us very much. Hezekiah speaks to us like we are Hezekiah's family or close friends; or
- We feel honored that Yahweh chose us to do this special work to serve Yahweh; or

- It has been a long time since our people worked in the temple. We hope the work is not too difficult.

Continue the drama.

After King Hezekiah finishes speaking, the Levites start to work. From Kohath's clan, the leaders are Mahath, Amasai's son, and Joel, Azariah's son. From Merari's clan, the leaders are Kish, Abdi's son, and Azariah, Jehallel's son. From Gershon's clan, the leaders are Joah, Zimmah's son, and Eden, Joah's son. From Elizaphan's descendants, the leaders are Shimri and Jeiel. From Asaph's descendants, the leaders are Zechariah and Mattaniah. From Heman's descendants, the leaders are Jehiel and Shimei. And from Jeduthun's descendants, the leaders are Shemaiah and Uzziel.

After the leaders brought all the other Levites together, the Levites all purified themselves to serve Yahweh. Then the Levites purified Yahweh's temple, just as the king told them to do, according to Yahweh's instructions. The priests entered Yahweh's temple to make the temple holy. The priests brought everything from inside that was unclean out to the courtyard. Then the Levites took those things away to the Kidron Valley.

The priests and Levites began to purify Yahweh's temple on the first day of the first month. By the eighth day of the month, the priests and Levites finished with the courtyard and reached the entrance to Yahweh's temple. Then for eight more days, the priests and Levites purified Yahweh's temple itself to make it holy, and they finished on the first month's 16th day.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the priests, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- I am surprised that there are so many things in the temple that we need to remove; or
- I did not expect it to take us this many days to clean the temple!

Ask the people playing the Levites who are not priests, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We are disappointed that we are not allowed to go into the temple like the priests; or
- The priests had a lot of work to do in the temple! or
- We are glad we do not have to stay in the Kidron Valley very long. The Kidron Valley is not a very nice place. We would rather be at Yahweh's temple, where we feel close to Yahweh.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 29:1–17 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

Hezekiah began to **reign** when Hezekiah was 25 years old. You will remember that to reign means to rule or act with power as king. Use the same word or phrase for reign as you used in previous passages.

Hezekiah opens the doors of Yahweh's house. Yahweh's house is another way to say Yahweh's **temple**. Use the same words or phrases for Yahweh's house or temple as you used in previous passages. For more information on temple, refer to the Master Glossary.

Hezekiah gathered the **priests** and the **Levites**. Use the same words or phrases for priests and Levites as you used in previous passages. For more information on priest and Levite, refer to the Master Glossary.

The priests and Levites must **consecrate** themselves and the temple. To consecrate a person or thing means to set that person or thing apart for special service to God or to make it holy. In the Old Testament, when a priest or Levite consecrated themself, it meant they did not have sexual relations with their wife for a certain amount of time, and then they had to take a special bath and put on fresh clothes. To consecrate the temple and all the objects in the temple, the priests sprinkled the blood of animals they had sacrificed in the temple and over the objects in the temple. Use the same word or phrase for consecrate as you used in previous passages. For more information, refer to consecrate in the Master Glossary.

Hezekiah refers to **Yahweh** as the **God** of the people's **fathers**. God is the general name for the most powerful spiritual being who created everything, and Yahweh is God's personal name. "Fathers" means ancestors. Use the

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same words or phrases for Yahweh, God, and fathers as you have used in previous passages. For more information, look up Yahweh and God in the Master Glossary.

The people's ancestors did **evil**. Use the same word or phrase for evil as you used in previous passages. For more information on evil, refer to the Master Glossary.

The Levites must take the dirty things out of the **Holy Place**. This refers to the middle room of the temple. Use the same word or phrase for Holy Place as you used in previous passages, where Holy Place referred to this room. For more information on Holy Place, refer to the Master Glossary.

The people's ancestors turned their faces away from Yahweh's **dwelling place**, or the place where Yahweh lives. In this passage, this refers to the temple, but in the original language, the same phrase can refer to the tabernacle, which was Yahweh's dwelling place or house before the temple. For more information on temple, refer to the Master Glossary. Use the same word or phrase for dwelling place or house as you used in previous passages.

The people's ancestors put out the **lamps**. You will remember that Yahweh instructed Moses how to make the lampstand in Exodus 25:31–40, and that this lampstand held seven oil lamps. These lamps symbolized the way that Yahweh led the people of Israel, and the priests were supposed to make sure these lamps always kept burning. Use the same word or phrase for lamps as you used in previous passages. For more information about the kind of lamps people used in Judah at this time, look up **oil lamp** in the Master Glossary.

Stop here as a group and look at a drawing of what the lampstand in the temple might have looked like. Pause this audio here.

The priests had also stopped **burning incense** and offering **burnt offerings** in the **sanctuary**. People make incense from things like spices and wood that smell very good when people burn the incense in a fire. The priests would burn incense as an offering to Yahweh. A burnt offering is a form of sacrifice where a person kills an animal and burns this animal completely on an altar, which is a special place meant for bringing gifts to Yahweh. Here, the sanctuary refers to the whole temple complex. Use the same words or phrases for burning incense, burnt offerings, and sanctuary as you used in previous passages. For more information on burnt offerings and sanctuary, refer to the Master Glossary.

Yahweh's **wrath** came on Judah and Jerusalem. Wrath is the attitude Yahweh has when Yahweh sees sin and evil. Wrath is stronger than anger. Look up wrath in the Master Glossary for more information. Use the same word or phrase for wrath as you used in previous passages.

Yahweh made people from other nations feel horrified when those people saw how Yahweh punished Judah. In the original language, this literally means the people trembled or felt very afraid when they saw how Yahweh punished the people of Judah.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **horrified**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The people of other nations also felt "astonished," or surprised. This is a similar idea to horrified. This word means to feel shocked by a bad thing that happens.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will describe how the people felt **astonished**. Pause this audio here.

Hezekiah says the people's ancestors were killed by the **sword**. A sword is a long, sharp weapon that people make from metal. People use a sword to fight and injure others in battle. A sword has a handle to hold and a blade to cut or stab. A sword is usually longer than a knife. Use the same word or phrase for sword as you used in previous passages.

It is in Hezekiah's **heart** to make a **covenant** with Yahweh. "Heart" is special language for the place where a person's thoughts, feelings, and decisions happen. When people make a covenant, those people make a solemn promise to each other that they cannot break. Use the same words or phrases for heart and covenant as you used in previous passages. For more information on heart and covenant, refer to the Master Glossary.

Yahweh has chosen the Levites to minister to Yahweh and to make offerings to Yahweh. To minister means to do the work of a servant, or to do work for someone who is more important.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **minister**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

An **offering** is a gift or sacrifice to Yahweh. People can make offerings for many reasons, including to give thanks, to be purified, or to ask forgiveness for sin. Use the same word or phrase for offering as you used in previous passages. For more information on offering, refer to the Master Glossary.

The priests and Levites cleanse, or purify, the temple. To cleanse means to make something ritually clean or holy.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **cleanse**, or **purify**. Look up purify in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

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Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (848 KB)
- Setting the Stage (4.3 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (9.1 MB)
- Embodying the Text (5.4 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (4.9 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

2 Chronicles 29:18–30

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 29:18–30 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 29:18–30 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

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Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 29:18–30 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

The events in this story happened some time after Hezekiah, king of Judah, had told the priests and the Levites to consecrate themselves and the temple of Yahweh, and after the priests and the Levites had finished consecrating themselves and the temple. The events in this story happened in Jerusalem.

This story is about how King Hezekiah, the priests, and the Levites started doing the worship service at the temple again. King Hezekiah did this because Hezekiah wanted to make a covenant with Yahweh so that Yahweh would stop being angry at Hezekiah and at the Israelites, because the ancestors of the Israelites had done evil things.

The priests and the Levites go to King Hezekiah and report that they have purified the entire temple of Yahweh, the altar of burnt offering with all its utensils, and the table for setting out the bread of the presence, with all the utensils that the priests used in the temple.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a picture of the altar with all the utensils and the table for the bread of the presence with all the utensils. Pause this audio here.

When you consecrate or sanctify someone, you set the person apart for special service to Yahweh. People can also consecrate or sanctify an object to do a special task for Yahweh. At that time, the priests and Levites consecrated an object by sprinkling the blood of animals they had sacrificed in the temple over that object. These objects were now holy—they belonged to Yahweh. People could not use these objects for ordinary use. If people did, that would be a terrible insult to Yahweh. These utensils are the things the priests used during the worship time at the temple of Yahweh, including the special tools and dishes.

The priests and the Levites say that they have prepared and consecrated all the utensils that King Ahaz removed when Ahaz was unfaithful to Yahweh. All the articles are now again in front of Yahweh's altar. You will remember in earlier stories that when King Ahaz was ruling as the king, King Ahaz took these utensils from the temple to use the utensils to worship idols. The priests and the Levites have brought back all these utensils into the temple.

Early the next morning, King Hezekiah gathers the officials or leaders of the city together and goes up to Yahweh's temple. King Hezekiah and the officials bring seven bulls, seven rams, seven male lambs, and seven male goats as a sin offering for the royal family of Judah, for Yahweh's temple, and for the rest of the kingdom. We know from the context of the passage that the male goats were for the sin offering. The priests sacrifice the bulls, rams, and male lambs as a burnt offering. A ram is an adult male sheep, usually over one year old. A lamb refers specifically to a young sheep that is less than one year old.

Stop here and, as a group, look at pictures of a bull, sheep, ram, lamb, and goat. Pause this audio here.

King Hezekiah and the officials brought these animals to sacrifice as offerings to remove the sin people had done in the royal family, in Yahweh's temple, and in the land of Judah.

King Hezekiah commands the priests, the descendants of Aaron, to offer the animals on the altar of Yahweh. So the people slaughter, or kill, the bulls, and the priests take the blood, and splash the blood against the altar. Next, the priests slaughter the rams and splash the rams' blood against the altar. Then the priests slaughter the lambs and splash the lambs' blood against the altar.

The priests then bring the goats for the sin or purification offering before the king and the people, and the king and the people lay their hands on the goats. Laying hands on the goats symbolizes that the people have

transferred their sins onto the animals. The animals die in place of the people who have sinned so that the people do not have to receive God's punishment for the people's sin.

The priests then kill the goats and present the blood of the goats as a sin offering on the altar to make atonement for all Israel. When someone makes atonement, they restore the relationship between people or groups of people. The king had commanded the priests to make the burnt offering and the sin or purification offering for all the people of Israel. The people had broken their relationship with Yahweh because of the sin the people committed. By making atonement, the people restore their relationship with Yahweh, and Yahweh cleanses the people of their sins.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what do people do to restore the broken relationship between a person and God, a person and gods, or a person and spirits? Pause this audio here.

King Hezekiah positions the Levites in the temple of Yahweh with cymbals, harps, and lyres. Hezekiah followed the same placement that David used for the temple musicians. Yahweh had commanded David to do so through the prophet Gad, who was King David's seer, and through Nathan the prophet. [You will remember that Gad was a prophet who served in David's royal court.]{.mark} You may also remember that people frequently used cymbals, harps, and lyres as musical instruments in worship.

A cymbal was a musical instrument that consisted of two metal discs that a person struck together in order to make a shrill, clashing sound. People made cymbals with copper or bronze at that time.

Stop here and look at a picture of a cymbal. Pause this audio here.

The harp and lyre are stringed instruments. The harp has 10 to 13 strings of unequal length. A harp does not have a connecting yoke like a lyre. A person plays a harp by plucking its strings to make music. A lyre has a rectangular sound box with two arms and a yoke that connects the two arms. Lyres had from four to eight strings of about the same length. A lyre is usually smaller than a harp, and a person plays a lyre to make music by plucking the strings.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a harp and a lyre. Pause this audio here.

So the Levites stand ready with the same kinds of instruments that King David had used, and the priests stand with their trumpets. It is unlikely that King David's own instruments were still in working condition after 300 years. A trumpet is a long, straight instrument that musicians blow air into. The trumpet had a limited range of notes. People made trumpets from hammered metal, either silver or bronze. Priests played these trumpets to sound an alarm in times of war or to produce music in times of celebration.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a trumpet. Pause this audio here.

Hezekiah gives the priests the order to sacrifice the burnt offering on the altar. The priests sacrifice the seven bulls, seven rams, and seven male lambs on the altar, as prescribed by the Law of Moses. As the priests begin the burnt offering, the musicians also begin singing to Yahweh. The priests join the singing by blowing the trumpets, and the Levites join the singing by playing the musical instruments of David, king of Israel.

All the people there bow in worship while the musicians play and the priests blow the trumpets. The people continue doing all these things until the priests have finished burning the offerings. When the sacrifice of burnt offerings is finished, King Hezekiah and everyone present with Hezekiah kneel down and worship Yahweh.

King Hezekiah and his officials order the Levites to sing praise songs to Yahweh with the words of David and the seer or prophet Asaph. So the Levites sing praise songs joyfully and bow down and worship Yahweh.

King David and the prophet Asaph were the authors of many of the Psalms, so it is probable that "the words of David and Asaph" refers to the songs that David and Asaph composed. Asaph was the Levite whom David appointed to oversee the musical parts of the worship in the temple.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 29:18–30 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has five scenes.

In the first scene: The priests and the Levites go to King Hezekiah and tell King Hezekiah that they have purified the entire temple.

In the second scene: Early the next morning, King Hezekiah gathers officials of the city and goes to Yahweh's temple with animals for a sin offering.

In the third scene: King Hezekiah commands the priests to offer the animals on the altar. The priests kill the bulls, rams, and lambs, and throw the blood on the altar. Then the priests kill the male goats and offer the male goats as sin offerings to make atonement for all the people of Israel.

In the fourth scene: King Hezekiah positions the Levites in the temple with different musical instruments. King Hezekiah commands the priests to sacrifice the burnt offerings on the altar. While the priests sacrifice the burnt offerings, the musicians begin to sing and play the musical instruments. The people bow in worship to Yahweh.

In the fifth scene: When the offerings finish burning, King Hezekiah and everyone present with Hezekiah kneel down and worship Yahweh. Then, King Hezekiah and his officials order the Levites to sing praise songs to Yahweh.

The characters in this passage are:

- The priests
- The Levites
- King Hezekiah
- The city officials
- The people who gathered at the temple of Yahweh
- And the musicians

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In scene one, the priests and the Levites go to King Hezekiah and report that they have purified the entire temple of Yahweh, the altar of burnt offering with all its utensils, and the table for setting out the bread of the presence, with all the equipment associated with it. The priests and Levites had made holy all the things that King Ahaz removed from the temple when King Ahaz was unfaithful to Yahweh, or betrayed Yahweh. All the actions in scene one probably happened at King Hezekiah's palace.

In scene two, King Hezekiah gathers the city officials together and goes up to Yahweh's temple early the next morning. King Hezekiah and the officials bring seven bulls, seven rams, seven male lambs, and seven male goats as a sin or purification offering for the kingdom, for the sanctuary or temple, and for Judah. In this context, the kingdom refers to the royal family, while Judah refers to the rest of the people in the kingdom of Judah. When the storyteller says "the sanctuary," the storyteller is referring to the temple and the people who serve in the temple.

Stop and discuss: How will you translate each of these groups of people so that people in your culture understand who the storyteller is referring to? Pause this audio here.

The number seven is a special number in many cultures of this area, including the people of Judah. The number seven is also an important number in the Bible as a symbol of completeness or fullness. By offering seven of each animal, King Hezekiah is emphasizing the importance of the sacrifice.

In scene three, King Hezekiah commands the priests, who are the descendants of Aaron, to offer the animals on the altar of Yahweh. In the original language, it is not clear who killed the bulls. It may be the priests, or it may be King Hezekiah and his officials. It may also be King Hezekiah, his officials, and the priests. However, according to the instructions Yahweh gave to Moses, the people making the burnt offering were usually the ones who actually slaughtered the animals. So, it is most likely that King Hezekiah and his officials killed the bulls. The priests take the blood from the slaughtered bulls and splash the blood against the altar. Next, the priests slaughter the rams and splash the rams' blood against the altar. Then, the priests slaughter the lambs and splash the lambs' blood against the altar.

The priests then bring the goats for the sin or purification offering before King Hezekiah and the people there, and King Hezekiah and the people lay their hands on the goats. Then, the priests kill the goats and present the blood of the goats as a sin or purification offering on the altar to make atonement for all Israel, because King Hezekiah has commanded the priests to make the burnt offering and the sin or purification offering for all the people of Israel.

Stop here and discuss as a group: If you have already translated Leviticus into your language, listen to your translation of Leviticus 4. Discuss how you will translate this section about the sin or purification offering. Pause this audio here.

After the priests kill the animals, the storyteller repeats King Hezekiah's command to emphasize that the king commanded the priests to make burnt offerings and sin or purification offerings for all of Israel.

In scene four, King Hezekiah positions the Levites in the temple of Yahweh with cymbals, harps, and lyres, in the way David and Gad, King David's seer, and Nathan the prophet had ordered many years before. A seer is another word for "prophet." People called Gad King David's seer, because Gad served in David's royal court as an advisor. Here, the storyteller explains that Yahweh, through Yahweh's prophets, commanded the Israelites to have Levites with musical instruments in Yahweh's temple. Yahweh commanded the Israelites to do so about 300 years ago, during the time of King David.

Then, the Levites stand ready with the instruments like those King David had used, and the priests stand with their trumpets. Hezekiah gives the priests the order to sacrifice the burnt offering on the altar. As the priests begin offering, the musicians also begin singing to Yahweh. The priests join the singing by blowing the trumpets, and the Levites join the singing by playing the musical instruments like those King David used.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story in which two events happened at the same time. In your language, how do people usually talk about two events that occur at the same time? Discuss how you will tell that the musical worship happened at the same time as the sacrifices. Pause this audio here.

All the people there bow in worship, while the musicians play and the priests blow the trumpets. The people continue doing all these things until the priests have finished burning the offerings.

Stop here and discuss as a group: In your culture, how do people use music in worship? When does music accompany worship rituals and activities? Pause this audio here.

In the fifth scene, when the offerings finish burning, King Hezekiah and everyone present with Hezekiah kneel down and worship Yahweh. King Hezekiah and his officials order the Levites to sing praise songs to Yahweh with the words of David and the seer Asaph. So the Levites sing praise songs joyfully and bow down and worship Yahweh.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 29:18–30 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has five scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- The priests
- The Levites
- King Hezekiah
- The city officials
- The people who gathered at the temple of Yahweh
- And the musicians

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

2 Chronicles 29:18–30

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

All the actions in scene one probably happened at King Hezekiah's palace.

The priests and the Levites go to King Hezekiah and report that they have purified the entire temple of Yahweh, the altar of burnt offering with all its utensils, and the table for setting out the bread of the presence, with all the equipment associated with it.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the priest, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am very tired but excited to let King Hezekiah know what we have accomplished; or
- I am looking forward to leading the worship service at the temple of Yahweh soon; or
- I will need to study all the laws for offering sacrifices so that I do not miss any steps.

Continue the drama.

King Hezekiah gathers the city officials together and goes up to Yahweh's temple early the next morning. King Hezekiah and the officials bring seven bulls, seven rams, seven male lambs, and seven male goats as a sin offering for the royal family of Judah, for Yahweh's temple, and for the rest of the kingdom.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing one of the city officials, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am very happy to get to serve a leader like King Hezekiah; or
- I have not worshipped Yahweh in many years. I am very excited now; or
- I hope Yahweh will accept our offerings and forgive our sins.

Continue the drama.

King Hezekiah commands the priests, the descendants of Aaron, to offer the animals on the altar of Yahweh. So the people slaughter the bulls, and the priests take the blood and splash the blood against the altar. Next, the priests slaughter the rams and splash the rams' blood against the altar. Then the priests slaughter the lambs and splash the lambs' blood against the altar.

The priests then bring the goats for the sin offering before the king and the people there, and the king and the people lay their hands on the goats. Then the priests kill the goats and present the blood of the goats as a sin offering on the altar to make atonement for all Israel because King Hezekiah commanded the priests to make the burnt offering and the sin offering for all the people of Israel.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing one of the priests, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- King Hezekiah and the people are serious about making atonement for their sins. They brought seven of each kind of animal; or
- I am grateful that King Hezekiah is helping us return to the proper worship of Yahweh.

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Ask the person playing one of the people gathered at the temple, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am happy that we now have a restored relationship with Yahweh; or
- I am so excited that the priests have made these offerings for us. Now Yahweh has forgiven our sins. It has been a long time!

Continue the drama.

King Hezekiah positions the Levites in the temple of Yahweh with cymbals, harps, and lyres in the way David and Gad, who was king David’s seer and Nathan the prophet, prescribed. Yahweh commanded the Israelites to do so through Yahweh’s prophets. So the Levites stand ready with musical instruments like those David used, and the priests stand with their trumpets.

Hezekiah commands the priests to sacrifice the burnt offering on the altar. As the priests begin offering, the musicians also begin singing to Yahweh. The priests join the singing by blowing the trumpets and the Levites join the singing by playing the musical instruments of David, king of Israel.

All the people there bow in worship, while the musicians play and the priests blow the trumpets. The people continue doing all these things until the priests have finished burning the offerings. When the offerings finish burning, King Hezekiah and everyone present with the king kneel down and worship Yahweh.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing a Levite who plays a musical instrument, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I feel peace and joy when I play music to worship Yahweh; or
- I am very happy to use my skill as a musician during the worship service; or
- Yahweh is worthy of our worship and praise. I cannot help but play my instrument for Yahweh.

Continue the drama.

King Hezekiah and his officials order the Levites to sing praise songs to Yahweh with the words of David and the seer or the prophet Asaph. So the Levites sing praise songs joyfully and bow down and worship Yahweh.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 29:18–30 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

The **priests** and the **Levites** go to **King** Hezekiah and report that they have **purified** the entire **temple** of **Yahweh**, the **altar** of burnt offering with all its utensils, and the table for setting out the **bread of the presence**, with all the utensils associated with it. Use the same words for priests, Levites, King, purify, temple, Yahweh, altar, and bread of the presence as you used in the previous passages. For more information on priests, Levites, king, purify, temple, Yahweh, altar, and “bread of the presence,” refer to the Master Glossary.

A **burnt offering** is a form of sacrifice that people bring to Yahweh. When a person brings Yahweh a burnt offering, that person kills an animal and burns this animal completely on an altar. When a person brings Yahweh a burnt offering, that person is saying to Yahweh, “Just as I am completely burning this animal, I am completely devoted to you.” Use the same word or phrase for burnt offering as you used in previous passages. For more information on burnt offering, refer to the Master Glossary.

The priests said that they **consecrated** all of the utensils that King Ahaz had taken out of the temple. When you consecrate someone, you set the person apart for special service to Yahweh. You could also consecrate an object to do a special task for Yahweh. Use the same word or phrase for consecrate as you used in previous passages. For more information on consecrate, refer to the Master Glossary.

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King Hezekiah and the officials bring seven bulls, seven rams, seven lambs, and seven male goats as a sin or purification offering for the "kingdom" or royal family of Judah, for Yahweh's temple, and for the rest of the kingdom of Judah. People also called the sin offering a purification offering or a purification sacrifice because the purpose of this offering was to purify someone who had become unclean or unfit to serve Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **sin or purification offering**. Look up "sin or purification offering" in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

If you use the term for "**kingdom**" instead of royal family, refer to kingdom in the Master Glossary for more information and translate kingdom in the same way you have previously. Use the same word for important **officials** and **Judah** as you have used previously, and refer to Judah in the Master Glossary for more information.

Use the same word or phrase for **slaughter**, or kill an animal, as you have used in previous passages.

Later, the priests bring the goats to the **assembly**, or gathering of people, and they kill the goats and present the blood of the goats as a sin offering on the altar to make atonement for all Israel. The people had broken their relationship with Yahweh because of the sin the people committed. By making atonement, the people restore their relationship with Yahweh, and Yahweh cleanses the people of their sins. Use the same word or phrase for assembly, or "special gathering of people," as you have used previously.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **atonement**. Look up atonement in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

King Hezekiah positions the Levites in the temple of Yahweh with **cymbals**, **harps**, and **lyres** in the way David and Gad, who was king David's **seer** and Nathan the **prophet**, prescribed. A prophet is a person who gives messages from Yahweh to the people. A seer is another word for a prophet. People called Gad King David's seer because Gad served as an advisor in David's royal court. Use the same words or phrases for cymbals, harps, lyres, prophet, and seer as you used in previous passages. For more information on prophet, refer to the Master Glossary.

Later, all the people at the temple of Yahweh **bow** in **worship** while the musicians play and the priests blow the **trumpets**. In the original language, the storyteller simply says "bow down," meaning that the people worshiped. When a person bows down before someone else, that person lowers their head or the whole top of their body forward. Sometimes people even stretched themselves out flat on the ground in front of a person. People do this to show respect and humility. When a person worships Yahweh, that person gives honor to Yahweh. That person is saying that Yahweh deserves all of that person's thanks, praise, and respect. Worship is not just performing rituals for Yahweh; it is about having a heart of awe and wonder towards Yahweh. Use the same words for trumpets, bow, and worship as you used in previous passages. For more information on bow and worship, refer to the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

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Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (852 KB)
- Setting the Stage (5.3 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (4.7 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.9 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (3.5 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

2 Chronicles 29:31–36

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 29:31–36 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 29:31–36 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 29:31–36 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passage, King Hezekiah commanded the priests to offer burnt offerings and sin or purification offerings for the royal family, the temple, and the people of Judah. Through these offerings, the people made atonement for their sin. The people bowed in worship while the priests made the offerings, and the Levites praised Yahweh with instruments and singing.

Now, Hezekiah says to the people that since the people have consecrated themselves to Yahweh, the people should come and bring sacrifices and thank offerings to Yahweh's temple. So the people there bring sacrifices and thank offerings. Sacrifices are offerings of sheep, goats, or cattle that people give to worship Yahweh, confirm their relationship with Yahweh, or ask forgiveness for something people have done wrong. A sacrifice could involve the killing of an animal, and then the priest would burn some parts of the animal on the altar. Thank offerings are sacrifices that people give to thank Yahweh for answered prayer.

Some people have a willing heart and make a voluntary sacrifice of burnt offerings. The people who brought voluntary burnt offerings were considered generous because the priests burned all the meat from those offerings on the altar. You will remember that for other sacrifices and thank offerings, the person who gave the offering ate what the priests did not burn.

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Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story about someone who did a good thing they did not have to do, or about someone who did more than was expected. Pay attention to how the storyteller describes this kind of person. What do people in your culture think about this kind of voluntary action? Pause this audio here.

The people bring 70 bulls, 100 rams, and 200 male lambs as burnt offerings. All these animals are for burnt offerings to Yahweh. When a person brings Yahweh a burnt offering, that person kills an animal, and the priest burns this animal completely on the altar. The people bring 600 bulls and 3,000 sheep and goats as consecrated or holy sacrifices.

However, there are not enough priests who are ritually clean to skin all of the animals for burnt offerings. So the Levites help the priests finish skinning the animals until other priests have consecrated themselves. Levites have done better at keeping themselves pure for Yahweh than the priests have.

According to the instructions Yahweh gave to Moses, the people who brought the sacrifices were the ones who had to skin the animals, not the priests. There were so many offerings this day that there was not enough space in the temple courtyard for all the people to skin the animals. This is probably the reason why the Levites helped the priests finish skinning the animals.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what do people usually do to purify themselves to worship God, gods, or the spirits? Pause this audio here.

There is a large number of burnt offerings, together with the fat of peace or fellowship offerings and the drink offerings that go with the burnt offerings. In the peace or fellowship offerings, the priests burned some of the offering on the altar, and the priests and the persons making the offering ate the rest of the offering. The purpose of peace or fellowship offerings was to establish or maintain good relations with Yahweh. The fat of the peace or fellowship offerings refers to the fatty animal parts of these offerings. Drink offerings are gifts of wine that priests pour onto the altar along with the other offerings. Wine is fermented grape juice.

So, the people begin to worship Yahweh again in the temple. Then Hezekiah rejoices along with all of Yahweh's people because Yahweh has helped them to renew worship in the temple very quickly.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 29:31–36 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has one scene.

In the scene: Hezekiah says to the people that they should bring sacrifices and thank offerings to Yahweh's temple. So the people do as Hezekiah says. The Levites help the priests skin the animals. Then, Hezekiah rejoices along with all of Yahweh's people.

The characters in this passage are:

- The priests
- The Levites
- King Hezekiah
- The city officials who are probably still there, although the storyteller does not mention them
- The people who gathered at Yahweh's temple
- And the musicians who are probably still there, although the storyteller does not mention them

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

Hezekiah says to the people that since they have now consecrated themselves to Yahweh, the people should come and bring sacrifices and thank offerings to Yahweh's temple. So the people there bring sacrifices and thank offerings, and all who are of a willing heart also bring burnt offerings. The sacrifices and thank offerings required that the priests burn only part of the meat. The people who made the offerings ate what the priests did not burn. But the burnt offerings indicated a special generosity since the priests burned all of the meat on the altar.

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Offerings that people made “with a willing heart” refer to sacrifices that people made because they wanted to, not because Yahweh required the people to. In other words, the storyteller is saying that the people who brought burnt offerings were generous.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Think back to your discussion about people who do more than expected. How will you translate the idea that some people gave from a willing heart? Pause this audio here.

The story action stops briefly while the storyteller shares the total number of animals the assembly, or group of people, gave as burnt offerings and sacrifices. The number of burnt offerings the people bring is 70 bulls, 100 rams, and 200 male lambs. The number of animals the people “consecrated,” or set apart as sacrifices, is 600 bulls and 3,000 sheep and goats.

You may remember that according to the instructions Yahweh gave to Moses, the people who brought the sacrifices were the ones who had to skin the animals, not the priests. There were so many offerings this day that there probably was not enough space in the temple courtyard for all the people to skin the animals. The storyteller continues and notes that there are not enough priests to skin all the animals for burnt offerings. So the Levites help the priests finish skinning the animals until other priests have consecrated themselves.

The Levites helped the priests because the Levites had done better at keeping themselves pure for Yahweh than the priests had. In the original language, the storyteller says that the Levites are more “upright in heart” than the priests. This is special language that people used to describe obedience. The Levites were more faithful and more diligent to keep themselves ritually pure than the priests were.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How do people in your culture describe someone who is faithful and diligent? How will you translate the idea that the Levites were more “upright in heart”? Pause this audio here

In addition to the large number of burnt offerings, there was the fat of the peace or fellowship offerings and the drink offerings that went along with the burnt offerings. The priests were very busy with the added work responsibilities of these offerings.

So, the people began to worship Yahweh again in the temple. Then Hezekiah and all the people rejoiced because God had helped them do all these things very quickly.

King Hezekiah rejoiced because Yahweh helped King Hezekiah, the priests, the Levites, and the Israelites to restart or renew worship in the temple in the first month of the first year that Hezekiah was king. That is why the storyteller said that all the things happened very quickly.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How do people in your culture express their joy when they are happy about something? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 29:31–36 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has one scene.

The characters in this passage are:

- The priests
- The Levites
- King Hezekiah
- The city officials who are probably still there, although the storyteller does not mention them
- The people who gathered at Yahweh’s temple
- And the musicians who are probably still there, although the storyteller does not mention them

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Hezekiah says to the people, "You have now consecrated yourselves to Yahweh. Come and bring sacrifices and thank offerings to the temple of Yahweh." So the people there bring sacrifices and thank offerings, and all who are of a willing heart also bring burnt offerings.

The number of burnt offerings the people bring is 70 bulls, 100 rams, and 200 male lambs. All these animals are for burnt offerings to Yahweh. The number of animals people set apart as sacrifices is 600 bulls and 3,000 sheep and goats.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing one of the people gathered at the temple, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am so happy to be able to worship Yahweh like this again. I am going to bring a special burnt offering to thank Yahweh; or
- This is so exciting. I have never seen so many people in the temple at one time; or
- There sure are a lot of animals. I hope we can get to my sacrifice today.

Continue the drama.

However, there are not enough priests to skin all of the animals for burnt offerings. So the Levites help the priests finish skinning the animals until other priests have consecrated themselves. This is because the Levites have done better at keeping themselves pure for Yahweh than the priests have.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing one of the Levites, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am very proud to be able to help the people sacrifice and worship Yahweh; or
- I am surprised because I have never seen this many animals in one place before; or
- I probably will not be able to smell or eat meat for about a month after this.

Continue the drama.

In addition to the large number of burnt offerings, there was the fat of the peace offerings and the drink offerings that went along with the burnt offerings.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing one of the priests, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- There sure is a lot of work to do. I am glad the Levites are helping us skin the burnt offerings; or
- I am so happy to be doing things properly again in the temple; or
- I wish the other priests had been more faithful in keeping themselves ritually clean. We could have used those priests' help today.

Continue the drama.

So, the people began to worship Yahweh again in the temple. Then, Hezekiah and the people rejoiced because God had helped them to do all these things very quickly.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Hezekiah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

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- I am very happy because I get to be the leader who restarts the worship at Yahweh's temple; or
- I am very thankful to Yahweh, who helped us to be able to worship at the temple again; or
- I am very hopeful that Yahweh will forgive our sins and our ancestors' sins.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing one of the worshippers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I cannot believe that we are worshiping Yahweh at the temple again; or
- I am happy and sad at the same time; or
- I am happy because I can worship Yahweh together with my fellow Israelites.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 29:31–36 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

King Hezekiah says to the people, "You have now **consecrated** yourselves to **Yahweh**. Come and bring **sacrifices** and **thank offerings** to the **temple**, the **house of Yahweh**." A thank offering is a type of freewill offering, or offering that people bring because they want to. Use the same words for king, consecrate, Yahweh, sacrifice, thank offering, and temple or "house of Yahweh" that you have used in previous passages. For more information, refer to king, consecrate, Yahweh, sacrifice, freewill offering, temple, and **house of God** in the Master Glossary.

The number of **burnt offerings** that the "**assembly**," or group of people, brings is 70 bulls, 100 rams, and 200 male lambs. Use the same words or phrases for assembly and for burnt offering as you used in previous passages. For more information on burnt offering, refer to the Master Glossary.

However, there are not enough **priests** to skin all of the animals for burnt offerings. So the **Levites** help the priests finish skinning the animals until other priests have consecrated themselves. Use the same words for priests and Levites that you have used in previous passages. Remember that these words are in the Master Glossary.

In addition to the large number of burnt offerings, there was the fat of the **peace or fellowship offerings** and the **drink offerings** that went along with the burnt offerings. A peace or fellowship offering is a sacrifice someone makes to have a better relationship with Yahweh. In the peace offerings, the priests burned some of the offering on the altar, and the priests and the persons who made the offering ate the rest of the offering. The fat of the peace offerings refers to the fatty animal parts of these fellowship offerings. Use the same word or phrase for "peace offering" that you have used in previous passages. For more information on peace offering, refer to "peace or fellowship offering" in the Master Glossary.

Drink offerings are gifts of wine that priests pour onto the altar along with the other offerings. Wine is fermented grape juice.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **drink offering**. Look up drink offering in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Hezekiah and the people rejoice because **God** has helped them restore the service of the temple. Use the same word for God as you have used previously. Refer to God in the Master Glossary for more information.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

2 Chronicles 29:31–36

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (853 KB)
- Setting the Stage (2.7 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (3.1 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.3 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.0 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

2 Chronicles 30:1–12

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 30:1–12 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 30:1–12 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 30:1–12 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous story, King Hezekiah, Hezekiah's officials, priests, Levites, and the people started the worship service again at Yahweh's temple. The events in this story happen some time later, but during King Hezekiah's reign. King Hezekiah and his officials invite other Israelites who live in the land of Israel, in the land of Judah, and other regions to come to Yahweh's temple to celebrate the Passover festival and to come back to Yahweh.

King Hezekiah sends a message to all the people in the land of Israel and in the land of Judah, even though King Hezekiah is king in the kingdom of Judah only. King Hezekiah also writes letters to the people in the territories

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of the tribes of Ephraim and Manasseh. In King Hezekiah's message, King Hezekiah invites all the Israelites to come to Yahweh's temple in Jerusalem and celebrate the Passover to honor Yahweh, the God of Israel.

You will remember that Passover is an important Jewish feast that begins the Festival, or Feast, of Unleavened Bread. During Passover, Jewish people celebrate the time Yahweh rescued the Israelites from Egypt during Moses' time. Yahweh commanded the Israelites through Moses to celebrate the Passover on the 14th day of the month of Nisan, the first month in the Hebrew calendar. If a person is ritually unclean at the time of Passover, that person could celebrate Passover in the second month.

During this year, the people could not celebrate the Passover in the first month because many priests were still ritually unclean and unable to serve in the temple. Also, the people of Judah had not gathered in Jerusalem for the festival. So, King Hezekiah, Hezekiah's officials, and the people gathered in Jerusalem decided to celebrate the Passover in the second month, as Yahweh allows in the Law of Moses. They decided to send a proclamation or announcement throughout all the land of Israel, from the city of Beersheba in the far south to the city of Dan in the far north.

Stop here and look at a map of Judah and Israel during Hezekiah's time. Locate the cities of Jerusalem, Beersheba, and Dan. Pause this audio here.

The people have not celebrated the Passover festival in great numbers, or according to the law that Yahweh gave to Moses. The last time the Israelites celebrated the Passover festival was probably during King Solomon's time. So, King Hezekiah sent messengers who carried letters from King Hezekiah and the princes or officials. These messengers went everywhere in the land of Judah and Israel.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what are the things a leader usually does when the leader wants to invite others to do something? How does the leader deliver messages to many people in many different places? Pause this audio here.

King Hezekiah's message urges the Israelites to return to Yahweh, the God of Abraham, Isaac, and "Israel," who we also know as Jacob. If the Israelites return to Yahweh, Yahweh might return to the few Israelites who are left, those who have escaped or survived the attacks by the kings of Assyria. King Hezekiah is speaking to the Israelites, whom the kings of Assyria did not kill or take as prisoners when the kings of the Assyrian Empire conquered the northern kingdom of Israel in 721 B.C. King Hezekiah himself is also one of the people the kings of Assyria did not kill.

When Hezekiah tells the people to "return to Yahweh," Hezekiah is telling the Israelites to repent, stop chasing after other gods, and return to worship Yahweh once again.

Hezekiah tells the Israelites that they should not be like their fathers and their brothers, who were unfaithful to Yahweh, the God of the Israelites' fathers. Because the Israelites' fathers and brothers were unfaithful to Yahweh, Yahweh made the Israelites an object of horror. King Hezekiah is saying that Yahweh brought such a terrible punishment on the Israelites that the people from surrounding nations were shocked when they saw how God punished the Israelites. The people of Israel had seen or had known very well about Yahweh's punishment.

Hezekiah tells the Israelites not to be "stiff-necked," as their fathers were. Hezekiah uses a common phrase to describe the Israelites' ancestors as stubborn and rebellious. Hezekiah tells the Israelites to obey Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about someone who was very stubborn and refused to do what he was supposed to do. Pay attention to the ways the storyteller describes this stubborn person. Pause this audio here.

Then, Hezekiah urges the Israelites to come to Yahweh's sanctuary, the temple which Yahweh has set apart for worship. Hezekiah tells the Israelites to serve or worship Yahweh, their God, so that Yahweh's fierce anger will turn away from the Israelites. Hezekiah tells the Israelites that if they come back to Yahweh, the Assyrian captors will show compassion to their Israelite brothers and their children and allow them to return to Israel because Yahweh is kind and merciful.

Hezekiah tells the Israelites that Yahweh will not abandon the Israelites if they return to Yahweh. If the Israelites come back to Yahweh, Yahweh will welcome and not reject the Israelites.

The messengers go from town to town in the territories of the tribes of Ephraim and Manasseh, and as far north as the region where the tribe of Zebulun lives. Many people who live there laugh at and mock the messengers. However, some people from the tribes of Asher, Manasseh, and Zebulun humble themselves and go to Jerusalem. You will remember that these tribes all separated from Judah and Benjamin when the kingdom of Israel divided.

Stop here and look at a map of the territory of the tribes of Ephraim, Manasseh, Zebulun, and Asher during King Hezekiah's time. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller says that the "hand" of Yahweh, or Yahweh's power, is on the people of Judah and gives the people one heart, unified for one purpose: to obey King Hezekiah and his officials and follow Yahweh's instructions.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 30:1–12 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: The assembly of Israelites in Jerusalem has not been able to celebrate the Passover festival at the regular time. So, King Hezekiah, King Hezekiah's officials, and the people who have gathered in Jerusalem decide to celebrate the Passover festival in the second month. King Hezekiah sends messengers with a message to other Israelites who are in the land of Israel and Judah, urging the Israelites to come back to Yahweh.

In the second scene: The messengers go to all the places King Hezekiah commands the messengers to go and give King Hezekiah's message to the people who live in those places. Many people laugh at and mock the messengers.

In the third scene: Some people humble themselves and go to Jerusalem. Yahweh leads the people in the land of the tribe of Judah to be unified for one purpose.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Hezekiah
- King Hezekiah's officials
- The assembly in Jerusalem
- King Hezekiah's messengers
- People who live in the former kingdom of Israel, including people who live in the territory of the tribe of Ephraim, Manasseh, Asher, and Zebulun
- And people who live in the kingdom of Judah

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

The passage begins by saying that King Hezekiah writes a message to send to all of Israel and Judah, including Ephraim and Manasseh. Hezekiah tells the people that the people should come to Jerusalem and celebrate the Passover on the 14th day of the second month. The storyteller then says why King Hezekiah has decided to wait until the second month instead of celebrating Passover in the first month. The Israelites have not been able to celebrate the Passover festival in great numbers at the regular time because not enough priests have consecrated or purified themselves, and the people have not assembled in Jerusalem. So, King Hezekiah, King Hezekiah's officials, and the people who have gathered in Jerusalem decide to celebrate the Passover festival in the second month. Everyone in Jerusalem agrees that the plan to celebrate the Passover festival in the second month seems like the right thing to do.

[If, in your language, you do not give information in this way, you may decide to reorder the passage and give the reason first. You would first tell how the people were not able to celebrate the Passover in the first month because the priests had not consecrated themselves, and not many people came to Jerusalem in time to celebrate. Then give King Hezekiah's decision to wait until the second month.]{.mark}

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Stop here and discuss how you will tell the order of the events in this passage so that the people in your culture will understand clearly. Pause this audio here.

So, King Hezekiah and all the people decide to send an announcement throughout the land of Israel. People will take the announcement from the city of Beersheba in the far south to the city of Dan in the far north, meaning the entire territory of the southern kingdom of Judah and the northern kingdom of Israel.

Stop here and look at the map of Judah and Israel during Hezekiah's time. Locate the cities of Jerusalem, Beersheba, and Dan, if needed. Discuss as a group: How will you translate this so that people will understand that Hezekiah was sending the message to the entire country? Pause this audio here.

In this announcement, Hezekiah calls all the Israelites to come to Yahweh's temple in Jerusalem and celebrate the Passover. You will remember that the Passover is one of the festivals that Jewish law requires the people to travel to Jerusalem to celebrate. Israelites have not celebrated the Passover festival in large numbers according to the Law of Moses. The last time all the Israelites celebrated the Passover festival was probably during King Solomon's time.

Then King Hezekiah commands messengers to take letters from the king and his officials to the people who live throughout the land of Israel and Judah. In the original language, the word for these messengers is similar to the word "to run" and shows that these messengers were to take the message quickly and possibly run to each location. You can also translate this word as "runners."

Stop and discuss: In your community, how do you send messages quickly to many places? How will you translate the idea of this kind of messenger in your translation? Pause this audio here.

In King Hezekiah's letter, Hezekiah urges the Israelites to return to Yahweh, the God of Abraham, Isaac, and Israel, so that Yahweh might return to the Israelites who are left, who have escaped from the "hand," or power, of the kings of Assyria. "The hand of the kings of Assyria" refers to the Assyrian conquest of the northern kingdom of Israel. Here, Hezekiah is speaking to everyone who has escaped or survived the Assyrian army's attacks.

Hezekiah tells the Israelites that they should not be like their fathers and their brothers who were unfaithful to Yahweh, the God of their fathers. Hezekiah is not speaking about the Israelites' actual fathers and brothers, but about the Israelites' ancestors. Hezekiah says that the Israelites' ancestors were unfaithful to Yahweh because they disobeyed and rebelled against Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your language, how would you say that someone is unfaithful to God, gods, or spirits? Pause this audio here.

Yahweh made the Israelites' fathers and brothers an object of horror, as the people of Israel have seen. Hezekiah is possibly referring to two things. First, Hezekiah is saying that Yahweh severely punished the disobedience of the Israelites' ancestors. Secondly, Yahweh's punishment was so severe that the people who saw it were very surprised. The people of Israel have seen how horrible their punishment is, and so have the other nations.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your language, how would you say that Yahweh made the ancestors and the relatives of the Israelites an object of horror? Pause this audio here.

Hezekiah tells the Israelites that they should not be "stiff-necked" or stubborn as their fathers were, but the people of Israel should submit to Yahweh. The term "stiff-necked" is special language. You will remember that in the story of the Exodus, Yahweh frequently described the Israelites as stiff-necked. The original meaning of the term "stiff-necked" probably comes from a farming expression. Farm animals wore yokes on their necks, and animals that stiffened their necks were stubbornly refusing to accept the yoke.

Stop here and remember your discussion from step two. How did you describe a very stubborn person, and how will you describe "stiff-necked" people in this passage? Pause this audio here.

Then, Hezekiah invites the people of Israel to come to Yahweh's sanctuary or temple, which Yahweh has consecrated, or made holy, forever. Hezekiah tells the people of Israel to serve and worship Yahweh, their God, so that Yahweh's fierce anger will turn away from the people. Hezekiah says that if the Israelites come back to Yahweh, the Israelites' captors, the Assyrians, will show compassion to their brothers and their children, and allow their brothers and children to return to the land of the Israelites.

Yahweh, the Israelites' God, is gracious and compassionate. Yahweh will not turn Yahweh's face from the Israelites if the Israelites return to Yahweh. Here, Hezekiah is using special language. In the Old Testament, people often used the image of Yahweh turning his face toward or away from a person to mean that Yahweh was either accepting or rejecting someone. Hezekiah said that if the Israelites return to Yahweh, Yahweh will accept the Israelites rather than reject them.

Stop here and discuss: How will you translate the idea that Yahweh will accept and not reject the people if they return to Yahweh? Pause this audio here.

In scene two, the messengers go from town to town in the territory of the tribe of Ephraim and in the territory of the tribe of Manasseh, as far as the region where the tribe of Zebulun lives. But people who live in those places laugh at and mock the messengers.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a map that includes all the places the messengers went. Pause this audio here.

In scene three, the storyteller says that even though some people mock the messengers, some people from the tribes of Asher, Manasseh, and Zebulun humble themselves and go to Jerusalem. The storyteller begins the next idea by showing that just as Yahweh was at work among the people of the tribes of Asher, Manasseh, and Zebulun in the north, so was Yahweh at work among the people of Judah in the south. The storyteller says that the hand of Yahweh is also on the people in the land of Judah. The "hand of Yahweh is on the people" is special language, meaning that Yahweh blesses or guides the people. Yahweh blesses the people with one heart, which shows that the people were unified in their purpose. The people were unified in their obedience to what King Hezekiah and his officials had ordered and followed the word, or message, of Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your language, how will you describe the idea that Yahweh blesses or guides the people to be unified in purpose? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 30:1–12 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Hezekiah
- King Hezekiah's officials
- The assembly in Jerusalem
- King Hezekiah's messengers
- People who live in the former kingdom of Israel, including people who live in the territory of the tribe of Ephraim, Manasseh, Asher, and Zebulun
- And people who live in the kingdom of Judah

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

2 Chronicles 30:1–12

The Israelites have not been able to celebrate the Passover festival in great numbers at the regular time, according to the Law of Moses, because not enough priests have consecrated themselves, and the people have not assembled in Jerusalem. So, Hezekiah and his officials and the whole assembly in Jerusalem decide to celebrate the Passover festival in the second month. The plan seems right to both King Hezekiah and the whole assembly.

So, King Hezekiah and all the people decide to send an announcement throughout the land of Israel. People will take the announcement to all the cities, from Beersheba in the far south to Dan in the far north. King Hezekiah, his officials, and the assembly invite all the Israelites to come to Yahweh's temple in Jerusalem and celebrate the Passover festival to Yahweh, the God of Israel.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Hezekiah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am looking forward to celebrate the Passover festival together will other Israelites for the first time during my rule to honor Yahweh; or
- I hope Yahweh will no longer be angry with us if many of us change our lifestyles and come to Jerusalem to celebrate the Passover festival to honor Yahweh at Yahweh's temple; or
- I hope spiritual revival will happen in every place where Israelites live.

Continue the drama.

Then, King Hezekiah and his officials write letters to all the people in the land of Israel and people in the land of Judah, including the people in the territory of the tribe of Ephraim and in the territory of the tribe of Manasseh. King Hezekiah commands messengers to take these letters to the people who live throughout the land of Israel and Judah.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Hezekiah's messengers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am very excited to give this invitation to other Israelites; or
- I am very happy because I will soon be able to celebrate the Passover festival with other Israelites; or
- I am a bit afraid because I do not know how other Israelites who are not under King Hezekiah's rule will respond to the invitation.

Continue the drama.

In King Hezekiah's message, Hezekiah says: "People of Israel, return to Yahweh, the God of Abraham, Isaac, and Israel, so that Yahweh might return to the Israelites who are left, those of us who have escaped from the hand of Assyria's kings. Do not be like your ancestors and relatives who were unfaithful to Yahweh, the God of their fathers. Yahweh made your fathers and brothers an object of horror, as you yourselves have seen. Do not be stubborn like your ancestors were, but submit yourselves to Yahweh. Come to Yahweh's temple, the special place Yahweh has forever made holy and set apart. Worship and serve Yahweh your God so that Yahweh's fierce anger will turn away from you.

"If you return to Yahweh, then the Assyrian captors will show compassion on your brothers and children. The captors will allow your brothers and children to return to this land. Yahweh your God is gracious and merciful. Yahweh will not continue to turn his face from you and reject you if you return to Yahweh."

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing one of the people from the territory of the tribe of Ephraim, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I wonder what secret plan King Hezekiah has because King Hezekiah is not even my king; or
- I have my own idols to worship at home. Why should I spend money to go to Jerusalem to worship Yahweh? or
- I am very happy because I will soon be able to celebrate the Passover festival at Yahweh's temple for the first time in many years.

Continue the drama.

The messengers go from town to town in the territories of the tribes of Ephraim and Manasseh, and as far as the region where the tribe of Zebulun lives. But most of the people who live in those places laugh at and mock the messengers. However, some people from the tribes of Asher, Manasseh, and Zebulun humble themselves and go to Jerusalem.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Hezekiah's messengers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am very sad because many of my fellow Israelites do not want to obey Yahweh; or
- I am very hurt because I was expecting to receive a warm welcome as I am urging people to obey Yahweh; or
- Even though many people reject the invitation I have brought with me, I am happy that there are some Israelites who want to obey Yahweh.

Ask the person playing one of the people from the tribe of Asher, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am very sad because many of my fellow Israelites do not want to obey Yahweh; or
- King Hezekiah reminds me to obey Yahweh and not be like my ancestors; or
- Even though many people reject King Hezekiah's invitation, I am happy about this message and look forward to celebrating the Passover again.

Continue the drama.

The storyteller says that Yahweh also blesses and guides the people of Judah. Yahweh gives the people one heart to obey what King Hezekiah and his officials have ordered, following the word of Yahweh.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing people who live in the kingdom of Judah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am thankful to Yahweh because I will soon be able to celebrate the Passover festival to honor Yahweh; or
- I am sad because many of my fellow Israelites do not want to celebrate the Passover festival as the Law of Moses requires; or
- I do not care what other Israelites do, but as for me, I will teach my family to worship and obey Yahweh by trying to be a good example.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 30:1–12 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

King Hezekiah sends a message to all the people in the land of **Israel** and in the land of **Judah**. King Hezekiah also writes letters to the people in the territories of the tribes of Ephraim and Manasseh. In King Hezekiah's message, Hezekiah invites the Israelites to come to the **temple** of **Yahweh** in **Jerusalem** and celebrate the Passover to honor Yahweh, the **God** of Israel. Use the same words or phrases for king, Israel, Judah, temple, Jerusalem, God, and Yahweh as you used in previous passages. For more information on king, Israel, temple, Jerusalem, God, and Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary.

Passover is an important Jewish feast that begins the Festival, or Feast, of Unleavened Bread. During Passover, Jewish people celebrate the time Yahweh rescued the Israelites from Egypt during Moses' time. Yahweh commanded the Israelites through Moses to celebrate the Passover on the 14th day of the month of Nisan, the first month in the Hebrew calendar. If a person is ritually unclean at the time of Passover, that person could celebrate Passover in the second month.

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Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **Passover**. Look up Passover in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

King Hezekiah and his high **officials**, or princes, and the whole **assembly** in Jerusalem decide to celebrate the Passover festival in the second month. The people have not been able to celebrate the Passover festival at the regular time because not enough **priests** have **consecrated** themselves, and the people have not assembled in Jerusalem. Priests were people who worked in Yahweh's temple in Jerusalem. When you consecrate someone, you set the person apart for special service to Yahweh. Use the same words or phrases for official, assembly, priest, and consecrate as you used in previous passages. For more information on priest and consecrate, refer to the Master Glossary.

King Hezekiah commands messengers or runners to take letters from Hezekiah and his officials to all the people living in Israel and Judah. In the original language, the word the storyteller used for these messengers is similar to the word "to run," which shows that these messengers were to take the message quickly and that they possibly ran to each location. You can also translate this word as "runners."

Stop here and discuss what word or phrase you will use for **messengers**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

In King Hezekiah's letter, Hezekiah tells the Israelites not to be like their **fathers** and **brothers** who were faithless and stiff-necked. When Hezekiah said "fathers and brothers," Hezekiah was referring to the Israelites' ancestors. Use the same words for fathers and brothers that you have used in previous passages for ancestors.

The Israelites' ancestors were "stiff-necked" or stubborn, just like a farm animal that refused to be placed in a yoke.

Stop here and discuss what word or phrase you will use for **stiff-necked**. If you have already translated this idea in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Hezekiah tells the Israelites to submit to or obey Yahweh, come to Yahweh's **sanctuary**, which Yahweh has made holy forever, and serve Yahweh, their God. A sanctuary is a holy place—a place that is set apart for the worship of Yahweh. In this context, the word sanctuary refers to the temple of Yahweh, especially the central part of the temple. Use the same word for sanctuary that you have used in previous passages. For more information on sanctuary, refer to the Master Glossary.

Hezekiah says that if the Israelites come back to Yahweh, their captors, the Assyrians, will show compassion to the Israelites' brothers and their children, and allow their brothers and children to return to the Israelites' land. When someone has compassion for someone, that person has a deep affection or love for someone.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **compassion**. Look up compassion in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Hezekiah tells the Israelites that Yahweh, their God, is gracious and merciful and will not turn away his face from the Israelites if the Israelites return to Yahweh. When someone is gracious to us or shows grace to us, that person does something good for us or gives us something good that we do not deserve.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **gracious** or **grace**. Look up grace in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

God is merciful. This means God is full of mercy; God wants to show mercy to people. The word mercy means goodness, kindness, or compassion. The meaning of mercy can be similar to the meaning of the word grace. Grace means that we receive something that we do not deserve. Grace and mercy go together. It is because of God's mercy that God does not punish us, and then it is because of God's grace that God also gives us good things.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **merciful** or **mercy**. Look up mercy in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

God's hand, or power, was on the people in Judah to give them one **heart** to follow the **word**, or message, of Yahweh**.** You will remember that in this culture, the people believed that the heart was the center of emotion and decision-making. The word of Yahweh is the message or instruction from Yahweh. Use the same words or phrases for heart and "word of Yahweh" as you have used previously, and refer to heart and word in the Master Glossary for more information.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

2 Chronicles 30:1–12

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (849 KB)
- Setting the Stage (4.1 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (6.4 MB)
- Embodying the Text (4.8 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (4.4 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

2 Chronicles 30:13–20

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 30:13–22 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 30:13–22 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.

2 Chronicles 30:13–20

4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 30:13–22 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous story, we learned that in the second month of the Jewish calendar, King Hezekiah sent invitations out from Jerusalem to the people living in the former kingdom of Israel and the kingdom of Judah to celebrate the Passover. The events in this story happen some time after King Hezekiah sent out those invitations. This story is about how the people celebrate the Passover and the Feast of Unleavened Bread in Jerusalem. The Israelites had not celebrated the Passover for many years, although the Law of Moses required the people to celebrate Passover every year.

The people respond to King Hezekiah's invitation. A very large crowd of people gathers in Jerusalem to celebrate the Festival of Unleavened Bread in the second month.

Stop here as a group and look at a map of Jerusalem. Pause this audio here.

The Feast of Unleavened Bread was an important Jewish festival. Jewish people celebrated the Feast of Unleavened Bread after the people celebrated Passover. Passover was a religious feast to celebrate when Yahweh rescued Israel from Egypt in Moses' time. You will remember that when the Israelites left Egypt, the Israelites carried bread dough that did not have yeast. We call the bread people make with this dough "unleavened bread." To remember these events, Moses told the Israelites to celebrate the Passover on the 14th day of the first month in the Hebrew calendar. Then, the people celebrated the Feast of Unleavened Bread from the 15th day to the 22nd day of the month. However, at this time, the Israelites gathered to celebrate the Festival of Unleavened Bread in the second month of the Hebrew calendar because the Israelites were not able to celebrate the festival in the first month.

The Israelites who gathered for the festival searched Jerusalem and removed every altar to foreign gods that the people found. Some altars were places where people made sacrifices, and others were places where people burned incense to these gods. The people destroyed all these altars and threw the pieces into the Kidron Valley. The Kidron Valley is to the east of Jerusalem between the Temple Mount and the Mount of Olives. The Kidron Valley is dry most of the year, but it has strong rushing water in the rainy season.

The people slaughter the Passover lambs on the 14th day of the second month. You will remember that Yahweh commanded the Israelites to remember the original Passover each year. Each family was to slaughter a Passover lamb, just as their ancestors had done during the first Passover.

Stop here and tell the story of the first Passover from Exodus. If you have already translated the book of Exodus into your language, listen to Exodus 12:1–30. Pause this audio here.

The priests and the Levites are ashamed and consecrate themselves and bring burnt offerings to Yahweh's temple. The priests and Levites are probably ashamed that the people had to delay the Passover celebration because the priests and Levites were slow to purify themselves. The priests and the Levites had delayed the Passover from the first month to the second month.

Yahweh gave instructions through Moses that the priests and Levites had to consecrate themselves, or make themselves pure, before they could do their duty for Yahweh. This means that the priests and the Levites did not have sexual relations with their wives for a certain amount of time, and then the priests and the Levites had to take a special bath and put on fresh clothes. The priests and the Levites were ashamed that they had neglected their duty to Yahweh. The priests and Levites now consecrated themselves so they could perform their duties for the Passover, something the priests and Levites should have done long before.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, how do people prepare themselves to be fit to worship God, gods, or the spirits? What is the process for religious leaders? What is the process for the normal worshipper? Pause this audio here.

2 Chronicles 30:13–20

Now that the priests and Levites have consecrated themselves to serve in the temple, the priests and Levites bring burnt offerings into the temple. The priests and Levites now take up their regular positions according to the Law of Moses, the man of God. You will remember that in the Law of Moses, Yahweh assigned the priests and the Levites to different duties and places in the tabernacle and temple. For the sacrifice of the Passover lamb, the Levites bring the blood to the priests. Then, the priests sprinkle the blood on the altar.

According to the Law of Moses, the heads of families were to kill the Passover lambs. Many of the ordinary people present for the Passover celebration had failed to go through the proper ritual cleansing that the Law of Moses required. So, the Levites have to kill the Passover lambs for all those who are not ceremonially clean and cannot consecrate, or make holy, their lambs to Yahweh.

Most of the people who have not purified themselves still eat the Passover, which is against the law. Many of these people come from the tribes of Ephraim, Manasseh, Issachar, and Zebulun.

Stop here as a group and look at a map of the land of the tribes of Ephraim, Manasseh, Issachar, and Zebulun during King Hezekiah's time. Pause this audio here.

King Hezekiah prays to Yahweh that Yahweh would forgive the people who sincerely desire to worship Yahweh, even though these people are not clean according to the sanctuary rules. Yahweh answers Hezekiah's prayer and heals the people. In other words, Yahweh forgives the people and does not punish the people.

The Israelites who are present in Jerusalem celebrate the Festival of Unleavened Bread for seven days with great rejoicing. The Levites and priests praise Yahweh every day, and they use musical instruments to help them worship.

Hezekiah encourages and thanks all the Levites for the way that they performed their service to Yahweh. For the seven days, the people celebrate and eat the proper food for the Festival of Unleavened Bread. The people offer fellowship or peace offerings and praise Yahweh, the God of their ancestors.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 30:13–22 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has five scenes.

In the first scene: A large crowd of people gathers in Jerusalem. Then, the people remove the altars for sacrifice and the incense altars.

In the second scene: The people slaughter the Passover lambs. The priests and the Levites consecrate themselves. The priests and the Levites take their positions in Yahweh's temple. The Levites kill the Passover lambs for the people who are not clean. People eat the Passover meal even though those people are not clean.

In the third scene: King Hezekiah prays for the people who sincerely desire to worship Yahweh. Yahweh forgives the people.

In the fourth scene: People in Jerusalem celebrate the festival for seven days while the Levites and priests praise Yahweh every day with musical instruments.

In the fifth scene: King Hezekiah encourages the Levites. The people eat the assigned food, offer fellowship offerings to Yahweh, and praise Yahweh.

The characters in this passage are:

- Israelites from the kingdom of Judah who have gathered in Jerusalem
- Israelites from the former northern kingdom of Israel who have gathered in Jerusalem
- The priests
- The Levites
- King Hezekiah

- And Yahweh

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In scene one, a very large crowd, or assembly, of people gathers in Jerusalem to celebrate the Festival of Unleavened Bread in the second month.

The people work hard together and remove the incense altars and other altars in Jerusalem and throw them into the Kidron Valley.

Stop here as a group and look at a map and a picture of the Kidron Valley. Pause this audio here.

In scene two, the people slaughter the Passover lambs on the 14th day of the second month. The priests and the Levites are ashamed and consecrate themselves, or make themselves holy and pure, and bring burnt offerings to Yahweh's temple.

Then, the priests and the Levites take up their regular positions according to the Law of Moses. The storyteller calls Moses "the man of God." The Levites bring the blood from the sacrificed animals to the priests. Then, the priests sprinkle or throw the blood. The storyteller does not say where the priests sprinkle the blood. In this context, the storyteller is most likely saying that the priests sprinkle or throw the blood on the altar.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your language, what word or phrase would you use for the word "sprinkle" or "throw"? If you have translated the book of Leviticus, use the same word for sprinkle or throw that you used in Leviticus 1:5. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller tells us why the Levites are giving the blood from the sacrifices to the priests. The Levites were not usually the people who did this. According to the Law of Moses, the heads of families were to kill the Passover lambs and give the blood to the priests. But since many of the people were not ritually clean, the Levites had to kill the lambs for the people.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your language, how will you make it clear that it is not the normal practice for the Levites to kill the Passover lambs? Pause this audio here.

Many of the people attending the Passover have not consecrated themselves, so these people are ceremonially unclean. When the storyteller calls the people unclean, the storyteller is not saying the people are dirty on the outside and in need of a bath. In the Bible, a clean person is a person who is fit for service to God and able to participate in the worship of God. A person who is unclean is unfit to serve God. An unclean person cannot bring a sacrifice, because that sacrifice would also be unclean.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Remind yourselves of how you have translated the ideas of people or objects being ceremonially clean and unclean in previous books of the Bible. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller uses a word to show that the opposite of what people expect to happen is happening. Most of the people who had not purified themselves or made themselves ritually clean still ate the Passover, which was against the law. According to the Law of Moses, people who have not purified themselves would not be able to participate in the Passover meal. Many of these people came from the tribes of Ephraim, Manasseh, Issachar, and Zebulun.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your language, what word or phrase would you use to show this kind of contrast, that even though people did not purify themselves, people ate the Passover meal? According to the law, we would expect these people not to participate in the Passover meal. Pause this audio here.

In scene three, because people who were not ritually clean ate the Passover, King Hezekiah prays to Yahweh for these people. King Hezekiah calls Yahweh good and the God of their ancestors. Hezekiah asks Yahweh to forgive everyone who sets that person's heart to seek Yahweh, the God of the Israelites' ancestors. Hezekiah says that these people have set their hearts to seek God, even though the people are not ritually clean according to the sanctuary or temple rules. Hezekiah is saying that the people have sincerely made up their minds and the people desire to worship Yahweh.

Stop here and do this activity as a group: Pretend you want to pray to Yahweh to forgive someone who disobeyed Yahweh. How would you say your prayer to show Yahweh that you care deeply about this person? Pause this audio here.

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Stop here and discuss how you will translate King Hezekiah's prayer into your language. Pause this audio here.

And Yahweh hears Hezekiah and heals the people. In other words, Yahweh forgives the people and does not punish the people. Yahweh had said in Leviticus 15:31 that no one should come into the sanctuary unclean, or those people might even become sick. However, you will also remember that Yahweh promised King Solomon earlier in 2 Chronicles that if Yahweh's people humble themselves, pray, and seek Yahweh, then Yahweh will hear the people, forgive the people, and heal the people.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your language, how will you say that "Yahweh forgave the people" or "Yahweh did not harm the people"? Pause this audio here.

In scene four, the Israelites who are present in Jerusalem celebrate the Festival of Unleavened Bread for seven days with great rejoicing. The Levites and priests praise Yahweh every day.

Some scholars believe that the Levites and the priests sang with all their strength to Yahweh. Some believe that the Levites and priests played on loud musical instruments. Others believe that the Levites and priests sang and played on loud musical instruments.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What version of this part of the passage have you heard before? Which version would people in your area be familiar with? Discuss how you want to translate this part. We recommend that you follow the accepted translation in your area. How will you describe how the Levites and priests praised Yahweh? Pause this audio here.

In scene five, King Hezekiah encourages and thanks all the Levites for their understanding of their service to Yahweh, or the way that the Levites performed their service to Yahweh. It is unclear exactly what Hezekiah is thanking the Levites for. It could be that the Levites did a good job when the Levites taught people about God, or that the Levites understand God and God's laws very well. It could be that Hezekiah appreciates how the Levites sang songs to God with skill and did a very good job leading worship at the temple.

The storyteller says that for the seven days, the people eat proper food for the Festival of Unleavened Bread and offer fellowship offerings and praise Yahweh, the God of their ancestors.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 30:13–22 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has five scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Israelites from the kingdom of Judah who have gathered in Jerusalem
- Israelites from the former northern kingdom of Israel who have gathered in Jerusalem
- The priests
- The Levites
- King Hezekiah
- And Yahweh

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

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The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

A very large crowd of people gathers in Jerusalem to celebrate the Festival of Unleavened Bread in the second month. The people work together and remove the altars and incense altars to pagan gods in Jerusalem. The people throw these altars into the Kidron Valley.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing one of the people who removed the altars for other gods, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am very happy to get rid of these altars for other gods from our land; or
- I do not need to be afraid of King Ahaz, who built these altars; or
- I can feel my fellow Israelites' strong desire to obey Yahweh when I see that the people are getting rid of altars for other gods.

Continue the drama.

The people slaughter the Passover lambs on the 14th day of the second month. The priests and the Levites are ashamed and consecrate themselves and bring burnt offerings to Yahweh's temple.

Then, the priests and the Levites take up their regular positions in the temple according to the Law of Moses, the man of God. The Levites bring the sacrificial blood to the priests. Then, the priests sprinkle the blood on the altar.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing one of the priests, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am very proud to do this for the people; or
- I am thankful to Yahweh for forgiving our sins; or
- This blood reminds me of the blood of lambs during the first Passover, when Yahweh rescued our ancestors from slavery in Egypt.

Ask the person playing one of the Levites, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am very proud that Yahweh asked us to help the priests; or
- I am very tired now; or
- I am very happy to be able to celebrate the Passover festival again.

Continue the drama.

Many people in the crowd have not consecrated themselves. So, the Levites have to kill the Passover lambs for all those who are not clean and cannot consecrate their lambs to Yahweh.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing one of the people who did not consecrate themselves, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel very bad for not preparing myself for the festival; or
- I am very thankful for the Levites who are helping me to be able to celebrate the Festival of Unleavened Bread; or
- I am looking forward to worshiping Yahweh.

Continue the drama.

Most of the many people who have come from the land of the tribes of Ephraim, Manasseh, Issachar, and Zebulun have not purified themselves, yet these people eat the Passover meal. This is against the Law of Moses.

So King Hezekiah prays to Yahweh for these people. Hezekiah says, "Yahweh, you are good, so I beg you to forgive everyone who sincerely wants to obey and worship you, the God of the people's ancestors. Forgive the people,

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even though these people are not ritually clean according to the rules of the temple." And Yahweh hears King Hezekiah and heals the people.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Hezekiah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am afraid that Yahweh might punish many Israelites who did not consecrate themselves but are now eating the Passover meal; or
- I sincerely do not want Yahweh to punish anyone with death during this festival; or
- I am very thankful to Yahweh because Yahweh listened to my prayer.

Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am very pleased with King Hezekiah's attitude and actions; or
- I am very happy for the Israelites because the Israelites are worshipping me again; or
- I like King Hezekiah's prayer.

Continue the drama.

The Israelites who are present in Jerusalem celebrate the Festival of Unleavened Bread for seven days with great rejoicing. The Levites and priests sing praise to Yahweh every day with loud instruments.

Hezekiah encourages all the Levites, thanking the Levites for their skill and their service to Yahweh. For the seven days, the people eat their assigned portion of the food for the Festival of Unleavened Bread, offer fellowship offerings, and praise Yahweh, the God of the people's ancestors.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 30:13–22 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

A very large crowd of people **assembled** in Jerusalem to celebrate the Festival of Unleavened Bread in the second month. Use the same word or phrase for assembly as you have used in previous passages.

The **Festival of Unleavened Bread** is an important Jewish festival that begins with the Passover Festival, or Feast. This feast reminded the people how Yahweh delivered their ancestors from slavery in Egypt. Use the same word or phrase for Festival of Unleavened Bread as you used in previous passages. For more information on "Festival of Unleavened Bread," refer to the Master Glossary.

The people work together and remove the **altars** in Jerusalem and clear away the **incense** altars. The people throw the altars into the Kidron Valley. An altar is a place where people make offerings or sacrifices to God. An altar is like a table or a platform that people make of earth or large stones. People placed gifts for God on this table. Often, this meant that people then burned the gift. The gift could be an animal, food items, or incense of sweet-smelling spices. Use the same words or phrases for altar and incense as you used in previous passages. For more information on altar, refer to the Master Glossary.

The people **slaughter** the Passover lambs on the 14th day of the second month. The **priests** and the **Levites** are ashamed and **consecrate** themselves and bring **burnt offerings** to the **temple** of **Yahweh**. Use the same words or phrases for slaughter an animal, priests, Levites, consecrate, burnt offerings, temple, and Yahweh that you have used previously. For more information about priests, Levites, consecrate, burnt offerings, the temple, and Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary.

Then, the priests and the Levites take up their regular positions in the temple, according to the **Law** of Moses, the man of **God**. The law is the set of instructions that God gave to the people of Israel. Use the same word or phrase for law and God as you used in previous passages. For more information on law and God, refer to the Master Glossary.

2 Chronicles 30:13–20

Many people in the crowd have not consecrated themselves. So, the Levites have to kill the Passover lambs for all those people who are not ceremonially clean and cannot consecrate their lambs to Yahweh. When the storyteller calls the people unclean, the storyteller is not saying the people are dirty on the outside and in need of a bath. In the Bible, a clean person is a person who is fit for service to God and able to participate in the worship of God. A person who is unclean is unfit to serve God. An unclean person cannot bring a sacrifice, because that sacrifice would also be unclean.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **clean**. Look up **clean and unclean** in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Although most of the many people who have come from the land of the tribes of Ephraim, Manasseh, Issachar, and Zebulun have not purified themselves, yet these people eat the Passover meal. This is not according to the **sanctuary**'s rules of cleanness. A sanctuary is a holy place—a place that is set apart for the worship of God. In this context, the sanctuary is the temple. Use the same word or phrase for sanctuary as you used in previous passages. For more information on sanctuary, refer to the Master Glossary.

So, Hezekiah **prays** for the people who have not purified themselves that Yahweh would **forgive** everyone who sets his **heart** to seek Yahweh. And Yahweh hears Hezekiah and **heals** the people. Use the same words for pray, forgive, heart, and heal that you have used in previous passages. For more information about pray, forgiveness, heart, and heal, refer to the Master Glossary

The Israelites who are present in Jerusalem celebrate the Festival of Unleavened Bread for seven days with great rejoicing. The Levites and priests **praise** Yahweh every day. Use the same word for praise that you have used previously. For more information, refer to the Master Glossary.

For the seven days, the people eat their assigned portion of the food for the Festival of Unleavened Bread, and offer **peace or fellowship offerings** to Yahweh, the God of their ancestors. Use the same word or phrase for peace or fellowship offerings as you used in previous passages. For more information, refer to "peace or fellowship offering" in the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

2 Chronicles 30:13–20

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (845 KB)
- Setting the Stage (4.2 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (5.6 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.7 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (3.2 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

2 Chronicles 30:21–27

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 30:23–27 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 30:23–27 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 30:23–27 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous story, we learned about the celebration of the Passover festival and the Feast of Unleavened Bread in Jerusalem. This story is about how the assembly in Jerusalem celebrated for another seven days and how Yahweh heard his people.

After the people celebrated the Passover festival for one day and the Feast of Unleavened Bread for seven days, the whole assembly of Israelites decided to celebrate for seven more days. So the people continued the festival with great joy for another week. This was a big decision because the people had probably only prepared for a seven-day celebration, but now the people were staying for an extra week.

Hezekiah, king of Judah, gives the people 1,000 bulls and 7,000 sheep and goats for the offerings. The officials provide the whole assembly with 1,000 bulls and 10,000 sheep and goats.

Stop here as a group and look at pictures of bulls, sheep, and goats if needed. Pause this audio here.

Many more priests consecrate themselves. The people were able to celebrate the Festival of Unleavened Bread for seven more days because King Hezekiah and his officials were very generous. These leaders gave the animals that people needed for the extra sacrifices. More priests were also ready to serve because many had set themselves apart and become ceremonially clean.

All the people of Judah were filled with joy. The priests, the Levites, and everyone who had come from the northern kingdom of Israel celebrated with the people. The assembly also included foreigners, or non-Israelites, who lived in Israel and had come from Israel for the festival, as well as resident foreigners who lived in Judah. You may remember that Yahweh told Moses that if a foreigner was living among the Israelites and wanted to celebrate Passover to honor Yahweh, people had to circumcise all of the males in that household. After that, the

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Israelites were to treat the foreigner like someone born in Israel, and Yahweh allowed the foreigner to join the festival.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what do people think about foreigners or strangers? How do people behave toward foreigners? How do people treat a foreigner who worships God, gods, or spirits that your people worship? Pause this audio here.

People in Jerusalem were very happy. The people had not celebrated like this since the time of

King Solomon, son of David. King Solomon lived more than 250 years before King Hezekiah.

The priests and Levites stood before the people and blessed the people. You will remember that Yahweh gave Moses a blessing that the priests were to pray for the people. Just as Yahweh promised, God hears the prayers of blessing from the holy place where God lives in heaven.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what are the things a person usually does or says to bless others? If you have already translated the book of Numbers, listen to a recording of Numbers 6:22–27 in your language.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 30:23–27 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has two scenes.

In the first scene: The whole assembly agrees to celebrate the festival for seven more days. King Hezekiah and King Hezekiah's officials provide animals for the additional days of celebration.

In the second scene: Many more priests consecrate themselves. The Israelites and non-Israelites in Jerusalem are very happy. The priests and Levites bless the people, and Yahweh hears their prayers.

The characters in this passage are:

- Israelites from the kingdom of Judah who have gathered in Jerusalem
- Israelites from the northern kingdom of Israel who have gathered in Jerusalem
- The priests
- The Levites
- King Hezekiah
- Yahweh
- King Hezekiah's officials
- Non-Israelites who live in the kingdom of Judah
- And non-Israelites who live in the northern kingdom of Israel

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first scene, the whole assembly, or gathering of Israelites, decided to celebrate for seven more days. So the people continued the festival with great joy for another week. King Hezekiah gave the people 1,000 bulls and 7,000 sheep and goats, and the officials gave 1,000 bulls and 10,000 sheep and goats. The storyteller does not say directly that the people offered these animals as sacrifices, but that is probably what the people did.

The people had likely only prepared for a seven-day celebration, but now the people were staying an extra week. The people needed animals for sacrifices during those extra days. You may remember that the people ate part of the peace or fellowship offerings, so these gifts from the king and the officials also provided food for everyone in the assembly.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How will you translate the gifts of the king and the officials so that people will understand that the people used the gifts as offerings? Pause this audio here.

In scene two, many more priests consecrate themselves. There are now more priests ready to serve because these priests had set themselves apart and become ceremonially clean.

All the people of Judah were filled with joy. The priests, the Levites, and everyone who had come from the northern kingdom of Israel celebrated with the people. The assembly also included foreigners, or non-Israelites, who lived in Israel and had come from Israel for the festival, as well as foreigners who lived in Judah.

A person is a foreigner in a country when that person is in a country that is not where that person was born. These kinds of foreigners are people who are foreigners in a country and temporarily live in that country, even though that country is not where the person was born. It is important to remember that these foreigners have chosen to follow the Law of Moses and worship Yahweh. If these foreigners did not follow the Law of Moses, the Israelites would not allow the foreigners to celebrate the festival with the Israelites.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your language, what word or phrase will you use for the foreigners, or non-Israelites? Pause this audio here.

There is great joy in Jerusalem. Since the days of Solomon, son of David, king of Israel, an event like this has not happened in Jerusalem.

The priests and Levites, or Levitical priests, rise to bless the people. In the original language, it is a little unclear who is doing the blessing. Some earlier versions seem to refer to “Levitical priests,” since the priests were descendants of Levi. Others believe that both the priests and the Levites who are not priests bless the people. However, according to the Law of Moses, priests were usually the ones who blessed the people.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: What version of this part of the passage have you heard before? Which version would people in your area be familiar with? Discuss if you will translate this section as “priests and Levites” or “Levitical priests.” We recommend that you follow the accepted translation in your area. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller says that the priests and Levites “arose.” This does not mean the priests and Levites were sitting or lying down before they blessed the people. Instead, the storyteller may be saying that the priests stood in front of the people when they gave the blessing.

In the original language, people sometimes use the word “rise” together with another action word to emphasize that action. Here, the storyteller is emphasizing that the priests did the action of blessing the people.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your language, how will you emphasize the priests’ action when you tell the story? Pause this audio here.

God hears the priests because the priests’ prayers of blessing reached heaven, which is the holy place where God lives.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 30:23–27 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has two scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Israelites from the kingdom of Judah who have gathered in Jerusalem
- Israelites from the northern kingdom of Israel who have gathered in Jerusalem
- The priests
- The Levites
- King Hezekiah
- Yahweh
- King Hezekiah’s officials

- Non-Israelites who live in the kingdom of Judah
- And non-Israelites who live in the northern kingdom of Israel

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

The whole assembly agrees to celebrate seven more days. So the people continued the festival with great joy for another week.

Hezekiah, king of Judah, provides 1,000 bulls and 7,000 sheep and goats to the assembly for their offerings. The officials give the assembly 1,000 bulls and 10,000 sheep and goats.

Many more priests consecrate themselves for service to Yahweh.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing one of King Hezekiah's officials, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am very happy because I get to contribute what I have for the Festival of Unleavened Bread to honor Yahweh; or
- I am very happy to be able to support many Israelites who sincerely want to obey Yahweh; or
- I just lost a lot of wealth, but I believe that Yahweh can bless me.

Continue the drama.

All the people of Judah were filled with joy. The priests, the Levites, and everyone who had come from the northern kingdom of Israel celebrated with the people. The assembly also included foreigners who had come from Israel for the festival, as well as foreigners who lived in Judah.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing one of the non-Israelites who are celebrating the Festival of Unleavened Bread, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel great joy as I worship Yahweh with the Israelites; or
- I am very thankful for all the priests who bless us; or
- I am very surprised to see a lot of people who still want to worship Yahweh.

Continue the drama.

People in Jerusalem were very happy. The people had not celebrated like this since the time of

King Solomon, son of David. The Levitical priests rise to bless the people. God hears the priests because the priests' prayers of blessing reach heaven, the holy place where God lives.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am listening to the prayers of the Levitical priests because they are doing things to please me; or
- I like the way the people worship together; or
- I cannot ignore the prayers of the people who are doing what is right. The people are doing what I have commanded them to do.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 30:23–27 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

The whole assembly agrees to celebrate seven more days. So Hezekiah, **king** of **Judah**, provides 1,000 bulls and 7,000 sheep and goats for the assembly for their **offerings**. Use the same words for king and Judah that you have used previously. If you decide to use the word offering in your translation, use the same word for offering or fellowship offering that you have used previously. For more information, refer to king, Judah, offering, and **peace or fellowship offering** in the Master Glossary.

The **officials** give the assembly 1,000 bulls and 10,000 sheep and goats. A great number of **priests consecrate** themselves, or purify themselves so they can help in worship to Yahweh. Use the same words for officials, priests, and consecrate that you have used previously. For more information on priest and consecrate, refer to the Master Glossary.

Use the same words for bulls, sheep, and goats as you have used in previous passages.

All the people of Judah were filled with joy. The priests, the **Levites**, and everyone who had come from the northern kingdom of **Israel** celebrated with the people. The assembly also included **foreigners** who had come from Israel for the festival, as well as foreigners living in Judah. A person is a foreigner in a country when that person is in a country that is not where that person was born. The foreigners in this story are people who are foreigners in a country and temporarily live there, even though that country is not where the person was born. Use the same words or phrases for Levites, Israel, and these kinds of foreigners as you used in previous passages. For more information on Levites, Israel, and foreigners, refer to the Master Glossary.

The people in **Jerusalem** are very happy because the people have not celebrated like this since the days of Solomon, son of King **David**. Use the same words for Jerusalem and David as you have used previously. Refer to the Master Glossary for more information about Jerusalem and David.

The Levitical priests rise to **bless** the people. When a person speaks a blessing over another person, they are praying that Yahweh will do good things for this other person. Use the same word or phrase for bless as you used in previous passages. For more information on bless, refer to the Master Glossary.

God hears the priests because their **prayer** of blessing reaches **heaven**, the holy place where God lives. When a person prays, that person is communicating with Yahweh. In this context, heaven refers to the place where God lives with his angels. Use the same words or phrases for God, prayer, and heaven as you used in previous passages. For more information, refer to God, pray, and heaven in the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

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Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (847 KB)
- Setting the Stage (2.2 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (3.4 MB)
- Embodying the Text (2.6 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.1 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

2 Chronicles 31:1–10

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 31:1–10 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 31:1–10 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 31:1–10 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passage, many Israelites traveled to Jerusalem and celebrated the Passover festival. In this passage, the Israelites leave Jerusalem and remove all the idols from the land, and then the people go home. King Hezekiah organizes the priests and Levites for the work in the house of Yahweh. Then Hezekiah tells the people to donate items to the house of Yahweh.

The Israelites celebrated the Passover festival for the first time in a long time. After the celebration was over, it seems that many of the Israelites felt a greater desire to obey Yahweh. These Israelites showed their dedication to Yahweh by removing all the sacred pillars, Asherah poles, high places, and altars in their land. The people had used all these things to worship false gods.

Stop here and discuss these questions: How common is idol worship in your culture? How do people represent the false gods they worship? What might happen if a group of people came and destroyed these idols? Pause this audio here.

The sacred pillars in Israel were large stones that people had placed in certain areas. People usually did not carve or shape the stones very much.

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Stop here and look at a picture of a sacred stone in Israel. Does the stone look like anything that exists in your culture? Pause this audio here.

The Israelites removed the idols, high places, and altars throughout the territory of Judah, Benjamin, Ephraim, and Manasseh.

Stop here and look at a map that shows the territory of Judah, Benjamin, Ephraim, and Manasseh. Pause this audio here.

The people of each Israelite tribe lived in their assigned territory. Within that territory, there were further divisions by clans and families. Most Israelites inherited the territory that belonged to their family.

Stop here and discuss these questions: In your culture, how do people decide where they will live? How do people decide who owns the land? Can a piece of land belong to just one person, or can the land belong to a family, a clan, or an entire tribe? How easy or difficult is it to move to a different place? Pause this audio here.

Next, Hezekiah told different groups of priests and Levites what jobs to do in the house of Yahweh. Many years before, King Solomon organized the priests and the Levites according to King David's instructions. Hezekiah most likely reestablished David's organization system for the priests and Levites.

The priests and Levites needed many things to do the work in the house of Yahweh. The priests and Levites needed animals to sacrifice, flour and oil to make bread, wine, incense, wood, materials for the priests' clothing, and food for the priests and Levites to eat. King Hezekiah contributed a portion of the animals that people needed to make the burnt offerings and peace or fellowship offerings.

Stop here and discuss these questions: Describe a time or an event when the leaders or rich people in your people group give things for the entire community to use. Why do these people do this? Is this a requirement, or do the people do it because they want to? Pause this audio here.

When the storyteller lists the sacrifices the priests make in the house of Yahweh, the storyteller starts with the offerings that the priests make every day, then the offerings that the priests make once a week on the Sabbath. Next, the storyteller mentions the offerings that the priests make once per month on the night of the new moon. Finally, the storyteller mentions the appointed festivals, or yearly festivals that Yahweh appointed, or chose, for the Israelites to celebrate. One group of festivals happens in the first part of the Israelites' year, while another group of festivals happens in the last part of the Israelites' year.

Stop here and discuss these questions: In your people group, when do people make sacrifices and offerings? What kinds of things do people use for sacrifices and offerings? What are the reasons why your people do this? How similar or different are these reasons from the reasons that the Israelites made sacrifices and offerings in Yahweh's temple? Pause this audio here.

The festivals that people celebrated toward the beginning of each year were Passover, the Festival of Unleavened Bread, the Festival of Firstfruits, and the Festival of Weeks.

In Israel, the people began to harvest their crops at the end of the rainy season. This time corresponds to May or early June in the modern calendar. During this time, the Israelites harvested grains like wheat and barley. The Israelites continued to harvest their crops until about four months into the dry season. This time corresponds to September or October in the modern calendar. At this time, the Israelites harvested fruits like grapes, figs, and olives.

Stop here and discuss these questions: In your area, what time of year do you harvest your crops? Do you harvest different crops at different times of the year? What holidays or festivals happen right before, during, or just after the harvest season? Pause this audio here.

After the harvest was finished, the Israelites celebrated the later festivals. These are the Festival of Trumpets, the Day of Atonement, and the Festival of Booths.

King Hezekiah also told the people who lived in Jerusalem to give goods to the priests and Levites. When each group of priests and Levites was on duty in the temple, they spent all their time doing the work of the temple. The priests and Levites did not have time to prepare food or do other kinds of work. So the people of Jerusalem gave the priests food to eat.

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Stop here and discuss these questions: In your culture, under what circumstances might your people come together and give food or other goods to workers, religious leaders, or someone else who needed it? How do the people feel about this? What roles or jobs always depend on donations to provide for those people's daily living? Pause this audio here.

Azariah, the high priest, is from the house of Zadok. This means that Azariah is a descendant of a priest named Zadok. Some Bible scholars think the storyteller means the Zadok who was the high priest during Solomon's reign, while other Bible scholars think that Azariah's grandfather's name was Zadok.

King Hezekiah and his officials were amazed at how many items the people of Israel gave to the priests and Levites. It was more than Hezekiah and the officials expected, and it made the men very happy. The people brought grain, new wine, oil, honey, and animals for the sacrifices, but the people also brought sacred, or holy, gifts to give to the priests. Nobody knows exactly what the sacred gifts were. It might mean anything that people did not use to make a sacrifice to Yahweh. All of these sacred gifts were in addition to the items that Yahweh required the Israelites to give to the priests and Levites. The people put all the gifts in "heaps," or large piles.

Stop here and discuss these questions: When do you expect the community to give something, whether it is money, food, or other items? Who benefits from the things that the people give? How often does the amount fall short of what the people need? How often do you have enough? How often do you have more than you need? When you have more than you need, how do the people in your community feel?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 31:1–10 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four scenes.

In the first scene: The Israelites remove all the idols and pagan altars from their land, then go home.

In the second scene: Hezekiah assigns the tasks of temple work to different groups of priests and Levites.

In the third scene: The Israelites bring goods to supply the house of Yahweh, the priests, and the Levites.

In the fourth scene: Hezekiah and his officials are very happy when they see that the people have given a great deal of goods to the priests and Levites.

The characters in this passage are:

- All the Israelites who came to the Passover festival
- King Hezekiah
- The divisions of priests
- The divisions of Levites
- The people who live in Jerusalem
- Hezekiah's officials
- And Azariah the high priest

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first scene, the Passover festival had just finished. All the people who traveled to Jerusalem left the city and went to other places in the territories of Judah, Benjamin, Ephraim, and Manasseh. Then the people destroyed all the things that the people had previously used to worship idols. The people tore down the sacred pillars and the wooden Asherah poles. These were objects that people made to represent the false gods the people worshipped. You already chose words for these objects in an earlier story.

If necessary, stop here and listen to the story at the beginning of 2 Chronicles chapter 14. In this story, King Asa smashed the sacred pillars and Asherah poles. Pay attention to the words you used for "sacred stones" and "Asherah poles." Pause this audio here.

The pillars and poles were probably tall and straight. For this reason, the storyteller says that the people had to pull them down. People made Asherah poles from wood, and we are not sure what the poles looked like. But people have found many sacred stones in Israel. Bible scholars think that some of these stones come from the time of Hezekiah.

Stop here and look at a picture of the sacred pillars that the Israelites might have used in their worship at this time. Pause this audio here.

The people of Israel also destroyed the high places and the altars that the people had used to worship idols. In this scene, the storyteller describes how the Israelites completely destroyed all the things that people used to worship idols.

Stop here and look at a picture of an altar. Also, look at a picture of what a high place in ancient Israel might have looked like. In the picture of the high place, look for any objects that you recognize. Pause this audio here.

After the people finished tearing down all the idols, each person went to his own possession. This means that each person went back to the land that belonged to his family. Remember that each tribe of Israelites lived in a certain area, and that area was further divided into territory for different clans and families. The easiest way to express this is to simply say that each person went home.

In the second scene, King Hezekiah assigns duties to the divisions of the priests and Levites. There were many jobs that people needed to do in the house of Yahweh. Hezekiah probably followed the same plan that King David gave Solomon for the organization of the priests and Levites. The priests and the Levites did different jobs in the house of Yahweh as part of their service to Yahweh. “Service” describes a person’s duty or area of responsibility.

Stop and discuss the words you have used in previous stories for “service” or “duty.” Decide which word you will use here. Pause this audio here.

The priests made burnt offerings every morning and evening. In contrast, the priests only made peace offerings during major celebrations and big festivals like Passover. The priests and the Levites had a special responsibility to minister in the house of Yahweh, in order to please Yahweh and for the benefit of the people of Israel. To minister means to serve or to help others. In previous stories, you already chose a word for “minister.”

If necessary, stop here and listen to the beginning of 1 Chronicles chapter 15 to remember the word you chose for “minister.” Pause this audio here.

“The camp of the Lord,” or “the camp of Yahweh,” technically refers to the tabernacle, or the Tent of Meeting, which was the large tent that the Israelites carried with them before Solomon built the house of Yahweh. Although the house of Yahweh was not the same thing as the Tent of Meeting, sometimes the storyteller uses the term “the camp of the Lord” or “the camp of Yahweh” when the storyteller is talking about the house of Yahweh. A camp is a temporary place to live. This term emphasizes that the place on earth where the Israelites minister to Yahweh is a temporary place for Yahweh. To make the meaning of this phrase clear, but to also keep the unusual way of saying it, we recommend that you say something that means “the house of Yahweh, the place where Yahweh camps on earth.”

Stop here and discuss what words you will use to make it clear that this phrase refers to the house of Yahweh, but also means that Yahweh lives in a temporary place on earth. Pause this audio here.

In the third scene, the storyteller describes how the king and the people provided goods so that the priests and Levites could do their work in the house of Yahweh. King Hezekiah contributed some of his own animals for the sacrifices at the temple. The priests made sacrifices in the morning and evening every day, then added extra sacrifices on the Sabbath and at the New Moon Festival. “New moon” refers to the night when the moon is completely dark in the night sky.

In the Bible, a festival is a day that people set aside for special spiritual or religious purposes. In ancient Israel, the people usually celebrated a festival to remember something that Yahweh did for them, such as the Passover. Or a festival might be a time when the Israelites were required to do a special religious activity, such as on the Day of Atonement. In a previous story in Chronicles, you chose a word for “festival.”

If necessary, stop here and listen again to the last part of 1 Chronicles 23. In the story in 1 Chronicles 23, the storyteller mentions the Levites' duties. Pay attention to the end of the story, when the storyteller mentions the yearly festivals. Pause this audio here.

King Hezekiah told the people who live in Jerusalem to provide the portion due to the priests and Levites. The Israelites gave the firstfruits of their grain, new wine, olive oil, honey, and the produce from their fields. "Firstfruits" means the first part of a harvest. The Israelites often thought that the first items that people harvested were the best part of the harvest. So this word implies that the people should give the best part of their harvest to Yahweh. If you have already translated the book of Exodus, then you have already chosen a word for "firstfruits."

Stop here and listen to the middle portion of Exodus chapter 23, if it is available in your language. Pay close attention to the word you used for firstfruits. If you have not translated Exodus yet, start discussing which word or phrase you could use for firstfruits. Pause this audio here.

Grain is a general term for the small part of plants like wheat, oats, rice, barley, and sorghum that you can eat. This term could also include beans and peas.

Stop here and discuss what word you could use here for "grain." Pause this audio here.

"New wine" refers to any wine that people freshly produce after the grape harvest. This word shows that as soon as the Israelites produced wine, the Israelites were supposed to give a portion of the wine to Yahweh. Most of the oil that the Israelites used was olive oil. While the Israelites did eat honey, which comes from bees, the word in this scene probably means a sweet syrup that people made from dates or other fruits.

Stop here and decide how you will describe the sweet syrup that the Israelites gave for the work in the house of Yahweh. If honey is common in your culture, you may use your word for honey. If honey is not common in your culture, decide what word you will use. Pause this audio here.

Next, the storyteller says that the people of Israel and Judah who lived in the cities of Judah brought a tithe of cattle, sheep, and sacred gifts. The storyteller makes it clear that these people did not live in Jerusalem, which was in the territory of Benjamin. These people lived in Judah, which was south of the territory of Benjamin. The word "tithe" means one-tenth, or one part out of ten. This means that if an Israelite had ten sheep, the Israelite was supposed to give one sheep as an offering to Yahweh. If an Israelite had ten kilograms of grain, the Israelite was supposed to give one kilogram of grain as an offering to Yahweh. If you have already translated the book of Numbers or the book of Deuteronomy, you have already chosen a word for tithe.

Stop here and listen to Numbers chapter 18 or Deuteronomy chapter 12, if they are available in your language, to remember the word you chose for tithe. If you have not translated either of these books yet, start to discuss what word you could use for tithe. Pause this audio here.

In this scene, "cattle" is a general term for larger livestock, such as bulls, cows, buffalo, and oxen. "Sheep" is a general term for small livestock animals, such as sheep and goats. If your language has general terms for large livestock and small livestock, you may use those here. Otherwise, it is also acceptable to use your words for cows and sheep.

Stop here and decide how you will describe the animals that the Israelites brought to the house of Yahweh. Pause this audio here.

The Israelites also brought sacred, or holy, gifts for the priests and Levites to the house of Yahweh. No one knows exactly what these gifts were. It is possible that the sacred gifts might have included the ingredients for the incense that the priests burned in the house of Yahweh, or material and precious stones to make the clothes that the priests wore. The word "sacred" simply means that the people gave these gifts for the purpose of doing the work in the house of Yahweh. "Consecrated" has the same meaning.

Stop here and decide what words you will use to say "sacred gifts." Pause this audio here.

Finally, the storyteller lets us know that the Israelites began to bring all these gifts for the priests and Levites in the third month and finished bringing things in the seventh month. This timeframe starts at the beginning of the harvest and finishes at the end of the harvest season.

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In the fourth scene, King Hezekiah and some leaders come to see the piles of goods that the people have given to the priests and Levites. These leaders were probably government officials. Then King Hezekiah and his officials bless Yahweh and Yahweh's people. When the storyteller says that Hezekiah and his officials blessed Yahweh, it means that these men praised Yahweh or gave thanks to Yahweh. The men also praised, or thanked, the people of Israel. In some languages, it may be impossible or unnatural to say that people blessed Yahweh. If this is the case with your language, you may say that Hezekiah praised Yahweh or thanked Yahweh.

Stop here and decide whether you will say that Hezekiah and his officials blessed Yahweh, praised Yahweh, or thanked Yahweh for all the goods the people gave. Pause this audio here.

Hezekiah was so amazed by the amount of goods the people of Israel gave that Hezekiah asked the priests and Levites about the goods. Azariah, the chief priest, answered King Hezekiah. The chief priest was the leader of all the priests. The storyteller mentions that Azariah was from the house of Zadok. This means that Azariah was a descendant of a man named Zadok. The storyteller is probably talking about the Zadok who was a priest while King David and King Solomon were alive. The descendants of Zadok had a reputation for faithfully obeying Yahweh, even when other priests were not faithful to Yahweh. When the storyteller mentions that Azariah was from the house of Zadok, the storyteller wants us to understand that Azariah was probably a faithful and trustworthy priest. If it is more clear in your language, you may say that Azariah was a descendant of Zadok, or that Zadok was an ancestor of Azariah.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 31: 1–10 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- All the Israelites who came to the Passover festival
- King Hezekiah
- The divisions of priests
- The divisions of Levites
- The people who live in Jerusalem
- Hezekiah's officials
- And Azariah the high priest

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

When the Passover festival was over, all the Israelites who had attended the festival went out to the towns of Judah. The Israelites smashed the sacred pillars and cut down the Asherah poles. The Israelites destroyed the pagan places of worship and removed the altars. The Israelites did this in all the territory of Judah and Benjamin, and also in all the territory of Ephraim and Manasseh, until the Israelites had destroyed all these things. Then everyone went home.

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Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the Israelites who went to the festival, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- I did not realize before how much Yahweh loves our people and how much Yahweh has done for us. Yahweh is truly amazing! or
- I feel sad that so many people in our country worship idols. We need to do something about it! or
- I feel glad that we are getting rid of all these filthy idols! We should have done this long ago.

Ask the people playing the Israelites who stayed home from the festival, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- Why are these people coming home and destroying our places of worship? What happened at that festival? or
- I feel sad that I could not go to the festival. The festival must have been really good! or
- I feel angry that people are tearing down our places of worship. We need those gods to help us! or
- I am glad that our people are finally tearing down these filthy idols.

Continue the drama.

King Hezekiah re-established the divisions of the priests and the Levites according to their service in the house of Yahweh. The priests and the Levites were to make the burnt offerings and peace offerings, to minister, to give thanks to Yahweh, and to sing praise in the gates of the house of Yahweh, the place where Yahweh camps on the earth.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Hezekiah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel relieved that our people will worship Yahweh correctly again; or
- I feel proud that I am the one who is making all these good things happen; or
- I feel glad that I have the opportunity to correct the wrong things that my father did.

Ask the people playing the priests and the Levites, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We feel so happy that we are going back to do our work in the house of Yahweh again; or
- Our fathers told us all about what it was like to serve in the house of Yahweh. We are so happy that now we get to serve Yahweh ourselves; or
- We feel grateful to King Hezekiah for making sure that everything in the house of Yahweh is operating correctly again; or
- We feel excited to see the house of Yahweh repaired and looking beautiful!

Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel happy that my people are making sacrifices to me again in the right way; or
- I feel pleased that my people want to worship me again; or
- It is wonderful that my people are honoring me again.

Continue the drama.

> King Hezekiah provided animals from his own herds and flocks to use for the morning and evening sacrifices, as well as for the sacrifices on the Sabbath, at the New Moon festivals, and the yearly festivals as required by the Law of Yahweh. Hezekiah told the people of Jerusalem to contribute the portion for the priests and Levites, so that the priests and Levites could devote all their time to fulfilling the requirements of the Law of Yahweh. As soon as Hezekiah gave the order, the Israelites generously gave the first portion of their grain harvest, their new wine, olive oil, and honey, and everything that the fields produced. The Israelites abundantly brought in one-tenth of everything the Israelites had. The Israelites and people of Judah who lived in the towns of Judah also brought one-tenth of their cattle and sheep and one-tenth of the sacred gifts, which were set aside for Yahweh. The people made piles of all these items. The people started making the piles in the third month, at the beginning of the harvest, and the people finished by the seventh month, at the end of the harvest.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Hezekiah, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I want the people to see that it is important to obey Yahweh’s laws, so I will give many of my own animals to make sure there are enough to make all the sacrifices; or
- I hope that Yahweh will be pleased with all the work I have done and all the things I have given to the house of Yahweh; or
- I feel excited to see people starting up all the sacrifices and rituals in the house of Yahweh again.

Ask the people playing the people of Jerusalem and the people of Judah, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The people might answer things like:

- We are glad to contribute our portion to make sure the priests and Levites have everything they need; or
- It is a good thing that the priests are making sacrifices in the house of Yahweh again. We will give the priests everything they need; or
- We wish it did not cost so much to keep the house of Yahweh running! or
- My harvest has been wonderful this year! It is not too much trouble to give one-tenth of my harvest to the house of Yahweh.

Ask the people playing the priests and Levites, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The people might answer things like:

- We have all the supplies we need! This is amazing! or
- We are amazed that the people have been so generous. The people must truly love Yahweh; or
- We are very happy that we can make sacrifices and worship Yahweh in Yahweh’s house again!

Ask the person playing Yahweh, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I feel happy that my people are so generous to the priests and the Levites; or
- This is how I always meant for things to be. Everyone contributes a small part, and everyone has enough; or
- It is wonderful that the people gave even more than they had to. The people are truly showing how much they value my house.

Continue the drama.

When Hezekiah and his officials came and saw the piles, they praised Yahweh and Yahweh’s people, the people of Israel. Then Hezekiah asked the priests and the Levites about the piles of goods. Azariah the high priest, who was a descendant of Zadok, said to the king, “Since the people began to bring the contributions into the house of Yahweh, we have had enough to eat, with plenty left over, because Yahweh has blessed Yahweh’s people, and this great quantity is what is extra.”

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Hezekiah, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- This is exactly what I hoped would happen. I gave generously to the house of Yahweh, and the people have done the same; or
- I am proud of the people because the people gave so generously; or
- I am grateful to Yahweh, for Yahweh is the one who really inspired the people to give so much.

Ask the people playing Hezekiah’s officials, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The people might answer things like:

- We are happy that the people are supporting the priests and the Levites so well; or
- We are relieved that the people did their part, and we did not have to force the people to support the house of Yahweh; or
- It is good that the people have been so generous, but what will happen in the future if the harvest is not as good?

Ask the person playing Azariah, the high priest, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The people might answer things like:

- With so many supplies, it will be easy to make sure that everyone has enough; or

- There is so much left over that we will be able to save some for the future; or
- I feel like the people truly value the work we do!

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 31:1–10 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Now, when all this was finished, all of **Israel** who were present went out to the cities of **Judah** and broke the sacred pillars into pieces and cut down the Asherah poles. The people also tore down the high places and the **altars**. The **Israelites** did this throughout the territory of Judah, Benjamin, Ephraim, and Manasseh until they had destroyed all of these things. Be sure to translate Israel, Judah, altar, high place, and Israelite the same way you did in previous passages. See the Master Glossary for more information on Israel, Judah, altar, and Israelite.

Be sure to translate **sacred pillars** and **Asherah poles** the same way you did in previous stories.

Then the Israelites returned to their own **cities**. Use the same word or phrase for cities as you have used in previous passages.

King Hezekiah assigned the **priests** and **Levites** to divisions, or special groups, each of them according to their service. The priests and Levites were to offer **burnt offerings** and **peace or fellowship offerings**, to minister, to give thanks, and to sing **praise** at the gates, or entrances, of the **house of Yahweh**, the place where **Yahweh** lives on earth. Be sure to use the same words for king, priest, Levite, burnt offering, peace or fellowship offering, house of Yahweh, and Yahweh that you used in previous stories. See the Master Glossary for more information on king, priest, Levite, praise, burnt offering, peace or fellowship offering, **house of God**, **temple**, and Yahweh.

Hezekiah also established the king's portion of the items for the offerings, for the morning and evening **burnt offerings**, and the burnt offerings for the **Sabbaths**, the **New Moon festivals** and for the yearly festivals. Hezekiah did this in accordance with the **Law** of Yahweh. Hezekiah also commanded the people who lived in **Jerusalem** to give the portion due to the priests and Levites. Be sure to use the same words for burnt offering, Sabbath, New Moon festival, law, and Jerusalem that you have used in previous stories. See the Master Glossary for more information on burnt offering, Sabbath, **festival of New Moon**, law, and Jerusalem.

As soon as Hezekiah's order spread, the sons of Israel provided in abundance the **firstfruits** of grain, new wine, olive oil, honey, and all the produce of their fields. They brought in abundantly the **tithe** of all. The sons of Israel and Judah who lived in the towns of Judah also brought the tithe of oxen and sheep, and the tithe of sacred gifts which were **consecrated** to Yahweh their **God**, and put them in piles. Be sure to use the same words for first fruits, tithe, consecrated, and God that you used in previous stories. See the Master Glossary for more information on firstfruits, tithe, consecrated, and God.

The people started making the piles in the third month, at the beginning of the harvest, and the people finished by the seventh month, at the end of the harvest.

Stop here and discuss how you will say that the Israelites began bringing gifts in the third month, at the start of harvest season, and finished in the seventh month, at the end of harvest season. Pause this audio here.

When Hezekiah and the leaders came and saw the piles, they **blessed** Yahweh and Yahweh's people Israel. Then Hezekiah asked the priests and the Levites about the piles. Azariah, the **high priest** of the house of Zadok, answered Hezekiah. Be sure to use the same words for blessed and high priest that you used in previous passages. For more information on bless and high priest, refer to the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

2 Chronicles 31:1–10

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (834 KB)
- Setting the Stage (5.5 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (9.3 MB)
- Embodying the Text (6.5 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.7 MB)
- Speaking the Word (1.1 MB)

2 Chronicles 31:11–21

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 31:11–21 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 31:11–21 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 31:11–21 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passage, the storyteller described how the Israelites destroyed all the idols in their land. Then the Israelites brought tithes, offerings, and special gifts to the house of Yahweh to give to the priests and the Levites. In this passage, the storyteller explains how the priests and Levites distributed the tithes, offerings, and special gifts.

Remember that King Ahaz, the father of Hezekiah, stopped the priests and the Levites from working in the house of Yahweh for about 16 years. But when Hezekiah became king, Hezekiah immediately reopened the house of Yahweh. Hezekiah restarted all the activities that the Law of Yahweh required. Remember also that the Levites and priests lived in cities that were scattered around the land of Israel. The priests, who were a smaller group among the Levites, lived in towns close to Jerusalem. The rest of the Levite towns were spread throughout Israel and Judah.

Stop here and look at a map of Israel that shows the location of the Levites' towns. Pause this audio here.

Each priest or Levite worked in the house of Yahweh about two weeks per year. In addition, the priests and Levites had to work in the house of Yahweh during special religious festivals. For the rest of the year, the priests and Levites lived and worked in their towns.

Stop here and discuss these questions: In your area, what roles or jobs require someone to live in a specific city or region? Describe why those people have to live in those places. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller of Chronicles wanted his hearers to understand that King Hezekiah organized the work in the house of Yahweh very well. King Hezekiah appointed leaders to make sure that they divided out the goods to the priests and Levites fairly and equally. Those leaders also chose more priests and Levites to help the leaders give out the tithes and gifts.

Stop here and discuss these questions: Talk about a time in your community when your leaders chose someone to do a very large or very important job, and then that person needed more people to help him do the job. Why was the job so large or so important? Why did the leaders choose that person to do the job? Who did the person leading the job choose to help him with the job? Did those people do the job well or not? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller emphasizes that everyone got a portion of the goods and no one was left out.

Stop here and discuss this question: In your culture, how important is it to treat each person fairly and equally? How hard do your leaders work to make sure that people treat each other fairly and equally? How do your people feel if your leaders do not treat everyone fairly and equally? In what kinds of situations might your leaders not treat everyone fairly and equally? Tell some stories about times when leaders or officials treated people fairly and equally, or when leaders or officials did not treat people fairly and equally. Pause this audio here.

However, the storyteller does point out that a priest or Levite had to meet certain requirements to receive material support. Only priests and Levites above a certain age could receive material support. In some cases, only priests and Levites whom someone had listed in the genealogy records received support. Other times, all priests and Levites received support, whether their names appeared in the records or not.

Stop here and discuss these questions: In your culture, for what reasons is it important to remember who your ancestors are? Who is responsible for remembering the list of all your ancestors? Which people have special rights, jobs, or honor and recognition because of who their ancestors were? Why do these people have special rights, jobs, or honor and recognition? Pause this audio here.

The priests and Levites had to keep themselves ritually pure in order to serve in the house of Yahweh. This means that the priests and Levites always had to follow Yahweh's rules about physical and ritual cleanness. People could become impure or unclean from things like contact with a dead body, certain kinds of sick people, or bodily fluids. Yahweh expected all the Israelites to follow these rules, but Yahweh expected even more from the priests and Levites. If a priest or Levite was ceremonially unclean at the time he was supposed to minister in Yahweh's temple, then that priest or Levite would not be able to do his work in Yahweh's temple.

Stop here and discuss these questions: In your culture, what kinds of things could make a person ceremonially unclean? What might happen to that person when that person is ceremonially unclean? If a religious leader in your community were ceremonially unclean, would the consequences be different for him or her? In what ways must your religious leaders keep themselves clean, pure, or holy? Pause this audio here.

When the system of tithes and offerings worked the way Yahweh designed the system to work, the priests and Levites were able to devote themselves fully to doing their work in the house of Yahweh because they had enough to eat and to use for their daily lives. When the priests and Levites completely obeyed Yahweh's instructions about how to work in the house of Yahweh, the entire community benefited.

Stop here and tell a story about a time that your entire community worked together to achieve something good. How did the whole community benefit? What bad things might have happened, or what good things might the community not have, if the entire community had not worked together? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller ends this story by saying that everything that King Hezekiah did for the priests and Levites was pleasing and good to Yahweh. Hezekiah did these things because Hezekiah wanted to please Yahweh. Because of this, Hezekiah was very successful in the things Hezekiah did.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 31:11–21 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: King Hezekiah appoints leaders to prepare storerooms in the house of Yahweh and bring all of the tithes, offerings, and gifts into the storerooms.

In the second scene: Kore son of Imnah, a Levite, and Kore's assistants supervise the distribution of the freewill offerings. The storyteller explains which priests and Levites could receive support.

In the third scene: The storyteller summarizes that all the things Hezekiah did for the house of Yahweh were right and good, and this is why Hezekiah was prosperous.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Hezekiah
- Conaniah and his brother Shimei
- Jehiel, Azaziah, Nahath, Asahel, Jerimoth, Jozabad, Eliel, Ismakiah, Mahath, and Benaiah
- Azariah, the high priest
- Kore, son of Imnah
- Eden, Miniamin, Jeshua, Shemaiah, Amariah, and Shecaniah
- The priests, the descendants of Aaron
- The Levites
- The wives and children of all the priests and Levites
- And Yahweh

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first scene, King Hezekiah orders the priests and Levites to prepare storerooms in the house of Yahweh. The priests and Levites did this so that they could store all of the contributions, tithes, and sacred gifts that the people of Israel gave to the priests and the Levites. The house of Yahweh already had storerooms, so it is not clear if the storyteller means that the priests and Levites built new storerooms or if they simply prepared the storerooms that were already there. Many Bible scholars think that the priests and Levites probably used the storerooms that already existed.

Stop here and talk about the different kinds of gifts, offerings, or sacrifices that your people bring to your places of worship. What words do you have for offerings that your religious laws require people to give, and what words do you have for gifts or contributions that your religious laws do not require people to give? What is the purpose of each offering, gift, or sacrifice? How does this compare to the purposes of the offerings, gifts, and sacrifices that the Israelites brought to Yahweh's temple? Pause this audio here.

In the original language, it is also not clear who brought all the gifts into the storerooms. If your language requires you to say who brought the gifts into the storerooms, it is acceptable to say that the priests and the Levites brought the gifts into the storerooms.

King Hezekiah and Azariah, the high priest, appointed 12 men to supervise the storage of the gifts in the storerooms. All of these men were probably Levites. Conaniah was the leader of this group of 12 men. Conaniah's brother, Shimei, was second-in-charge.

Stop here and discuss these questions: What special words or phrases do you have in your language to describe the person who is the second-highest authority in any situation? Discuss what word you will use in your translation to describe Shimei. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller lists the names of the other ten men whom King Hezekiah appointed to assist Konaniah and Shimei. In the original language, the storyteller says that these men were "under the hand of" Konaniah and Shimei. "Under the hand of" is special language that means "under the authority or power of". Konaniah and Shimei were a higher authority than the other ten men, and those ten men reported to Konaniah and Shimei. The storyteller does not say if any of these men were of higher authority than the others, so it is acceptable to say that they were all under the authority of Konaniah and Shimei. The storyteller calls Azariah "the official in charge of the house of God". This is another way of saying that Azariah was the High Priest. The High Priest had the greatest responsibility to make sure everyone who worked in the House of Yahweh did their jobs correctly. This is why the storyteller calls him the official in charge of the house of God.

In the second scene, a man named Kore, the son of Imnah, was in charge of giving out all the tithes, offerings, and gifts to the priests and Levites. Kore was the keeper of the East Gate. This means that Kore guarded the eastern gate of the house of Yahweh. The house of Yahweh had many gates, but the East Gate was the main gate that people went through to enter the house of Yahweh. So it was probably an important job to be the keeper of the East Gate.

Kore was in charge of giving out the freewill offerings, the contributions of Yahweh, and the most holy things. A freewill offering was an offering that the Law of Yahweh did not require people to give. People just gave freewill offerings to thank Yahweh for what Yahweh had done. If you have translated the book of Exodus, you have already decided how you will say "freewill offering."

Stop here and listen to Exodus chapter 36, verse 3, if it is available in your language. In this story, the Israelites bring freewill offerings and give the materials to make the tabernacle. Pay attention to the words you chose for "freewill offering." Pause this audio here.

Every time an Israelite made one of the required sacrifices to Yahweh, the priests received a portion of that offering. This is the portion that the storyteller calls "the contribution of Yahweh" or "the contribution that people reserved for Yahweh."

Stop here and discuss these questions: When you bring a sacrifice, offering, or gift to your place of worship, what happens to that thing? Do you burn, eat, or drink the gift? Do you use the gift to make something, give to a priest or religious leader, or do something else? How could you say "the contribution of Yahweh" so it is clear that this means the part of each offering that the priests received? Pause this audio here.

Kore was also responsible for the most holy offerings or consecrated gifts. These consecrated gifts were the portion of a sin or purification offering that the priests ate. If you have already translated the book of Leviticus, you have already decided how you will say "most holy offering" or "consecrated gift."

Stop here and listen to the beginning of Leviticus chapter 2, if it is available in your language. Pay attention to the words you chose for the portion of the offering that belongs to Aaron and Aaron's sons. Pause this audio here.

Kore had six assistants to help Kore with this job. These assistants' names were Eden, Miniamin, Jeshua, Shemaiah, Amariah, and Shecaniah. These men helped Kore distribute the items to the priests. It is not clear if these six men were priests and therefore lived in the cities of the priests, or if these men were Levites who traveled to the cities of the priests in order to give the priests their support.

The storyteller says that Kore's assistants gave out the portions faithfully to their brothers by divisions. In this case, "brothers" does not mean literal brothers; it just means that Eden, Miniamin, Jeshua, Shemaiah, Amariah, and Shecaniah were fellow Levites or fellow priests. The assistants had the same job as the other priests and Levites.

Stop here and discuss these questions: In your language, can you use the word for “brother” to describe someone who is not a relative but who has the same job, same role, or same responsibility as you? If you can, it would be best to use the word “brother” here. If you cannot use the word “brother” this way in your language, what words can you use in your language to describe someone who has the same job, same role, or same responsibility as you? Decide which word you will use here. Pause this audio here.

Kore and his assistants divided the gifts fairly among old and young alike. Later, the storyteller mentions that there was a minimum age for a priest to receive support. But as long as the priest was above that age, it did not matter if the priest was young or old; that priest got the same amount as everyone else.

Kore’s assistants divided the gifts among the families of priests by their divisions. This probably means that each division of priests got the same amount of gifts. This is one way that the storyteller emphasizes that the leaders of the priests and Levites divided all the gifts fairly and equally.

Stop here and discuss how you will say that the assistants divided the gifts among the families of the priests by their divisions, so that each division got the same amount. Pause this audio here.

In the rest of scene two, the storyteller wants his hearers to understand that there were some requirements for priests and Levites to receive the gifts that the people gave to the house of Yahweh. The leaders of the Levites needed to make a list of all the people who met those requirements in order to make sure that each person received a fair share. But in the original language, the details of these requirements can be confusing. Bible scholars do not agree on all aspects of how the distribution system worked. One important thing to keep in mind when you are working through a situation like this is that even though the meaning is not clear to us now, the meaning was clear to the Israelites at the time.

The next detail in this scene is one of the details that scholars do not agree on. The storyteller makes a comment about genealogical enrollment. This means whether or not someone’s name was in a list of ancestors and descendants. Unfortunately, Bible scholars do not agree on what the storyteller meant here. Some Bible scholars think this part means that the person’s name did have to be in the list of ancestors and descendants, and other Bible scholars think this part means that the person’s name did not have to be in the list of ancestors and descendants! While scholars disagree, the majority of Bible translations say that the person’s name did have to be in the list of ancestors and descendants, and we recommend that you say it this way.

Next, the storyteller talks about the minimum age requirement for priests to receive support. Some Bible translations say that all the males 3 years old and up received support, while others say that all the males 30 years old and up received support. We recommend that you follow the Bible translation that your local church uses.

Next, the storyteller says that the men who should receive support were the men who entered the house of Yahweh to do their daily duties according to their divisions. This just means that each man had to work in the temple when it was that man’s turn. If a man did not do his work, that man would not receive support.

Stop here and discuss how you will say that each man had to do his daily duties in the house of Yahweh, according to that man’s division, in order to receive support. Pause this audio here.

Next, the storyteller talks about the priests. Kore and Kore’s assistants made lists of the priests according to their fathers’ households. Remember that every Israelite belonged to his father’s tribe and his father’s household.

Stop here and discuss how you will say that Kore listed the priests according to their fathers’ households. Pause this audio here.

Kore and Kore’s assistants made lists of the Levites differently from how they made lists of the priests. Instead of listing the Levites according to their fathers’ households, Kore and Kore’s assistants listed the Levites according to the men’s duties and divisions. This makes sense because the Levites probably specialized in different kinds of jobs. Some Levites were gatekeepers, some were musicians, and other Levites took care of the items in the tabernacle or temple. In contrast, all the priests did basically the same job. The Levites also had to be 20 years old or older in order to receive support.

Stop here and talk about how people in your culture divide people into different groups. Discuss what different groupings exist, such as tribes, clans, families, social groups, or groupings related to jobs. Then, discuss how you will say that Kore listed the Levites according to their duties and divisions. Pause this audio here.

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Next, the storyteller mentions that Kore and Kore's assistants included the wives and children of the priests and Levites in their lists. This shows that Kore and Kore's assistants took into account how many people each man had to provide for. Kore and Kore's assistants did this because the whole assembly of people consecrated themselves faithfully. The whole assembly probably means the entire tribe of Levites. This probably means that all the Levites, including the women and children, followed all of Yahweh's commandments to be ritually pure.

The storyteller begins the third scene by saying that Hezekiah did these things throughout the land of Judah. Although the priests and Levites primarily worked in the house of Yahweh in Jerusalem, they lived in cities throughout the land that Hezekiah controlled. The storyteller uses three similar words to describe Hezekiah's actions: good, right, and faithful. These words describe that Hezekiah's actions benefited the people, were morally just, and were in agreement with what Yahweh wanted.

Stop here and discuss what words in your language have a similar meaning to "good," "right," and "faithful." Which three words will you use here? Pause this audio here.

Hezekiah did these things before Yahweh his God. This means that Yahweh knew about everything Hezekiah did.

Hezekiah did all these things in the service of the house of God. This means that Hezekiah did these things as a servant of God. Although Hezekiah was a king, Hezekiah's most important job as king was to serve God. Hezekiah did his service "in law and in commandment." This means that Hezekiah followed all the laws and all the commandments that Yahweh gave to the people of Israel.

Stop here and discuss how you will say that in every single act of service that Hezekiah did for the house of God, Hezekiah followed all of Yahweh's laws and commandments. Pause this audio here.

Finally, the storyteller connects Hezekiah's success and prosperity to the way Hezekiah sought God with all Hezekiah's heart.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 31:11–21 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Hezekiah
- Conaniah and his brother Shimei
- Jehiel, Azaziah, Nahath, Asahel, Jerimoth, Jozabad, Eliel, Ismakiah, Mahath, and Benaiah
- Azariah, the high priest
- Kore, son of Imnah
- Eden, Miniamin, Jeshua, Shemaiah, Amariah, and Shecaniah
- The priests, the descendants of Aaron
- The Levites
- The wives and children of all the priests and Levites
- And Yahweh

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

King Hezekiah commanded the priests and the Levites to prepare storerooms in the house of Yahweh. The priests and Levites prepared the rooms, and they faithfully brought in the contributions, tithes, and sacred gifts. Conaniah the Levite was the man in charge, and Conaniah’s brother Shimei was second-in-command. Ten men assisted Conaniah and Shimei: these men’s names were Jehiel, Azaziah, Nahath, Asahel, Jerimoth, Jozabad, Eliel, Ismakiah, Mahath, and Benaiah. These men did all these things under the authority of King Hezekiah and Azariah the high priest, the chief official of the house of God.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Hezekiah, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am so happy to see Yahweh’s house functioning well again; or
- I feel relieved that I have fixed the mistakes that my father made; or
- Conaniah, Shimei, and the other Levites are doing a good job. I am glad that I can count on these men.

Ask the people playing Conaniah, Shimei, and the other overseers, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The people might answer things like:

- I feel proud that King Hezekiah chose me for this task. It means that the king trusts me; or
- Yahweh’s gifts are passing through our hands. We must handle these gifts carefully and honestly; or
- We are amazed that the people are bringing so much! or
- We feel so happy to see Yahweh’s house operating again.

Ask the people playing the rest of the priests and Levites, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- We feel relieved that the people have been so generous to us. Now we have everything we need to do our work well; or
- We feel grateful to Yahweh. Yahweh is the one who is truly making all these things happen; or
- It is so nice to know that the community values our work here.

Continue the drama.

Kore, son of Imnah the Levite, who was the chief guard at the eastern gate of the house of Yahweh, was in charge of the freewill offerings to God. Kore was also in charge of giving out the portion of each sacrifice to Yahweh that belonged to the priests and of handing out the consecrated gifts. Kore’s assistants were Eden, Miniamin, Jeshua, Shemaiah, Amariah, and Shecaniah. These men worked in the cities of the priests to faithfully distribute their portions to their colleagues, the priests, by their divisions.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing Kore and his assistants, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The people might answer things like:

- We feel honored that the king chose us to do this important work for Yahweh and for our fellow priests and Levites; or
- We feel happy that the people have been so generous to us! or
- We feel grateful that King Hezekiah is making sure that everyone follows Yahweh’s instructions. This way, we can do our work correctly; or
- We must be very careful and make sure that we divide everything fairly and equally.

Ask the people playing the priests in the towns of the priests, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The people might answer things like:

- It has been so long since we received this much support! We are amazed; or
- It feels so good to know that the king and the people value our work so much; or
- We can focus on our duties now, because the people have met our needs; or

- We feel relieved because now, we do not have to worry as much about providing for our families.

Continue the drama.

Kore and Kore's assistants faithfully distributed the portions to young and old alike, to all males three years old and older, whose names were in the genealogical records, as long as those men went to the house of Yahweh to do their duties according to their divisions. Kore and his assistants also distributed the gifts to the priests and listed the priests according to their fathers' households. Kore and his assistants listed the Levites from 20 years old and upwards, according to their duties and their divisions. The lists included all the little children, wives, sons, and daughters of the priests and the Levites, for the entire assembly of the Levites had faithfully set themselves apart to follow the rules for holiness.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing Kore and his assistants, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We must be sure to include everyone who needs support, without showing favoritism or making mistakes; or
- We feel so happy that the whole community is obeying Yahweh's commands; or
- This is a very important task. Our work will make sure that everyone can play his role in serving Yahweh; or
- We are glad that the people are taking care of the priests and the Levites.

Ask the people playing the priests, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We feel grateful that our leaders are very concerned with fairness; or
- We feel happy that we can finally fulfill our role in the house of Yahweh; or
- We are relieved that we will be able to provide for our wives and children; or
- We feel honored to be the ones who make sacrifices to Yahweh on behalf of this community.

Ask the people playing the Levites, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- Our work might not be obvious, but it is an important part of our community life; or
- We feel honored to care for the holy things of Yahweh's house and to help the priests with their work; or
- We must be sure to be careful to continue to consecrate ourselves, so we can do the work Yahweh wants us to do; or
- We feel encouraged that the whole community is working together so well.

Ask the people playing the wives and children of the Levites, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We feel relieved that the community has provided so well for our families; or
- We feel honored to help our husbands do this important work in the house of Yahweh; or
- My dad works in the house of Yahweh, and everyone respects my dad. I want to be like my dad when I grow up; or
- It is amazing how the whole community comes together under the leadership of King Hezekiah to make sure that we all worship Yahweh properly.

Continue the drama.

Hezekiah did these things through all of the land of Judah. Hezekiah did what was good, right, and faithful in order to please Yahweh his God. In every single act of service that Hezekiah did for the house of God, Hezekiah followed all of Yahweh's laws and commandments. Hezekiah was a successful king because Hezekiah obeyed Yahweh his God with all his heart.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Hezekiah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel so happy that the people are faithfully worshipping Yahweh again; or
- I feel grateful that Yahweh has helped me lead the people in the right way.; or
- If we continue to follow Yahweh with all our hearts, Yahweh will continue to bless Judah.

Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel very happy that my servant Hezekiah is doing what is good, right, and faithful before me; or

- I am glad that the priests, Levites, and people are serving me as I commanded; or
- It is wonderful that the people are being so generous to the priests and Levites.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 31:11–21 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Then Hezekiah commanded people to prepare storerooms in the **house of Yahweh**. People prepared the rooms, and they faithfully brought in the contributions, **tithes**, and **consecrated** gifts. Be sure to use the same words for the house of Yahweh, tithe, and consecrated as you did in previous stories. For more information, refer to **house of God** or temple, tithe, and consecrate in the Master Glossary.

Storerooms are places where people store goods, food, and important items. The temple, or house, of Yahweh had many storerooms. Use the same word for storerooms as you use in 1 Chronicles 28:11.

Conaniah the **Levite** was the official in charge of these things, and Conaniah's brother Shimei was second-in-command. Jehiel, Azaziah, Nahath, Asahel, Jerimoth, Jozabad, Eliel, Ismakiah, Mahath, and Benaiah were the assistant overseers of this work, under the authority of Conaniah and his brother Shimei. Be sure to use the same word for Levite that you used in previous stories. See the Master Glossary for more information on Levite.

Stop here and discuss what words you will use in your language for "**official in charge**," "**second-in-command**," and "**assistant overseers**." Pause this audio here

The name Conaniah means "Yahweh has sustained" in the sense that Yahweh has kept someone alive or kept someone healthy.

Stop here and discuss how you will say the names of **Conaniah**, **Shimei**, **Jehiel**, **Azaziah**, **Nahath**, **Asahel**, **Jerimoth**, **Jozabad**, **Eliel**, **Ismakiah**, **Mahath**, and **Benaiah**. Pause this audio here.

King Hezekiah and Azariah, the chief official over the house of **God**, appointed these men for this work. The storyteller calls Azariah "the official in charge of the house of God." This is another way to say that Azariah was the **high priest**. Use the same words for king and God that you have used in previous passages. If you chose to call Azariah the high priest, then use the same word for high priest that you have used in previous passages. For more information on king and high priest, refer to the Master Glossary.

Kore, son of Imnah the Levite, who was the **gatekeeper** at the East Gate of the house of Yahweh, was in charge of the freewill offerings to God. Be sure to use the same word for gatekeeper that you used in previous stories.

A freewill offering was a type of fellowship offering that the Law of Yahweh did not require. A person would give a freewill offering to thank Yahweh or to show their love for Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **freewill offering**. Look up freewill offering in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Kore was also in charge of giving out the contributions for **Yahweh**, and of handing out the most **holy** gifts. Kore's assistants were Eden, Miniamin, Jeshua, Shemaiah, Amariah, and Shecaniah. These men worked in the cities of the **priests** to faithfully distribute their portions to the divisions of their brothers, the priests. These men divided the gifts equally between young and old alike. Be sure to use the same words for Yahweh, holy, and priests that you used in previous stories. See the Master Glossary for more information on Yahweh, holy, and priests.

Stop here and decide how you will say the names for **Kore**, **Eden**, **Miniamin**, **Jeshua**, **Shemaiah**, **Amariah**, and **Shecaniah**. Pause this audio here.

Kore and his assistants distributed the gifts to all males three years old and older whose names appeared in the **genealogy** records, to everyone who entered the house of Yahweh to do his daily work according to their divisions. Be sure to use the same word for genealogy that you used in previous stories. See the Master Glossary for more information on genealogy.

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Kore and his assistants also gave to the priests and enrolled or registered the priests by genealogy according to their fathers' **households**. Kore and his assistants gave to the Levites 20 years old and older, and enrolled the Levites according to their duties and divisions. The genealogical lists included their little children, wives, sons, and daughters. Use the same word for household that you have used in previous passages. For more information on household, refer to the Master Glossary.

Hezekiah did these things throughout all of **Judah**. Hezekiah did what was good, right, and faithful before Yahweh, Hezekiah's God. These words describe that Hezekiah's actions were good, or benefited the people, were right, or morally just, and that they were in agreement with what Yahweh wanted. Hezekiah did all these things in his service to the house of God and followed Yahweh's **laws** and **commandments**. Hezekiah sought his God with all his **heart**, and because of this, Hezekiah was prosperous. Be sure to use the same words for Judah, law, commandment, and heart as you did in previous stories. See the Master Glossary for more information on Judah, law, commandment, and heart.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

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Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 32:1–8 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 32:1–8 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

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Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 32:1–8 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passage, the storyteller explained how the priests and Levites gave out all the items that the people of Israel donated for the priests and Levites. In this passage, King Sennacherib of Assyria invades Judah and threatens Jerusalem. King Hezekiah and the people make preparations to defend Jerusalem, and King Hezekiah encourages the people to trust Yahweh their God to protect the people. The storyteller shows how God rescued King Hezekiah and his people from the army of Assyria and saved the city of Jerusalem.

Assyria was a large and powerful country northeast of Judah and Israel. At the time that Hezekiah was king of Judah, everyone was afraid of the Assyrian army. Assyria had already conquered other countries around Judah, and now Assyria began to attack Judah.

Stop here and look at a map that shows the locations of Judah, Israel, and Assyria. Pause this audio here.

Sennacherib and his army began by attacking Judah's fortified cities. Remember that King Solomon and other kings of Judah had built fortified cities all over their territory. The kings had built walls around the cities so that outsiders could not get in and attack the people who lived in those cities. King Hezekiah realized that Sennacherib was going to attack Jerusalem, so Hezekiah did everything Hezekiah could to protect Jerusalem and the people inside the city. The first thing Hezekiah and his men did was to stop up the springs around Jerusalem. That part of Israel got rain during the cooler part of the year, but during the hot part of the year, the people depended on springs for drinking water. A spring is a place where water comes up from underground and forms a small stream or a pool.

Stop here and talk about where your people get water to drink. What would your people do if you did not have these places to get water to drink? Pause this audio here.

Springs are very good sources of water to drink. The storyteller says that there was more than one spring around Jerusalem, but the main spring that we know about was the Gihon spring on the east side of Jerusalem.

Stop here and look at a picture of a spring and a map of Jerusalem that shows the location of the Gihon spring. Pause this audio here.

Hezekiah did more things to strengthen the defenses of Jerusalem. Hezekiah gathered the people to repair damage to Jerusalem's wall, to build a new wall, and to build towers along the wall. By climbing to the top of a tower, the people inside the city could see far away and see if Sennacherib's army was getting close to Jerusalem. Finally, Hezekiah's workers made more weapons and shields.

Stop here and talk about what it might be like to be in a city when you know people are coming to attack. How do you think you would feel? Maybe you have been in a similar situation. What was that situation like? Did your people have a leader who was able to protect you? Pause this audio here.

Finally, Hezekiah gathered the people together and spoke to the people. Hezekiah told the people to be strong and courageous. Hezekiah said the people should not be afraid or discouraged because Yahweh was with the people. Hezekiah was convinced that Yahweh was on the side of the people of Jerusalem and would help the people. Hezekiah's words helped the people to feel brave and hopeful.

Stop here and tell a story about a time when someone was facing a bad situation, but another person said something that caused the first person to see the situation in a better way. This can be a folk tale or a story from your own life. Talk about the situation, why it was a bad situation, and how the person's encouraging words made a difference.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 32:1–8 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

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This passage has two scenes.

In the first scene: The Assyrian army invades Judah and attacks the fortified cities of Judah. Hezekiah organizes workers to improve the defenses around Jerusalem.

In the second scene: Hezekiah gathers the people together and tells them not to be afraid, because Yahweh is on the people's side. The people feel encouraged.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Hezekiah
- King Sennacherib of Assyria
- The Assyrian army
- Hezekiah's officials and military advisers
- The people of Jerusalem
- And Yahweh

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In scene one, the storyteller begins the story by reminding us that Hezekiah had faithfully done many good works for Yahweh. The storyteller is referring to the fact that Hezekiah restarted worship in the house of Yahweh, celebrated the Passover festival, inspired the Israelites to destroy all the idols in the land, and required the Israelites to provide the tithes and offerings to support the priests and Levites.

Sennacherib was both the king of Assyria and the leader of the army. If you have already translated the book of 2 Kings, then you have already heard a version of this story and chosen a name for Sennacherib.

Stop here and listen to 2 Kings chapter 18, starting from the middle of the chapter. This story begins during the 14th year of King Hezekiah's reign. Pause this audio here.

In the original language, the storyteller uses special language and says, "Sennacherib's face was for war against Jerusalem." This means that Sennacherib intended to fight against the people of Jerusalem and to capture the city. The idea is that Sennacherib is looking at Jerusalem, and this shows that Sennacherib intends to come to Jerusalem. Sennacherib wants to fight against the people of Jerusalem, overthrow the king, and take control of the city himself.

Stop here and discuss these questions: What sayings do you have in your language that talk about the way a person faces something, or turns their face toward something, and how that action shows what the person plans to do? What other sayings use a different body part to show a person's intentions or plans? Pause this audio here.

Sennacherib's army laid siege to Judah's fortified cities. A siege is a military strategy to conquer a fortified city. To do a siege, the attacking army simply surrounds the fortified city so that the people on the inside cannot go in and out. Eventually, the people inside the city will run out of food and water. At that point, the people inside the city have three choices: fight their way out, starve to death, or surrender. In a previous story, you described the idea of doing a siege.

If necessary, stop here and listen to the beginning of 1 Chronicles chapter 20 to remember how you described doing a siege. Pause this audio here.

Apparently, Sennacherib did not want to wait for the people inside the fortified cities of Judah to surrender. Sennacherib gave his army instructions to break down the walls of the fortified cities. This was also a normal battle plan if the attacking army was strong enough to do it. The storyteller says that Sennacherib did this because Sennacherib intended to break into and conquer the cities for himself. This simply means that Sennacherib wanted to conquer and control Judah's cities.

Stop here and discuss the best way in your language to say that Sennacherib wanted to conquer and control Judah's cities. Pause this audio here.

Hezekiah saw what Sennacherib was doing and made efforts to defend Jerusalem against the Assyrian army. When the storyteller says that Hezekiah saw what Sennacherib had done, the storyteller means that Hezekiah was aware of Sennacherib's actions and that Hezekiah understood what Sennacherib intended to do. Hezekiah realized that Sennacherib intended to take over all of Judah by conquering Jerusalem.

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Stop here and discuss what the best way in your language is to say that Hezekiah knew what Sennacherib was doing and Hezekiah understood what Sennacherib's intentions were. Pause this audio here.

The first thing Hezekiah did was to talk to Hezekiah's government officials and military advisers. The men decided to stop the supply of water outside Jerusalem so that the Assyrians could not use it. Remember that the people of Jerusalem depended on fresh water from springs to get drinking water. We do not know exactly how Hezekiah and his officials stopped the supply of water from the springs, but the purpose was to make it hard for the Assyrian army to get water.

Many people came and helped Hezekiah's officials stop the flow of water from the springs. The people also stopped the flow of a stream that ran through the region. A stream is a small, shallow river. There are not very many streams in Jerusalem. This stream may have had the Gihon spring as its source. Again, the purpose was to make it difficult for the Assyrian army to get water.

To make it clear why the people stopped up the springs and the stream, the storyteller says that the people asked a question to which they did not expect an answer. The people say, "Why should the kings of Assyria come and find abundant water?" First, the phrase "kings of Assyria" probably refers to the Assyrian army's military leaders. These military leaders represent the entire army of Assyria. Second, this question means, "We do not want the Assyrian army to come here and find plenty of water to drink" or "We are not going to make it easy for the Assyrian army to come here and find plenty of water to drink."

Stop here and discuss how you will say that the people of Judah said that they would not make it easy for the Assyrian army to come and find plenty of water to drink. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller continues to describe all the things that King Hezekiah did to prepare for an attack by the Assyrian army. First, the storyteller says that Hezekiah took courage, or strengthened himself. This means that Hezekiah both felt brave and took strong action.

Stop here and discuss what words or sayings you have in your language that mean a person felt brave and took strong action. Then decide which word or saying you could use here. Pause this audio here.

Hezekiah rebuilt parts of the wall of Jerusalem that were broken. The capital city of Jerusalem had a wall for protection, but parts of the wall were broken. Hezekiah did not fix the wall himself but ordered Hezekiah's men to fix the wall. Hezekiah also ordered his men to build towers. Most city walls in ancient Israel had towers around or in the walls. People who stood in the towers to defend the city could see an attack coming from far away. We do not know exactly where these towers were. The towers were probably close to the wall or possibly even part of the wall itself.

Stop here and look at an image of a city wall with towers. What word could you use in your language for "tower"? Pause this audio here.

King Hezekiah also told his men to build another wall outside the original city wall of Jerusalem. This second wall made it even harder for the Assyrian army to attack Jerusalem. King Hezekiah's men also strengthened the Millo. The Millo was a structure in the City of David, which was one of the older parts of Jerusalem. We are not sure exactly what the Millo was. Some people think the Millo was terraces, while other people think the Millo was a building. A terrace is an area of land that people fill with dirt to make flat. There are usually several layers of terraces, almost like stair steps. In an earlier story, you already decided how you want to talk about the Millo.

Stop here and listen to the beginning of 1 Chronicles chapter 11. In this story, David becomes king of Israel, moves into Jerusalem, and builds the Millo. Pay close attention to how you decided to talk about the Millo. Pause this audio here.

Finally, Hezekiah made many weapons and shields for his people to use to fight against the Assyrian army. Once again, Hezekiah did not make these himself, but rather Hezekiah told his men to make the weapons and shields, and the men did. A weapon was any object that a person could use to hurt another person. In ancient Israel, swords, spears, bows, and arrows were common weapons. A shield was an object that a person could use to protect themself from those weapons.

In the second scene, King Hezekiah appoints more military officers over the people of Jerusalem. The word "people" here might refer to the army and not to the non-army people of Jerusalem. Then Hezekiah told the

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people to gather together in the square by the city gate. It is not clear if the storyteller means that Hezekiah assembled all the people of Jerusalem in the square at the city gate, or only the military officers.

A square was a wide open space in a city where people could gather. This square in Jerusalem was next to the city gate.

Stop here and discuss these questions: In your language, what do you call a wide open space in a city where people could gather? What word could you use for this space in your translation? Pause this audio here.

Hezekiah assembled the people and spoke to the people to encourage them. To encourage means to make someone feel better, have hope, or feel brave. The original language says that Hezekiah spoke to the people's hearts. This means that Hezekiah wanted to make the people feel good emotions rather than bad emotions.

Stop here and discuss these questions: How could you say in your language that Hezekiah spoke to the people in order to help the people feel better, have hope, or feel brave? Pause this audio here.

The first thing Hezekiah said was "Be strong and courageous." The word "strong" probably does not mean to be physically strong, but to be determined mentally and emotionally to do what people need to do. Hezekiah wanted the people to think that they could fight this battle and win.

Next, Hezekiah told the people, "Do not be afraid or discouraged because of the king of Assyria and the large army that is with the king." Discouraged means the opposite of encouraged. A person who is discouraged feels hopeless, sad, and afraid.

Next, Hezekiah states the reason why the people did not need to feel afraid or discouraged. Hezekiah says, "There is a greater power with us than with the king of Assyria." The greater power is Yahweh. Hezekiah means that Yahweh is on the side of the people of Israel and that Yahweh is more powerful than Assyria's army.

Stop here and discuss how you could say that the Israelites have a greater power on their side than the Assyrians have. Pause this audio here.

Hezekiah continues to describe how Yahweh is more powerful than Assyria's army. Hezekiah says that Sennacherib, the commander of the Assyrian army, only has an arm of flesh or mere human strength. Remember that in the Bible, someone's arm represents that person's power. And in the Bible, flesh represents the state of being human or mortal. Hezekiah means that Sennacherib only has ordinary human power to help Sennacherib. Hezekiah contrasts this with the spiritual power that the Israelites have because Yahweh is on the Israelites' side.

Stop here and discuss these questions: What sayings do you have in your language that mean that someone has only human power as opposed to spiritual power? Could you use any of these sayings here? Pause this audio here.

Hezekiah says that Yahweh our God is with us to help us and to fight our battles. This means that Yahweh will protect the people of Israel. Yahweh will help the Israelites to have enough power to win the battle against the Assyrian army.

Stop here and discuss how you will say "Yahweh our God is with us to help us and to fight our battles." Pause this audio here.

Hezekiah's speech to the people worked. The people felt encouraged and gained confidence.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 32:1–8 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has two scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Hezekiah
- King Sennacherib of Assyria

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- The Assyrian army
- Hezekiah's officials and military advisers
- The people of Jerusalem
- And Yahweh

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

After King Hezekiah had faithfully done all these things, King Sennacherib of Assyria came and invaded Judah. Sennacherib laid siege to all the fortified cities of Judah. Sennacherib gave orders to his army to break down the city walls and take control of the cities. When Hezekiah realized that Sennacherib intended to attack Jerusalem, Hezekiah consulted with his officials and military commanders. The men decided to stop the flow of the springs around Jerusalem. Many people came and stopped up all the springs and the stream that flowed through the region. The people did this so that it would not be easy for the Assyrian army to find water when the army came near Jerusalem.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Hezekiah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I did all these things to please Yahweh, but now Yahweh is allowing Sennacherib to attack Judah. Did I do something wrong? or
- I feel confident that Yahweh will not allow such an evil army to conquer the city where Yahweh's Name lives; or
- I will do everything in my power to make sure that Sennacherib does not conquer Jerusalem; or
- One of the best ways to defeat Sennacherib's army is to make sure the army has no water to drink.

Ask the person playing King Sennacherib, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Judah is a good land full of good farms and prosperous cities. I want that land! or
- It makes me happy to think of my people ruling over the towns of Judah; or
- My army is much stronger than Hezekiah's army. I am not afraid of Hezekiah's army!

Ask the people playing the Assyrian army, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We feel proud to conquer new lands for our king; or
- This is good land. It will benefit our people to control this land; or
- We are happy to fight to show everyone that our army is the strongest army in the world!

Ask the people playing Hezekiah's officials and military commanders, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We feel very nervous. The Assyrian army is strong and terrifying; or
- We are sad that we are losing our land to the Assyrians; or
- We are angry that the Assyrians have attacked our country. How dare the Assyrians hurt Yahweh's people! or
- We will do everything possible so that the Assyrians cannot conquer Jerusalem!

Ask the people playing the workers in Jerusalem, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

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- We feel afraid. Sennacherib has conquered so many other towns and cities. Will Sennacherib conquer Jerusalem, too? or
- We feel confident in our king. Look at all the things our king is doing to protect our city; or
- We are determined to make it as hard as possible for the Assyrian army to conquer Jerusalem; or
- We feel confused. We have been more faithful to Yahweh than the previous generation. Why is this happening to us now?

Continue the drama.

Then Hezekiah took courage and instructed his men to work hard to repair all the broken sections of the wall around Jerusalem. The men also built towers on the wall. Hezekiah's men built another wall outside the first wall and reinforced the Millo in the City of David. Hezekiah also made a large number of weapons and shields.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Hezekiah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We can defend this city. We just need to fix a few things; or
- I am proud of my people for working so hard; or
- I feel confident that our defenses will be strong enough; or
- I know that Yahweh is with us. Yahweh will not let this city fall.

Ask the people playing Hezekiah's workers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We feel confident in our king. Our king is doing the right things to defend the city; or
- We feel nervous. We are doing a lot of work, but will it be enough? or
- Surely Yahweh will not let the Assyrians destroy Jerusalem; or
- If the Assyrians do conquer this city, what will happen to me and my family?

Continue the drama.

Hezekiah appointed military officers over the people and told them to assemble before Hezekiah in the square at the city gate. Hezekiah encouraged the people, saying, "Be strong and courageous. Do not be afraid or discouraged because of the king of Assyria and the large army with him, because there is a stronger power on our side than there is on the king of Assyria's side. The king of Assyria only has human power, but Yahweh our God is on our side to help us and fight this battle for us." The people felt better after listening to what Hezekiah, the king of Judah, said.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Hezekiah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Yahweh has helped our people many times. Yahweh will help again; or
- I want my people to know that they do not need to be afraid, because Yahweh will protect us; or
- I feel safe and secure. Yahweh is better protection than any wall or shield.

Ask the people playing the people listening to Hezekiah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- Hezekiah is right! Yahweh is God over everything, and Yahweh will protect us; or
- We feel better. We just need to trust in Yahweh; or
- We feel excited to see how Yahweh will rescue us; or
- Yahweh is stronger than the Assyrians. We do have a chance to win here.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 32:1–8 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

After **King** Hezekiah had faithfully done all these things, King **Sennacherib** of **Assyria** came and invaded **Judah**. Sennacherib laid **siege** to all the **fortified cities** of Judah. Sennacherib gave orders to his army to break down

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the city walls and take control of the cities for Sennacherib. Be sure to use the same words for king, Sennacherib, Assyria, Judah, siege and fortified city as you have used in previous stories. See the Master Glossary for more information on king, Judah, and siege.

When Hezekiah realized that Sennacherib's face was for war against **Jerusalem**, Hezekiah consulted with his **officials** and **military commanders**. Use the same words for Jerusalem, officials, and military commanders that you have used in previous passages. Refer to the Master Glossary for more information about Jerusalem.

Stop here and discuss how you will say that Sennacherib's **face was for war** against Jerusalem, or that Sennacherib intended to attack Jerusalem. Pause this audio here.

The men decided to stop the flow of the **springs** around Jerusalem. Many people came and stopped up all the springs and the stream that flowed through the region. The people said to each other, "We do not want it to be easy for the Assyrian army to find water when they arrive here." Use the same word for springs that you have used in previous passages.

Then Hezekiah took courage and instructed his men to work hard to repair all the broken sections of the wall around Jerusalem. The men also built **lookout towers**. Use the same word for lookout towers as you have used previously, and refer to "lookout towers" in the Master Glossary for more information.

Stop here and decide how you will say that King Hezekiah **took courage**, or strengthened himself. Pause this audio here.

The men also built towers on the wall around Jerusalem. Hezekiah's men built another wall outside the first wall and reinforced the **Millo**, or **terraces,** in the City of David. Hezekiah also made a large number of weapons and **shields**. Be sure to use the same words for the Millo, or terrace, and shield as you have used in previous stories.

Stop here, if needed, and look at a picture of a spring. Pause this audio here.

Hezekiah appointed military officers over the people and told them to assemble before Hezekiah in the square at the city gate. Then Hezekiah "spoke to the people's hearts." Remember that this means that the king wanted the people to feel better, stop being afraid, and feel encouraged.

Stop here and decide how you will say that King Hezekiah **spoke to the people's hearts**. If needed, refer to **heart** in the Master Glossary for more information. Pause this audio here.

The King told the people, "Be strong and courageous. Do not be afraid or discouraged because of the king of Assyria and the large army with him, because there is a stronger power on our side than there is on his side. The king of Assyria only has an arm of flesh, but **Yahweh** our **God** is on our side to help us and fight this battle for us." Be sure to use the same words for Yahweh and God as you have used in previous stories. See the Master Glossary for more information on Yahweh and God.

Stop here and decide how you will say that the king of Assyria has only an "**arm of flesh**," which means that the King of Assyria is only depending on human power, as opposed to God's power. Pause this audio here.

The people felt better after the people listened to what Hezekiah, the king of Judah, said.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

2 Chronicles 32:1–8

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (588 KB)
- Setting the Stage (2.1 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (6.7 MB)
- Embodying the Text (3.8 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.1 MB)
- Speaking the Word (782 KB)

2 Chronicles 32:9–23

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 32: 9–23 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 32: 9–23 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 32: 9–23 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passage, King Hezekiah prepared to defend Jerusalem from an attack by the Assyrian army. In this passage, King Sennacherib of Assyria sends messengers to Jerusalem to try to scare Hezekiah and the people so that they will surrender to the Assyrian army. But Yahweh kills many Assyrian soldiers, and Sennacherib is the one who gives up instead.

Remember that by the time Hezekiah became the king of Judah, the Assyrian army had already completely conquered and occupied the northern kingdom of Israel. Some time after Hezekiah finished preparations for Sennacherib's attack, the Assyrian army attacked and captured many cities in Judah. When this story happens, the main Assyrian army, along with Sennacherib, is attacking a city called Lachish. Lachish was a very important city in Judah. You may remember that Lachish was one of the cities that King Rehoboam built up and fortified. Lachish was about 48 kilometers southeast of Jerusalem. Lachish was on a major road that led from Egypt to

Jerusalem. Since Sennacherib came from the north, if he successfully captured Lachish, then Sennacherib's army would have Jerusalem surrounded.

Stop here and look at a map that shows the locations of Judah, Assyria, Jerusalem, and Lachish. Pause this audio here.

It must have been terrifying for the people of Judah to think the Assyrian army was very close to surrounding the people. The Assyrian army was very cruel. But even though the Assyrian army was powerful, it would still be easier for Sennacherib if King Hezekiah and the people of Judah just surrendered. To surrender means to give up or to stop fighting and allow the other side to win. Leaders sometimes chose to do this if they thought their army had no chance to win. Sennacherib probably sends his messages to Hezekiah and the people of Judah to convince the people to give up without fighting.

Stop here and tell a story about someone who decided to give up without fighting. How did that decision benefit people? How did that decision harm people? Do you think the person was wise or unwise to give up? Pause this audio here.

In those days, many people believed that the gods of their country, the spirits of their ancestors, or other local spirits were supposed to protect the people in their country. People believed that if two countries fought each other, the country with the stronger gods, ancestors, or spirits would win. This is probably one reason why many people groups worshipped many gods, spirits, and the spirits of ancestors. People believed that if they worshipped more spiritual beings, those beings would fight for the people. Sennacherib strongly believes that his gods are stronger than Yahweh, Judah's God.

Stop here and discuss these questions: In your culture, how common is it for people to believe in other gods besides Yahweh? What kinds of things do people believe the false gods do? How common is it for people to believe that some false gods are more powerful than others? Pause this audio here.

In those days, many people also believed that the more high places, altars, and idols people built for their false gods, the happier those false gods would be. So Sennacherib thought that Hezekiah offended Yahweh when Hezekiah tore down all of the high places and altars in Judah, except for the altar in the house of Yahweh. Sennacherib did not understand that Yahweh wanted only one altar, in the house of Yahweh in Jerusalem.

Stop here and discuss these questions: How common is it in your culture for people to believe that other gods want many altars, shrines, or temples? How might people feel if someone damaged or destroyed those places? Pause this audio here.

Sennacherib's messengers delivered this first message, but the message did not cause King Hezekiah to surrender. So, Sennacherib wrote letters to Hezekiah and the people of Judah. These letters contained the same message. Sennacherib said, "The gods of the other nations could not save them from me, and your God, Yahweh, cannot save you either." The storyteller points out Sennacherib's key mistake: Sennacherib thinks that Yahweh, the God of Jerusalem, is exactly like the gods of the other peoples. Sennacherib does not realize that Yahweh is the one true God.

Stop here and talk about how Yahweh, the one true God, is different from the false gods or spirits that the people in your area worship. Pause this audio here.

After Sennacherib insulted Yahweh, King Hezekiah and Isaiah the prophet prayed to heaven about the situation. Heaven is the place where Yahweh lives, so this is another way to say that Hezekiah and Isaiah prayed to Yahweh. Isaiah was one of the most important prophets in the history of Israel and Judah. The relationship between King Hezekiah and Isaiah was good. Yahweh responded to Hezekiah and Isaiah's prayers and sent a messenger to help Hezekiah and the people of Judah. Most people call this kind of messenger from Yahweh an angel. An angel is a supernatural being who does what Yahweh wants.

Stop here and discuss these questions: How common is it in your culture for people to believe in angels? What do people believe about angels? What do people believe that angels do? Pause this audio here.

The angel that Yahweh sent killed all the mighty warriors, commanders, and officers in the Assyrian army. Because of this, Sennacherib left and went back to his own country in disgrace. Later, Sennacherib's own sons murdered Sennacherib. Yahweh not only saved King Hezekiah and the people of Judah from the Assyrian army but also

from all others who could be a threat to the people of Judah. For the rest of Hezekiah's lifetime, the people of Judah lived in peace.

Stop here and tell some stories about a time when your people were worried that something bad might happen to your people, but it did not happen. This could be a story of a time you thought that an army might attack your people; that a natural disaster like a flood, fire, drought, or a bad storm might come; or perhaps you feared that many people might get sick and die. What did your people do to prepare for the bad thing? Do you know why the bad thing never happened? How would your lives be different if the bad thing had happened? Pause this audio here.

After Sennacherib left Judah, people brought offerings to Jerusalem for Yahweh and gifts, or valuable items, for King Hezekiah. We are not sure if these people were all from Judah or if some of these people came from other countries. At the end of this story, the storyteller says that people in other nations honored and admired King Hezekiah, so it is possible that some of these people came from other nations. The people who lived in countries like Moab, Ammon, and Edom were also very afraid of the Assyrian army, and their leaders were probably very happy to hear that the entire Assyrian army died in Judah.

Stop here and tell stories about a time when your people celebrated something good that happened. This good thing could be anything, such as a good harvest, a victory in a sport, the end of a war, the end of a drought, the election of a leader, or anything else that was good for your community. What did you do to celebrate this good thing? How did any of the people who live around you react or join in the celebration?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 32:9–23 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: Sennacherib sends messengers to Jerusalem to tell Hezekiah and the people that Yahweh cannot save them from Sennacherib's attack.

In the second scene: Sennacherib writes letters with the same message. Sennacherib's servants read the letters out loud near the walls of Jerusalem, where all the people of Jerusalem could hear.

In scene three: King Hezekiah and Isaiah the prophet pray to Yahweh, and Yahweh saves Jerusalem. Sennacherib leaves Judah. People bring gifts to Yahweh and Hezekiah.

The characters in this passage are:

- Sennacherib, King of Assyria
- Sennacherib's messengers
- The Assyrian army
- King Hezekiah
- The people of Jerusalem
- Yahweh
- Isaiah the prophet
- The angel of Yahweh
- Sennacherib's sons
- And the people who brought gifts to Yahweh and Hezekiah

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

The first scene takes place after Hezekiah spoke to the people of Jerusalem to encourage the people. At this time, Sennacherib and his army were besieging the city of Lachish. You will remember that a siege happens when an army attacks a city with tall walls and the people of the city go inside and close the gates. The army surrounds the city so that the people inside cannot get out to get food and water. Armies in ancient times used sieges to conquer cities quite often.

Sennacherib did not go to Jerusalem himself. Sennacherib probably stayed near Lachish and sent messengers or government officials to give King Hezekiah a message. But Sennacherib also wanted all the people of Judah to hear Sennacherib's message. Sennacherib's messengers begin the message with a special statement to show that the words that come after are King Sennacherib's exact words.

Stop here and discuss these questions: In your language, how do you show that a messenger is saying the exact words that someone else told the messenger to say? Could you use any of these here? Pause this audio here.

Most of the statements in Sennacherib's message are questions that no one expects anyone to answer, or questions that everyone already knows the answer to. Remember that people in Bible times used these kinds of questions to emphasize something important. Each question in Sennacherib's message was intended to mock, insult, and frighten Judah's people, King Hezekiah, and Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss these questions: Are there any special ways you can use your language to insult someone, mock someone, or frighten someone? Could you use any of these in this scene? Pause this audio here.

The first question in Sennacherib's message is, "What are you trusting in that makes you think you can survive under siege in Jerusalem?" This question means something like, "It is foolish that you think you can survive under siege in Jerusalem."

Stop here and discuss how you will say Sennacherib's first question in your language. Pause this audio here.

The second question in Sennacherib's message is long and includes a quotation of something Hezekiah said. Sennacherib says, "Is not Hezekiah misleading you, so that you will die from hunger and thirst, when Hezekiah says, 'Yahweh our God will save us from the attack by the King of Assyria'?" Sennacherib's first claim is that Hezekiah is misleading the people of Jerusalem. Sennacherib also says that the result of Hezekiah's misleading the people is that the people will die of hunger and thirst. It was common that if an attacking army laid siege to a city, the people inside the city died of hunger and thirst. So what Sennacherib said was a very real threat.

There are several ways you could communicate this sentence's meaning. You could say something like, "Hezekiah is misleading you when Hezekiah says that Yahweh your God will save you from the King of Assyria. As a result, you will die of hunger and thirst." In the original language, the greatest emphasis is on the statement "Hezekiah is misleading you." Sennacherib wants the people inside Jerusalem to stop trusting their king and to feel afraid that the people will die of hunger and thirst.

Stop here and discuss how you will say Sennacherib's second question. Pause this audio here.

The third question in Sennacherib's message is also long and includes a quotation of something Hezekiah said. Sennacherib says, "Was it not Hezekiah himself who removed Yahweh's high places and altars and then told the people of Judah and Jerusalem, 'You must worship before one altar and burn incense on it?'" Sennacherib does not mean that Hezekiah personally went around the land and removed every altar and high place. Rather, Sennacherib means that Hezekiah told the people to go all over the land and remove the high places and altars, and because Hezekiah was the king, the people obeyed Hezekiah. Sennacherib blames Hezekiah for this. Sennacherib thinks that Yahweh will be angry that Hezekiah told the people to remove all the high places and altars, and that the people could only worship and burn incense in front of the altar in the house of Yahweh. Sennacherib does not realize that Hezekiah was actually obeying Yahweh when Hezekiah did these things.

For the first part of this statement, you could say something like, "Hezekiah is the one who was responsible for removing Yahweh's high places and altars." For the second part of this statement, you could say something like, "Hezekiah is the one who told the people of Judah and Jerusalem that you may only worship in front of one altar and burn incense on it."

Stop here and discuss how you will say Sennacherib's third question. Pause this audio here.

The fourth question in Sennacherib's message is shorter and simpler. Sennacherib says, "Do you not know what my fathers and I did to all the people of other lands?" When Sennacherib says "My fathers," Sennacherib means "my ancestors" or "my predecessors," who were Assyria's previous kings. When Sennacherib says "all the people of other lands," Sennacherib means the people who lived in the countries that the Assyrian army had already conquered. This question means something like, "You should know what my fathers and I did to all the people of other lands," or possibly, "You are stupid if you do not know what my fathers and I did to other lands."

Stop here and discuss how you will say Sennacherib's fourth question. Pause this audio here.

The fifth question in Sennacherib's message is, "Were the gods of the nations of the lands at all able to rescue their land out of my hand?" This question means, "The gods that those people worshipped were not able to do anything to save their land from me." The word "nations" means people groups other than the people of Judah. In this question, Sennacherib emphasizes that the gods of the other nations were not able to do even one very small thing to save their land from the Assyrian army.

Stop here and discuss how you will say Sennacherib's fifth question. Pause this audio here.

The sixth question in Sennacherib's message is similar to the fifth question. Sennacherib says, "Who among all the gods of these nations—which my fathers completely destroyed—could rescue his people from my hand?" This question means, "None of the gods of those nations could save the people from my power—my ancestors completely destroyed those people."

Stop here and discuss how you will say Sennacherib's sixth question. How will you make it different from the fifth question? Pause this audio here.

The seventh question in Sennacherib's message is, "How much less is your God able to rescue you from my hand?" This question means, "Your God will not be able to save you from me either."

Stop here and discuss how you will say Sennacherib's seventh question. Pause this audio here.

Finally, Sennacherib stops using questions that everyone already knows the answer to. Now, in his message, Sennacherib just says what Sennacherib wants the people of Jerusalem to do. First, Sennacherib uses a word that means "because of the things I just said, this is what you should do."

Stop here and discuss what words you have in your language that mean "because of the things I just said, this is what you should do." Pause this audio here.

Sennacherib tells the people of Jerusalem not to let Hezekiah deceive or mislead the people. "Deceive," or "lie," and "mislead" have very similar meanings, but the storyteller uses two words for emphasis. Unless it is very unnatural in your language to use two words with a similar meaning, we recommend that you use two words here to emphasize what Sennacherib says Hezekiah is doing to Hezekiah's people.

Stop here and discuss how you will describe what Sennacherib says Hezekiah is doing to Hezekiah's people. Pause this audio here.

Next, Sennacherib says, "Do not believe him." Sennacherib is talking about Hezekiah. Sennacherib says the people should not believe Hezekiah because no god of any nation or kingdom has ever been able to save people from the power of the kings of Assyria. When Sennacherib says "god" here, Sennacherib is not talking about Yahweh, the one true God. Sennacherib is talking about the false gods that the other people worshipped. "Nations" means people groups, but a "kingdom" means a territory that a king rules over. A kingdom at that time was more like a country is now.

The final statement in Sennacherib's message is, "How much less will your God rescue you from my hand!" This statement means something like, "Your God is not able to save you from my attack either."

Stop here and discuss how you will say Sennacherib's final statement. Pause this audio here.

At the end of scene one, Sennacherib's servants, or messengers, speak against Yahweh God, and against Yahweh's servant Hezekiah. To speak against someone means to say bad things about that person, or to say things that are not true. Sennacherib's messengers say bad things about both Yahweh and Hezekiah.

Stop here and discuss these questions: In your language, how do you say that someone said bad things or untrue things about another person? Which of these could you use here to say that Sennacherib's servants spoke against Yahweh and Hezekiah? Pause this audio here.

In the second scene, Sennacherib writes letters to insult Yahweh, the God of Israel. Once again, Sennacherib tries to convince the people in Jerusalem that Yahweh cannot save the people from the Assyrian army. Although the storyteller does not say so, it sounds like Sennacherib's messengers read the letters out loud from a place very close to the wall of Jerusalem. Sennacherib's messengers were close enough that the fighters who were

standing on top of the wall could hear what Sennacherib's messengers said. And Sennacherib's messengers used the language of Judah when they read the letters out loud.

In ancient times, people built walls around their cities to protect the city and the people inside. These walls were not like the walls of a house or a hut. People built the walls very thick and very tall. One ancient wall near Jerusalem was seven meters thick! On the inside, people built stairs so that soldiers could go to the top of the wall. It was not uncommon for people to stand or sit on the wall around the city to witness important events taking place on the ground below. If an army was attacking the city, soldiers could stand on the wall to shoot arrows or throw things at enemy soldiers outside the wall.

Stop here and look at a picture that shows soldiers standing on a city wall. Then discuss how you will make it clear to your hearers that these city walls were not like the walls of a house or a hut, but were very tall and thick and able to support many people standing on the walls. Pause this audio here.

Sennacherib says, "The gods of the nations of the lands have not rescued their people from my hand, or power." Sennacherib is once again talking about the false gods that the people who lived in the countries all around Judah worshipped. Sennacherib calls Yahweh "the God of Hezekiah." This means that Yahweh was the God whom Hezekiah worshipped. The storyteller also calls Yahweh "the God of Jerusalem." This could mean "the God that the people in Jerusalem worshipped," or "the God whose temple is in Jerusalem," or "the God who rules over Jerusalem."

Stop here and discuss how you will say "the God of Jerusalem" in your language. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller calls false gods "the work of men's hands" or "idols made by human hands." In this statement, the word "men" means human beings. This is a way to say that the false gods are not the one true Creator God. People used their hands to carve wood or stone images and called those images gods, but those images are not really gods.

Stop here and discuss how you could describe the false gods in your language to show that they are not real but made by human beings. Pause this audio here.

In the third scene, King Hezekiah and Isaiah the prophet cry out to heaven in prayer. "Cry out to heaven" is another way to say that Hezekiah and Isaiah prayed to Yahweh. Yahweh responds to Hezekiah and Isaiah's prayers and sends an angel to help them. This angel, or messenger, has supernatural power.

The angel of Yahweh destroys, or kills, every mighty warrior, commander, and officer in the camp of the king of Assyria. This means that the angel killed all the leaders and the best fighters in the Assyrian army. So Sennacherib returned in disgrace, or shame, to Sennacherib's own land. There were many reasons for Sennacherib to feel disgraced. Sennacherib's army was not able to conquer Jerusalem. All of Sennacherib's soldiers died. The Assyrian people may very well have wondered how anyone could lose an entire army. Sennacherib probably felt embarrassed, confused, and afraid.

Stop here and discuss how you will say that Sennacherib returned home in disgrace. Pause this audio here.

The Assyrian people worshipped many gods and built temples for those gods. One day, Sennacherib was worshipping in the house, or temple, of Sennacherib's god. Some of Sennacherib's own children came into the temple and struck Sennacherib down with swords. This means that Sennacherib's children killed Sennacherib by stabbing Sennacherib with swords. In the original language, the storyteller uses a special phrase for Sennacherib's children. The storyteller calls the children "those who came from his inner parts." This phrase emphasizes that the children came from Sennacherib's body.

Stop here and discuss these questions: In your language, what words or phrases do you have for children that emphasize that those children come from the father's body? Could you use any of these phrases here? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller finishes the story by saying that this is how Yahweh saved Hezekiah and the people of Jerusalem from Sennacherib and from the hand, or power, of all others. This means that no one else was able to frighten or threaten the people of Judah again during Hezekiah's lifetime.

The next statement about Yahweh is hard to understand in the original language. Some people think the statement means that Yahweh allowed the people of Judah to be at rest, or at peace, during this time. It is

possible that the storyteller says the same thing in two different ways for emphasis. However, some people think this statement means that Yahweh guided Hezekiah and the people in every way. Yahweh made sure that Hezekiah and the people of Judah made the right decisions and were successful. And some other people think that this means that Yahweh provided in every way for Hezekiah and the people of Judah. Yahweh made sure that Hezekiah and the people had everything they needed. We recommend that you either say that Yahweh guided Hezekiah and the people in every way or that Yahweh provided for Hezekiah and the people in every way.

Stop here and decide how you will say that Yahweh guided Hezekiah and the people in every way or that Yahweh provided for Hezekiah and the people in every way. Pause this audio here.

Finally, the people bring gifts, or valuable items, for Yahweh and Hezekiah. It is not clear whether the storyteller means that the people of Judah brought these gifts or if people from other nations also brought gifts. The people of all nations did have great esteem or respect for King Hezekiah.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 32:9–23 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Sennacherib, king of Assyria
- Sennacherib's messengers
- The Assyrian army
- King Hezekiah
- The people of Jerusalem
- Yahweh
- Isaiah the prophet
- The angel of Yahweh
- Sennacherib's sons
- And the people who brought gifts to Yahweh and Hezekiah

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Later, when Sennacherib and his army were laying siege to the fortified city of Lachish, Sennacherib sent messengers to Jerusalem with a message for Hezekiah, the king of Judah and for all the people of Judah who were in Jerusalem. The message from King Sennacherib of Assyria said: "It is foolish that you think you can survive under siege in Jerusalem! Hezekiah is misleading you when Hezekiah says that Yahweh your God will save you from the king of Assyria. Instead, you will die of hunger and thirst! Hezekiah is the one who made you destroy Yahweh's high places and altars. And Hezekiah is the one who told you, people of Judah and Jerusalem, that you may only worship in front of one altar and burn incense on it."

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Sennacherib, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I know I can conquer Jerusalem, but it would be easier if the people in the city just gave up. I will try to scare the people into surrender; or
- Hezekiah made a big mistake when Hezekiah destroyed all the high places and altars of his God, except for one. Hezekiah’s God must be very angry with Hezekiah; or
- I feel certain that this is going to be an easy victory.

Ask the people playing Sennacherib’s messengers, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The people might answer things like:

- We are enjoying speaking our king’s message to Hezekiah and the people in Jerusalem; or
- We feel powerful. Our army has defeated so many people, we do not have to worry about losing; or
- This message must really make the people inside Jerusalem feel afraid! The people should just give up now; or
- We do not understand why any king would destroy all the high places and altars of that king’s god except for one.

Ask the person playing Hezekiah, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- Sennacherib thinks that just because he conquered other lands, that means Sennacherib can conquer Yahweh’s land. Sennacherib is wrong; or
- I know Yahweh will protect us, but the way this arrogant man talks about Yahweh makes me feel angry! or
- I am confident that Yahweh will help us, but what if the people believe the things that Sennacherib is saying?

Ask the people playing the people of Judah in Jerusalem, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The people might answer things like:

- We have confidence that Yahweh will do something to save us from the Assyrian army; or
- We feel nervous. What if Sennacherib is right? or
- If the Assyrian army captures Lachish, we will be trapped. We will not be able to get away from Sennacherib; or
- Sennacherib is foolish. Sennacherib does not understand that when we destroyed all the high places and altars, it made Yahweh happy, not angry.

Continue the drama.

Sennacherib’s message continued: “Surely you know what my fathers and I did to all the people of other lands. The gods of those people were not able to do one thing to save their land from our armies. None of the gods of those nations could stop me from taking over their country. My ancestors completely destroyed those nations. And your God will not be able to save you from me either. Therefore, do not let Hezekiah deceive or mislead you. Do not believe what Hezekiah says, for no god of any people or kingdom has ever been able to save people from what the kings of Assyria want to do to them. Your god is not able to save you either.” And Sennacherib’s messengers said more vile things about Yahweh God and about Yahweh’s servant Hezekiah.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Sennacherib, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- My ancestors and I killed the people of many other nations. These people of Judah can never win against us; or
- If Hezekiah is smart, he will surrender. If Hezekiah is not smart, then we will show Hezekiah who has the more powerful army; or
- Yahweh, the God of Israel, cannot do anything to me. I am more powerful! or
- I am looking forward to marching into Jerusalem and capturing the city.

Ask the people playing Sennacherib’s messengers, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The people might answer things like:

- We feel relieved that we are on the side of the strongest army; or
- The people of Jerusalem are not very smart if they do not surrender to us; or
- If the people of Jerusalem do not give up, we will just kill them all.

Ask the person playing Hezekiah, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I feel angry that Sennacherib said that I am lying to my own people; or
- I am a little worried that my own people might feel afraid of the Assyrian army; or
- I am looking forward to seeing how Yahweh saves us from this situation.

Ask the people playing the people of Judah and Jerusalem, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The people might answer things like:

- We really hope that Yahweh saves us! or
- Hezekiah told us to be brave. We have to do what our king told us to do; or
- With Yahweh on our side, we can defeat the Assyrian army.

Continue the drama.

King Sennacherib also wrote letters to insult Yahweh, the God of Israel, and to lie about Yahweh. Sennacherib’s letters said, “Just like the gods of the other people have not saved their people from my power, so the God that Hezekiah worships will not save you either.” Sennacherib’s messengers shouted these things in the language of Judah to the people of Jerusalem who were standing on Jerusalem’s wall. Sennacherib’s messengers did this to frighten and terrify the people of Jerusalem, so that it would be easier to capture Jerusalem. Sennacherib’s messengers spoke about the God who lives in Jerusalem as if God were just like one of the pagan gods that humans made with their hands.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Sennacherib, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- Hezekiah is foolish to not surrender. I will give Hezekiah one more warning; or
- Why do the people of Jerusalem continue to trust in their God? The people should know I will destroy them if the people do not give in; or
- I feel a little unhappy that King Hezekiah has not surrendered yet.

Ask the people playing Sennacherib’s messengers, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The people might answer things like:

- The people of Jerusalem should not believe that their god can save them from us; or
- Hezekiah should know better than to get his people into an impossible fight; or
- We are content to wait for our king to come and conquer this city.

Ask the people playing the people of Judah and Jerusalem, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The people might answer things like:

- The Assyrians are speaking about Yahweh as if Yahweh were one of the false gods of our neighbors. The Assyrians have no idea what Yahweh is really like; or
- We hope that Yahweh will do something amazing, and then these Assyrians will see that Yahweh is more powerful than they are; or
- We feel nervous. Hezekiah says that Yahweh will protect us, but what if Yahweh does not?

Continue the drama.

Then King Hezekiah and the prophet Isaiah, son of Amoz, prayed to God in heaven and cried out to God for help. So Yahweh sent an angel who killed all the mighty soldiers and officers in the Assyrian army. So Sennacherib was forced to return to his own land in disgrace. Later, when Sennacherib went into the house of his god, some of Sennacherib’s own sons killed Sennacherib with swords. This is how Yahweh rescued Hezekiah and the people of Jerusalem from King Sennacherib of Assyria and from all the others who threatened them. And Yahweh provided for the people in every way. Many people came to Jerusalem and brought gifts for Yahweh and for King Hezekiah. From then on, the people in all the surrounding nations highly respected King Hezekiah.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Hezekiah, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I feel angry that Sennacherib insulted Yahweh! I want Yahweh to do something to Sennacherib; or
- This is a bad situation. I should get a prophet to help me; or
- I do not want to listen to Sennacherib's insults anymore. I want Yahweh to make the Assyrian army leave; or
- I hope that Yahweh will show everyone just how powerful Yahweh is!

Ask the person playing Isaiah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Sennacherib does not understand who Yahweh is. Sennacherib is in for a big surprise; or
- I feel angry that Sennacherib is threatening our people; or
- I feel confident that Yahweh will protect us; or
- This is an opportunity for Yahweh to show the whole world how powerful Yahweh is!

Ask the person playing the angel, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Now Sennacherib will see how powerful Yahweh, the God of Israel, is; or
- Yahweh told me to kill the soldiers. I am glad to do it so I can protect the people of Jerusalem; or
- It is sad that so many people have to die, but I must kill these soldiers to protect the people of Judah!

Ask the person playing Sennacherib, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel terrified! All my soldiers and leaders are dead! or
- This is the worst thing that has ever happened to me; or
- The people will think that I am a terrible military commander and a terrible king! I might not be safe anymore.

Ask the people playing Sennacherib's sons, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- Our father got an entire army killed. Our father must have done something really bad; or
- If we allow our father to live, the entire country will be weak; or
- It would probably be better if someone other than our father were leading the country.

Ask the people playing the people of Jerusalem, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We are amazed that Yahweh killed the entire Assyrian army; or
- We are grateful that Yahweh did such an amazing miracle to save us; or
- After this, we know that we can trust Yahweh in any situation! or
- King Hezekiah was right about Yahweh! Yahweh really is more powerful than all the other gods!

Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Now the Assyrians know that there is no one like me, Yahweh, in all the earth; or
- This will help the people of Jerusalem to understand how important they are to me; or
- I am glad that there is no one left to threaten the people of Judah and Jerusalem; or
- Now the people of Judah will be able to live in peace.

Ask the people playing the people who brought gifts, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We do not know how Hezekiah made the Assyrians run away. Hezekiah's God must be very powerful; or
- We are happy that the Assyrian army is no longer a threat; or
- Hezekiah must be a wise and powerful king. We will show Hezekiah that we want to be on good terms with Hezekiah; or
- King Hezekiah was right about Yahweh! We will bring some gifts to Yahweh in Jerusalem.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 32:9–23 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Afterward, **King** Sennacherib of Assyria sent some servants, or military officers, to **Jerusalem** while Sennacherib and his army were laying **siege** to Lachish. The storyteller calls King Sennacherib's military officers his "servants," but you should use whatever term you have been using for military officers here. Sennacherib sent a message for Hezekiah, the King of **Judah** and for all the people of Judah who were in Jerusalem. Be sure to use the same words for siege, Jerusalem, king, and Judah that you used in previous stories. See the Master Glossary for more information on siege, Jerusalem, king, and Judah.

This is what King Sennacherib of Assyria said: "You should not trust that you can survive under siege in Jerusalem! Hezekiah is misleading you, so that you will die of hunger and thirst, saying, '**Yahweh** our **God** will save us from the power of king of **Assyria**.' Hezekiah himself destroyed Yahweh's **high places** and **altars** and told you, people of Judah and Jerusalem, 'You may only **worship** in front of one altar and burn **incense** on it.'" Be sure to use the same words for Assyria, Yahweh, God, high place, altar, worship, and incense that you used in previous stories. See the Master Glossary for more information on Yahweh, God, altar, and worship.

"Surely you know what my ancestors and I did to all the people of other lands. The **gods** of the **nations** were completely unable to save their people from my **hand**, or power." Be sure to use the same words for gods and nations that you used in previous stories. See the Master Glossary for more information on gods and nations. You will remember that in this culture, people used the idea of hands to represent power. Use the same phrase for "hand" or power here that you have used previously.

Sennacherib continued and said, "Therefore, do not let Hezekiah deceive or mislead you like this. Do not believe what Hezekiah says, for no god of any nation or **kingdom** has ever been able to save people from either me or my predecessors." Use the same word for kingdom that you have used previously. For more information, refer to kingdom in the Master Glossary.

King Sennacherib also wrote letters to insult Yahweh, the God of **Israel**, and to speak against Yahweh. Be sure to use the same word for Israel that you used in previous stories. See the Master Glossary for more information on Israel.

Sennacherib's messengers shouted in Hebrew, the language of Judah, to the people of Jerusalem who were standing on the wall of Jerusalem. Then King Hezekiah and the **prophet Isaiah**, son of Amoz, **prayed** and cried out to **heaven**. Be sure to use the same words for prophet, Isaiah, pray and heaven as you did in previous stories. See the Master Glossary for more information on prophet, pray and heaven.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will say that the messengers shouted in the language of the people of Judah. You may say that the messengers shouted in **Hebrew**, or you may say that the messengers shouted in the language that the people of Judah spoke. For more information about Hebrew, refer to the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

So Yahweh sent an **angel** who killed every mighty warrior, commander, and officer in the camp of the king of Assyria. So Sennacherib was forced to return to his own land in disgrace. Be sure to use the same word for angel that you used in previous stories. See the Master Glossary for more information on angel.

Later, when Sennacherib went into the house of his god, some of Sennacherib's own sons, those who came from his inner parts, killed Sennacherib with swords.

Stop here and decide how you will say "sons, or those who came from his inner parts." Pause this audio here.

This is how Yahweh rescued Hezekiah and the people of Jerusalem from the attack of King Sennacherib of Assyria and from all the others who threatened them. And Yahweh guided the people in every way. Many people came to Jerusalem and brought **offerings**, or gifts, for Yahweh and valuable gifts for King Hezekiah. From then on, the people in all the surrounding nations greatly respected King Hezekiah. If you use the word for offerings for Yahweh, refer to offerings in the Master Glossary for more information.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

2 Chronicles 32:9–23

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (594 KB)
- Setting the Stage (4.1 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (9.0 MB)
- Embodying the Text (6.7 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.4 MB)
- Speaking the Word (798 KB)

2 Chronicles 32:24–33

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 32:24–33 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 32:24–33 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 32:24–33 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous story, King Sennacherib of Assyria invaded Judah and threatened to destroy Jerusalem. But King Hezekiah and Isaiah the prophet prayed to Yahweh, and Yahweh saved Judah from Sennacherib. In this story, Hezekiah almost dies from an illness, but Yahweh gives him a miraculous sign and heals Hezekiah. Then Yahweh blesses Hezekiah and makes him very rich. After Hezekiah dies, Hezekiah's son Manasseh becomes the next king.

If you have already translated the book of 2 Kings, then you have already translated one version of this story. If the book of 2 Kings is available in your language, stop here and listen to 2 Kings chapter 20 to help you remember the events of that story. Pause this audio here.

Hezekiah becomes very sick around the same time that King Sennacherib invades Judah. The king and the people are probably very afraid. The people of Judah need a strong leader to help them survive Sennacherib's attack. But Hezekiah is so sick that everyone thinks Hezekiah might die. However, Hezekiah prays to Yahweh, and Yahweh speaks to Hezekiah. Yahweh gives Hezekiah a miraculous sign, then Hezekiah recovers from his illness.

Stop here and tell a story about a miracle you have witnessed. What was happening when the miracle occurred? How did the people involved feel about it? What might have happened if this miracle had not taken place? Pause this audio here.

But even though Yahweh gives Hezekiah a miraculous sign and heals Hezekiah, Hezekiah does not respond in the right way. This is because Hezekiah is proud. Because Hezekiah is proud and ungrateful, Yahweh becomes angry at Hezekiah and the people of Judah.

Stop here and tell a story about a person who received a gift or a blessing but was not grateful. How do you describe the attitude of the person who was ungrateful? Pause this audio here.

However, when Hezekiah realizes that Yahweh is angry, Hezekiah does the wise thing and humbles himself. Humble means the opposite of proud. Hezekiah shows Yahweh that Hezekiah is not proud anymore. The people of Judah also humble themselves and show Yahweh that the people are sorry. So Yahweh is no longer angry at Hezekiah and the people, and Yahweh does not punish Hezekiah and the people of Judah while Hezekiah is still alive.

Next, the storyteller explains that Hezekiah became richer and more famous. The people highly honor Hezekiah. The storyteller explains that Hezekiah has so many valuable things that Hezekiah has to build special buildings to keep his possessions in. Hezekiah owns a great deal of silver, gold, precious stones, spices, shields, and other items.

Stop here and discuss these questions: What material goods do your people think are the most valuable? Where do your people keep the most valuable goods? Who owns the goods that your people think are very valuable? Pause this audio here.

Hezekiah also builds storehouses for extra grain, wine, and oil. Hezekiah probably stores these food and drink items to use in case drought, famine, or attacks by an enemy cause Hezekiah's country to run out of those things.

Stop here and discuss these questions: How often do your people have extra food available? When you have extra food, what do you do with that food? If drought or famine happens, how do you make sure that your people will have enough food? Pause this audio here.

Hezekiah builds stalls for his cattle and pens for his flocks of sheep. While cattle and sheep can live in the open fields quite well, people can protect their cattle and sheep by putting them in a stall or a pen. This kind of stall for cattle had a fence around it and a roof over it. The roof could protect the cattle from bad weather and provide shade during hot weather. A pen was a fenced area for sheep that was not covered by a roof. The pen kept all the sheep in one place. Hezekiah builds new stalls and pens because Hezekiah has so many flocks and herds of animals.

Stop here and discuss this question: In your area, what makes a person rich? What kind of things do rich people gather, such as money, land, or animals? Pause this audio here.

Hezekiah changes the flow of the waters of the Gihon spring so the water comes inside Jerusalem. A spring is a place where fresh water bubbles up from under the ground. In a hot and dry place like Jerusalem, it was very important for people to make sure they had access to water. During the dry season, other sources of water dried up, but the waters of Gihon kept flowing. So the Gihon spring was the most important source of water for people in Jerusalem.

Stop here and look at a map that shows the city of Jerusalem and the location of the Gihon spring. Pause this audio here.

2 Chronicles 32:24–33

In Hezekiah's time, the Gihon spring was located outside Jerusalem's city walls. If an enemy came and attacked Jerusalem from that direction, the people of Jerusalem would not be able to get water. Hezekiah realizes this is a problem, so Hezekiah stops up one part of the spring and orders his workers to dig an underground tunnel to bring water from the spring into the city. The tunnel was more than half a kilometer long and went through the rock underneath Jerusalem. The water flowed down through the tunnel and into a pool inside Jerusalem.

Stop here and discuss these questions: In your area, how do people get water? What might happen if your people could no longer get water in this way? Pause this audio here.

King Hezekiah is successful in everything he does. But one time, God tests Hezekiah. After God gives Hezekiah a miraculous sign, people in other countries hear about it. Some officials from Babylon come to ask Hezekiah about the miraculous sign. The storyteller says that at that moment, God leaves Hezekiah. This means that God does not tell Hezekiah what to do but lets Hezekiah make his own choices. God wants to see what Hezekiah will do without God's help. Sadly, as you may remember from listening to this story in 2 Kings chapter 20, Hezekiah makes a foolish choice. This choice shows what is really in Hezekiah's heart. Remember, the Israelites believed that a person's actions show what is inside that person's heart—if your heart is good, your actions will be good, but if your heart is bad, your actions will be bad.

Stop here and tell a story about someone who did something that showed that his heart was good or that his heart was bad. What did other people think when they saw the way that person acted? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller ends this story by telling the audience that they can find other stories about Hezekiah in other books, or scrolls. The name of one book, or scroll, is "The History of the Kings of Judah and Israel." The name of the other book is "The Vision of the Prophet Isaiah, son of Amoz." Some Bible scholars think these are two different books. But some Bible scholars think that "The Vision of the Prophet Isaiah" might be a smaller book that is part of "The History of the Kings of Judah and Israel." Nobody knows where these books are now. After Hezekiah died, the people buried Hezekiah in the tombs of David's descendants. Then Hezekiah's son Manasseh became the next king.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 32:24–33 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four scenes.

In the first scene: Yahweh heals Hezekiah from a deadly illness. At first, Hezekiah is not grateful for this healing, and Yahweh becomes angry. But Hezekiah repents of his pride, and Yahweh is no longer angry.

In the second scene: The storyteller describes how wealthy Hezekiah was. Hezekiah builds an underground tunnel so that water can flow from the Gihon spring into the city of Jerusalem.

In the third scene: Some ambassadors from Babylon visit Hezekiah, and God withdraws from Hezekiah in order to test Hezekiah.

In the fourth scene: Hezekiah dies, and the people bury Hezekiah in the royal tombs. Hezekiah's son Manasseh becomes the next king of Judah.

The characters in this passage are:

- Hezekiah
- Yahweh
- The people of Judah and Jerusalem
- The Babylonian ambassadors
- And Manasseh, Hezekiah's son

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

The events of the first scene happen around the same time as the Assyrian invasion of Judah. Hezekiah became very sick. Hezekiah was so sick that his family and servants were afraid that Hezekiah was going to die.

Stop here and discuss this question: In your language, how do you talk about a person who is so sick that they might die from the illness? Which of these words or expressions could you use here? Pause this audio here.

Hezekiah prayed to Yahweh, and Yahweh spoke to Hezekiah. Yahweh gave Hezekiah a miraculous sign. A sign is something unusual that is happening for a special reason. A sign can be something supernatural, like a miracle, or a sign can be something natural that happens after Yahweh told someone it was going to happen. If you have already translated the book of 2 Kings, then you have already translated the story of Hezekiah's illness and recovery and chosen a word for "sign."

Stop here and listen again to the beginning of 2 Kings chapter 20, if it is available in your language. Pay close attention to the word you used for "sign." Pause this audio here.

The storyteller assumes that the listener understands that the miraculous sign meant that Hezekiah would get well. The rest of the story shows that Hezekiah did get well and lived for many more years. But in some languages, it might be awkward to not say that the sign meant that Hezekiah would get well. It might also be awkward to not say that Hezekiah recovered from the illness. It is an acceptable translation choice to include this information in the story.

Stop here and discuss these questions: For your listeners, would it be better to say that God sent the sign to let Hezekiah know that Hezekiah would get well? Would it be better to say that Hezekiah did get well? Or would it be better to leave these things unsaid? Pause this audio here.

Next, the storyteller says that Hezekiah did not respond appropriately to the kind thing that Yahweh had done for Hezekiah. Hezekiah was ungrateful, even though Yahweh had saved Hezekiah from death.

Stop here and discuss these questions: Think of all the words or phrases you can to describe a person who is ungrateful for the good things they have. Which of these could you use here to describe King Hezekiah? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller says that Hezekiah's heart was proud. Remember, the Israelites believed that a person feels and thinks things in his heart. So this phrase simply means that Hezekiah was proud. Because Hezekiah was proud, Yahweh's wrath was against Hezekiah and the people of Judah and Jerusalem. Wrath is very strong anger, and wrath is Yahweh's response to sin. Yahweh was angry because Hezekiah's proud attitude was sinful. The storyteller does not mention how King Hezekiah and the people living in Judah and Jerusalem knew that Yahweh was angry with them. The storyteller only says that Yahweh's wrath was against them.

Fortunately, Hezekiah realized that Yahweh was angry because of Hezekiah's pride. So Hezekiah humbled himself, and the people of Jerusalem did the same thing. This means that they realized that their pride was wrong and they stopped being proud. The storyteller does not describe how Hezekiah and the people of Jerusalem showed Yahweh that they were not proud anymore. The storyteller just tells us the result of their repentance. Yahweh was no longer angry with Hezekiah and the people of Judah, and Yahweh's wrath did not come on them while Hezekiah was still alive. For the rest of Hezekiah's life, there was peace and prosperity in Judah.

Stop here and discuss these questions: in your culture, how does a person show that he is not proud? How does a person show that he has repented when he realizes he has done something wrong? What words and phrases do you use to describe these situations? Could you use any of those words or phrases here? Pause this audio here.

In the second scene, the storyteller says that Hezekiah was very rich and became even more rich over the course of Hezekiah's life. The storyteller also tells us that the people felt great respect for Hezekiah.

Stop here and discuss these questions: in your language, how do you say that people feel a lot of respect for someone? How do you say that people give great honor to someone? Which of these words or phrases could you use here? Pause this audio here.

Hezekiah became very wealthy while he was king, and he needed buildings to store all the material goods he had. Hezekiah's workers built special buildings called storehouses or treasuries to keep his material goods in. In addition to silver, gold, precious stones, spices and shields, Hezekiah had many other valuable items. You will

remember that shields are large, flat items that soldiers use to protect themselves in battle, so these were very valuable to armies.

Stop here and remember your discussion in the previous step about the material goods that your people think are most valuable. What words or phrases do you use in your language to refer to valuable items as a group? Which of these could you use here? Pause this audio here.

Hezekiah also built special buildings to store extra grain, wine and oil. This shows that during Hezekiah's reign, Judah had many good harvests and had more grain, wine and oil than the people needed. Hezekiah stored this extra grain, wine and oil in case they needed it in the future.

Stop here and discuss these questions: in your language, what special words do you have for a building where people store extra food and drink? If you do not have a word for this, how could you describe this kind of building for your listeners? Pause this audio here.

In this scene, the storyteller uses a word that is not the usual word for "wine". Bible scholars think this word might mean "new wine" or "unfermented wine". You will remember that people make wine from squeezing the juice from grapes and letting the juice sit for some time so that it becomes fermented.

Hezekiah collected a large number of herds of cattle, or large animals like cows, bulls, and oxen, and flocks of sheep. He built stalls for his cattle and pens for his sheep.

Stop here and discuss these questions: what do you call a fenced-in area with a roof where people keep cattle? What do you call a fenced-in area where people keep sheep? If you do not have special words for these things, how can you describe them for your listeners? Pause this audio here.

Hezekiah also built new cities. Hezekiah might have built these cities for all the things mentioned in this scene: his treasuries and storehouses. Some Bible scholars also think Hezekiah might have built new cities to place soldiers near the treasuries, storehouses, herds and flocks in order to protect them.

King Hezekiah changed the flow of the waters of the Gihon spring so that the water would come inside the walls of Jerusalem.

Stop here and discuss these questions: what do you call a spring, or a place where water bubbles up from under the ground? If your language does not have a word for this, how can you describe this so your listeners will understand? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller emphasizes that it was Hezekiah's idea to do this, and that Hezekiah planned and carried out the building project. Hezekiah probably did not do the work himself, but he told his workers to dig the tunnel.

Stop here and discuss these questions: in your language, how do you emphasize that a particular person did something? How could you emphasize that it was Hezekiah who started and completed this building project? Pause this audio here.

The Gihon spring was on the east side of Jerusalem, outside the city walls. Hezekiah changed the direction of the water by stopping the water from flowing out on the east side of the city, and then Hezekiah's workers dug an underground tunnel to bring the water into the city.

Stop here and look at a picture of the tunnel that Hezekiah's workers dug through the rock under Jerusalem to bring water from the Gihon spring into the city. Pause this audio here.

In scene three, the princes, or rulers, of Babylon sent some officials to Jerusalem to ask Hezekiah about the wonder, or miracle, that had happened in the land. Remember, when Hezekiah was sick, Yahweh showed Hezekiah a miraculous sign to prove that Hezekiah would get well. "Wonder" and "miracle" are both different words for a sign. It is something that happened that was unusual and seemed impossible.

Stop here and discuss these questions: what words do you have in your language that have a similar meaning to "miracle" or "wonder"? Which of these could you use here? Pause this audio here.

When the storyteller says that God left Hezekiah, it does not mean that God abandoned Hezekiah forever. It also does not mean that God did not love Hezekiah anymore. God only left Hezekiah for a short time in order to test

Hezekiah. The storyteller means that God did not intervene or stop Hezekiah from doing what Hezekiah wanted to do, because God wanted to know what Hezekiah's true character was like.

Stop here and discuss these questions: Tell a story about a time that a person in authority, such as a parent, teacher or boss, tested someone by allowing that person to do whatever the person wanted to do. How do you talk about this situation? What words or phrases can you use to describe when a parent, teacher, or boss could step in to help, but doesn't, because they want to see what the person will do on their own? Which of these could you use here? Pause this audio here.

In the fourth scene, the storyteller mentions a book or scroll that people called The Vision of the Prophet Isaiah, son of Amoz, and a book that people called the Book of the Kings of Judah and Israel. There are more stories about Hezekiah in these books. Unfortunately, these books do not exist anymore. And Bible scholars do not agree whether they were two separate books or scrolls, or if the Vision of the Prophet Isaiah was a smaller book inside the Book of the Kings of Judah and Israel. The Vision of the Prophet Isaiah is a different book from the Book of Isaiah in the Bible.

A vision is a kind of revelation from God. When a prophet has a vision, he sees something that other people do not see or hears something that other people do not hear.

The storyteller says that Hezekiah did things that showed that he was faithful to Yahweh and completely devoted to Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss these questions: what words do you have for actions that show that someone is faithful to another person? Which of these could you use here? Pause this audio here.

Hezekiah died and his people buried him in the upper part of the tombs where the people buried the descendants of David. The people of Judah gave Hezekiah special honor when Hezekiah died. The storyteller does not tell us exactly what this special honor was. Then Hezekiah's son Manasseh became the next King of Judah.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 32:24–33 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Hezekiah
- Yahweh
- The people of Judah and Jerusalem
- The Babylonian ambassadors
- And Manasseh, Hezekiah's son

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

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About that time, Hezekiah became deathly ill. Hezekiah prayed, and Yahweh gave Hezekiah a miraculous sign to show Hezekiah that he would get better. But Hezekiah was proud and was not grateful for the kindness that Yahweh had shown to Hezekiah. So Yahweh's great anger came against Hezekiah and also against Judah and Jerusalem. But Hezekiah humbled himself and repented of his pride, and the people of Jerusalem did the same thing. Therefore, Yahweh was no longer angry and did not bring judgment on Judah at that time, and things were good for the rest of Hezekiah's reign.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Hezekiah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I nearly died, but Yahweh saved me! I must be very special and valuable to this country. What would these people do without me? or
- Look at everything I have done for my people! Look at how Yahweh saved me so that I could keep helping my people. I am truly one of the greatest kings of Judah; or
- I feel awful that Yahweh is angry at our people because of my pride. I must humble myself and ask Yahweh for mercy, and the people should too! or
- I am grateful to Yahweh not only for saving me from illness, but also for saving me from my own foolish pride.

Ask the people playing the people of Judah and Jerusalem, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- What a miraculous sign that Yahweh gave our king! Yahweh is the only God who can do such great things! or
- We feel relieved that Yahweh saved our king. We need Hezekiah to protect us from the Assyrians; or
- Perhaps we have not shown Yahweh how thankful we are for Yahweh's help. We must humble ourselves before Yahweh; or
- We are grateful that Yahweh spared us from his wrath, in spite of our pride. Yahweh is a very merciful God.

Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Poor Hezekiah is so afraid of dying. I will give Hezekiah a sign to show Hezekiah that he will not die from this illness; or
- I am pleased that Hezekiah prayed to me to heal his illness. That shows that Hezekiah knows I am his healer and the one who gives Hezekiah life; or
- I feel angry that Hezekiah is so proud and ungrateful for all I have done for him. Not only that, but the people are just as proud as Hezekiah is! or
- I am very happy that Hezekiah and the people have repented of their pride. Because the people have done this, I will not punish them at this time.

Continue the drama.

Throughout Hezekiah's rule, Hezekiah was very wealthy, and the people highly honored Hezekiah. Hezekiah built special treasury buildings for his silver, gold, precious stones, spices, shields, and other valuable items. Hezekiah also built many storehouses for his grain, new wine, and oil. Hezekiah made many stalls for his cattle and pens for his flocks of sheep. Hezekiah built many towns and gathered many large herds of cattle and flocks of sheep because God had given Hezekiah great wealth.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Hezekiah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel grateful that Yahweh has blessed our nation with so much material wealth; or
- I am pleased with how rich the nation has become! Maybe we are not quite as rich as we were during the days of Solomon, but we are doing very well! or
- All these possessions are wonderful, but I am nervous that someone might try to come and steal them all.

Ask the people playing the people of Judah and Jerusalem, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We feel safe and secure knowing that our nation has everything we need and more; or
- We feel proud of our nation and our king. We are so glad that we live in Judah; or

- Yahweh has been very gracious to us since we humbled ourselves and repented of pride. We must remember to tell our children that this is the way to receive Yahweh's blessings.

Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel happy that my people have been humble and have received all my blessings with gratitude; or
- I am pleased with my servant Hezekiah. Hezekiah is taking very good care of the nation; or
- I love to provide for my people.

Continue the drama.

It was Hezekiah who closed the upper outlet of the Gihon spring and brought the water by tunnel to the west side of the City of David. And Hezekiah succeeded in everything Hezekiah did. But one day, some ambassadors arrived from Babylon to ask Hezekiah about the miraculous sign that had occurred in the land. At that time, God let Hezekiah make his own choices in order to test Hezekiah's character.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Hezekiah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- It worries me that our only year-round source of water is outside the walls of Jerusalem. We need to find a way to get that water inside the city; or
- I am so pleased with my workers! My workers found a way to tunnel through rock to bring the waters of the Gihon spring into Jerusalem; or
- I am so proud that these messengers from Babylon have come to see how great our nation is.

Ask the people playing the people of Judah and Jerusalem, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- It is wonderful that our king dug a tunnel to bring water into the city! Now we do not have to wonder where we will get water from if an enemy attacks us; or
- Look! Even the Babylonians have heard about the miraculous sign that Yahweh did in our country. Now the Babylonians know what a great God Yahweh is; or
- Yahweh has done many great things for us while Hezekiah has been king. Surely our people will continue to be safe and rich!

Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel glad that Hezekiah made a tunnel to bring water inside the city for my people. This makes Jerusalem more secure; or
- Hezekiah has been wise in the ways that he has prepared Jerusalem to stand strong if there are problems; or
- Here come some Babylonian ambassadors. This will be a good time to test Hezekiah to see if Hezekiah's heart is truly wise and if he is thinking about what is best for the nation.

Continue the drama.

The rest of the events in Hezekiah's reign and Hezekiah's acts of faithfulness to Yahweh are in "The Vision of the Prophet Isaiah son of Amoz," and in "The Book of the Kings of Judah and Israel." When Hezekiah died, the people buried Hezekiah in the upper part of the royal tombs. All of Judah and Jerusalem honored Hezekiah when he died. And Hezekiah's son Manasseh became the next king.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the people of Judah and Jerusalem, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We feel sad that King Hezekiah has died. Hezekiah was such a good king; or
- Hezekiah was a good king. Surely Hezekiah's son Manasseh will also be good to us; or
- King Hezekiah built a strong and prosperous country for us. Perhaps things will be even better with Manasseh as our king!

Ask the person playing Manasseh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

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- My father did great things for this nation, and I hope that I will be even greater than my father; or
- Now it is my turn to rule and I get to do the things that I think are best; or
- I feel sad that my father has died, but happy that I have a chance to make our country even greater than it already is.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 32:24–33 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

In those days, Hezekiah became sick and almost died. Hezekiah **prayed** to **Yahweh**, and Yahweh spoke to Hezekiah and gave him a sign to show that Hezekiah would get well. But Hezekiah was not grateful for the kindness he had received, because Hezekiah's heart was so proud. Be sure to translate pray and Yahweh the same way you did in previous passages. See the Master Glossary for more information on pray and Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **sign**. Look up sign in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here

Therefore, Yahweh's **wrath**, or strong anger, came against Hezekiah and on **Judah** and **Jerusalem**. However, Hezekiah humbled the pride in Hezekiah's heart, as did the people living in Jerusalem. And so the wrath of Yahweh did not come on the people during the days of Hezekiah. Be sure to translate wrath, Judah, and Jerusalem the same way you did in previous passages. See the Master Glossary for more information on wrath, Judah, and Jerusalem.

Then Hezekiah had great wealth and great honor. Hezekiah made treasuries for his silver, gold, precious stones, spices, shields, and other valuable items. Hezekiah built storehouses for grain, wine, and oil. And Hezekiah made stalls for all kinds of cattle and sheep pens for his flocks. Hezekiah built cities for himself and gained many flocks and herds because **God** had given Hezekiah great wealth. Be sure to translate God the same way you did in previous passages. See the Master Glossary for more information on wine and God.

Remember, in this scene, the storyteller uses a word for wine that probably means "new wine" or "unfermented wine."

Stop here and decide what word you will use for **wine.** Pause this audio here.

It was Hezekiah who stopped the upper outlet of the waters of the Gihon spring and directed the waters down to the west side of the City of **David**. And Hezekiah prospered in everything he did. But when it came to the matter of the ambassadors from **Babylon**, who came to Hezekiah to ask about the **miracle** that had happened in the land, God left Hezekiah alone to test him and see what was in Hezekiah's **heart**. Be sure to use the same words for **David**, **Babylon**, **miracle**, and **heart** that you used in previous stories. See the Master Glossary for more information on **David**, **miracle**, and **heart**. Remember, a miracle is similar to a sign.

As for the rest of the events in Hezekiah's reign and his deeds of faithful love, they are in the **Visions** of the **Prophet Isaiah** son of Amoz, and in the book, or **scroll**, of the **kings** of Judah and **Israel**. Hezekiah died, and the people buried Hezekiah in the upper part of the **tombs** of David's **descendants**. All of Judah and the inhabitants of Jerusalem honored Hezekiah when he died. And Hezekiah's son Manasseh became the next king. Be sure to use the same words for vision, prophet, Isaiah, scroll, king, Israel, tomb, and descendants that you used in previous stories. See the Master Glossary for more information on vision, prophet, scroll, king, Israel, tomb, and descendants.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

2 Chronicles 32:24–33

Audio Content

- Hear and Heart (598 KB)
- Setting the Stage (4.1 MB)
- Defining the Scenes (6.5 MB)
- Embodying the Text (4.9 MB)
- Filling the Gaps (2.1 MB)
- Speaking the Word (880 KB)

2 Chronicles 33:1–9

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 33:1–9 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 33:1–9 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 33:1–9 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous story, King Hezekiah became sick and humbled himself before Yahweh. Yahweh blessed Hezekiah in everything he did and gave Hezekiah great riches. Then Hezekiah died and his son Manasseh became the next king of Judah. In this story, the storyteller reveals that Manasseh is an evil king who worships idols and angers Yahweh.

2 Chronicles 33:1–9

Manasseh is only 12 years old when he becomes king of Judah, and Manasseh rules as king for 55 years. This means that Manasseh ruled Judah longer than any other king. Manasseh's story is included in the book of 2 Kings, although in that book the storyteller includes different details. If you have already translated the book of 2 Kings, it might help you to go back and listen to your translation.

Stop here and listen to the beginning of 2 Kings chapter 21, if it is available in your language. Pause this audio here.

Before the Israelites invaded Canaan, Yahweh told the Israelites not to worship the idols of the Canaanites or copy the practices of the Canaanites. Yahweh told the Israelites many times that the Canaanites worshipped false gods and did many things that Yahweh hated. Yahweh required the Israelites to worship Yahweh only and to obey the law that Yahweh gave to Moses.

Stop here and discuss these questions: In your area, how common is it for a person to believe in one God? How common is it for a person to believe in many gods? How common is it for a person to believe in no God at all? What differences do you see in the ways these three different groups of people live their lives? Pause this audio here.

Baal and Asherah were two of the gods that the Canaanites worshipped. The Canaanites often went to the top of a hill or mountain to worship these false gods, which is the reason why people sometimes called their altars"high places." King Hezekiah had destroyed all the high places where the Israelites worshipped Baal and Asherah, but Manasseh built these places again and worshiped there himself. Many Canaanites also worshipped the sun, moon, and stars. Yahweh told the Israelites not to worship the sun, moon, and stars, but King Manasseh worshipped them anyway and encouraged the Israelites to do so as well.

Stop here and discuss these questions: How common is it in your area for people to worship the stars? How common is it for people to believe that the stars influence our lives on earth? What other beliefs do people in your area have about the stars? Pause this audio here.

The temple of Yahweh in Jerusalem had an altar. The Israelites used that altar to make sacrifices to Yahweh. The temple of Yahweh was very special to Yahweh. Yahweh promised King David and King Solomon that Yahweh's presence would live in the temple forever. When King Manasseh built altars to other gods inside Yahweh's temple, it was a terrible insult to Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss these questions: Try to think of any places in your area that people have set aside for one special use only. The place could be something like a school, a hospital, a monument, a burial ground, or a religious place. How would you feel if someone went to that place and used it for a different purpose? What could someone do there that would feel disrespectful to the place? Pause this audio here.

King Manasseh also sacrifices his own sons to one of the Canaanite idols. Yahweh told the Israelites never to sacrifice people, but Manasseh copies this Canaanite practice. A person might sacrifice their child to show complete devotion to an idol, or to try to persuade that idol to reveal information about the future. But Yahweh said that Yahweh hated this practice very much.

Stop here and discuss these questions: Have any people in your area ever practiced human sacrifice? If so, do people still do this today? What do people in your area think about human sacrifice? Pause this audio here.

Manasseh does many things that Yahweh had told the Israelites not to do. Manasseh does these things to try to use spiritual powers besides Yahweh in order to learn secrets or control what happened on earth. For example, people at that time believed that special people called mediums could talk to the spirits of dead people and get information from those spirits. Others believed they could use magic to change what happened in the world. All of these people used other spiritual powers instead of Yahweh, and Yahweh told the Israelites never to do these things.

Stop here and discuss these questions: In your area, how common is it for people to believe that certain people have the ability to talk to spirits of dead people? If people do this in your area, tell a story about a time when you saw or heard about someone who did this. Pause this audio here.

In those days, many people also believed that if they used magic, those people could find out hidden information or influence events on earth. Sometimes people went to a special person called a witch, sorcerer, or diviner

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to help them do these things. This practice involved interaction with spiritual powers other than Yahweh, and Yahweh told the Israelites never to do these things.

Stop here and discuss these questions: In your area, how common is it for people to believe that they can use magic to control events on earth or to find out hidden information? How common is it for people to believe that a special person like a witch or a sorcerer can do these things? How common is it for people to seek the help of a witch or sorcerer? If any of these things happen in your area, tell a story about a time someone did this. Pause this audio here.

Yahweh promised the Israelites peace and safety in the Promised Land, but only if the Israelites obeyed the rules and laws Yahweh gave the people through Moses. Yahweh had removed the Canaanites from the land because they were doing very evil things, and Yahweh told the Israelites not to do the same things. Yahweh wanted the Israelites to live better lives than the Canaanites. But Manasseh leads the people of Judah and Jerusalem to do even worse things than the people who had lived in the land before them.

Stop here and discuss these questions: Think of a story about an evil or corrupt leader. What did this leader do that was so bad? What was the effect on his followers? In what ways did the followers suffer because of the leader's actions? Who else suffered because of this evil and corrupt leader?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 33:1–9 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: Manasseh becomes king of Judah and reigns for 55 years. While Manasseh is king, Manasseh does the same evil things that the Canaanites had done before Yahweh drove them out.

In the second scene: The storyteller gives us details of some of the evil things that King Manasseh did that made Yahweh angry.

In the third scene: The people of Judah willingly follow Manasseh's evil practices and do not pay attention to the things Yahweh told the people.

The characters in this passage are:

- Manasseh
- Manasseh's sons
- The mediums and spiritists
- The people of Judah and Jerusalem
- And Yahweh

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first scene, Manasseh becomes king of Judah at age 12. Manasseh is king of Judah for 55 years. The storyteller introduces Manasseh using the same formal language that the storyteller used to introduce all of the other kings that came before Manasseh. Be sure to use the same words and phrases in this part of the story that you used to introduce other kings.

The storyteller summarizes Manasseh's reign by saying Manasseh did evil in the eyes of Yahweh. This means that Manasseh did things that Yahweh said were wrong. Then the storyteller says that Manasseh did the same terrible things that the nations Yahweh chased out of the land had done. The storyteller calls these evil things "abominations" or "detestable practices." "The nations that Yahweh drove before the people of Israel" means the Canaanites who lived in the land before the Israelites came and lived there. You already translated this entire phrase in an earlier chapter of 2 Chronicles.

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Stop here and listen to the beginning of 2 Chronicles chapter 28, which introduces Ahaz king of Judah. Pay close attention to how you translated the phrase “according to the abominations, or detestable practices, of the nations whom Yahweh had cast out before the children of Israel.” Pause this audio here.

In scene two, the storyteller gives more details about the evil things that Manasseh does. Manasseh rebuilds the places of worship where the people of Judah worshiped false gods. People often called these altars “high places” because these altars were often located on top of hills or mountains. Manasseh’s father, Hezekiah, had removed all the high places when he became king.

Manasseh builds altars to the Canaanite god Baal and makes carved images of the Canaanite goddess Asherah. People carved a wooden pole to represent Asherah, and people often called the wooden pole an Asherah. Manasseh bows down to the sun, moon, and stars and worships them. In the Bible people bow down to show respect, honor, or worship. Many people at that time believed that the sun, moon, and stars were gods or that they had power to influence life on earth. Yahweh told the Israelites many times that these things were a sin against Yahweh, but Manasseh does these things anyway.

Stop here and discuss: Think about the discussion you had in step two about people who worship the sun, moon, and stars. How do you talk about worshipping these things in your language? Pause this audio here.

Manasseh builds altars for worshiping the sun, moon, and stars in Yahweh’s temple. This is a horrible insult to Yahweh, because the temple is supposed to be only for Yahweh. The temple of Yahweh was the place where Yahweh said Yahweh’s Name would live forever. Yahweh’s Name represents Yahweh’s presence and all of Yahweh’s characteristics. When Yahweh said that Yahweh’s Name would live in the temple, Yahweh meant that Yahweh’s holy presence would always be in the temple. Therefore, the Israelites could only use the temple to worship Yahweh. The temple was set apart for that special purpose only.

When Yahweh says “Jerusalem is where I will put My Name,” Yahweh says it in a way that emphasizes Jerusalem. Yahweh means that out of all the places on earth, Yahweh chose Jerusalem, and not any other place, as the place where Yahweh’s Name would live. This is another way to show how special Jerusalem is to Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss this question: In your language, how would you emphasize that Jerusalem is the special place where Yahweh’s presence will stay, and not any other place? Pause this audio here.

Manasseh built altars for the sun, moon, and stars in the two courts of Yahweh’s temple. This means that the altars were in the inner courtyard and the outer courtyard of the temple. The word “court” means a space in the temple that is mostly or entirely surrounded by walls, but does not have a roof.

One of the most awful practices of the Canaanites was the practice of human sacrifice. When the storyteller says that Manasseh makes his sons pass through the fire, the storyteller means that Manasseh sacrifices his sons in the fire. Yahweh said that Yahweh hates this practice and told the Israelites that the people should never do it.

Stop here and discuss: Remember your discussion in step two about human sacrifice. How do you describe human sacrifice in your language? Pause this audio here.

Manasseh sacrifices his sons in a place called the Valley of Ben Hinnom. Most Bible scholars think this is a valley southwest of Jerusalem. Some Bible scholars think that child sacrifice was a form of divination, which is a way that people try to find out secret or hidden information through spiritual means. You already translated the name of this valley in an earlier story.

Next, the storyteller lists four evil things that Yahweh had forbidden, but that Manasseh does anyway: witchcraft, divination, sorcery, and consulting mediums and spiritists. The word for witchcraft primarily describes the way that people use magic to try to see the future and control events. The word for divination usually describes how people consult spirits other than Yahweh to get information or to find out what will happen in the future. The word for sorcery usually describes how people try to use evil spirits to control events. Yahweh told the Israelites to never use witchcraft, divination, or sorcery.

Stop here and discuss these questions: How do you talk about these practices in your language? What words or phrases do you have for the people who do these things? Pause this audio here.

In Bible times, it was common for people to believe that certain special people had the ability to talk to spirits or the ghosts of dead humans. This is the kind of person that the Bible calls a medium or a spiritist. People might

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try to talk to spirits or the dead in order to find out secret information. In this story, the storyteller uses two words that have very similar meanings. One of Manasseh's sins is that Manasseh goes to mediums and spiritists so that they could talk to spirits and ghosts for Manasseh.

Stop here and discuss these questions: How common is it in your area for people to believe that certain special individuals can talk to the spirits or talk to the dead? How do you describe a person who can talk to spirits and dead people? Could you use any of these words or phrases here? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller ends the second scene by reminding us that Manasseh does a huge amount of evil in the sight of Yahweh. This means that Manasseh does many things that Yahweh said were wrong. Yahweh is angry because Manasseh disobeys Yahweh, treats Yahweh and Yahweh's temple disrespectfully, and kills Manasseh's sons as part of Manasseh's idolatry.

In the third scene, Manasseh takes a carved image that represents an idol and puts it in the temple of God. In this part of the story, the storyteller begins to call Yahweh "God" rather than use the name Yahweh. You should make sure that you also switch to using the word for God in this part of the story.

God told King David and King Solomon that God chose Jerusalem as the place where God would put God's Name forever. The storyteller repeats something he said earlier in the story, which reveals how very important the temple was to God and how important Jerusalem was to God. This repetition might sound awkward in your language, but it is important to show that this was very important to God. The repetition emphasizes that Manasseh was insulting God's temple and therefore, insulting God.

God chose Jerusalem out of all the tribes of Israel. This might sound confusing because Jerusalem is the name of a city and not the name of a tribe of Israel. God means that he could have chosen any location throughout the land of Israel as the location for God's temple, and God chose Jerusalem.

God promised that if the Israelites did everything God told them to do, then the Israelites could live in the Promised Land forever. This is what God is talking about when God says, "I will not again remove the foot of Israel from the land which I gave to their ancestors." But God will only allow the Israelites to continue to live in the land if the Israelites obey God.

Stop here and discuss how you could say in your language that Yahweh promised to let the Israelites live forever in the land Yahweh gave their ancestors as long as they did what Yahweh commanded the people to do. Pause this audio here.

God clarifies what God expects the Israelites to do. God expects the Israelites to obey all of the laws, statutes, and ordinances that God gave the people through Moses. These three words—laws, statutes, and ordinances—are a way to summarize all of the instructions that God gave to Moses about how the Israelites were supposed to worship God and live in the Promised Land. You have already used the word for law many times in this book.

But the people of Judah and Jerusalem do not listen to God. Instead, the people follow their king, Manasseh, and do many evil things that God had told the people not to do. Manasseh misled the people, or led them astray. This means that Manasseh led the Israelites to behave in a bad way, like someone leads people off a good path and onto a bad one.

Stop here and discuss this question: How do you describe someone who tempts another person to stop doing good things and start doing bad things? Pause this audio here.

At the end, the storyteller says that Manasseh and the Israelites do more evil than the Canaanite nations. The storyteller reminds us that Yahweh destroyed those Canaanite nations as the Israelites took over the Promised Land. This reminds the hearers that the Israelites only live in the Promised Land because Yahweh removed the people who lived there before the Israelites did. Although the Israelites did have to fight for their land, it was Yahweh who caused the Israelites to win. Here, at the very end of the story, the storyteller switches back to calling God "Yahweh," and you should follow this change in your translation.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 33:1–9 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

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Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Manasseh
- Manasseh's sons
- The mediums and spiritists
- The people of Judah and Jerusalem
- And Yahweh

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Manasseh was 12 years old when he became king, and Manasseh ruled for 55 years in Jerusalem. Manasseh did things that Yahweh said were evil, the same detestable things that the Canaanite nations had done before Yahweh drove those nations out of the land.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Manasseh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I do not care what Yahweh said. I am going to do things my way; or
- We need all the help we can get, so I will worship every god I know about in order to earn those gods' favor; or
- I will do everything I have to do to become a rich and powerful king.

Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel angry that Manasseh does not care what I said and does not obey me; or
- I feel sad to see my people following the ways of the Canaanites, even though I told the people these things are evil; or
- Manasseh is such a fool. Manasseh thinks he does what is good for the people, but Manasseh actually hurts the people.

Continue the drama.

Manasseh rebuilt the high places that his father, Hezekiah, had destroyed. Manasseh built altars for Baal, and Manasseh built an Asherah pole. Manassh bowed down to the sun, moon, and all the stars in the heavens and worshiped them. Although Yahweh had said, "Jerusalem is the place where My Name will live forever," Manasseh built altars to other gods in Yahweh's temple. Manasseh placed altars to the sun, moon, and all the stars in the heavens in both courtyards of Yahweh's temple. Manasseh sacrificed his sons in the fire in the Valley of Ben Hinnom. Manasseh practiced witchcraft, divination, and sorcery, and Manasseh consulted mediums and spiritists. Manasseh did a great deal of evil in the sight of Yahweh and made Yahweh very angry.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Manasseh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

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- My father was unwise to destroy these high places, but I am going to restore them; or
- I feel pleased that I am building so many altars and places of worship to all the gods. Perhaps I will gain the favor of all of the gods; or
- This might be Yahweh's temple, but I am going to put whatever I want here; or
- If sacrificing my sons is what it takes to become a wealthy and powerful king, then that is what I will do.

Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel very sad that Manasseh has rebuilt the high places so the people can worship false gods. The people are so far away from me; or
- I have told my people over and over again not to do these things, but the people always go back to doing them; or
- I am outraged that Manasseh sacrificed his sons to an idol. Manasseh does not value human life.

Continue the drama.

Then Manasseh set the carved image of the idol that he had made in the temple of God. This was the temple about which God had said to David and David's son, Solomon, "I will make my Name live forever in this house and in Jerusalem. It is the place that I have chosen out of all the territory of the tribes of Israel. The Israelites must do everything that I commanded them, in accordance with the law, statutes, and ordinances that my servant Moses commanded. Then, I will never make the people leave this land which I gave to their ancestors." But Manasseh misled the people of Judah and Jerusalem to do more evil than the nations that Yahweh destroyed when the Israelites went into the land.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Manasseh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am pleased that all the people follow my example and worship as many gods as they can; or
- I feel proud that I do not limit my people to only worship Yahweh. Instead, I show my people that there are many gods out there; or
- I do not care what Yahweh told our ancestors. I am going to do what I think is right for us now.

Ask the people playing the Israelites, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel relieved that the king no longer requires us to only worship Yahweh. To worship these other gods is much more fun! or
- I am glad that we do not have to follow all of Yahweh's laws anymore. Yahweh's laws were too hard.; or
- Yahweh said we should only worship Yahweh, but if the king is worshipping other gods, can it really be that bad? or
- I think it is wise to worship all the gods. If we make the gods all happy, then the gods will all bless us!

Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- Manasseh has inherited all the promises that I gave to David and Solomon, but Manasseh is throwing the promises away to worship stars and idols of wood. Manasseh is foolish; or
- I am angry that Manasseh has dishonored my temple with all kinds of idols. My temple is the special place where I meet with my people; or
- Although my people have turned away from me, I will still forgive my people if they come back.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 33:1–9 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Manasseh was 12 years old when he became **king**, and Manasseh ruled for 55 years in **Jerusalem**. Manasseh did things that **Yahweh** said were **evil**, according to the abominations, or detestable practices, of the **nations** that Yahweh had driven out of the land. Be sure to use the same words for king, Jerusalem, Yahweh, evil, and nations

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as you did in previous stories. See the Master Glossary for more information on king, Jerusalem, Yahweh, evil, and nations.

If necessary, stop here and listen to the beginning of 2 Chronicles chapter 28, which introduces Ahaz, king of Judah, to remember how you said the phrase "according to the **detestable practices** of the nations that Yahweh had driven out of the land." You will remember that detestable practices are actions that Yahweh hates. Pause this audio here.

Manasseh rebuilt the **high places** that his father, Hezekiah, had destroyed. Manasseh built **altars** for **Baal**, and Manasseh built an **Asherah** pole. Manasseh **bowed down** to the sun, moon, and stars and **worshiped** them. Although Yahweh had said, "Jerusalem is the place where My Name will live forever," Manasseh built altars in Yahweh's **temple**. Be sure to use the same words for high place, altar, Baal, Asherah, bow down, worship, **gods**, and temple as you did in previous stories. See the Master Glossary for more information on altar, Baal, bow, worship, gods, and temple.

Manasseh placed altars to all the stars in the heavens in both courtyards of Yahweh's temple. Manasseh **sacrificed** Manasseh's sons in the fire in the Valley of Ben Hinnom. Manasseh practiced witchcraft, **divination**, and sorcery, and Manasseh consulted **mediums** and spiritists. Manasseh did a great deal of evil in the sight of Yahweh and made Yahweh very angry. Be sure to use the same words for sacrifice, divination, and medium as you did in previous stories. See the Master Glossary for more information on sacrifice.

If necessary, stop here and decide what words or phrases you will use for **witchcraft**, **divination**, and **sorcery**, and what words you will use for medium and spiritists. See the Master Glossary for more information on divination and medium. Pause this audio here.

> Then Manasseh set the carved image of the **idol** that he had made in the temple of **God**, the very temple about which God had said to **David** and David's son, Solomon, "I will make my Name dwell forever in this house and in Jerusalem, the place which I have chosen out of all the territory of the **tribes** of **Israel**." Be sure to use the same words for idol, God, David, tribes, and Israel as you did in previous stories. See the Master Glossary for more information on idol, David, God, and Israel.
>
> God continued and said, "And if the Israelites will only be sure to do everything I have commanded them, according to all the **laws**, **statutes**, and **ordinances** that Moses commanded them, then I will not ever make the Israelites leave this land which I gave to their ancestors." But Manasseh misled **Judah** and the inhabitants of Jerusalem to do more evil than the nations that Yahweh destroyed when the **Israelites** went into the land. Be sure to use the same words for laws, statutes, ordinances, Judah, and Israelites as you used in previous stories. See the Master Glossary for more information on law, statutes, ordinances, Judah, and Israelites.
>
> If necessary, stop here and listen to the middle part of 2 Chronicles chapter 19, where King Jehoshaphat appoints some of the Levites to judge disputes and enforce the statutes and ordinances. This should remind you of the words you used for statutes and ordinances.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

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Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

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Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 33:10–20 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 33:10–20 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 33:10–20 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous story, Manasseh became the king of Judah and sinned against Yahweh in many ways. Manasseh led the people to worship false gods and to practice divination, sorcery, and witchcraft. In this story, Yahweh allows the Assyrian army commanders to take Manasseh prisoner, and Manasseh repents of his sin. Then Yahweh brings Manasseh back to Judah, and Manasseh removes all the foreign gods and idols from the country.

King Manasseh did more evil than almost any other king of Judah. Yahweh speaks to Manasseh and the people of Judah and tells them to stop doing evil things. But Manasseh and the people do not do what Yahweh tells them to do. Because Manasseh does not listen to Yahweh, Yahweh allows the Assyrian army to attack Judah and capture Manasseh. The Assyrians take Manasseh as a prisoner from Jerusalem to the city of Babylon. At this time, the city of Babylon was part of Assyria. Babylon is about 1,450 kilometers from Jerusalem.

Stop here and look at a map that shows the locations of Jerusalem and Babylon. Pause this audio here.

When the Assyrians take Manasseh prisoner, the Assyrians put a ring in Manasseh's nose and bind him with bronze chains. The Assyrians do this to make sure that Manasseh will not escape. When the Assyrians put a ring in a person's nose, the Assyrians also attached the ring to a chain or a rope. Then an Assyrian soldier would hold onto the chain or the rope so that the prisoner could not escape. The Assyrian soldier could also pull on the rope to hurt the prisoner.

Stop here and look at a picture of an Assyrian carving that shows an Assyrian soldier holding a rope attached to a prisoner's nose ring. Pause this audio here.

The Assyrians also use bronze chains to make sure Manasseh cannot escape. People put chains around another person's legs or wrists, or sometimes both, to stop that person from running away.

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The Assyrians do these things to Manasseh to make sure Manasseh cannot escape, but also to shame Manasseh. When Manasseh is a prisoner, Manasseh very likely feels ashamed, afraid, sad, and hopeless. Manasseh is probably worried about what will happen to Manasseh and to Manasseh's country. So Manasseh humbles himself, prays to Yahweh, and asks Yahweh to help Manasseh. Yahweh knows that Manasseh is truly sorry, so Yahweh causes the Assyrians to set Manasseh free. Manasseh goes back to Judah and again leads Judah as king. But the most important detail is that now, Manasseh knows that Yahweh is the one true God.

Stop here and tell a story about someone who first lived their life one way, then changed and was completely different. What caused the person to change his life? How did that person change? How did the change affect the people around that person? Pause this audio here.

After Manasseh goes back to Judah, Manasseh repairs the walls of Jerusalem. Manasseh repairs the wall and makes it higher, from the Fish Gate on the north side of Jerusalem to the Gihon spring on the southeastern side of Jerusalem, and also around a hill called Ophel.

Stop here and look at a drawing of Jerusalem that shows the location of the Fish Gate, the Gihon spring, and the hill called Ophel. Pause this audio here.

Manasseh also stations military officers in all the fortified cities of Judah. But the most important part of this story is that Manasseh proves that he really believes in Yahweh through Manasseh's actions. Manasseh removes all the foreign gods, idols, and altars in Jerusalem. Manasseh was the one who had built all of these things, but now Manasseh does the right thing and tears them down. Manasseh also tells the people to only worship Yahweh.

Stop here and tell a story about a leader who tried to make big changes in his community. Why did that person try to make the changes? How did the people respond? Was the leader successful in making the changes? Pause this audio here.

Manasseh also repairs the temple of Yahweh and makes peace or fellowship offerings and thank offerings to Yahweh. When the Israelites sacrificed a peace or fellowship offering, the Israelites sacrificed a male animal with no defects in the temple. The purpose of the peace offering was to establish or maintain good relations with Yahweh. In this case, because Manasseh had defiled Yahweh's temple before, Manasseh might feel that he needs to make some sacrifices in order to show that Manasseh was sorry.

Stop here and discuss these questions: In your culture, if two individuals or groups have a serious conflict and then make peace, what actions do those people take to show that they are now at peace with each other? Can you tell a story about two groups who were once in conflict but then made peace and showed that peace through some kind of action or ritual? Pause this audio here.

Manasseh also sacrifices thank offerings to Yahweh. A thank offering was similar to a peace offering except that people also gave different kinds of bread in addition to an animal. People gave thank offerings to thank Yahweh for something Yahweh did. In this case, Manasseh probably wants to thank Yahweh for saving Manasseh from the Assyrians and bringing Manasseh back to Jerusalem. Manasseh tries to lead the people to worship only Yahweh in the right way. However, Manasseh does not remove all of the high places. Although the people still make sacrifices in these places, the storyteller says that the people only make sacrifices to Yahweh. The people still disobey Yahweh when the people do this.

Stop here and tell a story about someone who received instructions to do something but only did part of it. Why did that person only do part of it? What was the result? How did the person who gave the instructions feel? Pause this audio here.

People wrote about all of the things that Manasseh did in two books, or scrolls. One of those books is the "History of the Kings of Israel." In this case, when the storyteller says "Israel," the storyteller means both the kingdom of Israel and the kingdom of Judah together. The storyteller also mentions another book called the "Records of the Hozai." Some Bible scholars think that the Hozai were a group of prophets, or seers. So sometimes people called this book "The Records of the Seers." No one knows where either of these books is now. Although Manasseh repented and believed in Yahweh later in his life, most of the things that Manasseh did as king of Judah were evil.

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Manasseh died, and the people buried Manasseh in Manasseh's own house. This probably means that the people buried Manasseh in a tomb located somewhere in the palace, where the king and his family lived. Then Manasseh's son Amon became the next king of Judah.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 33:10–20 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: Yahweh warned Manasseh and the people of Judah, but they did not listen to Yahweh's warnings. So Yahweh lets the Assyrian army attack Judah and take King Manasseh as a prisoner. Manasseh humbles himself and prays to Yahweh, so Yahweh causes the Assyrians to set Manasseh free. Manasseh goes back to Jerusalem.

In the second scene: After Manasseh returns to Jerusalem, Manasseh is faithful to Yahweh. Manasseh removes all the foreign gods from Judah and stops most of the sinful practices that Manasseh had started.

In the third scene: Manasseh dies, and Manasseh's people bury him. Manasseh's son Amon becomes the next king of Judah.

The characters in this passage are:

- Yahweh
- Manasseh
- The people of Judah
- The commanders of the Assyrian army
- The military commanders of Judah
- The seers who spoke to Manasseh
- And Amon, Manasseh's son

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first scene, the storyteller begins the story by saying that Yahweh spoke to Manasseh and his people. It is unclear whether "his people" means "Yahweh's people" or "Manasseh's people." Although both possibilities are true, Bible scholars think the storyteller means "Yahweh's people." Manasseh and the people did not listen to what Yahweh said to them. The storyteller does not mention how Yahweh spoke to Manasseh and the people, but later the storyteller does say that the seers, or prophets, spoke to Manasseh in the name of Yahweh, the God of Israel. But Manasseh and the people did not pay attention to what Yahweh said to them. Remember that in the original language, the word for "listen" not only means to hear the words that someone says, but to also act on those words or obey the person who is speaking.

Stop here and discuss these questions: In your language, how do you describe a situation where one person hears the words that another person says but does not act on what that person said or obey that person's commands? Which of these could you use here? Pause this audio here.

Because Manasseh and the people did not listen to Yahweh, Yahweh sends the Assyrian army commanders to Jerusalem, and they capture Manasseh. The Assyrian army commanders probably brought the Assyrian army with them when they captured Manasseh. The storyteller sometimes talks about things people did and says that Yahweh did those things. This shows that Yahweh controls all events on earth. The king of Assyria probably decided to send his army commanders to Jerusalem to capture Manasseh and bring Manasseh to Babylon, but it was Yahweh who caused the king of Assyria to make that decision.

Stop here and discuss these questions: How confusing do you think it will be for your hearers to hear the storyteller say, "Yahweh sent the commanders of the army of the king of Assyria against Manasseh and the people of Judah"? If it is too confusing for people, how can you say it so that people will understand that a person made the decision, but Yahweh caused that person to make that decision? Pause this audio here.

The Assyrian army commanders force Manasseh to go to Babylon. The storyteller says that the Assyrians capture Manasseh with hooks. The storyteller probably means that the Assyrians put a hook in Manasseh's nose as they did to many of their prisoners. The Assyrians also put bronze chains on Manasseh. The Assyrians most likely did these things so that Manasseh could not run away.

Stop here and discuss these questions: In your culture, how do you stop prisoners from running away? After you discuss this, look again at the picture of an Assyrian prisoner with a hook in his nose, and the picture of bronze chains. Decide how you will say that the Assyrians captured Manasseh with hooks and bound Manasseh with bronze chains. Pause this audio here.

The Assyrian commanders take Manasseh to the city of Babylon. At this time, the Assyrians controlled the city of Babylon and all the territory around Babylon.

When Manasseh is a prisoner, Manasseh probably feels sad, afraid, embarrassed, and angry. When Manasseh is in this terrible situation, Manasseh finally asks Yahweh for help. Manasseh pleads with Yahweh and humbles himself. This means that Manasseh is no longer proud and no longer rebels against Yahweh. Manasseh admits to Yahweh that the things Manasseh did were wrong.

Stop here and discuss these questions: What words or phrases do you use for a situation where one person who is in trouble asks a more powerful person for help? Which of those could you use here? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller calls Yahweh "the God of his fathers." This phrase means "the God that Manasseh's ancestors followed."

When Manasseh prays, Yahweh hears Manasseh's words. Yahweh is moved by Manasseh's request. This means that Yahweh feels sorry for Manasseh and wants to help Manasseh.

Stop here and discuss these questions: what words or phrases do you have to describe a situation where one person feels sorry for another person and wants to help that person? Which of these could you use here? Pause this audio here.

Yahweh causes the Assyrians to release Manasseh so that Manasseh can go back to Jerusalem.

At the end of this scene, the storyteller says, "And Manasseh knew that Yahweh is God." This is the most important statement in this scene. This statement means that Manasseh finally realizes that Yahweh is the only God and that all other gods are false gods.

Stop here and discuss these questions: [Manasseh not only knew that Yahweh is God. Manasseh also realized that all the other gods and idols Manasseh had previously worshiped were not really gods like Yahweh is God. Discuss how you can show this in the way you translate this part.]{.mark} Pause this audio here.

In scene two, the storyteller tells us what Manasseh did after Manasseh came back to Jerusalem from Babylon. First, Manasseh repaired the outer wall of the City of David. The storyteller does not tell us why Manasseh needed to repair the wall. It is possible that the Assyrian army damaged or destroyed part of the wall when they attacked and took Manasseh prisoner. It is also possible that Manasseh completed the wall that Hezekiah started building. Or, it is possible that Manasseh built a new wall.

The Fish Gate was a gate in the city wall on the north side of Jerusalem. The Ophel hill and the Gihon spring are on the southeastern side of Jerusalem. The Gihon spring is in a deep valley on the eastern side of Jerusalem. This valley is called the Kidron Valley. Many Bible scholars think that the part of Jerusalem that people called "The City of David" was between these two locations. So Manasseh needed to repair a large section of the city wall from the Fish Gate on the north side of the city to Gihon on the southeastern side of the city.

Stop here and look at a drawing of Jerusalem that shows the location of the Fish Gate, the Gihon spring, and the hill called Ophel. Pause this audio here.

Manasseh also stationed military commanders in all of Judah's fortified cities. A fortified city is a city with a wall and other structures for defense. The king usually kept soldiers in fortified cities to help fight off any attack. It seems like Manasseh put more commanders in these cities to make the country stronger.

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Manasseh got rid of all the foreign gods that Manasseh had brought into Jerusalem. “Foreign gods” were the gods that people in other nations worshipped. The people made objects, or idols, to represent those gods. “Foreign gods” were any objects of worship other than Yahweh.

Manasseh removed the idol that he had placed in Yahweh’s temple. An idol is a statue or object that represents a false god. Manasseh removed all of the altars that Manasseh had built on the hill where Yahweh’s temple stood. Manasseh also removed altars from other places around Jerusalem. The people of Judah worshipped false gods at these altars, so Manasseh needed to remove and destroy them as well.

Next, Manasseh restored the altar inside Yahweh’s temple. Yahweh said that this altar was the only place where the Israelites could make sacrifices to Yahweh. Then Manasseh sacrificed peace or fellowship offerings and thank offerings on the altar. To make these sacrifices, Manasseh would have brought live animals to the temple, usually a young bull or male sheep, as well as bread for the thank offerings. Manasseh killed the animal and cut it into pieces. Then, the priests burned part of the animal on the altar, while they cooked another part and ate the meat. The priests also burned the bread for the fellowship offering.

After Manasseh did all this, Manasseh commanded the people of Judah to serve Yahweh, the God of Israel. This means that the people of Judah should not worship any other gods, but only Yahweh. It seems that the people obeyed Manasseh’s commands and stopped making sacrifices to idols. But the people did do one thing wrong. The people continued to make sacrifices to Yahweh at places of worship other than Yahweh’s temple. The people sometimes called these places of worship “high places” because people often built these places on top of hills.

Stop here and discuss this question: How can you make it clear to your hearers that the people were not supposed to make sacrifices at the high places? Pause this audio here.

In the third scene, the storyteller says that people wrote down more stories about what Manasseh did. People wrote about Manasseh’s prayer, which is probably the prayer that Manasseh prayed while he was a prisoner in Babylon. People also wrote down the messages that the prophets or seers gave to Manasseh. The prophets spoke in the name of Yahweh, which means that these prophets spoke on Yahweh’s behalf. These stories are in the “Book or Scroll of the History of the Kings of Israel.” Remember that the storyteller often calls the southern kingdom of Judah “Israel.” This is a different book from the book of Kings in our Bibles.

Other stories about Manasseh are in a different book called the “Records of Hozai” or the “Records of the Seers.” Bible scholars do not agree on what this book was. Nobody knows what happened to the “Records of Hozai.” In this book, someone recorded stories about how Manasseh sinned, worshipped idols, and built high places. Manasseh made carved images of the goddess Asherah, which are sometimes called Asherah poles. Manasseh also made carved images of other false gods. “Carved image” is another way to say “idol.” People usually carved idols out of wood or stone.

The storyteller does not tell us how much longer King Manasseh lived after Manasseh came back from Babylon. When Manasseh died, Manasseh’s people buried him in his own house. This probably means there was a tomb located somewhere on the palace property. Then Manasseh’s son Amon became the next king of Judah. The name Amon means “skilled.”

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 33:10–20 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Yahweh
- Manasseh
- The people of Judah
- The commanders of the Assyrian army

- The military officers of Judah
- The seers who spoke to Manasseh
- And Amon, Manasseh's son

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Yahweh warned Manasseh and his people, but they refused to pay attention. So Yahweh sent the commanders of the Assyrian army to invade Judah. The Assyrian commanders captured Manasseh, stuck hooks in Manasseh, put Manasseh in chains, and took Manasseh to Babylon. But while Manasseh was in great distress, Manasseh pleaded with Yahweh his God and sincerely humbled himself before the God of Manasseh's ancestors. And when Manasseh prayed, Yahweh listened to his plea and felt compassion for Manasseh. So Yahweh brought Manasseh back to Jerusalem and to his kingdom. Then Manasseh finally realized that Yahweh is the only one true Creator God!

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Manasseh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- My kingdom is strong and the Assyrians are far away. No one can harm me; or
- I feel so embarrassed! I was the king of Judah but now I am nothing but a prisoner. What will happen to me and my people? or
- I was wrong to be so proud and rebellious! I was wrong to worship idols! Have mercy on me, Yahweh! or
- I am so grateful that Yahweh was merciful to me in spite of all the evil things I have done. Yahweh truly is the only God!

Ask the people playing the people of Judah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We should not listen to those arrogant prophets who claim to speak for Yahweh. It is better to worship as many gods as we can; or
- The Assyrians are invading! Maybe if we pray to the Assyrians' gods, those gods will stop the Assyrians from attacking us; or
- We feel terrified. The Assyrians captured King Manasseh and took him away. How will our people survive now? or
- We are amazed! King Manasseh has come back, and Manasseh says that Yahweh saved him. If Yahweh can forgive Manasseh, then Yahweh is truly a great and loving God.

Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I have spoken to Manasseh many times, and Manasseh will not listen to me. It is finally time to do something so that Manasseh will humble himself; or
- I warned my people over and over again, but the people keep on following their king and worshipping idols. The people will have to see the result of their rebellion or else the people will never repent; or
- I am so happy that Manasseh repented! Now I will bless Manasseh and bring him back to Jerusalem!

Continue the drama.

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After this, Manasseh rebuilt the outer wall of the City of David. Manasseh started west of the Gihon spring in the Kidron Valley to the Fish Gate. Manasseh also made the wall go around the hill of Ophel. Manasseh built the wall even higher than it had been before. And Manasseh stationed his military officers in all the fortified towns of Judah. Manasseh also removed the foreign gods and the idol from Yahweh's temple. Manasseh tore down all of the altars he had built on the hill where the temple stood. Manasseh tore down all the altars that were in Jerusalem and dumped them outside the city. Then Manasseh restored the altar of Yahweh. Manasseh sacrificed peace offerings and thanksgiving offerings on the altar. Manasseh also encouraged the people of Judah to worship Yahweh, the God of Israel. However, the people continued to worship at the pagan altars, but they only worshipped Yahweh their God.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Manasseh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I thought Jerusalem was strong before, but now I see that I was wrong. I need to make the city stronger and ready for an attack; or
- I feel terrible that I encouraged the people to worship false gods. I need to destroy all the foreign gods and lead the people back to Yahweh; or
- I want to show Yahweh that I am sorry for all the terrible things I did and am grateful for Yahweh's love and mercy. I will make many sacrifices to Yahweh; or
- I am the king and it is my responsibility to make sure the people are faithful to Yahweh. I will tell the people that Yahweh alone is God and that the people should not worship any other gods!

Ask the people playing the people of Judah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We feel relieved that the king is rebuilding the walls of Jerusalem. It will make the city safer; or
- We feel glad that Manasseh has restored the temple of Yahweh. We hope that Yahweh will bless us even more now; or
- King Manasseh said we should only make sacrifices at the temple, but the journey is too long. Let's just make sacrifices at the high place nearby; or
- I do not understand why we cannot worship Yahweh at the local shrine. Is that not just as good as the temple in Jerusalem?

Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am very happy that Manasseh has genuinely repented. I love Manasseh so much, and Manasseh has returned to me; or
- I am glad that Manasseh destroyed all the idols and pagan altars, but the people are still worshipping at the high places. I feel sad that the people will not obey me completely; or
- If these people would be completely faithful to me, I would bless the people more than they could imagine!

Continue the drama.

Everything else Manasseh did while he was king, including Manasseh's prayer to Yahweh his God and the words that the prophets spoke to Manasseh in the name of Yahweh the God of Israel, is in "The History of the Kings of Israel." Manasseh's prayer and plea to Yahweh, all of Manasseh's sin and unfaithfulness, and all the locations where Manasseh built high places and set up Asherah poles and other carved images before Manasseh humbled himself are in the "Records of the Seers." Manasseh died, and the people buried Manasseh in his own house. Then Amon, Manasseh's son, became the next king.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Manasseh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I regret all the terrible things I did in my life. I hope that the changes I made at the end will be enough to protect our people; or
- I feel so grateful for Yahweh's mercy. I did not deserve it, but Yahweh forgave me; or
- I hope that my son and my people will continue to worship Yahweh after I am gone.

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Ask the people playing the people of Judah, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- Manasseh was once very evil, but at the end, Manasseh turned back to Yahweh. At least Manasseh finished his life well; or
- We feel amazed at how Yahweh forgives even the worst people. If Yahweh can forgive someone like Manasseh, then Yahweh can forgive anyone! or
- We wonder what Manasseh’s son Amon will be like. Will Amon worship idols like Manasseh did when he was young, or will Amon be faithful to Yahweh?

Ask the person playing Amon, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I am sad that my father is dead; or
- I am happy that I am now the king. I get to do things my way! or
- I will do whatever I have to do to keep the country safe and strong.

Ask the person playing Yahweh, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I feel happy that Manasseh turned back to me and that Manasseh ended his life well; or
- Although Manasseh was very sinful for most of his life, at the end, Manasseh returned to me and became a good leader for the people; or
- The next king is coming to the throne. Leaders come and go, but my purposes and my covenant with the people of Judah will never change.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 33:10–20 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Yahweh spoke to Manasseh and his people, but they did not listen. So Yahweh brought against them the army **commanders** of the **king** of **Assyria**. The Assyrians took Manasseh prisoner, put hooks in him, bound him with **bronze** chains, and took him to **Babylon**. Be sure to use the same words for Yahweh, commander, king, Assyria, bronze, and Babylon that you used in previous stories. See the Master Glossary for more information on Yahweh, king, and bronze.

Stop here and look again at the picture of bronze chains if needed. Pause this audio here.

When Manasseh was in great distress, Manasseh sought the favor of Yahweh**,** his **God,** and Manasseh humbled himself greatly before the God of his ancestors. When Manasseh **prayed** to Yahweh, Yahweh listened to Manasseh’s plea and was moved by Manasseh’s request. So Yahweh brought Manasseh back to **Jerusalem** and to his **kingdom**. Then Manasseh knew that Yahweh alone is God! Be sure to use the same words for God, pray, Jerusalem, and kingdom that you used in previous stories. See the Master Glossary for more information on God, pray, Jerusalem, and kingdom.

Afterward, Manasseh rebuilt the outer wall of the City of David, west of the Gihon **spring** in the valley, as far as the entrance of the Fish Gate and going around the hill of Ophel. Manasseh also made the wall much higher. Manasseh stationed military commanders in all of Judah’s **fortified cities**. Be sure to use the same words that you used in previous stories for spring and fortified city.

Manasseh threw away all the foreign **gods** and removed the **idol** from the **temple** of Yahweh. Manasseh also removed all the **altars** that Manasseh had built on the temple hill and in Jerusalem, and Manasseh threw them out of the city. Be sure to use the same words for gods, idol, temple, and altar that you used in previous stories. See the Master Glossary for more information on gods, idols, temples, and altar.

Then Manasseh restored the altar of Yahweh and **sacrificed peace or fellowship offerings** and **thank offerings** on it. Manasseh told the people of **Judah** to serve Yahweh, the God of **Israel**. However, the people continued to sacrifice at the **high places**, but the people only made sacrifices to Yahweh their God. Be sure to use the same words you used for sacrifice, peace offerings, thank offering, Judah, Israel, and high places that you used in

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previous stories. See the Master Glossary for more information on sacrifice, peace or fellowship offering, Judah, and Israel.

The “History of the Kings of Israel” records the rest of Manasseh’s deeds as king. It includes Manasseh’s prayer to God and the words the **seers** spoke to Manasseh in the name of Yahweh, the God of Israel. The “Records of the Hozai” also describe Manasseh’s prayer, how God listened to his plea, and all his **sins** and actions that were unfaithful to Yahweh, or betrayed Yahweh. The records also list the places where Manasseh built high places, Asherah poles, and carved images before Manasseh humbled himself. Manasseh died, and his son Amon became king after Manasseh. Be sure to use the same words you used for seer and sins that you used in previous stories. See the Master Glossary for more information on seer and sin. The entry for seer is under the entry for **prophet** in the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

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Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 33:21–25 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 33:21–25 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 33:21–25 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous story, King Manasseh humbled himself before Yahweh and repented of worshipping false gods. Manasseh removed all the foreign gods and foreign altars from Israel. Then Manasseh died, and Manasseh's son Amon became the next king of Judah. In this story, Amon rules as king for only two years, and then Amon's officials kill Amon. And the people of Judah make Amon's son Josiah the next king.

Amon was 22 years old when he became the king of Judah, and Amon reigned for two years. Amon did the same evil things that his father, Manasseh, had done for most of Manasseh's life. Amon made sacrifices to idols and worshipped the idols. Unlike Manasseh, Amon did not repent of his sin. Instead, the storyteller says that Amon was even more guilty than his father, Manasseh.

Amon ruled as king for only two years because Amon's servants, or officials, gathered together and decided to kill Amon. In this story, the word servants probably means Amon's court officials. The storyteller does not tell us why the officials decided to kill Amon. The storyteller does tell us that the officials killed Amon right in Amon's own house.

Stop here and tell a story about a leader who was such a bad leader that his own people decided to kill him. Why did the followers kill this leader? What happened to the people who killed the leader? Who became the next leader? Pause this audio here.

After these officials killed King Amon, the people of the land killed all those officials. The storyteller does not tell us the reason why the people of the land decided to kill the officials.

After the people of the land killed the officials who murdered King Amon, the people made Amon's son Josiah the next king of Judah.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 33:21–25 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has two scenes.

In the first scene: Amon became the king of Judah and reigned for two years. Amon worshipped idols and rejected Yahweh, just like Amon's father Manasseh did. Then Amon's officials plotted against Amon and killed him.

In the second scene: The people of Judah killed the officials who murdered Amon. Then the people made Amon's son Josiah king of Judah.

The characters in this passage are:

- Amon
- Yahweh
- Amon's servants, or officials
- The people of the land of Judah
- And Josiah

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first scene, Amon became king when he was 22 years old, and Amon reigned as king for two years. King Amon did evil in the eyes of Yahweh, just like Amon's father Manasseh had done. The storyteller says this in the same way that the storyteller said it in previous stories.

The most important detail to the storyteller was that Amon served the same idols that Amon's father Manasseh had served. These idols were images of the gods of the nations around Israel. When the storyteller says that Amon served the idols, it means that Amon worshipped those idols and made sacrifices to the idols.

Amon did not humble himself before Yahweh like his father Manasseh had done. This means that Amon never repented of worshipping false gods, and Amon never turned back to follow Yahweh's laws. Instead, Amon

multiplied his guilt. This might mean that Amon sinned even more than his father Manasseh sinned, or the storyteller might have meant that Amon's guilt was very great. When Amon disobeyed Yahweh and worshipped other gods, Amon became guilty of doing great wrong against Yahweh, and Amon deserved punishment.

Amon's servants, or officials, conspired against Amon. In this context, the servants were Amon's officials. This means that some of Amon's officials made a secret plan to kill Amon.

Stop here and tell a story about a group of people who got together and made a secret plan to do something against the law. What words do you use to describe what those people did? Could you use any of those words here? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller does not say how many officials conspired against Amon. The officials killed Amon right in his own palace.

Stop here and discuss this question: What special words does your language have for when someone kills a leader or another important person? If your language does not have a word like this, it is fine to use the normal word for "killed." Pause this audio here.

In the second scene, the people of Judah killed all of the officials who conspired against King Amon. The storyteller does not say why the people did this. Then the people made Amon's son Josiah the next king of Judah. The name Josiah means "Yahweh supports," in the sense that Yahweh helps Josiah or Yahweh approves of Josiah. If you have already translated the book of 2 Kings, then you have already decided how to translate the name "Josiah."

If necessary, stop here and listen to the beginning of 2 Kings chapter 22 to remember how you translated the name "Josiah." Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 33:21–25 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has two scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Amon
- Yahweh
- Amon's officials
- The people of the land of Judah
- And Josiah

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Amon was 22 years old when he became king, and Amon ruled in Jerusalem for two years. Amon disobeyed Yahweh, just like Amon's father Manasseh had done. Amon worshipped the idols that Amon's father had made

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and made sacrifices to those idols. Amon's father, Manasseh, had turned back to Yahweh, but Amon refused to do that. Instead, Amon sinned even more than Amon's father.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Amon, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- My father was foolish to stop worshipping all of the gods. I want to start worshipping all of the gods again; or
- I feel angry that my father removed all of the altars and foreign gods. I do not want to worship only Yahweh. I want to worship other gods too! or
- Now I am the king, and I get to decide what happens in this country; or
- My father was weak at the end of his life. I am going to do what I want, and the prophets of Yahweh cannot stop me.

Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am sad because I showed mercy to Amon's father, but Amon did not understand. Now Amon is worshipping foreign gods; or
- I am angry. Amon's father put the people on the right path, but now Amon has started worshipping other gods again; or
- I feel disappointed that Amon does not understand that I am the only God and there is no other.

Continue the drama.

Some of Amon's officials made a plan and killed Amon in his own house. But the people of Judah killed the servants who had murdered Amon. And the people made Amon's son Josiah the next king.

Ask the people playing Amon's officials, "What are you feeling or thinking?" Those people might answer things like:

- Amon is a terrible king. Amon is worse than his father was! We need to do something about Amon; or
- We want to get rid of King Amon, but is it worth the risk? If anyone catches us, we will be in big trouble; or
- We know that it would be wrong to kill Amon, but it is probably better for the people if Amon does not continue to be the king.

Ask the people playing the people of Judah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We are confused. Our kings cannot seem to decide who we should worship; or
- We are angry and scared. Manasseh finally stopped worshipping idols, but now Amon is worshipping the idols again; or
- I am worried about the new king, Josiah. If these corrupt officials killed Josiah's father, what might the officials do to Josiah if they do not like him? or
- Although Amon was a terrible sinner, Amon's servants had no right to kill Amon.

Ask the person playing Josiah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am sad that my father is dead; or
- I am scared. My father trusted those officials, and those officials killed my father. What is going to happen to me? or
- I need Yahweh to help me. I want to be a good king, but this is a scary place.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 33:21–25 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Amon was 22 years old when he became **king**, and Amon ruled in **Jerusalem** for two years. Amon did many things that **Yahweh** said were **evil**, just as Amon's father Manasseh had done. Be sure to use the same words for king, Jerusalem, Yahweh, and evil as you did in previous stories. See the Master Glossary for more information on king, Jerusalem, Yahweh, and evil.

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Amon served, or **worshipped**, and offered **sacrifices** to all the **idols** that Manasseh had made. But unlike his father, Manasseh, Amon did not humble himself before Yahweh. Instead, Amon's **guilt** was even greater. Be sure to use the same words for worship, sacrifice, idols, and guilt as you did in previous stories. See the Master Glossary for more information on worship, sacrifice, idols, and guilt.

Amon's **servants**, or officials, conspired against Amon and killed him in his own house or **palace**. Then the people of the land killed the servants who had murdered King Amon, and the people made Amon's son Josiah the next king. Remember that in this story, the word "servants" means government officials and not household servants. Be sure to use the same word for palace, or king's house, as you did in previous stories. Use the same word that you used for servant when "servant" means a government official. If you have already translated the book of Kings, then you have already decided how to translate the name "Josiah."

If necessary, stop here and listen to the beginning of 2 Kings chapter 22 to remember how you translated the name "**Josiah**." If you have not translated this name yet, decide now how you will translate it.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

2 Chronicles 34:1–7

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 34:1–7 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 34:1–7 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

2 Chronicles 34:1–7

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 34:1–7 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous story, Amon was king of Judah for two years. Then Amon's officials killed Amon, and the people of Judah made Amon's son Josiah the next king. In this story, Josiah becomes king when he is eight years old. Eight years later, Josiah begins to follow Yahweh and destroys all of the idols and pagan altars in the land.

The storyteller begins this story by giving us the usual information about the new king. Josiah was eight years old when he became king, and Josiah ruled for 31 years. Josiah ruled in Jerusalem, the capital city. The storyteller immediately lets us know that Josiah was a righteous king. Josiah lived his life in a similar way to Josiah's ancestor King David. Josiah was faithful to Yahweh and always did what pleased Yahweh. Josiah never worshipped false gods and idols or did any of the other things that Yahweh did not allow.

Stop here and tell a story about a person who always lived in a very good way, as one of that person's ancestors did. How do you describe this person? Pause this audio here.

After Josiah had been king for eight years, when Josiah was around sixteen years old, Josiah began to seek God. This means that Josiah decided that he would always do what Yahweh wanted Josiah to do, obey Yahweh's commands, and make Yahweh happy.

Josiah knew that Yahweh did not want Josiah to worship other gods. Josiah also knew that Yahweh did not want the people of Israel to worship other gods. In addition, because Josiah was the king, it was Josiah's job to lead the people and show the people how to obey Yahweh. So Josiah decided to go through the land of Judah and destroy every idol and every place where the people worshipped false gods.

Josiah did these things throughout the land of Judah. But Josiah also destroyed idols in the territory that belonged to the tribes of Manasseh, Ephraim, Simeon, and Naphtali.

Stop here and look at a map of Israel that shows the territory that belonged to each tribe. Pay attention to the location of the tribes of Judah, Manasseh, Ephraim, Simeon, and Naphtali. Pause this audio here.

The territory of Simeon was located inside the territory of Judah, so it was probably easy for Josiah to control this territory. The territories of Ephraim, Manasseh, and Naphtali were north of the kingdom of Judah. The territories of Ephraim, Manasseh, and Naphtali used to be a part of the northern kingdom of Israel. Eighty-two years before Josiah became king, the Assyrian army defeated and took over the kingdom of Israel. But when Josiah was king, the Assyrian empire had become weak and did not strongly control the land of Israel. So Josiah was able to destroy the idols in these parts of the former kingdom of Israel as well.

Stop here and discuss this question: Tell a story about a time when another group took over the territory of your people. How did your people feel about this? Pause this audio here.

Josiah was quite thorough when Josiah destroyed the idols in the land. Josiah not only tore the idols down, but Josiah also cut the idols to pieces, smashed them, and crushed them. Josiah made sure that he completely destroyed the idols, and no one could ever use the idols again. Josiah tore down the altars of Baal. Baal was a storm god, and many of the nations around Israel worshipped Baal. Josiah also tore down and destroyed the symbols of the goddess Asherah. Many people in the nations around Judah also worshipped Asherah.

Josiah also destroyed the incense altars in the land. Incense is a sweet-smelling substance. The Israelites burned incense as part of their worship of Yahweh, but the Israelites were only allowed to burn incense inside Yahweh's temple. The nations around Judah burned incense to worship their false gods. This is the main reason why Josiah destroyed all the incense altars in the land.

Stop here and discuss these questions: In your area, what sweet-smelling things do people burn to worship their gods? How do people worship their false gods, spirits, the sun and stars, or other things? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller adds an unusual detail. The storyteller says that Josiah burned the bones of the priests on their altars. These priests were not servants of Yahweh. These priests led people to worship false gods. When Josiah burned the bones of these priests on the same altars they had used, it was a way to show that those priests

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were not worthy of respect. It was also a way to show that the false gods the priests worshipped were powerless. By doing this, Josiah defiled these altars and made the altars unfit for worship.

Stop here and discuss these questions: In your culture, how do people treat a dead body with respect? How common is it in your culture to burn the body of a dead person? What are some things that would be disrespectful to do to a dead body? When your people hear that Josiah burned the bones of these priests, what might people think? Will people understand that Josiah meant to insult the dead priests and the gods they worshipped? Pause this audio here.

When Josiah burned the bones of the pagan priests on their altars, Josiah did what Yahweh said would happen many years ago in a prophecy. About 300 years before Josiah was king of Judah, the first king of the northern kingdom of Israel, King Jeroboam, built an altar to worship idols in the town of Bethel. A prophet came to Jeroboam while Jeroboam was burning incense to worship the idols. The prophet told Jeroboam that a descendant of David named Josiah would sacrifice the pagan priests and burn their bones on that altar. The town of Bethel was located in the territory of Ephraim, so Josiah certainly went there and did exactly what the prophet said Josiah would do. This was probably a very serious insult to those priests. The Israelites always buried the body of a dead person. The Israelites believed that burning a dead person's body was a way to show no respect to that person.

All of Josiah's activities purified Judah and Jerusalem. This means that after Josiah did these things, Yahweh considered Judah and Jerusalem to be ritually pure again. When the Israelites worshipped false gods, the Israelites made the nation impure. Josiah wanted the nation to be pure again, so Josiah removed all the idols from the land.

After Josiah finished purifying the territories of Judah, Simeon, Ephraim, Manasseh, and Naphtali, Josiah went back to Jerusalem.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 34:1–7 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has two scenes.

In the first scene: The storyteller summarizes the reign of King Josiah.

In the second scene: After Josiah had been king for eight years, Josiah began to seek Yahweh. Josiah destroyed all the idols and pagan altars in Judah and even in the territory of some other tribes of Israel.

The characters in this passage are:

- Josiah
- Josiah's servants
- The people of Judah
- The people in the cities of Manasseh, Ephraim, Simeon, and Naphtali
- And Yahweh

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first scene, Josiah became king of Judah when Josiah was eight years old. Because Josiah was so young, Josiah probably received help from other people in order to rule Judah. Josiah ruled in Jerusalem for 31 years.

The storyteller summed up Josiah's time as king of Judah by saying that Josiah did right in the sight of Yahweh. This means that Josiah always did the things that Yahweh approved of. Josiah walked in the ways of his ancestor, King David. This means that Josiah followed the example of King David, and Josiah lived his life in the same way that David did.

Stop here and discuss this question: In your language, how do you describe a situation where one person behaves exactly like another person? Pause this audio here.

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Josiah followed David's example and did not turn away to the right or the left. This means that Josiah always followed Yahweh's way of doing things.

Stop here and discuss this question: In your language, how do you describe a person who always does what is right and never does what is wrong? Pause this audio here.

In the second scene, the storyteller described Josiah's efforts to remove all the false gods from the land of Judah and part of the old kingdom of Israel. When Josiah was about 16 years old, Josiah began to seek God. This means that Josiah devoted himself to worshipping Yahweh and did not worship any other gods. Josiah tried to worship Yahweh in the same way that Josiah's ancestor, King David, did.

Four years later, when Josiah had been king of Judah for 12 years, Josiah began to purge Judah and Jerusalem of all forms of idol worship. "Purge" means to eliminate, drive out, or destroy something completely. In this story, "purge" also means to purify, or make clean, so that the land is acceptable to Yahweh again. When the people of Judah and Israel worshipped idols, Yahweh saw the people as impure. So Josiah had to make the land and the people pure again.

Stop here and discuss these questions: What words or phrases do you have in your language that mean to eliminate, drive out, and destroy something? Which of these words or phrases could also mean to make something clean or pure again? Which of these words or phrases could you use here? Pause this audio here.

Josiah destroyed the high places because the people often worshipped idols in the high places. The storyteller says that Josiah did all of these things, but the storyteller probably means that Josiah gave the orders for people to do this. Josiah probably helped the people do these things as well. Josiah destroyed the Asherah poles because they represented a false god. Josiah destroyed the altars of Baal because people used these altars to worship a false god. Josiah destroyed all the carved and metal idols because Yahweh told the people not to worship those things. A carved idol is an idol that people carved from wood or stone. A metal idol was an idol that people made by melting metal and then shaping the metal to look a certain way when the metal cooled.

Stop here and discuss these questions: What words do you have in your language to describe an object that people make when they melt metal and then shape the metal as it cools? Which of these could you use here? Pause this audio here.

Next, the storyteller says that "they" tore down the altars of the Baals in Josiah's presence. It is not clear who "they" are, but it probably means the people of Judah or possibly the government officials who served Josiah. The storyteller makes a point to say that Josiah was personally present when the people tore down some, if not all, of the altars to Baal. This shows that it was very important to Josiah to make sure that people completely destroyed the altars of Baal.

The people also cut down the incense altars that were above the altars of Baal. You will remember that the people around the nation of Judah burned incense to their false gods as a way of worshipping those gods.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How could you translate this so that it is clear that people used the incense altars to worship these idols? Pause this audio here.

The people, or Josiah's servants, took the Asherah poles, carved idols, and metal idols, broke them into pieces and ground them into powder. This was a way for the people to completely destroy these objects. Then, Josiah had his people scatter the powder on the graves of people who worshipped those idols. It is not clear exactly why the people did this, but it is most likely some way to express that the gods those people worshipped were nothing. It might also be a way to insult the people who had once worshipped those idols. We also do not know if these idol worshipers were already dead or if Josiah and his servants killed the idol worshipers.

Stop here and discuss these questions: When you hear that Josiah's people scattered the ashes of the smashed idols over the graves of people who worshipped those idols, what does this cause you to think of? What words would you use to describe this action? What do you think that your people will think about this action? How could you describe this action to make sure your people understand that it shows the idols were nothing? Pause this audio here.

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Next, Josiah and his followers burned the bones of the priests who had worshipped the false gods. This was probably a very serious insult to those priests. Many scholars think that this also means that Josiah and his servants killed the pagan priests.

Stop here and discuss these questions: In your culture, do people think it is disrespectful to burn the body of a dead person? If not, how can you help your hearers understand that when Josiah burned the bones of the pagan priests on the idol altars, Josiah insulted both the priests and the idols? Pause this audio here.

Josiah also did all these things in the territories of the tribes of Manasseh, Ephraim, Simeon, and Naphtali. The territory of the tribe of Simeon was located inside the territory of Judah. The territories of the tribes of Manasseh, Ephraim, and Naphtali were all located north of Judah.

The storyteller adds that there were ruins around the cities in Manasseh, Ephraim, Simeon, and Naphtali. The Assyrian army had destroyed many buildings and cities in the land many years earlier.

Stop here and discuss: Describe places that you know about that people have destroyed in war. How will you translate the ruins in the Israelite territories? Pause this audio here.

Josiah did all the same things in the territories of the old northern kingdom of Israel that Josiah did throughout the land of Judah. Once Josiah finished these activities, Josiah went back to Jerusalem. Josiah had traveled throughout Israel because it was very important for Josiah to make sure that his servants thoroughly purged, or purified, the land.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 34:1–7 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has two scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Josiah
- Josiah's servants
- The people of Judah
- The people in the cities of Manasseh, Ephraim, Simeon, and Naphtali
- And Yahweh

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Josiah was eight years old when he became king, and Josiah ruled for 31 years in Jerusalem. Josiah did what was pleasing to Yahweh. Josiah followed the example of Josiah's ancestor David and always obeyed Yahweh's laws.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Josiah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

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- I want to be a good king, but I am so young. If I do everything that Yahweh says to do, Yahweh will help me to be a good king; or
- I feel scared because the whole country is counting on me to lead them in the right direction; or
- I am glad that I can count on Yahweh to help and protect our people.

Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am so happy with Josiah. Finally, Judah has a leader who loves me and wants to please me; or
- Josiah has a good heart and his devotion to me is true. I will make Josiah a blessing to the nation; or
- Because Josiah is a good and faithful servant, the people will return to faithfulness to me.

Continue the drama.

In the eighth year that Josiah was king, while Josiah was still young, he began to earnestly follow the God of his ancestor David. In the 12th year of Josiah's reign, Josiah began to destroy all the high places, Asherah poles, carved idols, and metal idols in Judah and Jerusalem. With Josiah present, people tore down the altars of the false god Baal and chopped down the incense altars that were high above them. Josiah told the people to break the Asherah poles, carved idols, and metal idols into pieces and grind them into powder. Then Josiah told the people to scatter the powder on the graves of the people who had made sacrifices to those idols. Josiah also burned the bones of the pagan priests on the altars of the idols they worshipped, in order to insult them. And so Josiah purified the land of Judah and Jerusalem.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Josiah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel very happy to watch while my people destroy these detestable idols and altars; or
- I feel relieved that we are removing all these idols from the land. Now these idols will not tempt the people to worship false gods; or
- These pagan priests were foolish to disobey Yahweh and worship false gods. I will show everyone what happens to people who turn away from Yahweh; or
- I am grateful that Yahweh has put me in a position of power so I can lead the nation to worship Yahweh properly again.

Ask the people playing Josiah's servants, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- We are very happy that we finally have a king who will make sure our nation stops worshipping idols; or
- We are very pleased to take these idols and cut them up into pieces! or
- I feel angry because the king's servants just tore down the altar of my favorite god! or
- I still want to worship all the gods. I will have to be very careful and hide what I am doing.

Ask the people playing the people of Judah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We feel angry and worried. These are the gods we trust! Why is the king destroying them? or
- We feel confused. For so long, our people have worshipped many gods. Why is the king now making us worship Yahweh only? or
- King Josiah is serious about serving Yahweh alone. Maybe we should be too; or
- We are so happy that we finally have a king who loves Yahweh! Maybe this is the new beginning we have been hoping for.

Continue the drama.

Josiah did the same thing in the towns in the territories of Manasseh, Ephraim, Simeon, and even as far north as the territory of Naphtali. Josiah did this in all the devastated territory around those cities, too. Josiah destroyed the pagan altars and the Asherah poles, and Josiah crushed the idols into dust. Josiah cut down all the incense altars throughout the former kingdom of Israel. Then Josiah returned to Jerusalem.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Josiah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

2 Chronicles 34:1–7

- I am so grateful to Yahweh, who has given me an opportunity to purify the land of Judah; or
- I am glad that I am able to help the people of Manasseh, Ephraim, Simeon, and Naphtali destroy the idols and return to faithful worship of Yahweh; or
- I am relieved that I can be sure that there is no more idol worship in the land that I control.

Ask the people playing the people of Manasseh, Ephraim, Simeon, and Naphtali, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We feel shocked and afraid. King Josiah just destroyed all our gods. What will happen to us now? Is Yahweh really more powerful than all these other gods? or
- We feel hurt and angry. King Josiah has destroyed everything we know; or
- King Josiah has no right to destroy our gods and tell us what to do! or
- Maybe Josiah is right that we should only worship Yahweh.

Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am so pleased with Josiah. Josiah loves to honor me and is showing all the people that I alone am the one true God; or
- I am grieved that the people of Manasseh, Ephraim, Simeon, and Naphtali have been suffering for such a long time because of their sin. Now I will bless those people if they are faithful to me; or
- I will use Josiah's faithfulness as an example to the people. The people must see that I bless people when they obey me. The worthless idols cannot bless people.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 34:1–7 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Josiah was eight years old when he became **king**, and Josiah ruled in **Jerusalem** for 31 years. Josiah did what pleased **Yahweh** and followed the example of his ancestor **David**. Josiah did not stray from following the way that pleased Yahweh. Be sure to use the same words that you used for king, Jerusalem, Yahweh, and David in previous stories. See the Master Glossary for more information on king, Jerusalem, Yahweh, and David.

After Josiah had been the king for eight years, while he was still a young man, Josiah began to seek the **God** of his ancestor David. After Josiah had been king for 12 years, Josiah began to purge **Judah** and Jerusalem of the high places, the Asherah poles, and other **idols**. Be sure to use the same words that you used in previous stories for God, Judah, and idols. See the Master Glossary for more information on God, Judah, and idol.

Stop here and decide what word you will use for "**purge**." If you choose to use a word or phrase that means to purify or make clean, refer to **purify** in the Master Glossary for more information. Pause this audio here.

In Josiah's presence, the people tore down the **altars** to **Baal** and cut to pieces the **incense** altars that were high above them. Josiah and the people smashed the Asherah poles and all the other idols, ground them up into powder, and scattered the powder over the **graves** of people who had made **sacrifices** to the idols. Be sure to use the same words that you used in previous stories for altar, Baal, incense, grave, and sacrifice. See the Master Glossary for more information on altar, Baal, grave, and sacrifice.

Josiah also burned the bones of the pagan **priests** on the altars of the idols they **worshipped**. So Josiah purified Judah and Jerusalem. In the towns of Manasseh, Ephraim, Simeon, and even as far north as the land of Naphtali, and in the ruined areas around those towns, Josiah tore down the altars and the Asherah poles. Be sure to use the same words that you used in previous stories for priest and worship. See the Master Glossary for more information on priest and worship.

If you need a reminder on how you decided to say the names of Manasseh, Ephraim, Simeon, or Naphtali, stop here and listen to the beginning of 1 Chronicles chapter 2. Pause this audio here.

Josiah crushed those idols into dust and cut to pieces all of the incense altars throughout the land of **Israel**. Then Josiah went back to Jerusalem. Be sure to use the same word that you used for Israel in previous stories. See the Master Glossary for more information on Israel**.**

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

2 Chronicles 34:8–21

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 34:8–21 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 34:8–21 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 34:8–21 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous story, King Josiah began to rule when Josiah was eight years old. After eight years as king, Josiah began to follow Yahweh, and Josiah destroyed all the idols and pagan altars in the land. In this story, Josiah begins to repair the temple of Yahweh, and Hilkiah the priest finds the Book of the Law. Shaphan the scribe reads the Law to King Josiah, who feels very sad because he knows that his ancestors had not obeyed Yahweh's Law.

This story begins when Josiah had been king of Judah for 18 years. Josiah was now around 26 years old. Josiah had finished removing all of the idols and pagan altars from Judah and from part of the territory of Israel. Then Josiah decided to repair the temple of Yahweh in Jerusalem. Josiah needed to repair the temple because the previous kings of Judah had not taken care of it, and the temple was now in poor condition.

Stop here and describe a building in your area that is in poor condition. Why is this building in poor condition? Who is responsible for fixing the building? Describe this building to each other and compare this building to how it looked when it was new. Pause this audio here.

To pay for the repairs, Josiah will use the money that the doorkeepers collected at the temple. We do not know why the doorkeepers had collected money at the temple. This money was probably the temple tax that Moses commanded every Israelite male over 20 years old to pay. The people gave this money to help care for the place of worship, first the tabernacle and then the temple. The people may have given this tax to the doorkeeper when the people came to the temple in Jerusalem. The doorkeepers were responsible for making sure only authorized people entered Yahweh's temple. The doorkeepers also helped to care for the temple. It is also possible that the Levites living in the different regions collected the tax for the people and brought it to the doorkeeper in Jerusalem. The people of Judah, plus people from the territories of Manasseh, Ephraim, Benjamin, and the entire remnant of Israel, gave money to repair the temple in Jerusalem. Although enemies had conquered the northern kingdom of Israel many years before, some Israelites still survived and lived in the land of Israel. These Israelites were the "remnant," or those Israelite people who still lived in Israel.

Stop here and tell a story about a time when your community collected money or materials for something that would benefit everyone. Why was it important to your people to collect money or materials for this cause? Who were the leaders of this project? How long did it take to raise the money or collect the materials? How did your people feel about it? Pause this audio here.

All of the temple doorkeepers were Levites, and they were important officials. The Levites were one tribe of Israel, and the Levites had the special responsibility to take care of the temple and lead all of the activities at the temple.

Stop here and discuss these questions: In your culture, which jobs or responsibilities belong only to one family, clan, or tribe? How do your people feel about this? How do the members of that family, clan, or tribe feel about this? How important is that job or responsibility to your people? Pause this audio here.

Josiah sent three officials to oversee repairs to the temple. These men gave the money from the temple doorkeepers to Hilkiah the high priest. Hilkiah gave the money to the men who were overseeing the work on the temple. The storyteller named four overseers, all of whom were Levites. These men's names were Jahath, Obadiah, Zechariah, and Meshullam. The Levites were all descended from Levi, one of Jacob and Leah's sons. Levi had three sons, Merari, Kohath, and Gershon, and each son's descendants were a family group. In this story, Jahath and Obadiah came from Merari's family, and Zechariah and Meshullam came from Kohath's family. The Levites were in charge of watching over the workers fixing the temple. The Levites made sure the wood and stone workers did their jobs well. The workers did their jobs honestly and used the money the right way.

While Shaphan, Maaseiah, Joah, and Hilkiah were bringing out the money to the workers in the temple, Hilkiah found a book. Though many translations call this a book, this was actually a collection of scrolls. A scroll is a long strip of material on which people would write down stories, laws, histories, family lines, or anything else that people wanted to remember. Usually, people would write on strips of papyrus or parchment. This book contained the Law of Yahweh. These are the instructions that Yahweh gave the Israelites about how the people should live and how they should worship Yahweh. Sometimes people called this law "the Law of Moses," because Yahweh told these things to Moses and then Moses wrote them down.

Stop here and discuss these questions: What stories are especially important to your people? Which of these important stories tell your people about what rules people should follow? Have your people written any of these stories in books? What might happen to your people if you did not have these stories? Pause this audio here.

Hilkiah gave the book to Shaphan. Shaphan took the book and went to see King Josiah. First, Shaphan told Josiah that he had given the money to the workers in the temple and that the workers were doing the work they were supposed to do. Then Shaphan told Josiah that Hilkiah had found a book in the temple. This strongly implies that Hilkiah, the other priests, the people, and King Josiah had not heard the words in the Book of the Law before. So Shaphan read the book out loud to King Josiah.

Stop here and discuss these questions: Do your people have a story that involves a book that people lost and then found again? If so, tell that story now. If not, tell any story about an important object that someone lost

and then someone found again. Why was the object so important to the people in the story? Why was the object lost? What happened after someone found the object again? Pause this audio here.

When Josiah heard what the Book of the Law of Yahweh said, Josiah felt very sad. Josiah was sad because Josiah realized the people of Judah had not done all the things that the Law of Yahweh required. To show how sad Josiah was, Josiah tore Josiah's clothes.

Stop here and discuss this question: When someone in your culture feels very sad, what does that person do to show other people that they are very sad? How often do people do this thing? Pause this audio here.

Josiah realized that the people of Israel and Judah had not been obeying Yahweh's instructions for a long time. Josiah became very worried for himself and the people. The Law of Yahweh said that Yahweh would bless the people if the people obeyed Yahweh's commands, but that Yahweh would punish the people if the people disobeyed Yahweh's commands. Josiah suddenly understood that because the people had disobeyed for many years, something very bad was going to happen.

Stop here and tell a story about a time when you knew something bad was going to happen. How did you feel? How did other people in that situation feel? Did you try to stop the bad thing from happening? What was the result? Pause this audio here.

So Josiah sent Hilkiah, Shaphan, Shaphan's son Ahikam, Micah's son Abdon, and Asaiah the king's servant to ask Yahweh what to do. Josiah did this because he wanted to know how Yahweh felt about the situation and what Yahweh wanted Josiah and the people to do.

Stop and discuss these questions: In your culture, when someone is worried or has a big problem, who does that person ask for advice? How easy is it to ask other people for advice? Who do you think gives good advice, and who gives bad advice?

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 34:8–21 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: Josiah chooses people to oversee the temple's repair. These men give the money the Levites collected to Hilkiah, the high priest. The workers make the repairs faithfully.

In the second scene: Hilkiah the priest finds the Book of the Law in the temple and gives it to Shaphan the scribe. Shaphan takes the book and reads it out loud to King Josiah.

In the third scene: When Josiah hears what the Book of the Law says, Josiah is very sad. So Josiah sends his servants to ask Yahweh what to do.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Josiah
- Shaphan, Maaseiah, and Joah
- Hilkiah, the high priest
- The Levites
- The people of Manasseh, Ephraim, and all the remnant of Israel
- The people of Judah and Benjamin
- The people who live in Jerusalem
- The overseers in the house of Yahweh: Jahath, Obadiah, Zechariah, and Meshullam
- The workmen in the house of Yahweh
- Ahikam, Abdon, and Asaiah
- And Yahweh

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first scene, after Josiah had been the king for 18 years, Josiah began to repair the temple of Yahweh. Josiah may have wanted to repair the temple as part of Josiah's process to purify the land and the temple, or Josiah may have started to repair the temple after Josiah had purified the land and the temple. You should follow the translations that you have in your area's major languages. In the previous story, Josiah purified the land by destroying all the idols and foreign altars, not only in Judah but also in the territories of Manasseh, Ephraim, Naphtali, and Simeon. The storyteller does not mention how Josiah purified Yahweh's temple. The storyteller might assume that his audience understands that this means Josiah removed any false gods or idols from Yahweh's temple.

Stop here and discuss this question: When your people hear that Josiah purified the temple, what will they think this means? Pause this audio here.

Josiah needed money, wood, and stone to repair Yahweh's temple. Josiah would use the money that the doorkeepers collected at the temple. The doorkeepers had collected money not only from the people of Judah and Jerusalem, but also from the people of Manasseh, Ephraim, Benjamin, and all the remnant of Israel. The doorkeepers were probably storing the money they collected in one of the temple's storerooms.

Stop here and look at a map that shows the location of the territory that belonged to each of the tribes of Israel. Pay attention to the location of the territories of Manasseh, Ephraim, and Benjamin. Pause this audio here.

Some Levites worked as doorkeepers or gatekeepers in the temple. The remnant of Israel is the small group of people from the northern kingdom of Israel who were left in the land after the Assyrian army attacked them. The Assyrians killed many Israelites, took some of the Israelites prisoner, and left a few of the Israelites alive in the destroyed land.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How will you talk about the "remnant" of Israel? Pause this audio here.

Josiah sent three officials to repair Yahweh's temple. These officials were probably responsible for coordinating the work as Josiah's official representatives. The officials were Shaphan the son of Azaliah, Maaseiah, and Joah the son of Joahaz. Later in the story, the storyteller says that Shaphan was a scribe. A scribe was a person who could read and write. The scribes had very important religious jobs, such as making copies of the Law that Moses had given to the Israelites. But the scribes also worked for the king.

Stop here and discuss which word you will use for "scribe." Pause this audio here.

Maaseiah was a very important official. Many Bible scholars think Maaseiah was the governor, the most important government official in Jerusalem.

Stop here and discuss this question: What words do you have for the person who is the most important government official of a city? Pause this audio here.

Joah was a recorder. A recorder was something different from a scribe. Like a scribe, a recorder could read and write. But it seems that a recorder had a very special and specific job to write down things that the king said and did. The recorder might have also been responsible to tell other government officials what the king said and did. You should choose a word for "recorder" that is different from the word that you use for "scribe."

Stop here and discuss these questions: What words do you have for a person who can read and write, who is also a very important government official? Which of these words could mean a person who writes down what the king or highest leader says? Which of these words could you use here? Pause this audio here.

Shaphan, Maaseiah, and Joah gave the money that the doorkeepers had been collecting to Hilkiah the high priest. The high priest was the leader of all the priests in Yahweh's temple. The high priest was the most important priest who had very important responsibilities in Yahweh's temple. In this story, King Josiah also trusted the high priest to make sure that the workers repairing Yahweh's temple did a good job.

Stop here and discuss: Think of a group of people in your culture who do a special religious job. What words or phrases do you have for the person who is the religious leader of this group? Think about how you might say "high priest" in your language. Pause this audio here.

King Josiah needed craftsmen or skilled workers to repair Yahweh's temple. A smaller group of overseers managed all of the workers in the temple. The overseers' job was to make sure that the workers did their work correctly.

Stop here and discuss this question: What words do you have in your language for someone who oversees the work of other people? Pause this audio here.

The workmen gave the money to carpenters and builders to buy the materials to repair the temple of Yahweh. A carpenter is someone who knows how to make things out of wood. A builder is a more generic term for someone who knows how to build things. The builder might be able to build things out of wood, stone, or even other materials. The builders could work with quarried stone, which is stone that the workers have already cut into the desired shape.

Stop here and discuss these questions: What words or phrases do you have for stone that someone has already cut into a specific shape? If you do not have a word or phrase for this, how can you make sure that your hearers know that people had already cut this stone into the desired shape? Pause this audio here.

Timber is another word for wood. The workers used the wood to make joists and beams. A beam is a large, thick, long piece of wood that the workers used to build the roof of the house. Bible scholars are not sure what the joists were. Some translations call these “braces,” “couplings,” or “binders.” A joist might have been a smaller piece of wood that people used to attach two larger pieces of wood together.

Stop here and discuss these questions: What words do you have for a large, thick, and long piece of wood that you use to make the roof of a house? What words do you have for a smaller piece of wood that you use to attach two larger pieces of wood together? If you do not have words for these things, how can you describe these items so that your readers will understand what they are? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller says that the kings of Judah let these buildings become ruins. The storyteller does not mean that all of the kings of Judah allowed the temple of Yahweh to become ruined. The storyteller probably means that only certain kings of Judah allowed the temple to become ruined. It is acceptable here to say something like “the houses which some of the kings of Judah had allowed to become ruined.”

Stop here and describe a building in your area that people have not taken care of and is now in bad condition. What words or phrases do you use to describe this building? Pause this audio here.

The storyteller says that the workers did their work faithfully. This means that the workers were honest, did a good job, and did not steal or waste the money the workers received.

Stop here and discuss this question: How do you describe a worker who is honest and does a good job? Pause this audio here.

Next, the storyteller names some of the men who were the overseers of the work to repair the temple. Jahath and Obadiah were Levites who were descended from Merari, one of the three sons of Levi. Zechariah and Meshullam were Levites who were descendants of Kohath, another son of Levi. These Levites supervised the burden bearers and all the workmen. A burden bearer was probably a worker who helped move heavy objects from one place to another. Stones and beams of wood were large and heavy, and these objects probably required many men to move them from one place to another.

Stop here and discuss this question: In your language, what words do you have for a worker who helps to move heavy objects from one place to another? Pause this audio here.

Next, the storyteller mentions that all of the Levites were skilled at playing musical instruments. We do not know if the phrase “all of these Levites” refers to the Levites that the storyteller has just told us oversee the work, or if this is a separate group of Levites. It might seem odd that the storyteller says this in the middle of a story about repairing the temple. Bible scholars are not sure why the storyteller says this. But the storyteller does say this, and you should work this statement into your story in the most natural way possible. Some of the Levites were scribes, officials, and gatekeepers.

In the second scene, Shaphan, Maaseiah, and Joah were still at the temple with Hilkiah the high priest. These men were in the process of giving the money to the overseers and the workmen so that they could repair the temple of Yahweh. While Shaphan, Maaseiah, Joah, and Hilkiah were doing this, Hilkiah found the Book of the Law of Yahweh. Bible scholars do not agree on exactly what this book was, but scholars do agree that the book contained at least part of the five books of Moses, which are the first five books in the Bible. These books are

called the books of Moses because Moses wrote these books down. The Book of the Law of Yahweh included instructions for how to worship Yahweh.

Hilkiah told Shaphan that Hilkiah found the Book of the Law. Then Hilkiah gave the book to Shaphan. Shaphan took the book with him when Shaphan went to report to King Josiah. First, Shaphan told King Josiah that the workers in the temple of Yahweh were doing what Josiah wanted the workers to do. Shaphan specifically told Josiah that the overseers had given the money for repairs to all of the supervisors and workers. This is the information that Josiah was expecting to hear from Shaphan. Then Shaphan told Josiah that Hilkiah had found a book in the temple. Shaphan read the book out loud to Josiah. Be sure to say this in a way that is clear to your listeners that Shaphan did not read the book silently but read it out loud so that everyone could hear.

In the third scene, when Josiah heard what the Book of the Law of Yahweh said, Josiah felt very sad. Josiah showed that he felt very sad by tearing Josiah's clothes. If your hearers will not understand that Josiah tore his clothes because Josiah felt sad, it is acceptable to say something like, "Josiah tore his clothes to show that he was sad."

Stop here and discuss these questions: How clear will the meaning be when your hearers hear the statement "Josiah tore his clothes"? Will you add a statement to clarify that Josiah tore his clothes to show that Josiah was sad? Pause this audio here.

Josiah was sad because Josiah realized that he and his people had failed to obey many of Yahweh's commands. Then Josiah gave an order to some of his officials. Josiah gave this order to Hilkiah the high priest and to Shaphan the scribe, but Josiah also included Ahikam the son of Shaphan, Abdon the son of Micah, and another man named Asaiah. The storyteller does not tell us what job Ahikam and Abdon did, but the storyteller does say that Asaiah was Josiah's attendant. An attendant is simply a person who helps the king in whatever way the king needs.

Stop here and discuss this question: What words do you have for a person who helps another person in whatever way that person needs help? Pause this audio here.

Josiah told Hilkiah, Ahikam, Abdon, Shaphan, and Asaiah to inquire of Yahweh. To inquire of Yahweh simply means to talk to Yahweh and find out what Yahweh wants. When an Israelite wanted to inquire of Yahweh, that person usually asked a prophet. Josiah wanted his officials to find out what Yahweh had to say about the words in the Book of the Law. "The words of this book" actually mean the teachings or instructions that are in the book.

Josiah said that their ancestors had not kept the word of Yahweh. To keep the word of Yahweh means to obey Yahweh's instructions. Josiah realized that Yahweh was probably angry with the people because the people's ancestors had not obeyed the instructions in the Book of the Law.

Stop here and discuss these questions: What words or phrases do you have in your language that mean to obey the instructions that a person of higher status gives you? Which of these could you use here? Pause this audio here.

Josiah also said that Yahweh has poured out his wrath against the people. This is just a special way to say that Yahweh is very angry with the people of Judah and Israel.

Stop here and discuss these questions: In your language, how do you say that one person is very angry at another person? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 34:8–21 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Josiah

- Shaphan, Maaseiah, and Joah
- Hilkiah, the high priest
- The Levites
- The people of Manasseh, Ephraim, and all the remnant of Israel
- The people of Judah and Benjamin
- The people who live in Jerusalem
- The overseers in the house of Yahweh: Jahath, Obadiah, Zechariah, and Meshullam
- The workmen in the house of Yahweh
- Ahikam, Abdon, and Asaiah
- And Yahweh

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

After Josiah had been the king for 18 years, and he had finished cleansing all the idols from the land and from the temple of Yahweh, Josiah sent three officials to repair the temple of Yahweh, Josiah’s God. The officials’ names were Shaphan son of Azaliah, Maaseiah the highest official of Jerusalem, and Joah son of Joahaz, who kept the government records. These three men went to see Hilkiah the high priest. The men gave Hilkiah the money that the doorkeepers of the temple had collected from the people of Manasseh, Ephraim, and the rest of Israel, as well as from those who lived in Judah, Benjamin, and Jerusalem.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Josiah, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I feel excited that we are finally going to repair the temple of Yahweh and make it look as beautiful as it once did; or
- I am grateful that Yahweh has made it possible for me to be the one who will make Yahweh’s temple look wonderful again; or
- I hope that when the people see the repaired temple of Yahweh, the people will remember that Yahweh is the one true God.

Ask the people playing Shaphan, Maaseiah, and Joah, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- We feel happy that the people gave so much money to repair the temple of Yahweh; or
- We feel proud of our people. Our people were very generous and donated this money to make the temple of Yahweh look good again; or
- I hope that when the people see the repaired temple of Yahweh, the people will remember that Yahweh is the one true God.

Continue the drama.

Shaphan, Maaseiah, and Joah gave the money to the men appointed to oversee the work on Yahweh’s temple. The overseers paid the men who repaired and restored the temple. The overseers also gave money to the carpenters and builders to purchase prepared stone, wood for the braces, and beams for the buildings that the recent kings of Judah allowed to become ruined. And the workers did their work honestly. The workers’ overseers were Jahath and Obadiah, who were Levites from the clan of Merari, and also Zechariah and

Meshullam, who were Levites from the clan of Kohath. The Levites, who were all skilled at playing musical instruments, were also in charge of the men who transported the materials and supervised all the workmen doing various jobs. And some of the Levites were scribes, officials and doorkeepers.

Stop here. Ask the people playing Jahath, Obadiah, Zechariah, Meshullam, and the Levites, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We feel honored that the king has trusted us to lead this great work; or
- We feel so happy that King Josiah is restoring the temple; or
- This is a holy task. We must make sure that the work goes well and that the workers use the money wisely; or
- Once the people see a beautiful temple, maybe it will help the people return to worshiping Yahweh!

Ask the people playing the workers in the temple of Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We feel proud that we get to use our skills to make this temple beautiful again; or
- This is not an ordinary building project. We are repairing the house of God; or
- We must be very honest and work hard. Yahweh will know if we do not do this the right way; or
- We want to show the king and the overseers that we are trustworthy and faithful.

Continue the drama.

While the overseers were bringing out the money that the Levites collected at the temple of Yahweh, Hilkiah the high priest found the Book of the Law of Yahweh, which Moses wrote. Hilkiah told Shaphan the scribe, "I have found the Book of the Law in Yahweh's temple!" Then Hilkiah gave the book to Shaphan. Shaphan took the book to the king and said, "Your officials are doing everything you assigned them to do. We gave the money that the Levites collected to the supervisors and the workmen." Shaphan also told the king, "Hilkiah the priest has given me a book." So Shaphan read the book to the king.

Stop here. Ask the person playing Hilkiah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I have heard about a book of the Law of Yahweh, but I have never seen it. Could this be it? or
- I feel worried that our people have disobeyed Yahweh's law; or
- I am in awe. These are the very words of Yahweh that Moses himself wrote! This could change everything for our people; or
- The king must hear the words of this book.

Ask the person playing Shaphan, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- This might be the most important discovery of my lifetime! or
- I am excited that we are about to find out more information about how to please Yahweh; or
- What will the king do when the king hears the words of this book?

Continue the drama.

When Josiah heard what was in the Book of the Law of Yahweh, Josiah tore his clothes in sorrow. Josiah immediately called together Hilkiah, Shaphan, Ahikam the son of Shaphan, Abdon the son of Micah, and Josiah's servant Asaiah. Josiah said, "Go and speak to Yahweh on my behalf and on behalf of all the remnant of Israel and Judah. Ask Yahweh about the contents of this book. For Yahweh must be very angry at us because our ancestors have not obeyed Yahweh's instructions. We have not been doing everything that this book says we must do."

Stop here. Ask the person playing Josiah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am sad because I did not know that we were supposed to do all these things; or
- I am afraid because Yahweh would be right to punish us for disobeying Yahweh's instructions; or
- I must find out what Yahweh wants me to do about this situation; or
- It is my responsibility as the king to show the people how to obey Yahweh's law.

Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am pleased with Josiah's humility and repentance. Josiah is really sad that the people have not obeyed me; or
- Now that the people have found the Book of the Law, we will see if they will obey it or not; or
- Although the people have disobeyed me for a very long time, I will have mercy on anyone who repents and begins to live the right way.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 34:8–21 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

After Josiah had ruled for 18 years, when Josiah had **purified** or cleansed the land and the **temple**, Josiah sent Shaphan, the son of Azaliah, Maaseiah, a high official of the **city** of **Jerusalem**, and Joah, son of Joahaz, the royal historian, to repair the temple of **Yahweh**, Josiah's **God**. Be sure to use the same words you used in previous stories for purify, temple, city, Jerusalem, Yahweh, and God. See the Master Glossary for more information on purify, temple, Jerusalem, Yahweh, and God.

Shaphan, Maaseiah, and Joah came to Hilkiah the high priest and gave Hilkiah the money that the people had brought into the house of God. The high priest was the leader of all the priests in the temple of Yahweh. The high priest was the most important priest who had very important responsibilities in Yahweh's temple.

Stop here and decide what word or phrase you will use for **high priest**. Look up high priest in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The **doorkeepers** of the temple, who were **Levites**, collected this money from the people of Manasseh and Ephraim, from all the remnant of **Israel**, from all the people of **Judah** and Benjamin, and all the people who lived in Jerusalem. Be sure to use the same words you used in previous stories for doorkeeper, Levite, Israel, and Judah. See the Master Glossary for more information on Levite, Israel, and Judah.

Then these men gave the money to the men who were overseers of the temple of Yahweh, and the men in the temple of Yahweh used the money to restore and repair the temple. An overseer manages a group of workers. The overseers' job was to make sure that the workers did their work correctly.

Stop here and decide what word or phrase you will use for **overseer**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The workmen gave money to the carpenters and builders to buy prepared stone, wood for braces, and to make beams for the buildings, which the recent **kings** of Judah had allowed to fall into disrepair. Be sure to use the same word you used in previous stories for king. See the Master Glossary for more information on king.

A carpenter is someone who knows how to make things out of wood. A builder is a more generic term for someone who knows how to build things. The builder might be able to build things out of wood, stone, or even other materials.

Stop here and decide what words or phrases you will use for **carpenter** and **builder**. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same words that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The men did this work completely honestly. The overseers who supervised the men were Jahath and Obadiah, Levites from the clan of Merari, plus Zechariah and Meshullam, Levites from the clan of Kohath. The Levites, who were all skilled at playing musical instruments, also supervised the men who moved materials from one place to another and supervised all the workmen on various jobs. And some of the Levites were **scribes** and officials

and doorkeepers. Be sure to use the same word you used in previous stories for scribe. See the Master Glossary for more information on scribe**.**

> While the overseers were bringing out the money that the Levites collected at the temple of Yahweh, Hilkiah the high priest found the "Book, or Scroll, of the Law of Yahweh," which Moses wrote. Hilkiah gave the scroll to Shaphan. Shaphan took the scroll and went to see the king. Be sure to use the same word or phrase that you used in previous stories for "Book, or Scroll, of the Law of Yahweh." For more information, refer to **scroll** and **law** in the Master Glossary.
>
> Shaphan read the book to the king. When King Josiah heard the words written in the Book of the Law of Yahweh, Josiah tore his **robes** in sorrow. The king immediately commanded Hilkiah, Shaphan, Ahikam the son of Shaphan, Abdon the son of Micah, and Josiah's own **servant**, Asaiah, "Go and inquire of Yahweh for me and for those who are left in Israel and Judah. Find out about the instructions in this book that Hilkiah found. For Yahweh's **wrath** must be very great, because our ancestors have not obeyed the **word** of Yahweh. They have not followed the instructions in this book." Be sure to use the same words you used in previous stories for robe, servant, wrath, and word. See the Master Glossary for more information on robe, servant, wrath, and word.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

2 Chronicles 34:22–33

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 34:22–33 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 34:22–33 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.

4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 34:22–33 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passage, Hilkiah, the high priest, found the Book, or Scroll, of the Law in the temple, and King Josiah's scribe read the book to King Josiah. Josiah was very sad because the Israelite people had not obeyed Yahweh's commands in the Book of the Law. Josiah ordered Hilkiah and some other men to go to a prophet to ask Yahweh for wisdom.

Stop here and listen as a group: If you have already translated 2 Kings 22:14–23:14, which contains the same information, listen to your translation now. Pause this audio here.

In this passage, Hilkiah the high priest and some other men go to ask Yahweh for wisdom through a prophetess, or female prophet, whom people call "Huldah." Josiah wants these men to find out what Yahweh says about the Israelite people's disobedience to Yahweh's law. A prophet gives messages from God to the people. People call Huldah's husband "Shallum." Shallum's father is Tokhath, and Shallum's grandfather is Hasrah. In 2 Kings 22, people call Tokhath by the name "Tikvah," and people call Hasrah by the name "Harhas."

Hasrah is the keeper of the wardrobe for the temple. The wardrobe may be the special clothing people wear at religious functions. Hasrah probably takes care of the clothing that priests and Levites wear when they serve in the temple. Priests are people who serve God in the temple. Levites are Levi's descendants who serve the priests. Huldah lives in a part of Jerusalem that people call the New Quarter or the Second Quarter, but we are not sure exactly where this part of the city is. Jerusalem is the most important city in Israel.

Stop here as a group and look at a map of the country of Judah, including the city of Jerusalem. Pause this audio here.

Huldah tells the men to tell King Josiah what Yahweh, the God of Israel, says about the Israelite people's disobedience. Yahweh will cause disaster, or bad things, to happen in the country of Judah and will punish the people in Jerusalem and Judah. All the curses from the Book, or Scroll, of the Law will come true. In the Book of the Law, Yahweh promised to bless the people if the people obeyed Yahweh's commands, but Yahweh promised to curse the people if they did not obey Yahweh's commands. This is the same Book of the Law that Hilkiah found in the temple.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story about a time when people knew that if they did certain kinds of things, their god would bless or curse the people. Pause this audio here.

Yahweh will bring disaster or bad things because the people of Israel and Judah rejected Yahweh and offered incense to other gods and idols that the people made. Yahweh is very angry with the people of Judah, and Yahweh's wrath will make Yahweh act against the people of Judah.

However, Huldah has a separate message from Yahweh specifically for King Josiah. When Josiah heard Yahweh's words in the Book of the Law, Josiah humbled himself and tore his robes and wept. Because Josiah regretted what his people had done and humbled himself, Yahweh promises that Yahweh will not send disaster on the land and the people right away. Josiah will go to his ancestors in peace. Yahweh will allow Josiah to die, and Josiah's people will bury Josiah peacefully before Yahweh sends disaster. Josiah will not have to see the bad things that Yahweh will send to the country and the people.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story where someone promises to punish a group of people, but the person delays their actions to protect someone or a group of people that they like. Pause this audio here.

The men report all of Huldah's words to King Josiah. King Josiah commands all the elders, or older leaders, in Jerusalem and the rest of Judah to meet with Josiah, so they all come together and go to Yahweh's temple. The rest of the people who live in Jerusalem, people who live in the other towns in Judah, the priests, and the Levites all join Josiah and the elders at the temple. All kinds of people go with Josiah to Yahweh's temple, from the least

important to the most important person in Jerusalem and Judah. In the story in 2 Kings 22, the storyteller says prophets, not Levites, go to the temple with Josiah. Yahweh often speaks to the Israelites through prophets, and Levites are men from the tribe of Levi who assist the priests in the temple. Because all of the people in Jerusalem and Judah go to the temple, most likely both the Levites and prophets probably join King Josiah and all the rest of the people at the temple.

Josiah reads out loud everything that Yahweh says in the Book of the Covenant. When people make a covenant, people make a solemn promise that they cannot break. The Book of the Covenant describes Yahweh's covenant with the people of Israel. The Book of the Covenant and the Book of the Law are the same book. You will remember that Hilkiah found this book in the temple.

After Josiah finishes reading, Josiah stands in the place that people reserve for the king by the pillar. Kings probably stand in this place when they make important official announcements and speak with authority. Throughout the Old Testament, storytellers describe leaders who make covenants between Yahweh and the people. Each time a leader makes a new covenant or renews an old covenant, the leader stands in front of all the people and reads the covenant out loud. When Josiah renews this covenant, Josiah reminds the people how Yahweh makes covenants with Yahweh's people, the Israelites.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a pillar. Pause this audio here.

Josiah promises to obey Yahweh and to keep Yahweh's commands, testimonies, and statutes completely and faithfully with all Josiah's heart and soul. By promising to obey all of Yahweh's words, Josiah renews the covenant with Yahweh.

Josiah orders all the people who are present to promise to keep the covenant as well. So the people from Jerusalem and Judah obey the covenant they made with God, the God of their ancestors. An ancestor is someone from whom a person descended. Yahweh has been the God of the Israelite people through many generations of ancestors. Because Josiah orders the people to keep the covenant, the people obey Yahweh again.

King Josiah removes all the detestable idols from the whole country of Israel. Josiah requires everyone in Israel to serve Yahweh their God. Throughout Josiah's lifetime, the people do not turn away from following Yahweh, the God of their ancestors.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 34:22–33 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has three scenes.

In the first scene: The high priest Hilkiah and other men go to speak with the prophet Huldah in Jerusalem. Huldah tells the men that Yahweh promises to bring disaster on Judah and its people because the people rejected Yahweh and served other gods. However, Huldah says Yahweh will not punish the people until after Josiah dies because Josiah responded with humility.

In the second scene: When the men tell Josiah about Yahweh's words through Huldah, Josiah calls all the people of Judah, from the least to the greatest, to come to the temple in Jerusalem. Josiah reads the words of Yahweh's covenant from the Book of the Covenant out loud. Then Josiah and all the people renew the covenant with Yahweh.

In the third scene: Josiah removes all the idols from Judah and Israel. As long as Josiah lives, the people obey Yahweh, the God of Israel.

The characters in this passage are:

- Hilkiah
- Men whom Josiah sends with Hilkiah
- Huldah

- Yahweh
- King Josiah
- Elders of Judah and Jerusalem
- Priests and Levites
- And all the rest of the people who live in Jerusalem

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first scene, Hilkiah the high priest and some other men go to inquire, or to find out, what Yahweh says about something. The men go to the prophetess Huldah. Huldah's husband is Shallum, whose father is Tokhath and whose grandfather is Hasrah. Hasrah was the keeper of the wardrobe for the temple. Huldah lives in a part of Jerusalem that people call the New Quarter.

Because Huldah is a prophetess, Huldah speaks the message of Yahweh. Huldah tells the men, "This is what Yahweh, the God of Israel, says." In the Bible, prophets use language like this to introduce an important message from Yahweh. Huldah wants the men to know that Yahweh has a serious message for King Josiah. When Huldah speaks to the men, the men should understand that they are listening to Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story where one person speaks for another person. In the story, people should understand that they are hearing words from the second person even though the first person is speaking. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group: You just told a story about one person who speaks for another person. How did you help your audience understand who is speaking and whose words that person speaks? Pause this audio here.

Through Huldah, Yahweh says, "I will cause bad things to happen in this country and will punish the people in it. All the curses that someone read to Josiah from the Book of the Law will come true. I will do this because the people from Israel and Judah rejected me and burned incense to other gods. I am angry because of all the idols that the people made. I will pour out my anger on Jerusalem, and no one will be able to stop it. My anger is like a fire that no one can put out."

Yahweh is angry because the people disobeyed Yahweh's commands when the people burned incense to other gods and created idols. Yahweh will cause disaster or bad things to happen to the people in Jerusalem. Yahweh will pour out or show all of Yahweh's anger to the people of Jerusalem. The storyteller describes Yahweh's anger with special language that compares anger to a fire that no one can quench or put out.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How do you talk about anger in your culture? What kinds of words or phrases will help you describe Yahweh's anger here? Pause this audio here.

Yahweh keeps speaking through Huldah, but now Yahweh has a different message specifically for King Josiah. Yahweh says, "This is what I say about the words you read in the Book of the Law. You were sorry when you heard the words from the book, and your heart was tender, so you humbled yourself before me when you heard what I will do to the people from Judah and Jerusalem. You tore your clothes in sorrow and wept in front of me. I heard you, so now I will let you die, and your people will bury you peacefully. You will not be alive when I bring all the bad things to the people of Judah and Jerusalem."

When the storyteller says Josiah's heart was tender, the storyteller means Josiah cared and felt sad because the people of Judah and Jerusalem disobeyed Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How do you talk about the way a person dies peacefully in your culture? Pause this audio here.

In the second scene, the king's men return to Josiah and report all of Yahweh's words. King Josiah commands all the elders in Jerusalem and the rest of Judah to meet with Josiah, so they all come together and go to Yahweh's temple. The rest of the people who live in Jerusalem, people who live in the other towns in Judah, the priests, and the Levites all join Josiah and the elders at the temple. All kinds of people go with Josiah to Yahweh's temple, from the least important to the most important person in Jerusalem and Judah.

Josiah reads out loud all the words that Yahweh wrote in the Book of the Covenant, which is the same Book of the Law that Hilkiah the high priest found in the temple. You will remember that this was really a scroll, or a long piece of parchment that someone turned around a long stick. King Josiah stands in his place by the

pillar and renews the covenant with Yahweh. Josiah promises to follow Yahweh and to faithfully keep Yahweh's commands, testimonies, and statutes. These three words—commands, testimonies, and statutes—together refer to everything that Yahweh says. Josiah promises to obey every word that Yahweh says, and Josiah will obey with all Josiah's heart and soul. In the Bible, the storyteller uses a person's heart as special language for the place where a person's thoughts, feelings, and decisions happen. A person's soul represents the invisible part of a person, or a person's thoughts, feelings, and desires. Josiah promises to follow Yahweh completely and faithfully.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story about someone who obeys someone else completely and faithfully. How do you describe a person who obeys like this? Pause this audio here.

After Josiah renews the covenant, Josiah orders all the people who are present to make a similar promise. So the people from Jerusalem promise to obey the covenant they made with God, the God of the people's ancestors.

In the third scene, Josiah removes all the detestable idols that people made in the entire land of Israel. You will remember that something that is detestable is something that Yahweh hates very much. Josiah requires every person in the land of Israel to worship Yahweh their God. As long as Josiah lives, the people obey Yahweh, the God of their ancestors.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 34:22–33 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has three scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Hilkiah
- Men whom Josiah sends with Hilkiah
- Huldah
- Yahweh
- King Josiah
- Elders of Judah and Jerusalem
- Priests and Levites
- And all the rest of the people who live in Jerusalem

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Hilkiah the high priest and some other men go to inquire of Yahweh through the prophetess Huldah. Huldah's husband is Shallum, whose father is Tokhath and whose grandfather is Hasrah, the keeper of the temple wardrobe. Huldah lives in a part of Jerusalem that people call the New Quarter.

Huldah tells the men, "This is what Yahweh, the God of Israel, says: 'I will cause bad things to happen in this country and will punish the people in it. All the curses that someone read to Josiah from the Book of the Law will come true. I will do this because the people from Israel and Judah rejected me and burned incense to other

2 Chronicles 34:22–33

gods. I am angry because of all the idols that the people made. I will pour out my anger on Jerusalem, and no one will be able to stop it. My anger is like a fire that no one can put out.'"

Yahweh continues to speak with a different message specifically for King Josiah. Yahweh says, "This is what I say about the words you read in the Book of the Law. You were sorry when you heard the words from the book, and you humbled yourself before me when you heard what I will do to the people from Judah and Jerusalem. You tore your clothes in sorrow and wept in front of me. I heard you, so now I will let you die, and your people will bury you peacefully. You will not be alive when I bring all the bad things to the people of Judah and Jerusalem."

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Hilkiah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am afraid of Yahweh's anger; or
- I am afraid that King Josiah may become angry with us because we bring a serious message from Yahweh.

Ask the person playing Huldah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am fearful that these men might not believe that the words I speak belong to Yahweh; or
- I feel angry that my people have disobeyed Yahweh and received Yahweh's great anger and punishment.

Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel very angry because my people rejected me; or
- I feel sad because I must punish my people because they failed to keep my covenant, even though I remained faithful to them; or
- I feel hopeful because King Josiah responded to me with such humility.

Continue the drama.

The men return to Josiah and report Yahweh's words. King Josiah commands all the elders in Jerusalem and the rest of Judah to meet with Josiah, so they all come together and go to Yahweh's temple. The rest of the people who live in Jerusalem, people who live in the other towns in Judah, the priests, and the Levites all join Josiah and the elders at the temple. All kinds of people go with Josiah to Yahweh's temple, from the least important to the most important person in Jerusalem and Judah.

Josiah reads out loud all the words that Yahweh wrote in the Book of the Covenant, which is the same book that Hilkiah the high priest found in the temple. King Josiah stands in his place by the pillar and renews the covenant with Yahweh. Josiah promises to follow Yahweh and to faithfully keep Yahweh's commands, testimonies, and statutes. Josiah promises to obey every word that Yahweh says, and Josiah will obey with all Josiah's heart and soul. Josiah promises to follow Yahweh completely and faithfully.

After Josiah renews the covenant, Josiah orders all the people who are present to make a similar promise. So the people from Jerusalem promise to obey the covenant they made with God, the God of their ancestors.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Josiah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel sad that my people disobeyed Yahweh; or
- I feel relieved that Yahweh will not make me see the disaster that Yahweh will bring to my people; or
- I feel sad that I must die and will not be able to continue to encourage my people to obey Yahweh.

Ask the people playing all the people of Jerusalem and Judah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We feel fearful that we will experience Yahweh's anger; or
- We feel hopeful that maybe Yahweh will not punish us if we continue to obey Yahweh as Josiah requires.

Continue the drama.

Josiah removes all the detestable idols that people made in the entire land of Israel. Josiah requires every person in the land of Israel to worship Yahweh their God. As long as Josiah lives, the people obey Yahweh, the God of their ancestors.

2 Chronicles 34:22–33

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 34:22–33 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Stop here and listen as a group: If you have already translated 2 Kings 22:14–23:14, which contains the same information, listen to your translation now. Pause this audio here.

King Josiah sends Hilkiah the **high priest** and some other men to see the prophetess Huldah. A king is someone who rules over a city or a territory. Priests were people who worked in the temple in Jerusalem. The high priest was the most important priest. Once every year, the high priest offered a sacrifice on behalf of the people for forgiveness of sins. A **prophet** is a person who gives messages from God to the people, and a prophetess is a female prophet. Use the same word or phrase for king, high priest, and prophet as you used in previous passages. For more information on king, high priest, and prophet, refer to the Master Glossary.

Huldah's husband is Shallum, who is Hasrah's grandson. Hasrah is the "keeper of the wardrobe." The wardrobe probably describes the special clothing people wear at religious functions. Hasrah probably takes care of the clothing that priests and Levites wear when they serve in the temple.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **keeper of the wardrobe**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Huldah lives in the city of **Jerusalem**. Jerusalem is the most important city in Israel, and people built Yahweh's temple in Jerusalem. Use the same word or phrase for Jerusalem as you used in previous passages. For more information on Jerusalem, refer to the Master Glossary.

As a prophet, Huldah speaks words or messages from **Yahweh**, the **God** of **Israel**. Yahweh is the name God gives himself. This name reminds people of the covenant that God made with the Israelites during the time of Moses. God created everything and is the most powerful spiritual being. Israel is the name of the territory where the Israelites lived. Use the same words or phrases for Yahweh, God, and Israel as you used in previous passages. For more information on Yahweh, God, and Israel, refer to the Master Glossary.

Yahweh tells Josiah's men that Yahweh will bring **disaster** on the land of Judah and the people who live there. A disaster is a sudden event that causes great damage or loss of life. Use the same word or phrase for disaster as you used in previous passages.

Yahweh also says that all the curses Yahweh wrote will come true. To curse someone means to wish that something bad would happen to that person. When God curses people, God promises to make bad things happen to those people.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **curse**. Look up curse in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Yahweh feels very angry with the people because the people burned incense to other gods. Yahweh says he will pour out Yahweh's strong anger, or **wrath,** on the people. In the Bible, "God" refers to the most powerful spiritual being who created everything. However, sometimes people worship other spirit beings or idols as if they have power. God told the people of Israel not to worship or follow any other **gods** but Yahweh. Use the same words or phrases for wrath and gods as you used in previous passages. Refer to the Master Glossary for more information about wrath and gods.

Yahweh says that Yahweh will not make Josiah see the disaster Yahweh will bring on the people because Josiah **humbled** himself before Yahweh. Josiah believed Yahweh's commands were more important than Josiah's desires. Yahweh will allow the people to bury Josiah in **peace**. When people live in harmony with one another without fighting, those people live in peace. Because Josiah did not fight with Yahweh about the people's disobedience, Josiah will die in peace. Use the same words or phrases for humbled and peace as you used in previous passages. For more information on peace, refer to the Master Glossary.

2 Chronicles 34:22–33

King Josiah called together all the **elders** of Jerusalem and the rest of Judah to come to the **temple**. All the rest of the people of Judah, including the **priests** and **Levites**, also meet at the temple. The elders in a community are people with authority in a community. The temple is the place where the Israelites worshiped God. Priests are people who serve God in the temple. Levites are descendants of Levi who serve the priests. Use the same words or phrases for elder, temple, priest, and Levite as you used in previous passages. For more information on elder, temple, priest, and Levite, refer to the Master Glossary.

Josiah read out loud all of the Book of the Covenant. At this time, people wrote books on a scroll, which is a long roll of material like paper that people write on and then roll up. When people make a covenant, they make a solemn promise to each other that those people cannot break.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a scroll. Pause this audio here.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for "Book, or **Scroll**, of the **Covenant**." If you have already translated this word or phrase in another book of the Bible, use the same word or phrase that you have used there. For more information on scroll and covenant, refer to the Master Glossary.

Josiah promises to keep Yahweh's **commands**, **testimonies**, and **statutes** with all of Josiah's **heart** and **soul**. When a storyteller uses commands, testimonies, and statutes all together, the storyteller talks about all that Yahweh says. A person's heart is special language for the place where a person's thoughts, feelings, and decisions happen. A person's soul represents the invisible part of a person, or a person's thoughts, feelings, and desires. Use the same words or phrases for commands, testimonies, statutes, heart, and soul as you used in previous passages. For more information on commands, testimonies, statutes, heart, and soul, refer to the Master Glossary.

Josiah required all the people to promise to keep the covenant to Yahweh, the God of their **ancestors**. An ancestor is someone from whom a person descended. Use the same word or phrase for ancestor as you used in previous passages.

Josiah removed all the **idols** from the land of Israel. An idol is an object that people make in order to worship a god. Use the same word or phrase for idol as you used in previous passages. For more information on idol, refer to the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

2 Chronicles 35:1–19

2 Chronicles 35:1–19

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 35:1–19 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 35:1–19 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 35:1–19 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passage, a prophet told King Josiah's men that Yahweh would send disaster on the people because the people had rejected Yahweh. However, because King Josiah responded to Yahweh with humility, Yahweh would not send the disaster until after Josiah died. Josiah and all the people renewed the covenant with Yahweh, and Josiah required all the people to obey Yahweh.

If you have already translated 2 Kings 23:21–23, which has some of the same information, stop here as a group and listen to your translation. Pause this audio here.

In this passage, King Josiah commands all the people to celebrate the Passover festival to honor Yahweh. Passover is an important annual Jewish festival that reminds the people of how Yahweh rescued the people from Egypt. People also call Passover the "Feast of Unleavened Bread" because Passover happens on the first day of the Feast of Unleavened Bread, so people celebrate Passover and the Feast of Unleavened Bread at about the same time. To celebrate Passover, the people eat roasted lamb along with bitter herbs and unleavened bread, or bread that people make without yeast. Yahweh gave instructions about the Passover and the Feast of Unleavened Bread to the Israelites through Moses.

If you have already translated Exodus 12:1–28 and Deuteronomy 16:1–8, where Yahweh tells the people how to celebrate Passover, stop here as a group and listen to your translations. Pause this audio here.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a lamb, a picture of bitter herbs, and a picture of unleavened bread. Pause this audio here.

On the 14th day of the first month in the Jewish calendar, people kill lambs for the Passover festival in Jerusalem. The storyteller says that the people kill the Passover lamb, but we know the people slaughter many lambs or goats as Passover offerings. People call the first month in the Jewish calendar "Abib," and this month occurs in the spring.

Josiah chooses priests to do specific work in the temple and encourages the priests to serve well. Priests are descendants of Moses' brother Aaron, the first high priest, and priests are part of the Israelite tribe of Levi. Priests work in Yahweh's temple and offer sacrifices to Yahweh on behalf of the people. Josiah then speaks to the Levites. People called the descendants of Levi who were not from Aaron's family line, and were therefore not priests, "Levites." Yahweh consecrated or gave the Levites the special duty to serve Yahweh in the temple, and the Levites taught the Israelites in the temple and helped the priests take care of the temple. Levites do not offer sacrifices to Yahweh. Priests and Levites work together to serve Yahweh in the temple.

Josiah tells the Levites to leave the ark in the temple that King Solomon, King David's son, built. You will remember from a previous passage that the "ark," or ark of the covenant, is a symbol of Yahweh's presence. Before Solomon built the temple, the priests carried the ark from place to place. The priests set the ark on poles,

and the priests carried the ark by putting the poles on the priests' shoulders. However, now the ark should stay in the temple. We do not know if someone moved the ark out of the temple or if Josiah wants the Levites to know they should not take the ark out of the temple in the future.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of the ark in the temple and a picture of the ark with the poles the priests used to carry the ark. Pause this audio here.

Josiah also tells the Levites to serve Yahweh their God and to serve the Israelite people well. Josiah tells the Levites to be ready to do the work that King David and David's son Solomon assigned to each Levite division. David and Solomon wrote instructions and organized families of Levites into larger groups that people call divisions. Each division takes responsibility for specific duties in the temple.

Josiah tells each division of Levites to stand in specific places throughout the temple. When the Israelite families who are not priests or Levites enter the temple for Passover, the Levites will be available to help. The Levites will kill the Passover lambs, and then the Levites will consecrate themselves to make themselves pure. The Levites probably wash themselves in a special way to make themselves pure. Once the Levites make themselves pure, the Levites will prepare the lambs to be Passover offerings for the lay people. The Levites will do all these things according to the instructions that Yahweh gave through Moses.

From Josiah's own herds of animals, Josiah gives enough animals for all the lay people to make Passover offerings. Josiah gives 30,000 lambs and young goats for the Passover offerings. Josiah also gives 3,000 cattle. People probably use the lambs and goats for Passover offerings, and people use the cattle for other offerings during the Feast of Unleavened Bread, which continues for several days after the Passover ends.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a lamb, a young goat, and cattle. You will remember that cattle can include cows, bulls, and oxen. Pause this audio here.

Josiah's other leaders also give freely to the people, the priests, and the Levites. Hilkiah the high priest, Zechariah, and Jehiel, the officials in charge of Yahweh's temple, give the priests 2,600 lambs and goats along with 300 cattle. The leaders of the Levites, including Conaniah and his brothers Shemaiah and Nethanel, along with Hashabiah, Jeiel, and Jozabad, give 5,000 lambs and 500 cattle to the Levites.

The priests and Levites finish preparations and stand in their places in the temple in their divisions as King Josiah ordered. The Levites kill the lambs for the Passover offerings and give the blood to the priests. The priests splash the blood on the altar while the Levites remove the skin from the animals.

At the same time that the Levites kill and skin the Passover offerings, the Levites kill and set aside other animals that the Levites prepare to be burnt offerings. When people make burnt offerings, a priest offers an entire animal on the altar until the entire animal burns up. These offerings are not the same as the Passover offerings that the priests make. The Levites will give these animals that will be burnt offerings to the family divisions of non-Levite people so that the people can offer them according to Yahweh's commands in the Book, or Scroll, of Moses. The Book of Moses probably refers to the first five books in the Old Testament. The Levites also set aside the cattle for families to use for other offerings to Yahweh.

The Levites roast lambs for the Passover offerings over a fire according to Yahweh's instructions. The Levites boil pieces of the cattle for other holy offerings in pots, caldrons, and pans. The other holy offerings may be fellowship or peace offerings, in which the priests burn the fat of the animal on the altar but boil the rest of the animal so that the priests and lay people may eat the animal. The Levites serve the meat from the Passover and other offerings to the non-Levite people immediately.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a pot, caldron, and pan. Pause this audio here.

After the Levites serve the lay people, the Levites prepare for the Passover for themselves and for the priests. The priests make offerings on the altar from the morning until the sun goes down, so the Levites prepare animals for the priests to make offerings for themselves.

Previously, King David, along with Asaph, Heman, and Jeduthun, King David's seer, assigned specific places for musicians to stand in the temple many years before this. Asaph, Hemam, and Jeduthun were musicians who served King David and led the temple musicians. A seer understands messages from God like a prophet. We are not sure if only Jeduthun was David's seer, or if Asaph, Heman, and Jeduthun were all seers for King David. Now,

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the musicians or singers, who are descendants of Asaph, stand in the places Asaph, Heman, and Jeduthun had assigned many years before. The musicians and doorkeepers, or Levites who guard the temple, do not need to leave their assigned places because the rest of their fellow Levites prepare the offerings for them.

At that time, the priests and Levites prepare everything they need to worship Yahweh. They celebrate the Passover festival and make burnt offerings on Yahweh's altar. The people do all this as King Josiah commanded them. All the people present from Israel and Judah celebrate the Passover feast on the first day and then celebrate the Feast of Unleavened Bread for the next seven days.

No one had celebrated the Passover festival in this way since the time of the prophet Samuel, who lived during the time of King David. Many previous kings in Israel celebrated the Passover festival, but none of the former kings celebrated Passover like King Josiah. Josiah celebrates the Passover with the priests, the Levites, and all the people of Jerusalem, Israel, and Judah in Jerusalem during the 18th year that Josiah rules as king.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 35:1–19 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four scenes.

In the first scene: Josiah orders all the people to celebrate the Passover feast. Josiah assigns priests and Levites to serve in specific places in their family divisions in the temple. Josiah also tells the Levites to leave the ark in Yahweh's temple and to help the Israelite laypeople celebrate Passover.

In the second scene: King Josiah provides lambs and cattle for Passover and other offerings. Josiah's officials, who take care of the temple along with the leaders of the Levites, also provide lambs and cattle for sacrifices.

In the third scene: The priests and Levites stand in their places in the temple to help the rest of the Israelite people make offerings and sacrifices to Yahweh. The Levites also make all the preparations for the rest of the Levites and priests, and the musicians and gatekeepers stay in their places because the Levites make preparations for them.

In the fourth scene: All the Israelites celebrate Passover according to Yahweh's commands that day, and the people celebrate the Feast of Unleavened Bread for the next seven days. No one had celebrated Passover in this way since the time of the prophet Samuel. Josiah celebrates Passover with the priests, Levites, and all the people from Jerusalem and Judah and Israel in the 18th year that Josiah rules as king.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Josiah
- Priests
- Levites
- Israelites who are not Levites
- Officials in charge of the temple: Hilkiah, Zechariah, and Jehiel
- Levite leaders: Conaniah, Shemaiah, Nethanel, Hashabiah, Jeiel, and Jozabad
- Musicians
- And doorkeepers

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first scene, Josiah commands all the people to celebrate the Passover in Jerusalem. The Levites kill the lambs for Passover offerings on the 14th day of the first month of the year in the Israelite calendar, which happens in our month of March or April. Yahweh had already told the people to celebrate Passover on this day each year. Josiah chooses priests to perform specific duties in the temple and encourages the priests to serve Yahweh and the Israelite people well.

Josiah then gives orders to the Levites. Yahweh consecrated or set the Levites apart for a special duty to serve Yahweh in the temple alongside the priests. Josiah tells the Levites, “Place the ark in the temple that King David’s son Solomon built. Do not carry the ark on your shoulders anymore. Now, get ready to serve Yahweh and the Israelite people. King David and his son Solomon wrote down instructions for you to organize your families into divisions. Each division should stand in its place in the temple to help the laypeople. You Levites will kill the lambs, make yourselves pure, and prepare the lambs for the Israelite laypeople as Yahweh commanded through Moses.”

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story where one person gives commands to another person about what that person will do in the future. How do you talk about actions that will happen in the future but have not happened yet? Pause this audio here.

In the second scene, the storyteller pauses the action to talk about how Josiah and Josiah’s leaders provide animals for offerings. King Josiah provides from his own flocks 30,000 lambs and goats as Passover offerings for the lay people. Josiah also provides 3,000 cattle from his own herds for other offerings. Josiah’s officials freely give more Passover offerings and cattle for the priests and Levites. Hilkiah the high priest, Zechariah, and Jehiel, the officials in charge of the temple, give the priests 2,600 Passover offerings and 300 cattle. The leaders of the Levites, including Conaniah with his brothers Shemaiah and Nethanel, along with Hashabiah, Jeiel, and Jozabad, give the Levites 5,000 Passover offerings and 500 cattle.

In the third scene, the storyteller continues the action. The priests and Levites obey Josiah’s instructions and stand in their places in the temple so they can help the Israelite laypeople. The Levites kill the Passover offerings and probably put the blood in bowls to hand to the priests. The priests splash the blood on the altar while the Levites remove the skin from the Passover animals. The Levites kill and set aside other animals that the Levites prepare to be burnt offerings, and the cattle that the Levites will boil for other offerings. The Levites give these other animals to the laypeople according to their family divisions so the people can offer the animals the way Yahweh commands in the Book of Moses.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story where one person gives instructions to another person, but then the storyteller stops the action to give more details. Then the second person continues the action when he obeys the instructions from the first person. How will you help your audience understand the timing of this story? Pause this audio here.

Stop and do this activity as a group: Act out the order of events in this passage to make sure you understand when each event happens. Pause this audio here.

The Levites roast the Passover offerings over a fire as Yahweh commanded, but the Levites boil the cattle in pots, caldrons, and pans. A pot is a deep, round utensil with a wide opening that people use to boil food in water. A caldron is a deep, round-bottomed, two-handled cooking pot. A pan is probably a wide bowl. People use pots, caldrons, and pans to boil food in water. The Levites serve the meat from the Passover offerings and the meat from the boiled cattle to the laypeople right away. After the Levites finish all the preparations for the laypeople, the Levites make preparations for themselves and for the priests. The Levites do this because the priests are busy at the altar offering burnt offerings and fat portions to Yahweh from morning to evening. Burnt offerings refer to animals that the priests burn completely on the altar. The people eat the meat from some of the other animals they offer to Yahweh, but the people give the fat portions to the priests to burn on the altar. So the Levites make the preparations for themselves and for the priests, Aaron’s descendants.

Stop here and discuss as a group: In this story, the storyteller talks about Passover offerings, burnt offerings, and other offerings. Discuss how you will describe the differences between these types of offerings. Pause this audio here.

The musicians or singers, who are descendants of Asaph, stand in the places that King David Asaph, Heman, and Jeduthun, King David’s seer, assigned to the musicians many years before. The doorkeepers, Levites who guard the gates of the temple, do not leave their places because their fellow Levites prepare everything for the doorkeepers.

In the fourth scene, all the priests and Levites worship Yahweh at that time. The priests and Levites help all the Israelites who are present to celebrate Passover and make burnt offerings on Yahweh’s altar as King Josiah

ordered. The Israelites who participate celebrate Passover and then celebrate the Feast of Unleavened Bread. The Feast of Unleavened Bread began on the day of Passover and lasted seven days. No one had celebrated Passover in this way since the time of the prophet Samuel. None of the kings from Israel or Judah celebrated the Passover as Josiah does with the priests, the Levites, and the people from Jerusalem, Judah, and Israel. The people celebrate this Passover during the 18th year that Josiah rules as king.

Stop here and discuss as a group: No one before Josiah celebrated Passover in the same way that Josiah celebrated. Josiah obeyed Yahweh's instructions about how to celebrate Passover very closely, and no one else had obeyed so carefully. How will you talk about how no one celebrated Passover "in the same way" as Josiah? Pause this audio here.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 35:1–19 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Josiah
- Priests
- Levites
- Israelites who are not Levites
- Officials in charge of the temple: Hilkiah, Zechariah, and Jehiel
- Levite leaders: Conaniah, Shemaiah, Nethanel, Hashabiah, Jeiel, and Jozabad
- Musicians
- And doorkeepers

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Josiah commands all the people to celebrate the Passover in Jerusalem. The Levites kill the lambs for Passover offerings on the 14th day of the first month of the year in the Israelite calendar. Josiah chooses priests to perform specific duties in the temple and encourages the priests to serve Yahweh and the Israelite people well. Josiah then gives orders to the Levites. Yahweh consecrated or set the Levites apart to serve Yahweh in the temple alongside the priests. Josiah tells the Levites, "Place the ark in the temple that King David's son Solomon built. Do not carry the ark on your shoulders anymore. Now, get ready to serve Yahweh and the Israelite people. King David and his son Solomon wrote down instructions for you to organize your families into divisions. Each division should stand in its place in the temple to help the laypeople. You Levites will kill the lambs, make yourselves pure, and prepare the lambs for the Israelite laypeople as Yahweh commanded through Moses."

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Josiah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel confident that the priests and Levites will obey my instructions to celebrate Passover the way Yahweh commands; or
- I feel pleased that the Israelite people will be able to make Passover offerings with the Levites' help; or
- I feel hopeful that, because we make these sacrifices, Yahweh might forgive the people and not punish them so severely.

Ask the people playing the priests and Levites, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We are happy to serve Yahweh in the temple in the way that Yahweh commands; or
- We feel excited to obey King Josiah and to help our people celebrate Passover in the right way at the right time.

Continue the drama.

King Josiah provides from his own flocks 30,000 animals for the laypeople to make Passover offerings. Josiah also provides 3,000 cattle from his own herds for other offerings. Josiah's officials freely give more Passover offerings and cattle for the priests and Levites. Hilkiah the high priest, Zechariah, and Jehiel, the officials in charge of the temple, give the priests 2,600 Passover offerings and 300 cattle. The leaders of the Levites, including Conaniah with his brothers Shemaiah and Nethanel, along with Hashabiah, Jeiel, and Jozabad, give the Levites 5,000 Passover offerings and 500 cattle.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the officials in charge of the temple and the leaders of the Levites, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We feel happy to give some of our animals for our fellow priests and Levites to use in their offerings; or
- We feel certain that Yahweh will be pleased with our generous gifts; or
- We feel hopeful that King Josiah will think well of us because we choose to be generous just like the king.

Continue the drama.

The priests and Levites obey Josiah's instructions and stand in their places in the temple so they can help the Israelite laypeople. The Levites kill the Passover lambs and hand the blood to the priests, who splash the blood from the lambs on the altar while the Levites remove the skin from the lambs. The Levites set aside the animals that the Levites prepare to be burnt offerings and the cattle that the Levites will boil for other offerings. The Levites give these animals to the Israelites according to their family divisions so the people can offer the animals in the way Yahweh commands in the Book of Moses. The Levites roast the Passover lambs over a fire as Yahweh commanded, but the Levites boil the cattle in pots, caldrons, and pans. The Levites serve the meat from the Passover lamb and the meat from the boiled cattle to the Israelites right away.

Ask the people playing the Israelites who are not Levites, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We feel grateful that the priests and Levites help us make offerings to Yahweh; or
- We feel excited to celebrate Passover together in the way Yahweh commands.

Continue the drama.

After the Levites finish all the preparations for the Israelites, the Levites make preparations for themselves and for the priests. The Levites do this because the priests are busy at the altar, presenting burnt offerings and fat portions to Yahweh from morning to evening. So the Levites make the preparations for themselves and for the priests, Aaron's descendants. The musicians or singers, who are descendants of Asaph, stand in the places that King David, along with Asaph, Heman, and Jeduthun, King David's seer, assigned to them. The gatekeepers do not leave their places because their fellow Levites prepare everything for the gatekeepers.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing musicians and gatekeepers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We feel grateful that our fellow Levites take care of the preparations for Passover so we can keep serving in our assigned places; or
- We feel excited to serve Yahweh in our specific ways.

Continue the drama.

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At this time, the priests and Levites complete everything they need to worship Yahweh on Passover and to make burnt offerings on Yahweh's altar. The priests and Levites do all this as King Josiah commanded them. All the people present from Israel and Judah celebrate the Passover feast and then the Feast of Unleavened Bread for seven days. No one had celebrated the Passover feast in this way since the time of the prophet Samuel. Josiah celebrates the Passover with the priests, the Levites, and all the people of Jerusalem, Israel, and Judah in Jerusalem during the 18th year that Josiah rules as king.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Josiah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel peaceful because my people obey Yahweh and celebrate Passover exactly the way Yahweh commands; or
- I feel pleased because I obeyed Yahweh, and I know Yahweh will not punish me; or
- I feel hopeful that maybe Yahweh will not act so harshly and will not send disaster because the people obeyed by celebrating Passover according to Yahweh's commands.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 35:1–19 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

If you have already translated 2 Kings 23:21–23, which has some of the same information, stop here as a group and listen to your translation. Pause this audio here.

King Josiah commands the people to celebrate **Passover** in Jerusalem to honor **Yahweh**. The people kill **lambs** for Passover on the 14th day of the first month of the year. Passover is an important Jewish festival that reminds the Israelites of how Yahweh rescued the Israelites from Egypt. People also call Passover the **Festival or Feast of Unleavened Bread** because people celebrate both feasts at the same time. **Jerusalem** is the most important city of the Jewish people. Yahweh is the name God gives himself, and this name reminds people about the covenant God made with the Israelites at the time of Moses. A lamb is a young sheep, or an animal with four legs, hooves, and a thick, woolly coat. In the Bible, people often offer lambs as sacrifices to Yahweh. Use the same words or phrases for Passover, Festival of Unleavened Bread, Jerusalem, Yahweh, and lamb as you used in previous passages. For more information on Passover, Jerusalem, and Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a lamb if necessary. Pause this audio here.

King Josiah chooses **priests** to perform specific duties in the **temple**. Priests were from the Israelite tribe of Levi, and all the priests came from Aaron's family line. Priests were people who worked in the temple. Priests offered sacrifices on behalf of the people and taught the people how to live. The temple is the place where the Israelites worship God, and priests offer sacrifices in the temple. Use the same words or phrases for priest and for temple as you used in previous passages. For more information on priest and temple, refer to the Master Glossary.

King Josiah also gives orders to the **Levites**. Levites were people who belonged to the Israelite tribe of Levi but not to Aaron's family line. Levites helped the priests take care of the temple and taught the people of **Israel**. Israel is the name of the territory where the Israelites lived. Yahweh **consecrated** or set the Levites apart for special service to Yahweh. People may also consecrate themselves when they perform rituals to make themselves pure. Use the same words or phrases for Levite, Israel, and consecrate as you used in previous passages. For more information on Levite, Israel, and consecrate, refer to the Master Glossary.

King Josiah tells the Levites to leave the sacred or **holy ark** in the temple and not to carry the ark on their shoulders. People dedicate or set apart holy objects to Yahweh. The "ark," or the ark of the covenant, is a wooden box that is a symbol to the Israelites of Yahweh's presence. Use the same words or phrases for holy and ark as you used in previous passages. For more information on **holy** and **ark of the covenant**, refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of the ark in the temple if necessary. Pause this audio here.

Josiah tells the Levites to stand in the **Holy Place** to get ready to serve Yahweh their **God** and the Israelite people. The holy place can refer to any place in the tabernacle where the priests did their work. God is the most powerful

spiritual being. Josiah tells the Levites to be ready to do the work that **King David** and David's son **Solomon** assigned to each Levite division. David and Solomon wrote instructions and organized families of Levites into larger groups that people call divisions. Each division takes responsibility for specific duties in the temple. David was the second king of Israel, and Solomon was David's son and the next king after David. A king is someone who rules over a city or territory. Use the same words or phrases for God, Holy Place, David, Solomon, and king as you used in previous passages. For more information on God, Holy Place, David, and king, refer to the Master Glossary.

Josiah tells the Levites to stand in specific places in the temple so they can help the "people who are not Levites." To celebrate Passover, the Israelites who are not Levites need the priests and Levites to help the people make offerings to Yahweh.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will talk about **"**people who are not Levites." If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Josiah, the officials in charge of the temple, and the leaders of the Levites provide **lambs** and **young goats** to be Passover offerings and **cattle** for other holy **offerings**. These animals are for the laypeople, priests, and Levites. Lambs and young goats are animals with four legs that people use for meat and milk. In the Bible, people sometimes sacrifice lambs or young goats as an offering to Yahweh for Passover. Cattle refers to more than one cow or ox. Cows and oxen are both four-legged animals with hooves that people use for meat, milk, and to carry heavy loads. An offering is a gift or sacrifice that people offer to God, usually in the temple. People can make offerings for many reasons. Use the same words or phrases for lamb, young goat, cattle, and offering as you used in previous passages. For more information on offering, refer to the Master Glossary.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a goat and cattle, if necessary. Pause this audio here.

The Levites **slaughter** the lambs for Passover and give the blood to the priests, who **splash** the **blood** onto the **altar**. Slaughter is a special word that people use to talk about killing an animal for sacrifice. The priests splashed or threw the blood onto the altar from the bowls of blood. An altar is a place where people make offerings or sacrifices to God. In the Bible, blood symbolizes the breath of life. Blood was an important part of the sacrifices the Israelites made to God. Use the same words or phrases for slaughter, splash, altar, and blood as you used in previous passages. For more information on altar and blood, refer to the Master Glossary.

The Levites set aside the animals for **burnt offerings** so the people could make sacrifices according to the Book of Moses. A burnt offering is a form of sacrifice that people bring to God. When a person brings a burnt offering to God, that person burns an animal completely on the altar. People make burnt offerings to show their devotion to God. The Book of Moses probably refers to the Pentateuch, the first five books of the Bible, which Moses wrote. Use the same words or phrases for "burnt offering" and "Book or **Scroll** of Moses" as you used in previous passages. For more information on burnt offering and scroll, refer to the Master Glossary.

The Levites roast the Passover offerings over fire, but the Levites boil the cattle for other offerings in pots, caldrons, and pans. A pot is a deep utensil with a wide opening that people use to boil food in water. A caldron is a deep, round-bottomed, two-handled cooking pot. A pan is probably a wide bowl.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a pot, a caldron, and a pan. Discuss what words or phrases you will use for **pot**, **caldron**, and **pan**. Since these objects all have the same use, you may use the same general word for pot, caldron, and pan if you would like. If you have already translated these words in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

The Levites make preparations for Passover for the priests, who are **descendants** of Aaron. A person's descendants are his children, grandchildren, and all future generations from the same family line. Use the same word or phrase for descendants as you used in previous passages. For more information on descendants, refer to the Master Glossary.

The **musicians** and **doorkeepers** did not leave their assigned places because the Levites made preparations for them. A musician is a person who plays a musical instrument or sings. A gatekeeper is a person who guards the entrance to a specific place. Use the same words or phrases for musician and doorkeeper as you used in previous passages.

Josiah and the people celebrate the Passover in the way that Yahweh commands. No one had celebrated Passover in this same way since the days that Samuel the **prophet** lived. A prophet is a person who gives messages from God to the people. Samuel the prophet lived around the time of King David. Use the same word or phrase for prophet as you used in previous passages. For more information on prophet, refer to the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

2 Chronicles 35:20–27

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 35:20–27 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 35:20–27 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 35:20–27 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the previous passage, King Josiah commanded all the priests, Levites, and people from Israel and Judah to celebrate the Passover festival in Jerusalem to honor Yahweh. No one had celebrated Passover in the same way since the time of the prophet Samuel.

If you have already translated 2 Kings 23:28–30, which contains some of the same information, listen to your translation as a group. Pause this audio here.

This passage probably takes place about 13 or 14 years after King Josiah restored the temple and celebrated Passover with all the people. Neco, the king of Egypt, comes with his army to the city of Carchemish near the Euphrates River. Carchemish is on the west bank of the Euphrates River. From another story in the Bible, we know that King Neco probably goes to Carchemish to help the king of Assyria fight against Babylon. Assyria was a powerful kingdom that had previously conquered the kingdom of Israel. Even though the Assyrians did not conquer the kingdom of Judah, the Assyrians still sometimes showed that they were powerful and required the people of Judah to serve them by paying the Assyrians money. The kings of Judah did not like Assyria. Babylon was a kingdom that eventually conquered Assyria and later conquered the kingdom of Judah. The King of Egypt probably wants to help Assyria fight against Babylon because King Neco does not want the Babylonians to come to Egypt.

Stop here as a group and look at a map that includes Egypt, Judah, Carchemish, Assyria, Babylon, and the Euphrates River. Pause this audio here.

King Josiah takes the Israelite army to fight against King Neco. Josiah probably goes to fight against Neco because King Josiah does not want Neco to help the people of Assyria. Josiah may support the Babylonians instead of the Assyrians, or Josiah may want to keep the Egyptians out of Judah. But Neco sends men to tell Josiah that Neco does not want to fight against Josiah. Neco asks Josiah what disagreement exists between Neco and Josiah. Neco does not plan to attack Judah because Neco plans to fight against another enemy nation. Neco even tells Josiah that God told Neco to hurry. Neco says God is on the Egyptians' side and Josiah should not oppose Neco. If Josiah interferes, God will destroy Josiah.

However, King Josiah does not stop his attack against King Neco. Josiah puts on different clothes so that no one will recognize Josiah. Josiah does not listen to God's words through Neco. Instead, Josiah takes his army to the plain of Megiddo to fight against King Neco's army. People also call the plain of Megiddo the Jezreel Valley. The city of Megiddo is in the Jezreel Valley about 40 kilometers southwest of the southern tip of the Sea of Galilee. Megiddo is along the main route from Egypt to Syria. The nation that controls Megiddo has access to trade routes that go north, south, and east, so many armies fight important battles at this location.

Stop here as a group and look at a map of the city of Megiddo in the Jezreel Valley. Pause this audio here.

During the battle, some of King Neco's soldiers fight with arrows. People call these soldiers archers. Archers use a bow to shoot arrows. A bow is a curved piece of wood connected by a taut string. Arrows have wooden shafts with a sharp point made of wood or metal at one end. Some of Neco's archers shoot at and hit King Josiah with arrows. In the story in 2 Kings 23:28–30, the storyteller says Neco kills Josiah, but here the storyteller says Neco's archers actually kill Josiah.

King Josiah tells some of his officers to take Josiah away from the battlefield because Josiah has a severe injury. The officers take Josiah out of his chariot and place Josiah in Josiah's other chariot. A chariot is a two-wheeled vehicle that horses pull, and people often use chariots during battle. Josiah's first chariot probably carried only one or two people. The other chariot may be bigger to carry supplies during battle. Josiah's officers probably move Josiah to the second chariot to provide more space and comfort for the injured king.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a bow and arrow and a chariot. Pause this audio here.

Josiah's officers take Josiah back to Jerusalem, where Josiah dies. In the 2 Kings story, the storyteller says Josiah dies in Megiddo, but Josiah probably did not die right away. Josiah probably receives a severe wound in Megiddo and dies slowly on the way to Jerusalem. Josiah's people bury Josiah in the royal cemetery near Josiah's ancestors. In a previous passage, a prophet told Josiah that Josiah would die peacefully and that Josiah's people would bury Josiah with Josiah's ancestors. Josiah dies close to Jerusalem, and Josiah dies in the presence of his own soldiers. In this way, Josiah's death was peaceful, and the people bury Josiah with honor. All the people who live in Jerusalem and in the other towns in Judah mourn Josiah's death.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How do people mourn the death of a leader in your culture? Pause this audio here.

The prophet Jeremiah writes laments or funeral songs to honor Josiah. Jeremiah was a prophet who gave the people messages from God. Jeremiah lived around the same time as Josiah. People use laments to mourn the death of someone or to grieve the loss of something. Israelite tradition requires all the male and female singers

to remember and honor Josiah with these songs from the time of Josiah's death through the time the storyteller writes about Josiah. Someone writes these funeral songs in the book or scroll that people call The Book of Laments. This is not the book that Jeremiah wrote that people call Lamentations in the Old Testament. We do not have a copy of the Laments book today.

Josiah did many other things while Josiah was king of Judah. Josiah remained faithful to Yahweh because Josiah obeyed the Law of Yahweh. People find the Law of Yahweh in the first five books of the Old Testament. Because Moses wrote these books, people sometimes call these books the Law of Moses. People wrote down all the things Josiah did, from the beginning to the end of Josiah's reign as king, in the "Book or Scroll of the Kings of Israel and Judah." This is not the same book as 1 and 2 Kings in the Old Testament. We no longer have a copy of the Book of the Kings of Israel and Judah.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 35:20–27 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four scenes.

In the first scene: Some time after Josiah restored the temple and celebrated Passover, Neco, king of Egypt, brings the Egyptian army to the city of Carchemish. King Josiah goes to meet Neco for battle, but Neco sends messengers to tell Josiah that Neco does not want to fight Josiah. God told Neco to hurry and fight another enemy, and if Josiah interferes, God will destroy Josiah.

In the second scene: King Josiah refuses to listen to God's words through Neco. Josiah goes to battle against Neco, but Neco's archers shoot Josiah with arrows. Josiah tells officials to take Josiah away from the battle because Josiah is injured, and the military officers take Josiah back to Jerusalem, where Josiah dies.

In the third scene: All the people mourn for Josiah. The prophet Jeremiah writes a lament about Josiah. Tradition still requires singers to sing these songs of lament about Josiah. Someone writes these songs in The Book of Laments.

In the fourth scene: Josiah did many other things while he was king, and Josiah remained faithful to obey Yahweh's law. Someone writes down all the things that Josiah did as king, from the beginning to the end of Josiah's reign, in the book about the kings of Israel and Judah.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Josiah
- King Neco of Egypt
- Neco's messengers
- Josiah's soldiers and officers who took Josiah back to Jerusalem
- Neco's soldiers
- People from Jerusalem and Judah
- And Jeremiah

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

In the first scene, around 13 or 14 years after Josiah restored the temple and celebrated Passover, King Neco of Egypt brings soldiers towards the city of Carchemish on the Euphrates River. Josiah marches out to meet Neco in battle. But Neco sends messengers to King Josiah, who say, "King of Judah, what reason do we have to fight? I have not come to fight against you today. I want to fight against another enemy. God told me to do this quickly. I am doing what God told me to do, so do not fight against me. If you do fight me, God will destroy you." Neco is at war with another house. In this case, a "house" can describe a family or another nation. When Neco asks Josiah the question about what reason they have to fight, Neco does not actually expect Josiah to answer the question. Neco wants to emphasize that Neco does not wish to fight Josiah and the people of Judah.

Stop here and discuss as a group: How do people in your culture emphasize important points that they want other people to understand? Pause this audio here.

In the second scene, despite Neco's message, Josiah refuses to turn away from battle against Neco. Josiah puts on different clothes so no one will recognize Josiah in the battle. Josiah refuses to listen to the words that Neco spoke. The storyteller says Neco's words are from the "mouth of God." The storyteller uses special language to say that what Neco says are God's own words. Josiah takes his army and goes to fight against Neco near the plain of Megiddo. A plain is a large area of flat land with few trees. However, Neco's archers shoot arrows that hit and severely injure Josiah.

Josiah tells his servants, "Take me away from the battle because I am severely injured." The servants that Josiah speaks to are probably Josiah's military officers. Josiah's officers take Josiah out of his chariot and move Josiah to Josiah's other chariot. The officers bring Josiah to Jerusalem, and Josiah dies. Josiah's people bury Josiah in the royal cemetery close to Josiah's ancestors, and all the people from Jerusalem and Judah mourn for Josiah. When people bury the body of a king, the people put the dead body in a natural cave or room that someone carved out of a rock.

In the third scene, the prophet Jeremiah writes laments, or funeral songs, for Josiah. Male and female singers still sing these laments at the time the storyteller writes about Josiah. The singers do this according to tradition to honor Josiah. Someone writes the laments that Jeremiah wrote in The Book of Laments.

Stop here and discuss as a group: Tell a story about people who mourn for someone who dies. How do people in your culture talk about a person whom they respect and want to honor after that person dies? Pause this audio here.

In the fourth scene, the storyteller uses a common formula to summarize Josiah's reign. In the Bible, storytellers often talk about all that a king does during his reign in this same way after the king dies.

Stop here and discuss as a group: In your culture, after a ruler dies, how do people talk about the things the ruler did while the ruler was alive? Pause this audio here.

Josiah did many other things during Josiah's reign as king. Josiah faithfully obeyed the Law of Yahweh that Moses wrote down. Someone wrote all the things that Josiah did, from the beginning to the end of Josiah's reign, in the Book or Scroll of the Kings of Israel and Judah.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 35:20–27 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- King Josiah
- King Neco of Egypt
- Neco's messengers
- Josiah's soldiers and officers that took Josiah back to Jerusalem
- Neco's soldiers
- People from Jerusalem and Judah
- And Jeremiah

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Around 13 or 14 years after Josiah restored the temple and celebrated Passover, King Neco of Egypt brings soldiers north towards the city of Carchemish on the Euphrates River. Josiah marches out to meet Neco in battle. But Neco sends messengers to King Josiah, who say, "King of Judah, what reason do we have to fight? I have not come to fight against you today. I want to fight against another enemy. God told me to do this quickly. I am doing what God told me to do, so do not fight against me. If you do fight me, God will destroy you."

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Neco, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel frustrated that Josiah will not listen me; or
- I feel surprised that Josiah will not listen to God now because I know Josiah has always listened to God in the past; or
- I do not want to waste my army's energy fighting against Josiah's army. I came to help Assyria fight against Babylon.

Ask the people playing Neco's messengers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We feel shocked that Josiah refuses to listen to Neco; or
- We feel afraid that God might destroy Josiah because Josiah will not listen.

Continue the drama.

Despite Neco's message, Josiah refuses to turn away from battle against Neco. Josiah puts on different clothes so no one will recognize Josiah in the battle. Josiah refuses to listen to God's words that Neco spoke. Josiah goes to fight against Neco near the plain of Megiddo. However, Neco's archers shoot arrows that hit and severely injure Josiah.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Josiah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel shocked that God allowed Neco's archers to kill me; or
- I feel sad that I did not trust God, but instead did what I thought was best; or
- I feel afraid that God will now destroy my people, the Israelites.

Continue the drama.

Josiah tells his officers, "Take me away from the battle because I am severely injured." Josiah's officers take Josiah out of his chariot and move Josiah to Josiah's other chariot. The officers bring Josiah to Jerusalem, where they realize Josiah is dead. Josiah's people bury Josiah in the royal cemetery close to Josiah's ancestors, and all the people from Jerusalem and Judah mourn for Josiah.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing Josiah's soldiers, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The people might answer things like:

- We feel sad that our king has died; or
- We feel surprised that Josiah disobeyed Yahweh because Josiah had obeyed Yahweh so faithfully before now.

Continue the drama.

The prophet Jeremiah writes laments, or funeral songs, for Josiah. Male and female singers still sing these laments at the time the storyteller writes about Josiah. The singers do this according to tradition to honor Josiah. Someone writes the laments that Jeremiah wrote in The Book of Laments.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Jeremiah, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person might answer things like:

- I feel sad because Josiah did not listen to God; or
- I feel sad because I know the people will not follow God the way Josiah wanted them to.

Continue the drama.

Josiah did many other things during Josiah’s reign as king. Josiah faithfully obeyed the Law of Yahweh that Moses wrote down. Someone wrote all the things that Josiah did, from the beginning to the end of Josiah’s reign, in the Book of the Kings of Israel and Judah.

Pause the drama. Ask the people playing the people from Jerusalem and Judah, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The people might answer things like:

- We mourn for Josiah because we know Josiah was a good ruler; or
- We want to obey God because Josiah told us we should remain faithful to God.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 35:20–27 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

If you have already translated 2 Kings 23:28–30, which contains some of the same information, listen to your translation as a group. Pause this audio here.

After Josiah restored the **temple**, **King** Neco of Egypt marched towards the city of Carchemish. The temple is the place where the Israelites worship God. A king is someone who rules over a city or territory. **Judah** is the name of a region in Israel where Josiah was king. Use the same word or phrase for temple, king, and Judah as you used in previous passages. For more information on temple, king, and Judah, refer to the Master Glossary.

King Neco sends messengers to Josiah, who say Josiah and Neco do not need to fight. Neco plans to attack a different house. A house refers to a particular family or people group.

Stop here and discuss as a group how you will say that Neco plans to attack a different “**house**,” or group of people. For more information, refer to **household** in the Master Glossary. Pause this audio here.

Neco’s messengers also tell Josiah that **God** sent them to fight another enemy and told them to hurry. God is the most powerful spiritual being, and God created everything and has power over everything. Use the same word or phrase for God as you used in previous passages. For more information on God, refer to the Master Glossary.

Josiah refused to listen to Neco and marched into battle, but some of Neco’s archers shot Josiah. An archer is a person who shoots with a bow and arrows.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a bow and arrow. Discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **archer**. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Josiah’s servants put Josiah in a **chariot**. The word the storyteller uses can mean servants or military officers. You may choose to use the word servant or officer here. A chariot is a two-wheeled vehicle that horses pull. People often use chariots during battle. Use the same word or phrase for chariot as you used in previous passages.

Stop here as a group and discuss what word you will use: **servants** or **officers**. If you choose to use the word servant, look up servant in the Master Glossary for more information. Use the same word or phrase for servant as you used in previous passages. Pause this audio here.

Stop here as a group and look at a picture of a chariot, if necessary. Pause this audio here.

Josiah’s officers take Josiah back to **Jerusalem**. Jerusalem is the name of the most important city to the Jewish people. Use the same word or phrase for **Jerusalem** as you used in previous passages. For more information on Jerusalem, refer to the Master Glossary.

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The people in Jerusalem bury Josiah in the royal cemetery or the **tombs** of Josiah's **fathers**. The word "fathers" refers to a person's **ancestors**. A tomb is the name for a place where people bury a dead person. An ancestor is a person from someone's family who lived before that person. Use the same word or phrase for tomb and father or ancestor as you used in previous passages. For more information on tomb, refer to the Master Glossary.

The prophet Jeremiah writes laments to honor Josiah after Josiah's death. A lament is a song people sing to mourn the death of someone or to grieve the loss of something.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for **lament**. Look up lament in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

Josiah stayed faithful to Yahweh and obeyed all Yahweh's commands in the "**Law** of **Yahweh**." The Law of Yahweh refers to the Pentateuch, or the first five books in the Old Testament. Yahweh gave this law to Moses, and Moses wrote the law in these books. People sometimes call the Law of Yahweh the "Law of Moses." Use the same word or phrase for "Law of Yahweh" as you used in previous passages. For more information on law and Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary.

Someone writes all the things that Josiah did as king, from the beginning to the end of Josiah's reign, in the Book of the Kings of Israel and Judah. This book is not the same as the books of 1 and 2 Kings in the Old Testament. We no longer have copies of this book. Use the same word or phrase for "Book or Scroll of the Kings of Israel and Judah**"** as you used in previous passages. For more information on **Israel** and **scroll**, refer to the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

2 Chronicles 36:1–16

Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 36:1–16 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 36:1–16 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

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1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 36:1–16 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In the last passage, King Josiah attacked King Neco of Egypt when Neco marched north with his army. Even though Yahweh warned Josiah through Neco to stay away, Josiah attacked the Egyptians anyway. Egyptian archers wounded Josiah badly in battle, and Josiah died.

After the people grieve the loss of their king, the people of Judah make Josiah's son Jehoahaz the new king. Jehoahaz is 23 years old when he begins to rule from Jerusalem. Jehoahaz rules for only three months. Normally, the oldest son becomes king after his father dies. However, the people of Judah choose Jehoahaz, the youngest son, to rule instead.

While Jehoahaz is king, King Neco of Egypt captures Jehoahaz and makes him a prisoner to stop Jehoahaz from ruling in Jerusalem. King Neco demands that the people of Judah pay Neco a fine of 100 talents, or 3,400 kilograms, of silver and 1 talent, or 34 kilograms, of gold. King Neco then forces Josiah's son Eliakim to be the next king of Judah. The king of Egypt has so much power that Neco forces Eliakim to change his name to Jehoiakim. King Neco then brings Jehoahaz to the land of Egypt as a prisoner.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In this passage, leaders of powerful nations controlled who became king in Judah. In your culture, how do outside groups or powerful leaders influence decisions in your community? Pause this audio here.

Jehoiakim, the older brother of Jehoahaz, is 25 years old when he begins to rule from Jerusalem. Jehoiakim rules for 11 years as the king of Judah. Jehoiakim does evil in the eyes of Yahweh or does not live in a way that pleases Yahweh. While Jehoiakim is king, King Nebuchadnezzar of Babylon attacks Judah. Nebuchadnezzar is not only king of the city of Babylon but of the whole territory of Babylon.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a map of the kingdom of Judah and the nation of Babylon during the time of Jehoiakim. Pause this audio here.

Nebuchadnezzar defeats Jehoiakim and binds him with bronze chains. It is unclear whether the king of Babylon kills Jehoiakim in Jerusalem or if he takes Jehoiakim as a prisoner to the city of Babylon.

After Nebuchadnezzar defeats Jehoiakim, Nebuchadnezzar takes objects out of the temple of Yahweh and brings them to Babylon. It is unclear whether Nebuchadnezzar places the temple objects in his personal palace or in a temple in Babylon. The storyteller says we can read more about King Jehoiakim and his time as king in the book called The Book or Scroll of the Kings of Israel and Judah. This book no longer exists. The storyteller emphasizes that Jehoiakim's acts are abominations, or detestable and horrible actions against Yahweh. Yahweh hates these acts. After Jehoiakim dies, his son Jehoiachin becomes the next king of Judah.

Jehoiachin rules from Jerusalem when he is only 18 years old. Jehoiachin rules as king for three months. Like his father, Jehoiachin does not live in a way that pleases Yahweh. In the spring, King Nebuchadnezzar orders his army to surround Jerusalem and bring Jehoiachin to Nebuchadnezzar in Babylon. We know from 2 Kings 24:10–17 that Jehoiachin surrenders and Nebuchadnezzar takes Jehoiachin, Jehoiachin's family, and Jehoiachin's government officials as prisoners to Babylon. While in Jerusalem, the Babylonian army also takes many precious objects from the temple of Yahweh. After this, Nebuchadnezzar chooses Jehoiachin's uncle Zedekiah, the brother of Jehoiachin's father, to replace Jehoiachin as king of Judah.

Zedekiah becomes king of Judah at age 21 and rules for 11 years in Jerusalem. Zedekiah does not live in a way that pleases Yahweh. The storyteller notes that Zedekiah intentionally ignored what Yahweh said through the prophet Jeremiah. In chapter 21 of the book of Jeremiah, Jeremiah repeatedly urged Zedekiah to submit to Babylon rather

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than ask for help from Egypt, but Zedekiah did not listen. Zedekiah also rebelled against Nebuchadnezzar after Nebuchadnezzar made him swear by the name of Yahweh that Zedekiah would be loyal to him. It is normal for leaders to take an oath, or swear by the name of a person's god, when leaders make formal promises or agreements with each other. But when Zedekiah breaks his oath and rebels, Zedekiah shows how stiff-necked, or stubborn, Zedekiah truly is. Zedekiah hardens his heart or stubbornly refuses to obey Yahweh, the God of Israel.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what promises or oaths do people consider unbreakable? What happens if someone breaks one of these promises or oaths? Pause this audio here.

In addition, all of the leaders of the priests and the people of Judah abandon Yahweh for other gods. These people do the same evil practices that other nations are doing, acts that Yahweh hates. These practices make the temple of Yahweh ceremonially unclean or unfit for worship. Yahweh consecrated, or set apart, the temple in Jerusalem for himself, but the leaders choose to make it unclean by bringing in false gods.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what kinds of things do people consider to be sacred or set apart? How would someone make those things or places unclean? Pause this audio here.

Yahweh shows compassion on Yahweh's people and on his temple by sending many messengers to speak to his people. Even though the prophets warn the people to turn back to Yahweh, the people do not respect the prophets and laugh at them instead. Finally, Yahweh becomes so angry with his people that nothing can stop Yahweh from judging Judah.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 36:1–16 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has five scenes.

In the first scene: The people of Judah make Josiah's son, Jehoahaz, the next king. Jehoahaz does not follow Yahweh. Jehoahaz rules for three months before King Neco takes Jehoahaz as a prisoner to Egypt. King Neco makes the people of Judah pay Neco a large fine. King Neco makes Jehoiakim, the brother of Jehoahaz, the next king of Judah.

In the second scene: Jehoiakim does not follow Yahweh and rules as king for 11 years. While Jehoiakim is king, Nebuchadnezzar's army attacks Jerusalem. Nebuchadnezzar binds Jehoiakim in metal chains. Nebuchadnezzar takes many of the temple treasures to Nebuchadnezzar's home in Babylon. Jehoiachin, the son of Jehoiakim, becomes the next king of Judah.

In the third scene: Jehoiachin rules for three months and does not obey Yahweh. Nebuchadnezzar's army attacks Jerusalem again, takes Jehoiachin prisoner, and carries more temple treasures to Babylon. Nebuchadnezzar then appoints Zedekiah as king, who swears by Yahweh's name to be loyal to Nebuchadnezzar.

In the fourth scene: Zedekiah is king for 11 years, and Zedekiah does not follow Yahweh. Zedekiah does not listen to Jeremiah. Instead, Zedekiah breaks his vow and rebels against Nebuchadnezzar.

In the fifth scene: The leaders and priests of Judah do not listen to Yahweh either. Instead, they make the temple unclean by worshiping false gods. Yahweh sends prophets to talk to them, but the people do not listen. Instead, they laugh at the prophets. Yahweh becomes so angry with his people that no one can stop Yahweh from destroying the people.

The characters in this passage are:

- Jehoahaz
- King Neco of Egypt
- Jehoiakim
- King Nebuchadnezzar of Babylon
- The Babylonian army

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- Jehoiachin
- Zedekiah
- Jeremiah, the prophet
- Yahweh
- The people of Judah
- And leaders of the priests of Judah

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

After Josiah, only four kings ruled Judah. The storyteller briefly introduces each king and what happened during each king's reign.

The storyteller introduces Jehoahaz in the usual pattern: his name, age, city, and how long he ruled. Jehoahaz, Josiah's son, becomes king at 23 and rules from Jerusalem for three months.

After three months, King Neco of Egypt attacks Judah with his army and captures Jehoahaz so that Jehoahaz can no longer rule as the king of Judah.

King Neco demands that the people of Judah pay Neco 100 talents of silver and 1 talent of gold—about 3,400 kilograms of silver and 34 kilograms of gold.

King Neco appoints Josiah's other son, Eliakim, to be the next king of Judah. King Neco forces Eliakim to change his name to Jehoiakim. King Neco brings Jehoahaz back to Egypt as a prisoner.

Stop here as a group and look at a map of the kingdom of Judah in relation to Egypt. Pause this audio here.

Jehoiakim becomes king when he is 25 years old. Jehoiakim reigns from Jerusalem, and he rules as king for 11 years. Jehoiakim does evil in the sight of Yahweh, or lives in a way that does not please Yahweh.

During Jehoiakim's reign, King Nebuchadnezzar of Babylon attacks Judah, defeats Jehoiakim, and binds him with metal chains to take Jehoiakim away. While in Jerusalem, Nebuchadnezzar also takes valuable items that the people used to serve inside the temple. Nebuchadnezzar takes the items to his palace in Babylon.

Stop here and look, as a group, at a map of the kingdom of Judah and the nation of Babylon during the time of Jehoiakim. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller tells us we can find all of Jehoiakim's acts as king in a book called "The Book or Scroll of the Kings of Israel and Judah." The storyteller emphasizes that Jehoiakim's acts were abominations, or horrible and detestable actions against Yahweh.

Jehoiakim dies, and Jehoiakim's son, Jehoiachin, becomes the next king of Judah. Jehoiachin is only 18 years old when he becomes king. Jehoiachin rules from Jerusalem, and he is king for three months and 10 days. Jehoiachin does evil in the sight of Yahweh, or lives in a way that does not please Yahweh.

In the first part of the year, when kings usually went to war, Nebuchadnezzar sends his army to besiege, or surround, Jerusalem. Nebuchadnezzar brings Jehoiachin to Babylon as a prisoner. We know from the 2 Kings story that Jehoiachin surrendered. The Babylonian army raids the temple again and takes many of its valuable treasures. It is important to remember that the temple had a storeroom where kings kept valuable treasures.

King Nebuchadnezzar makes Jehoiachin's uncle Zedekiah, who is Jehoiakim's brother, the king of Judah. It is important to note that Nebuchadnezzar forced Zedekiah to swear in the name of Yahweh to be loyal to Nebuchadnezzar. This was a normal custom when kings made formal agreements during this time. However, we do not learn this until later.

Zedekiah is 21 years old when he becomes king. Zedekiah rules from Jerusalem, and he is king for 11 years. Zedekiah does evil in the sight of Yahweh, or lives in a way that does not please Yahweh.

Yahweh sends the prophet Jeremiah to speak to Zedekiah, but Zedekiah does not listen to him. Jeremiah speaks the word of Yahweh, or a message from Yahweh, so Zedekiah directly rejects Yahweh. Even though Zedekiah swore to be loyal to Nebuchadnezzar, Zedekiah decides to rebel against Nebuchadnezzar. Zedekiah becomes stiff-necked, or stubborn, and Zedekiah hardens his heart, or refuses to listen to Yahweh, even though Yahweh is

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the God of Israel. By using both expressions, the storyteller is making a strong statement that Zedekiah is very stubborn.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: How would you describe someone who is “stiff-necked” or “hard-hearted”? Do you have words or examples in your language for someone who is persistently stubborn and refuses to listen? Pause this audio here.

All of the leading priests, or religious leaders who serve in the temple, also refuse to obey Yahweh, and they continue to be more and more unfaithful. The leaders and people of Judah do the same evil practices that other nations do. The people defile the temple, or make the temple ceremonially unclean, by worshiping false gods inside the temple.

The temple was a place Yahweh had consecrated for himself. This means Yahweh made the temple set apart for himself so that Yahweh could live among his people. But Yahweh’s people defile his house and make it unfit for worship.

The storyteller says Yahweh has compassion for Yahweh’s people and for the place where Yahweh lives among his people, the temple. Yahweh sends prophets many times to warn his people to turn back to Yahweh, but the people do not listen. Instead, the people mock and ridicule the prophets.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story of a time when people mocked or ridiculed an important message. Pay attention to what words you use to describe this kind of reaction. Pause this audio here.

Yahweh becomes so angry with his people that Yahweh decides to destroy them. Yahweh’s chosen people were beyond healing, which means no one could change Yahweh’s mind.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 36:1–16 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has five scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Jehoahaz
- King Neco of Egypt
- Jehoiakim
- King Nebuchadnezzar of Babylon
- The Babylonian army
- Jehoiachin
- Zedekiah
- Jeremiah, the prophet
- Yahweh
- The people of Judah
- And leaders of the priests of Judah

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, “What are you feeling or thinking?” The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

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Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Act out the people of Judah making Josiah's son, Jehoahaz, the next king. Jehoahaz does not follow Yahweh. Jehoahaz rules for three months before King Neco takes Jehoahaz as a prisoner to Egypt. King Neco makes the people of Judah pay Neco 100 talents of silver and 1 talent of gold. King Neco makes Jehoiakim, the brother of Jehoahaz, the next king of Judah.

Act out Jehoiakim not following Yahweh and ruling as king for 11 years. While Jehoiakim is king, Nebuchadnezzar's army attacks Jerusalem. Nebuchadnezzar defeats Jehoiakim and binds him in metal chains. Nebuchadnezzar takes many of the temple treasures to Nebuchadnezzar's home in Babylon. Jehoiachin, the son of Jehoiakim, becomes the next king of Judah.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Nebuchadnezzar, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel powerful. I am not worried about Neco. Jerusalem will belong to me; or
- I am strategic. I will make Jehoiakim a prisoner so that the next king will be loyal to me; or
- I do not understand why the people built such an extravagant temple for one god. I will take some items from their temple to let them know who is really in control.

Continue the drama.

Act out Jehoiachin ruling in Judah for three months. Jehoiachin does not obey Yahweh. While Jehoiachin is king, Nebuchadnezzar's army surrounds Jerusalem. Nebuchadnezzar makes Jehoiachin a prisoner and takes him to Babylon. Once again, the Babylonian soldiers take some of the temple treasures to Babylon. Nebuchadnezzar makes Zedekiah the next king of Judah. Zedekiah swears in the name of Yahweh to be loyal to the king of Babylon.

Act out Zedekiah being king for 11 years. Zedekiah does not follow Yahweh. Zedekiah does not listen to Jeremiah. Instead, Zedekiah breaks his vow and rebels against Nebuchadnezzar.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Zedekiah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel angry. I am tired of being ruled over by other kings; or
- I feel stubborn. Yahweh did not protect my brothers. Why should I listen to Yahweh? or
- Nebuchadnezzar does not know me very well. To swear in Yahweh's name means nothing to me.

Continue the drama.

Act out the leaders and priests of Judah not listening to Yahweh either. Instead, these people make the temple unclean by worshiping false gods. Yahweh tries to talk to the people by sending prophets, but the people do not listen. Instead, the people laugh at the prophets. Yahweh becomes so angry with his people that no one can stop Yahweh from destroying the people.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing Yahweh, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel angry. I have given the people many chances to turn back to me. It is time for the people to feel the consequences of their disobedience; or
- I feel sad. If only my people would listen to my prophets, then I would show my people compassion; or
- I will use this destruction for the people's good.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 36:1–16 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

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In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Jehoahaz becomes the next **king** and rules from **Jerusalem**. A king is someone who rules over a city or territory, like a region or a country. Jerusalem was the capital city of Judah. Use the same words or phrases for king and Jerusalem as you used in previous passages. For more information on king or Jerusalem, refer to the Master Glossary.

Jehoahaz was the king of **Judah**. Judah refers to the southern kingdom of Israel. Use the same word or phrase for Judah as you used in previous passages. For more information on **Judah**, refer to the Master Glossary.

King Neco demands that the people of Judah pay him 100 **talents** of silver and one talent of gold. A talent is a measurement that equals 34 kilograms or 75 pounds. One hundred talents of silver would be around 3,400 kilograms of silver. Use the same word or phrase for talent as you used in previous passages. For more information on talent, refer to the Master Glossary.

The storyteller emphasizes that Jehoiakim's actions were **abominations**, or horrible acts that Yahweh hates. Use the same word or phrase for abominations or horrible acts that Yahweh hates as you used in previous passages.

Jehoiakim became king and did **evil in the eyes of Yahweh**. In other words, Jehoiakim continually disobeyed Yahweh and did not live in a way that was pleasing to Yahweh. Evil is the opposite of good. Be sure to use the same word or phrase for "evil in the eyes of Yahweh" as you used in previous passages. For more information on **evil**, refer to the Master Glossary.

Nebuchadnezzar, the king of Babylon, attacks the land of Judah and takes valuable items from the **temple** of **Yahweh**. The temple was the place where the Israelites worshiped Yahweh. In the temple, specially appointed people called priests offered gifts and sacrifices to God on behalf of the people. Yahweh is God's personal name and showed God's special relationship with his people. Use the same words for temple and Yahweh as you used in previous passages. For more information on temple or Yahweh, refer to the Master Glossary.

The storyteller says the rest of the acts of Jehoiakim are in the "**Book of the Kings of Israel and Judah**." This was a historical account of the kings of Israel and Judah; however, the book no longer exists. Be sure to translate "The Book or **Scroll** of the Kings of Israel and Judah" in the same way you did in previous passages. For more information about a scroll, refer to the Master Glossary.

Zedekiah did not humble himself before the **prophet** Jeremiah, which means Zedekiah refused to listen to the **word** of Yahweh. The word of Yahweh is anything Yahweh speaks to people. In this case, Yahweh used prophets, or people who give Yahweh's message to people. Use the same words or phrases for "word of Yahweh" and prophet as you used in previous passages. For more information on word or prophet, refer to the Master Glossary.

Nebuchadnezzar forces Zedekiah to make an **oath** of loyalty to Nebuchadnezzar in the name of Yahweh. When someone swears an oath, they say, "I will absolutely keep my promise. If I do not, God may punish me." Zedekiah did not keep his promise to Nebuchadnezzar to be loyal, so Zedekiah broke his oath. In that culture, it was a disgraceful and dangerous thing to break an oath. Use the same word or phrase for oath as you used in previous passages. For more information on oath, refer to the Master Glossary.

The storyteller describes Zedekiah as **stiff-necked** and says Zedekiah hardened his **heart**. Both expressions are different ways to say that Zedekiah was stubborn and refused to listen. In the Bible, the heart is special language for the place where a person's thoughts, feelings, and decisions happen. Use the same words or phrases for "stiff-necked" and heart as you used in previous passages. For more information on heart, refer to the Master Glossary.

Zedekiah would not turn to Yahweh, the **God** of **Israel**. God refers to the God who created everything. God is the most powerful spiritual being. This is the God who made a covenant, a special promise, to Abraham and his descendants, the Israelites. Here, Israel refers to the nation of God's chosen people. Use the same words or phrases for God and Israel as you used in previous passages. For more information on God or Israel, refer to the Master Glossary.

Judah's unfaithfulness was so bad that even the leading **priests** were worshiping false gods. Priests are people who served in the temple and offered gifts and sacrifices to God on behalf of the people. Use the same word or phrase for priest as you used in previous passages. For more information on priest, refer to the Master Glossary.

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Yahweh specially **consecrated** the temple as Yahweh's dwelling place, but the people made it unclean. When God consecrates someone or something, God sets them apart for special service to himself. The person or thing now belongs to God, and it is holy or clean. But the people disobey Yahweh and worship false gods, which defiles the temple or makes it unclean. Use the same word or phrase for consecrate and **defile** as you used in previous passages. For more information on consecrate or defile, refer to the Master Glossary.

Yahweh sends prophets to speak to his people, but the people mock the prophets until Yahweh's **wrath** rises against his people. Wrath is the attitude that God has when God sees sin and evil. God is holy and just. Wrath is stronger than anger, and wrath involves punishing people for their sin. Use the same word or phrase for wrath as you used in previous passages. For more information on wrath, refer to the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.

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Hear and Heart

In this step, hear 2 Chronicles 36:17–23 and put it in your hearts.

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 36:17–23 three times, in three different translations, if possible.

Pause this audio here.

Now, as a group, discuss the following questions:

1. What do you like in this passage? Pause this audio here.
2. What do you not like or not understand in this passage? Pause this audio here.
3. What does this passage tell us about God? Pause this audio here.
4. What does this passage tell us about people? Pause this audio here.
5. How does this passage affect our daily lives? Pause this audio here.
6. Who do you know who needs to hear this passage?

Setting the Stage

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 36:17–23 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

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In the last story, King Zedekiah of Judah rebelled against Nebuchadnezzar. Zedekiah and the people of Judah refused to listen to Yahweh's prophets, so Yahweh became angry and decided to judge them.

Yahweh causes King Nebuchadnezzar of the Chaldeans, or Babylonians, to attack Judah. Nebuchadnezzar and his soldiers kill Judah's young men in the temple of Yahweh. Nebuchadnezzar shows no compassion for anyone. Instead, Nebuchadnezzar and his soldiers kill young men and women, as well as old people and weak people. Yahweh allows all the people of Judah to be in the hand, or the power, of Nebuchadnezzar. So, just like Yahweh said would happen through the prophet Jeremiah, Nebuchadnezzar kills many people in the city of Jerusalem.

Nebuchadnezzar takes all of the valuable items that the people used to serve in the temple and all the temple treasures. The Babylonians also take the treasures of King Zedekiah and his officials to Babylon. The soldiers burn down Yahweh's temple and break down Jerusalem's city walls. The soldiers also burn down all of the palaces, or large houses, and destroy all of the valuable things in the city.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your culture, what are the signs that people have abandoned or destroyed a community? Tell a story of a time when someone completely destroyed or abandoned a community. Pause this audio here.

Nebuchadnezzar and his soldiers take all the people of Judah who are still alive to Babylon as prisoners. Those prisoners become slaves to Nebuchadnezzar and his descendants until the kingdom of Persia becomes powerful and replaces the kingdom of Babylonia. The Persians would conquer many kingdoms until the Persian Kingdom grew to include territory from India in the east to Ionia in the west.

Stop here and, as a group, look at a map of the Persian Kingdom during the reign of King Cyrus. Pause this audio here.

Yahweh fulfills his message that Jeremiah the prophet had spoken, and the land of Judah lies empty for all the time that the people did not observe the sabbath rest. According to the Law of Moses, the people were not supposed to grow anything in the land every seventh year. But the people of Judah did grow things every year. So the land of Judah lies empty for 70 years to make up for all the years the people did not allow the land to rest.

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: In your community, are there times when people allow the land, animals, or people to rest? What might happen if people never let their land or bodies rest? Pause this audio here.

Jeremiah said that the people of Judah would live in exile for 70 years. Scholars disagree about when the time of exile began and ended. One explanation is that the exile began when Nebuchadnezzar first took people to Babylon and ended with Cyrus' announcement. Another explanation is that the exile began when Nebuchadnezzar destroyed the temple and ended when the Israelites rebuilt the temple. Either way, the Israelites' exile lasted around 70 years.

Around 70 years after Nebuchadnezzar destroys the temple, King Cyrus of Persia takes over the kingdom of Babylon and begins to rule over Babylon. The storyteller gives us hope by saying Yahweh will fulfill Jeremiah's prophecy and allow the people of Judah to return to their land.

In the first year that Cyrus is the king of Persia, Yahweh causes Cyrus to write a message and send it throughout his kingdom. In the Persian Kingdom, royal messengers traveled to different parts of the kingdom to deliver the king's announcements. The royal messengers then read the king's message aloud to the people. King Cyrus's message said: "Yahweh, the God of heaven, has given me all the kingdoms of the earth. Yahweh has chosen me to build a temple for him in Jerusalem in Judah. May Yahweh your God be with all of you who are his people. You are free to go up to Jerusalem."

Stop here and discuss this question as a group: Tell a story about a time when someone received help or freedom from a person they least expected. Pause this audio here.

In King Cyrus' message, Cyrus recognizes Yahweh as the one who made Cyrus successful. Cyrus gives his blessing, or favor, to the people of Judah to return to their land and rebuild the temple in Jerusalem. The story of the return from Babylon to Jerusalem continues in the books of Ezra and Nehemiah.

Defining the Scenes

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 36:17–23 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

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Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will define the scenes, characters, and setting of this passage. Then the group will visualize this passage.

This passage has four scenes.

In the first scene: Yahweh causes King Nebuchadnezzar and his army to attack the city of Jerusalem. Nebuchadnezzar kills the young men in the temple. Nebuchadnezzar's soldiers do not spare anyone. The soldiers kill the young, the old, and even the weak people.

In the second scene: The Babylonian soldiers take all of the valuables from the temple, the king's house, and the houses of his officials. Then the soldiers burn down the temple and other important buildings. The soldiers also destroy the walls that surround Jerusalem. The Babylonians take all the treasure and the remaining people to Babylon as prisoners. The people of Judah arrive in Babylon and begin to serve Nebuchadnezzar and his family as slaves.

In the third scene: The people of Judah are slaves for 70 years. During that time, the land of Judah rests, and no one grows anything. King Cyrus becomes the new king of Babylon and Persia after the Persian Kingdom defeats the Babylonians.

In the fourth scene: Yahweh causes King Cyrus to send out an official message throughout his land. In the message, Cyrus recognizes Yahweh and gives Cyrus' blessing to the people of Judah to return to their land and rebuild the temple in Jerusalem.

The characters in this passage are:

- Yahweh
- King Nebuchadnezzar of Babylon
- The Babylonian army
- The people of Judah, including the young, old, and weak
- The remnant of the Jewish people who go to Babylon
- Jeremiah
- King Cyrus of Persia
- And King Cyrus' messenger

As a group, pay attention to these parts of the passage's setting:

The storyteller introduces events by saying it is Yahweh who caused the king of the Chaldeans to attack Jerusalem. The storyteller is referring to Nebuchadnezzar, the king of Babylon. The Chaldeans lived in southern Babylonia. So, "Chaldeans" was another way to say Babylonians.

Nebuchadnezzar allows his soldiers to kill the young men of Judah with their swords inside Yahweh's temple. Nebuchadnezzar and his soldiers show no compassion for Judah's people. Instead, the soldiers kill young and old people, men and women, and even those who are sick or weak.

Yahweh gave all the people into Nebuchadnezzar's "hand." In the original language, storytellers used the hand as an image of power. Like a strong hand holding something tightly, the king has control over the people. So, in other words, Yahweh allowed Nebuchadnezzar to have power over the people of Judah.

Nebuchadnezzar has his soldiers take all of the valuable objects from inside the temple, both great and small, to Babylon. In other words, the soldiers take every valuable part of the temple regardless of size. This would have included smaller items like pure gold serving spoons to large, heavy bronze pillars. The soldiers take all the valuables from the temple, the king's palace, and the homes of his officials.

After taking what they want, the soldiers destroy everything else. The soldiers burn down the temple of Yahweh, the king's palace, and all the other important buildings in Jerusalem. The soldiers also break down the stone wall that surrounds Jerusalem, which leaves Jerusalem unprotected.

Nebuchadnezzar takes the remaining people who escaped the sword, or the people whom the soldiers did not kill, to be prisoners in Babylon. The prisoners from Judah become slaves who serve Nebuchadnezzar and his descendants in Babylon.

Stop here and discuss with your group: Tell a story of a time when enemies destroyed a sacred place in your community. Pay attention to what words you use to describe the destruction of the land after the enemies left. Pause this audio here.

The storyteller gives us hope by telling us that the people of Judah will not be slaves in Babylon forever, but only until the king of Persia comes to power.

We know the people of Judah were exiles in Babylon for around 70 years. During this time, the land enjoys its sabbath rest. This means nobody in Israel plants crops during these years, and that this makes up for all the sabbath years when people had previously worked the land. According to Yahweh's law, the people were supposed to let the land rest every seven years, but the people had disobeyed.

The prophet Jeremiah warned the people of Judah that they would be prisoners in Babylon for 70 years. Everything happens just as Yahweh said it would through Jeremiah.

The kingdom of Persia defeats the kingdom of Babylonia, and King Cyrus of Persia begins to rule over Babylon. During King Cyrus's first year as the king over Babylon, Yahweh stirs up the spirit of Cyrus to make a proclamation, or official announcement. In other words, Yahweh causes Cyrus to have the desire to send a message throughout Cyrus' country.

Stop here and discuss with your group: In your language, how do people talk about something or someone motivating a person to do something? What special language do they use? Pause this audio here.

Official messengers go throughout the Persian Kingdom and tell everyone the king's message. King Cyrus says, "Yahweh, the God of heaven, has given me all the kingdoms of the earth. Yahweh has chosen me to build a temple for Yahweh in Jerusalem in Judah. May Yahweh your God be with all of you who are his people. You are free to go up to Jerusalem."

The exile of Judah comes to an end, and King Cyrus allows the people of Judah to return to their land.

Now, the group should storyboard, draw, or use objects to visualize the passage and the action in it.

Embodying the Text

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 36:17–23 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will dramatize the passage.

This passage has four scenes.

The characters in this passage are:

- Yahweh
- King Nebuchadnezzar of Babylon
- The Babylonian army
- The people of Judah, including the young, old, and weak
- The remnant of the Jewish people who go to Babylon
- Jeremiah
- King Cyrus of Persia
- And King Cyrus' messenger

As a group, act out the passage twice. You should act out the passage in your own language.

First, act out the passage without stopping. Pay attention to the dialogue, flow, plotline, and chronology of the passage. Make sure you do not skip acting out the difficult or important parts of the passage. Help each other remember every part of the passage.

Pause this audio here and act out the passage.

The group should act out this passage a second time. At certain points in the drama, pause the drama and ask the person playing the character, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person playing the character should answer what they would be feeling or thinking if they were that character. Then continue the drama.

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Pause this audio here and act out the passage a second time.

The following is an example of the drama and possible responses.

Act out Yahweh causing King Nebuchadnezzar and his army to attack the city of Jerusalem. Nebuchadnezzar kills the young men in the temple. Nebuchadnezzar's soldiers do not spare anyone. The soldiers kill the young and the old people, and even the weak people.

Act out the Babylonian soldiers taking all of the valuables from the temple, the king's house, and the houses of his officials. Then the soldiers burn down the temple and other important buildings. The soldiers also destroy the walls that surround Jerusalem.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the remaining people of Judah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am devastated. How could Yahweh allow this to happen? or
- I feel alone. The soldiers took my family from me. I have no future; or
- I feel hopeless. We lost the temple and the Promised Land. Yahweh is far from us.

Continue the drama.

The Babylonians take all of the treasure and the remaining people as prisoners to Babylon. The people of Judah arrive in Babylon and begin to serve Nebuchadnezzar and his family as slaves.

Act out the people of Judah being slaves in Babylon for 70 years. During that time, the land of Judah rests, and no one grows anything. King Cyrus becomes the new king of Babylon after the Persian Kingdom defeats the Babylonians.

Act out Yahweh causing King Cyrus to send out an official message throughout Cyrus' land.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing King Cyrus, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I feel inspired. The God of the Israelites has spoken to me. I must listen to him; or
- I feel compassion. The Israelites have been through enough. It is time for the people to go home; or
- I am determined. I will make sure people rebuild the temple so that they can worship the God of the Israelites as he deserves.

Continue the drama.

In the message, Cyrus recognizes Yahweh and gives his blessing to the people of Judah to return to their land and rebuild the temple in Jerusalem.

Pause the drama. Ask the person playing the people of Judah, "What are you feeling or thinking?" The person might answer things like:

- I am surprised. I never thought I would be free. Now I can return home; or
- I feel humbled. Jeremiah's message from long ago was right. Yahweh has not forgotten us! or
- I am hopeful. We will go home and rebuild.

Filling the Gaps

Listen to an audio version of 2 Chronicles 36:17–23 in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this step, the group will discuss key terms and words in this passage.

Yahweh brings the **King** of the Babylonians against Jerusalem. A king is someone who rules over a city or territory, like a region or a country. Nebuchadnezzar ruled over the kingdom of Babylonia. Use the same word or phrase for king as you used in previous passages. For more information on king, refer to the Master Glossary.

2 Chronicles 36:17–23

King Nebuchadnezzar kills the young men of Judah with a sword in the **sanctuary**. The word "sanctuary" means a place that people set apart to worship God. Here, it refers specifically to Yahweh's temple in Jerusalem. Use the same word or phrase for sanctuary as you used in previous passages. For more information on sanctuary, refer to the Master Glossary.

God gives the people of Judah into Nebuchadnezzar's **hand**. The storyteller uses the image of a hand to represent power. So, in other words, Yahweh allowed Nebuchadnezzar to have power over the people of Judah. Use the same word or phrase for "in the hand of" as you used in previous passages.

The soldiers take all of the valuable treasures out of the **temple** of God. **Yahweh** is a name that God gives himself. It reminds people of the covenant Yahweh made with the Israelites. Israelites worship Yahweh in the temple or the "house of God." Use the same word or phrase for Yahweh and temple as you used in previous passages. For more information on Yahweh and temple, refer to the Master Glossary.

The soldiers burn down the temple and break down **Jerusalem's** walls. Jerusalem was the capital city of the kingdom of Judah. Use the same word or phrase for Jerusalem as you used in previous passages. For more information on Jerusalem, refer to the Master Glossary.

The soldiers also burn down the palace of King Zedekiah as well as the homes of Zedekiah's officials. Here, palace refers to a big, protected house instead of specifically referring to the king's house.

Stop here and discuss how you will say "big, protected house" in your language. Pause this audio here.

The people of Judah who the soldiers do not kill become the **servants** of Nebuchadnezzar and Nebuchadnezzar's **sons**. Here, a servant refers to someone who does not get paid for his work. This person does not have the freedom to leave his master whenever he wants. In other words, this person is a slave and the property of his master. Nebuchadnezzar's sons refer to his descendants and not just Nebuchadnezzar's biological sons. Use the same words or phrases for servant and sons as you used in previous passages. For more information on servant or sons, refer to the Master Glossary.

The Jewish people in Babylon serve Nebuchadnezzar's family until the **Kingdom** of Persia comes to power. Kingdom refers to a territory that a king rules. Use the same word or phrase for kingdom as you used in previous passages. For more information on kingdom, refer to the Master Glossary.

The land of Judah enjoys its **sabbaths** for 70 years. According to the law of Yahweh, the Israelites needed to let the land rest every seventh year by not growing anything. Just like people set apart the sabbath day for Yahweh, the seventh year of planting belonged to God. By resting every seventh year, the people learned that they could trust God for all that the people needed. It also allowed the land to continue to be productive. But the Israelites did not keep the sabbaths for many years, so God uses the time of the people's exile to allow the land to rest. Use the same word or phrase for sabbath as you used in previous passages. For more information on sabbath, refer to the Master Glossary.

Jeremiah warned the people when he spoke the **word** of Yahweh, but no one listened to him. The word of Yahweh is every word that God tells people. In this case, Yahweh spoke through the words of the prophet Jeremiah. Use the same word or phrase for the "word" as you used in previous passages. For more information on the "word," refer to the Master Glossary.

Yahweh stirred up the spirit of King Cyrus to let his people return to Jerusalem. "Stirred up the spirit" is special language that means God caused Cyrus to have a strong desire to let the Israelites go. When the Bible uses the word spirit, the focus is on the relationship that a person has with God.

Stop here and discuss as a group what word or phrase you will use for "**stirred up the spirit**." Look up **spirit** in the Master Glossary for more information. If you have already translated this word in another book of the Bible, use the same word that you have used there. Pause this audio here.

In his official message, Cyrus calls **God** "Yahweh, the God of **heaven**." Yahweh is a name that God gives himself. God is the most powerful spiritual being who created everything. Heaven refers to the place where God lives. Use the same words or phrases for God and heaven as you used in previous passages. For more information on God and heaven, refer to the Master Glossary.

2 Chronicles 36:17–23

Cyrus wants to see the people rebuild the temple in **Judah**. Judah refers to the southern kingdom of the nation of Israel. Use the same word or phrase for Judah as you used in previous passages. For more information on Judah, refer to the Master Glossary.

Speaking the Word

Listen to an audio version of the passage in the easiest-to-understand translation.

Pause this audio here.

In this session, retell the passage, as a group, in your own language.

First, the whole group should practice telling the passage in your own language. Remember to include the things you decided in previous steps, like chronology, words, phrases, emotions, or anything else you discussed.

One group member should tell a few sentences of the passage and pause. Another group member should tell the next part of the passage and pause. Do this until the group has retold the whole passage. The group members can correct each other in this step.

Pause this audio here.

Next, each member of the group should tell the whole passage without interruption at least one time. A group member can use random objects, motions, or their storyboard to help them remember the passage.

Pause this audio here.

Next, the group can decide whose version of the passage you like the most. You may decide that you liked the way one group member told one scene but you liked the way a different group member told another scene.

Pause this audio here.

Finally, the group can put together a final version of the passage that everyone agrees on. Each group member should practice telling this final version of the passage.